

THE SORCERER'S LEGACY

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Book Two of The Lattice Chronicles

VERDANTLIFE LLC

The Sorcerer's Legacy
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First edition.

*For fathers who come home late,
and for the ones who leave the light on.*

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*If the dark comes calling, don't you mind—
a lantern's lit for the ones behind.*

— Ashbourne lullaby

PROLOGUE

A NEW THREAT



CORIN BELL WAS ELEVEN years old the night his sister forgot her name.

They were in the high pasture above Harrowgate, in the far north of Caldor, where the hills ran up into the first grey shoulders of the Ironback range and the wind came down off the snow even in summer. It was late. The sheep were folded. The fire was banked. Corin was lying on his back in the heather with his hands behind his head, looking at the stars, and his sister was sitting beside him with her knees drawn up, singing under her breath.

Mella was sixteen. She'd been Kindled in the spring, at the old Stone in Harrowgate square, the first spring after the Keepers came through and took the flags off it, and the first spring after the smith with the gold eyes flew in on a dragon and laid his hands on it and broke every Ceiling it had ever held. Mella had put her hand on the Stone afterward, in front of the whole village, and the silver had come up and said *Shepherd, Uncommon*. And then a moment later, as if the Stone had thought about it, it had said something else.

Weatherwise. Rare.

She'd laughed for a week. She could feel storms coming now, a day before they came. She could smell snow on the wind three valleys away. She'd told Corin it was like having a second pair of ears, ears for the sky. She was going to go to Highcrest in the autumn, she said, to the Royal

Observatory, where the Queen had said that any Unbound with a weather-class could come and learn.

She was singing a song about the sky now. Corin didn't know the words. He wasn't really listening. He was nearly asleep.

And then she stopped.

Not at the end of a line. In the middle of a word. Just stopped. As if someone had put a hand over her mouth.

Corin opened his eyes.

His sister was sitting very still beside him in the heather. She was looking at her hands. Turning them over. Looking at the palms, then the backs, then the palms again, the way you'd look at something you'd found on the road and didn't recognize.

"Mel?" said Corin.

She looked at him.

And he saw it. In her eyes. Something that wasn't there anymore. Like a lamp that had been burning in a window, and someone had walked past and pinched the wick.

"Who's Mel?" she said.



HE THOUGHT SHE WAS joking. Of course he did. He laughed, and sat up, and punched her arm, and said *very funny*. And she looked at the place on her arm where he'd punched it, and then at him, with an expression of polite puzzlement, as if a stranger had punched her.

"I'm sorry," she said. "Do I know you?"

Corin stopped laughing.

"Mel. Mella. It's me. Corin. Your brother."

"I don't have a brother," said his sister. She said it kindly. Gently. The way you'd tell a lost child that you weren't his mother. "I don't think so. I don't—" She stopped. Her brow creased. She looked down at her hands again. "I don't think I have anyone," she said slowly. "I can't remember having anyone." She looked up at him. "What's my name?"

"*Mella.*" His voice cracked. "*Mella Bell. You're sixteen. You live in Harrowgate. You're a Weatherwise. You're going to Highcrest in the autumn—*"

"Mella," she said, trying it. Like a word in a foreign language. "Mella. That's nice." She frowned. "It doesn't feel like mine."

And then she started to fade.

Not all at once. Slowly. Like a picture drawn in chalk, left out in the rain. Her edges went soft. Her colors went pale. He could see the heather through her hand. Through her arm. Through her face, which was still turned toward him with that polite, puzzled, kindly expression, as if she were waiting for him to explain something she didn't understand.

"Mel—"

He reached for her. His hand went through her shoulder like it was going through mist. Cold mist. Colder than the snow on the Ironbacks.

"Mella! MELLA!"

She was almost gone now. A shape in the starlight. A pale outline of a girl sitting in the heather with her knees drawn up.

And then she wasn't even that.

The heather where she'd been sitting was flattened. There was a dent in it. The shape of someone. And her shawl, the blue wool one their mother had knitted, lay on the ground where it had slipped off her shoulders.

And nothing else.



HE RAN DOWN THE hill to Harrowgate in the dark, screaming.

He hammered on the door of his own house until his father came out with a lamp, bleary and frightened. *Mella*, he sobbed. *Mella's gone, she's gone, she faded, she didn't know her name, she didn't know me, she just went—*

And his father looked at him with the same polite, puzzled, kindly expression his sister had worn in the last moment before she faded.

"Who's Mella?" said his father.

Corin stood on the doorstep in the dark and stared at him.

"Your daughter," he whispered. "Your *daughter*, Da. Mella. She's sixteen. She sleeps in the room at the top of the stairs."

His father looked at him for a long moment. Then he turned and looked back into the house. At the stairs. At the door at the top of them.

"That's the storeroom," he said slowly. "We keep the wool up there." He looked back at Corin, and his face was full of worry now. "Corin, lad, are you feeling all right? You've been out in the cold too long. Come in. Come in by the fire."

Corin pushed past him and ran up the stairs.

The room at the top of them was full of wool. Bales of it. Fleeces. Spindles. Baskets of carded roving. And nothing else. No bed. No chest. No little shelf with the clay bird Mella had made when she was seven. No dresses on hooks. No boots by the door.

As if she'd never been there at all.

He went back down. His mother was up now, in her nightgown, with her hair in a braid. She looked at him the way his father had. Worried. Kind. Puzzled.

He made himself look at her. He made himself ask.

"How many children do you have, Mam?"

His mother laughed. It was a soft, puzzled, loving laugh.

"Just you, sweetheart," she said. "Just you. You know that."



HE WAS THE ONLY one who remembered.

He went round the whole village in the morning. Every house. He asked everyone. The miller. The smith. The old woman who kept bees. Mella's friends, the girls she'd been Kindled with in the spring. He asked them all. *Do you remember Mella Bell? Sixteen. Weatherwise. She was going to Highcrest.*

And every one of them looked at him with the same polite, puzzled, kindly expression. And said *no*.

He went to the Stone.

The old Stone in Harrowgate square. Grey and lichen and roughly the shape of a gravestone. The one Mella had put her hand on in the spring, and laughed, and laughed. He put his own hand on it. He wasn't sixteen. He wasn't Kindled. He didn't have a class or a panel or anything at all. But he put his hand on it anyway, and closed his eyes, and *asked*.

Where is she? Where did she go?

The Stone didn't answer. Of course it didn't. It was just a stone. But when he opened his eyes and took his hand away, there was something in the air in front of him. Just for a moment. A shape. Burned into the morning light like the afterimage of a lamp.

A keyhole.

Black. The size of his hand. Hanging in the empty air above the Stone with nothing around it. Like someone had taken a knife and cut a keyhole-shaped hole in the world.

And through it, very faintly, so faintly he would never be sure afterward that he'd heard it at all, a sound. A girl's voice. Singing a song about the sky. Getting further and further away.

Then the keyhole closed, and was gone, and it was only morning in Harrowgate square.



THE KEEPERS CAME ELEVEN days later.

Corin had never seen a Keeper. He'd heard about them. Everyone had. The old Wardens, the grey cloaks, who'd taken their silver lattice-pins off and become something else when the new Queen was crowned. Who went from village to village taking the flags off the Stones. Who wore a new pin now: a little lantern, silver, on the left breast.

There were two of them. A tall lean grey-haired man with a face like a hatchet, and a short wiry woman with a tracker's squint. They came up the road from the south on tired horses and stopped at the Stone in Harrowgate square and got down and looked at it for a long time.

Corin was sitting on the edge of the well. He'd been sitting there every day for eleven days. Waiting. He didn't know for what.

The hatchet-faced man noticed him first.

"You," he said. Not unkindly. "Boy. Have you seen anything strange here? In the last fortnight? Anything at all?"

Corin looked at him.

"My sister," he said. "She faded. And everyone forgot her. Everyone except me."

The hatchet-faced man went very still.

The short wiry woman beside him turned her head sharply.

"*Commander*," she said.

"I know, Fenn." The tall man crouched down in front of Corin, so their eyes were level. His eyes were pale blue and very steady. "What's your name, son?"

"Corin Bell."

"And your sister's?"

"Mella." Corin's voice cracked. "Mella Bell. She was sixteen. She was a Weatherwise. She was going to Highcrest in the autumn."

The tall man looked at him for a long moment. Then he looked over his shoulder at the woman, and something passed between them that Corin couldn't read.

"That's the ninth village," said the woman quietly. "Ninth this summer. Ninth that we know of."

"And the first time anyone's remembered," said the tall man.

He turned back to Corin.

"Corin Bell," he said. "I'm Commander Daxian Roole, of the Keepers. I'm going to ask you to show me exactly where your sister was sitting when she faded. And then I'm going to ask you to come with us. To Highcrest."

"Why?"

Roole looked at him. And something in his hatchet face softened.

"Because you're the only person in nine villages who remembers someone who's been taken," he said. "And there's a smith in the south with gold eyes who's going to want to talk to you very badly."



BEFORE THEY LEFT, CORIN showed them the place in the high pasture.

The flattened heather. The dent in it, the shape of a girl sitting with her knees drawn up. The blue wool shawl, still lying there, damp with eleven days of dew.

Commander Roole knelt beside it. He didn't touch the shawl. He looked at the air above it. And Corin saw him draw in a breath, very sharp.

"*Fenn*," he said. "Look."

The short woman knelt beside him. She looked. Her squinting tracker's eyes went wide.

Corin looked too.

There was something in the air above the shawl. Faint. So faint he wouldn't have seen it if he hadn't been looking for it every day for eleven days. Not a keyhole. Not anymore. Just a scar. A thin black line, hanging in the empty air, the shape of a keyhole that had been cut and then healed over. Like the white line on a man's hand where a knife went in a long time ago.

"*Unwritten*," said Fenn softly. "That's what they're calling it in Highcrest. The Royal Archivist. She's been tracking the reports. She says it's like someone took a knife to the Lattice and cut a person's thread right out of it. Every record. Every memory. Everything that held them in the world." She swallowed. "Like they were never written in the first place."

Roole didn't say anything. He was staring at the scar.

"Commander?" said Fenn.

"I've seen this shape before," said Roole slowly. "Once. A long time ago. On an old Warden map in the Spire's sealed vault. The one the High Warden kept in her private office." He was very quiet for a moment. "It was drawn in the margin. Beside a note in her own hand."

"What did the note say?"

Roole stood up. He looked north. Up at the grey shoulders of the Ironbacks, and beyond them, to where the sky went pale and strange over a land that wasn't on any map in Caldor.

"*The Key*," he said.



THAT NIGHT, FAR TO the east, beyond the healing Blightmarch, beyond the black ring of stones where Duskhold had stood, in the Sundered Lands where the Veil grew thin and strange and the ground did not always stay where you left it, an old man sat alone by a fire.

He was not as old as he had been.

That was the strange thing. Three years ago, when he walked out of Duskhold with nothing but nine stolen points of Authority and a note he couldn't bear to finish, he had been bent and grey and hollow, a man of sixty-one who looked eighty. Now he sat straighter. His hair was still grey,

but there was dark in it again. The lines on his face had softened. His hands, holding a cup of something hot, were steady.

He had no staff. He didn't need one anymore.

At his belt, on a chain of dull black iron, hung a key.

Not a whole key. Part of one. The bow. The handle, the ring at the end of a key that your fingers hold to turn it. It was black. Not the black of iron, or Gloam, or anything Corin Bell would have recognized. The black of the space between stars. Of the dark before the first word. It was carved all over with Wellsript so fine you'd need a jeweler's lens to see it. And in its center, where a jewel might sit on a noble's key, there was a hole.

A keyhole. In the bow of a key. As if the key could open itself.

The man by the fire wasn't looking at it. He was looking at the flames. And in his mind, in the place under the air where his Authority burned, he was counting.

Not nine anymore.

Forty-three.

He had taken the ninth one that summer. A girl in the north, in a high pasture, singing about the sky. He hadn't known her name. He'd only known that her thread was bright and new and unbound, the way all the Unbound threads were, and that when the key's bow touched it, it came away from the net as easily as a loose thread from a hem. And the mana that had been in it came to him.

He told himself it didn't hurt them. He told himself they didn't feel it. They simply... stopped being written. Stopped being remembered. It wasn't death. It was something gentler than death.

He told himself a great many things, by the fire, at night.

You're doing well, Elric, said a voice in his mind. Old. Very old. Kind. The kindest voice he had ever heard. *Forty-three points. In three years. Without anyone giving you anything. You've earned every one.*

The old man who wasn't as old as he had been closed his eyes.

"*The Bit,*" he said aloud. His voice was rough. "*Where is it?*"

South, said the voice. *Far south. In the glass, where the sun is too bright to look at. A pause. But you won't need to find it, Elric. Someone else is going to find it for you.*

"*Who?*"

The voice was silent for a long moment.

My blood, it said at last. Gently. *The young one. The smith. He'll go looking. He always goes looking.* Something in the kind old voice that might have been fondness. *He's so very like me.*

Elric Thorne opened his eyes.

He looked at the fire for a long time.

Then he reached down and touched the black bow of the key at his belt. And far to the south and west, in a village called Ashbourne, in a forge with twelve anvils, a young man with gold eyes woke suddenly in the dark with a feeling like a hand closing on his heart.

And didn't know why.

PART ONE



THE KEY OF SHADOWS

CHAPTER 1

THREE YEARS OF PEACE



THE IRON WAS WRONG, and Lex knew it before the hammer came down.

He knew it the way he'd always known it: a tiny lurch of the stomach, a sense of the world being a finger's width off true. A dull note under the iron's ring. A seam, deep in the heart of the bar, where some careless smelter had let a bubble of slag cool inside.

He didn't turn his wrist this time. He didn't need to.

He laid his palm flat on the glowing bar instead, the way he'd never once been able to before the night of the gloamhounds, and *listened*. Not with Forge Sense. With Stone. The slow heavy hum of the earth that the iron had come from, that it still remembered, deep in its grain. And under the hum, the flaw. Small and dark and hard, like a seed in a plum.

Come out, he told it. Not in words.

And the slag came out. It rose up through the glowing iron like a bubble rising through honey, and broke the surface, a bead of grey-black scum, and he flicked it off the anvil with the edge of his hand. The bar beneath it was clean. Perfect. Ringing.

"*How* did you *do* that?"

The girl at the next anvil was staring at him. Seventeen, round-faced and freckled, with a smith's burn scars already on her forearms and a leather apron two sizes too big for her. Tilda Crane, from Millbridge. The one who'd sat in front of a cold hearth for nine days until the fire leaned toward her.

"Stone," said Lex. "It's in the iron. It remembers where it came from. If you listen, it'll tell you where the flaws are."

"I can't hear Stone. I can only hear Flame."

"Then you'll learn Stone. Or you won't, and you'll find the flaws with Flame instead. There's more than one way to find a slag pocket." He picked up the clean bar in his tongs and turned it to the light. "Brannoc used to do it by ear. Forty years. Never once heard a slag pocket in his life, he says. But he could tell by the ring of the hammer when a bar was wrong."

From the far end of the forge, a voice like distant thunder: "*I heard that.*"

"You were meant to."

"*I could always tell,*" said Brannoc, without looking up from his own anvil. "*Didn't need any fancy rock-listening to do it. I just knew.*"

"He just knew," Lex told Tilda gravely.

"*And I could still put you through that wall, lad.*"

Tilda giggled. All down the long hall, at all twenty anvils, other students were grinning.



THE ASHBOURNE FORGE HAD twenty anvils now.

It had swallowed two more houses and another barn and the whole of Farmer Tobbin's old east pasture, which his widow had sold to them for a copper penny and a promise that her grandson could learn to strike runes. There was a long hall with twenty hearths, open to the air in summer, with slate roofs and timber posts and a great brick chimney at each end. There was Hedda's reading room, which had become two reading rooms and a library and a copying-house where three Scribes from Highcrest sat all day transcribing the *Book of Making* and the Listeners' Codex into fresh copies to send to the other forges.

Because there were other forges now. Seven of them. In Millbridge and Thistledown and Saltreach and Highcrest itself, and three more in the healing Blightmarch, in villages that had been grey three years ago. Small ones, mostly. Two or three anvils. Run by smiths who'd come to Ashbourne and learned and gone home.

They called themselves runesmiths. The Lattice called them that too, sometimes. Not always. The Lattice was still learning, Seraphine said. Still catching up with what three years of Unbinding had done to it.

Lex walked the length of the long hall at midmorning, the way he did every day, stopping at each anvil. Looking at the work. Saying a word here, a word there. *Your upstroke's crooked. Your heat's too low; it'll crack. That's good. That's very good. Do it again.*

[You're a good teacher,] said Ember.

I'm a terrible teacher. I just say the same five things over and over.

[That's what good teachers do.] A pause. *[Your father was the same. With the Circles. He'd say "shape the channel" until people wanted to throw things at him.]*

Did they?

[Elric did. Once. A teapot.] Another pause. Shorter. *[He missed.]*

Lex didn't say anything to that. Ember didn't either.

They didn't talk about Elric much. Not in three years.



AT NOON, HE WENT out onto the green and called up his status, the way he did every day. Out of habit. The way he had every morning for three years in the old forge, before any of this.

ALEXANDER VEY		
Age: 22		
Class: FORGEHEART SORCERER (Unique)		
– WELL-BOUND –		
Tier III – Level 61		
MIG 72 AGI 68 VIT 88		
INT 66 SPI 184 RES 74		
Well-bound: all stats +10%		
ATTUNEMENT		
Flame SPEAKING		
Stone ANSWERING		
Tide –		
Gale –		
ROOT		
Authority: 100 / 100		
Prerogatives: True Sight, Command,		
Sanction, Unbind, Unbind (Stone)		

Sixty-one.

Three years ago he'd been fifty-one, kneeling on the black floor of Duskhold with his father's crystal clearing behind him and a dead knight in front of him. He'd thought, then, that he'd climb fast. That he'd be seventy by now, Tier IV, the way his father was.

He'd climbed ten levels in three years.

[That's not slow,] said Ember, reading the thought the way it always did. [That's actually rather fast, for Tier Three. Most people take ten years to climb ten levels at Master.] A pause. [You've just been busy. Teaching doesn't give much experience. Unbinding Stones gives a little. Forging gives a little. Nothing's tried to kill you in three years.]

That's a good thing.

[It's a very good thing. I'm only saying.]

Three years. Two hundred and sixty Stones. He'd counted. Seraphine had a ledger in Highcrest with every one of them written down, with dates and places and the number of threads unbound. Two hundred and sixty Stones, out of something over four thousand in Caldor alone. Lex and Antho, on Ashka's back, flying from one to the next, laying their hands on cold grey stone and breaking three hundred years of Ceilings.

Four thousand Stones. At this rate, it would take them forty years.

[Longer, if you count Saltreach and the Sunreach and the Fells,] said Ember helpfully.

Thank you, Ember.

[You're welcome.]



THE COTTAGE STOOD ON the hill above the village, at the end of a lane lined with chestnut trees.

It was new. Lex and Brannoc had built it, the summer after Duskhold, on the bones of the old one. The Harrow cottage. The one that had burned eleven years before, with his mother inside it, or not inside it, or somewhere else entirely. They'd cleared away the last of the old charred timbers and the blackened hearthstones and the iron pots melted into lumps. Brannoc had kept one of the pots. He'd put it on a shelf in the forge without saying anything.

The new cottage was stone, with a slate roof and a woodpile against one wall and a door painted blue. Like the old one. Lex hadn't planned that. Brannoc had brought the paint.

And in the kitchen window, facing out over the village, there was a little clay lamp.

Not Seren's lamp. That was still on its rock above the Hollowmaw, a hundred miles north, burning. This was a new one. Lex had made it the first night they slept in the new cottage, with clay from the riverbank and *Ardent* struck into its base. It had burned every night since. It would burn as long as he lived.

A light left on for the lost.

Wren wasn't home.

He'd known she wouldn't be. She'd been gone three weeks. The Queen's business. Wren was a Mistwalker now, Epic, level fifty-two, and Mistwalkers were rare enough that the Queen had asked her, very politely, if she'd consider serving as a royal scout. Not a soldier. Not a guard. A *pathfinder*. Someone who could go where no road went and come back and say what was there.

Wren had said yes before the Queen finished the sentence.

So she was gone a great deal. North, to the Ironbacks. East, to the edge of the Blightmarch where it bordered the Sundered Lands. South, to the Sunreach deserts. She'd come back windburned and grinning and full of stories, and sleep for two days, and then be restless by the third, standing in the cottage doorway at dusk looking at the sky.

He didn't mind. Not really. She'd always been like that. He'd met her in a tavern in Thistledown, bargaining to take a stranger up a mountain for four times what anyone else would ask.

He just missed her.

[She'll be back soon,] said Ember. *[She said three weeks. It's been three weeks.]*

She said three weeks the last time too. It was five.

[That was the Sunreach. Things are slower in the Sunreach. Everyone says so.]

Lex stood in the cottage doorway and looked at the little lamp burning in the window in the middle of the day. Then he turned and looked north. At the Greyspine, blue and white against the summer sky. At the highest peak. At the faint glow, even in daylight, from the great cleft in its face, where a hundred lanterns burned.



HIS FATHER'S LETTER CAME that afternoon.

Quill brought it. The raven had stayed with Lex after Duskhold. Nobody had ever been entirely sure whose raven he was now. He spent most of his time on the forge chimney, eating Mother Orla's bacon and insulting students. But when there was a letter from Highcrest, he always brought it.

He dropped it on the anvil in front of Lex and sat down beside it and looked at him expectantly.

"I don't have any bacon," said Lex.

"*Liar,*" said Quill.

Lex gave him the rind from his lunch. Then he opened the letter.

It was in his father's hand. Small and neat and slanting slightly backward, as if the writer had been left-handed and fighting it. The same hand as the letter to Elric, which Lex still kept in his coat.

Lexander—

I won't be able to come on the first of the month. I'm sorry. Brannoc will be furious. Tell him I owe him a drink and an argument, with interest.

Things are difficult in Highcrest.

Lord Chancellor Sorn spoke in the High Council again last week. Two hours. The usual complaints, but louder. The Unbound are taking places in the guilds. The noble houses' children can't get apprenticeships, because commoners with Rare classes are winning them. The Royal Observatory has more farmers' daughters than lords' sons. The Ceiling, he says, was a kindness. It kept order. It kept everyone in their place. And now no one knows their place, and the realm is falling into chaos.

It isn't. But that doesn't matter. What matters is that half the noble houses agreed with him, loudly, and the other half agreed with him quietly. And three of them have withdrawn their knights from the Royal Guard.

The Queen is holding. She's very good. But she's very young, and very alone, and there are a great many people in Highcrest who would be happier with a different Queen.

I'm staying here. She needs me.

And Lexander. There's something else.

The Royal Archivist has been tracking disappearances. Or what she thinks are disappearances. She's found gaps in the Lattice records. Places where a thread should be and isn't. Not dead. Not ended. Just—gone. As if it were never written. Nine villages in the north this summer. Perhaps more. Nobody in those villages remembers anyone missing. That's the strangest part. They don't remember. There's no one to report it.

Seraphine only found them because she reads the records every day, and she noticed the holes.

I don't know what it means. I have a guess. I'm afraid of my guess.

Be careful. Watch the Stones. If anything feels wrong, write to me at once.

—A.

P.S. Mind the quench.

Lex read it twice. Then he folded it very carefully and put it in his coat, beside the others.

[He has a guess,] said Ember quietly. [And he's afraid of it.]

He's always afraid of his guesses. And he never tells anyone what they are.

[Lex—]

Three years, Lex thought. Three years since Duskhold. Three years since he said "I need to be sure." About Mam. Three years since "A Key has been turned." Three years he's been searching for something and he won't say what. He picked up the hammer. He asked Antho to forgive him for keeping secrets. Antho did. And he's still keeping them.

Ember was quiet for a long moment.

[I know,] it said at last. [I'm a piece of him. I know exactly how he thinks.] A pause. [He thinks if he tells you, and he's wrong, it'll hurt you worse than not knowing.]

And if he's right?

[Then he thinks it'll hurt you worse than that.]

Lex brought the hammer down on the anvil. *Chang.* The iron rang clean.



HE FELT IT THAT evening.

He was walking back up the lane to the cottage at dusk, under the chestnut trees, with the lamp glowing in the kitchen window ahead of him. The sky was pale gold over the Greyspine. The swallows were out. Somewhere down in the village, someone was playing a fiddle at the Crooked Kettle.

And he stopped.

He didn't know why. He just stopped, in the middle of the lane, with his hand on the gate.

There was something wrong.

Not here. Not in the lane, or the village, or the Vale. Somewhere else. Far away. North. He could feel it the way he felt a slag pocket in iron. A dull note under the ring. A flaw in the grain of the world.

[Lex?]

Do you feel that?

[Feel what?]

He closed his eyes. He reached down, the way he reached for Stone. Down past the silver, past the gold. And then *out*. Not to Stone. To the net. To the Lattice. To the great silver web spread over all of Aldermere,

every thread, every knot. He'd learned to feel it, these three years. Faintly. Like the hum of a forge in another room. Unbinding Stone after Stone, he'd started to feel the whole net, the way you feel the shape of a building you've walked through many times, even in the dark.

There was a hole in it.

Not a breach. Not a tear, like Vhessa. Smaller. Neater. *Precise*. As if someone had taken a very fine knife and cut a single thread out of the weave. And then another. And another. Little holes. A line of them. Far to the north.

And at the end of the line, so faint he almost thought he'd imagined it, something *turning*. Like a key in a lock.

[Oh,] said Ember very softly. *[Oh. I feel it now.]*

What is it?

[I don't know.] Ember's voice was strange. *[But it feels like the panel. Three years ago. At the festival. "A Key has been turned."]* A long pause. *[It feels like that, only smaller. Like an echo.]*

Lex stood in the lane with his hand on the gate and his eyes closed, feeling the holes in the net.

Nine of them, his father had said. Nine villages.

He counted.

Eleven.



HE DIDN'T SLEEP THAT night.

He sat at the kitchen table in the new cottage with the little clay lamp burning in the window and a cup of tea going cold in front of him and the *Book of Making* open on the table, turning the pages without reading them.

Something was cutting threads out of the Lattice. People. Unbound people. He was almost sure of that. The holes he'd felt were in the new places, the bright places, the places where Ceilings had been broken. Like someone walking through an orchard picking only the ripest fruit.

And nobody remembered them.

He thought about the Inkwraths in the Drowned Archive. *They eat meaning*. He thought about the Thornwood, eating memories. He

thought about the Barrow-King's soldiers, nine hundred years in the black water, who had forgotten their own names because the Lattice had written them out of the world.

He thought about the bronze foil from Qel'Varran. *It wants to unmake them. To take them back to before they were. Before they had names.*

[You think it's the Unmaker,] said Ember quietly.

I don't know what I think.

[You think it's the Unmaker. Or something to do with it.] A pause. *[And you think your father thinks so too. And that's why he's afraid of his guess.]*

Lex didn't answer.

He sat at the table until the sky outside began to grey. Then he got up and went to the door and stood in it, looking north.

And that was when he heard the horses.



THEY CAME UP THE south road from Millbridge in the dawn. Two of them, tired, lathered, ridden hard. Lex saw them from the cottage doorway as they came over the last rise and down into the village. He saw them stop on the green beside the white Stone. He saw the riders get down.

He was already running.

He came down the lane and across the green at a run, and the taller of the two riders turned at the sound of his boots, and Lex saw a hatchet face and close-cropped iron-grey hair and pale blue eyes, and a little silver lantern pinned to the left breast of a plain grey coat.

"Commander," he said, out of breath.

"Harrow." Roole had never stopped calling him that. Three years, and a Queen's advisor for a father, and it was still *Harrow*. "I'm sorry for the hour."

"What's happened?"

Roole didn't answer. He turned and looked at the second horse.

There was a boy on it. Sitting behind Corporal Fenn, who'd ridden with Roole since the Hollowmaw and was a Keeper-Lieutenant now with a squint to match. The boy was small and thin and pale, eleven or twelve, with a shock of fair hair and enormous eyes and a blue wool shawl wrapped

around his shoulders, though it was summer. He was clutching the shawl with both hands.

He was looking at Lex.

At his eyes. At the gold in them, which never quite went away anymore.

"Are you him?" said the boy. His voice was very small. "The smith? The one with the gold eyes?"

"I'm a smith," said Lex. "My eyes are gold."

The boy looked at him for a long moment.

"My sister faded," he said. "And everyone forgot her. Everyone in the whole village. My mam and my da and her friends." His voice cracked. "Everyone except me."

Lex went very still.

He looked at Roole. The Keeper-Commander was looking back at him, and his hatchet face was grey with exhaustion and something else. Something Lex had seen on it once before, on a snowy slope below the Hollowmaw, when he'd lain in the slush with a burning hammer over his head and hadn't flinched.

Fear.

"His name's Corin Bell," said Roole quietly. "He's from Harrowgate. In the far north. Under the Ironbacks." He paused. "His sister was Unbound in the spring. By you. At the Harrowgate Stone. She was a Weatherwise. Rare."

Lex remembered. A grey Stone in a grey square, at the end of a long cold flight north on Ashka's back. A crowd of villagers watching. A girl of sixteen in a blue shawl, laughing, laughing, at the front of the crowd, when her panel changed.

"*Mella*," he said.

The boy's head came up so fast his fair hair flew.

"*You remember her*," he whispered. "*You remember. Nobody remembers. Nobody, not anyone, not even Mam—*"

"I remember," said Lex. "She laughed. When her class changed. She laughed so hard she had to sit down on the Stone."

Corin Bell stared at him.

Then he slid off the back of Fenn's horse, and walked across the green, and stopped in front of Lex, and put his arms around his waist, and wept.



[Lex,] said Ember, very quietly, while the boy cried against him in the dawn. *[You remembered her. You. Not anyone else. The boy and you.]*

I know.

[The boy because she was his sister. Blood. And you—] Ember stopped. *[You because you Unbound her. Because your hands were on her thread. Your Root touched it.]*

Lex looked over the boy's fair head at Roole.

"How many?" he said quietly. "Villages."

"Nine that we've found," said Roole. "Seraphine found the holes in the records. We went looking. Nine villages in the north, since spring." His jaw tightened. "We only found the boy in the ninth. He's the only one anywhere who remembers."

"It's eleven," said Lex.

Roole's pale eyes narrowed.

"I felt them," said Lex. "Last night. In the net. Holes. A line of them. Going north." He swallowed. "Eleven."

Roole looked at him for a long moment.

"There's something else," he said. He reached into his coat and drew out a folded paper. Old. Creased. A map. He unfolded it and held it out. It was drawn in the Spire's precise style, faded brown ink on yellowed paper, and in the margin, beside a cluster of notes in a neat cramped hand Lex didn't recognize, there was a drawing.

A keyhole.

"I found this in Isaura Kell's private office," said Roole. "After she fled. I took it with every other paper she left behind. I've had it three years. I never knew what it meant." He tapped the drawing. "There was a scar in the air above the place where the boy's sister faded. A thin black line. Healed over." His voice was very quiet. "This shape."

Lex looked at the keyhole drawn in the margin of the High Warden's map.

And beside it, in Kell's neat cramped hand, two words.

The Key.

[Lex,] said Ember. And its voice had gone very cold. Very quiet. Very sure. [Lex, I know whose hand that is. Under Kell's notes. The fainter writing, in the corner. Do you see it?]

He saw it. Very small. Very faint. Almost rubbed away. A second hand, under the first. Spiky. Rapid.

He'd seen that hand before. On a slip of paper tied to a raven's leg, on a cold morning outside the Hollowmaw.

If you are reading this, you are alive, and so presumably is your brother, and I am an old man who gambles well.

He looked up at Roole.

"Elric," he said.

CHAPTER 2

THE FESTIVAL OF SORCERERS



HIGHCREST BURNED GOLD.

Lex saw it from Ashka's back, coming in from the south at dusk, with Antho on the dragon's neck in front of him and Corin Bell wedged between them, wrapped in his blue shawl, his eyes enormous. The whole city. Every terrace, every tier, every street and stair and rooftop, from the crowded Lower Town to the castle on the crag. Lanterns. Thousands of them. Tens of thousands. In every window, on every sill, hung from every eave and balcony and lamppost. The mountain city glowed in the blue summer dusk like a great coal in a banked fire.

And at the very top, beside the castle, the Spire. The white needle. With the Great Stone at its summit pulsing silver-blue against the evening sky, as it had for nine hundred years.

There was a lantern hanging from the top of it.

A real one. Enormous. Brass and glass, the size of a cart, hung from the very peak of the Spire on a chain, burning gold. Someone had climbed all the way up there to hang it. Lex had heard it was the Keepers. Roole's idea. The first year, they'd hung a small one. The second year, bigger. This year, the third Festival of Sorcerers, it was so big you could see it from Millbridge.

A light left on for the lost.

"It's beautiful," whispered Corin.

Antho turned his head on the dragon's neck. In the dusk, his grey eyes were very dark. Shade-dark. The sky between the stars.

"It is," he said quietly. "It's very beautiful." He looked at the boy. "Your sister would have liked it."

Corin's face crumpled. He didn't cry. He'd stopped crying, mostly, in the week since Ashbourne. He just held on tighter to his shawl.

Antho reached back without a word and put a scarred hand on the boy's shoulder, and left it there all the way down.



THEY LANDED IN THE castle courtyard.

The Queen had given permission, three years ago, for the dragon to land wherever she liked. It had caused a sensation the first time. Now the castle guards barely looked up. Ashka folded her vast storm-colored wings and settled onto the flagstones like a cat settling by a fire, and a stable-boy came running with a bucket of water the size of a bathtub, and she drank it in three long swallows and sneezed sparks at him in thanks.

Seraphine was waiting at the top of the steps.

Royal Archivist of Caldor. In a dark grey dress with the Queen's silver crown embroidered small on the collar, and new spectacles on her nose, uncracked, and ink on her fingers as always. The scars down the left side of her face had faded to fine silver lines. She stood very straight at the top of the castle steps with her hands clasped in front of her and watched the dragon land.

Antho slid off Ashka's neck. He walked up the steps. He didn't hurry. He stopped one step below her, so their eyes were level.

"Hello," he said.

"You're late," said Seraphine. "You said the twelfth. It's the fourteenth."

"There was a storm over the Fells. Ashka wanted to eat it."

"Of course she did."

They looked at each other. Neither of them moved. Lex, climbing down off the dragon with Corin, felt his face go warm and looked away.

When he looked back, Seraphine had her face pressed into Antho's coat and his arms were around her, and she was saying something into his chest that sounded very much like *I missed you, you idiot, I've been reading your letters until the paper wore through*, and Antho was laughing very softly into her hair.

[Hm,] said Ember.

Don't.

[I didn't say anything.]

You were going to.

[I was going to say,] said Ember with great dignity, *[that they write to each other every week. By raven, when Quill's willing. Seraphine keeps the letters in a box under her bed.]* A pause. *[Like Garrick's wife did.]*

Lex didn't say anything to that.



THE COUNCIL MET THAT night in a small round room at the top of the castle's east tower.

The Queen's private room. Lex had been in it a dozen times in three years. Bookshelves on every wall. A fire. A round table, scarred and old, with no head and no foot, so nobody sat above anybody else. A window looking out over the whole golden city.

The Queen was already there when they came in.

Lysandra of Caldor was twenty-six now. Tall and slender, in a plain blue dress with no jewels, her dark hair bound up simply, a thin silver circlet on her brow that was the only sign she was anything more than a merchant's daughter. Her fine-boned face had grown thinner in three years. Her dark serious eyes had grown older. She was standing at the window with her back to the door, looking down at the lanterns.

She turned when they came in.

"Smith," she said. She always called him that. Never *Lexander*, never *Lord Vey*, though she'd offered him a title twice and he'd refused it twice. "Thank you for coming." Her eyes went to Corin, standing very close to Lex's side. "And this is the boy."

"Corin Bell," said Lex. "From Harrowgate."

The Queen crossed the room. She crouched down in front of Corin, in her plain blue dress, so their eyes were level. The way Roole had crouched in Harrowgate square.

"Corin," she said. "I'm told you remember your sister."

Corin stared at her. At the silver circlet. He swallowed.

"Yes, Your Majesty," he whispered.

"What was her name?"

"Mella."

"Mella," said the Queen. She said it carefully. Deliberately. As if writing it down. "Mella Bell. Weatherwise. Rare." She looked at him. "I'm going to remember that name, Corin. I'm going to have it written in the royal records. In ink. On paper. Where no one can unwrite it." She put her hand on his shoulder. "And I'm going to find out who took her."

Corin's face crumpled again.

The Queen stood up. She looked around the room. At Lex. At Antho and Seraphine, standing very close together by the bookshelves. At Roole, by the fire, with his arms folded. At Hedda Vorne, who had come up from Ashbourne on the cart with Lex's tools and refused to stay behind, and who was sitting in the best chair by the fire with her cudgel across her knees as if she owned it.

And at the man standing in the corner by the window.

Lean. Grey-eyed. Silver at the temples. In a long dark coat, with his hands clasped behind his back. A face that slid off your attention like water off oiled leather.

"Lord Advisor," said the Queen. "I believe you have a guess."



ARION VEY DIDN'T ANSWER at once.

He was looking at Lex. Lex looked back. Three years. Three years of first-of-the-months in the Ashbourne forge, of arguments with Brannoc in the Crooked Kettle, of evenings at the anvil, father and son, striking runes side by side. Three years, and Lex still couldn't read his father's face when his father didn't want it read.

He could read it now, a little. Enough to see that Arion was afraid.

"Yes," said Arion at last. "I have a guess."

He came to the round table. He didn't sit. He laid his hands flat on the scarred wood, the way he'd laid them on the black floor at Duskhold.

"Nine hundred years ago," he said quietly, "Aurelian Vey wove the Lattice. You know that. You know it was a net over the will of men, and a lid over the hunger beneath. What you don't know, what almost no one knows, because the Order spent three centuries burning every record of it,

is that a lid needs a *lock*." He looked around the table. "And a lock needs a key."

Seraphine had gone very still.

"Aurelian forged it," said Arion. "With his own hands. On his own anvil. A key to the lid between the Lattice and the Hollow. So that if the binding ever failed, if the hunger ever grew too strong for the net, someone of the blood could open the lid just enough to reach down and *fix* it." His jaw tightened. "That's what he told the other Founders, anyway."

"And then?" said the Queen.

"And then he broke it." Arion's voice was flat. "Into three pieces. And hid them. In three places, far apart. And told no one where." He was quiet for a moment. "The Founders' records call it the Key of Shadows. Because he forged it from his own shadow. Literally. The old texts say he stood in the light of the first fire and cut his shadow off the ground with a blade of Wellsript and folded it on the anvil like steel." He looked up. "That's the kind of thing Aurelian could do."

"And someone found it," said Lex.

"Someone found one piece." Arion looked at him. "Three years ago. At the first Festival. You saw the panel. *A Key has been turned*."

"Elric," said Lex.

His father closed his eyes.

"Yes," he said. "I think so. I've thought so for three years." He opened them. "I've been looking for him. Every month. With every Keeper Roole could spare, and every raven, and every scrap of Root I could reach. I've been through every Stone in the east. I've walked the edge of the Sundered Lands." He shook his head slowly. "Nothing. He's hidden himself. The way I taught him. The way we both learned in the Spire, forty years ago."

"*Three years*," said Antho. His voice was very quiet. Very cold. "You've known for three years. That Elric had a piece of a key that opens the lid on the thing in my head." He looked at their father. "And you didn't tell us."

"I wasn't *sure*—"

"You're never sure." Antho's grey eyes were very dark. "You weren't sure about Mam. You're *still* not sure about Mam. You weren't sure about the Vhessa breach until Morvane told us for you." His jaw worked. "I forgave

you for keeping secrets, Father. On a plinth in Duskhold. In front of eleven thousand people. And you're still keeping them."

The room was very quiet. The fire crackled. Corin Bell had pressed himself against Lex's side.

Arion stood at the table with his hands flat on the wood and looked at his eldest son. His lean face was very still.

"Yes," he said at last. "I am."

"*Why?*"

"Because I was afraid," said Arion simply. "Because the last time I told anyone what I was afraid of, I tore a hole in the world. Because every time I've decided I knew best, I've been wrong, and someone I love has paid for it." His voice was very low. "And because I hoped. I hoped I'd find Elric first. Quietly. Before anyone else got hurt. Before either of you had to—" He stopped.

"Had to what?" said Lex.

His father didn't answer.



"THE HOLES," SAID SERAPHINE. She'd taken out a ledger from somewhere, a thick one, bound in grey, and opened it on the round table. "Let me show you the holes."

She turned the pages. Rows and rows of her neat cramped handwriting. Villages. Dates. Numbers.

"I read the records every day," she said. "Every Stone in Caldor reports to the Spire's Great Stone. Every Kindling, every death, every level. I read them all. It's what I do." She pushed her spectacles up her nose. "In the spring, I started noticing gaps. A village where the Stone's thread-count dropped by one, overnight. No death recorded. No departure. No transfer. The thread just... wasn't there anymore. And when I went back through the old records, the thread wasn't there either. Not in last year's. Not in the year before. Not at the Kindling." She looked up. "As if the person had never been Kindled at all. Never been born."

"Unwritten," said Roole quietly.

"Unwritten." Seraphine turned another page. "I found nine. All in the north. All since spring." She looked at Lex. "You said eleven."

"I felt eleven. In the net. Last week."

Seraphine stared at him. Then she turned back to her ledger and started writing very fast.

"And they're all Unbound," said Lex.

Everyone looked at him.

"The ones I felt," he said. "The holes. They're all in the bright places. Where we broke the Ceilings." He looked at Antho. "Mella Bell was Unbound at the Harrowgate Stone in the spring. By us. The others—I'd bet every one of them was Unbound too." He swallowed. "Someone's going through the orchard, picking the ripest fruit."

"*Why?*" said Hedda Vorne from her chair by the fire. It was the first thing she'd said. "Why the Unbound?"

Arion was looking at the ledger.

"Because their threads are new," he said slowly. "Freshly freed. Loose, the way a new knot is loose before it's pulled tight. Easier to cut." His voice dropped. "And because they're *bright*. Unbound threads carry more mana than capped ones. Much more. No Ceiling holding them down. All that potential, flowing freely." He looked up. "If you cut one out of the net, the mana in it has to go somewhere."

"Into whoever cut it," said Antho.

Their father didn't answer. He didn't need to.



WREN CAME IN THROUGH the window.

Literally. The council had been going for an hour, and they'd moved from the holes to the north, to the line of them Lex had felt running up toward the Ironbacks and beyond, and Roole had unrolled Kell's old map on the table with its keyhole in the margin. And then the window behind the Queen's chair, the one that looked out over the golden city, flew open with a bang that sent every candle in the room guttering.

And a small slim figure in a patched coat with a fox-red braid stepped in off the empty air above the city, windburned and grinning, and dropped lightly onto the floor.

"*Sorry I'm late,*" said Wren Ashdown. "*The Sunreach is enormous. Did anyone know the Sunreach was enormous?*"

The Queen had half-risen from her chair with her hand on the dagger at her belt. Roole had his sword halfway out. Hedda had her cudgel raised.

Wren looked around at all of them. Then at Lex.

"Hello, Hammer," she said.

He was across the room before he knew he'd moved.



THEY FOUND A CORNER. Later. After the council broke up, after Roole took Corin down to the kitchens to be fed, after Antho and Seraphine vanished somewhere together and the Queen went back to the window to look at the lanterns. A window seat in a corridor, looking out over the city.

Wren sat with her back against the stone and her knees drawn up and her boots on Lex's lap, the way she always sat. She'd taken her braid down. Her fox-red hair was a wild tangle around her windburned face.

"Five weeks," he said.

"I said three."

"You always say three."

"I always mean three." She leaned her head back against the window. "The Sunreach is *enormous*, Lex. It's all sand. Sand and sun and rocks and more sand. And the people are wonderful. And their queen has a scimitar the size of your hammer and rides a horse made of—I don't even know. It glows. It's made of light, or fire, or something." She laughed. "She wants to meet you. The smith with the gold eyes. Everyone in the Sunreach wants to meet you. They have Stones too. Thousands. Nobody's ever taken the flags off them."

"Thousands," said Lex. "More Stones."

"I told her you'd come. Someday." She looked at him sideways. "When you're not busy."

"I'm always busy."

"I know." She was quiet for a moment. "I heard about the holes. From Seraphine. Before I came in through the window." Her green eyes were very serious now. "The Unbound. Someone's cutting them out."

"Yes."

"You're going after them. Aren't you."

He didn't answer.

"You've got the line between your eyebrows," said Wren. "The thinking line. You've had it since I came through the window." She pressed her boot into his thigh. "You're going north. To where the holes go. To find whoever's cutting them."

"Yes."

"When?"

"Soon."

"Then I'm coming."

"No," said Lex.

Wren stopped.



SHE DIDN'T SAY ANYTHING for a long moment. She just looked at him. Her face had gone very still.

"No?" she said.

"Wren—"

"No?" She took her boots off his lap. Slowly. She put her feet on the floor. "You don't get to say *no*, Hammer. You've never once in three years got to say *no*. That's not how this works."

"It's different this time."

"How?"

"*Because they're taking the Unbound.*" It came out louder than he meant. He made himself breathe. "Because whoever's doing this is going through the orchard picking the brightest ones. The ones who were freed. The ones whose threads are new and loose and full of everything the Ceiling held back." He looked at her. "You're a Mistwalker, Wren. Epic. Level fifty-two. Gale at Speaking. Unbound at a Stone by *my hands*." His voice cracked. "You're the brightest thread there is."

Wren stared at him.

"If whoever it is gets near you," said Lex, "if they put that key to your thread—you'll fade. Like Mella. And everyone will forget you. Your mam. Your brothers. Brannoc. The Queen. Everyone." He swallowed. "Everyone except me."

The corridor was very quiet. Out the window, the lanterns of Highcrest glowed gold.

"And you think," said Wren slowly, "that I'm going to let you go up there alone? Into whatever this is? While I sit in the castle and wait?"

"I think you're the person I'm most afraid of losing."

"And you think I'm not afraid of losing YOU?"

She was on her feet. Her fists were clenched. The wind had come up in the corridor from nowhere, a sudden cold gust that set the tapestries flapping and the candles streaming, and her hair was lifting around her face.

"You're the brightest thread there is, Lex. You're *Root*. You're the one who Unbound every one of them. If they want bright, you're the brightest thing in Aldermere." Her voice shook. "And you want to go up there alone. Like you always do. Like you went up the Hollowmaw alone, and into the Frostvault alone, and down the stair at Avaloria alone, and into the dark forge in the middle of yourself *alone*—"

"I wasn't alone in the dark forge. You were the bellows."

"EXACTLY."

The wind slammed every shutter in the corridor.

They stood facing each other in the sudden silence. Wren breathing hard. Lex not breathing at all.

"I'm not asking you to protect me," said Wren. Her voice had dropped. "I've never once asked you to protect me. I'm asking you to *let me come*." Her green eyes were very bright. "*With* you. Not for you. You said that. On the cliff in the Stillwater. *With* you." Her voice cracked. "Did you mean it?"

Lex looked at her.

He thought about Mella Bell, laughing on the Harrowgate Stone. He thought about Corin, the only one who remembered. He thought about a blue wool shawl lying in the heather, damp with eleven days of dew.

He thought about Wren fading. Going soft at the edges like chalk in rain. Looking at him with polite, puzzled, kindly eyes and saying *do I know you?*

"I meant it," he said. "I still mean it."

"Then—"

"And I can't," said Lex. "Not this time. I'm sorry."

Wren looked at him for a very long time.

Then she turned and walked away down the corridor without a word, and the wind went with her, and the tapestries fell still.

[Lex,] said Ember, very quietly.

Don't.

[I'm only going to say one thing.]

Don't, Ember.

[Your father did this,] said Ember. [Exactly this. On a stormy night in a cottage in Ashbourne. He decided what was best for the people he loved, and he didn't ask them, and he left.] A pause. [I know. I was there. I'm what he left on the anvil.]

Lex didn't answer.



THE FESTIVAL REACHED ITS height at midnight.

The Queen spoke in the great square below the castle, at the foot of the stair that climbed up to the Spire. It was a tradition now. Three years old. The young Queen of Caldor standing on the steps in a plain blue dress with a lantern in her hand, speaking to her people.

Lex stood in the crowd. He didn't want to be anywhere near the steps. He didn't want to be seen. So he stood near the back of the great square, with his hood up, among the bakers and tanners and dockworkers of the Lower Town. And listened.

"Three years ago," said Queen Lysandra, "a Ceiling was broken. For the first time in three hundred years."

The square was utterly silent. Ten thousand people. More. Holding lanterns.

"Since then," said the Queen, "nine hundred and forty thousand Ceilings have been broken. In Caldor alone. Nine hundred and forty thousand of you have looked at your panels and seen a number with no end."

A roar went up. It shook the windows. It went up the stair and up the Spire and set the great lantern at its peak swinging on its chain.

Lex didn't roar. He was watching the edge of the crowd. Where a knot of people stood together near the stair, apart from the rest. Fine cloaks. Fine

boots. Silver at their throats. And on their left arms, all of them, a band of grey cloth.

[The Ceiling Party,] said Ember. [Sorn's people. Nobles and their followers. They wear the grey bands in protest. Grey for the Ceiling.] A pause. [There's Sorn himself. In the middle. The tall one with the silver beard.]

Lex looked. A tall, broad, handsome man of sixty, with a silver beard trimmed to a point and a fine dark coat and a face like a carved statue of a wise old king. He was watching the Queen on the steps with an expression of polite, patient attention.

"Some say," said the Queen, *"that the Ceiling was a kindness. That it kept order. That it kept everyone in their place."*

The knot of nobles near the stair didn't move. But Lex saw Lord Chancellor Varric Sorn smile very slightly.

"I say," said the Queen, and her voice rang across the square like a bell, *"that no one's place is decided for them by a flag on a Stone. I say that every one of you has the right to climb as high as your gift will take you. I say that the Ceiling was not a kindness. It was a theft."*

The roar this time was so loud Lex felt it in his chest.

And under the roar, very faint, so faint he almost didn't feel it, something *turned*.



HE FELT IT IN the net.

A hole. Opening. Not far to the north. *Here*. In the square. In the crowd. Twenty paces from where he stood.

He spun around.

A man. A baker, by the flour on his apron. Middle-aged, round-faced, with a little boy on his shoulders holding a paper lantern. He was cheering with the rest of them. Shouting. His face red and happy.

And as Lex watched, he stopped.

In the middle of a cheer. Mid-word. As if a hand had been put over his mouth.

He looked down at his hands. Turned them over. Palms, backs, palms.

The little boy on his shoulders was still cheering. The woman beside him, his wife, by the flour on her apron too, was still cheering. Neither of them had noticed.

Lex used True Sight.

The world went gold. And he saw it. Saw the man's thread, bright and new, running out of him into the great net of the Lattice. *Unbound*. Lex could see the broken grey band, the Ceiling, rusted and hanging. He'd broken it himself. At the Lower Town Stone. The spring before last.

And he saw something else.

A second thread. Black. Thin as a hair. Running out of the man's chest, up into the air above the crowd. To a place in the empty air where the light was *wrong*. A shape. Hanging above the heads of ten thousand cheering people, black, the size of a man's hand.

A keyhole.

The black thread ran into it. And through it. And away.

And it was *pulling*.

The baker's thread was coming loose from the net. Lex could see it. Like a thread being drawn out of a hem, slowly, stitch by stitch. And as it came loose, the man was going *soft*. At the edges. Like chalk in rain.

His wife turned to him. Still smiling. Still cheering. She opened her mouth to say something to him.

And stopped.

She looked at him. At his face. And her expression changed. From joy to polite, puzzled, kindly confusion.

"I'm sorry," she said to her husband. "Do I know you?"



LEX MOVED.

He didn't think. He went through the crowd like a hot iron through wax, people stumbling out of his way, and reached the baker in three strides and grabbed his arm. And *reached*. With Root. With everything. Into the man's thread, the bright gold Unbound thread he'd freed himself, the one that was coming loose from the net stitch by stitch.

He grabbed it. And held on.

It was like grabbing a rope that a horse was pulling. The black thread was hauling on it. From the keyhole. From somewhere far away on the other side of the keyhole. Hauling, hauling, steady and strong and patient.

And Lex hauled back.

[Lex, you can't—] Ember. *[You can't win this. Whatever's on the other end, it's—]*

I know.

[Then let go before it pulls you through too!]

He didn't let go.

He held the baker's thread in both hands, in the place under the air, and pulled. And for one long moment, it held. The thread stopped coming loose. The baker stopped fading. His edges firmed up. His wife blinked.

And Lex looked up at the keyhole.

And saw through it.

Just for an instant. Like looking through an actual keyhole into a dark room. He saw a fire. A small one. In a strange land under a sky with too many stars. And sitting beside the fire, an old man in a grey cloak.

Not as old as he had been.

His hair was grey, but there was dark in it again. His face was lined, but the lines were softer. He sat straight. His hands were steady. And at his belt, on a chain of dull black iron, hung something black. The bow of a key. The ring at the end that your fingers hold to turn it. With a keyhole in its center.

His fingers were on it. Turning it.

He looked up. Through the keyhole. Across the impossible distance. Straight at Lex.

And smiled.

"Hello, Lex," said Elric Thorne.



THE THREAD TORE OUT of his hands.

Not slowly. Not stitch by stitch. All at once. Like a rope snapping. The black thread *yanked*, and the baker's bright gold thread came out of the net in a single rush, and out of Lex's grip, and up into the keyhole, and *through*.

And the baker faded.

All at once. In the space of a breath. Soft edges, pale colors, transparent, gone. His flour-dusted apron fell to the cobbles. The little boy on his shoulders fell too, and Lex caught him, and the boy stared up at him with a paper lantern in his hand and an expression of complete bewilderment.

"*Who are you?*" said the boy. "*Where's—*" He stopped. Frowned. "*I was sitting on something.*"

The woman was looking at the apron on the cobbles at her feet. Puzzled. She bent and picked it up. She looked at it.

"Someone's dropped this," she said. "It's got flour on it. Like mine." She looked around. "Is anyone missing an apron?"

Above the crowd, the keyhole closed. Healed over. A thin black scar in the air, already fading.

And nobody in the great square of Highcrest, out of ten thousand people cheering their Queen, had noticed a thing.

Except one.

Lex looked up. Across the square. Over the heads of the crowd. To the steps at the foot of the Spire, where the Queen stood with her lantern raised.

She wasn't looking at the crowd anymore. She wasn't speaking. She was looking straight at him. At the boy in his arms. At the woman holding the apron.

Her face was white.

She saw it, Lex thought. She saw it. She remembers.

And then he looked down at the boy in his arms. At the paper lantern. And he realized, with a cold lurch in his chest, that he didn't know the baker's name.

He'd Unbound him. The spring before last. At the Lower Town Stone. He'd held the man's thread in his hands not a minute ago. He'd seen his face.

He reached for the name. It wasn't there.

Not *forgotten*. Not the way you forget a name and it comes back later. *Gone*. Cut out. Like the thread. There was a hole in his memory the exact shape of a round-faced baker with a little boy on his shoulders, and the hole had no name in it at all.

[Lex,] said Ember. Its voice was shaking. [Lex, I can't remember him either. I was there. I saw him. And I can't—]

Lex stood in the middle of the great square with a stranger's child in his arms and ten thousand people cheering around him, and felt the cold go all the way through him to the bone.

He's getting stronger, he thought. Mella, I remembered. This one, I can't. He's getting stronger.

And somewhere very far away, beyond the end of every map, an old man by a fire took his fingers off a black key, and counted.

Forty-four.



HE LEFT AT DAWN.

He didn't tell anyone. He wrote a letter to his father, and one to Antho, and one to the Queen. Short ones. *I've gone north. Don't follow. I'll write.*

He wrote one to Wren. It was longer. He wrote it four times, and burned three, the way he'd once watched an old man burn letters by a candle in the dark, and stirred the ashes into a cup of water. The fourth one, he folded and left on the pillow in the room in the castle where she was sleeping. Where she'd gone to sleep without speaking to him.

It said: I'm sorry. I meant it. With you. Not for you. I'm breaking my word. I know I am. I'll spend the rest of my life making it up to you. Please be here when I come back. —L.

And under it, smaller: I love you. I'm an idiot. I know.

Then he went down to the castle courtyard in the grey light, where a stable-boy was asleep against a bucket and a vast blue dragon was curled on the flagstones like a cat by a fire.

Ashka opened one golden eye as he came near.

He put his hand on her warm blue scales.

"Not you," he said quietly. "Antho needs you. Go home with him. To the Hollowmaw. Watch the door."

The dragon looked at him for a long moment. Then a picture came into his head, sharp and bright and full of reproach. *Same blood. Alone. Stupid. Alone again. STUPID.*

"I know," said Lex.

He shouldered Anvilson, and walked out of the castle gate, and down through the waking city, and out through the north gate, and onto the road.

Alone.

[You know this is a mistake,] said Ember quietly, as the city fell away behind him into the morning mist.

Yes.

[You're doing it anyway.]

He took a man in the middle of a crowd of ten thousand people. Through a keyhole. From the other end of the world. Lex's jaw tightened. And I couldn't hold on. And I can't remember his name. He walked faster. If he can do that to a baker in the square at Highcrest, he can do it to anyone. Wren. Antho. Brannoc. Anyone with a bright thread.

[And you think going alone will stop that?]

I think if I'm alone, he has fewer threads to pull on.

Ember was quiet for a long time.

[Your father thought that too,] it said at last. *[Fifteen years ago.]*

Lex didn't answer.

He walked north. Toward the Ironbacks. Toward Harrowgate, and the high pasture where a blue shawl had lain in the heather. Toward the line of holes in the net that ran up into the strange pale sky beyond the end of every map.

Behind him, in the castle on the crag, a small slim figure with a fox-red braid stood at a window in a nightgown with a letter in her hand, and watched him go. She didn't cry. She'd stopped crying, mostly, years ago, on a mountain.

She just stood there, with the letter crushed in her fist, until he was out of sight.

Then she turned away from the window, and went to find her boots.

CHAPTER 3

UNVEILING DARKNESS



THE NORTH WAS EMPTY.

Not empty the way the Pale Wastes had been empty, white and dead and silent. Empty the way a house is empty when someone has just left it. The villages were still there, scattered up the long green valleys toward the Ironbacks. The fields were still planted. Smoke still rose from chimneys. People still worked and talked and laughed and sang.

But there were gaps.

Lex started noticing them on the third day out from Highcrest. A cottage at the edge of a village, its door standing open, its hearth cold, its garden going to weeds. When he asked the neighbors who lived there, they looked at him with polite, puzzled, kindly expressions and said *no one, as far as I know. It's always been empty.*

A chair at a tavern table, pulled out, with a mug of ale on the table in front of it, going flat. Nobody sitting in it. Nobody remembering who'd ordered it.

A child's wooden horse lying in the middle of a lane. A spinning wheel with half-spun wool still on the spindle. A pair of boots by a door, too big for anyone in the house.

Small things. Things nobody noticed. Things nobody could explain, and so nobody tried to.

[It's like walking through a room after someone's taken the furniture,] said Ember quietly, on the fifth day. *[You can see the marks on the floor where it used to be.]*

How many?

[I've been counting the holes. In the net. As we pass.] A pause. [Nineteen, so far. Since Highcrest.]

Nineteen.

[And every one of them Unbound. Every one in a bright place.] Ember's voice was very quiet. [He's not just picking the orchard anymore, Lex. He's harvesting it.]



HE USED TRUE SIGHT on every village Stone he passed.

It cost him a point of Authority each time. He had a hundred, and the Wells fed it back four times faster than the old way, so it didn't matter. He laid his palm on each grey lichened Stone in each village square and let the gold rise behind his eyes and looked down into it, into the threads, the way he'd looked into the Lower Town Stone in Highcrest three years ago and seen the flags.

And he saw the holes.

Not in the Stone itself. In the *record*. The Stone held every thread that had ever been Kindled at it, the living and the dead, a great bundle of gold and silver running down into the net like the roots of a tree. And here and there, among the roots, there was a place where a root *should* be and wasn't. A gap. Not a dead thread. Not a broken one. A *nothing*. As if someone had reached into the soil and pulled a root out so cleanly that the earth had closed over the hole behind it.

STONE: Coldbrook (N. Caldor)
Threads (living): 312
Threads (dead): 2,847
Anomalies:
VOID ×3 – thread: UNWRITTEN
Signature:  (Key – partial)

Unwritten.

He stood with his hand on the Coldbrook Stone for a long time.

[It's not death,] said Ember slowly. [Death leaves a thread. A dead thread, with an ending. A last date, a last place. Like the line drawn under a column of numbers.] A pause. [This leaves nothing. It's not like they died. It's like they were never born.]

Where do they go?

[The people? I don't know.] Ember was quiet for a moment. *[The mana? I can feel that. A little. Through the holes.]* A pause. *[It flows north. And east. Toward the Ironbacks. And beyond them.]*

To Elric.

[To whatever's on the other side of that keyhole. Yes.]



HE FOUND THE HALF-MAN on the seventh day.

He was crossing a high moor above Coldbrook, in the last of the evening light, with the Ironbacks rising grey and snow-streaked ahead of him. The wind was cold. The heather was purple. A curlew was crying somewhere over the bog.

And something was following him.

He felt it first. The way he'd learned to feel things, these three years, the way he felt slag in iron. A wrongness behind him. A flaw in the grain of the evening.

He stopped. He turned.

There was nothing there. Just the moor, and the heather, and the long grey line of the Ironbacks behind it.

He walked on.

A hundred paces later, he felt it again. Closer.

He stopped. He turned. He used True Sight.

The world went gold.

And there was a man standing in the heather twenty paces behind him.

Or most of one. Lex could see him only with True Sight. A young man, perhaps twenty, thin and dark-haired, in a farmer's smock and boots. But *faded*. Pale. Soft at the edges. Like a chalk drawing left out in the rain. Lex could see the heather through his legs. Through his chest. Through his face.

But not all the way. Not like the baker in the square, who'd gone from solid to nothing in the space of a breath. This man was stuck. Halfway. As if he'd started to fade and then something had caught him and held him there.

He was looking at Lex. His eyes were dark, and very frightened, and very, very lost.

"*You can see me,*" he said.

His voice was faint. Like a voice heard from the next room. Like a voice heard in a dream.

"Yes," said Lex.

The faded man made a sound. It might have been a laugh. It might have been a sob.

"*Nobody can see me,*" he said. "*Nobody. Not for weeks. I walk into villages and stand in front of people and shout, and they walk through me. They don't hear me. They don't see me.*" His faint voice cracked. "*I thought I was dead. I thought I was a ghost. But ghosts know their names.*"

"You don't know your name?"

The faded man looked at him for a long moment.

"No," he whispered.



LEX MADE A FIRE.

He did it with Flame, not flint. A ring of stones in a hollow in the heather, sheltered from the wind, and a few sticks of dead gorse, and a thought. *I'm cold. There's someone here who's lost. I want to keep him warm.* The fire came up gold and steady and leaned toward the faded man sitting on the other side of it, the way it leaned toward Lex.

The faded man stared at it.

"*It sees me,*" he said. "*The fire. It sees me.*"

"Fire sees most things," said Lex. "It's honest that way."

He looked at the man properly. With True Sight. Deep. The way he'd looked at Seraphine on the moor, three years ago, when Elric had wanted him to doubt her.

NAME: ██████████
Age: 21
Class: ██████████ (was: Uncommon)
Level: ███
THREAD: UNWRITTEN (partial – 71%)
Severed by: KEY (partial – Bow)
Anchored by: KIN-MEMORY
– source: ████████ VARN
(blood: sister)
Anchor strength: weakening
STATUS: FADING

Kin-memory.

[Someone's holding him,] said Ember softly. [His sister. Someone named Varn. She remembers him. And because she remembers him, he can't fade all the way.] A pause. [It's like the boy. Corin. He remembered Mella. But Mella faded anyway.]

Why didn't this one?

[I don't know.] Ember was quiet for a long moment. [Maybe the sister remembers him harder. Maybe she's doing something. Fighting for him.] Another pause. [Maybe she's a Listener.]

"Your sister," said Lex aloud. "Do you remember a sister?"

The faded man looked at him through the fire. His dark eyes were very far away.

"Fire," he said slowly. "There's fire. Someone with fire. Red hair. Laughing." His face creased, as if trying to see something through fog. "She burned the barn down once. When we were small. By accident. Da was so angry." He was almost smiling. "She laughed and laughed. She said it was the prettiest fire she ever saw."

"What's her name?"

The faded man opened his mouth.

Nothing came out.

He tried again. His face twisted with effort. His faint hands clenched on his faded knees.

"I can't," he whispered. "I can see her. I can hear her laughing. I can't—her name's gone. Mine's gone. They're both gone." His voice broke.

"I'm forgetting her face. A little more every day. Every day, she's a little less. And when she's gone, I'll be gone too." He looked at Lex across the fire. *"Won't I."*

Lex didn't answer.

He didn't have to.



THE FADED MAN FOLLOWED him into the Ironbacks.

Lex hadn't asked him to. He hadn't said no. In the morning, when he kicked out the fire and shouldered Anvilson and started up the long slope toward the mountains, the faded man was simply there, walking a few paces behind him, faint as mist in the early light.

"You're going north," the faded man said. *"Following the holes."*

"How did you know?"

"I can feel them. Like you can." He was quiet for a moment. *"I'm one of them, aren't I. A hole. Or most of one."* His faint voice was very calm. *"I can feel the others. The ones who went all the way. There's a pull. Like a current in a river. Going north and east."* He looked up at the Ironbacks. *"Toward whatever took me."*

"Do you remember it? What took you?"

The faded man walked in silence for a long time.

"A man," he said at last. *"Old. In grey. With a black key."* His voice dropped. *"I was in the field. Bringing the cows in. And he was just there. At the gate. He didn't say anything. He just looked at me. With such sad eyes."* He shuddered. *"And then he touched the key. And I felt something pull. Here."* He pressed his faint hand to his chest. *"Like a hook in a fish's mouth. And then I didn't know my name."*

[Elric,] said Ember.

I know.

"He said something," said the faded man. *"When I was fading. Before I stopped being able to hear."* He frowned. *"He said, I'm sorry. Very quietly. Like he meant it."* He looked at Lex. *"And then he said: It's nothing personal. I'm only taking what I'm owed."*



THE IRONBACKS WERE COLD and grey and very old.

Older than the Greyspine, Seraphine had told him once. Older than anything in Caldor. Worn down by ages of wind and ice into great rounded shoulders of grey rock, with long scree slopes and black tarns and snow that never melted in the high corries. Few people lived up there. A few shepherds. A few miners. A village here and there, tucked into a valley, clinging on.

Lex followed the holes.

He could feel them more clearly up here. The pull that the faded man had described. A current in the net, flowing north and east, carrying the mana of every unwritten thread away toward something. He followed it like a tracker follows a trail, up through the high passes, over the grey shoulders, past tarns as black and still as Mirrormere.

And on the tenth day, he found the scars.

They were hanging in the air above a high pass. A dozen of them. Thin black lines in the empty air, the shape of keyholes, healed over. Some old and faint. Some fresh and dark. In a line. Like footprints. Like the marks a man leaves when he's been walking the same path over and over.

"*He came this way,*" said the faded man. He was standing very still, looking at the scars. "*Many times.*"

Lex used True Sight on the nearest.

KEY-SCAR (healed)
Age: 14 days
Signature: BOW (Key of Shadows)
Direction: N/NE – origin point

"*Origin point,*" Lex read aloud.

[*He's been going somewhere,*] said Ember. [*And coming back. Over and over. Along this path.*] A pause. [*Somewhere in the north. Somewhere that matters.*]



THE SHADOWS CAME AT dusk.

Lex was making camp in the lee of a great grey boulder below the pass, with the faded man sitting faint and silent on the other side of a fire. The sky over the Ironbacks had gone from grey to deep blue. The first stars were coming out. The wind had dropped.

And the shadows of the rocks began to move.

Not the way shadows move when the sun goes down, slowly, stretching. They moved *wrong*. They peeled up off the ground. Off the boulders. Off the scree. They rose up into the air like smoke rising off a fire, and folded, and took shape.

Not Gloam. Lex knew Gloam. Gloam was oily and black and stank of wet ash and nothing. These were different. Thinner. Cleaner. Almost *beautiful*. Like shadows cast by a candle on a wall. Tall, and slender, and shaped like men in long cloaks, and their faces were smooth and featureless, like the faces of the Lumen Wardens at Avaloria, only dark instead of light.

UMBRAL WARDEN – Level 1 52

(x6)

Origin: KEY OF SHADOWS

(guardian – Aurelian's shadow)

"Aurelian's shadow," Lex breathed.

[He forged the Key from his own shadow,] said Ember sharply. [Your father said so. Cut it off the ground and folded it on the anvil like steel. These are—] It stopped. [These are pieces of it. Left behind. Guarding the path.]

The faded man had leaped to his feet. He was backing away from the fire, his faint face twisted with terror.

"Them," he whispered. "They came with him. The old man. When he took me. They stood behind him at the gate."

The Umbral Wardens turned their smooth dark faces toward the fire.

Toward the faded man.

And they *reached*.



LEX WAS ON HIS feet with Anvilson in his hands before the first one moved.

He hit it with an Ember Strike. A Tier III Forgeheart's Ember Strike, Well-fed, Flame at Speaking. Three years ago, at Duskhold, it would have torn a hole through a Hollow-knight and the three behind it.

It went through the Umbral Warden like a hand through smoke.

The shadow didn't burst. It didn't scream. It *rippled*, the way a reflection ripples in water, and reformed, and turned its smooth dark face toward him.

[*It's not Gloam,*] said Ember fast. [*Fire doesn't eat it. It's not hungry. It's not the Hollow. It's shadow**. Aurelian's shadow. Forged.]* A pause. [*It's a made thing, Lex. Like your hammer.*]

The shadow struck back.

Not with a weapon. It reached out with one long dark hand and touched Lex's chest, and something *pulled*. Like a hook in a fish's mouth. Like a thread being drawn out of a hem.

He felt it go for his thread. His bright gold Root-thread, running out of him into the net. Felt the cold dark fingers close on it. Felt them *tug*.

[*LEX—*]

He didn't let them. He reached down for Stone. The old slow heavy hum of the mountain under his feet, the oldest mountain in Caldor. And he *rooted*. Like a tree in a gale. Like an anvil on a stump. He made himself heavy. Immovable. The Umbral Warden tugged at his thread and the thread didn't come, because Lex was holding it, and Stone was holding Lex, and the mountain was holding Stone.

The shadow tugged harder.

And behind it, the other five were reaching for the faded man.

He was backing away across the heather, his faint hands raised in front of his face, and the five tall dark shapes were drifting after him, and Lex could see it: their long dark fingers stretching out toward the faint, faded thread still running out of the man's chest. The seventy-one percent that had already been cut. The twenty-nine that was still holding on, anchored by a sister's memory.

They were going to finish it.

"NO—"

Lex tore free of the shadow that held him. He didn't know how. He just *pulled*, with Stone, with the mountain, with everything, and the cold dark fingers slipped off his thread, and he was running. Across the heather. Toward the faded man. Toward the five shadows reaching for him.

He didn't have anything that worked on them. Flame went through them. Stone held him but didn't hurt them. They weren't Gloam, they weren't Hollow, they weren't anything he'd ever fought.

They're made things, Ember had said. *Like your hammer.*

He was a smith.



HE THREW HIMSELF BETWEEN the faded man and the shadows.

He didn't use Ember Strike. He didn't use Flame. He reached for Aurelian's little hand-hammer, the one with the open hand and the flame on its head, the one he kept in his belt and had never once used in a fight. It was a tool. A fine-work hammer. For coaxing runes into clay lamps and silver wire.

He pulled it out, and he did the only thing a smith knows how to do with a made thing he doesn't understand.

He looked for the flaw.

He used True Sight. And Forge Sense. And Stone. All at once. On the nearest Umbral Warden. And he *listened* to it, the way he listened to iron. For the dull note under the ring. For the place where the maker had been careless.

And he found it.

It was very small. A seam. Deep in the dark weave of the shadow, at the place where a heart would be. A place where, nine hundred years ago, a smith had folded his own shadow on an anvil, and folded it again, and again, and somewhere in all that folding, he'd been in a hurry, or tired, or afraid. And he'd left a tiny gap. A slag pocket. A flaw.

Lex reached out with Aurelian's hammer and tapped it.

Tink.

The Umbral Warden came apart.

Not burst. Not shattered. *Unfolded.* The way a badly-made blade unfolds along its seams when you strike it in the wrong place. The tall dark shape simply opened, like a flower blooming in fast motion, and its folds fell away from each other, and fell, and lay on the heather.

Just shadow. Ordinary shadow. The shadow of a boulder, lying on the ground where it belonged.

The other four stopped.

They turned their smooth dark faces toward him. Toward the little hammer in his hand. And Lex thought, though they had no faces to show it, that they *recognized* it.

His, they seemed to say. *His hammer. The maker's hammer.*

"Yes," said Lex. "*His.*" He raised it. "*And I know where he was careless.*"



HE UNMADE THEM. ALL five. And the one that had held him by the boulder.

It wasn't fast. It wasn't easy. Each one had its flaw in a different place, and he had to find each one, listening, while they reached for him and he rooted himself in Stone and held. One had its seam in the throat. One at the wrist. One, the last one, so deep in its core that he had to let it get its cold fingers on his thread before he could get close enough to hear it.

But he found them all.

Tink. Tink. Tink.

And when it was over, there were six shadows lying on the heather in the starlight, where shadows belonged. And the moor was quiet. And the faded man was sitting in the heather with his faint arms wrapped around his faint knees, shaking.

UMBRAL WARDEN ×6 – UNMADE
+XP

LEVEL UP!
Forgeheart Sorcerer – Level 62

SKILL GAINED: Unmaking
"Find the maker's flaw. Strike
there. What was folded, unfolds."

Unmaking.

Lex looked at the word for a long time.

[That's an uncomfortable name for a skill,] said Ember quietly.

The Unmaker unmakes things.

[Yes.] A pause. *[But that's not what you did. The Unmaker takes things back to before they were. You took a made thing back to what it was made*

from*.]* Another pause. *[A shadow, back to a shadow. That's not unmaking. That's just... honest smithing.]*

Lex looked down at Aurelian's little hammer in his hand.

He was careless, he thought. Aurelian. The greatest smith who ever lived. He left flaws in his own shadow.

[Everyone leaves flaws,] said Ember. [Your father says so. He says the only smiths who don't leave flaws are the ones who never make anything.]



THE FADED MAN WAS looking at him.

He'd stopped shaking. He was sitting very still in the heather, faint and pale in the starlight, with his dark eyes fixed on Lex's face.

"You saved me," he said. *"They were going to finish it. I felt them. And you saved me."*

"I'm sorry I can't do more."

"You can see me," said the faded man. *"You can hear me. That's more than anyone's done in weeks."* He was quiet for a moment. *"I don't know your name."*

"Lex."

"Lex," the faded man repeated. Carefully. The way the Queen had said *Mella Bell*. As if writing it down. *"I'll try to remember. As long as I can remember anything."*

He looked north. Up at the high pass. At the line of keyhole-shaped scars hanging in the dark air, faint and black.

"There's a place," he said slowly. *"At the end of the scars. I can feel it. The pull's strongest there."* His faint brow creased. *"A temple. Old. Older than anything. Ice and stone."* He shuddered. *"And something else. Someone else. Fire."* His voice cracked. *"Red hair. Laughing."*

Lex went very still.

"She's there," whispered the faded man. *"I think. Or she's going there. My sister."* He looked at Lex. *"She's looking for me. She's been looking for me since I faded. That's why I'm not gone."* He pressed his faint hand to his chest. *"I can feel her. Holding on."*

[The anchor,] said Ember. [Kin-memory. Varn.]

"What's the temple called?" said Lex.

The faded man was quiet for a long time, looking north.

"I don't know," he said at last. "But the scars go there. All of them. Every time." He looked at the six ordinary shadows lying in the heather. "And they came from there. Those things. I can feel it."



LEX DIDN'T SLEEP MUCH that night.

He sat by the fire with Aurelian's little hammer in his lap, turning it over and over in the gold light. The open hand and the flame, worn almost smooth on its head. The pale wood of the haft, worn dark in exactly the places his own fingers fell.

He made those shadows, he thought. Aurelian. Nine hundred years ago. He cut off his own shadow and folded it on an anvil and made a key out of it. And then he made guardians out of the scraps, to watch the path.

[Yes.]

And Elric's using it. The key. To cut people out of the world.

[Yes.]

And Father knew. Three years. He knew someone had turned it. He knew it was probably Elric. Lex closed his hand around the little hammer. And he didn't tell us. And now there are forty-four people nobody remembers.

[Forty-five,] said Ember quietly. [I felt another one. An hour ago. Far to the east.]

Lex didn't say anything.

Across the fire, the faded man was lying in the heather with his eyes closed. Sleeping, or something like it. He was a little fainter than he'd been at dusk. Lex was almost sure. A little more of the heather showing through his chest.

Every day, she's a little less, he'd said. And when she's gone, I'll be gone too.

Lex looked up at the line of keyhole-shaped scars hanging in the dark air above the pass. Pointing north. Toward a temple of ice and stone, older than anything. Toward a woman with red hair who burned a barn down once and laughed.

[Lex,] said Ember, very gently. [You know your father's going to be furious. About you going alone.]

I know.

[And Wren.]

I know.

[And Antho.]

I know, Ember.

The voice was quiet for a long moment.

[I'm glad I'm here, at least,] it said at last. [You can't go entirely alone. Not while I'm around.]

Lex almost smiled.

No, he thought. I suppose I can't.

In the morning, they went north. The smith, and the voice in his head, and a faded man with no name, following a line of scars toward a temple at the end of the world.

CHAPTER 4

THE TEMPLE OF YSMIR



THE WORLD ENDED IN ice.

Lex had known it would. Seraphine's maps said so. North of the Ironbacks, the land fell away in long grey slopes to a coast that no one in Caldor had visited in living memory, and beyond the coast, the sea froze. Not in winter. Always. A white sea, flat and endless, stretching away under a pale sky to a horizon that shimmered with strange lights at night. The old texts called it the White Shore. The maps just stopped.

He came down to it on the fourteenth day out of Highcrest.

The faded man walked beside him. Fainter now. Lex could see the snow through his chest when he looked at him without True Sight, and with True Sight, the gold panel over his head read *THREAD: UNWRITTEN (partial — 76%)*. Five percent in a week. *Anchor strength: weakening*.

He didn't talk much anymore. When he did, his voice was so faint Lex had to stop walking to hear it.

"*There*," he said, on the fourteenth evening.

Lex looked.

The coast curved away to the east in a long white arc. And at the far end of the arc, where a great river of ice came down out of the mountains and met the frozen sea, there was a glacier. Blue-white and enormous, a wall of ice a thousand feet high. And carved into its face, the way the Barrow-King's door had been carved into the side of the mound, there was a temple.

Columns. Arches. Stairs. All carved from the living ice of the glacier itself, blue and white and glittering in the last of the sunset. A great arched doorway, three hundred feet tall, opening into darkness. And above it, carved into the ice in letters taller than a man, Wellsript.

[Ysmir,] read Ember. [Temple of Ysmir. Keeper of What Was.]

And the scars led straight to it.

A line of them. Dozens. Keyhole-shaped, black, healed over, hanging in the air above the frozen shore like footprints. Old and new. Faint and dark. Leading up the long white slope of the shore to the great arched doorway in the ice.

And the doorway was cracked.

Lex could see it from a mile off. A great jagged split running up through the carved ice of the arch, from the threshold to the keystone. Black. Fresh. And spreading out from it, smaller cracks, a web of them, running through the columns and the stairs and the carved Wellsript like the cracks in a dropped plate.

[He's been breaking it,] said Ember quietly. [Every time he comes. A little more.]

Why?

[I don't know. Looking for something, maybe. Or just—not caring what he breaks to get it.]



THE INSIDE OF THE temple was blue.

Blue ice. Blue light. The light came from the ice itself, the way the white stone had glowed at Avaloria, a soft blue radiance that came from everywhere and cast no shadows. The great doorway opened into a hall so vast that Lex couldn't see its ceiling, only a blue dimness overhead, like the inside of a frozen wave. Columns of ice as thick as oaks rose up into it. The floor was ice too, smooth and clear and so deep that Lex could see things frozen in it far below his feet.

He stopped. He looked down.

There were *things* in the ice. Under the floor. Deep down, suspended like flies in amber.

A book, open, its pages spread. A sword. A child's toy, a little wooden boat. A woman's comb. A loaf of bread. A letter, folded. Hundreds of things. Thousands. Scattered through the deep blue ice under the floor of the hall like stars in a night sky.

[Ysmir,] said Ember slowly. [Keeper of What Was. She was one of the Founders. Aurelian's sister. The second oldest. Malachi mentioned her, once.] A pause. [The Founders' records say she kept the memories of the world. Things that were lost. Things that were forgotten. She froze them here, so they'd never be lost again.]

"Memories," whispered the faded man. He was standing very still beside Lex, looking down into the ice. "They're memories."

He knelt. He laid his faint hand on the ice of the floor. Lex saw his fingers go through it, a little. Not all the way. Just into the surface, the way a hand goes into deep water.

"I can feel them," said the faded man. "Every one. A boy who lost his boat in a river. A woman who lost her comb on her wedding day. A man who wrote a letter to his brother and never sent it." His voice cracked. "They're all here. Everything anyone ever lost."

Lex knelt beside him.

"Is yours here?" he said quietly. "Your name?"

The faded man looked at him. Then down into the ice. Searching. Deep down. Further.

"No," he whispered. "Not here. Not yet." He swallowed. "But maybe deeper."



THEY WENT DEEPER.

The great hall opened at its far end into passages. Dozens of them. Branching away into the glacier like the roots of a tree. Blue and glowing and silent. And every passage had things frozen in its walls and floor and ceiling. Memories. Lost things. A pair of spectacles. A wedding ring. A drawing, in a child's hand, of a house with a lantern in the window.

The scars led them. The black keyhole-shaped scars, hanging in the air of the passages. Elric had come this way. Many times. And every time he'd come, he'd broken something. The cracks were everywhere here. Running

through the walls. Splitting the frozen memories inside them. Lex passed a crack that ran straight through a frozen letter, splitting it in half, and the two halves had drifted apart in the ice like two pieces of a broken boat.

[He doesn't care,] said Ember. Its voice was very cold. [About any of it. He walks through here and breaks it as he goes.]

The faded man walked close beside Lex, and every time they passed a cracked memory, he flinched.

And then they heard the fire.



IT CAME FROM AHEAD. Down a passage. Around a bend. A roar. Not the roar of a wind or a beast. The deep throaty crackling roar of a fire. A *big* one. Bigger than anything should be able to burn in a temple made of ice.

And a voice. A woman's. Shouting.

"Come on, then! Come ON! I've burned a dozen of you already! I'll burn a dozen more! Come and get it, you faceless—"

The rest of it was lost in the roar.

Lex ran.

He came around the bend into a round chamber of blue ice, and stopped.

There was a woman in the middle of it.

She was tall and lean and fierce, in a long red coat scorched black at the hem, with a mane of red hair so bright it looked like it was burning. It *was* burning. Lex saw that a heartbeat later. Little flames were dancing along the ends of it, licking up toward her ears, and she didn't seem to notice. Her face was sharp and freckled and twisted in a snarl. And her hands—

Her hands were on fire. Both of them. To the wrist. Great roaring gouts of orange-red flame pouring off her fingers, and she was flinging them in great arcs around her, a whirling storm of fire that lit the whole round chamber orange and set the blue ice walls streaming with meltwater.

And around her, closing in, the Umbral Wardens.

Eight of them. Tall and dark and featureless, their long shadowy fingers reaching. And her fire was going *through* them. The way Lex's Ember

Strike had gone through them on the moor. They rippled. They reformed. They kept coming.

"Burn, damn you!" the red-haired woman was screaming. "*Why won't you BURN?*"

One of them reached her. Its long dark fingers touched her chest.

And *pulled*.

Lex saw her stagger. Saw her face go white with shock. Saw her fire flicker and gutter.

And then saw something that made his heart stop.

Nothing happened.

The shadow's fingers were on her chest, pulling, the way they'd pulled on Lex's thread on the moor, the way they'd pulled on the faded man's. But there was nothing there to pull. No thread. No silver. No gold. Nothing running out of her into the net at all.

[*She's not in the Lattice,*] said Ember sharply. [*Lex. She's not in it at all. She's never been Kindled.*]

The shadow pulled at nothing. And the red-haired woman, finding herself still standing, still whole, threw back her burning head and *laughed*. A wild, delighted, furious laugh.

"Ha!" she shouted. "*Can't get me, can you! Nothing to hook! Nothing to—*"

And the other seven shadows, finding nothing to pull, simply raised their long dark hands, and struck her.

Not her thread. *Her*. Her body. Seven blows at once, from seven directions, cold and hard as black ice. And she went down.



LEX WAS THERE BEFORE she hit the floor.

He didn't think about it. He went in under the reaching shadows with Aurelian's little hammer already in his hand and True Sight already blazing behind his eyes, listening for the flaws. *Tink*. One. *Tink*. Two. They came apart around him like flowers blooming in fast motion, unfolding, falling, lying on the blue ice floor as ordinary shadows.

Tink. Tink. Tink.

The last one had its flaw so deep he had to step into its arms to find it. Cold. So cold. Its dark fingers on his chest, on his thread, pulling. He rooted himself in Stone and held. And reached in, past the cold, past the dark, and found it. A tiny seam. A place where a smith nine hundred years ago had folded too fast.

Tink.

It unfolded.

And the round chamber of blue ice was quiet. And full of steam. And there were eight ordinary shadows lying on the floor, and a woman in a scorched red coat lying among them, and a young man with gold eyes standing over her with a little hand-hammer in his fist.

UMBRAL WARDEN x8 – UNMADE
Unmaking → Novice 4

The woman rolled over. She looked up at him.

Her eyes were amber. Bright, fierce, burning amber, like a fire seen through honey. They took in his face. His gold eyes. The hammer in his hand. The eight dead shadows around them.

And her face twisted.

"*You*," she snarled. "*You're with HIM.*"

She came up off the floor like a striking snake. Fire roared off her hands. She swung a burning fist at his head.



HE CAUGHT IT.

He didn't know he was going to. His hand just came up, the way it came up to catch a falling tool, and closed around her burning wrist. And the fire, which should have taken the skin off his palm, which would have taken the skin off anyone else's palm, *leaned*.

Toward him.

The way the fire in Malachi's hearth leaned. The way the eternal fire under the water at Qel'Varran leaned. Her fire, her wild red-orange fire, pouring off her fingers, bent toward his hand like a flower toward a window. And curled around his fingers. And didn't burn.

The red-haired woman stared at her own hand.

At her fire, wrapping itself around a stranger's fingers like a cat around an ankle.

"*What*," she said. Very quietly. "*What are you?*"

"A smith," said Lex.

"*That's not what I asked.*"

"It's the only answer I've got." He let go of her wrist. Slowly. Her fire stayed curled around his fingers for a moment, then drifted back to her, reluctantly. "I'm not with him. The old man with the key. I'm hunting him."

"*Liar.*" But she didn't swing again. She was staring at him. At his eyes. "*You've got gold eyes. Root eyes. Like him. Like his key. I've seen them in the dark, when he cuts people out.*" Her voice cracked. "*And you unmade those things like you knew where they'd been made. Like you made them.*"

"They were made by my ancestor," said Lex. "Nine hundred years ago. I know where he was careless."

"*Your—*" She stopped.

[*Lex,*] said Ember. [*Look at her. Properly.*]

He looked. With True Sight. Deep.

And there was nothing there.

No panel. No silver. No gold. No threads. Like Malachi. The Lattice looked at her and saw nothing at all. She'd never been Kindled. She'd never been in the net.

But there was something else. Not in the Lattice. *Under* it. In the place where the river ran. He could feel it, the way he felt Flame in Malachi's hearth. A fire. Wild and bright and furious and *bers*. Answering her. The way it answered him.

[*She's a Listener,*] breathed Ember. [*An unlatticed one. Flame. Answering, at least. Maybe more.*] A pause. [*No wonder the shadows couldn't pull her thread. She doesn't have one.*]

And then Lex felt something else.

Behind him. In the doorway of the round chamber. Faint as mist.

The faded man.

He'd come in. Lex hadn't noticed. He was standing in the doorway with his faint hands at his sides and his faint face turned toward the red-haired woman. And he was *brighter*.

Not much. Not solid. But brighter. More there. The blue ice of the doorway showing a little less clearly through his chest. And his dark eyes were fixed on the woman's face, wide and wondering.

"Red hair," he whispered. "*Laughing. Fire.*"

The woman didn't turn. She couldn't see him. She couldn't hear him. She was still staring at Lex.

But her hand, the one that had been on fire, came up to her chest. To the place over her heart. And pressed there. As if something had hurt her.

"What," she said, "*did you just do?*"

"Nothing," said Lex. "I didn't do anything." He didn't look away from her. "What's your name?"

She hesitated. "*Kestrel,*" she said. "*Kestrel Varn.*"

Varn.

Anchored by: KIN-MEMORY. Source: [REDACTED] VARN. Blood: sister.

"Kestrel," said Lex gently. "Do you have a brother?"



SHE WENT WHITE.

It was like watching a fire go out. All the fury drained out of her face at once. Her amber eyes went wide. Her hand, pressed over her heart, clenched into a fist.

"How," she whispered. "*How do you—nobody knows. Nobody remembers. I don't even—*" She stopped. Her voice cracked. "*I don't even remember. Not really. I don't remember his name. I don't remember his face.*" She was shaking. "*I just know. I know I had one. I know there was someone. Someone who's supposed to be there, next to me, and isn't. Like a tooth that's been pulled.*" She pressed her fist harder against her chest. "*Everyone says I'm mad. My village. My friends. They say I never had a brother. They say I'm grieving for someone who never existed.*"

"You're not mad," said Lex.

"How would you know?"

"Because he's standing behind me," said Lex. "In the doorway. And he's been following me for a week. And he remembers you." He swallowed. "Red hair. Laughing. You burned the barn down once, when you were

small. By accident. Your father was so angry. You laughed and laughed and said it was the prettiest fire you ever saw."

Kestrel Varn made a sound like something tearing.

She looked past him. At the doorway. At the place where the faded man stood, faint and pale and staring at her.

She couldn't see him. Lex could tell she couldn't see him. Her amber eyes went straight through him to the blue ice of the passage beyond.

But she took a step toward him anyway.

And another.

And stopped, in the middle of the round chamber, a pace from the doorway. Close enough to touch, if she'd known he was there.

"*Are you there?*" she whispered. Not to Lex. To the empty doorway. "*Are you really there?*"

"*Kes,*" said the faded man.

It came out of him like a breath. Like a word he'd been trying to say for weeks and hadn't been able to find, and suddenly there it was, on his tongue, as if it had never been gone.

"*Kes. Kessie. Kestrel.*" His faint face was crumpling. "*Your name's Kestrel. You're my sister. You're my sister.**"

She couldn't hear him.

But Lex saw her face change. Saw her flinch. Saw her hand come up to her ear, as if something had brushed past it.

"*Kessie,*" she whispered. "*Nobody calls me that. Nobody's ever—*" She stopped. "*Only—*" Her face twisted. "*Only one person ever called me that. I can't remember who. I can't remember who, but I remember—*"

And the fire came off her.

Not wildly. Not in a storm. Gently. Slowly. Out of her hands, out of her burning hair, out of her chest where her fist was pressed. It rose up around her in a soft golden-red halo, warm and steady, like a hearth on a winter night. And it *leaned*.

Toward the doorway. Toward the faded man.

And wrapped around him.

Lex saw it. With True Sight. Saw the fire reach the faint, faded shape in the doorway and curl around it like a blanket. And saw the panel over the faded man's head flicker.

THREAD: UNWRITTEN (partial)

76% → 73% → 70%

Anchored by: KIN-MEMORY + FLAME

– source: KESTREL VARN

Anchor strength: STRENGTHENING

[She's holding him,] whispered Ember. *[With Flame. She doesn't even know she's doing it. She can't see him. She can't hear him. But her fire can.]*

The faded man was weeping. Faint tears on a faint face, in a halo of his sister's fire.

"Kes," he said. "Kes, I'm here. I'm right here."

And Kestrel Varn, standing in the middle of a round chamber of blue ice in a temple at the end of the world, with her fire wrapped around a brother she couldn't see, began to cry.



IT WAS A LONG time before anyone said anything.

They sat on the blue ice floor, the three of them. Lex. Kestrel. And the faded man, sitting so close to his sister that if he'd been solid their shoulders would have touched. Her fire was still curled around him, low and gold. She'd stopped crying. She was staring at the place where he sat, where she couldn't see him, with an expression Lex had seen once before.

On Antho's face. In the Hollowmaw. Looking at a little clay lamp.

"Tell me," she said at last. Hoarse. "Tell me what he looks like. Tell me what he says."

Lex told her.

Thin and dark-haired. Twenty-one. A farmer's smock. Dark eyes. He'd been bringing the cows in, the day the old man came. He remembered her burning the barn. He remembered her red hair.

He didn't remember his own name.

"Tamsin," said Kestrel.

It came out of her very suddenly. As if it had been knocked loose. She stared at the empty air beside her, her amber eyes very wide.

"Tamsin," she said again. "Tam. His name's Tamsin. Tamsin Varn." Her voice broke. "I didn't—I couldn't remember. For weeks. I couldn't

remember, and now it's—" She pressed her hands over her mouth. "Tamsin."

The faded man had gone very still.

"Tamsin," he whispered. "Tamsin. That's—" His faint face changed. Like a lamp being lit in a window. "That's me. That's my name. Tamsin."

THREAD: UNWRITTEN (partial – 70% → 64%)

NAME: TAMSIN VARN (restored –
kin-speech)

[A name,] breathed Ember. [She said his name. Out loud. And it went back into him.] Its voice was shaking. [Lex, that's how. That's how you fight it. The Key cuts the thread out of the Lattice. But if someone remembers the name, and says it—]

It goes back in.

[Not the thread. Not all of it. But the name.] A pause. [Like the Drowned Dead. Like Antho on the causeway. Saying their names. And they remembered themselves.]

Lex looked at Tamsin Varn, sitting in his sister's fire. Still faded. Still faint. But less. A little less. And with a name.

"Your brother says thank you," he told Kestrel. "He says it's a good name."

Kestrel laughed. Wet and broken.

"It's a terrible name," she said. "Mam named him after a sheep. A prize ram. At the Coldbrook fair. Da never let her forget it." She wiped her face. "I used to call him Tam the Ram. He hated it."

"I did," said Tamsin faintly. "I really did."

Lex didn't tell her that. He didn't need to. She was smiling.



"He took him," said Kestrel, later. "The old man in grey. With the key."

They were still in the round chamber. She'd built a fire on the blue ice floor, a real one, from the scorched remains of a wooden chest that had been frozen in the wall and thawed out by her fury. It burned without melting the ice beneath it. She said it was a trick her grandmother taught her.

"Did you see him?" said Lex.

"No. I wasn't there. I was in the hills. Hunting." Her amber eyes were hard. "I came home and the farm was empty. Half the beds in the house were stripped. There was a boy's coat on a hook by the door that nobody would admit to owning." Her jaw tightened. "And there was a scar. In the air above the cow gate. Black. Shaped like a keyhole."

"You followed it."

"I followed it. And then I found another one. And another." She stared into the fire. "Six weeks. I've been following them for six weeks. Across the Ironbacks. Up to the White Shore. Into this frozen pile of ice." She looked around at the blue walls. "It's where they all go. Every scar I've found. They all end up here eventually. He comes here. Over and over."

"Why?"

Kestrel looked at him.

"I don't know," she said. "But I've been through half the passages. And there's one at the very bottom that goes down further than all the rest. And it's warded. Old wards. Older than anything." She paused. "And the scars stop right in front of it. Every one. Like he goes up to the door, and stops, and can't get in."

[Founders' wards,] said Ember. [On the deepest part of the temple. Wards that open only to—]

Blood, thought Lex.

He looked at Kestrel.

"Take me there," he said.



THE PASSAGE AT THE bottom of the temple went down a long way.

Down through the blue glowing ice. Down past frozen memories growing older and older, stranger and stranger. Coins with faces on them Lex didn't recognize. Swords of a shape he'd never seen. A crown. A great iron key, as long as his arm, frozen sideways in the wall like a fish in a lake.

The cracks were everywhere. Black. Fresh. Running through everything.

And at the bottom, there was a door.

It was ice, like everything else. Blue and clear and glowing. A tall narrow arch, barely wide enough for one person to pass through. And carved into its surface, deep and fine and perfect, a symbol.

An open hand, palm up. And above the palm, not a flame.

A keyhole.

And in front of it, hanging in the air in a cluster so thick it looked like a swarm of black flies, the scars. Dozens of them. Hundreds. Healed-over keyholes, black and faint, all crowded together in the air in front of the door. As if someone had stood here over and over and over, trying to cut his way in. And failed. Every time.

"*There,*" said Kestrel. "*He can't get through. I've watched. I saw him do it once. Two weeks ago. I hid in a side passage and watched him stand here for an hour, turning that black key over and over in his hands, cutting at the door.*" She shook her head. "*Nothing. It just healed. Every time.*"

"Did he say anything?"

Kestrel was quiet for a moment.

"*He said: Not mine. It's never mine.*" Her mouth twisted. "*And then he hit the wall with his fist so hard he cracked it. And walked away.*"

Lex stood in front of the ice door with the swarm of black scars hanging in the air around him.

He looked at the carving. The open hand. The keyhole.

[*Vey,*] said Ember quietly. [*That's the Vey sigil. Only it's a keyhole instead of a flame.*] A pause. [*This door opens to blood. Like Avaloria. Like the waystation in the Frostvault.*]

And Elric can't get in.

[*Elric isn't blood.*] Another pause. [*Elric has never been blood.*]

Lex laid his palm on the ice.

The door didn't dissolve. It didn't swing open. It didn't do anything at all, for a long moment.

And then a voice spoke.

Not in the air. Not in his head. In the ice. In every frozen memory in the whole glowing temple, all at once, so that the words came from everywhere. Old. A woman's voice. Calm and precise and very, very sad.

Blood of my brother. Blood of the one who made the Key.

You have come at last.

I have been keeping this for you for nine hundred years.

And the ice door went clear as glass. And through it, Lex could see a small round room. And in the center of the room, on a plinth of blue ice, something frozen in a block so clear it seemed to be floating in the air.

A book. Open. Its pages blank.

And above it, hanging in the air, written in letters of frozen light, a verse.

CHAPTER 5

THE CURSED PROPHECY



THE VERSE HUNG IN the air above the frozen book like breath on a winter morning. Letters of light, pale blue-white, written in Wellsript so old that even Ember had to read it slowly, word by word, the way Lex had once read the hymn-board in the Ashbourne chapel when he was six.

[Give me a moment,] it said. [This is—old. Older than the Book of Making. Older than anything I've seen.] A pause. [All right. All right. Here.]

And it read it to him, in the quiet of his head, while the blue light of the vault moved across his face.

*Three the pieces: bow and bit and blade.
One in the sundered dark, where the old roads fade;
One in the glass, where the sun was unmade;
One under lanterns, where the door is laid.
When three are one, and the turning's paid,
The lid will lift, and the night will stay,
And what was hungry will have its day.
Only a made hand can unmake the made.
Only the blood that forged it can bar the way.
And the blood that bars it, the blood will pay.*

Lex read it twice. The second time, the last line seemed to settle into his chest like a stone dropped into a well, falling and falling and never hitting bottom.

And the blood that bars it, the blood will pay.

"Well," said Kestrel Varn, behind him. *"That's cheerful."*

He turned. She was standing in the narrow arch of the ice door, peering past his shoulder, her amber eyes narrowed. She couldn't read Wellsript. But the letters of light were reflected in her eyes, and she was frowning at them as if they'd insulted her mother.

"You can't read it," he said.

"I don't need to read it. I can feel it." She rubbed her arms. *"It's like walking past a gallows. Every hair on my body's standing up."* She glanced at him. *"What does it say?"*

He told her.

She was quiet for a while after.

"Bow, bit and blade," she said at last. *"That's a key. The parts of a key. The bow's the handle. The bit's the teeth. The blade's the shaft between them."* She looked at him. *"He's got the bow. I've seen it. Round his neck on a chain. Black as a hole in the world."*

"Yes."

"So there's two more."

"Yes."

"In the glass where the sun was unmade, and under lanterns where the door is laid." She chewed her lip. *"I don't know what either of those means."*

Lex did.

Not the first one. Not yet. But the second—

Under lanterns. Where the door is laid.

[Lex,] said Ember, very quietly. [The Hollowmaw.]

He'd thought it before Ember said it. Hundreds of lanterns, hanging in the dark of a mountain cave. All of them lit now. A door between the world and the Hollow, sealed by two brothers with a lamp and a song. And his brother, living in the middle of it. With students. With a dragon. Watching the door.

It's under the Hollowmaw. The third piece. That's why there was a breach there in the first place. That's why it opened there and nowhere else.

[And Elric knows it.] Ember's voice was cold. *[He has to. He's been looking for nine hundred years' worth of hiding places with Aurelian whispering in his ear. If the voice told him the bit was in the glass, it's told him where the blade is too.]*

Then why hasn't he gone for it?

[Because the Hollowmaw is the most guarded place in Caldor. Because your brother is Tier III and doesn't sleep much, and there's a storm-drake the size of a barn sitting on the doorstep.] A pause. *[Because he wants all three, and he's taking them in order. The easy ones first.]*

Lex stood very still in the blue light.

I sent Ashka home with Antho, he thought. *I told her, watch the door.*

[You did right.]

Did I? Or did I just put every one of the people I love in one place, right on top of the thing he wants most?

Ember didn't answer.



"Blood of my brother."

The voice came from everywhere. From the walls. From the floor. From every frozen memory in the glacier, all at once, so that the whole vault seemed to speak with one calm sad voice.

And then it came from somewhere particular.

From the ice behind the plinth. Lex saw it move. Not crack. *Move*, the way still water moves when something rises up through it from underneath. A shape, coming up through the clear blue ice from far down, from the deep places where the oldest memories were frozen. Taller than a man. Slender. Pale. Drawing nearer and clearer, the way a face comes clear through a frosted window when someone breathes on the glass.

A woman.

She stepped out of the ice.

She wasn't solid. She wasn't a ghost either, not the way the Drowned Dead had been ghosts, or the Barrow-King. She was ice. Made of it. Carved from it, as if a sculptor had worked the glacier for a hundred years to make a single statue and then the statue had decided to walk. Clear and blue and faintly glowing, with long hair that fell to her ankles in frozen ripples and a

long plain gown with frost-flowers at its hem. Her face was calm and narrow and severe, with high cheekbones and a long straight nose.

It was Antho's face.

Not exactly. Older, and a woman's, and carved from ice. But the bones of it. The set of the eyes. The mouth that didn't smile easily. Lex had seen that face across a campfire for three years, and he'd have known it anywhere.

"Ysmir," he whispered.

"*What is left of her.*" The ice woman inclined her head. Her voice was the same voice that had come from the walls, but closer now, smaller, and very tired. "*An echo. A memory of a woman, kept in the place she made for keeping memories. I was the Keeper of What Was. When I died, I kept myself.*" Something moved at the corner of her frozen mouth. Not quite a smile. "*It seemed wasteful not to.*"

[*That's a Vey,*] breathed Ember. [*That is very definitely a Vey.*]

"Aurelian's sister," said Lex.

"*His sister. The next after him.*" Ysmir's ice-blue eyes moved over him. Slowly. Taking him in, the way Hedda took in a new apprentice: hands first, then shoulders, then face. "*And you are his blood. Many times removed. I can see him in you. In the eyes, mostly. And in the hands.*" Her gaze lingered on his scarred knuckles. "*He had a smith's hands too. Before he had a king's.*"

"I have his hammer," said Lex. He didn't know why he said it. He took it out of his belt and held it up. Aurelian's little hand-hammer, worn smooth, with the faint gold tracery of runes on its cheeks.

Ysmir looked at it for a long moment.

"Yes," she said quietly. "*He made that the year he made the Lattice. He was so happy that year. He used to sing at the anvil.*" She was silent. "*I remember everything. That is the curse of my gift. I remember him singing. And I remember what he became.*"

"What did he become?"

She looked at him.

"Afraid," she said.



SHE SHOWED HIM.

She didn't ask. She simply raised one hand of clear blue ice, and touched the air between them, and the air turned to ice, a pane of it, thin and clear as a window. And behind the window, something moved.

A forge. Not like Ashbourne. Huge, round, open to the sky, on top of a white mountain under stars so bright and close that Lex could almost hear them. And in the center of it, an anvil of gold, and a man standing at the anvil.

Tall. Fair-haired. Beautiful, in a tired way, like a fine blade that's been used too long. He wore a smith's leather apron over a robe of white and gold, and his sleeves were rolled up, and his forearms were corded and scarred exactly like Lex's.

He held a knife in one hand. A silver knife, long and thin, its blade shining like moonlight. And with it, slowly, carefully, the way a tanner takes the hide from a deer, he was cutting his own shadow off the floor.

Lex watched him do it. Watched the silver knife slide along the edge of the black shape on the stone where the man's shadow fell. Watched the shadow come away. Peeling up off the floor like a sheet of black silk. Lifting. Hanging from the man's hand, limp and dark and somehow *alive*, twitching faintly, the way a lizard's tail twitches after the lizard has dropped it.

And the man laid it on the gold anvil. And folded it. Once, and again, and again. And picked up a hammer. Not the little hand-hammer. A great one. And began to strike.

Every blow rang like a bell at the bottom of the sea.

There was a woman in the window too. At the edge of the forge. Tall and dark-haired, with Antho's face, flesh and blood and alive. Watching.

"*Brother,*" she said. "*What are you making?*"

The man didn't stop. "*A key.*"

"*A key to what?*"

"*To the lid. The binding. Everything we've made.*" Strike. Strike. "*If something goes wrong, Ysmir. If we're wrong. If the Lattice turns into a cage instead of a shelter, or if what's under it gets loose. Someone has to be able to open it. To start again.*" Strike. "*So I'm making a way.*"

"*Out of your own shadow.*"

"It's the only thing strong enough. The only thing that belongs to both sides." He looked up at her then. And his eyes, in the starlight, were gold. Root gold. Lex's gold. *"Don't look at me like that. I know what I'm doing."*

"Do you?" The woman in the window came closer. *"You haven't slept in a month, Aurelian. You've stopped eating. You talk to the dark at night. I hear you, through the wall."*

"I talk to everyone at night. I'm the Root of the world. Everyone talks to me."

"That's not what I mean, and you know it."

He struck again. The shadow on the anvil was taking shape now. Long and black and narrow. A key. A great black key, as long as a man's arm, with a looped bow and a shaft and a bit of jagged teeth like a mountain range.

"It's done," he said.

And he picked it up, and looked at it, and the woman who was Ysmir watched his face. And Lex, watching through the window of ice nine hundred years later, saw what she saw.

Love. Love like a man looking at his child.

And under it, so faint that he almost missed it, the thing Ysmir had named.

Afraid.



THE WINDOW MELTED.

The vault came back. Blue light. Ice. The plinth with the frozen book. Kestrel, standing in the arch with her arms folded and her eyes narrowed. She hadn't seen any of it.

"He broke it the next spring," said Ysmir. *"The Key. In three. He came to me with the pieces in a bag and his hands shaking and asked me to help him hide them."* She was quiet. *"He said he had made a mistake. That the Key was too dangerous to exist whole. That something in the dark had begun to ask him for it."* She looked at Lex. *"I did not ask what. I was afraid to know. I took the bit to the glass. Our brother Tarn took the bow beyond the Veil. Aurelian kept the blade himself, and buried it under the mountain where the door was thinnest, so he could guard it."*

"The Hollowmaw."

"It was not called that then. But yes." She inclined her frozen head. *"And then I wrote the verse. And I built this place. And I came here to keep what was, because I could see what was coming, and I could not stop it."* Her voice didn't change. *"He fell, a hundred years later. Into the Hollow. Into the thing he had sealed there. You know this."*

"Yes."

"And now someone is turning his key."

"An old man," said Lex. "Elric Thorne. He was my father's friend. He found the bow in the Sundered Lands three years ago. He's been using it to cut people out of the Lattice." His jaw tightened. "And there's a voice in his head. A kind voice. It told him where to look."

Ysmir closed her eyes.

For a long moment, the vault was silent. The frozen memories in the walls glimmered faintly blue. Somewhere far above, in the great hall, something creaked. Ice settling.

"Then my brother is awake," said Ysmir. *"Or something wearing him is."*



"The book," she said. *"Take it."*

Lex looked at the plinth. At the open book, frozen in its block of clear ice, its pages blank.

"What is it?"

"The Ledger of What Was." Ysmir moved to stand beside it, her long frozen hair trailing across the floor without a sound. *"I made it when I made the verse. Because I knew that if the Key was ever turned again, it would be turned against people. Cutting them out of the Lattice. Out of memory. Out of the world."* She looked at Lex. *"The Key unwrites. But I am the Keeper of What Was. And what has been written cannot be entirely unwritten. Not while someone keeps it."*

She laid her ice hand on the frozen block.

It cracked. Clean, like the shell of an egg. The ice fell away in two halves, and the book lay on the plinth, open, its pages soft and old and smelling faintly of cold.

"Your blood," said Ysmir. *"On the page."*

Lex took his knife from his belt. He looked at it. Then at his palm, already crossed with old scars from a dozen blood-wards and blood-doors. Avaloria. The Frostvault. The waystation. The Root.

[Every Founder's door in the world wants a little piece of you,] said Ember. *[It's like being a very popular cake.]*

He almost laughed. He cut his palm. Not deep. He pressed it to the open page.

And the book drank.

He felt it. A pull, gentle, the way the Hollow had pulled at Antho, the way the Umbral Wardens had pulled at his thread. But warm. Asking, not taking. The blood soaked into the pale old paper and spread through it in thin red lines. And where the lines went, the red turned to black. And the black turned into letters.

Names.

They wrote themselves. One by one. In a hand that wasn't his, a narrow precise elegant hand, flowing across the page as if an invisible pen were moving very fast.

Mella Bell, of Harrowgate. Sixteen. Weatherwise. She sang to the goats.

Tamsin Varn, of Coldbrook. Twenty-one. Farmer. He brought the cows in every evening and talked to each one by name.

Odo Ferris, of Stellan's Ford. Forty. Cooper. His barrels never leaked.

Hollis Penn, of Highcrest. Thirty-four. Baker. He gave the burnt loaves to the children by the fountain and said they were the best ones.

Lex made a sound.

Hollis Penn.

It came back to him. Like a door opening. The baker in the square. The flour on his arms. His *name*. Lex had held his thread and lost it and been unable to remember his name for nearly a month, and here it was, written in a dead woman's handwriting on a page he'd bled on, and the moment he read it he *knew* it. As if it had been there the whole time, just behind a curtain.

Hollis Penn. He'd had three children. He'd sung in the Lower Town choir, badly. His wife's name was Ada.

[I've got it too,] said Ember. It sounded shaken. *[Lex. I remember him. I couldn't, before. And now I can.]*

The names kept coming. Line after line. Page after page. The book turned its own pages, fluttering in a wind that wasn't there.

Twenty names. Thirty. Forty.

Eda Moss. Fennick Hale. Rue Talbot. Corwin Ash.

Each one with a line. Never more than a line. *She grew the best leeks in the valley. He could whistle like any bird you named. She was learning to read. He was going to be married in the spring.*

Forty-seven names.

And then the pen stopped.

The book lay still. Forty-seven names, in black ink, on pages that had been blank a moment ago.

Lex stared at them.

Forty-seven people, he thought. *He's taken forty-seven people. And every one of them was somebody.*



"It cannot bring them back," said Ysmir quietly. "I want you to understand that. The Ledger remembers. That is all it does. While it is kept, they are not entirely gone. Their threads are not entirely cut. They linger at the edge of the world, like the man who walks beside you." Her ice-blue eyes went past Lex, to the doorway, where Tamsin Varn stood faint and pale beside his sister. "If the Ledger is destroyed, they will be gone. Truly gone. Every thread cut through. And all that is left of them will go to the one who holds the Key."

"That's why he's been trying to get in here."

"Yes. He has been at my door for two years. Breaking my house around me, piece by piece, trying to reach it." Her voice was very calm. "Every memory he cracks in my walls is a memory lost. He does not care. He wants the Ledger burned. Then the forty-seven are entirely his, and he is that much stronger."

Lex looked at the Ledger. At the names.

"How do I bring them back?"

Ysmir was silent.

"What the Key unwrites," she said at last, "only the Key can write again."

Kestrel moved. Fast. Out of the doorway, across the vault, to stand at Lex's shoulder and stare down at the Ledger, at the names she couldn't read

except one. She had found it with her finger, as if she knew by instinct which line it was. *Tamsin Varn, of Coldbrook*. Her finger rested on it.

"*The key*," she said. "*His key. It can put them back?*"

"*It can.*" Ysmir looked at her. A long look. Sad. "*Whole, it can do almost anything. That is what makes it terrible.*"

Kestrel didn't say anything.

But Lex saw her face. And he saw her hand, on the page, close very slowly into a fist over her brother's name.



SOMETHING BOOMED, FAR ABOVE.

The whole glacier shook. Ice dust sifted down from the vault ceiling in a fine blue glittering rain. The frozen memories in the walls trembled.

Ysmir's head came up.

"*He is here*," she said.

Lex felt it a moment later. Through the Root. Through the net. A *cut*. A clean dark slice through the Lattice, like a knife going through silk. Somewhere above them, in the great hall of the temple. And through the cut, something coming.

[*Elric*,] said Ember. [*The vault opening. The blood. It rang through the whole net like a bell. He felt it.*]

He's been waiting for someone to open it for him.

[*Of course he has. He can't get in. You can. So he waited.*] Ember's voice was hard. [*"My blood, the smith, will find it for you." That's what the voice told him. It's what the voice always tells him. It's using you to fetch things.*]

The Ledger. Lex snatched it up off the plinth. It was heavy and cold and fit in the crook of his arm like a sleeping cat. He shoved it inside his coat, against his chest, and felt it there, cold through his shirt, forty-seven names pressed against his heart.

Footsteps. Coming down the long passage from above.

Unhurried.

"*Go*," said Ysmir. "*Blood of my brother. Take the Ledger and go.*"

"*There's only one way out.*"

"Then you will have to go past him." She turned her ice face toward the passage. *"I will hold my house up for as long as I can. He will try to bring it down on you."*

Kestrel's hands were already burning.

The footsteps came around the last bend.



HE DIDN'T LOOK SEVENTY anymore.

That was the first thing Lex noticed. Elric Thorne had been an old man when he walked into the Ashbourne forge four years ago. Thin and grey and stooped, with a tired, clever face and a tattered cloak. He'd been an old man at Duskhold, standing in a black corridor with his staff in his hand and fury in his eyes.

The man who came around the bend into Ysmir's vault was perhaps fifty. Tall and straight, his hair iron-grey instead of white, his face lined but firm. He wore a long coat of dark grey wool, very well cut, and good boots, and gloves. And around his neck, on a black chain, the Bow.

Lex had seen it in a hundred nightmares since the festival. Seeing it now was different. It was the size of his palm, a looped handle of black that wasn't metal and wasn't stone. It was *nothing*. A hole in the world, shaped like the handle of a key. When he looked at it, his eyes slid off it. When he looked at it with True Sight, it hurt.

"Hello, Lex," said Elric.

He sounded the same. That was the worst of it. The same dry, warm, faintly amused voice that had explained the Lattice to a terrified smith's apprentice over a campfire in the Greyspine. The same voice that had taught him mana-shaping on the Old Founders' Road.

"Elric."

"You've grown." Elric's eyes moved over him. Brown eyes. Not gold. They'd never been gold. "Three years. You look like your father did at thirty, if he'd ever had to work for a living." His gaze dropped to Lex's coat, where the Ledger sat against his chest. "And you've done my errand for me. Thank you."

"It's not yours."

"No. It's Ysmir's." Elric looked past him, at the tall shape of blue ice standing by the plinth. And something moved in his face. Not fear. Something like courtesy. He inclined his head. "Lady Ysmir. I've been knocking for two years. You might have answered."

"You knock with a crowbar, Elric Thorne," said the ice woman. *"I do not answer to crowbars."*

"No," Elric agreed. "Nor did Arion. In forty years." He smiled. A thin, tired smile. "The Veys and their doors. Always shut. Always someone else outside them."

"You took forty-seven people," said Lex.

"Forty-eight now. There was a shepherd on the White Shore last night." Elric's voice didn't change. "And I took them because they were owed to me. I gave forty years of my life to your father's work. To the Lattice. I mended it with my own hands, Stone by Stone, while Arion sat in Avaloria and made speeches about responsibility. And when I asked, *once*, for what I'd earned, he said no." He touched the black thing at his throat. "So I've stopped asking."

"Those people never did anything to you."

"No. They were bright. That's all. Bright and loose and ripe, because you went through Caldor with your hammer knocking the Ceilings off every Stone you could find, and you never once thought about what that would *mean*. A Ceiling is a lid, Lex. It holds things in." His brown eyes were steady. "You took the lids off forty thousand people and called it freedom, and you never asked what else could get at them once the lid was gone."

Lex felt Ember go very still in his head.

"You don't get to make that my fault."

"I'm not. I'm telling you what's true. It's a different thing." Elric held out his gloved hand. "Give me the book."

"No."

"Give me the book, and I'll stop taking the young ones. The bright ones. I'll take the old and the dying. People who were going to go soon anyway." His voice was reasonable. Patient. A teacher's voice. "You can't stop me, Lex. But you can choose who pays."

"He's lying," said Kestrel.

Elric looked at her. For the first time. A long, curious, faintly puzzled look.

"I don't believe we've met," he said.

"You took my brother."

"I've taken a lot of people's brothers." Elric's gaze moved over her. Slowly. And Lex saw him frown. Saw him try to look at her with whatever sight the Key gave him. And find nothing. No thread. No silver. Nothing at all. "Oh," he said softly. "Oh, how *interesting*. You're not in it at all, are you?"

"Come closer," said Kestrel, *"and find out."*

Elric smiled.

And moved.



HE DIDN'T COME AT Kestrel. He came at Lex. One step, and his gloved hand closed around the black Bow at his throat, and he *turned* it.

Lex felt it.

Like a hook going into his chest. Not into his body. Into his thread. The bright gold-and-silver cord that ran from the center of him out into the great net of the world. The Bow found it the way a fishhook finds a fish's lip, and caught, and *pulled*.

He went to his knees.

It didn't hurt. That was the terrible thing. It didn't hurt at all. It was like falling asleep. Like being very, very tired and lying down in warm snow. He could feel himself coming loose. Thread by thread. Strand by strand. His name going soft at the edges.

And inside him, in the Root, in the gold place where Ember lived, someone screamed.

[LEX—]

Ember. Ember was *in* the thread. Ember was *part* of it, a construct cut from Arion's mind and woven into the Root, and the Key was cutting the Root, and Ember was coming apart with it.

[Lex, hold on, hold ON, you have to—]

He couldn't. He couldn't. He was so tired.

He rooted.

Not in Flame. In Stone. The way he'd done on the moor, against the Umbral Wardens. Down through the ice, down through the glacier, down and down into the bedrock of the world under it, old and cold and patient. *Stand. Hold. Stay.*

And held.

The hook in his thread caught. Stopped. Pulled harder.

He held.

"*Stubborn,*" said Elric, through his teeth. "*You were always stubborn. You and your brother both.*" He twisted the Bow. "*But I've got forty-eight people's worth of—*"

Fire hit him in the face.

Kestrel Varn came across the vault like a falling star. Both hands burning. Hair burning. Coat burning at the hem. She didn't throw her fire. She *ran into* Elric with it, both burning fists, straight into his chest, and knocked him backwards across the vault into the wall of blue ice with a crash that shook frozen memories loose from the ceiling.

The hook in Lex's chest tore free.

He gasped. Came up off his knees. Felt his thread snap back into place like a bowstring, humming.

[I'm here,] whispered Ember. *[I'm here, I'm here, I'm—Lex. I'm here.]* It was shaking. *[That was—]*

I know.

Elric was on the floor against the wall. His fine grey coat was burning. He beat at it with his gloved hands, swearing softly. His face was red and raw on one side, the iron-grey hair singed. He looked up at Kestrel, standing over him with fire roaring off her hands.

And he did something Lex didn't expect.

He tried to use the Key on her.

Lex saw him do it. Saw his hand close on the black Bow, saw him turn it, aim it at Kestrel's chest. Where her thread should have been.

Nothing happened.

There was nothing there. There was nothing to hook. Kestrel Varn had never been Kindled, never been in the net, never had a thread at all. The Key reached for her and found the same nothing the Umbral Wardens had found. And she stood there, burning, completely untouched.

"*Can't,*" she said, savagely. "*Can you, old man. Can't cut what was never tied.*"

And she hit him again.



HE WENT THROUGH THE wall.

Not really. He went into the keyhole. A black slit opened in the ice behind him as she struck, and he went backwards into it the way a fish goes back into dark water, and her burning fist hit the blue ice where his chest had been a moment before, and the ice *steamed*.

And then his voice came through the keyhole. From very far away. Calm again.

"*Keep the book, Lex. For now.*" A pause. "*But you'll bring me the bit. You know you will. The voice says so, and the voice has never once been wrong.*"

And then, colder:

"*And in the meantime, I'm afraid I've been inside this temple for a very long time, and I know exactly where it's weakest.*"

The keyhole closed.

And the whole glacier screamed.



IT WAS THE CRACKS.

Two years of cracks. Every crack Elric had made in Ysmir's house. In the walls, the floors, the columns, the frozen memories. And now, all at once, every one of them was widening. Lex could *hear* them. A sound like a thousand bones breaking at once, running up through the whole temple from the bottom to the top.

The vault floor split. A black crack opened across it from wall to wall, and the plinth tipped and fell into it, and was gone.

"*Run,*" said Ysmir.

She was standing very straight in the middle of the vault, her ice hands raised. And the ice around her was *moving*. Not cracking. Flowing. Rising up the walls in great blue ridges, pouring itself into the cracks like mortar into stone, holding. Holding the ceiling up. Holding the walls together.

And she was getting smaller.

Lex could see it. She was pouring herself into the ice. Every crack she filled took a piece of her. Her long frozen hair was already gone, flowed away into the walls. Her gown. Her hands were thinning.

"Ysmir—"

"Go, child." She didn't look at him. *"I cannot hold it for long. I am only an echo. Echoes fade."*

"Come with us. You can—"

"I am the Keeper of What Was. This is what was." Her voice was very calm. *"Every memory in these walls is going to be lost tonight. A thousand years of lost things. I will not leave them to break alone."* She turned her head at last, and looked at him with her ice-blue eyes. Antho's eyes. *"Keep the Ledger. Remember them. Someone must."*

Kestrel had his arm. Pulling.

"Come on, smith. COME ON."

He went.



THEY RAN UP THROUGH a temple that was dying around them.

The passages shook. Ice fell in sheets. The frozen memories in the walls were breaking, one after another, with tiny sounds like bells. A child's toy boat. A wedding ring. A drawing of a house with a lantern in the window. Cracking. Shattering. Falling away into nothing.

Lex ran with the Ledger against his chest and Kestrel's burning hand on his arm and Tamsin Varn's faint shape beside them, and every time a memory broke he flinched.

They came out into the great hall.

It was falling. The blue dimness overhead was full of falling ice, great slabs of it the size of houses, crashing down onto the clear floor and shattering into a thousand glittering shards. The columns were swaying. The frozen memories under the floor were cracking, a great spiderweb of black lines spreading through the deep blue ice beneath their feet.

And far ahead, the great arched doorway. Three hundred feet tall. Open to the grey morning. With a black crack running up through it from threshold to keystone.

Kestrel let go of his arm. "*I can't hold it up,*" she gasped. "*Fire's no good for this. It just melts and comes down faster.*"

"I know." Lex stopped in the middle of the falling hall. He went down on one knee. He put his free hand flat on the cracking ice of the floor.

And *spoke* to Stone.

Not Flame. Not this time. Stone. The bedrock under the glacier. The deep old patient bones of the world. He didn't command it. He wasn't strong enough to command it, not yet, not at Answering. But he *asked*. The way he'd asked it on the moor. The way Malachi had taught him: not *do this*, but *help me*.

Hold. Just for a little. Just long enough. Please.

And far down below the glacier, the bedrock of the world stirred.

He felt it come up. Slowly. Grudgingly. Like an old man getting up from a chair. Up through the ice, up through the cracks, a great slow grinding push from underneath. The floor stopped cracking. The columns stopped swaying. The falling slabs of ice, halfway down, seemed to hang for a moment in the air, as if the whole hall had taken a breath.

ATTUNEMENT – STONE

Answering → Answering (deepening)

"The mountain does not hurry. But it does, sometimes, agree."

"*NOW*," he shouted.

They ran.

Down the length of the great hall, under the hanging ice. Past the swaying columns. Over the cracked floor where a thousand lost things were breaking under their feet. Toward the great doorway and the grey light beyond.

Behind them, Lex felt Ysmir. Felt her the way he'd felt his mother's thread once, in the Root. Faint and cold and very calm. Pouring the last of herself into the walls of her house. Holding them up. Holding them up.

They burst out through the doorway into the grey morning. Down the long carved stair. Out onto the frozen shore.

And behind them, the Temple of Ysmir came down.



IT TOOK A LONG time. Glaciers don't fall fast.

The great carved face of the ice cracked from top to bottom, along the line of Elric's crack, and slid. Slowly. Majestically. Like a curtain coming down at the end of a play. A thousand feet of blue-white ice, columns and arches and stairs and great carved Wellsript, sliding down into the frozen sea with a roar that went on and on and on, and threw up a cloud of glittering ice-dust that hung in the grey air like smoke after a fire.

When it was over, there was no temple. Just a raw blue scar on the face of the glacier, and a mountain of broken ice on the shore, and a silence so deep it rang.

Lex stood in it.

He had the Ledger against his chest. He could feel it there, cold and heavy, forty-seven names pressed against his heart.

Forty-eight, he thought. *A shepherd on the White Shore last night.*

He opened the book.

There, at the bottom of the last page, in the same narrow elegant hand, very faint, as if the pen had been running dry:

Bram Sowerby, of the White Shore. Sixty. Shepherd. He named every one of his lambs after a star.

And under it, fainter still, so faint he could barely read it, a new line. Not a name. Written in the same hand, but shakier.

Keep them, child. I have kept them long enough.

And then nothing. The pen had stopped.

Lex closed the book. He held it against his chest for a long time.

LEDGER OF WHAT WAS – BOUND
(Founder's artifact – Legendary)
Holder: LEX VEY
Names kept: 48
While kept, the Unnamed are not wholly cut. Their threads linger.
If destroyed: all threads severed.
Mana released to KEY-HOLDER.

LORE UNLOCKED: The Key of Shadows

Bow — held (Elric Thorne)

Bit — "in the glass, where the
sun was unmade"Blade — "under lanterns, where
the door is laid"

"So," said Kestrel.

She was sitting on a rock at the edge of the frozen shore, with her knees drawn up and her red coat wrapped around them, and her fire banked down to a faint glow in her hair. Tamsin sat beside her. Faint. Pale. Close.

"*That old man,*" she said. "*He's going to come after you.*"

"Yes."

"*Because you've got the book.*"

"Yes."

"*And because you'll bring him the other bit. That's what he said. The voice says so.*" She looked at Lex. Her amber eyes were very sharp. "*Will you?*"

"No."

"*How do you know?*"

He thought about it. Honestly. The way Malachi had taught him to think about things. Not *what do I want to be true. What is.*

"I don't," he said. "But I know he needs me to find it. He can't get into Founders' doors. Only blood can. Which means whatever's guarding the second piece, he can't get past it. And I can." He looked down at the Ledger. "So I have to find it first. And get it somewhere he can't follow."

"*Where's that?*"

"I don't know yet."

Kestrel looked at him for a long time.

"*You don't know a lot of things, smith.*"

"No," Lex agreed. "Not many."

She snorted. It was almost a laugh. She looked out at the frozen sea.

"*In the glass, where the sun was unmade,*" she said. "*I know where that is.*"

He looked at her.

"My grandmother was from the Sunreach. Down south. Past the Bitter Hills." She didn't look at him. *"She used to tell stories. About a desert made of glass. Where a sun fell out of the sky a long time ago and melted the sand for a hundred miles. Nobody goes there. The glass cuts your boots to ribbons. And there are things in it. Old things."* She paused. *"She said the fire there is the oldest fire in the world. Older than the sun that fell."*

[A Flame-Well,] said Ember slowly. [Or what's left of one. A Founder-age catastrophe. If something burned hot enough to make a hundred miles of glass—]

"How far?" said Lex.

"From here?" Kestrel laughed. Not nicely. "The whole length of the world, smith. The whole length of Caldor and then some. Two months on foot, if you don't die."

"I've got a dragon."

"You've got a—" She stopped. Looked at him. "Where?"

"With my brother. Watching a door."

"Then you've got no dragon."

"No," Lex admitted. "Not at the moment."

Kestrel Varn looked at him for a very long time. And then, for the first time since he'd met her, she laughed properly. A real laugh. Startled and helpless, throwing her head back, her red hair flaring with little flames.

"Light help me," she said. "I've followed a scar across the whole world and found a smith with no dragon and a magic book and no plan." She wiped her eyes. *"Tam, I'm so sorry. He's all we've got."*

Beside her, faint and pale, her brother smiled.

"Tell her," he said to Lex, "she always did pick the worst horses at the fair."

Lex told her.

She stopped laughing. She stared at the empty air beside her. And then, very slowly, her face crumpled, and she put her face in her hands, and her shoulders shook. And her fire came up around her, gold and soft, and wrapped her faded brother in it like a blanket.



THEY SET OUT SOUTH that afternoon. Down the long grey slope from the White Shore, toward the Ironbacks and everything beyond them.

Lex walked with the Ledger inside his coat, and the verse going round and round in his head.

Only a made hand can unmake the made.

Only the blood that forged it can bar the way.

And the blood that bars it, the blood will pay.

[Lex,] said Ember, very quietly. [*That last line.*]

I know.

[*It means—*]

I know what it means. He walked. *Blood of the Veys. To stop the Key. And it costs. The blood pays.* He didn't slow down. *Me. Or Antho. Or Father.*

[*It's a prophecy. They're not always—*]

Ysmir wrote it. She was the Keeper of What Was. She didn't make things up.

Ember was silent for a long time.

[*Then we'll find another way,*] it said at last. [*We always find another way. That's what we do. That's the whole point of a smith.*] A pause. [*You don't accept the shape the metal comes in. You make it the shape you need.*]

Lex didn't answer.

But he put his hand on the Ledger, cold against his chest, and walked a little faster.

And that night, camped in a hollow in the foothills of the Ironbacks, with Kestrel asleep by her fire and her brother keeping a faint watch beside her, he felt something through the Bloodbond.

Far to the south and east. In the Greyspine. In a cave hung with a thousand lit lanterns.

His brother.

Awake. Very still. And afraid.

CHAPTER 6

THE BROTHER WHO STAYED



THERE WERE ONE THOUSAND one hundred and eleven lanterns in the Hollowmaw.

Antho knew, because he counted them. Every evening. He'd counted them every evening for three years, since the night he and Lex had carried their mother's clay lamp down the long black passage and set it in the niche before the sealed door, and every lantern in the mountain had caught fire at once.

He didn't need to count them anymore. They didn't go out. They hadn't gone out once in three years. They burned on their own, without oil, without wicks, with a steady small gold light that came from nowhere and smelled faintly of a summer evening. He could have left them alone. Everyone told him to leave them alone.

He counted them anyway.

He started at the mouth of the cave, where the great cleft opened onto the mountainside and the wind came in off the Greyspine smelling of snow. An old tin lantern, dented and rusted, hanging from a spike. *One*. A brass one beside it. *Two*. Three paper lanterns gone brown with age, strung on a single cord. *Three, four, five*. On down the long passage, past the place where the floor dipped and the walls narrowed, past the great carved hall where the students slept, past the kitchen and the library and the cold-room where Teo kept his fish. *Four hundred. Five hundred*. Down and down, into the deep part of the mountain, where the passage widened into the round high cavern like the inside of a bell.

One thousand one hundred and ten.

And at the bottom of the bell, the door.

It wasn't a door, exactly. It had been a breach, once. A wound in the world. A jagged black tear in the rock at the bottom of the cavern, ten feet high, breathing cold and whispers and the smell of wet ash, while a mad warlock held it shut with green fire and his own sanity for eight years.

Now it was a wall of black glass. Smooth. Cold. Very faintly warm at the center, the way a hearthstone is warm in the morning when the fire's been banked all night. When Antho put his hand on it, he could feel nothing on the other side. No hunger. No whispers. Just a deep, patient, waiting quiet.

And in a niche carved in the rock beside it, a little clay lamp. Brown and round and plain, with a chip in its spout and a thumbprint pressed into its base. A cheap thing. The kind they sold for a copper at the Ashbourne market. Burning with a small, steady, golden flame.

One thousand one hundred and eleven.

Antho stood in front of it, the way he did every evening, and looked at the flame.

"Evening, Mam," he said.

The flame didn't answer. It never did.

He stood there a little longer anyway.



[Still counting,] said the Murmur.

It was quiet. It was always quiet now. A thread of a whisper, at the very back of his head, in the four percent of him that wasn't clear. It didn't say much. It didn't need to.

[One thousand one hundred and eleven. Every night. As if one might have run away while you were teaching.] A faint dry rustle, like dead leaves.
[As if counting kept them lit.]

Antho didn't answer. He'd learned not to, years ago. You didn't answer the Murmur. You let it talk, the way you let the wind talk, and you kept walking.

But it wasn't wrong. That was the trouble. It was never entirely wrong.

He went back up the long passage to the hall, where nine young people were waiting for him to teach them how to listen to the dark.



"*Again*," he said.

Odile Marsh rolled her eyes so hard Antho half expected them to stay up there.

She was seventeen, from a fishing village on the Tidewater coast, with a sharp face and black hair cut short as a boy's and a tongue like a filleting knife. She heard Shade. Better than anyone he'd ever met, except himself and possibly Malachi. She could sit in a dark room and tell you how many people were in it, and which of them were lying, and which of them were afraid. She also found it very, very boring.

"*Master Antho*," she said, "*with respect. I've been sitting here listening to this rock for an hour. It's a rock. It's very quiet. It's not going to say anything.*"

"It's said three things since you sat down," said Antho.

She stared at him. "*It has not.*"

"It said there's water running in a crack forty feet under your left knee. It said there's a family of bats in the roof of the cold-room that Teo hasn't found yet. And it said that you skipped breakfast, because your stomach is making a sound like an upset badger."

The hall erupted. Teo Brask fell sideways off his bench. The twins from Millbridge clutched each other. Even little Pim, who never laughed, who sat at the very end of the front row with his knees pulled up and his thin face turned to the floor, made a tiny sound into his sleeve.

Odile went red to the ears.

"*That's not the rock*," she said. "*That's just you.*"

"It's the same thing." Antho sat down on the edge of the old stone table at the front of the hall. "Shade doesn't talk in words. It talks in absence. In the space where something *isn't*. You listen to the quiet, and you notice where the quiet has a shape." He looked at her. "There's a quiet the exact shape of a bowl of porridge in your middle, Odile. Go and eat something."

She went. Scarlet. Muttering. But she went, and when she came back, she sat down on her bench and closed her eyes and listened to the rock again without being told.

Antho watched her. And thought, not for the first time, that teaching was the hardest thing he'd ever done. Harder than the breach. Harder than the Hollow. Harder than Duskhold.

At least the Hollow had never rolled its eyes at him.



THERE WERE NINE OF them now. There'd been three at the festival, three years ago. Then word got round, the way word does, and they'd started arriving. On foot, mostly. Climbing the long mountain path to the Hollowmaw with their bundles on their backs and their faces white with fear, because everyone in the east still told stories about the mad warlock of the Greyspine, and these were children who heard things in the dark. Who'd always heard things in the dark. Whose families had sent them to priests and herb-women and, once, to a man in Kessick who'd tried to beat it out of a nine-year-old with a belt.

That was Pim.

He didn't talk. He'd been at the Keep for four months, and he'd said perhaps twenty words, all of them to Ashka. He sat at the end of the front row with his knees pulled up and listened. Antho had never seen anyone listen like that. As if the dark were the only thing in the world that had ever been kind to him.

Antho knew exactly what that was like.

So he didn't push. He sat with Pim in the evenings, sometimes, at the mouth of the cave, and didn't say anything, and let the boy not say anything back. It was the best thing anyone had ever done for Antho, at that age. He'd been on the woodpile. At fifteen. Listening to voices. And his little brother had come out every evening and sat with him, and not asked, and not pushed, and just been there.

Lex had been ten.

He's not here now, said the four percent. *Is he*.



THE LETTER WAS ON the shelf above Antho's bed. He'd read it a hundred times. It wasn't long.

Antho—

I've gone north. Alone. Don't follow. I know you'll want to, and I know you'll be angry, and you're right to be. But someone has to watch the door, and you're the only one who can. I've sent Ashka with you. Keep her close.

He's taking the bright ones. You're the brightest thing I know. Please stay where it's safe.

I'll write.

—L.

P.S. I'm sorry about the festival. I'm sorry about all of it. I'll explain when I'm back.

He hadn't written. Three weeks, and nothing. Not a raven, not a goat, not a word.

Antho had been angry for the first week. Properly, coldly angry, the way he hadn't been angry since before Duskhold. He'd stood on the mountainside at the mouth of the Hollowmaw and looked north and thought about saddling Ashka and going after him and dragging him back by the ear.

Don't follow.

Stay where it's safe.

As if Antho were a child. As if he were the little brother. As if he hadn't held a breach in the world shut for eight years with his own mind while Lex was learning to make horseshoes.

And then, the second week, the anger had gone, and something else had come in behind it, and that was worse. Because underneath the anger, if he was honest, if he made himself be honest the way he'd had to learn to be honest, so as not to drown, there was the other thing.

He's right.

Someone has to watch the door.

And it was always him. It was always going to be him. The brother who stayed. Lex went out into the world and lit it up. Lex walked into burning forges and Founders' temples and the Pale Warden's fortress, and came out the other side with a new class and a new hammer and a crowd cheering his name. And Antho stayed. On the woodpile. In the Hollowmaw. In the dark, with the door, keeping it shut.

He didn't resent it. Not really.

He just wished, sometimes, that someone would ask him.



"She's eating the goat again," said Teo.

Antho looked up from the book he was pretending to read. It was late morning, the students were at their chores, and Teo Brask was standing in the doorway of the library, dripping.

Teo was always dripping. He was fifteen, round-faced and earnest and homesick for the Tidewater marshes, and he heard Tide. It was the only thing he heard, and he heard it all the time. Water followed him. Puddles formed under his chair. Rain found him on cloudless days. He'd been at the Keep for a year and had never, as far as Antho knew, been entirely dry.

"Which goat?"

"Correspondence."

Antho closed the book.

Correspondence was Malachi's goat. The one that had walked into the Hollowmaw three years ago with a letter tied round its neck, all the way from the Stillwater, across the Wastes. It had delivered the letter, eaten half of Antho's spare cloak and refused to leave. It now lived in a pen at the mouth of the cave, and every few weeks Malachi sent another letter, and Correspondence went and fetched it. Nobody knew how. Antho had stopped asking.

Ashka hated it.

He found them on the mountainside below the cave. Ashka was sprawled across half the slope like a fallen thundercloud. She was huge now. Twice the size she'd been at Duskhold. Her scales were the deep blue-grey of a storm sky, and when she breathed, little sparks of lightning crawled along her flanks and crackled in the grass. She had Correspondence's hind leg in her jaws.

Very gently.

Correspondence was standing on three legs on the slope, chewing a mouthful of grass and looking unimpressed.

"Ashka," said Antho.

The dragon rolled one great silver eye toward him. She didn't let go.

"Put the goat down."

She made a sound. It was a low rumbling growl that shook small stones loose from the slope and sent them clattering away down the mountain. It meant, as clearly as if she'd spoken: *The goat looked at me.*

"The goat looks at everyone. It's a goat. Put it down."

Ashka considered this. Then, very slowly, with enormous dignity, she opened her jaws and let Correspondence's leg slide out.

Correspondence finished its mouthful. Looked at the dragon. Looked at Antho. And walked over and began, placidly, to eat the hem of his coat.

Behind him, he heard Teo trying very hard not to laugh.

"Not a word," said Antho.

"No, Master Antho."

"Not one."

"No, Master Antho." A pause. A snort. A hiccup of suppressed laughter. *"It's just—Correspondence."*

"Malachi named it."

"I know. It's just. It's a very good name."

Antho looked down at the goat chewing his coat. And at the dragon sprawled across the hillside, watching the goat with an expression of profound and ancient offense. And at the boy behind him, dripping on the grass, red in the face from not laughing.

And something in his chest, for the first time in three weeks, eased.

"Yes," he said. "It is."



IT CAME THAT NIGHT.

He was standing in front of the door, at the end of the count. *One thousand one hundred and eleven.* The cavern quiet around him. The lanterns burning gold on every wall. The clay lamp in its niche.

And the flame leaned.

He saw it. The small gold flame in his mother's lamp, which had burned straight up, steady and still, every night for three years. It leaned. Not much. A finger's width. Toward the door. Toward the black glass.

Antho went very still.

And then he heard it.

Very faint. So faint he wasn't sure, at first, that he'd heard anything at all. Coming through the black glass of the sealed door, from somewhere very far on the other side. A voice. A woman's voice. Low and a little rough, as if from long disuse.

Singing.

If the dark comes calling, love, don't you mind. A lantern's lit for the ones behind.

He stopped breathing.

He knew that song. Everyone in the Greyspine knew that song. It was an old mountain lullaby, the kind every mother sang. He and Lex had sung it together in this cavern three years ago, with their mother's lamp between them, and every lantern in the mountain had caught fire.

But he knew *this* voice singing it.

Low and rough. A little flat on the high note. The way she'd always sung it, in the cottage at Harrow, in the dark, when he was small and frightened of the noises in the walls.

If the dark comes calling, love, don't you fear. There's a light in the window, and I'm right here.

He didn't realize he'd moved until his hand was on the glass.

Cold. Then warm. Very faintly warm, at the center, where the voice was coming from. He pressed his palm flat against it. And the voice stopped.

And on the other side of the glass, something pressed back.

He felt it. Through the black smooth surface of the sealed door. A hand. Small. Cold. A woman's hand, pressing flat against the other side, palm to palm with his.

CLARITY: 96 / 100

ANOMALY

Hollow-link: dormant →

Source:

Threat assessment:

[*Oh, don't,*] whispered the Murmur. [*Don't, don't, don't. You know what this is. You know what it does. It finds the softest place in you and it puts its hand there.*] Its voice was suddenly urgent. Almost kind. [*It sang to you*

before. When you were fifteen. In your mother's voice. Do you remember? Do you remember what you did?]

He remembered.

He remembered the woodpile. He remembered nights on the woodpile with his hands over his ears. He remembered a voice that sounded exactly like hers, calling to him from the dark under the trees, and walking out toward it barefoot in the frost, and his little brother's hand on his sleeve, pulling him back.

[It's the Hollow,] said the Murmur. [It's always been the Hollow. It wears whatever face will open the door.]

Antho stood with his hand on the black glass and his eyes closed.

The hand on the other side didn't move.

And then the voice spoke. Not singing. Speaking. So faint it was barely a breath against the glass.

"Not yet, love."

He opened his eyes.

"Not yet. Keep the lamp lit. Keep the door shut." A pause. The faintest pressure of a palm against his. *"He's coming. For what's under the floor. Don't let him have it."*

And the hand was gone.

The glass was cold. Just cold. The lamp's flame straightened in its niche and burned straight up, steady and still, as if nothing had happened.

Antho stood there for a long time.

Then he went and sat down on the cold floor of the cavern with his back against the wall, and his arms around his knees, the way he'd sat on the woodpile at fifteen. And he stayed there until the morning, looking at the door, and didn't tell anyone.



HE DIDN'T TELL ANYONE for a week.

He told himself it was because he wasn't sure. Because the Murmur was right: the Hollow had sung to him before, in that voice, when he was fifteen and half-mad and alone. Because his Clarity was at ninety-six and that left four percent of him that couldn't be trusted, and he didn't know which four percent had heard the song.

That was true. It was also a lie.

He didn't tell anyone because if he said it out loud, he'd have to decide whether he believed it. And if he believed it, then his mother was on the other side of the door. Alive. Or something like alive. And had been, all this time, while he sat on this side of it lighting lanterns.

And he didn't know what he would do with that.

So he taught. And he counted. And every night, at the end of the count, the lamp leaned, and the voice sang, and he put his hand on the glass and felt a hand press back. And every night she said the same thing.

Not yet. Keep the door shut. He's coming. For what's under the floor.



SERAPHINE CAME ON THE eighth day.

He felt her before he saw her. He always did now. A particular quality of quiet, coming up the mountain path. Not the quiet of Shade. The quiet of someone reading, very intently, while walking up a mountain and not looking where she was going.

He went out to meet her.

She was halfway up the switchbacks, on a mule, with a royal escort of four bored Keepers in grey trailing behind and a crate of books strapped to a second mule. She had a book open on the mule's neck in front of her. She was reading it. The mule was picking its way up the steep path entirely on its own initiative.

She looked up when he came round the bend. And her face, which had been frowning at the page, did a thing he'd never got used to. It *opened*. All at once. Like a window being thrown wide.

"*Antho*," she said.

He'd known her four years. They'd been something for three. He still didn't entirely understand how. She was the cleverest person he'd ever met, and she'd been tortured for a week in the Spire on Kell's orders and walked out of it with a pale scar down her face and her mind entirely her own. She was afraid of almost nothing, except spiders, and the sea, and being wrong about a date. She read faster than anyone alive. She had ink on her fingers always, and she wrote him letters every week, long ones, full of crossings-out and small furious drawings of people she'd met at court, and

he kept every single one in a box under his bed, and read them when the four percent got loud.

He reached up and helped her down off the mule. She came down into his arms and stayed there.

"*You're thinner,*" she said into his coat.

"I'm the same."

"*You're thinner and you haven't been sleeping. I can tell. You've got the look. The hollow-eyed one.*" She leaned back and looked up at him. Her spectacles were askew. "*What's happened?*"

He opened his mouth to say *nothing*.

And didn't.

"Come inside," he said. "I'll tell you."



HE TOLD HER THAT night, in the library, with the door shut and a fire in the grate and the students asleep.

All of it. The lamp. The song. The hand on the glass. *Not yet. He's coming. For what's under the floor.*

She didn't interrupt. She sat in the chair across from him with her hands folded in her lap and her face very still, and listened the way she listened to everything. Completely.

When he'd finished, she was quiet for a long time.

"*Do you believe it's her?*" she said at last.

"I don't know."

"*That's not an answer.*"

"It's the only one I've got." He stared into the fire. "The Hollow used her voice before. When I was fifteen. It's how it got its hooks into me in the first place. I'd hear her, at night, calling from under the trees, and I'd go." His jaw tightened. "Lex used to pull me back. By the sleeve. He was ten."

"*And this time?*"

"This time it's not asking me to come." He looked at her. "That's what I keep thinking about. It's never once asked me to open the door. It's asking me to keep it *shut*." He rubbed his face. "The Hollow wouldn't do that. It's always wanted out. That's all it's ever wanted."

"Unless it's clever," said Seraphine quietly. *"Unless it knows that's the one thing you'd believe."*

"Yes."

She was silent.

Then she reached down beside her chair, into the leather satchel she'd carried all the way up the mountain on her own back because she didn't trust the mule with it, and took out a roll of paper. Old paper. Yellow-brown and brittle, the edges scorched black.

"I didn't come up here just to see you," she said. "Though I would have. I'd have come anyway. But I found this."

She unrolled it on the table between them.

It was a map. Or part of one. Most of it was burned away, a ragged black edge eating in from three sides. But what was left was clear enough. The long jagged line of the Greyspine, drawn in faded brown ink. The rivers. The passes. Wellscript, in a small precise hand, in the margins.

And in the middle of the eastern Greyspine, at the place where the Hollowmaw would be, a symbol. Drawn in red ink, very carefully.

An open hand. Palm up.

And above the palm, a keyhole.

"It's from the Spire," said Seraphine. "The sealed vaults. Kell kept them locked for twenty years. When she fled, the Queen had them opened, and I've been cataloguing them ever since. Most of it's nonsense. Tax records. Old Sanction ledgers. Love letters from a High Warden two hundred years ago to a woman who wasn't his wife." Her mouth twitched. "They were very bad love letters." She touched the scorched edge of the map. "This was in a box with the Order's seal on it. And a note from the High Warden of the time. Dated four hundred years ago." She looked up. "It said: Destroy. Do not read. The Founders' Key must never be made whole."

Antho stared at the red keyhole.

"Someone tried to burn it," said Seraphine. "And didn't quite finish." Under the floor.

He's coming. For what's under the floor.

"It's here," said Antho. Very quietly. "Isn't it. The third piece. Whatever Father said at the council. It's under the Hollowmaw."

"*I think so.*" Seraphine's hand found his across the table. "*I think that's why there was a breach here at all. Something under the mountain thinned the world. Something forged from the dark side of the lid.*" She swallowed. "*I think you've been sitting on it for eleven years, Antho. Holding the door shut on top of it.*"

He didn't say anything.

He thought about eight years of green fire. Of holding the breach with his own mind. Of the Murmur in his head every hour of every day. Of the voices. Of the woodpile. Of everything.

All of it. Because something was buried under the floor. And had been, for nine hundred years. And nobody had told him.

Nobody ever tells you, said the four percent. *Do they.*



"*There's more,*" said Seraphine, after a while.

He looked at her.

"*In the capital.*" She'd taken her hand back. She was twisting her fingers together in her lap, which was what she did when she was about to say something she didn't want to say. "*Since the festival. Since Lex left.*" She took a breath. "*Lord Chancellor Sorn has put a bill before the Queen's council. The Registration Act. Every Unbound sorcerer in Caldor to be registered with the Crown. Name, class, level, location. For their own protection, he says. So that if the unwriter comes for them, the Crown can guard them.*"

"That's not why."

"No." Her mouth was a thin line. "*It's a list. A list of every bright thread in the kingdom, with addresses. Sorn's Ceiling Party wants it, and half the noble houses want it, and the Queen can't stop it on her own. She needs a majority of the council.*" Seraphine looked at him. "*Your father's been arguing against it. Every day. Very well. Very eloquently.*" She hesitated. "*And then going home at night to his rooms in the Spire and not coming out until morning.*"

"He always did keep odd hours."

"*Antho, it's not that.*" She leaned forward. "*There's something wrong with him. Since the festival. Since the baker. He's—he's frightened. I've never seen*

him frightened, not like this. He looks at the lanterns in the city at night as if he's counting them." She stopped. *"And Wren came back to Highcrest two days after Lex left."*

Antho went still.

"She was going after him. She told me. She had her boots on and her bow strung, and she was halfway out the window." Seraphine's voice was very careful. *"And your father caught her. And took her into his rooms, and shut the door, and they talked for an hour. And when she came out, she didn't go north."*

"Where did she go?"

"Nowhere. She's still there. In the Spire. She's sleeping in the corridor outside his rooms with her bow across her knees." Seraphine looked at him. *"She won't tell me why. She just says, someone has to."*

Antho looked at the fire for a long time.

Someone has to watch the door.

Someone has to.



HE WENT DOWN TO the door that night with Seraphine beside him.

He hadn't meant to bring her. He'd meant to tell her and leave it there, and go down alone the way he always did. But at the end of the count, when he turned to go down the last long passage into the bell, she'd taken his hand and come with him, without asking. The way Lex used to, on the woodpile.

They stood in front of the black glass together.

The lamp burned in its niche. Straight up. Still.

"Will it happen with me here?" whispered Seraphine.

"I don't know."

They waited.

The lanterns burned gold on every wall. Somewhere far above, at the mouth of the cave, Ashka shifted in her sleep, and a faint growl of thunder rolled down the passage. The cavern was very quiet.

And the flame leaned.

Seraphine's hand tightened on his. He heard her breath catch.

If the dark comes calling, love, don't you mind—

He put his hand on the glass.

The hand on the other side pressed back.

And this time, the voice didn't say *not yet*. It didn't sing. It spoke fast, and low, and urgently, the way you speak when you know you only have a moment.

"Antho. He's found the second one. The bit. He's close. Your brother is leading him to it and doesn't know." A pause. A sound like something straining. "When he has two, he'll come for the third. Here. He'll bring the dark with him. You can't hold the door against two pieces of the Key. Not alone. Not even you."

"Then what do I do?"

He hadn't meant to speak. It came out of him like a breath.

The hand on the other side of the glass went very still.

And then, so softly he almost didn't hear it:

"Oh, my love. You've got so big."

He couldn't breathe.

"Find the Ferryman," said the voice. Fast again. Urgent. "West. Past the Teeth. Where the world gets thin. The grey river. Ask him to take you to the Drowned Country. There's someone there who can help you. Someone the Hollow has been keeping for a long, long time." A pause. "Take the dragon. She's been hearing her mother calling for a month. She hasn't told you, because she doesn't know how."

The pressure of the hand on the glass began to fade.

"Wait—" said Antho. "Wait, Mam—"

"Keep the lamp lit."

And she was gone.



HE STOOD WITH HIS hand on the cold black glass for a long time.

Seraphine didn't say anything. She stood beside him with her hand in his and her face wet and didn't say anything at all, and it was the kindest thing anyone could have done.

At last he took his hand away.

He looked at it. His scarred, long-fingered hand. Pale in the gold light.

"You heard it," he said. Not a question.

"*I heard a woman's voice,*" said Seraphine. Carefully. Honestly. The way she said everything. "*I heard it through the glass. I don't know whose.*" She swallowed. "*But I heard it, Antho. It wasn't only in your head.*"

He closed his eyes.

Four percent, he thought. *And she heard it too.*

The Murmur didn't say anything. For the first time in years, it had nothing to say.



ASHKA WAS AWAKE WHEN he came up to the mouth of the cave.

She lay across the slope with her great head lifted and turned to the west. Toward the Teeth. Toward the high jagged peaks at the far end of the Greyspine, black against the stars, where no road went and no one lived and the maps said only *Here the world grows thin*.

She was keening. Very low. So low it was more a feeling than a sound, a deep slow vibration that came up through the rock under his feet and into his chest. A sound he'd never heard her make. Lonely, and searching, and very old.

He went and stood beside her. He put his hand on her great storm-grey neck.

"How long?" he said.

She turned her head and looked at him. One huge silver eye. Lightning moved in the depths of it like fish in deep water.

He'd found her in a nest in the high rocks above the Hollowmaw, the first winter, still wet from the shell. He'd fed her and talked to her through eight years of the dark, when she was the only living thing that would come near him. He knew her the way he knew his own hands.

She'd been hearing it for a month. And she hadn't told him. Because he'd been angry, and then sad, and then lost in the door, and she hadn't known how.

"I'm sorry," he said. "I wasn't listening."

Ashka put her great head down on the slope beside him, very gently, and huffed a breath of warm air that smelled of ozone and summer rain. And kept looking west.



HE FOUND SERAPHINE IN the library at dawn, reading.

She looked up when he came in. She'd been crying again; he could see it. But her face was calm.

"You're going," she said.

"Yes."

"West. To the Teeth. To find a ferryman on a river nobody's ever heard of, because a voice through a door told you to."

"Yes."

"And leave the door."

That was the thing. That was the thing he'd been turning over all night, standing on the mountainside beside his dragon, looking west. *Keep the door shut. Watch the door. Someone has to.* Eleven years. Eleven years of staying. And now the voice that had told him to stay was telling him to go.

"I'll ask Roole for Keepers," he said. "As many as he can spare. And Brannoc and Hedda, if they'll come. The students know the door. Odile can feel the Hollow better than I could at her age." He swallowed. "And it won't be long. A week. Two."

"And if he comes while you're gone?"

Antho didn't answer.

Seraphine looked at him for a long time.

Then she closed her book. She stood up. She came round the table and put her inky hands on either side of his face, and looked up at him through her spectacles.

"Do you know what I've been thinking, all night?" she said. "I've been thinking about you on the woodpile. At fifteen. Lex told me about it, once. How you'd sit there every night, listening to the voices, and not go. Not go into the trees. Even when it was her voice calling." Her thumbs moved on his cheekbones. "Everyone always talks about the brother who went. Lex went to Avaloria. Lex went to Duskhold. Lex went north." She shook her head slowly. "Nobody ever talks about the brother who stayed. Who sat on a woodpile in the dark for a year and held on with his fingernails because he had a little brother to look after. Who held a breach in the world shut for eight years so nobody else would have to. Who stayed. Every time. When going would have been so much easier."

He couldn't say anything.

"*Staying isn't nothing, Antho,*" said Seraphine. "*Staying is a thing you do. It's the hardest thing. Lex knows it. That's why he left you here. Not because he thinks you're weak. Because he knows you're the only one strong enough to stay.*" She took a breath. "*And now you have to go. Just this once. And that'll be hard too. In a different way.*"

"How do you know?"

"*Because I know you.*" She smiled. Small and wet and fierce. "*You count lanterns, Antho. Every night. One thousand one hundred and eleven. You can't bear to leave a single one of them alone.*" She kissed him. Once. Quickly. "*Go and find your ferryman. I'll count them for you while you're gone.*"



HE LEFT THAT AFTERNOON.

Roole's Keepers wouldn't arrive for four days. Brannoc had sent a letter by raven saying he and Hedda were coming *and if anything happens to that door before we get there I will personally go into the Hollow and drag you back out by your ear, lad*. Odile had listened to Antho's instructions with her arms folded and her eyes narrowed, and then said, *I know, Master Antho, I've been listening to that door for a year, I could hold it in my sleep*, and then hugged him, very hard and very fast, and walked away before he could see her face.

Pim had come and stood beside Ashka while Antho strapped on the saddle. Not saying anything. Just standing there, small and thin and grave, with his hand on the dragon's great foreleg.

When Antho was done, Pim looked up at him.

"*Come back,*" he said.

It was the first thing he'd ever said to Antho.

Antho knelt in the grass and looked at him. At the thin face. At the dark, careful, listening eyes.

"I will," he said. "I promise."

Pim nodded. Once. Then he turned and walked back up the slope to the mouth of the cave, and sat down on the rock beside Seraphine, and pulled his knees up, and watched.

Antho climbed onto Ashka's neck.

He looked back once. At the cave mouth. At the two figures sitting on the rock, one small and one not. At the great cleft in the mountain, glowing gold from within with one thousand one hundred and eleven lanterns.

And somewhere far below, at the bottom of the bell, a little clay lamp with a chip in its spout, burning.

I'll be back, Mam, he thought. Keep it lit.

Ashka spread her wings. Thunder rolled down the valley.

And the brother who stayed went west.

CHAPTER 7

THE FORBIDDEN REALMS



THE WORLD GREW THIN past the Teeth.

Antho had known it would. The maps said so, the old ones, the ones Seraphine had spread out on the library table the night before he left, peering at them through her spectacles with her nose almost touching the paper. *Here the world grows thin.* Every map. Every century. Written in the same place, at the far western end of the Greyspine, where the great range broke apart into a jumble of jagged black peaks like the teeth of some enormous broken jaw. Beyond them, nothing. Blank paper. Not even a guess.

"Nobody's ever come back to draw it," Seraphine had said. "Or if they did, they didn't remember what they'd seen."

He'd thought she was being dramatic.

He'd been wrong.



IT STARTED WITH THE color.

They crossed the last of the Teeth on the third morning, Ashka laboring up through thin cold air over a pass so high the snow on it had never melted, and came down the other side into a long valley. And the valley was grey.

Not grey like ash. Not grey like the Gloam-touched land had been, three years ago, dead and sick and rotting. Grey like a drawing. Like someone had sketched a valley in charcoal and forgotten to paint it. The grass was grey. The trees were grey. The sky over them was a pale flat

white-grey, like an unpainted ceiling. There was a river at the bottom of the valley, and it was grey too, and it didn't sparkle.

Antho looked down at his own hand on Ashka's neck. It was still the right color. Pale, scarred, real. But at the edges, very faintly, where his fingers met the grey air, it seemed to blur. Like a drawing someone had started to rub out.

[Oh,] said the Murmur. [Oh, I know this place.]

He didn't answer it. But he lifted the Keeper's Lantern from the hook on Ashka's saddle and held it up, and the small steady gold flame inside it pushed the grey back a little. Not much. A circle the size of a cartwheel. Inside the circle, his hand stopped blurring.

Ashka flew on, westward, down the grey valley. Her storm-colored scales were going dull. He could see it. The blue-grey of her flanks fading, little by little, toward the same charcoal grey as everything else. The lightning that usually crawled along her sides had gone quiet. She was flying slowly. Heavily. As if the air were thick.

But she didn't turn back. She kept her great head pointed west, and kept making that low, lonely, searching sound in her chest, the one that came up through the saddle into his bones.



THE LATTICE WENT STRANGE in the afternoon.

He'd been expecting that, too. He'd felt it before, at the Hollowmaw breach, years ago, and at Vhessa, and in the black hall at Duskhold: the places where the net was thin, where the silver threads of the world stretched and frayed and the Hollow showed through underneath. The panels went wrong in places like that. Words dropped out. Numbers scrambled.

But not like this.

LATTICE - SIGNAL WEAK

Location: [REDACTED]

(unmapped - no Stone in range)

World-thickness: 31%

[REDACTED] CAUTION [REDACTED]

Below 25%: self-coherence

not guaranteed

Self-coherence not guaranteed.

Antho read it twice. Then he put the Lantern on his knee where he could see it, and watched its flame, and didn't look at anything else for a while.

[It means,] said the Murmur helpfully, [that you might forget which bits of you are you.]

"I know what it means."

[I'm only saying. I've been here before. Well. Near here. Before I was in you. Before I was much of anything.] A pause. A faint dry rustle. *[It's very restless, actually. Once you stop fighting it.]*

"Be quiet."

[You always say that.]

"You never listen."

[True.] The faintest hint of something like amusement. *[We are very alike, you and I.]*

Antho didn't answer. He looked at the Lantern. The small gold flame burned on, steady and still, and the four percent of him that wasn't clear grumbled and subsided.

The Keeper's Lantern. Lex had made it, with twelve Hush-runes on its glass and the whole of his heart in its making, and Malachi's eternal fire had finished it. *Voices can't act through you while it's lit.* That was what the panel had said. Antho had read it a hundred times since. Every time the four percent got loud.

He'd never told Lex what that meant to him. That his little brother had sat at an anvil for two days without sleeping and made him a way to be alone in his own head.

He should have. He should have told him a lot of things.

He went north without you, said the four percent. *He didn't ask.*

Antho looked at the flame and didn't answer.



THEY CAME DOWN AT dusk in a grey wood, because Ashka couldn't fly anymore.

She didn't say so. She couldn't. But she began to drop, slowly, her great wings beating heavier and heavier, the silver wing-frame Lex had forged for

her creaking at the joints. And then she simply folded and glided, down and down, into a clearing among grey trees, and landed hard, and lay there with her sides heaving.

Antho slid off her neck and went round to her head.

"I know," he said. "I know. It's all right."

She rolled one great eye at him. It had gone grey. All the silver and lightning in it fading.

He put his hand on her nose. And did something he hadn't done in years: he *listened* to her. Not with his ears. With Shade. The deep cold quiet hearing that lived in the space between heartbeats. He listened to the shape of the silence inside his dragon. The places where she wasn't.

And found it.

A hole. Small. At the very center of her. Where the lightning lived. Where a storm-drake's storm comes from. As if someone had reached into her and pinched out a candle.

[The grey drinks storm,] said the Murmur. [It drinks everything. Color. Warmth. Lightning. Names, if you stay too long.] A pause. [It's very old and very thirsty. It isn't wicked. It's just thin, and it wants to be full.]

Antho kept his hand on Ashka's nose and pushed.

Not with Shade. With Gale. The second of his Wells, the one he'd only reached Answering in, the one that had come to him in the black hall at Duskhold the night Garrick died. Wind. Moving air. The breath of the world. He didn't know how to give her lightning. But he knew how to give her *air*. And air was where storms came from.

He pushed it into her. A long steady breath of cold wind out of his own chest and into hers, through his palm, through her scales, into the small hole at the center of her where the lightning had been pinched out.

And something sparked.

Faint. Tiny. A single blue-white thread of lightning, crawling up the side of her nose. Then another. She lifted her head. She sneezed. A great crackling sneeze that shook grey leaves off every tree in the clearing and singed the grey grass black in a fan-shape in front of her.

The black grass stayed black. Real black. Real color, in the middle of the grey.

Ashka looked at it. Then at him.

And made a sound he'd never heard her make before. Small, and hoarse, and a little embarrassed.

"You're welcome," said Antho.

ATTUNEMENT — GALE

Answering → Answering (deepening)

*"Wind is only air that has
somewhere to be."*

He sat down against her side, in the circle of the Lantern's light, with the grey wood all around them. He felt very tired. Gale had taken more out of him than he'd expected. And he could feel the grey pressing against the edge of the Lantern's light, very patient, very thirsty, like water against a dam.

Thirty-one percent, he thought. And it gets thinner the further west we go.



THE THINNED CAME IN the night.

He heard them before he saw them. Or rather, he heard where they weren't. Shade was very loud here, in the thin places. The silence of the grey wood was full of shapes, and some of the shapes were moving. Coming through the trees toward the clearing. Slow. Careful. A lot of them.

He stood up with the Lantern in one hand and his staff in the other. The staff of black wind-twisted pine he'd cut on the road out of the mountains, the first week he'd travelled with his brother, when he was still too proud to lean on people.

They came out of the trees.

Deer, at first. A herd of them. Or what had been deer. They were grey, like everything else, and *thin*. Not thin like starving. Thin like paper. He could see the trees behind them through their bodies. Their eyes were empty. Their hooves made no sound on the grey grass.

And they were *hungry*. He could feel it. Not for meat. For the Lantern. For its gold light. For the black scorch-mark on the grass. For Ashka's newly sparking scales. For Antho. For anything with color in it.

[Thinned,] said the Murmur. [Things that came too close to the river. That stayed too long. The grey drank them down to almost nothing, and now

they want it back. Anything they can get.] A pause. [They're not wicked either. They're just very, very empty.]

Behind the deer came other things. A fox. A bear, huge and slow and grey as smoke. A flock of birds, flapping silently among the branches. And at the back of them, something that had been a man.

Antho's chest went tight.

It was a man. Or had been. Tall and thin and grey. Wearing the faint ghost-shape of a traveler's cloak. Holding the faint ghost-shape of a walking-stick. His face was blurred, rubbed out, a smudge where the features should have been.

And he was walking toward the Lantern with his grey hands held out. Like a man coming in from the cold toward a fire.

"Please," he whispered. It was barely a sound. Wind through dry grass. "Please. Just a little. Just a little warm."



ANTHO DIDN'T ATTACK.

He thought about it. He had the power. Void Bolt would have gone through the thinned like a stone through paper. Shadowbind would have held them. He could have cleared the clearing in a few heartbeats.

But they weren't wicked. The Murmur was right. They were just empty. Hungry. Cold. Things that had come too close to something too big for them and been drunk down to nothing. And Antho had been something like that, once. For eight years. In a cave, in the dark, with the Hollow drinking him.

He looked at the grey man with the rubbed-out face.

He came here looking for something, thought Antho. Like me.

He set the Lantern down on the grass.

And opened its shutter.

Not all the way. Just a little. The gold light spilled out, wider, warmer, a circle the size of a cottage, and the thinned deer at the edge of it flinched and stopped. The grey man stopped too. He stood at the very edge of the light with his hands held out, trembling.

"Come and sit," said Antho quietly. "All of you. You can't have it. But you can sit by it."

The grey man didn't move.

Then, very slowly, he took one step forward. Into the light.

And didn't burn. Didn't flee. He stood in the gold light of the Keeper's Lantern with his grey hands held out, and Antho saw the light go *into* him. Not much. A little color. A faint flush on the smudge of his face. A faint brown in his cloak.

The man sank down onto the grass. Slowly. Folding up like a tired old man at the end of a long road. And sat there, at the edge of the light, with his empty face turned to the flame.

"Thank you," he whispered.

One by one, the others came. The deer. The fox. The great grey bear, lumbering into the light and lying down with a long silent sigh. The birds settled on the branches overhead. They didn't come close. They didn't try to take. They just sat, at the edge of the circle of gold, in the grey wood, and warmed themselves at a dead woman's light that her son had carried across the Teeth.

Ashka watched them with her head on her forelegs and lightning crawling faintly along her nose. She didn't growl. Antho didn't know why. Maybe she understood.

He sat down against her side again with his staff across his knees. And kept the shutter open all night. It cost him. The Lantern drew on his mana to burn this wide, a steady slow drain, like a cut that won't stop bleeding. By dawn he was grey himself with tiredness, and his hands were shaking.

But in the morning, when the pale flat light came up over the grey wood, the thinned were still there. All of them. Asleep, or something like asleep, curled up in the grass at the edge of the light.

And the grey man had a face.

Not much of one. Faint. Like a portrait in very weak watercolor. But there. An old man's face, lined and gentle, with a white beard. Asleep. Smiling.

SKILL ACQUIRED (Twilight Warlock)*HEARTHGLOW (Lantern) – Novice 1**"Some of the lost do not want saving. They only want to sit by a fire for a while."**Effect: the thinned and Hollow-touched may rest within the Lantern's light. While at rest, they cannot be drawn on.*

Antho read it twice. He didn't feel anything about it. He was too tired to feel anything.

He shut the Lantern down to its usual small circle. He climbed onto Ashka's neck. And as they rose up out of the grey wood, heading west, he looked down and saw the old man with the faint white beard lift his head from the grass and watch them go.

And raise one faint, grey, slowly coloring hand. And wave.



THEY FOUND THE RIVER on the fifth day.

He'd been expecting a river. The voice through the door had said so. *The grey river.* He'd imagined something like the Ashbourne millstream, or the wide slow Silverrun at Highcrest. Water. Banks. A river.

It wasn't.

It was a mist. A long wide slow-moving river of grey mist, a mile across, flowing from somewhere far to the north to somewhere far to the south, through a valley so wide and flat and grey that Antho couldn't see its edges. It moved like water. It rippled like water. When the wind blew across it, it made small grey waves that broke soundlessly on the grey shingle of the shore.

But it wasn't water. He could see that, the moment they came down on its bank. It was *thinness*. The world, worn so thin that it had stopped being solid and had become something else. Something in between. Something that flowed.

And on the far side of it, a mile off across the grey, there was another shore.

He could just see it. A dark line on the horizon. Darker than grey. Not black, exactly. More like the color of the back of his own eyelids at night. And above it, a sky that was the same color. Deep. Endless. Quiet.

The Hollow.

He knew it the way he knew his own heartbeat. He'd had it inside him for eight years. He'd held its door shut with his own mind. He'd heard it whispering every night of his life since he was fifteen. And there it was. A mile away. Across a river of grey mist.

[Home,] whispered the Murmur. Very softly. Almost reverent. *[Oh, Oh, I'd forgotten.]*

He held the Lantern up, and the Murmur went quiet.

LATTICE SIGNAL

World-thickness: 9%

SELF-COHERENCE WARNING

Anchor detected: KEEPER'S

LANTERN (Legendary)

Coherence maintained (for now)



THERE WAS A BOAT on the shore.

He hadn't seen it at first. It was grey, like everything else, and long and flat and low, like the punts the eel-fishers used in the Tidewater marshes. It was drawn up on the shingle a little way downstream. And standing beside it, leaning on a long grey pole, was the Ferryman.

He was tall. Very tall. Taller than the Barrow-King had been, taller than anyone Antho had ever seen. Thin as a heron. He wore a long robe of grey cloth, and a wide-brimmed grey hat pulled low over his face, and from the top of his long pole there hung a lantern.

The lantern was unlit.

Antho walked down the shingle toward him. His boots made no sound on the stones. Behind him, Ashka followed, her great head low, her nostrils flaring. She wasn't afraid. He could feel that through his hand on her neck. She was something else. Eager. Straining. Every line of her great body pointing across the river, toward the far dark shore.

The Ferryman turned his head as they approached.

Under the brim of the grey hat, there was a face. Long and narrow and grey, like weathered driftwood. And no eyes. Just smooth grey skin where eyes should have been, as if they'd been worn away by a thousand years of wind.

"*Anthoren Vey*," said the Ferryman.

His voice was like rain on a slate roof. Soft. Steady. Very old.

"You know my name."

"*I know every name that comes to my river. That is what I am for.*" The eyeless face turned toward Ashka. "*And the storm-child. Daughter of the old storm. She has been calling, has she not? Across the water. I have heard her. Every night for a month.*" A pause. "*Her mother hears her too.*"

Ashka made a sound. Low and urgent and pleading.

"Her mother's alive?" said Antho.

"*Her mother is in the Drowned Country. Across the river, and down. Under the water that is not water.*" The rain-voice didn't change. "*The Hollow has been keeping her there for eleven years, as your world counts them. Far longer, as she has felt them. Time is thin at the edge. Drinking her lightning. A little at a time. A storm-mother has a great deal of lightning in her. She has lasted very long.*"

"Then take us across."

The eyeless face turned back to him.

"*There is a price*," said the Ferryman.



ANTHO HAD KNOWN THERE would be. The voice through the door hadn't said so, but there was always a price. That was the first thing the Hollow had taught him, at fifteen, on the woodpile. Nothing comes free. Not out of the dark.

"Name it."

"*I take memories*," said the Ferryman. "*That is my fee. Every crossing. One memory, from each who crosses.*" He tilted his grey head. "*Not just any memory. That would be too easy. I take the one you would least wish to lose.*"

Antho went still.

"*The best thing*," said the Ferryman softly. "*The brightest. The one you carry closest. The one you take out in the dark, when the voices are loud, and*

turn over in your hands like a warm stone." The eyeless face was turned full toward him. *"I know which one it is. I can see it. It is very bright."*

Antho didn't say anything.

"A riverbank," said the Ferryman. *"A summer evening. A small boy with a flat grey stone in his hand. You, fifteen, showing him how to throw it. Low, low, like you are trying to make it fly under a door."* His voice was very gentle. *"And it skips. And you count. You always count. And it skips five times."*

Antho's hand had closed on his staff so hard his knuckles hurt.

"You told him four," said the Ferryman. *"And then, years later, under the stars, you told him the truth. And he laughed. And it was the best night of your life."* A pause. *"That is the price. For you and the storm-child both. One crossing there. One back. That memory, and no other."*



HE COULDN'T SPEAK.

He stood on the grey shingle of the river between the world and the Hollow, with his dragon straining at his side and the Lantern in his hand, and he couldn't speak.

Five times.

He remembered it. All of it. The millpond below the Ashbourne mill. The willows. The low gold evening light. Lex at ten, skinny and freckled and furious at himself, throwing stone after stone after stone into the water with a great *plunk*. And Antho kneeling beside him in the reeds, guiding his small wrist. *Low. Flatter. Like it's trying to fly under a door.* And the stone leaving Lex's hand, spinning, and touching the water, and lifting, and touching, and lifting.

One. Two. Three. Four. Five.

And Lex's face.

And then, years later, in the dark, on the Old Founders' Road, the two of them lying on their backs under the stars. *It skipped five times. I counted. I always count. I told you four.* And Lex, beside him, laughing. Helpless. Laughing so hard he couldn't breathe. *You absolute—you liar. Nine years, Antho!*

That was it. That was the warm stone. That was the thing he took out in the dark when the four percent got loud. Not the battles. Not the breach closing, or Duskhold, or Morvane falling. Not the Queen's crown or the eleven thousand people cheering.

A stone that skipped five times. And his little brother laughing under the stars.

[Pay it,] whispered the Murmur. [What's one memory? You've lost so many. You've lost years. What's one more?]

He looked at the Lantern. The Murmur went silent.

But it wasn't wrong. That was the trouble. He *had* lost years. Eight years in the Hollowmaw that he barely remembered, gone grey and blurred like the thinned. His childhood, half of it buried under the Murmur. His mother's face: he could see the shape of it, but not the details anymore. Not her eyes. Not her smile.

He'd lost so much. He had so little left that was bright.

And this was the brightest.

"No," he said.

The Ferryman didn't move.

"Not that one. Take another. Take—" He stopped. Swallowed. "Take Duskhold. Take the breach closing. Take anything."

"I take the one you would least wish to lose. That is the price. It is not mine to change."

"Then I won't pay it."

"Then you will not cross."



ASHKA SCREAMED.

Antho had never heard her scream. Not when he found her, wet and furious and tiny in a nest of frozen rock. Not when her wing broke. Not at Duskhold, with Sorrowmaw's jaws closing on her. She'd roared, and growled, and thundered. Never screamed.

She screamed now. Long and terrible and grief-stricken, a sound like a storm tearing itself in half. And she threw herself at the river.

"ASHKA—"

He grabbed for her. Too late. She went past him in a great rush of grey scales and crackling wings, down the shingle, and into the grey mist. Not flying. Wading. Plunging into the river of thinness up to her chest, her great wings beating at it, pushing toward the far dark shore.

And the river *took* her.

He saw it. Saw the grey mist close around her chest and her shoulders. Saw the color drain out of her, all at once, the storm-blue of her scales fading to grey in the space of a heartbeat. Saw the lightning crawling along her sides gutter and go out. Saw her great silver eyes go flat and dull.

She stopped. In the middle of the grey, ten paces out from the shore. And stood there. Her wings slowly folding. Her head slowly lowering. As if she'd forgotten where she was going.

As if she'd forgotten why.

"*She did not pay,*" said the Ferryman, behind him. Very quietly. "*The river takes what it is owed. One way or another.*"

Antho was already running.



THE MIST WAS COLD.

Not cold like ice. Cold like forgetting. It came up over his boots and his knees and his waist, and everywhere it touched, he felt himself fading. Not his body. *Him*. His name. His face. The shape of himself, going soft at the edges, like the man with the rubbed-out face in the grey wood.

He held the Lantern up over his head. High. In both hands. The small gold flame burned against the grey.

Anthoren Vey, he thought. *Anthoren Vey. Twenty-seven. Twilight Warlock. Brother of Lex. Son of Seren. I count the lanterns. One thousand one hundred and eleven.*

The grey pressed in around the light. Thirsty. Patient. Very old.

One thousand one hundred and eleven, he thought, and kept walking.

He reached Ashka. She was standing chest-deep in the mist with her head drooping almost into it. Grey as stone. Her silver eyes were open, but they didn't see him.

He put his hand on her neck.

He couldn't feel her. Not with Shade. Not the shape of her, the familiar dragon-shaped silence he knew better than his own. There was just *grey*. Grey inside her. Grey where the storm had been.

"Ashka," he said.

Nothing.

"*Ashka*." Louder. He pressed his hand flat against her scales. "Ashka, it's me. It's Antho. Come on. Come back."

Nothing. Grey.

She's gone, said the four percent. *The river's got her. You're next.*

He felt it. Felt it coming up through his own legs, into his chest. His name going soft. *Anthoren. Anthoren V—*

He did the only thing he could think of.

He sang.

Not well. He'd never sung well. His voice was rough and low and had cracked on every high note since he was thirteen. He stood waist-deep in the river between the world and the Hollow, with the Lantern held over his head and his hand on his dragon's grey neck, and sang the song she'd hatched to.

Not the lantern song. The other one. The one he'd sung to a newly hatched drake in a nest of frozen rock, the first night, because it was the only thing he could think of to keep her warm. An old Greyspine herding-song. Nonsense words about a storm coming over the hill and a shepherd bringing the flock home.

Oh the storm is coming, the storm is near, bring them home, bring them home, there's thunder on the mountain, but I'm right here, bring them home, my love, bring them home.

He sang it badly. He sang it with his voice cracking and the grey eating at his edges. He sang it the way he'd sung it that first winter, over and over, night after night, until the tiny wet furious thing inside his coat stopped shivering and bit him on the thumb.

Bring them home, my love, bring them home.

And under his hand, something sparked.



IT WAS TINY. THE size of a seed. A single blue-white spark, deep in the grey of her neck, under his palm.

He sang louder.

It spread. A thread of lightning, crawling up through the grey of her. Another. Her scales flickering. Blue. Grey. Blue again. Her great head lifting. Slowly. Her silver eyes—

They found him.

She looked at him. Ashka. His dragon. Out of a grey face, with lightning crawling back up her nose, and her eyes coming back silver.

And she made a sound. Small. Bewildered. The sound she'd made that first night in the rocks, wet and furious and new. The sound she'd made the first time she ever saw him.

"There you are," he said. His voice cracked again. *"There you are."*

He turned her. It was like turning a ship. She was huge and slow and grey and confused, and he had to push her with his whole weight, his hand flat on her neck, singing all the while, step by step back through the grey toward the shore.

Ten paces. Five. The shingle under his boots.

They came out of the river onto the grey stones of the bank and both fell down.



HE LAY ON THE shingle for a long time.

Ashka lay beside him. He could feel her breathing. Slow and heavy. Her lightning was back, crawling faintly along her flanks. Her eyes were silver. She'd put her great head down beside his, so close her breath stirred his hair.

But something was wrong. He could feel it. In the dragon-shaped silence of her, where he listened with Shade. There was a hole in it. Small. At the very center.

"The river takes what it is owed," said the Ferryman.

He was standing over them, leaning on his long pole. The unlit lantern swaying gently.

"She waded in without paying. So it took its fee." The eyeless face turned toward Ashka. "It took the thing she would least wish to lose. The brightest thing."

Antho sat up. Slowly. "What did it take?"

"Her mother's voice."

He went cold.

"She has heard it every night for a month. Across the water. Calling her home. She has followed it across the Teeth, across the grey, all the way to my shore." The rain-voice was very gentle. "And now she cannot remember what it sounded like. She knows she was looking for something. She does not remember what."

Antho looked at Ashka.

She was lying on the shingle with her head beside his. She lifted it, slowly, and looked out across the grey river. At the far dark shore. And he saw her frown, in the way dragons frown, a faint creasing of the scales above her eyes. Puzzled. As if she'd come into a room for something and couldn't remember what.

She looked at the far shore for a long time.

Then she put her head back down beside his, and closed her eyes.

She didn't keen. She didn't make that low lonely searching sound. She just lay there, quietly, beside him, the way she had when she was small.

As if there were nothing on the other side of the river at all.



HE SAT ON THE shore of the grey river until dark.

He didn't know what else to do. He sat on the shingle with his staff across his knees and the Lantern beside him and his dragon asleep at his back, and looked across the grey at the far dark shore, and thought.

She paid it for me. She couldn't pay, so the river took it from her. Because I wouldn't.

Because I wouldn't give up a stone that skipped five times.

The Ferryman hadn't left. He stood a little way off, beside his long grey boat, leaning on his pole. Waiting. Patient as the river.

"Can she get it back?" said Antho at last.

"If she crosses. If she finds her mother. If she hears the voice again." The Ferryman didn't turn. *"What the river takes, it takes. But a voice can be heard twice."*

"And if I pay. For both of us. Can she cross?"

"Yes."

Antho closed his eyes.

"You do not have to decide tonight," said the Ferryman. *"The river is very patient. It has been here since before the world was made. It will be here when the world is gone."* A pause. *"The price will not go down. But the time to pay it may run out."*

"What does that mean?"

The eyeless face turned toward him.

"It means that something is coming," said the Ferryman softly. *"From the east. Through the world. Cutting as it comes. I can feel it in the river. Every thread it cuts falls into my water."* He was silent for a long moment. *"Forty-eight. Forty-nine. Fifty."*

Antho's head came up.

"When it has what it seeks," said the Ferryman, *"it will come for what lies under your lanterns. And then you will need the old storm. You will need her very much."*



MUCH LATER, IN THE dark, with the river flowing grey and silent beside him and Ashka asleep at his back, Antho said:

"Have you ever taken anyone else of my blood across?"

The Ferryman was quiet for so long that Antho thought he wasn't going to answer.

Then:

"Once."

Antho didn't move.

"A woman," said the rain-voice. *"Long ago. Not so long, for me. Long for you."* A pause. *"She came down to my shore at night, with a lamp in her hand. A small clay lamp. Burning. She asked me to take her across."*

Antho's heart had stopped.

"She paid," said the Ferryman. "More than you can imagine. More than anyone has ever paid me." His eyeless face was turned toward the far dark shore. "I will not tell you what. That was hers, and she paid it freely, and it is not mine to give away."

"When?" Antho's voice came out of him in pieces. "When was this?"

But the Ferryman only turned away, and leaned on his long grey pole, and looked across the river. And the unlit lantern on the top of it swung gently in the wind that came off the water. And he didn't say anything else.

Antho sat on the grey shore with his hands over his face.

A small clay lamp.

Burning.

And far, far away to the south, through the Bloodbond, so faint it was barely a whisper, he felt his little brother. Walking. Steady. Determined. Heading down into a country of sun and glass.

And behind him, a long way behind, but following, something cold.

Lex, he thought. Lex. Turn around.

But the Bloodbond was thin here, as thin as everything else, and he didn't know if his brother heard.

CHAPTER 8

THE UNLIT

"*You can't go through Fallowmere,*" said Kestrel.

They were standing on a ridge in the southern foothills of the Ironbacks, eleven days out of the White Shore, looking down at a market town in a green valley. Smoke from a hundred chimneys. A church spire. A Lattice Stone in the square, glowing faint silver in the afternoon light. Lex could feel it from here. Its threads. Its people. Six thousand souls, give or take, and nine hundred and forty of them Unbound, their threads running bright and loose and free.

He'd Unbound that Stone himself. Two summers ago. He remembered the miller's daughter who'd cried, and the old soldier who'd sat down in the square and laughed until he couldn't breathe.

"Why not?"

"*Because you're you.*" Kestrel looked at him. "*You're Lex Vey. The Forgeheart. The man who broke the Ceiling. There's a song about you, did you know that? Every alehouse in the north. 'The Smith of Ashbourne.' It's terrible. It rhymes 'anvil' with 'grand will.'*" Her lip curled. "*You walk into Fallowmere, they'll ring the church bell. There'll be a feast. Children'll want you to touch their heads.*"

"I'll keep my hood up."

"*You've got gold eyes and you're the size of a door.*" She folded her arms. "*And that's not even the real reason.*"

He waited.

"*He's following you,*" said Kestrel quietly. "*The old man. You know he is. He said it himself. You'll bring me the bit.*" She nodded down at the town. "*Every place you stop, he can find. And every place he finds, he takes someone. You walk into Fallowmere and have your feast, and next week some girl in that town is going to wake up and nobody will remember her name.*"

Lex looked down at the town.

[She's right,] said Ember quietly. *[I hate it. But she's right.]*

He'd known it. He'd known it since the White Shore. Since he'd opened the Ledger and found a forty-eighth name at the bottom of the page. *Bram Sowerby, of the White Shore. He named every one of his lambs after a star.* A shepherd. Last night. A mile from the temple. While Lex was walking north toward it.

Elric had been *close*. Following. Taking, as he went.

"Then where?"

"*Round,*" said Kestrel. "*West, through the Bitter Hills. It's longer. It's wild. Nobody lives there.*" She hesitated. "*Nearly nobody.*"

Lex looked at her. She didn't look back. She was staring down at Fallowmere with her jaw set, and her fire was very low in her hair, barely a glow.

"Who's nearly nobody?"

Kestrel was quiet for a long moment.

"*Friends,*" she said at last. "*Of a sort. My grandmother's sort.*" She glanced at him sideways. "*They won't like you.*"

"Why not?"

"*Because you're the net,*" said Kestrel simply. "*And they're the ones who fell through it.*"



THE BITTER HILLS were well named.

They rose up south and west of the Ironbacks in a long, broken, ugly sprawl of brown scrub and grey stone and old, old mine-workings. Nothing grew there but gorse and thorn and a kind of tough wiry grass that cut your ankles. The streams ran orange with rust. The wind smelled of slag.

[Iron country,] said Ember. [Once. A long time ago. Before the Lattice. They mined it out and left.]

There were no Stones here. Lex felt it the moment they crossed into the hills: the net going thin and quiet around him, the silver threads of the world spreading out and out until they were so far apart he could barely feel them. Like walking out of a crowded hall into an empty field at night.

It should have made him uneasy. It didn't. It was restful, in a way he hadn't expected. For the first time in years, there weren't six thousand people humming at the edge of his mind.

Tamsin walked beside them. Fainter, now that Kestrel's fire was banked. Lex could see the gorse through his chest. But his face was clearer than it had been on the White Shore. He had a name. He held onto it the way a drowning man holds a rope, and every hour or so Lex would hear him whisper it to himself, very softly. *Tamsin. Tamsin Varn. Tam.*



THEY WALKED THREE DAYS into the hills before anyone found them.

Lex felt it first. On the third evening, as they were coming down a long scree slope into a narrow valley full of thorn. A prickle at the back of his neck. A sense of being *looked at*.

He stopped.

"*What?*" said Kestrel.

"Someone's watching."

She looked around. At the empty slope. The thorn. The brown hills going purple in the dusk. "*I don't see anyone.*"

He didn't either. That was the thing. He looked at the valley with his ordinary eyes and saw nothing. Thorn and rock and an orange stream.

He started to reach for True Sight.

And stopped.

He didn't know why. It was a feeling. Like a hand on his wrist. *Don't*. The same way he sometimes knew a weld was going to fail before he struck it.

He looked with his ordinary eyes again. Slowly. The way Wren had taught him to look in the forest, years ago, at the very start, on the road to the Greyspine. *Don't look for the deer. Look for where the forest is wrong.*

There. Twenty paces down the slope. A thornbush. Exactly like every other thornbush in the valley. Except that the evening wind was blowing hard from the west, bending every thornbush in the valley eastward.

And this one wasn't moving.

"That one," said Lex, and pointed.

There was a pause.

Then the thornbush said, in a young woman's voice, deeply annoyed: "*Oh, for—how?*"

And a second thornbush, three paces to its left, which Lex hadn't noticed at all, said in an almost identical voice, also annoyed: "*I told you the wind was wrong.*"

"*You didn't tell me anything.*"

"*I thought it very loudly.*"

The two thornbushes rippled. Like a reflection in a pond when you drop a stone. And were gone. And in their place stood two people.

Twins. Lex could see that at once. Small and slight and sharp-faced, perhaps twenty-four, with identical untidy mops of mouse-brown hair and identical narrow grey eyes and identical expressions of profound irritation. One was a young woman in a patched green coat. One was a young man in a patched brown one. They each had a long knife in their belt and a sling in their hand, and they were looking at Lex the way a cat looks at a dog that has unexpectedly learned to open doors.

"*Kestrel,*" said the young woman, without looking away from Lex. "*What have you brought us.*"

"*A smith,*" said Kestrel.

"*Is that—*" The young man was staring at Lex's face. At his eyes. "*Is that the smith? The song one? Anvil and grand will?*"

"*Yes.*"

"*Oh, Kes,*" said the young woman. "*Oh, Kes, no. Dorran's going to have a fit.*"



THEIR NAMES WERE ILSE and Ivo Marrow. They were from Kessick, a mill town on the Silverrun, and they were thieves. They said so cheerfully, within the first five minutes, as they led Lex and Kestrel down the thorn-valley in the dusk.

"Illusionists," said Ivo. *"Technically. But mostly thieves."*

"Mostly thieves," agreed Ilse. *"Illusion's only really good for two things. Stealing and not getting caught stealing."*

"And parties."

"And parties," Ilse allowed. *"But there aren't many parties in the Bitter Hills."*

They were Unbound. Lex could feel it, faintly, even without True Sight. Two bright loose threads, running out from them into the thin net. But there was something strange about the threads. Something blurred.

"How did you hide?" he said. "From me. I couldn't see you at all."

Ilse glanced at him. A quick, sharp, assessing look.

"We didn't hide from you," she said. *"We hid from the light."*

"Lampshade," said Ivo. *"That's what we call it. It's an illusion. But not on your eyes. On the—"* He waved a hand vaguely at the air. *"The silver. The net. We make our threads look like nothing. Like the net's just empty where we are."*

Lex stopped walking.

[Lex,] said Ember sharply.

"You can hide your threads," he said. "From the Lattice."

"Well, not from the Lattice exactly. The Lattice knows we're there. We can't fool the Stones." Ivo shrugged. *"But from anyone looking at it. Anyone reading it. You, for instance. Wardens. Anyone with sight."* He paused. *"That old man with the key."*

"That's why we're alive," said Ilse simply.



THE UNLIT LIVED UNDER a hill.

Not in caves. In a mine. An old iron mine, abandoned centuries ago, its shafts and galleries running deep into the heart of the hill. The entrance was a black hole in a cliff-face, half hidden by thorn and gorse, and from inside it came a smell Lex hadn't expected.

Beeswax.

They went in, and down, and the passage widened into a gallery, and Lex stopped.

Candles.

Hundreds of them. Thousands. On every ledge, in every niche, on every jut and outcrop of the old rust-red rock. Fat beeswax candles and thin tallow ones, candles in jars, candles in tin cups, candles stuck in their own wax on the bare stone. The whole gallery glowed with soft, warm, flickering yellow light. Not silver. Not gold. Not Lattice-light, or Root-light, or the steady glow of the lanterns in the Hollowmaw.

Just candles. Ordinary fire.

"The Wickhollow," said Kestrel quietly. *"Welcome to the Unlit."*

There were people. Not many. Forty, maybe fifty. Sitting on benches carved into the rock, or working at tables, or cooking at a long stone hearth at the far end of the gallery. Men and women and a few children. Old and young. Some with the bright loose threads of the Unbound. Some with the dull capped threads of people who'd never been freed.

And some with no threads at all.

Like Kestrel. Like Malachi. Nothing there. The Lattice looking at them and seeing empty air.

They all stopped what they were doing and looked at him.

[Unlatticed,] said Ember. *[A dozen of them, at least. Lex, I didn't think there were this many in the whole of Caldor.]*

Lex stood in the doorway of the gallery with forty people staring at him and felt, for the first time in a long time, entirely out of place.



"No," said Dorran Vask.

He was the biggest man Lex had ever seen. Bigger even than Brannoc.

Lex was big. He'd been big since he was fourteen. Brannoc used to say he'd been built for the forge the way some men are built for the sea. But Dorran Vask was half a head taller and half again as broad. He was perhaps fifty, with a great slab of a face, a nose that had been broken at least three times, a shaved head and a short grey beard. He wore an old leather coat and a smith's apron, of all things, and his hands were the size of shovels.

And on his right forearm, burned deep into the skin, faded and scarred and very old, there was a mark Lex knew.

The Order's lattice-sigil. The brand they put on Wardens of the Kindling. The ones who stood beside the Stones at every village Kindling-day and pressed the Ceiling down on every child who came of age.

"No," said Dorran Vask again. He was standing at the long stone hearth with a ladle in his hand, staring at Lex across the gallery. His voice was a deep slow rumble, like rocks shifting in a stream. *"Kestrel. What have you done?"*

"He's not with the Order, Dorran."

"He's worse than the Order. He's the Root. He's the man with the net in his hands." Dorran set the ladle down. Very carefully. As if he were afraid he'd break it. *"You've brought the Lattice into the Wickhollow. Into the one place in Caldor where it can't see us."*

"He's hunting the key," said Kestrel. *"The old man's key. The one that's taking people."*

"And the old man is hunting him." Dorran looked at Lex. Steady, heavy, unblinking. *"Isn't he."*

"Yes," said Lex.

"So you've brought him here too."

"I don't know," said Lex honestly. "I hope not. I don't know how he follows me. I don't know if he does." He met the big man's eyes. "If he does, I'll go. Tonight. I won't put your people in danger."

Dorran Vask looked at him for a long moment.

"You already have," he said quietly. *"By being born."*



THEY GAVE HIM FOOD anyway. A bowl of thick barley stew from the pot on the hearth, and a heel of dark bread, and a seat at the end of a bench as far from everyone else as the gallery allowed. Kestrel sat beside him. Tamsin stood behind her. Nobody else came near.

Lex ate and watched them. The Unlit. Watching him back.

[They're frightened of you,] said Ember quietly.

I know.

[Not of you. Of what you are. Of the gold in your eyes.] A pause. [Most of these people have spent their lives running from the Lattice. Hiding from Wardens. Hiding from Kindling-day. And you're the thing at the very center of it.]

I broke the Ceiling. I Unbound forty thousand people.

[And the people who weren't in it? The ones who were never Kindled at all? The ones who ran?] Ember was silent for a moment. [You didn't do anything for them, Lex. You couldn't. They weren't in the net to free.]

He looked at a little girl, perhaps eight, sitting on her mother's lap at the far end of the gallery. No thread. Nothing. She was staring at him with enormous solemn eyes over the edge of her bowl.

I didn't even know they existed, he thought.

[No,] said Ember. [Nobody did. That was the point.]



ORIEL SANT FOUND HIM after supper.

He didn't hear her come. She was simply there, sitting on the bench beside him, where Kestrel had been a moment before. Kestrel had gone to argue with Dorran at the hearth. Their voices rose and fell in the candlelight.

Oriel Sant was very old. Older than Mag the herbwoman had been, older than anyone Lex had ever met except Malachi. She was tiny and bent and brown, wrapped in a shawl of faded red wool, and her eyes were white. Not clouded. White. Pure white, like the inside of a shell, without iris or pupil.

She had no thread.

"*Smith,*" she said. Her voice was thin and dry and very precise.

"Mother," said Lex. It was what you called old women in Ashbourne. It seemed right.

She smiled. It made her whole face crease like crumpled paper. "*Mannerly. Good. Dorran thinks you'll have us all killed. Kestrel thinks you'll save her brother. The twins think you're the most interesting thing to happen in the Bitter Hills since the goat fell down the north shaft.*" She tilted her head. "*I think you have someone looking out of your eyes.*"

Lex went still.

"What?"

"*I'm blind,*" said Oriel Sant. "*Born blind. Never been Kindled. My mother hid me from the Wardens, because a blind girl at Kindling-day was a girl who'd be capped at nothing. Useless. Better off dead, the Wardens used to say.*" Her white eyes were turned toward him. "*So I never had the Lattice. And I never had sight. But I've always been able to see. Not with eyes. Not with silver. I see what's there.*"

"What do you see?"

"*A young man,*" she said. "*Big. Tired. Very sad, and pretending not to be. With a little gold fire in him that talks.*" She smiled again. "*Hello, little fire.*"

[*She can see me,*] said Ember, sounding stunned. [*Lex, she can see me.*]

"*And behind the fire,*" said Oriel Sant, "*far back, in the deep part of the gold, where you can't see it yourself—*" Her smile went away. "*An eye.*"

Lex didn't move.

"*It isn't always open,*" said Oriel. "*It isn't always looking. Most of the time, it's asleep. But when you use the gold—when you reach into that deep place and pull the power up—it opens. Just a crack.*" Her thin dry hand found his wrist. Her fingers were cold. "*And it sees what you see.*"



[*No,*] said Ember.

It said it very fast. Very sharp. The way it had said *no* in the black hall at Duskhold when Elric had raised his staff.

[*No. No, that's not—Lex, I'm in the gold. I live there. I'd know. I'd know if there was something else in there. I've been in the Root with you every day for four years and there's nothing, there's nobody, it's just us—*]

"*The little fire doesn't believe me,*" said Oriel Sant gently. "*That's all right. The little fire was made by someone very clever, out of a piece of someone very good. It sees what it was made to see.*" She patted Lex's wrist. "*It wasn't made to see that far down.*"

"Whose eye is it?"

Oriel was quiet.

"Old," she said at last. *"Very old. Older than anything I've ever seen. And very kind."* She tilted her head. *"Kind the way a cat's kind to a mouse it hasn't decided to eat yet."*

Lex sat very still on the bench, in the warm candlelight, with the old woman's cold fingers on his wrist.

My blood. The smith. Will find it for you.

The voice says so, and the voice has never once been wrong.

He thought about the moor, and the Umbral Wardens, and the way he'd used True Sight to find their flaws. The vault at Ysmir, and the blood on the Ledger. The night he'd felt eleven holes in the net, from his forge at Ashbourne, reaching out with the Root as far as it would go.

Every time he used the gold.

Every time.

He's been watching through me, Lex thought. *Aurelian. He's been watching through my eyes. And telling Elric what he sees.*

[Lex—]

The bit's in the glass. He knew that already. But he doesn't know where in the glass. A hundred miles of desert, Kestrel said. His hands had gone cold. *He doesn't need to know. He just needs me to go and find it. And look at it. With the gold.*

[Then don't. Don't use it. Not until we know.]

How am I supposed to find a Founders' artifact in a hundred miles of glass without Root sight?

Ember didn't answer.



"There are ways," said Oriel Sant.

Lex looked at her. He hadn't said anything out loud. But she was smiling faintly, her white eyes turned toward him, as if she'd heard every word.

"There's always ways," she said. *"That's what the Unlit are for, smith. We've spent our whole lives finding ways to live without the gold and the silver."* She patted his wrist again. *"You've spent your whole life inside it. You've never had to learn."*

"Will you teach me?"

The old woman laughed. A thin dry crackle, like dead leaves.

"Me? No. I'm too old, and I'm blind, and I've seen how this ends." She turned her white face toward the hearth, where Kestrel and Dorran were still arguing. *"But they might. If you ask them properly."* A pause. *"Dorran most of all. Though he won't want to. Ask him about his list."*

"What list?"

But Oriel Sant had already got up, slowly, leaning on a stick of black thorn, and was shuffling away down the gallery into the candlelight.



HE FOUND DORRAN VASK the next morning at the far end of the mine, in a side gallery Lex hadn't seen before.

It was a forge.

Not much of one. A stone hearth built against the rock, with a chimney cut up through the hill to the surface. A bellows of old patched leather. An anvil, battered and black and very old, with a horn worn smooth by a hundred years of use. A rack of tools on the wall.

Dorran was at the anvil, working a bar of iron. A plowshare. Lex could tell from the shape. He was doing it badly. Not badly enough that anyone else would notice. But Lex noticed. The angle of the blows was wrong. Too heavy. Too much shoulder, not enough wrist.

He stood in the doorway and watched for a while. Then he said, before he could stop himself: "You're hitting it too hard."

Dorran's hammer stopped mid-swing.

He turned his great slab of a head and looked at Lex in the doorway. His face didn't change.

"I've been hitting iron for thirty years."

"You've been hitting it too hard for thirty years," said Lex. "It's a plowshare, not a Warden's mace. You're trying to make it do what you want. You've got to let it do what it wants, and help."

There was a very long silence.

Then Dorran Vask held out the hammer.

Lex came and took it. He looked at the bar of iron on the anvil, cooling. He pumped the bellows three times, slow. Laid the bar back in the coals.

Waited. Took it out when it was the color of a summer sunset. Laid it on the anvil.

And struck.

Light. Fast. All wrist. Letting the hammer bounce. *Tink-tink-tink*, the way Brannoc had taught him at twelve, in the Ashbourne forge, before he'd ever heard of the Lattice or the Root or a dead man's hammer. Ordinary smithing. No gold. No Flame. Just iron and fire and the ring of a hammer on an anvil.

The bar bent. Easily. Gratefully, almost. Curving into the shape it had wanted all along.

Dorran watched him. He didn't say anything.

When Lex had finished, and quenched it, and laid it on the bench, the big man picked it up. He turned it over in his huge hands. He ran his thumb along the edge.

"*Hub*," he said.

That was all.

But he didn't ask for the hammer back. And when Lex picked up the next bar from the pile and laid it in the coals, Dorran went and stood at the bellows without being asked, and pumped them, slow and steady, the way a striker does for a smith.

They worked all morning like that. Not talking. The bellows and the hammer and the ring of the iron. And by noon, there were six plowshares on the bench, and Lex's arms ached the good way, and the side gallery smelled of hot iron and coal-smoke, and for a few hours he'd forgotten about keys, and eyes, and everything.



"*Oriel said to ask you about your list*," said Lex, when they stopped to eat.

They were sitting on the floor of the forge with their backs against the warm stone of the hearth. Dorran had brought bread and cheese and a jug of small beer. He'd been quiet all morning. He was quieter now.

For a long time, he didn't say anything at all.

Then he reached into his old leather coat. And took out a book.

Small. Thick. Bound in cheap brown leather gone black with handling. He held it in his great hands for a moment. Then he gave it to Lex.

Lex opened it.

Names.

Pages of them. Hundreds of pages. Written in a big clumsy careful hand, in faded brown ink. Names, and villages, and dates, and a number beside each one.

Aldo Cray. Fen Hollow. Spring Kindling. Ceiling 18.

Bess Rook. Fen Hollow. Spring Kindling. Ceiling 12.

Wat Lister. Fen Hollow. Spring Kindling. Ceiling 15.

On and on. Page after page. Village after village.

"Kindling-day," said Dorran Vask. Very quietly. *"Twenty-two years. I was a Warden of the Kindling for twenty-two years. Every spring and every autumn, I went round my circuit. Twelve villages. And every child who'd turned fourteen came up to the Stone, one by one, and put their hand on it."* He was looking at the cold hearth. *"And I stood beside the Stone, and put my hand on their shoulder, and set their Ceiling."*

Lex didn't say anything.

"That's what the brand's for." Dorran held up his forearm. The faded sigil. *"Gives you the Sanction to set them. You put your hand on the child, and you feel their thread, and you push down. Like closing a lid."* His great hand closed, slowly, into a fist. *"Some of them cried. Some of them didn't know what was happening. Most of them just looked up at me. Trusting. Because I was the Warden, and that's what Wardens were for."*

He was silent for a long time.

"Four thousand, one hundred and nine," he said. *"I wrote down every one. I don't know why. I started the first year. I just—wanted to remember them."* He shook his head slowly. *"I didn't know, then. What it was. What I was doing. They told us it was for the children's protection. That an uncapped thread was dangerous. That the Ceiling kept them safe."*

"When did you find out?"

"The year the Marrow twins came up." Dorran almost smiled. Almost. *"Kessick. Ten years ago this spring. Two little mouse-haired things, holding hands. They put their hands on the Stone together, and I put my hand on their shoulders, and I felt their threads."* He stopped. *"They were so bright. Both of them. Brighter than anything I'd ever felt. Like two stars."* His voice dropped very low. *"And I pushed down. And I felt them go dim. And the*

girl looked up at me. Ilse. And she said, very quietly, so no one else could hear: Why did you put the light out?"

The forge was very quiet.

"I put my brand in the fire that night," said Dorran Vask. "Tried to burn it off. Didn't work. Sanction's in the thread, not the skin." He looked at his scarred forearm. "Then I walked into the Bitter Hills, and I didn't come out."

"Ilse and Ivo—"

"They found me. Five years later. They'd been running since they were sixteen. Thieving. Hiding." Dorran shrugged his enormous shoulders. "They recognized me. I thought they were going to kill me." He paused. "Ivo wanted to. Ilse wouldn't let him."

"Why not?"

"She said I'd only been doing my job." Dorran's great face twisted. "And then she said the Unlit needed someone big to lift things. And I've been lifting things for them ever since."

Lex looked down at the book in his hands. Four thousand one hundred and nine names.

"They're Unbound," he said. "The Marrows. They're Unbound now."

"Yes. Your Unbinding. Two summers past. They went down to the Kessick Stone in disguise, the day you came through, and stood in the crowd." Dorran looked at him. "Ilse came back and found me in this forge and didn't say anything. Just stood there, glowing. And then she hit me." He rubbed his jaw. "Very hard. And then she cried. And then she went and stole a pie."

Lex laughed. He couldn't help it.

And after a moment, Dorran Vask laughed too. A deep slow rumble, like rocks shifting in a stream.



"How many?" said Dorran, when they'd stopped. "Of my list. How many have you Unbound?"

Lex looked at the book.

"I don't know," he said. "I'd have to check. Against the Stones." He turned a page. "Fen Hollow. I haven't been to Fen Hollow. Or—" He turned another. "Brackwater. Or Thornby."

"Most of my circuit's in the west. Out past the Blightmarch. Small places. The Order never cared much about them."

"Neither did I," said Lex quietly. "I went where the big Stones were. Where the most people were. Highcrest. Kessick. The cities." He closed the book. "There are four thousand Stones in Caldor. I've done two hundred and sixty."

"That's a lot."

"It's not enough."

He held out the book to Dorran. The big man looked at it. Didn't take it.

"When this is over," said Lex. "When the key's dealt with. I'll go west. To your circuit. All twelve villages." He met Dorran's eyes. "And you'll come with me. And stand beside the Stone. And put your hand on their shoulders."

Dorran Vask stared at him.

"Why?"

"Because you closed the lids," said Lex. "You should be there when they open."

Dorran didn't say anything for a very long time.

Then he took the book. And held it in both his great hands. And bent his shaved head over it, and his shoulders shook, once.

Lex looked away, at the cold forge, and gave him that.



"Teach him," said Dorran that night.

He was standing at the long stone hearth in the main gallery, with the whole of the Unlit gathered around on the benches in the candlelight. Kestrel. Tamsin, faint behind her. The Marrow twins, perched together on a ledge with their legs dangling. Oriel Sant in her red shawl. Forty-odd others. All looking at him. Then at Lex.

"Teach him the Lampsbade," said Dorran. *"And whatever else he needs. To find the old man's key without the gold."*

There was a murmur. Uneasy.

"Dorran," said Ivo. *"Last night you said he'd get us all killed."*

"He might." Dorran didn't look away from Lex. *"He's the Root. He's dangerous just by being. Everyone near him is in danger."* He paused. *"But I spent twenty-two years putting out lights. He's spent four years lighting them."* He folded his enormous arms. *"I've decided I know which of us I'd rather follow."*

Ilse Marrow looked at her brother. Her brother looked at her.

Something passed between them, the way it did between twins. A whole conversation in a glance.

"Fine," said Ilse. *"We'll teach him."* She pointed at Lex. *"But he's terrible at it. He walked straight past Ivo yesterday."*

"He did not," said Ivo. *"He saw me. He saw both of us."*

"He saw me. He didn't see you until you moved. You twitched. You always twitch."

"I sneezed."

"Same thing."

Oriel Sant laughed, a thin dry crackle, at the end of the bench. And somewhere in the candlelight, the little girl with no thread, the one who'd stared at Lex over her bowl the night before, came and stood in front of him. And looked up at him with her enormous solemn eyes.

"Are you the anvil man?" she said.

"I'm a smith," said Lex.

"Can you make me a candle-holder? A proper one? Mine's broken."

Lex looked at her. Small and solemn and threadless. The Lattice had never once looked at her and seen anything at all.

"Yes," he said. *"Tomorrow. I'll make you the best candle-holder in the Bitter Hills."*

She nodded, gravely, as if this were a serious bargain. Then she climbed up onto the bench beside him and sat there, swinging her legs, and leaned her head against his arm.

And that was how the Unlit decided.



THE LAMPSHADE TOOK HIM eleven days.

It wasn't magic. Not the way he knew magic. There was no Well in it. No Flame, no Stone, no Root. It was a trick of the mind. A way of thinking

about yourself. Ilse explained it on the first morning, sitting cross-legged on the floor of the forge gallery with Ivo beside her.

"Your thread's a light," she said. "Right? Everyone's is. Silver, gold, whatever. It shines. And anyone with sight can look at the net and see it shining."

"Yes."

"So you don't put it out." Ilse held up her hand. "You can't put it out. You'd die. You put a shade on it." She cupped her other hand over the first. "Like a lampshade. The light's still there. Still burning. You're just—making it look like the room's dark."

"How?"

"You believe it," said Ivo. "That's all. That's the whole trick. You sit very still, and you think about being nothing. Being empty. Being the dark bit of the room where nobody's sitting." He shrugged. "And if you believe it hard enough, the net believes it too."

"Illusion's just lying very convincingly," said Ilse. "To other people. Or to the world."

"Or to yourself," said Ivo.

Lex was terrible at it.

He'd never been good at lying. Brannoc used to say he had a face like an open door. And this was harder than lying. This was lying to the deepest part of himself: the part that was gold, and burning, and *there*, the Root-heir of the Lattice, with Ember humming in him like a hearth.

Be nothing, he told himself. Be empty. Be the dark bit of the room.

[You're thinking about being nothing so loudly,] said Ember, [that I can hear it from in here.]

The twins laughed at him. Kestrel laughed at him. Dorran didn't laugh, but his great slab of a face did something at the corners that might have been the beginnings of it.

On the fourth day, he managed it for a heartbeat. On the sixth, for a count of ten. On the ninth, Ilse sat across from him with her eyes narrowed, reading the net, and said, *"Oh. Oh, there you go. There's nobody there."*

And on the eleventh day, he walked from one end of the Wickhollow to the other with his thread shaded, and Oriel Sant, sitting on her bench in

her red shawl, turned her white eyes toward him as he passed and said, "*Smith? Is that you? I can't see your eye anymore.*"

SKILL ACQUIRED (unlatticed technique)

LAMPSHADE – Novice 1

"The light still burns. The room only looks dark."

Effect: thread concealed from sight-based reading (incl. Root sight & Key-sight). Cannot be maintained while using Root Prerogatives.

Cannot be maintained while using Root Prerogatives.

He read it twice.

So it hides me. But only while I don't use the gold.

[Which means,] said Ember quietly, [that if you want to stay hidden from whatever's looking out of your eyes, you have to stop being the Root.] A pause. [Lex, I've been in there every day. I've looked. I can't find it. I can't find anything.]

Oriel can.

[I know.] Ember was very quiet. [That's what frightens me.]



HE WROTE LETTERS ON the last night. He'd promised. *I'll write.* And he hadn't. Not for six weeks.

The Unlit had a way of sending them. They didn't say what it was. A tinker, maybe, or a carter, or a girl with a basket who walked out of the Bitter Hills to Fallowmere market every tenth day. It didn't matter. The letters would go.

He wrote to his father. Short. *I'm alive. I'm going south. Elric has the bow. The bit is in the Sunreach and the blade is under the Hollowmaw. Guard Antho. Guard the door. Something is watching through the Root, Father. Through my eyes. Did you know? Tell me if you knew.*

He wrote to Antho. Longer. Then shorter again. Then he tore it up, and wrote: *I'm sorry I left without you. You were right to be angry. The blade is under your floor. Don't let him have it. I love you. Go and skip stones on your lake and wait for me. I'll come and beat you. —L.*

He wrote to Wren last.

He sat with the pen in his hand for a long time. The candles burned down around him in the forge gallery.

Wren—

I'm an idiot. You said so in your note and you were right. I left because I was afraid for you, and that was a stupid reason, because you're the bravest person I know and you can look after yourself better than I can.

I've found people. They're good. You'd like them. There's a fire-witch who's even angrier than you are, and two thieves who could steal the boots off your feet, and a very large man who can't hit a plowshare properly.

I miss you. I miss you every day. I think about the festival lanterns, and your hair in the window seat, and I think about how stupid I was not to say it back properly when you said it.

I love you. I'm saying it now. Properly.

Stay safe. Stay with Father, if that's where you are. Something's wrong with him, I think, and he'd never say so.

—Hammer

He folded it. He sealed it. He sat looking at it for a long time.



THEY LEFT THE WICKHOLLOW on the twelfth morning.

Not just Lex and Kestrel. Dorran Vask came, with his great hammer on his shoulder and his book of names in his coat. Ilse and Ivo came, bickering, with their slings and their long knives and a sack of stolen provisions they refused to account for. And Oriel Sant came, which nobody had expected, riding on a mule with her stick across her knees and her white eyes turned south.

"You'll need me," she said, when Dorran tried to argue. "Somebody has to see what's there. And the smith can't look."

The little threadless girl stood at the mouth of the mine with her mother and waved. She was holding a candle-holder. Iron, with a twist in the stem like a vine, and a little drip-dish shaped like a leaf, and a ring to carry it by. Lex had made it the morning after he'd promised. It was the best candle-holder in the Bitter Hills.

He waved back.

They went south. Down out of the Bitter Hills, across the broad brown plains at the southern edge of Caldor, toward a long line of red mountains on the horizon that the maps called the Scald. Beyond them, the Sunreach. Beyond that, the glass.

Lex walked with his thread shaded and his eyes ordinary brown-gold, and didn't reach for the Root once. It was like walking with one hand tied behind his back. Like being half-blind. He didn't know how far away anything was. He didn't know who was near. He couldn't feel the net humming at the edge of his mind.

But behind him, somewhere, he knew Elric was following. And now Elric couldn't see him.

Let's see how he likes walking blind, Lex thought.



ON THE NINTH DAY, they came up out of the foothills of the Scald onto a high red pass, and looked down into the Sunreach.

Lex stopped.

It was gold. All of it. A vast plain of gold and red and ochre, stretching away south under a sky so blue and wide and hot that it hurt to look at. Mesas. Canyons. Rivers that ran in deep green ribbons through red rock. And far, far away to the south, on the very edge of sight, a line of light. Shimmering. Blinding. Like the sun on the sea.

"The glass," said Kestrel softly. *"There it is."*

And between them and it, coming up the long red slope toward the pass in a great cloud of red dust, riders.

Fifty of them. More. On tall lean golden horses, with long spears and bronze shields and white cloaks streaming out behind them. Coming fast. Straight for the pass.

At their head rode a woman. Tall in the saddle. Dark-skinned, with a great crown of black braids bound up in gold wire, and a curved sword at her hip, and a face like a hawk's.

The riders drew up in a long line across the slope below them. Fifty spears lowered. The dust drifted.

And the woman at the head of them looked up at the pass, at the small ragged band of the Unlit standing on it, and at the big young man in the middle with ordinary brown-gold eyes. And raised her voice.

"*Lex Vey,*" she called. In good Caldorean, with an accent like warm honey. "*Smith of Ashbourne. Root-heir of the Lattice. I am Ishara, Queen of the Sunreach.*"

She smiled. It wasn't a friendly smile.

"*You have been hiding from my eyes for nine days. Nobody hides from my eyes.*" She lifted one hand. Fifty spears lifted with it. "*Come down. We need to talk about what you have brought into my country.*"

CHAPTER 9

THE GLASS DESERT



THERE WAS A HAWK on the queen's shoulder.

Lex hadn't seen it from the pass. It was the color of the desert, red-gold and ochre, and it sat so still on the bronze pauldron of her armor that it might have been part of it. But as he came down the long red slope toward the line of riders, with Kestrel at his side and Dorran at his back and the twins muttering and Oriel's mule picking its way behind, the hawk turned its head. And looked at him. With eyes like drops of honey.

And he understood.

"You've been watching us," he said. "With hawks."

Queen Ishara of the Sunreach smiled. It was a hawk's smile. All edges.

"Nine days," she said. "Since you came down out of the Bitter Hills. Every morning, a hawk over your camp. Every evening, another." She tilted her head. "Your thread was dark. My Stone-readers could not find you. They told me the Root-beir of Caldor had vanished from the world." She stroked the hawk's breast with one finger. "But Zahir does not read threads. Zahir reads people. Big ones, with red hair beside them. Walking south."

[The Lampshade hides you from sight,] said Ember, sounding chagrined. *[Not from sight. From Lattice-sight. A bird's just a bird.]*

Ilse didn't mention that.

[I don't think Ilse's ever been hunted by a queen with hawks.]

Behind him, he heard Ivo say, very quietly, *"Hawks. Of course it's hawks. We never thought of hawks."*

"*We never thought of hawks*," agreed Ilse, in a tone of real professional grief.



SHE TOOK THEM TO Saffaran.

It took two days on the tall golden horses, riding south across the red plains with fifty white-cloaked riders around them like a moving wall. Lex had never ridden a horse for more than an afternoon. By the end of the first day, he couldn't feel his legs. By the end of the second, he could feel them far too much.

Dorran, who was too large for any horse in the Sunreach, walked. He walked the whole way. He kept pace with the riders without seeming to try, his great hammer on his shoulder, his shaved head turning slowly as he looked around at the red country. The riders looked at him sideways and muttered to each other. Lex heard the word *ghul* more than once. He didn't ask what it meant.

Saffaran was built on a mesa.

A great flat-topped tower of red rock, rising sheer out of the plain a thousand feet high, with a green river curving around its foot. And the whole top of it was city. Domes and towers and terraces of red stone, white-washed walls, gardens hanging over the edge of the cliff in great green cascades. Bridges of rope and timber swinging between the mesa and smaller pillars of rock around it. Hawks, everywhere, wheeling over the towers in the hot blue sky.

And in the center of the city, on the highest point of the mesa, a Lattice Stone.

Lex felt it from the plain. A great silver weight. Older than the Highcrest Stone. Bigger. And *heavy*. Heavier than any Stone he'd ever felt in Caldor. Its threads ran out from it into the city and the plains, thousands upon thousands of them.

And every one of them was capped.

Not the old Ceiling. Something worse. He'd felt it once, at the Spire, in the High Warden's private records: a Ceiling set not just on a person but on a whole people. Every thread pressed down flat. Every one marked, in the deep silver code of the net, with the same flag.

SUNREACH — TREATY OF SCALD — CAPPED (permanent)

[Wren told us,] said Ember quietly. [At the festival. Thousands of flagged Stones. I didn't—I didn't understand what she meant.]

He didn't reach for it. He wanted to. Every instinct in him wanted to reach into that Stone with the Root and *pull*, the way he'd pulled at Harrowgate and Kessick and two hundred and fifty-eight other places. Unbind. Unfold. Let the light out.

He kept his thread shaded, and kept his hands at his sides, and rode up the long switchback road into the city of hawks.



"Two hundred years," said Queen Ishara.

She'd taken them to her hall. A great round chamber at the top of the highest tower in Saffaran, open on all sides to the wind, with a floor of red and gold tiles and a ring of carved pillars holding up a domed roof painted with stars. Hawks perched on every pillar. They watched the Unlit with honey-colored eyes.

The queen stood at the edge of the hall, where the floor ended in a low wall and then nothing, a thousand feet of red air down to the green river. Zahir sat on her shoulder.

"Two hundred years ago," she said, *"the Sunreach fought a war with Caldor. Over the Scald. Over water. The usual things."* Her voice was very calm. *"We were winning. We had the old fire, the Ashari fire, and your Caldorean knights could not stand against it. And then the Order came. Your Wardens. With their silver net."* She turned. *"They did not fight us. They did not need to. They simply went to our Stones, one by one, in the night, and capped every thread in the Sunreach. Every man. Every woman. Every child."* Her hawk's eyes were very steady. *"And then they wrote a treaty. And made my great-great-grandmother sign it. And the Ceiling has been on us ever since."*

Lex didn't say anything.

"When I heard," said Ishara, *"three years ago, that a smith in Caldor had broken the Ceiling. That he was walking from Stone to Stone, freeing every thread he touched."* Her voice didn't change. *"I sent riders. To the border. To wait for him."* She tilted her head. *"He did not come."*

"I didn't know," said Lex quietly.

"No. *Your friend with the red braid told me so. When she came last spring.*" Ishara's mouth twisted. "*She was very sorry. She was very angry, on our behalf. She said she would tell you, and you would come.*" A pause. "*You did not come.*"

"I didn't—" He stopped. *I didn't have time. There were four thousand Stones in Caldor. I was going to come.* Every word true, and every one an excuse.

"I'm sorry," he said instead.

Ishara looked at him for a long moment.

"*And now you have come,*" she said. "*Not to free us. To find something in the glass.*" Her voice was very cold. "*And behind you, something has come too.*"



SHE SHOWED THEM.

A village at the edge of the plain, a day's ride south of Saffaran, at the very rim of the glass. Lex saw it from the back of a golden horse at dawn. Mud-brick houses. A well. A grove of date palms.

And in the air above the well, a keyhole.

Black. Healed over. Hanging in the bright morning like a hole cut in the sky.

"Six," said Ishara. "*Six of my people. In four villages along the glass. In the last month.*" She didn't look at him. "*Their families do not remember them. Their beds are empty. Their names are gone.*" She looked at the keyhole. "*My Stone-readers found the holes in the records. And my hawks found these. Hanging in the air.*"

Lex took out the Ledger.

He hadn't told Ishara about it. He opened it now, on the saddle in front of him, and turned to the last page.

Bram Sowerby, of the White Shore. Sixty. Shepherd.

And below that, six more names. In a narrow precise elegant hand, very faint, as if written in water.

Amira bint Hassa, of Qarn. Nineteen. She was going to be a healer.

Tarek al-Nur, of Qarn. Twenty-two. He played the oud at every wedding in the village.

He read them out. All six.

Ishara went very still on her horse.

He looked up. Her face had changed. All the hawk had gone out of it. She was staring at the book in his hands.

"Read them again," she said. Her voice was not steady.

He read them again.

When he finished, the Queen of the Sunreach turned her horse away from him and rode a little way off, to the edge of the date grove. And sat there for a long time, with her back to them, and her hawk on her shoulder, and her head bowed.

[She knew them,] said Ember quietly. *[One of them, at least. Lex. She knew them.]*

When she came back, her face was the hawk's face again. But her eyes were red.

"Tarek al-Nur," she said. *"He played at my daughter's naming. Four years ago."* A pause. *"I did not remember him. Until you read his name."*

"The Ledger keeps them," said Lex. "As long as it's kept, they're not gone. Not all the way. They can be brought back."

"How?"

He looked at her.

"With the key," he said. "The thing that took them. It's in three pieces. He has one. One is under my brother's house in Caldor. And one—" He looked south. At the line of blinding light on the horizon. "One is in your glass."

Ishara followed his gaze.

"No one comes back from the glass," she said.

"I have to."

"If you go into the glass," said the Queen of the Sunreach, *"and find this thing, and bring it out, the man who is taking my people will take it from you."* She looked at him. *"That is what your red-haired witch tells me. That he wants you to find it for him."*

"Yes."

"Then why should I let you go?"

Lex was quiet for a while.

"Because he'll find it anyway," he said. "Sooner or later. He's got a voice in his head that knows where everything is. And every month it takes him, he takes more of your people." He closed the Ledger. "And because I can't promise I'll keep it from him. But I can promise I'll try. And I'll promise you something else."

"What?"

"When this is over," said Lex, "if I'm still alive, I'll come back. To Saffaran. To your Stone. And I'll take the Ceiling off every thread in the Sunreach." He met her eyes. "Every one. I'll start with yours."

Queen Ishara looked at him for a very long time.

"Your friend with the red braid," she said at last, "said you would say something like that." Her mouth twisted. "She said you are very stupid, and very stubborn, and that you always keep your promises, even the ones you should not have made."

"That sounds like her."

"She also said," said Ishara, "that you are the best man she has ever known. And that if I hurt you, she would come back and put an arrow through my hawk."

Lex laughed. He couldn't help it.

Something moved at the corner of the queen's mouth. Not quite a smile.

"I liked her," said Ishara. "Very much." She turned her horse toward the glass. "Come, then, smith. I will take you to the edge. No further. My people do not go into the glass."



THE GLASS BEGAN WITHOUT warning.

One moment they were riding across the red stony plain, through scrub and thorn and dry yellow grass. The next, the ground under the horses' hooves changed. From stone to something smooth and hard and ringing. The horses shied. The riders reined them in.

And ahead of them, stretching away south to the horizon, under a sky so bright it was nearly white, the Glass Desert.

It was beautiful. That was the first thing. Lex hadn't expected it to be beautiful. A vast flat plain of glass, a hundred miles of it, smooth and clear and golden-green, like the glass of an old bottle held up to the sun. In places it was flat as a millpond. In others it rose in frozen waves and ripples, great curling crests of glass taller than a house, caught in the moment of breaking. Here and there, columns of it rose up out of the plain like trees, branching, twisting, their glass limbs catching the light.

And everywhere, the light.

It bounced. It danced. It came up off the glass in great sheets and flares and blinding white streaks. Every surface caught it and threw it back, so that the whole desert seemed to be on fire with reflected sun. Lex had to squint to look at it at all. Even then, it made his eyes water.

"The Sunfall," said Ishara. *"That is what we call it. In the old songs, a sun fell out of the sky. Here. Before the Founders. Before the Lattice. Before anything."* She was looking out at the glass with an expression Lex couldn't read. *"It burned for a year. When it was done, the desert was glass."*

[Not a sun,] said Ember, very quietly. *[A Flame-Well. A Well of Flame, erupting. Lex, the power it would take to do this—]*

Malachi said the Wells were wells. Places where the elements come up from below.

[Malachi said the Wells were fed. By the river under the world. And if something went wrong with one. If something poisoned it, or broke it open—]
A pause. *[I think this is what's left of a Well that broke.]*

"There are reflections in the glass," said Ishara. *"That is why no one comes back. You walk in, and the glass shows you things. People. Places. Things you have lost."* Her voice was very flat. *"And you follow them. Deeper and deeper. And the sun cooks you. And the glass cuts your feet. And when my riders find you, months later, you are lying on the glass with your eyes open and a smile on your face."*

Kestrel shifted beside him.

Lex looked at Oriel Sant.

She was sitting on her mule at the very edge of the glass, with her white eyes turned south. Her face was calm. She was the only one of them, he realized, who wasn't squinting.

"Well," she said. *"It's a good thing I can't see any of it, then."*



THEY WENT IN AT noon, on foot. The horses wouldn't go.

Ishara gave them boots. Thick-soled desert boots, with layers of hardened leather and a sole of something black and rubbery that the Sunreach people harvested from a tree in the southern canyons. They gave them white robes and head-cloths, and water-skins, and little round mirrors of polished bronze to signal with if they got lost.

"If you signal," said Ishara, "no one will come. But at least we will know where you died."

"Comforting," said Ivo.

"I am not here to comfort you, little thief." The queen looked at Lex. "Seven days. If you are not out in seven days, I will tell the red-braided one that you were stupid and stubborn to the end."

"Tell her I'm sorry," said Lex. "If it comes to that."

Ishara looked at him. Then, unexpectedly, she reached out and gripped his forearm. Hard. A warrior's grip.

"Find it," she said. "Bring my people's names home."

And then she turned her horse and rode back toward the red plain, with Zahir lifting off her shoulder and wheeling up into the white sky over the glass.

Lex watched the hawk go up. Higher and higher. Until it was just a speck.

She's still watching, he thought.

[Good,] said Ember. [Somebody should be.]



ORIEL LED.

She sat on her mule. The mule had been given boots too, four of them, and walked with an expression of profound and personal offense. Oriel held the reins loosely in one hand and her black thorn stick in the other, and tapped the stick on the glass every few paces. Listening. Her white eyes turned south. She didn't hesitate. She didn't look around.

Everyone else did.

It started within the first hour.

Lex saw it out of the corner of his eye. A flicker in the glass. A shape, moving under the surface, the way a fish moves under ice. He turned his head.

There was a woman in the glass.

Not on it. *In* it. Under the smooth golden-green surface, as if the glass were water and she were swimming just beneath. Dark-haired. Laughing. In a blue dress, with flour on her hands.

His mother.

He stopped walking.

He knew it wasn't her. He *knew*. Ishara had told them. Oriel had told them. The glass showed you what you'd lost. But he'd been ten when the fire took her, and he'd forgotten so much: the exact color of her eyes, the shape of her hands, the way her hair fell when she bent over the hearth. And there it all was. In the glass. Under his feet. Looking up at him.

She smiled. She lifted one floury hand, and beckoned.

This way, love.

"Smith."

Oriel's voice. Thin and dry and very precise.

"Whatever you're looking at," said the old woman, without turning around, *"stop."*

Lex dragged his eyes away from the glass.

His mother was still there. He could feel her, at the edge of his vision. Beckoning. But he made himself look at the back of Oriel's mule. At the old woman's red shawl. At the black thorn stick tapping on the glass.

And walked.



EVERYONE SAW SOMETHING.

Lex could tell from their faces. Kestrel walked with her jaw clenched and her fire burning in her hair, staring straight ahead, and every so often her eyes would slide sideways and go wide and wet before she wrenched them back. He didn't have to ask what she saw. Tamsin walked beside her, faint as ever, but Lex had seen her look down once and stop dead, and he'd known. In the glass, her brother would be solid. Whole. Laughing. Tam the Ram.

The twins held hands. Lex didn't think they knew they were doing it. They walked shoulder to shoulder, eyes front, fingers laced, and every so often Ivo's grip would tighten until his knuckles went white.

Dorran walked at the back. He was the only one who looked down at the glass on purpose. Steadily. His great slab of a face unchanging. Lex didn't know what he saw. Children, maybe. Four thousand one hundred and nine of them. Looking up at him through the glass, trusting.

Nobody talked.

And Oriel Sant rode at the front on her offended mule, tapping her stick on the glass, her white eyes turned south. Calm. Untroubled. The only one of them who couldn't see a thing.



THEY CAMPED THE FIRST night in the lee of a glass wave twenty feet high, frozen in the act of breaking. It held the day's heat like an oven. The sun went down and the glass went from gold to red to violet, and the reflections went with it, until the whole desert seemed to be full of ghosts in a sunset.

Then it went dark, and the reflections went out, and there were stars.

So many stars. The glass caught them too. Every star in the sky reflected in the glass below, so that sitting in the middle of the desert was like sitting in the middle of the sky. Stars above. Stars below. Nothing else.

"It's lovely," said Ilse quietly. *"I hate it."*

"Me too," said Ivo.

Kestrel had lit a fire. A little one, from nothing, on the glass. It burned without fuel, the way her fires did when she wanted them to. Gold and red. They sat around it. Nobody wanted to look away from it into the dark.

"What did you see?" said Kestrel. To Lex. Not looking at him.

"My mother."

She nodded.

"Tam," she said. *"Solid. Laughing. He was holding out his hand."* Her voice was hard. *"I wanted to take it so much I could feel my fingers aching."*

Beside her, Tamsin put his faint hand over hers on the glass. She couldn't feel it. But she went quiet. And after a moment, her fire burned a little brighter.

"*Children*," said Dorran.

Everyone looked at him. He was sitting at the edge of the firelight, his great hands on his knees. He didn't look up.

"*My list*," he said. "*All of them. Looking up through the glass.*" He paused. "*Not angry. Just looking.*" He was quiet. "*That's worse.*"

Nobody said anything.

"*Oriel*," said Ivo after a while. "*What do you see?*"

The old woman was sitting on a folded blanket with her black stick across her knees and her white eyes turned toward the fire. She smiled faintly.

"*Nothing, boy*," she said. "*I've never seen anything in my life. That's my gift.*" She tilted her head. "*But I can hear it. The glass. Under all the light.*"

"*What does it sound like?*"

Oriel was quiet for a long moment.

"*Like something weeping*," she said. "*Very far down. Very old. For a very long time.*"



LEX COULDN'T SLEEP.

He lay on the warm glass in the dark with the stars above and the stars below, and the Ledger against his chest, and thought about not using the gold.

It was harder than he'd expected. Harder than the Lampshade. Every hour of the day, he wanted to reach for it. To look at the glass with True Sight and *see* it. To read it. To feel for the Bit with the Root and find it the way he'd found eleven holes in the net from his forge at Ashbourne. It would be so easy. One breath. One reach.

And something far down in the gold would open its eye.

[*I've been looking*,] said Ember, very quietly, in the dark. [*Every night. Since the Wickhollow. Since Oriel said it.*]

And?

[*Nothing. I can't find anything. I go down as far as I can go, into the Root, into the deep gold where your father's thread runs and your mother's used to and Aurelian's ran first of all.*] A pause. [*And there's nothing there. Nobody. Just the gold. Going down and down.*]

Oriel said you weren't made to see that far.

[I know.] Ember was quiet. [I keep thinking about that. That I was made. That someone made me. Your father, out of a piece of himself. And he made me to see some things and not others.] Another pause. [Lex, what if he made me not to see it on purpose?]

Lex lay very still.

Father wouldn't—

[Wouldn't he? He hid you from the Order. He hid Antho from the Order. He hid your mother's fate for eleven years. He hid the Key for three.] Ember's voice was very small. [What if he's been hiding this too? From both of us?]

Lex didn't answer.

He lay on the glass and looked up at the stars, and down at the stars, and thought about the letter he'd sent from the Wickhollow. *Something is watching through the Root, Father. Through my eyes. Did you know? Tell me if you knew.*

He didn't know if he wanted the answer.



IT TOOK FOUR DAYS to reach the center.

Four days of white light and terrible reflections and glass that rang under their boots like a struck bell. Ilse cut her hand on a glass branch on the second day, a long clean slice across the palm, and the blood ran down onto the glass and the glass drank it, and for an hour afterward she kept looking at her hand as if it belonged to someone else. Ivo stopped talking on the third day, which frightened Ilse more than anything. Dorran carried the water. All of it. On his back, in great sloshing skins, without complaint.

And Oriel led. Tapping her stick. Listening. Never once turning aside.

On the fourth day, in the afternoon, the glass began to slope downward.

Gently at first. Then more steeply. They were walking down the inside of a great bowl, a crater in the glass, miles across. The glass here was darker. Not gold-green but deep amber, and then brown, and then, near the bottom, black. Black glass, smooth and dark and gleaming, like obsidian.

And at the very bottom of the bowl, at the center of the crater, a tower.

It wasn't built. It had grown. A great spire of black glass, rising out of the crater floor, twisted and branching like a lightning strike frozen in place. Three hundred feet high. At its foot, a doorway. Narrow and dark.

And carved into the black glass above the doorway, an open hand.

And above the palm, a keyhole.

[Ysmir's sigil,] said Ember. [Lex. That's it. That's where she put it.]

Lex stood at the bottom of the crater and looked up at the black spire.

He didn't feel anything from it. Not with his thread shaded. Not without the gold. He couldn't feel its Wellspring, or its wards, or whatever was waiting inside. He could only see it with ordinary eyes. A tower of black glass in the middle of a desert, with a door.

It was the strangest feeling. Like being deaf in a room where everyone else was singing.

"There's a fire in there," said Kestrel.

He looked at her. She was standing very still beside him with her hands at her sides and her head tilted, the way Oriel tilted hers when she listened.

"Under it," said Kestrel. "Under the whole crater. I can feel it in my feet." Her amber eyes were wide. "It's not burning. It's—it's like a coal that's gone grey on top. Still hot underneath. Very hot. Very old." She swallowed. "My grandmother's fire. The Ashari fire. It comes from there."

[The Well,] said Ember. [The Flame-Well. It's not dead. It's banked.]

And in the depths of himself, in the place below the Lattice where the river ran, Lex felt Flame turn its head.

He hadn't been reaching for it. He hadn't done anything. Flame wasn't the gold; it was below the gold, older than the Root, the deep wild river that Malachi had taught him to hear. And it had heard *him*. The way it always did, when he came near a fire. It turned toward him, from somewhere very far down under the black glass, and *leaned*.

Hello, he thought at it.

Something answered. Very faint. Very old.

Very, very sad.



THE DOORWAY OPENED TO blood.

Of course it did. Lex cut his palm, the same way he'd cut it at Ysmir and Avaloria and the Frostvault, and laid it on the open hand carved in the glass, and the glass drank, and the doorway, which had been black and solid, went clear.

"Just you," said Oriel Sant, behind him. *"I can hear it. It'll only let the blood through."*

"Like the vault," said Kestrel.

"Like every Vey door in the world," said Ivo. It was the first thing he'd said in two days. His voice was hoarse. *"Family's got a lot of doors."*

Lex looked back at them. The Unlit. Burned and cut and half-blind from four days of glass. Kestrel, with her fire low and her brother at her shoulder. Dorran, with the water-skins on his back. The twins, holding hands. Oriel on her mule.

"If I'm not out by morning," he said.

"We'll come in after you," said Dorran.

"You can't. It won't let you."

"Then we'll break it," said Dorran simply. He hefted his hammer. *"I'm very good at hitting things too hard."*

Lex almost laughed.

He went in.



THERE WERE STAIRS. GOING down. Black glass, spiraling, lit from below by a faint red glow.

He went down a long way. Further than the tower was tall. Down into the crater floor, into the rock beneath the glass. The air got hotter. The red glow got brighter. The walls of the stair changed from black glass to red-black stone, veined with seams of something that glowed like the inside of a forge.

And then the stair ended, and he was standing at the edge of the Well.

It was a pit. Round. A hundred feet across. Its walls went straight down into a red darkness he couldn't see the bottom of. And from the darkness, very faint, came heat. And light. A dull, sullen, banked red glow, like a forge-fire that's been left overnight under a heap of ash.

In the middle of the pit, rising out of the darkness on a column of black glass as thin as a candle, was a cradle. A little cup of glass, the size of two hands held together.

And in the cradle, something black.

He couldn't see it properly. He looked at it, and his eyes slid off. A hole in the world, small and jagged, like a row of teeth.

The Bit.

There was no bridge. No path. Just the edge of the pit, and a hundred feet of red-glowing nothing, and the thin black column rising out of it with the black thing at its top.

[Of course,] said Ember. [Of course there's no bridge. There's never a bridge.]

Lex stood at the edge and looked down into the Well.

And the Well looked back.



HE FELT IT. THROUGH his feet. Through the stone. Through the deep place in him below the Lattice where the river ran. Flame. Not the wild bright Flame of Malachi's hearth, or the eternal fire under Qel'Varran's waters, or Kestrel's furious red. Something older. Banked. Grey on top. Hot underneath.

And grieving.

He didn't know how he knew. But he did. The way you know, walking into a house, that someone in it has died. The Flame-Well under the Glass Desert was grieving. It had been grieving for a very long time.

[What happened to it?] breathed Ember.

Lex didn't answer. He knelt at the edge of the pit. He put his scarred hands flat on the hot red-black stone. And he didn't reach for the gold.

He *listened*.

The way Malachi had taught him. The way he listened to iron in the coals, waiting for the color. The way he'd listened to the bedrock under Ysmir's temple. Not *do this*. Not *give me that*. Just: *I'm here. I'm listening. Tell me.*

And the Well told him.

Not in words. In heat. In a long slow pulse of red warmth that came up through the stone into his palms and his arms and his chest, carrying with it a picture, the way Thraxis had thrown a picture at him across the black hall at Duskhold.

A sky. Blue. A plain of red earth and green grass and rivers. People, living on it. Herders. Farmers. Singing.

And something coming up out of the ground. Out of the deep dark under the world. Something hungry. Something with no shape, that ate light.

And the Well, rising to meet it. All of its fire. Everything. Pouring up out of the earth in a great burning column, a sun, a sun rising from below, to burn the hungry thing back down into the dark.

And it worked. It worked.

And when it was over, the plain was glass. And the people were gone. Every herder. Every farmer. Every singer. Burned in the light of the sun that had saved them.

Lex knelt at the edge of the pit with tears running down his face and didn't know when he'd started crying.

It saved them, he thought. It saved the whole world. And it killed everyone it was saving. And it's been grieving ever since.

[Nine hundred years,] whispered Ember. [No. Longer. Before the Lattice. Before the Founders. It's been down there alone in the dark all this time, banked under the glass, and nobody's ever come down to listen.]



HE SPOKE TO IT.

Not with Command. Not with the Root. With Flame. Speaking, the third stage of the Wells, the one Malachi had said was the hardest to reach and the easiest to misuse. *To Speak is not to give orders, smith. It is to answer back. To have a conversation. And most people, when they finally get to talk to something greater than themselves, only want to talk about what they want.*

He didn't talk about what he wanted.

I'm sorry, he told the Well. I'm so sorry. Nobody should have to carry that alone.

The heat under his palms flickered.

You did the right thing. You saved the world. You couldn't have known. You couldn't have done it any other way. He pressed his palms flatter. *I'm a smith. I know what fire does. Fire doesn't choose who it burns. It just burns. The only thing you can choose is what you burn it for.*

The flicker grew. The banked red glow at the bottom of the pit pulsed. Brighter. Then dimmer. Then brighter again. Like something breathing.

You burned it for them, Lex told it. For all of them. That's the best thing fire can do.

And the Well woke.

Not all the way. Not erupting. He felt it, rising up out of the deep, not in a column but in a long, slow, swelling *breath*. Heat poured up out of the pit. Red, then orange, then gold. The red-black walls of the Well lit up, one seam after another, like the coals in a forge when you pump the bellows. The air shimmered. The black glass column in the center of the pit glowed from within.

And across the pit, from the edge where he knelt to the black column with the cradle at its top, the fire *rose*.

A bridge. Of fire. Gold and red and narrow, no wider than his two hands. Arching out across the pit from his knees to the column. Steady. Burning. Holding its shape.

Offering.

ATTUNEMENT – FLAME

Speaking → Speaking (deepening)

"Fire remembers every hand that ever warmed itself at it. Not one of them thanked it."

THE SUNWELL – GRIEF-BANKED (awakened)

Relationship: ACQUAINTED

[Lex,] said Ember. [You're going to walk on that, aren't you.]

It's offering.

[It's fire.]

So am I.

He stood up. He stepped out onto the bridge.

It didn't burn. It held him, the way Kestrel's fire had curled around his fingers in Ysmir's vault: warm, and strong, and *leaning* into him. He walked across a hundred feet of red-glowing nothing on a bridge no wider than his hands, with the heat roaring up around him and the Well breathing below, and he didn't look down once.

He reached the column. The cradle of glass. The black jagged thing inside it.

He looked at it with ordinary eyes. It was the size of his palm. A row of teeth. Black. A hole cut in the shape of a key's bit.

Don't use the gold, he told himself. *Don't. Not now. Not here.*

He reached out.

And touched it.



THE EYE OPENED.

He didn't use the gold. He didn't reach for the Root. He kept his thread shaded, the Lampshade wrapped tight around him like a cloak, the way Ilse had taught him.

It didn't matter.

The Bit was Aurelian's. Forged from his shadow. Folded on his anvil. And when Lex's fingers closed on it, it didn't care about Lampshades or shading. It *knew* him. It knew his blood. And something reached up out of it, up through his hand, up through his arm, into the deep gold of the Root where Ember had never been made to look.

And opened.

He felt it. A warmth. Not Flame. Not Ember. Something else. Something gold and huge and very, very old, waking up in the bottom of him like a man stirring in a deep chair by a fire. Stretching. Opening its eyes.

Looking out through his.

And a voice spoke. Not in the air. Not in his ears. In the gold. In the deepest part of him. Warm, and kind, and tired, and so gentle it made his heart ache.

Ab, it said. *There you are.*

[LEX—]

Thank you, child, said the voice. *I knew you would find it. You always find things. It is what you were made for.*

And far above him, at the top of the stair, at the mouth of the black tower, out on the floor of the crater where the Unlit were waiting, Lex felt something cut through the world.

A keyhole. Opening.

And through it, stepping out onto the black glass in the red light of the waking Well, a man in a fine grey coat, with something black hanging at his throat. And behind him, others. A tall pale woman in the white of a High Warden. Shapes made of shadow. A great many of them.

He's here, said the voice in the gold. Warmly. Approvingly. *Good. Bring it up to him, child. There's a good boy.*

And Lex stood on a column of black glass in the middle of a burning Well, with the second piece of the Key of Shadows in his hand and something ancient looking out through his eyes, and for the first time since he'd walked into the Ashbourne forge at twelve years old, he didn't know which way to go.

CHAPTER 10

SHADOWS AWAKENED



Bring it up, child.

The voice was so kind.

That was the worst of it. Lex had faced the Pale Warden, who'd spoken softly and reasonably about mercy while black mist poured out of his veins. He'd faced Elric in the black corridors of Duskhold, furious and bitter. He'd faced the Murmur in his brother's head, and the Barrow-King, and the Drowned Dead.

He'd never faced anything that sounded like it *loved* him.

Bring it up. He's waiting. He has been waiting so long, poor man. And your friends are up there, and they're frightened, and there are so many shadows. A pause, warm and gentle as a hand on his hair. You don't want anyone to get hurt. I know you don't. You never have.

Lex stood on the black glass column in the middle of the Sunwell with the Bit in his fist. The fire-bridge burned gold at his feet. Below him, a hundred feet of red-glowing pit breathed slow heat.

[Lex.]

Ember. Very faint. Very far away. As if it were calling to him from the bottom of a well.

[Lex, don't listen. Don't listen to it. I'm—I'm going down. I'm going to find it. Hold on.]

Ember, no—

[It's in our house, Lex. It's in the Root. It's in the place I live.] Ember's voice was shaking. *[I'm not letting it sit in there and look out of your eyes like it owns you.]*

And it was gone.

He felt it go. Down. Down into the deep gold, into the dark at the bottom of himself, toward the warm vast stirring thing that had just woken up there.

Oh, said the voice in the gold. Gently. Almost amused. *Oh, the little construct. Arion's clever little copy.* A pause. *He always did make things too brave for their own good.*

And then, from far down in the gold, Lex felt something that made his blood turn to ice.

Nothing.

Ember's warmth. Its humming, steady, hearth-like presence that had been with him every hour of every day for four years. Gone. Not dead. He'd have known if it were dead. Just *gone*. Swallowed. Like a coal dropped into deep water.

ROOT – INTERNAL

EMBER (construct): UNRESPONSIVE

Location: [REDACTED]

Status: [REDACTED]

"No," said Lex aloud. His voice echoed off the walls of the Well. "No. Ember. EMBER."

Hush, said the voice in the gold. *It's quite all right. I haven't hurt it. I would never hurt it.* A pause. *I've only put it somewhere quiet, so that we can talk.*



HE RAN.

Across the fire-bridge. Back over a hundred feet of red-glowing nothing, the gold bridge flexing and leaning under his boots like a living thing. He reached the edge. The stair. Up. Two steps at a time. Round and round, up through the red-black stone, into the black glass, the Bit clenched in his fist so hard the jagged teeth of it bit into his palm.

That's it, said the voice. *That's my good boy. Up you come.*

He didn't answer it. He didn't know how. He'd never had to fight anything that lived *inside* him. Antho had. For eight years. Every hour of every day. And Lex had never, not once, really understood what that meant until now.

He came up out of the stair into the black tower. Into the doorway. Into the light.

And stopped.



THE CRATER FLOOR WAS full of shadows.

Umbral Wardens. Dozens of them. Thirty. Forty. Tall and featureless and dark, standing in a great ring around the foot of the black tower, their long fingers hanging at their sides. Not moving. Not yet. Waiting.

Inside the ring, the Unlit.

Dorran stood in front, with his great hammer raised in both hands and his feet planted on the black glass. Kestrel was beside him, both hands burning, her hair a crown of fire. The twins stood back to back behind them, knives out, slings loaded. Oriel Sant sat on her mule in the very center of the ring, with her black thorn stick across her knees and her white eyes turned toward the tower door.

And standing at the edge of the ring, just inside it, between the shadows, two people.

Elric Thorne, in his fine grey coat. The Bow hanging black at his throat. His face healed from Kestrel's burns, but pink and new on one side, like a scald. He was smiling.

And beside him, a woman Lex had seen only once, three years ago, across the floor of the High Council chamber on the morning Queen Lysandra stripped her of her office. She had walked out of the Spire before the guards could reach her, and nobody had seen her since.

High Warden Isaura Kell.

She'd changed. That morning she'd been a tall, cold, silver-haired woman in white and silver, the most powerful person in the Order, with a face like a winter morning. She was still tall. Still cold. But her silver hair had been cut short, ragged, as if with a knife. Her white robes were stained

and travel-worn. And her face had gone gaunt and hard, all the polish worn off it, so that what was left was bone and will.

Her eyes were still the same. Pale grey. Calculating. Missing nothing.

They found Lex in the doorway of the tower. And held.

"*Lex Vey,*" said Isaura Kell. "*You've grown.*"

"Everyone keeps saying that."

"*Everyone is correct.*" Her voice was flat. "*You were a boy the last time I saw you. A frightened boy in a borrowed coat, standing at the back of the Council chamber, watching me lose everything.*" A pause. "*Now you're the man who broke my Order.*"

"Your Order broke itself."

"*Did it?*" Kell's thin mouth moved. Not a smile. "*Three years, and your precious Unbound are being cut out of the world one by one, like fruit off a tree. Because you took the lids off.*" She inclined her head toward Elric. "*He's right, you know. He's been right all along. The Ceiling was a lid. It kept things in. And it kept things out.*" Her pale eyes didn't waver. "*I would never have chosen him as an ally. I despise everything he's done. But he understands what you never did. That freedom is a door. And doors open both ways.*"



"*Bring it here, Lex,*" said Elric.

He held out his gloved hand. The same gesture as in Ysmir's vault. Patient. Reasonable. A teacher's hand.

"*Bring me the bit, and we'll go. All of us. No one gets hurt.*"

"*He's lying,*" said Kestrel. Her voice was ragged. "*Smith, he's lying, he always lies—*"

"*Kestrel,*" said Elric, without looking at her. "*Do be quiet. You're not in this.*" He kept his eyes on Lex. "*You know I'm not lying. You know what I want. I've always told you exactly what I want.*" A thin smile. "*It's the Veyes who lie. Your father lied to me for forty years. Your brother lies to himself. You—*" He tilted his head. "*You haven't learned yet. You're still very honest. It's one of the things I've always liked about you.*"

He's right, said the voice in the gold. Gently. *You know he is. Give it to him, child. Then he'll go. And your friends will be safe.*

Lex stood in the doorway of the black tower, with the Bit in his fist and a voice in his head and a ring of shadows around the people he'd brought here.

Think, he told himself. Think. Like a smith. What's the metal? What's it want to do?

Elric couldn't come in. That was the first thing. The tower was a Vey door. Elric had stood in front of Ysmir's vault for two years and never got through. He couldn't come into the tower. He couldn't get down to the Well.

But he didn't need to. He had the Unlit.

And Lex had—

The Well.

He felt it. Behind him. Below him. Down the long spiral stair, at the bottom of the pit. Awake now. Breathing. Gold and red and grieving. *Acquainted.* It had heard him, and he had heard it, and it had built him a bridge.

And it had seen something like these shadows before.

Something coming up out of the ground. Something hungry. Something with no shape, that ate light.

Lex looked at the Umbral Wardens. Tall and dark and faceless. Folded out of a dead man's shadow, nine hundred years ago, on an anvil of gold.

Made of Aurelian's shadow, he thought. And Aurelian fell into the Hollow. Into the thing he sealed there. And something wearing him is talking to me right now.

The Well's seen that before. It knows what it tastes like.

"All right," he said aloud. "I'll bring it."

Kestrel made a sound like a slap.

Elric smiled.

And Lex took one step out of the doorway of the tower, onto the black glass of the crater floor, and went down on one knee, and laid his bleeding palm flat on the glass.

Remember, he told the Well.



IT REMEMBERED.

He felt it come. Up from the bottom of the pit. Up through the red-black stone, through the black glass, through the floor of the crater. Not fast. Not erupting. *Rising*. The way a man stands up out of a chair when he hears a sound he's heard once before, a long time ago, in the worst night of his life.

The glass under Lex's palm went warm. Then hot. Then it began to *glow*. Red, spreading out from his hand across the black crater floor like ink through water. Under the Unlit's feet. Under the ring of shadows. Under Elric and Kell.

"*What are you—*" said Elric sharply.

The Umbral Wardens moved.

All at once. Forty of them. Turning their faceless heads toward the red glow spreading under their feet. And Lex saw them *flinch*. Saw it run through all forty of them at once, a single shudder, like grass in a gust of wind.

They knew it too.

Child, said the voice in the gold. Not warm now. Sharp. *Child, stop that*.

"*No*," said Lex.

And the Sunwell came up.



IT CAME UP THROUGH the glass in a column.

Not under the Unlit. Lex had asked it. *Not them. Not my people. Never again*. It came up under the *shadows*. Forty columns of fire, gold-white and roaring, bursting up out of the black glass of the crater floor exactly where the Umbral Wardens stood, like forty suns rising at once from below.

And the shadows *burned*.

Not the way Lex's Ember Strike had burned them on the moor, passing through, leaving them rippling and whole. Not the way Kestrel's fire had gone through them in Ysmir's temple. They *burned*. Like paper. Like dry leaves. Like something that had been waiting nine hundred years to be burned and had finally found the right fire.

The Sunwell had burned something like them once before. It had burned the hungry thing back down into the dark under the world, and

turned a hundred miles of grassland into glass doing it. It remembered the taste.

Forty Umbral Wardens went up in forty pillars of gold-white flame and were *gone*. Not unfolded. Not unmade. Burned. Ash. Less than ash. A faint dark smoke, rising into the white sky over the crater, and then nothing.

The light was enormous. Lex couldn't see. He knelt on the glowing glass with his hand flat on the floor and his eyes screwed shut and the light coming through his eyelids red and gold, and he heard the Well roaring, a sound like the whole world breathing out, and under it, the voice in the gold.

Screaming.

Not in pain. In *fury*. A long, high, terrible scream, coming up from the very bottom of him, from the deep gold where Ember had gone. A sound like a beautiful thing tearing.

How DARE you—

And then nothing. The voice cut off. Like a door slamming.

THE SUNWELL – RISEN (partial)

UMBRAL WARDEN x40 – CONSUMED

"It has burned the hungry thing before.

It remembers how."

ATTUNEMENT – FLAME

Speaking → COMMANDING (threshold)

Status: UNSTABLE (borrowed fire)

Commanding. The fourth stage. *Not yet*, thought Lex, dimly. *That's not mine yet. That's the Well's*. And he could feel it: the borrowed fire pouring through him, far too much, far too hot, burning along every channel of him like molten iron poured into a mould that wasn't ready for it.

Enough, he told the Well. *Enough. Thank you. Please. Enough.*

And slowly, grudgingly, the fire went down.



WHEN HE COULD SEE again, the crater was steaming.

The black glass floor was cracked in forty places, forty round black holes where the columns had come up, still glowing red at their edges. Smoke drifted. The air shimmered.

The Unlit were standing in the middle of it. Alive. All of them. Kestrel had her arms wrapped around her head, and her fire had gone out entirely, and she was staring at the forty smoking holes with her mouth open. Dorran had lowered his hammer. The twins were clutching each other. Oriel sat on her mule, entirely calm, her white eyes turned toward Lex.

"Well," she said. "That was loud."

Lex tried to stand up. His legs didn't work. He'd burned something out of himself. He could feel it. The channels the borrowed fire had poured through were raw and blistered and aching, the way his hands had ached after the first time he'd forged a blade at twelve, before they'd learned to hold the hammer properly.

He got one foot under him. Then the other.

And then he looked for Elric.



ELRIC WAS STANDING AT the edge of the crater, where the slope began.

He hadn't burned. Of course he hadn't. He wasn't a shadow. Neither was Kell. The Sunwell had burned only the hungry thing, the way Lex had asked, and the two people standing among the shadows had been left whole.

Elric's fine grey coat was singed again. His face was white. He was staring at the forty smoking holes in the crater floor. And then at Lex.

And Lex saw something on his face he'd never seen there before.

Fear.

Not of Lex. Of whatever had screamed. Elric had heard it. Lex was suddenly sure of it. The voice in the gold, the kind voice that had told him where to find the Bow, that had promised him everything, had screamed in fury through the Key at his throat, and Elric had heard it, and for one moment he'd heard what it really sounded like.

Then it was gone. Smoothed over. His face was calm again.

"*Very clever,*" he said quietly. "*Very clever, Lex. You always were.*" He brushed ash off his sleeve. "*But you've forgotten something.*"

And he turned his head, and looked at Ilse Marrow.



HE DIDN'T NEED THE shadows.

Lex understood that a moment too late. Elric had never needed the shadows. They were only to hold the Unlit still. To keep them in one place. The Key had always been enough.

But the twins were shaded. Their threads were hidden, the way Lex's was. The Lampshade. Elric couldn't see them. Couldn't hook them.

"*Isaura,*" said Elric.

High Warden Kell lifted one hand.

Lex felt it. Even without the gold. Even shaded. A great cold silver *pressure*, coming down out of the air over the crater like a lid. Inspection. The Order's oldest power. The thing every Warden of the Kindling had done to every child in Caldor for nine hundred years. *Show yourself. Show your thread. Show what you are.* And she was Tier IV, the highest Sanction the Order had ever granted, and the Lattice still remembered whose voice it had obeyed for twenty years.

The Lampshades tore.

Lex felt his own rip. Like a cloak torn off in a high wind. His thread blazing out, gold and silver, naked in the net. And beside him, the twins: two bright loose Unbound threads, suddenly *visible*, shining like two stars.

"*No—*" said Ivo.

Elric turned the Bow.



HE HOOKED ILSE.

Lex saw it. Saw the girl's head snap back. Saw her face go slack and white. Saw her knife fall from her fingers onto the glass with a small bright sound. And saw her start to fade. Not her body. *Her.* Going pale at the edges. The color draining out of her patched green coat.

"*ILSE—*"

Ivo caught her as she fell. He was screaming her name. *Ilse, Ilse, Ilse*, over and over, holding her against him, and Lex could see his hands going *through* her, a little. Just at the edges.

"*Bring it here*," said Elric quietly. "*Lex. Bring me the bit*."

His gloved hand was on the Bow at his throat. Turning it. Slowly. Like a man turning a key in a lock he isn't quite sure of.

And Ilse Marrow was coming apart in her brother's arms.



DORRAN MOVED FIRST.

He didn't go for Elric. He went for Kell. Across the cracked glowing glass in four enormous strides, his great hammer coming round in a two-handed swing that would have stove in a castle gate.

Kell didn't move. She raised her hand, and said one word, and Dorran Vask *stopped*. Mid-stride. Frozen. His hammer hanging in the air at the top of its swing. His great slab of a face straining.

"*Vask*," said Isaura Kell. She was looking up at him with something almost like surprise. "*Dorran Vask. My best Warden of the Kindling. Twenty-two years without a single complaint*." Her pale eyes moved over his face. "*I wondered where you'd gone*."

"*Let*," said Dorran, through his teeth, "*her. Go*."

"*I'm not holding her. He is*." Kell's voice was very calm. "*I'm only holding you*." She tilted her head. "*Your brand still answers, Vask. The Sanction's in the thread, not the skin. You know that. I taught you that*."

Dorran's whole body shook. The hammer trembled at the top of its arc. His face had gone dark red. A vein stood out on his shaved scalp like a rope.

And Lex saw his forearm. The old Kindling-brand. Glowing. Silver. Answering her.



KESTREL WAS LOOKING AT Elric.

Not burning. Not moving. Just standing there, on the cracked glass, her fire gone out, staring at the man in the grey coat with an expression Lex couldn't read.

Elric glanced at her. And smiled. Very faintly.

"You see," he said softly, to her. Only to her. *"This is what the Key does. It holds. It lets go. It can cut a thread."* His eyes moved to Ilse, fading in her brother's arms. *"And it can write one back."*

Kestrel didn't say anything.

"When I have all three," said Elric, *"I can write anyone back. Anyone at all. Every name in that book. Every one."* He looked at her. *"Your brother, for instance."*

Behind Kestrel, faint and pale, Tamsin Varn went very still.



Bring it to him, said the voice in the gold.

It was back. Quiet. Calm again. As if it had never screamed. Gentle as a hand on his hair.

Bring it to him, child. And the thief girl lives. Do you want her to die? Is a piece of metal worth a girl's life?

Lex stood on the cracked floor of the crater with the Bit in his fist.

Think. Think. What does the metal want?

But there was no metal. There was no trick. There was a girl fading in her brother's arms, and a man with a key, and a choice.

He'd made it before he knew he was making it.

"Let her go," he said. "Let her go, and it's yours."

"Throw it."

"Let her go first."

Elric looked at him for a long moment. Then he turned the Bow. Slowly. The other way.

Ilse gasped. A great tearing breath, like a drowning girl coming up for air. Her eyes flew open. Color flooded back into her face. Not all of it. But some. She clutched at her brother's coat, and Ivo made a sound Lex never wanted to hear again, and pulled her against him.

Lex threw the Bit.



IT TURNED OVER AND over in the air above the crater, black and jagged, a row of teeth cut out of the world. Elric caught it in one gloved hand.

And held it up. Beside the Bow, at his throat.

And brought them together.

They *clicked*.

Lex heard it. Everyone heard it. A sound like a lock turning in a door the size of the world. Not loud. Small. Final. The black jagged teeth of the Bit sliding into the loop of the Bow, fitting, joining. Two pieces of the Key of Shadows, made one.

And the sky went dark.

Not all of it. Not night. A shadow. Passing over the sun like the shadow of a great bird. Just for a moment. The whole Glass Desert going dim, the blinding white light turning grey, the reflections in the glass going out like candles. A cold wind blowing across the crater from nowhere, smelling of wet ash and old stone.

And then the light came back.

WORLD NOTICE

TWO KEYS HAVE BEEN TURNED.

And then, in silver, plain and cold, a panel that Lex had never seen before. Not over his head. Over Elric's.

He could read it. His thread was naked now, his Lampshade torn, and the gold was open in him whether he wanted it or not. True Sight came up on its own, like a reflex.

ELRIC THORNE

Class: ██████████ → USURPER OF KEYS

(Unique – Tier IV)

"What is locked, I open.

What is held, I take."

Level: 71 → 79

AUTHORITY: 55 → 68

(source: Key of Shadows ×2;
unwritten threads ×55)

Sixty-eight, thought Lex. *Fifty-five unwritten. Fifty-five people.*

And *Tier IV*.

Elric looked down at the joined pieces in his hand. At the black loop and the black teeth, fitted together. And his face changed.

It wasn't triumph. Lex had expected triumph. It was something stranger. Something almost like grief. He held the two pieces of the Key the

way you'd hold something you'd wanted all your life and finally had, and found, in the having, that it was heavier than you'd thought.

Then he closed his hand over it.

"*Thank you, Lex,*" he said quietly. And he sounded as if he meant it. "*Truly.*"

He turned to Kestrel.

"*The blade is under the lanterns,*" he said. "*Under your smith's brother's house. When I have it, I'll have all three.*" A pause. "*If you want your brother back, fire-witch, you know where I'll be.*"

And the keyhole opened behind him, and he stepped back into it.

Kell went with him. She lowered her hand as she went, and Dorrان Vask came unfrozen and crashed forward onto the black glass, his hammer striking the floor where she'd stood with a sound like a bell breaking. She didn't look back.

The keyhole closed.



IT WAS VERY QUIET in the crater.

Smoke drifted from the forty holes. The glass ticked and cracked as it cooled. Somewhere far above, in the white sky, a hawk was circling.

Ivo was holding his sister and rocking her. She was conscious. Breathing. Her eyes were open. But she was *pale*. Not sick-pale. Faded. The way Tamsin had been faded, at first, on the moor, when Lex had found him. The green of her coat was washed out. The brown of her hair had gone the color of dust. And when Lex looked at her with the True Sight he couldn't turn off, there was a panel over her head that made his chest close up.

ILSE MARROW

THREAD: UNWRITTEN (partial – 34%)

Anchored by: KIN-MEMORY (twin)

– source: IVO MARROW

Anchor strength: STRONG

"*She's here,*" Ivo was saying. "*She's here, she's here, Ilse, you're here, I've got you, I remember you, I remember everything, you're Ilse Marrow and you're*

born seven minutes before me and you never let me forget it and you stole the bishop's hat at the Kessick fair when we were nine, I remember—**

And with every word, the panel flickered.

34%. 32%. 30%.

Lex knelt beside them on the glass. He didn't know what to say.

Ilse looked up at him. Her face was very pale. Very faint. But her grey eyes were clear.

"*You gave it to him,*" she whispered.

"Yes."

"*For me.*"

"Yes."

She looked at him for a long moment.

"*Idiot,*" she said faintly. And then she started to cry. And so did Ivo. And so, after a moment, kneeling on the cracked black glass in the middle of the crater, so did Lex.



HE WENT DOWN INTO himself that night.

They'd camped at the edge of the crater, in the lee of the black tower. Nobody wanted to go any further. Nobody could. Dorran sat with his back against the tower and his book of names in his hands and didn't speak. Kestrel sat apart from everyone, with her knees drawn up, staring north, toward Caldor, toward a mountain hung with a thousand lanterns. She hadn't said a word since Elric left. Tamsin sat beside her, faint, watching her face.

Lex sat with his back against the warm black glass and closed his eyes and *looked*.

Not outward. In. Down. Into the Root. Into the gold.

He'd never done it before. Not like this. He'd used the Root a thousand times, for True Sight and Command and Sanction and Unbind. But he'd always reached *out* with it. Into the net. Into the world. He'd never once turned around and looked *down*.

It was very deep.

Gold, going down. And down. Like looking into a well full of sunlight. He could feel the threads that ran through it: his own, bright and close. His

father's, older, stronger, further down. His brother's, twined around his own like a vine, dark and cold and steady. And further. Further. Older threads. Threads that had been cut, or ended, and still left their marks in the gold like old scars on an anvil.

His mother's. A pale silver line, going down into the dark, and then simply stopping.

And at the very bottom. So far down he could barely feel it. A thread so old and so thick and so bright it was like a pillar. Gold. The first thread. The one all the others came from.

Aurelian.

And at the very bottom of that pillar, where it went down into the deepest dark, there was—

A door.

He couldn't see it. Not properly. But he could feel it. The way you feel a draft in a dark house. A door, at the bottom of the gold. At the root of the Root. Where the first thread went down into the dark.

And it was open.

Just a crack. Just a little. But open. And through the crack came warmth. And a faint gold light. And the faint, faint sound of something breathing.

Lex stopped. Hanging there, in the gold, in the dark, a long way down.

Ember, he thought. As loud as he could. *Ember. Ember. Are you there?*

Nothing.

And then. Very faint. From somewhere near the door. So faint he almost didn't hear it.

[...Lex?]

He nearly wept.

Ember. Ember, where are you? Are you hurt? What did it—

[I'm—here. I'm all right. I think. It's very—it's very dark. It put me in a—] A pause. Shaky. *[It's not an eye, Lex. Oriel was wrong. It's not an eye. It's a door.]*

I know. I can feel it.

[At the bottom of the Root. At the very bottom. Where Aurelian's thread goes down.] Ember's voice was getting stronger. A little. *[It's always been there. I just—I was never made to look. Your father didn't make me to look*

that far down.] A pause. [I think he didn't know it was there. I think he really didn't know. I think nobody did.]

And it's open.

[A crack. Just a crack. Since you touched the bit.] Ember was quiet for a long moment. [Lex. When the Well came up. When it burned the shadows. It screamed. Did you hear it?]

Yes.

[I heard it from inside. I was right there. Right beside the door.] Ember's voice dropped. [It wasn't Aurelian. Not the way Malachi talks about him. Not the smith who sang at his anvil. It was something wearing him. Something very old and very hungry wearing a kind face and a kind voice like a coat.]

Lex hung in the gold, in the dark, and didn't move.

[The Sunwell knew it,] said Ember. [That's why it burned so hot. It's tasted that thing before.]

Can you come back up?

[I'm—trying. It's like swimming in honey. I'll get there.] A pause. A very small, very Ember-like sound, almost a laugh. [You gave him the bit. For Ilse. Didn't you.]

Yes.

[Good.] Very firmly. [That was right. Whatever the cost. You don't trade people for metal. That's the first thing a smith ever learns.]

It's the first thing Brannoc ever taught me.

[I know. I was listening.] A pause. [I'm coming, Lex. Give me a little while. Keep the door shut if you can.]

How?

[I don't know.] Ember's voice was fading again. [Ask your brother. He's had a door in him for years.]



HE CAME BACK UP out of the gold with his face wet and Oriel Sant sitting beside him on the glass.

He didn't know how long she'd been there. She sat with her black thorn stick across her knees and her red shawl pulled tight and her white eyes turned toward him.

"*You went down,*" she said.

"Yes."

"*And?*"

"It's not an eye. It's a door."

Oriel was quiet for a long time.

"Yes," she said at last. "*Yes. That makes sense. I wondered why it looked so deep. She tilted her head. "Is your little fire all right?"*

"It's coming back. Slowly."

"Good." She patted his knee. "*I liked your little fire.*"

They sat together in the warm dark at the edge of the crater, under a sky full of stars, with the glass full of stars beneath them.

"*You know what you have to do,*" said Oriel. "*Don't you.*"

Lex looked at his hands.

"Go home," he said. "To the Hollowmaw. Before he does." He swallowed. "He's got two. He'll go for the third. And Antho's alone with the door, and the voice knows exactly where it is, and Kestrel—"

He stopped.

Across the camp, Kestrel Varn was sitting with her knees drawn up and her face turned north. Her fire had come back. A little. A faint red glow in her hair. And she was holding something in her hands, turning it over and over. Lex couldn't see what.

"Yes," said Oriel quietly. "*Kestrel.*"

"He offered her Tamsin."

"*He did.*"

"Will she take it?"

Oriel Sant didn't answer for a long time. When she did, her voice was very gentle.

"*What would you do, smith? If someone offered you your mother?*"

Lex didn't answer.



THEY CAME OUT OF the glass two days later, at noon, onto the red stony plain. And Queen Ishara of the Sunreach was waiting for them.

She was alone. Her riders were back at the edge of the scrub, a long white line under the hot sky. She sat on her golden horse with Zahir on her

shoulder and watched them come. Six ragged, burned, glass-cut figures and a mule. And one faint shape that only Lex could see.

She looked at Lex for a long moment.

"*Zahir saw,*" she said. "*From above. The fire. The shadows burning.*" Her hawk's face didn't change. "*And the old man. And the black thing you threw him.*"

"Yes."

"*You gave it to him.*"

"He was killing my friend."

Ishara's gaze moved to Ilse. Pale and faded, leaning on her brother's shoulder. Then back to Lex.

"*And now my people,*" she said, "*are in more danger than before.*"

"Yes," said Lex. "I'm sorry."

The Queen of the Sunreach sat on her horse and looked at him for a long time. Then she looked north. Toward Saffaran. Toward the great old Stone on top of the mesa, and the thousands upon thousands of capped threads running out from it.

"*Your friend with the red braid,*" she said, "*told me something else. Last spring.*"

He waited.

"*She told me that when you take the Ceiling off,*" said Ishara, "*the threads are brighter. Easier to see. Easier to cut.*" Her voice was very calm. "*She told me that is why the old man takes the Unbound. Because they shine.*"

"Yes."

"*She told me so I would understand what I was asking for.*" Ishara turned back to him. "*I have thought about it every day since. Every day for a year.*" A pause. "*I am still asking.*"

Lex stared at her.

"*You have your gold back,*" said the queen. "*I can see it in your eyes. They were brown and ordinary in the glass, and now they are gold again.*" She leaned forward in her saddle. "*Whatever was looking out of them has already seen everything. You told me so, at the edge of the glass. So there is nothing left to hide.*" Her hawk's eyes were very fierce. "*Free my people, smith. Now. Today. Before you go.*"

"If I do, they'll shine. He'll see them. He'll come for them."

"Then they will see him coming," said Queen Ishara of the Sunreach, "with their eyes open. And they will fight him with the Ashari fire their grandmothers had, which your Order took from us two hundred years ago." Her voice rose, very slightly. *"Better to burn bright and be hunted, smith, than live forever under a lid. Ask your red-haired witch. Ask your thieves. Ask anyone in the Sunreach."*

Behind Lex, very quietly, Ilse Marrow said: *"She's right."*

Everyone looked at her. She was leaning on Ivo, pale as dust. But her grey eyes were very clear.

"I'd do it again," she said. "Being Unbound. Even knowing. Even after today." She swallowed. "Two years of being bright. I wouldn't give them back for anything."

Lex looked at her. Then at Ishara.

Then he climbed up behind the Queen of the Sunreach on her golden horse, and they rode north to Saffaran.



HE DID IT AT sunset, at the great old Stone at the top of the mesa.

All of Saffaran came out to watch. They crowded the terraces and rooftops and the hanging gardens, thousands of them, in white robes and bright head-cloths, silent, watching the big young man from Caldor kneel at the foot of their Stone and lay his scarred hands on it.

He didn't shade himself. There was no point. Whatever was at the bottom of the gold had already seen. Let it watch.

Watch this, he thought at the door. *Watch me do this.*

And reached into the Stone with the Root, and found the Treaty of Scald, two hundred years old and heavy as a millstone, pressed down flat on every thread in the Sunreach. And put his hands under it.

And lifted.

It was the hardest Unbinding he'd ever done. Harder than Highcrest. Harder than Kessick. The Treaty had been set by forty Wardens at once, two centuries ago, and every year since, the Order had renewed it, pressing down and down. It didn't want to come up. It fought him. It weighed on him like a mountain.

He didn't have Ember to help him. He was alone in the Root for the first time in four years. Just him and the gold and the weight.

But he'd learned something in the Glass Desert. From a grieving Well. *Not do this. Help me.*

So he didn't command the Stone. He asked it. *They've been under there so long. Let them up. Please. Let them breathe.*

And the old Stone of Saffaran, which had been forced to hold down its own people for two hundred years, and had hated every minute of it, sighed.

And let go.



THE LIGHT CAME UP off the mesa like a sunrise at sunset.

Gold and silver, pouring up out of the Stone and out through every thread in the city, out across the plains and the canyons and the red mountains, out into every village and herder's camp and riverside town in the whole of the Sunreach. Lex felt it go. Felt the threads come loose, all at once, hundreds of thousands of them, like a whole country taking its first deep breath after a lifetime of holding it.

And from the terraces and the rooftops and the hanging gardens of Saffaran, a sound. Not a cheer. Something older. A long, rising, ululating cry, thousands of voices at once, the old cry of the Sunreach, that Lex learned later had not been heard in the city for two hundred years.

And then fire.

All over the city. Small flames, appearing in people's hands. On their fingers. In their hair. Little gold and red flames, flickering into being on every terrace and rooftop, like the lanterns at the festival in Highcrest. The Ashari fire. Coming back.

Lex knelt at the foot of the Stone with his hands on it and watched the whole city of Saffaran catch fire, gently, joyfully, without burning, and felt the tears running down his face.

WORLD NOTICE

THE TREATY OF SCALD IS BROKEN.

SUNREACH: 412,880 CEILINGS LIFTED.

LEX VEY – Level 62 → 66

UNBIND → Expert 1

ATTUNEMENT – FLAME: Speaking

(Commanding threshold: glimpsed)

He felt someone kneel beside him. He turned his head.

Queen Ishara of the Sunreach knelt at the foot of the Stone beside him, in the dust, in the sunset. There was fire in her hands. Small and gold and steady, cupped in her palms like water. She was staring at it.

"My grandmother," she said. Her voice was very small. "She used to tell me stories. About the Ashari fire. I thought they were only stories."

She looked up at him. There were tears on her hawk's face.

"Thank you," she said.

And far, far down in the gold, at the very bottom of the Root, at the door, Lex felt something watching. Not kind now. Not warm. Very, very still.

I see you, he thought at it. I know you're there. And I'm not afraid of you.

It was a lie. He was terrified.

But he thought it as loudly as he could anyway, kneeling at the foot of the Stone of Saffaran in a city full of fire.

And the next morning, with the Unlit at his back and Ilse leaning on her brother and Kestrel Varn walking a little apart from everyone else, staring north, he set out for home.

CHAPTER 11

THE FERRYMAN'S PRICE



HE FELT IT ON the ninth night by the river.

He'd been sitting on the grey shingle, the way he'd sat every night since he came, with the Lantern beside him and Ashka asleep at his back and the Ferryman standing a little way off beside his long grey boat. He hadn't decided. He'd tried, every day, to decide. He'd walked up and down the shore of the river between the world and the Hollow, and turned it over and over, and every time he came to the edge of deciding, he'd remember the millpond. The willows. The gold evening light. Lex's freckled furious face. *One. Two. Three. Four. Five.*

And he'd stop.

Nine days, said the four percent. *Nine days of sitting on a riverbank doing nothing. You were always good at that.*

And then the sky went dark.

Not here. Not over the grey valley, where the sky was always the same flat colorless white. Somewhere else. Somewhere far away to the south. He felt it through the Bloodbond, through the thin frayed thread that ran from him across the whole width of the world to his brother: a shadow passing over the sun. Cold. A wind smelling of wet ash.

And then a sound. Not a sound. A *click*. Small and final. Like a lock turning in a door the size of the world.

WORLD NOTICE
TWO KEYS HAVE BEEN TURNED.

Antho stood up.

Behind him, Ashka lifted her great head off the shingle. She'd felt it too. Her silver eyes were wide.

"Two," said the Ferryman. He hadn't moved. He stood beside his boat, leaning on his long pole, his eyeless face turned south. *"I felt the river shiver. Something has been joined that was broken."* A pause. *"Fifty-five threads in my water now. Fifty-five. And the river is cold."*

"Lex," said Antho. "Is he—"

"Your brother lives. I would know, if he did not. All the dead of your blood come to my shore eventually." The rain-voice was very calm. *"But the one with the key is stronger now. Much stronger. And he will turn east."*

Toward the Hollowmaw. Toward Seraphine and Odile and Pim and Teo and nine children and a door and a little clay lamp.

He'll bring the dark with him. You can't hold the door against two pieces of the Key. Not alone. Not even you.

Antho looked at the river.

At the far dark shore, a mile away across the grey.

He didn't decide. He realized, afterward, that he'd never really had to. It had been decided on the woodpile, at fifteen, when he'd sat in the dark with his hands over his ears and not gone into the trees, because there was a little boy in the house who needed him. Everything since had only been him finding out what he'd already chosen.

He turned to the Ferryman.

"Take it," he said.



THE FERRYMAN DIDN'T MOVE for a moment.

Then he turned his long eyeless face toward Antho. And under the brim of the wide grey hat, something changed. Not a smile. The Ferryman didn't smile. Something like recognition.

"You are sure."

"No," said Antho. "But take it."

"It is the brightest thing you have."

"I know."

"When it is gone, you will not know what you have lost. Only that something is missing. Like a tooth pulled in the night." The rain-voice was very gentle. *"You will reach for it, in the dark, when the voices are loud. And there will be nothing there."*

"I know," said Antho. "Take it."

The Ferryman looked at him for a long time. Then he lifted one long grey hand, thin as a heron's leg, and laid it on Antho's forehead.

It was cold. Not like ice. Like the river.

"Think of it," said the Ferryman. *"One last time. Hold it in your hands. Then let go."*



HE THOUGHT OF IT.

The millpond. Below the Ashbourne mill. Summer. The air thick and gold and humming with midges. The willows trailing their long green hair in the water. The smell of mud and mint and cut hay from the meadow across the stream.

Lex. Ten years old. Skinny as a rake, all knees and elbows, burned brown from the summer, his hair sticking up at the back where he'd slept on it. Freckles. So many freckles. Standing on the stony bit of the bank with a flat grey stone in his fist and his tongue stuck out of the corner of his mouth in concentration.

Throwing. *Plunk*. Throwing. *Plunk*. Stone after stone after stone, straight down into the water like dropped bread.

It's no good, Lex had said. Near tears. *I can't do it. I'm rubbish. I'll never be able to do it.*

And Antho, fifteen, kneeling in the reeds beside him. The last summer before the voices. The last summer before everything. Taking his little brother's small brown wrist in his hand.

No. Look. You're throwing it at the water. Don't throw it at the water. Throw it across the water. Low. Flatter. Like it's trying to fly under a door.

That doesn't make any sense.

It will. Try.

And Lex trying. And the stone leaving his hand, spinning, flat and low, and touching the water, and *lifting*.

One.

Touching. Lifting.

Two.

Antho had stopped breathing.

Three. Four.

Lex's mouth falling open.

Five.

And sinking. A little ring spreading out on the gold water where it went down. And the heron lifting off the far bank in fright, great grey wings flapping. And Lex turning to him with his face lit up like the sun coming out—

Did you see? Did you SEE? How many? Antho, how many?

And Antho had looked at that face, that lit-up freckled face, and thought: *Five. Five times. I've never done more than four.*

And said: *Four. It was four. That was brilliant. You're brilliant.*

And picked him up and swung him round. Lex shrieking with laughter. The willows. The gold light. His little brother's arms around his neck.

And then. Years later. The Old Founders' Road. Lying on their backs in the dark under ten thousand stars. *It skipped five times. I counted. I always count. I told you four.* A long silence. And then Lex, beside him, laughing. Helpless. Laughing until he couldn't breathe, until he was rolling on the grass, until Antho started laughing too. *You absolute—you liar. Nine years, Antho! Nine years I've been telling people four!*

I'm sorry.

Don't be sorry. Don't you dare be sorry. That's the best thing anyone's ever told me.

He held it.

All of it. The gold light. The heron. The weight of a ten-year-old boy swung round in his arms. The stars. The laughter. He held it in his hands like a warm smooth stone, the way he'd held it every night in the dark for three years when the four percent got loud.

Five, he thought. It was five.

And let go.



IT DIDN'T HURT.

That was the strangest thing. He'd expected it to hurt. He'd expected it to feel like something being torn out of him. It didn't. It was like breathing out. Like setting down a heavy bag at the end of a long road and not noticing, for a moment, that your hands are empty.

The Ferryman took his hand away.

Antho stood on the grey shingle of the river between the world and the Hollow and blinked.

He felt strange. Light. A little dizzy. As if he'd stood up too fast. He looked at the river. At the far dark shore. At Ashka, watching him with her great silver eyes.

Something's gone, he thought.

He reached for it. In the dark. In the place where he kept the warm things.

There was a gap there. A smooth round hollow, the size of a stone. Warm, still, the way a bed is warm after someone's got out of it. But empty.

He didn't know what had been in it.

He knew it had been something good. He knew it had been something to do with Lex. He could feel the shape of his brother around the edges of the hollow, the way you feel the shape of a missing tooth with your tongue. A summer, maybe. Water? Something about water.

He couldn't find it.

He stood very still and tried, and tried, and there was nothing. Just the warm empty hollow. Just the shape of something he'd loved, and couldn't remember loving.

[*Oh,*] said the Murmur. Very softly. And for once, it didn't sound cruel. It sounded almost sad. [*Oh. That one.*]

"*It is done,*" said the Ferryman. "*The fee is paid. For you and the storm-child both. Across, and back.*"

Antho looked at his hands.

Then he picked up the Lantern. And his staff. And walked down the shingle to the long grey boat.



THE RIVER WAS VERY quiet.

The Ferryman stood at the stern and pushed with his long grey pole, slow and steady, and the boat slid out into the grey. It didn't make a sound. No splash. No creak of wood. The mist parted in front of the bow like curtains and closed again behind the stern.

Antho sat in the middle of the boat with the Lantern on his knees. Its gold light pushed the grey back in a small circle, the size of the boat. Inside the circle, he was still himself. He held onto that.

Ashka didn't fit in the boat. She swam. Or rather, she *walked*, the way she'd walked into the river nine days ago, chest-deep in the grey mist, with her great wings folded tight against her sides and her head held high above the surface. But this time the grey didn't drink her. The fee was paid. The river let her pass. Her scales stayed storm-blue and the lightning crawled steady along her flanks, and she kept her silver eyes fixed on the far shore and didn't look back.

Halfway across, she stopped.

Antho saw her head come up. Saw her nostrils flare. Saw her whole great body go rigid in the mist.

And then he heard it.

Not with his ears. Through the hand he'd laid on the gunwale of the boat, through the grey water, through the river itself. A sound. Far away. Deep and slow and rumbling. Like thunder over mountains a hundred miles off.

A voice.

A dragon's voice, calling. Very old. Very tired. Calling a name.

Ashka screamed.

Not like before. Not grief. *Joy*. A great ringing cry that shook the mist around them and sent lightning leaping from her horns into the grey sky. And she plunged forward through the river, past the boat, toward the far shore, faster than Antho had ever seen her move.

"She hears it again," said the Ferryman behind him. Quietly. *"Her mother's voice."* A pause. *"What the river takes, it takes. But a voice can be heard twice."*

Antho watched his dragon go. Racing through the grey toward the dark, crying out, her whole body blazing with lightning. And he felt his throat close up.

He didn't know why.

He reached for the warm hollow in the dark. Empty.

But he watched her go, and his eyes stung, and he didn't know why.



THE FAR SHORE WAS the color of the inside of his eyelids.

Not black. Antho had expected black. The Hollow had always been black to him: the black of the breach, the black of the Gloam, the black of the thing in his head. But this was different. A deep, soft, endless dark, faintly blue, faintly violet, like the sky an hour after sunset when the first stars are coming out. The shore was smooth dark stone. The sky above it was the same color as the stone. There was no horizon. The land and the sky simply met, somewhere far off, and became each other.

And it was *quiet*.

Not the hungry quiet of the breach. Not the whispering quiet of the Murmur. The quiet of a room where someone is sleeping. The quiet of snow falling at night.

He stood on the shore with the Lantern in his hand and felt the Murmur in him go very still.

[Oh], it whispered. [Oh. I remember now. I remember. This is where I was, before.] A pause. [It's so quiet.]

"*This is not the Hollow,*" said the Ferryman. He'd stepped out of the boat behind Antho, onto the dark stone. "*Not the deep of it. This is the shallows. The Drowned Country. Where the Hollow touches the edge of things, and the edge of things drowns.*" He lifted his long pole and pointed with it. Inland. Down a long slope of dark stone toward something that shimmered faintly. "*The storm-mother is down there. Under the water.*"

Antho looked.

There was a lake. A great flat stretch of it, dark and still, filling a valley between low hills of dark stone. And under its surface, faint and blurred, as if seen through very old glass, there were shapes.

Towers. Roofs. Streets. A whole city, drowned. Sunk beneath the dark water. And among the towers, deep down, something enormous. Coiled. Faintly, faintly glowing, with a dim blue-white light, like a lamp seen through fog.

Ashka was already at the water's edge. Pacing. Crying out. Her voice rang across the dark lake and the shape under the water *stirred*.



THE WATER WASN'T WATER.

Antho found that out when he waded in. It was like the river: thin, and grey-blue, and cold like forgetting. But thicker. Heavier. It pressed on him. It pulled at his edges, gently, the way the grey had in the valley beyond the Teeth.

He held the Lantern up. The gold light pushed the drowning back.

[You could stay, you know,] said the Murmur. Dreamy. [It's very peaceful. No voices. No doors. No counting.]

"Be quiet."

[I'm only saying.]

He went down. The lake bottom sloped away under his feet, smooth dark stone, and the not-water closed over his head, and he kept walking, down, with the Lantern held high and its little circle of gold around him like a bubble of air.

He could breathe. He didn't know how. He didn't think about it.

Ashka came down beside him. She had to swim: the not-water was too deep for her to walk, and she beat her great wings through it in slow heavy strokes like a heron flying in a gale. The lightning crawled along her flanks, lighting the drowned dark around them in flickering blue.

And they came down into the drowned city.



IT WAS VERY OLD.

Older than Duskhold. Older than Avaloria. The towers were tall and thin and strange, built of a pale stone that had gone grey-green under the not-water. The streets were wide and paved with great slabs, cracked and tilted. There were statues in the squares, worn smooth, their faces gone. There were doorways with no doors. Windows with no glass.

And there were people.

Not living. Not the Drowned Dead either, the pale ghosts of Qel'Varran who'd lost their names. These were something else. Shapes. Faint and grey and drifting, like the thinned in the valley beyond the Teeth.

They moved slowly through the drowned streets, going about errands that had ended a thousand years ago. A woman carrying a basket. A man leading a horse that wasn't there. Children, running, without sound, in a game that had no end.

They didn't look at him.

"They do not know you are here," said the Ferryman.

Antho turned. The Ferryman was walking beside him, down the drowned street. His long grey pole tapped on the cracked slabs. Antho hadn't heard him come.

"They do not know anything," said the Ferryman. *"This was a city, once. Before the Lattice. Before the Founders. The hungry thing came up out of the dark under it and drank it down, and it drowned here, at the edge of the Hollow, and it has been drowning ever since."* He tapped his pole. *"Your ancestor sealed the hungry thing away. But the places it had already eaten stayed eaten."*

"Can they be saved?"

The Ferryman was quiet for a long time.

"I do not know," he said at last. *"No one has ever tried."*

Antho looked at a child running past him. A little girl, faint and grey, with her hair streaming out behind her, laughing without sound.

He opened the Lantern's shutter. Just a little. Just a crack.

The little girl stopped.

She turned. Slowly. And looked at the gold light spilling out across the drowned street. And came toward it. Slowly. One faint step at a time. Like the thinned in the grey wood. Like a child coming in from the cold.

She stood at the edge of the light, and held out her faint grey hands toward it.

Hearthglow, thought Antho. *Some of the lost don't want saving. They only want to sit by a fire for a while.*

He set the Lantern down on the drowned street.

"I'll come back," he said to the little girl. "I promise. I have to go and find someone. But I'll come back, and leave a light here for you."

She didn't answer. She didn't understand. She sat down at the edge of the gold light with her faint grey hands held out to it, and her face turned

up, and Antho thought, maybe, though he couldn't be sure, that she smiled.

He picked up the Lantern again, and closed the shutter, and walked on. And she watched him go.



THE STORM-MOTHER WAS IN the square at the center of the city.

She was the biggest living thing Antho had ever seen.

Bigger than Sorrowmaw. Bigger than Thraxis. Bigger than anything. She lay coiled in the great drowned square like a sleeping cat, if a cat could be the size of a cathedral. Her scales had been storm-blue once; Antho could see that, in patches, under the grey-green bloom that coated them. Her wings were folded against her sides, vast, ragged, torn in a hundred places. Her head lay on the cracked flagstones of the square, longer than a barn, her great jaws closed, her eyes shut.

And she was *chained*.

Not with iron. With dark. Long ropes of it, thick as Antho's waist, black and soft and faintly writhing, like the shadows of chains. They came up out of the cracks in the flagstones all around her. Dozens of them. Wrapped around her neck, her legs, her wings, her tail. Holding her down.

And on the chains, all along them, things were feeding.

Antho stopped.

They were small. The size of a cat. Dark and soft and boneless, like leeches, like slugs. Hundreds of them. Clustered along the black chains wherever the chains touched her scales. And where they clustered, he could see it: little threads of blue-white light, being drawn up out of the great dragon's body, through the chains, into the soft dark things.

Lightning. They were drinking her lightning.

[*Drinkers,*] said the Murmur. Quietly. [*The Hollow's little mouths. I remember them. They go where the light is. They take it a little at a time. They never stop.*]

"*Eleven years,*" said the Ferryman. "*Eleven years as the world counts. Down here, where time is thin, it has felt to her like three hundred. A storm-mother has a very great deal of lightning in her. But not endless.*"

Ashka had stopped too.

She hung in the drowned dark above the square, her wings beating slowly, staring down at the coiled shape below her. At the chains. At the feeding things. And Antho saw her shudder. All along her body. Like a horse shaking off flies.

And then the great dragon in the square opened one eye.



IT WAS GOLD.

Not silver, like Ashka's. A deep molten gold, slit-pupiled, and very, very old. Dimmed. Clouded at the edges, like an old woman's eye. But gold, and glowing faintly, and fixed on the small storm-drake hanging in the dark above her.

And Antho *heard* her.

Not with his ears. With Grave-Speech. With the old cold hearing that had let him speak to the Drowned Dead, and to Thraxis in the black hall at Duskhold. It had never worked on the living before. But she was so close to the edge. So drained. So nearly gone.

Her voice came into his head like thunder over the sea.

LITTLE ONE.

Ashka cried out.

LITTLE ONE. LITTLE SPARK. I HEARD YOU. ACROSS THE WATER. I HEARD YOU CALLING.

And a picture. Thrown at him, huge and blazing, the way Thraxis had thrown his:

A nest in the rocks. High. Cold. Lightning. Two eggs, blue as storm-clouds. One hatching. A tiny wet blue head, a tiny cry.

Seven winters of guarding them alone, after the Gloam took their father. Seven winters of storms and waiting.

And then: a crack in the mountain. A hole in the world, newly torn, breathing cold. Black hands like smoke, reaching out of it. Chains. Being dragged down into it. The nest, the eggs, left behind in the snow. One cracked and hatching. One still whole.

And then the dark. The Hollow. The drowned city. The chains.

Eleven winters. Three hundred years.

"*Mother,*" Antho whispered. He didn't know he'd said it. "*She's—Ashka's mother.*"

NOT ASHKA'S MOTHER, said the great dragon. *I DID NOT NAME HER. I NEVER SAW HER. SHE WAS STILL IN THE SHELL WHEN THEY TOOK ME.*

The gold eye moved. Slowly. From Ashka to Antho. And Antho felt it see him. All of him. Right down to the warm empty hollow in the dark where something had been.

YOU NAMED HER, said Vharuun. *YOU FOUND HER IN THE ROCKS. YOU KEPT HER WARM. YOU SANG TO HER.*

Her eye was very bright.

I HEARD. IN THE DARK. FOR SIX YEARS. A MAN SINGING TO MY CHILD. BADLY.

Antho's throat closed.

THANK YOU, said the storm-mother.



HE FREED HER.

It took all night. If there was night in the Drowned Country. It took everything he had.

He went from chain to chain. With the Lantern open. With Shade. With Void Bolt and Shadowbind and every cold quiet thing he knew. The Drinkers fled from the gold light, squealing without sound, shriveling where it touched them. But the chains didn't care about light. The chains were the Hollow itself. The dark at the bottom of the world, twisted into rope.

He couldn't break them. He tried. He threw everything he had at the first one, and it didn't even dent.

So he did what he'd done for eight years in the Hollowmaw.

He *held*.

Not the chain. The *dark*. The deep cold Hollow-stuff the chain was made of. He put his scarred hands on it and reached into it with Shade, the way he'd reached into the breach, and *held it still*. The way you hold a dog that wants to bite. The way you hold a door shut. And while he held it, Ashka bit through it.

She had storm in her jaws. Lightning, crawling along her teeth. And the chain, held still, couldn't flow away from the bite the way it wanted to. It parted. Like a rope cut with a hot knife. And fell, and dissolved, and was gone.

One.

He moved to the next.

[You can't do this,] said the Murmur. [There are forty of them. It's taking everything you've got. You'll burn yourself out. You'll drown here.]

"Then I'll drown," said Antho, and put his hands on the next chain.

Two. Three. Ten.

His hands were bleeding. Not from cuts. From the cold. The Hollow-chains were colder than anything in the world, and holding them still was like holding ice that bit back. His fingers had gone black at the tips. He couldn't feel them.

Fifteen. Twenty.

The Lantern's light was getting dimmer. It drew on his mana, and he was running out. The gold circle around him shrinking. The not-water pressing in.

Twenty-five.

Ashka's lightning was fading too. She'd bitten through twenty-five chains of solid Hollow, and her jaws were bleeding, and the light along her flanks was faint and flickering. But she didn't stop. She looked at him, after every one, with her silver eyes. And waited. And when he put his hands on the next chain, she bit.

Thirty.

He couldn't see properly anymore. The drowned square was going grey at the edges. Like the thinned. Like the man with the rubbed-out face.

Anthoren Vey, he thought. Anthoren Vey. Twenty-seven. I count the lanterns.

One thousand one hundred and eleven.

Thirty-five.

He fell. His knees hit the cracked flagstones of the square. He got one hand on the next chain. Held. Felt Ashka's jaws close on it. Felt it part.

Thirty-six.

He couldn't get up.

There were four left. Around her neck. The thickest. The oldest. He could see them, black against the faded storm-blue of her scales, a few paces away. He couldn't reach them.

Get up, he told himself. *Get up. Get up. You held a breach for eight years. Get up.*

He couldn't.

And then a voice. Not the Murmur. Not Vharuun. Very faint, very far away. From somewhere deeper in the dark. Low and a little rough, as if from long disuse.

Oh, my love. You've done so well.

He lifted his head.

There was a light. Far off. Beyond the edge of the drowned square, beyond the drowned city, out in the deep dark where the Drowned Country went down into the real Hollow. A small light. Gold. Steady. The size of a candle flame. Like a lamp in a window, very far away across a field at night.

Let me help, said the voice.

And the four chains around Vharuun's neck *loosened*.

Not broke. Loosened. As if someone very far away, at the other end of them, down in the deep dark, had let go.



VHARUUN ROSE.

Slowly. The way the Sunwell had risen, Antho thought later. The way an old man gets up from a chair. The four last chains fell away from her neck and slid back into the cracks in the flagstones like snakes going into holes. And the great storm-mother lifted her head off the floor of the drowned square for the first time in eleven years that had felt like three hundred.

And breathed.

It came up out of her in a great slow roll. Not fire. Not lightning. Thunder. A sound so deep it was barely a sound, a vibration that came up through the stone and the not-water and Antho's bones. And as it rolled out across the drowned city, the grey-green bloom on her scales cracked and fell away, and underneath, faint and patchy but *there*, they were blue.

Storm-blue. Ashka's blue.

She spread her wings. Ragged and torn, vast as sails. The not-water churned around them.

LITTLE ONE, she said. *COME HERE*.

Ashka came. Down out of the dark, slowly, her jaws bleeding, her lightning faint. And pressed her long narrow head against her mother's jaw. The way she'd pressed it against Thraxis's, in the black hall at Duskhold, three years ago, while her father died.

And Vharuun breathed on her.

Not everything. She didn't have everything. She'd been drunk on for eleven years that had felt like three hundred, and there was very little left. But some. A slow soft stream of blue-white light, pouring out of the old dragon's jaws into the young one's. And Ashka's flanks lit up. Her wounds closed. Her lightning came back, crawling bright along her scales.

And she made a sound Antho had never heard her make. A small, soft, rumbling purr. Like a kitten. Like the sound she made curled in his lap when she was the size of a cat.

He was lying on the flagstones of the drowned square. He couldn't get up. He watched the two storm-dragons pressed together, the huge old faded one and the young bright one, and the tears ran down the sides of his face into his ears, and he didn't know if they were his.

And far out in the dark beyond the drowned city, the little gold light was still burning.



"*Who was that?*" said Antho.

He'd got up eventually. He didn't know how long it took. Vharuun had breathed on him too, at the end, a little gentle huff of storm-air that smelled of rain on hot stone, and he'd felt strength come back into his hands. Not much. Enough to stand.

He stood at the edge of the drowned square and looked out into the dark, where the gold light had been. It was gone now. Just dark. Deep and soft and endless.

"*Who was that?*" he said again. "*The light. The voice. Who loosened the chains?*"

Behind him, the Ferryman didn't answer.

Antho turned. "You know. You know who it was."

The eyeless face looked at him from under the wide grey hat.

"I have told you," said the Ferryman, "that I will not speak of what was paid to me freely. It is not mine to give."

"That's not an answer."

"No," the Ferryman agreed. *"It is not."*

Antho stared at him. Then out at the dark again. Where the light had been.

Oh, my love. You've done so well.

Let me help.

Not yet. Keep the lamp lit.

A small clay lamp. Burning.

THE WOMAN WITH THE LAMP, said Vharuun.

Antho turned.

The storm-mother had lifted her great head and was looking at him with her one clouded gold eye. Ashka was curled against her side. And Vharuun's voice came into his head again, quieter now, like thunder very far away.

THE WOMAN WITH THE LAMP. I HAVE SEEN HER. IN THE DARK. FOR MANY YEARS.

Antho couldn't breathe.

SHE COMES TO THE EDGE OF THE DROWNED COUNTRY, SOMETIMES. TO REST. SHE SITS AT THE EDGE OF THE DEEP AND LIGHTS HER LAMP AND SINGS. A pause. SHE SINGS TO THE DOOR. A LITTLE SONG. ABOUT A LANTERN IN THE WINDOW.

"Is she—" He couldn't finish.

SHE IS TIRED, said Vharuun. VERY TIRED. SHE HAS BEEN HOLDING SOMETHING FOR A LONG TIME. Her gold eye moved, slowly, to the dark beyond the drowned city. Down. Toward the real Hollow. Toward the deep. *SOMETHING THAT WANTS VERY MUCH TO COME OUT.*

And then, very softly:

SHE LOOKS LIKE YOU. AROUND THE EYES.



THEY CAME BACK ACROSS the river at what might have been dawn.

Antho sat in the long grey boat with the Lantern on his knees and didn't speak. The Ferryman pushed with his pole, slow and steady, and the mist parted and closed. Behind the boat, two storm-dragons swam through the grey: one young and bright, one old and vast and faded, her ragged wings folded tight, her one good eye fixed on the shore of the world ahead.

The river let them through. The fee was paid.

Halfway across, Antho reached for the warm hollow in the dark. He didn't know why. He did it without thinking, the way you put your tongue to the gap where a tooth was.

Empty. Smooth. Warm.

He didn't know what had been there. He knew it had been about Lex. He knew it had been the best thing he had.

He'd given it for a storm-mother he'd never met, and eleven years of chains that had felt like three hundred, and four chains loosened by a light in the dark.

He thought it was probably worth it.

He wished he could remember what it was.



THE FERRYMAN STOOD ON the grey shingle as they climbed out of the boat. He didn't follow them up the shore.

"Anthoren Vey," he said.

Antho turned.

The eyeless face was turned toward him under the wide grey hat. And the unlit lantern at the top of the long grey pole swung gently in the wind off the river.

"I have been the Ferryman of this river since before the world was made," he said. *"I have taken a great many memories. Kings' crowns and lovers' kisses and the faces of children. I keep them all. That is what I am for."* He paused. *"Yours is a good one. One of the best. I will keep it carefully."*

Antho didn't know what to say.

"If you ever wish to see it again," said the Ferryman, "come back to my shore. I cannot give it back. But I can let you look." A pause. "That is not nothing."

"Thank you," said Antho.

The Ferryman inclined his long grey head. Then he turned, and stepped back into his long grey boat, and pushed off from the shore with his pole. And the mist closed around him, and he was gone.



THEY FLEW EAST.

Vharuun couldn't fly well. Her wings were too torn, her strength too drained. But she could glide, and she could ride the wind, and Antho had Gale. He sat on Ashka's neck with the Lantern hanging from the saddle and one hand stretched out toward the old dragon flying beside them, and *pushed*. Wind. Moving air. Lifting under her ragged wings, holding her up. It cost him. Every hour, it cost him. By the second day his hand was shaking and his face was grey.

But they crossed the grey valley. And the Teeth. And came down out of the high cold passes into the long green valleys of the western Greyspine, where the world was thick and real and full of color again, and Antho almost wept at the sight of an ordinary pine tree.

And on the fourth day, toward evening, they came over the last ridge and saw the Hollowmaw.

It was still lit.

He saw it from twenty miles off. The great cleft in the mountain, high on the slope, glowing gold from within. One thousand one hundred and eleven lanterns.

He let out a breath he felt like he'd been holding for three weeks.

Still lit, he thought. Still here. Still home. He hasn't come.

Not yet.

And then he saw the camp.

Below the Hollowmaw, on the long green slope of the valley, where there had been nothing but grass and goats and Correspondence's pen. Tents. Dozens of them. Grey tents, in neat rows. Cookfires. Horses. And Keepers, in their grey coats, drilling on the slope in long lines.

Roole, he thought. Roole's Keepers. He sent them. As many as he could spare.

There were more than he'd expected. Many more. Hundreds.

And as Ashka and Vharuun came gliding down out of the evening sky toward the mouth of the cave, the Keepers on the slope looked up and saw them, and shouted, and pointed. And a small figure came running out of the mouth of the Hollowmaw, down the slope, through the long grass. In a grey dress. With spectacles. Holding up her skirts with one inky hand and waving with the other.

Seraphine.

And behind her, smaller, slower, a thin dark-haired boy who never spoke, walking very carefully down the slope, with his eyes on the sky.

Antho slid off Ashka's neck before she'd finished landing. He nearly fell. He didn't care.

Seraphine reached him first. She didn't say anything. She threw her arms around him and held on, and he held on back, and she was saying something into his coat that he couldn't hear.

Then she leaned back and looked up at him. And her face changed.

"*Antho,*" she said. "*What happened? Your face. There's something—something's different.*"

"I paid the Ferryman," he said.

"*With what?*"

He opened his mouth to tell her.

And didn't know.

He stood on the slope below the Hollowmaw with his arms around her and his mouth open, and reached for it, and there was nothing there. Just a warm smooth empty hollow, the shape of something he'd loved.

"*I don't know,*" he said. "*Something about Lex. Something good.*" His voice cracked. "*I don't know what it was.*"

Seraphine stared at him.

Then she put her inky hands on either side of his face, very gently, and pulled his head down, and pressed her forehead against his. And held it there. And didn't say anything at all.

Behind them, the great old storm-mother Vharuun settled onto the slope below the Hollowmaw like a mountain lying down. And a hundred Keepers in grey coats stopped drilling and stared.

And Pim came up beside Antho, and looked up at the vast ragged faded dragon. And then at Antho.

"You came back," he said.

It was the second thing he'd ever said.

CHAPTER 12

THE QUEEN'S ADVISOR



WREN ASHDOWN HAD SLEPT in a great many uncomfortable places.

Under hedges. In ditches. In the crook of an oak forty feet up, tied to the trunk with her own belt so she wouldn't fall out. On the back of a dragon at night over the Greyspine, with the wind screaming and a large warm smith holding onto her so she didn't slide off. In a cell in the Spire, once, for four days, on a floor so cold she'd stopped being able to feel her feet on the second.

The corridor outside Arion Vey's rooms was not the worst. But it was in the top five.

It was stone. Everything in the Spire was stone. Grey, cold, polished smooth by nine hundred years of Wardens' boots. The corridor ran the length of the fortieth floor of the great white tower, with tall narrow windows on one side looking out over the golden city, and doors on the other. Most of the doors were empty now. Since Kell fled, half the Order had gone with her, or gone home, or gone quiet. The fortieth floor had been the High Council's floor. Now it was mostly dust and echoes and Arion.

And Wren. Sitting on a folded blanket with her back against the wall beside his door, her bow across her knees, an arrow on the string, and her eyes on the corridor.

Fifty-three nights.

She'd counted. She'd picked that up from Antho, years ago. The counting. It helped, somehow. It made the nights into something with edges.

Fifty-three nights, she thought. And not one assassin. Not one. Not so much as a cross look from a footman.

He's paranoid. He's an old man who's frightened of shadows, and he's got me sleeping on a floor for nothing, while Lex is out there somewhere with—

She stopped that thought. She'd learned to stop that thought. It didn't go anywhere good.



SHE REMEMBERED THE HOUR in his rooms.

Fifty-four days ago. The morning after the festival. She'd woken in the castle guest-room with Lex's note on the pillow beside her—*I'm sorry. I love you. Stay safe. Stay.*—and she'd read it twice, and said a word that would have made Brannoc blush, and pulled her boots on, and strung her bow, and gone to the window.

She'd had one leg over the sill. The wind already under her, already lifting. Windstep. She could have been over the Ironbacks by nightfall.

And a hand had closed on her arm.

Arion Vey. Standing in the doorway of the guest-room in his plain grey coat, with the dawn light on his lean face. She hadn't heard him come in. She never heard him come in.

"*Wren,*" he'd said. "*Please. Give me an hour.*"

She'd almost pulled away. She'd almost gone anyway.

But she'd looked at his face. And it was Lex's face. Older, leaner, harder. But the same jaw. The same brows. The same line between the eyebrows, the thinking line, that Lex got when something was wrong.

And Arion Vey, Warden-Architect, the most powerful sorcerer in Caldor, was afraid.

So she'd given him an hour.



"*Someone is going to try to kill me,*" he'd said.

They'd been in his rooms in the Spire. A big cold round room at the top of the tower, full of books and maps and instruments she didn't

understand, with a fire that never seemed to warm anything. He'd sat in a chair by the fire. She'd stood by the window with her arms folded.

"Before winter," he said. "I don't know who. I don't know how. But I know it's coming."

"How?"

"Because it's what I'd do." His voice was very quiet. "If I were Elric. Or Sorn. Or Kell. If I wanted the Registration Act passed, and the Unbound listed, and the Queen without her strongest voice on the Council." He looked into the fire. "I'm the only thing standing between Sorn and his majority, Wren. Lysandra can't hold the Council alone. Not yet. She's too young, and the old houses don't trust her."

"So hire guards."

"I have guards. Roole's best. Twelve of them, in shifts." He shook his head. "They're good men. But they won't see it coming. Whatever it is." He looked up at her. "You will."

She'd stared at him.

"You want me to stay," she said slowly. "Here. In the Spire. Guarding you. While Lex walks into—whatever's up there. Alone."

"Yes."

"No."

"Wren—"

"No. Absolutely not. I'm going after him. He's an idiot and he left me a note on a pillow like some kind of—" She'd stopped. Breathed. "He thinks I'm the brightest thread he knows. He thinks if I come, Elric will use me against him."

"He's right," said Arion quietly.

She'd turned on him.

"He's right," Arion had said again. He didn't flinch. "You're Unbound. You're Epic. You're a Mistwalker at level fifty-two with Gale at Speaking. Your thread shines like a beacon." His grey eyes held hers. "And you're the thing Lex loves most in the world. If Elric gets near you, he won't need to fight my son. He'll only need to hold your thread and wait."

She hadn't said anything. She couldn't.

"I can't stop you going," said Arion. "No one can stop you doing anything. I've seen that." Something moved at the corner of his mouth. "But I'm

asking you to stay. Not for me. For him. So that when he comes home, there's still something here to come home to."

And then, so quietly she almost didn't hear:

"And because I'm afraid, Wren. I've never said that to anyone. Not in two hundred years."

She'd heard *two hundred*. She'd thought it was a figure of speech.

She'd stayed.



FIFTY-THREE NIGHTS.

She sat in the corridor outside his door with her bow across her knees, and listened to the Spire breathing around her. The creak of the old stone settling. The wind moaning in the windows. The faint footsteps of the guard shifts changing, three floors down.

And from behind Arion's door, very faintly, the sound of his voice.

He talked at night. She'd noticed it the first week. Not to anyone. There was no one in there. She'd checked, the first time, slipping the lock with a hairpin and peering in. He'd been sitting in his chair by the cold fire, alone, with his eyes closed and his lips moving.

She couldn't hear the words. Not usually. Just the murmur of his voice, low and steady, going on for an hour or two hours at a time. Like someone talking to a sick person by their bedside.

Some nights, she caught a word. A phrase.

Hold on.

Not much longer.

I know. I know, love. I know.

She'd never asked him about it. It wasn't the kind of thing you asked.

But she'd thought about it. Every night. Lying in the corridor with her bow across her knees.

Love.



THE LETTER CAME ON the fifty-fourth morning.

She was on the roof when the courier found her. She went up there at dawn, every dawn, after the night watch, to stretch her legs and feel the wind. The Spire's roof was a flat circle of white stone, eight hundred feet

above the city, with a low parapet and nothing else. No one went up there except her and the pigeons.

The courier was a girl of perhaps twelve, out of breath from the climb, in a tinker's patched coat. She held out a folded square of paper, sealed with a blob of candle-wax.

"From the Bitter Hills," she said. *"For the red-haired lady who sleeps on the floor."* She looked Wren up and down. *"That's you, right?"*

"That's me."

"He said you'd be grumpy." The girl grinned. *"He said to tell you he's sorry and he loves you and you were right."* She considered. *"He said that last bit twice."*

Wren took the letter.

She didn't open it until the girl had gone. Then she sat down on the parapet of the Spire, with her back to the eight-hundred-foot drop and her feet dangling over the roof, and broke the seal.

Wren—

I'm an idiot. You said so in your note and you were right.

She read it through once, fast, the way she read everything. Then again, slowly. Then a third time, very slowly, one word at a time.

I love you. I'm saying it now. Properly.

She sat on the parapet of the Spire with the letter in her hands and the dawn wind in her hair and laughed. Out loud. And then, without any warning at all, she was crying. Great ugly gulping sobs, the kind she hadn't cried since she was eight and her mother had gone into the dark and not come out for a year.

The pigeons all flew away.

Idiot, she thought. *Idiot, idiot, stupid great lump of a smith. Two months, and you write me this, and you're halfway across the world where I can't hit you.*

She folded the letter very small and put it inside her shirt, against her heart.

There's a fire-witch who's even angrier than you are.

Well, she thought. *We'll see about that.*



THERE'D BEEN ANOTHER LETTER in the courier's bag. For Arion. The same blob of candle-wax. The same handwriting.

She took it to him.

He was at his desk, in the big cold round room, writing. He always seemed to be writing. Speeches for the Council. Letters to the Queen. Notes in a small hand in the margins of old books. He looked up when she came in.

"From Lex," she said, and held it out.

His face changed. Just for a moment. Like a door opening and closing. He took the letter. He broke the seal.

She watched him read it.

It was short. She could see that from across the desk. A few lines. She watched his eyes move down them. And she watched his face go white.

Not pale. *White*. All the color draining out of it in a heartbeat, like water from a cracked jug. His hand, holding the letter, went very still.

"What?" said Wren. *"What is it? Is he hurt?"*

Arion didn't answer.

He read the letter again. Then he folded it, carefully, along its creases. And held it over the candle on his desk. And watched it burn.

"Arion."

"He's not hurt," said Arion. His voice was very quiet. *"He's alive. He's going south. To the Sunreach."* He watched the last of the paper curl and blacken. *"He's found the second piece. Or knows where it is."*

"That's not what made you go white."

He looked at her. A long look.

"No," he said. *"It isn't."*

She waited.

"He asked me a question," said Arion at last. *"He asked if I knew something. Something about the Root."* He looked down at the ash on his desk. *"I didn't. I swear to you, Wren, I didn't know."* A pause. *"But I should have guessed. I should have guessed two hundred years ago."*

There it was again. *Two hundred years.*

Wren didn't ask. Not yet.

But she looked at him. Properly. The way she looked at a forest when something in it was wrong. *Don't look for the deer. Look for where the forest*

is wrong. And she saw it. Saw what she'd been not-seeing for fifty-four nights.

He hadn't changed.

She'd known him for three years now. Since Duskhold. Since he came out of the crystal. And in three years, Arion Vey had not changed by a single hair. Not a line on his face. Not a grey thread in his dark hair. Lex had grown a beard and shaved it off and grown it again. Antho had gone from a gaunt wild-eyed wreck to a lean grave man. The Queen had gone from a princess to a monarch, and it showed around her eyes. Wren herself had a scar on her chin now, and a little crease beside her mouth that hadn't been there at nineteen.

Arion Vey looked exactly as he had the day he stepped out of the crystal at Duskhold. Forty-five, perhaps. Lean and dark and tired.

Exactly the same.



THE COUNCIL MET ON the fifty-sixth day.

Wren went. She always went. She stood at the back of the High Council chamber in her patched coat with her bow on her shoulder, and the old lords and ladies looked at her sideways and muttered, and she ignored them.

The chamber was round, like everything in the Spire. A great domed hall with tiers of carved wooden benches rising up on every side. At the bottom, in the center, a round table of black stone, and around it the twelve chairs of the High Council. The Queen's chair, carved with the lion of Caldor. Arion's, plain grey, at her right hand. The rest held by the great houses of the realm.

And at the Queen's left hand, in a chair of red wood carved with grapevines, Lord Chancellor Varric Sorn.

Wren had disliked him on sight, three years ago, at the first festival. She disliked him more every time she saw him. He was perhaps fifty, tall and thin and elegant, with silver hair swept back from a high forehead and a neat pointed silver beard. He wore black velvet, always, with a single grey armband on his left sleeve. He had a beautiful voice. Deep and warm and reasonable. He used it the way Wren used her bow.

"Majesty," he was saying. *"My lords. I do not ask this lightly."*

Yes, you do, thought Wren.

"Fifty-five of our people," said Sorn. *"Gone. Unwritten. Their families do not even remember their names." His voice dropped, grave and sorrowful. "And every one of them was Unbound. Every one. Freed from the Ceiling by our young Forgeheart, with the best intentions in the world, and left shining in the dark like a lamp in a window for anything that hunts to find."*

Murmurs, around the tiers. Nods.

"I do not blame Lex Vey," said Sorn. *"I want to be very clear on that. He is a hero. He freed us from the Pale Warden. He is young, and brave, and did what he thought was right." He spread his long white hands. "But a lamp left burning in a window draws moths. And now it draws something worse."*

He looked around the chamber.

"The Registration Act does not cage anyone," he said. *"It does not Ceiling anyone. It only asks that every Unbound sorcerer in Caldor be known to the Crown. Their name. Their class. Where they live." His voice was very gentle. "So that when the unwriter comes, the Crown can stand between him and our people."*

So that the Crown has a list, thought Wren. *Of every bright thread in the kingdom. With addresses.*

And so that whoever holds the list knows exactly where to go.

Arion stood up.

He didn't raise his voice. He never did. He stood at the black stone table in his plain grey coat with his hands flat on its surface, the way Lex stood at an anvil, and the chamber went quiet.

"My lord Chancellor," he said. *"How many of the fifty-five were registered with the Crown before they were taken?"*

Sorn's face didn't change. *"None, my lord. That is precisely the point—"*

"How many were registered with the Order? On the Stones? In the Lattice records?"

A pause. *"All of them, I should think. Every Kindled person is."*

"All of them," said Arion. *"Every one of the fifty-five was written in the records of the Lattice. With their name, and their class, and where they lived." He looked around the chamber. "And the man who took them found every single one."*

Silence.

"He doesn't need a list, my lords," said Arion quietly. "He has one. The Lattice is a list. Every Stone in Caldor is a list." He looked at Sorn. "A second list does not protect anyone. It only gives a second copy to whoever wants it." A pause. "I wonder who that might be."

The chamber erupted.

Wren watched Sorn's face. While the lords shouted, while the Queen called for order, while the old Duke of Harlowe stood up and shook his fist. She watched the Lord Chancellor's elegant face, under his silver hair.

And for one moment, just one, she saw something move in it. Not anger. Something colder.

He looked at Arion, across the black stone table, the way Wren looked at a deer before she loosed.



THE ACT FAILED. SIX to five, with the Queen abstaining as custom required. Arion's vote, and the Queen's four loyal houses, and the Duke of Harlowe, who had changed his mind halfway through Arion's speech.

"It'll come back," said Elowen Dunmore, walking with Wren down the long spiral stair of the Spire after the session. "Sorn'll bring it back. Next month. And the month after. Until he has his six."

Elowen was Garrick's daughter. Twenty-eight, broad-shouldered and square-jawed, with her father's steady grey eyes and his habit of saying exactly what she thought. She was Knight-Captain of the Queen's Guard now, and she wore Oathkeeper on her back, the great plain sword that had been her father's. Wren had liked her from the first day. She was one of the few people in Highcrest who didn't look at Wren sideways.

"I know," said Wren.

"And your father-in-law-to-be has just made himself the most hated man in the room."

"He's not my—" Wren stopped. Scowled. "He's not anything to me. He's Lex's father."

Elowen looked at her sideways. "Mm."

"Don't mm me, Dunmore."

"*I didn't say anything.*" Elowen's mouth twitched. "*Only that you've slept outside his door for fifty-six nights, and you carry a letter around inside your shirt that you think nobody's noticed, and every time anyone says the word smith you go red.*"

Wren went red.

"*There,*" said Elowen. "*Like that.*"

"*I will put an arrow in you.*"

"*You'd miss,*" said Elowen comfortably. "*You'd be thinking about him.*" She clapped Wren on the shoulder with one big hand. "*Get some sleep, Ashdown. Real sleep, in a bed. I'll put my best men on his door tonight.*"

Wren didn't. She never did.

That was the night they came.



SHE HEARD IT AT the turn of the night.

The dead hour. Three hours after midnight, when the Spire was at its quietest, when even the guards three floors down had stopped talking and were only leaning on their spears. She was sitting in the corridor outside Arion's door with her bow across her knees and her eyes half closed. Not asleep. She never slept, on watch. Just resting. Listening.

And the Spire's breathing changed.

It was nothing. A creak. Not the usual creak of stone settling. A creak with a *weight* to it. A footstep, very soft, on old stone. Somewhere down the corridor. In the dark, past the last window, where the moonlight didn't reach.

Wren didn't move. She didn't open her eyes all the way. She slowed her breathing. In. Out. Like a sleeper.

And she *listened*.

Not with her ears. With Gale. The wind in the corridor. The tiny drafts that moved along the floor and under the doors and through the cracks in the old stone. She'd learned it at the Stillwater, from Malachi, three years ago. *The wind touches everything, lightfoot. Listen to what it touches.*

It touched something. Three somethings. Coming down the corridor in the dark, very slowly, very softly. Pressed against the wall. Moving the way she moved when she hunted. Toe first. Weight forward.

And it touched something else. Something cold. Something that moved through the air of the corridor the way a stone moves through water, pushing the drafts aside.

Metal. Chains. Heavy, fine, silver-black links. She knew that feel. She'd felt it once before, in Hedda Vorne's shop in Highcrest, three years ago, coiled around Hedda's body like a snake. Cutting her off from everything. Every skill. Every stat. Every scrap of magic. Leaving her a level-one nobody, slumped against a counter.

Severance chains.

Wren opened her eyes.



THERE WERE THREE OF them. In grey. Not Keepers' grey. A darker grey, like ash, with hoods pulled low and cloth over their faces. They were ten paces away and closing, and the one in front had a coil of silver-black chain over his shoulder, and the other two had short swords, and none of them had expected her to be awake.

She shot the one with the chain first.

She didn't stand up. She didn't need to. She drew from sitting and loosed, and the arrow took him through the thigh and pinned him to the floor, and he went down with a shriek and the chain spilled off his shoulder onto the stone with a sound like a bag of coins.

The other two came at her.

She was on her feet before the first one reached her. She didn't draw again; there wasn't time. She swung the bow, two-handed, like a staff, and cracked him across the side of the head with the upper limb, and he staggered. The second one lunged. Short sword, low, at her belly. She stepped back. Not on the floor.

On the *wind*.

Windstep. Up. Into the air of the corridor, three feet off the ground, the draft under her boots holding her like a step on a stair. The sword went under her. The man stumbled forward, off balance, his face turning up toward her in shock.

She kicked him in it.

He went down. She came down on top of him, landed on his back, drove both knees into his spine, and heard the breath go out of him in a great *oof*. She had her knife out and at his throat before he could get it back.

"*Don't*," she said.

He didn't.

The one she'd hit with the bow was getting up. Swaying. Groping for his sword on the floor. She looked at him.

"*Really?*" she said.

He looked at her. At his friend, under her knees, with a knife at his throat. At the other friend, pinned to the floor by an arrow through the thigh, moaning.

He ran.

She let him. She could have shot him. She didn't want to leave the man under her knees. She heard him go clattering away down the corridor, toward the stair. And then she heard him stop.

And heard Elowen Dunmore's voice, from the stairwell, say very calmly: "*Evening*." And then a meaty thud. And then nothing.



ARION'S DOOR OPENED.

He stood in it in his shirtsleeves, with a candle in his hand. He hadn't been asleep either. She could see that. He looked down at the corridor. At the man pinned to the floor by an arrow, moaning. At the coil of silver-black chain lying on the stone. At Wren, kneeling on the back of an assassin with a knife at his throat.

His face didn't change.

"*Severance*," he said quietly. Looking at the chain.

"*They were going to put it on you,*" said Wren. "*In your sleep. And then—*" She didn't finish.

"*And then I'd be nobody,*" said Arion. "*No Authority. No Root. No Prerogatives. A level-one man in a nightshirt.*" He looked at the chain for a long moment. "*Very easy to kill. Or to carry away.*"

Elowen came up the corridor from the stair, dragging the third man by the collar like a sack of grain. He was unconscious. Behind her came four of her guards, swords out, looking furious and embarrassed.

"Got past us on the thirty-eighth floor," said Elowen grimly. *"Came up the outside of the tower. On ropes. From the roof."* She dropped the unconscious man at Wren's feet. *"The roof, Ashdown. Eight hundred feet. Who comes up the outside of the Spire on a rope?"*

"Someone who knew there'd be a guard on the stair," said Wren.

She was looking at the man under her knees. She reached down with her free hand and pulled the cloth off his face.

He was young. Twenty, perhaps. Ordinary. A face you'd pass in the street. And on the sleeve of his ash-grey coat, half hidden under the cuff, a band of grey cloth.

And pinned to the band, very small, a silver brooch. In the shape of a key.



THE MAN WITH THE arrow in his thigh talked. Eventually. In a cell in the lower Spire, with Elowen standing over him and Wren sitting on the edge of the cot, turning an arrow over and over in her fingers.

He didn't know much. He'd been hired in the Lower Town, in a tavern, by a man in a mask. Fifty crowns. Fifty more when the job was done. The chain had been given to them in a sack. The rope, the hour, the route up the outside of the tower, all of it written on a paper he'd burned.

"And the brooch?" said Wren.

He wouldn't look at it.

"The Concord," he said at last. Very low. *"They said we were the Concord now. That when it was done, there'd be a new order. No more Unbound. No more wildcasters. Everything back the way it was."* He swallowed. *"They said the Ceiling would come back. That the Key would bring it back. That the world would be safe again."*

"Who said?"

"I don't know. The man in the mask. I don't know." He was shaking. *"He said the night of the masks. When it's done, the night of the masks, everything changes."*

Elowen and Wren looked at each other.

"The night of the masks," said Elowen slowly. *"Sorn's masquerade. At his house on the Crown Terrace. The whole court's invited. The whole Council. The Queen."* Her square face had gone very still. *"It's in five days."*



WREN WENT BACK UP to the fortieth floor at dawn.

She didn't sit down in the corridor. She knocked on Arion's door. And when he said *come in*, she went in, and shut the door behind her, and leaned against it with her arms folded.

He was in his chair by the cold fire. He looked up at her. He looked very tired.

"I want to know," she said.

"Know what?"

"Everything." She didn't move from the door. *"Two hundred years. You keep saying it. I thought it was a figure of speech. It's not, is it."* She stared at him. *"You haven't aged a day since Duskhold. Not a hair. Not a line. Three years."* Her voice was very flat. *"How old are you, Arion?"*

He was quiet for a long time.

Then he got up. Slowly. And went to the far wall of the round room, where a tall bookcase stood, crammed with old leather spines. He put his hand on one of the books. Pulled it. Not out. *Down.*

And the bookcase swung open.



THERE WAS A ROOM behind it.

Small. Round. Windowless. Lit by a single Lattice-lamp on a hook, silver and steady. It smelled of dust and old paper and lavender.

And on the walls, portraits.

Dozens of them. Hung frame to frame, from floor to ceiling, all the way round. Old oil paintings in gilt frames, cracked and darkened with age. Charcoal sketches on yellowed paper. A miniature on ivory, no bigger than her palm. A great dark canvas taller than she was.

All of them the same man.

Lean. Dark-haired. Grey-eyed. Tired. In a dozen different costumes from a dozen different centuries. In the white and silver robes of a High Warden, two hundred years out of fashion. In the plain brown coat of a

country scholar. In the black velvet and white ruff of a courtier, from the reign of some king Wren had only read about in Seraphine's books. In armor. In rags. In the grey of the Order.

Arion Vey. Over and over. Never older. Never younger. The same face, staring out of every frame.

Wren stood in the doorway of the little round room and didn't breathe.

She went to the biggest one. The great dark canvas. A man in the white and silver robes of a High Warden, standing beside a Lattice Stone, one hand resting on it. Behind him, through a painted window, a city on a mountain. Highcrest. But wrong. Smaller. No Spire. Where the Spire should have been, there was scaffolding. Half a tower, white, rising out of a forest of wooden poles.

There was a brass plate at the bottom of the frame. She bent to read it.

WARDEN-ARCHITECT ARION VEY upon the laying of the first stone of the Spire in the reign of King Osrice the Second

Osrice the Second.

She knew that name. Seraphine had made her read the king-lists once, on a long boring night on the Old Founders' Road, as a cure for Wren's insomnia. It had worked. But some of it had stuck.

Osrice the Second. Two hundred years ago. More.

She turned around.

Arion stood in the doorway of the little round room. In his shirtsleeves. With the silver lamplight on his face. The same face as the man in the painting, standing beside a Lattice Stone while they built the Spire.

"Two hundred and thirty-one," he said quietly. "I'll be two hundred and thirty-two at midwinter."



SHE SAT DOWN ON the floor.

She didn't mean to. Her legs just went. She sat on the dusty floor of the little round room with her back against the wall under a portrait of Arion Vey in a white ruff, and stared at him.

He came and sat down too. On the floor. Across from her. With his back against the opposite wall, under a charcoal sketch of himself in rags.

"*The Root*," he said. "*It keeps you. As long as it needs you.*" He looked at his hands. "*I took it when I was thirty-one. From my father, when he died. And I stopped. Just—stopped. The way a clock stops.*" He was quiet. "*I didn't know, at first. It took ten years before I noticed. Twenty before anyone else did.*"

"*And then?*"

"*And then I moved. Every thirty years or so. Changed my name. My face, a little. Hair. Beard. Spectacles.*" Something that might have been a smile. "*Arion Vey the scholar. Arion Vey the Warden. Arion Vey's son. Arion Vey's nephew. Arion Vey's grandson.*" He gestured at the portraits. "*I kept these because I was afraid I'd forget which one I was.*"

"*Does Lex know?*"

"*No.*"

"*Antho?*"

"*No.*" He looked at her. "*Seren knew. No one else. Not Elric. Not in forty years. He thought I was a man who'd been lucky with his looks.*" His mouth twisted. "*He used to tease me about it. Arion, you vain old peacock, what's your secret.*" He was quiet. "*That's part of why he hated me, I think. In the end. That I never got older. That I'd always be there, first, at the front, while he got old and grey and slow behind me.*"

Wren stared at him.

"*Will they?*" she said. "*Lex. Antho. They've got the Root too. Will they stop?*"

Arion was silent for a long time.

"*I don't know,*" he said at last. "*I've been wondering that since Duskhold. Since I came out of the crystal and saw them both with gold in their eyes.*" He looked at her. "*I hope not. I've never hoped for anything so much.*"

"*Why?*"

"*Because it isn't a gift, Wren.*" His voice was very low. "*It's a sentence. You watch everyone you love grow old and die. You stand at the front while the world goes by. You wait.*" He looked at the portraits. "*And something at the bottom of the gold watches you while you wait. And whispers.*"

Wren went very still.

"*That's what Lex asked you,*" she said. "*In the letter. Isn't it.*"

Arion closed his eyes.

"He asked if I knew that something was watching through the Root. Through his eyes." His voice was barely a breath. "And I didn't. I swear to you I didn't. But I've heard it whisper. For two hundred years. At night. When I'm tired." He opened his eyes. "I always thought it was my own mind. My own loneliness. I thought every man who'd lived as long as me would hear voices, at the end."

"And now?"

"And now my son has found a door at the bottom of the Root," said Arion Vey, "with something on the other side of it. Looking out." He looked at her. "And I'm two hundred and thirty-one years old, and I'm more frightened than I've ever been in my life."



SHE DIDN'T ASK ABOUT the voice at night. The one she heard through his door. *Hold on, love. Not much longer.*

She thought about asking. She almost did. She opened her mouth.

And then she looked at him. Sitting on the dusty floor of a secret room, surrounded by two hundred years of his own face, with his hands lying open and empty in his lap. And she thought about what Lex would say. Lex, who couldn't lie. Lex, who always asked.

And she thought about what Antho would say. Antho, who knew what it was to have a door inside you.

Not today, she thought. He's told me one thing. That's enough for one morning.

She got up. She held out her hand.

He looked at it. Then took it. She pulled him to his feet. He was lighter than she expected.

"Five days," she said. "Sorn's masquerade. The night of the masks. Something's going to happen there."

"Yes."

"You're going."

"Of course I'm going." He looked at her. "I'm the Queen's advisor. If I don't go, Sorn knows I know."

"Then I'm going too."

"Wren—"

"In a mask," she said. "And a dress, if I have to. I've never worn a dress to a party. I'll probably fall over." She narrowed her eyes. "But I'll be there. With a knife in my garter and my bow behind the curtains. And if anyone so much as looks at you sideways, I'll put an arrow in them before they finish blinking."

Arion looked at her for a long moment.

And then he laughed. Properly. For the first time in fifty-six days. A short, startled, helpless laugh, the kind that comes out of you before you can stop it.

"Seren," he said, "would have liked you very much."

Wren didn't know what to say to that. So she didn't say anything. She just nodded, once, and turned and walked out of the little round room full of portraits, and back out into the cold round room with the fire that never warmed, and back out to the corridor.

She sat down on her folded blanket. She put her bow across her knees.

Fifty-seven nights.

She took the letter out of her shirt and read it again.

Stay with Father, if that's where you are. Something's wrong with him, I think, and he'd never say so.

Oh, Hammer, she thought. You have no idea.



TWO DAYS LATER, A raven came.

Not Quill. A Keeper's raven, sleek and grey, with Roole's seal on the message tied to its leg. Elowen brought it up the stair at a run and found Wren on the roof, and thrust it into her hands without a word.

Ashdown —

Lex is back in Caldor. Crossed the Scald four days ago with a party of six. Coming north fast on Sunreach horses. Says the Key is in two pieces now and the old man has both. Says he's coming to Highcrest before he goes to the Hollowmaw.

Antho's back at the Keep. He's brought a dragon. A big one. You'll have to see it to believe it.

Kell's been seen in the north with three hundred men in grey. Ash-grey. Not mine.

Watch the masquerade. Watch everything. I'm sending you Fenn and twenty Keepers.

— D. Roole

Wren read it twice. Then she looked out from the roof of the Spire, south, across the golden city and the green river valley and the long blue hills, toward the Scald and the Sunreach and the road that came up out of them.

Coming north fast.

Coming to Highcrest.

She didn't realize she was smiling until Elowen said, very dryly, behind her:

"You've gone red again, Ashdown."

CHAPTER 13

THE DARK ALLIANCE



EMBER CAME BACK ON the road north, somewhere in the green hills below the Scald, on an afternoon so ordinary that Lex almost missed it.

He was riding at the front of the little column on a tall golden Sunreach horse that hated him. Ilse was asleep in the saddle behind her brother, her faded head on his shoulder. Dorran walked. Oriel rode her offended mule. Kestrel rode at the back, a long way back, alone, and hadn't said more than ten words in a week.

And in the deep gold, at the bottom of him, something cleared its throat.

[Well,] said Ember. [That was unpleasant.]

Lex nearly fell off the horse.

Ember.

[Hello, Lex.] It sounded tired. Thin, like a voice after a long fever. But *there*. Humming, faint and steady, in the place where it had always hummed. *[I'm back. Mostly. I've had to swim up through about a mile of honey, and something very large and very patient sat on me for a week, but I'm back.]*

He didn't say anything. He couldn't. He rode with his eyes stinging and the reins slack in his hands, and the golden horse, sensing weakness, tried to eat a hedge.

[Don't cry on the horse,] said Ember. [It's already got a low opinion of you.]

I thought you were gone.

[I thought so too, for a bit.] A pause. *[It didn't hurt me, you know. That's what I keep thinking about. It could have. It had me right there, at the door, in its hand. And it was gentle. It put me down somewhere quiet and dark and soft, like a mother putting a baby in a cradle, and it hummed to me.]* Ember's voice dropped. *[I didn't like that at all.]*

What was it humming?

[A lullaby.] Very quietly. *[The lantern song. Your mother's song. In a voice that wasn't hers.]*

Lex rode for a long time without saying anything.

[The door's still open,] said Ember. *[A crack. I sat beside it the whole time. I can feel it now, under us. Like a draft.]* A pause. *[I think it only opens wider when you touch something of his. The Key pieces. His shadow. Things he made.]*

The hammer?

[No. I checked. The hammer's—clean. Malachi's right about it. It's happy with you.] Something like a smile. *[Aurelian made it before. When he was still just a smith who sang at his anvil. Before whatever happened to him happened. It doesn't remember the thing at the door. It only remembers the singing.]*

Lex put his hand on the little hammer at his belt. Worn smooth. Warm. Good, he thought.

[Lex.] Ember was quiet for a moment. *[Kestrel.]*

I know.

[She's been riding at the back for a week. She hasn't talked to anyone. Not even Tamsin.] A pause. *[She's holding something. In her coat. She takes it out at night and looks at it when she thinks everyone's asleep.]*

What is it?

[I don't know. I couldn't see. I was a bit busy being sat on.] Ember's voice was very careful. *[But I don't think it's anything good.]*



THEY CAME TO HIGHCREST on the eve of the masquerade, at sunset, up the long south road through the river valley with the golden city climbing the mountain ahead of them.

Lex saw her before he saw anything else.

A speck. Far up. Against the red sky, above the Spire. Then not a speck. A figure. Small and slim, in a patched coat, with a red braid streaming out behind her like a banner. Falling. No. Not falling. *Stepping*. Down out of the sky, stair by invisible stair, on the wind, faster than any stair had ever been taken, straight down out of the sunset toward the south road.

He was off the golden horse before he knew he'd decided to be. He was running.

She came down the last fifty feet without stepping at all. She just *dropped*. And hit him in the chest like a sack of grain thrown off a cart, and he caught her and staggered and they both went down in the dust of the road together in a tangle of arms and legs and bow.

"*You*," said Wren Ashdown, on top of him, with her hands fisted in the front of his coat and her face six inches from his. "*You absolute—you stupid, idiot, stubborn, enormous—*"

"I know."

"*A note. On a pillow. Like a—like a man in a bad ballad—*"

"I know."

"*Two months. Two months and not a word, and then a letter, and in the letter you say—you say—*" Her voice cracked. Her green eyes were very bright. "*You say it properly. In a letter. From a mine. When I can't even hit you.*"

"You can hit me now," said Lex.

She looked down at him. Breathing hard. Windburned and furious and so beautiful he couldn't breathe.

And then she kissed him. Hard. In the dust of the south road below Highcrest, at sunset, with the whole of the Unlit standing around them in a ring.

He kissed her back.

It went on for some time.

"*Ahem*," said Ivo Marrow eventually.

Wren lifted her head. She looked around at them. At the giant with the hammer. At the twin thieves, one of them pale and faded. At the blind old woman on the mule. At the red-haired woman sitting very still on her horse at the back of the column, with her amber eyes narrowed.

"*Who*," said Wren, "*are all these people?*"

"Friends," said Lex. From the dust. "This is Dorran. That's Ilse and Ivo. That's Oriel. And that's—"

"*The fire-witch,*" said Wren. She was looking at Kestrel. "*The one who's angrier than I am.*"

Kestrel looked back at her. A long, level, measuring look.

"*He said that?*" said Kestrel.

"*He wrote it in a letter.*"

Kestrel's mouth twisted. "*He's not wrong.*"

"*We'll see,*" said Wren.

[*Oh, good,*] said Ember faintly. [*I'm so glad I came back for this.*]



HIS FATHER WAS WAITING at the gate of the Spire.

Arion Vey stood in the great arched doorway of the white tower, in his plain grey coat, with the last of the sunset on his lean face. He didn't come down the steps. He stood at the top of them and watched his son come up the street, with a red-haired archer holding his hand and a band of strangers behind him.

Lex stopped at the bottom of the steps.

They looked at each other.

[*He looks frightened,*] said Ember quietly.

He did. Lex could see it. Not in any one thing. In all of it. In the set of his father's shoulders. In the way his hands hung at his sides, not quite still. In his face, which hadn't changed at all in three years, and which looked older now than Lex had ever seen it.

"You got my letter," said Lex.

"Yes."

"Did you know?"

Arion was silent for a long moment.

"No," he said at last. "I swear it, Lex. I didn't know." He came down one step. Then another. "But I've heard it. For a long time. At night. Whispering. I always thought it was my own mind." He stopped two steps above his son, so their eyes were level. "I should have known. I should have guessed. I'm sorry."

Lex looked at him.

Three years ago, at the first festival, he'd have shouted. A year ago he'd have been coldly, quietly angry. Even two months ago, in the Queen's tower, he'd have stood with Antho and demanded *why didn't you tell us*.

But he'd been to the Glass Desert since then. He'd heard a kind voice in the bottom of himself call him *good boy*. He'd felt something vast and patient sit on Ember for a week. And he understood, now, standing on the steps of the Spire, what it might mean to hear that voice for years. For decades. Alone. At night. And think it was your own.

"It's in me too," he said quietly. "Now. The door's open. A crack."

His father closed his eyes.

"I know," he said. "I felt it. In the Root. The day you touched the bit." He opened them. "I've been sitting in my chair every night since, listening to it breathe."

Behind Lex, Wren made a small sound. He glanced back. She was looking at his father with an expression Lex couldn't read. Something careful. Something that knew more than it was saying.

He filed it away. For later.

"Come in," said Arion. "All of you. There isn't much time. There's something you need to know about tomorrow night."



THEY SAT AROUND THE round table in the Queen's tower until long after midnight. The Queen. Arion. Elowen Dunmore with Oathkeeper across her back. Fenn, Roole's Keeper-Lieutenant, lean and freckled and very serious, with twenty Keepers waiting in the corridor outside. Seraphine was gone; she'd gone to the Hollowmaw two months ago and stayed. Lex felt her absence like a missing tooth.

And the Unlit. Sitting around the Queen's table in their travel-stained coats and their road dust, looking at the tapestries and the silver candlesticks and the Queen of Caldor herself with expressions that ranged from wonder (Ivo) to suspicion (Dorran) to complete indifference (Oriel, who couldn't see any of it).

Kestrel sat at the end of the table. Silent. Her hands in her lap.

"The night of the masks," said Wren, and told them. The three men in ash-grey. The Severance chain. The key-shaped brooch. *The Concord. When it's done, the night of the masks, everything changes.*

"Sorn," said Queen Lysandra. Very quietly. *"He's going to try for the Crown."*

"Not the Crown," said Arion. "Not openly. He's cleverer than that." He laid his hands flat on the table. "He'll declare an emergency. The unwriter on the loose, the Queen too young, the Council deadlocked. He'll ask for a regency. *Temporary.* For the realm's safety. And with Kell's three hundred men around his house and the whole Council inside it, there'll be no one to say no."

"And the Registration Act?"

"Passed by decree. The first morning." Arion's voice was flat. "A list of every Unbound sorcerer in Caldor, in Sorn's hands. And Sorn's hands are Elric's hands."

The Queen looked at him for a long moment.

"Then we don't go," said Elowen. *"Simple. Majesty stays in the castle. We put the Guard on the walls. Let Sorn have his party."*

"If I don't go," said Lysandra, *"he'll say I'm afraid. He'll say I'm hiding. And half the old houses will believe him, and the other half will wonder."* She shook her head. *"I've spent three years trying to make them trust me. I can't hide in my tower the first time someone threatens me."*

"Majesty—"

"I'm going, Elowen." The Queen's voice was very calm. *"In a mask, and a gown, and a smile. And you're going to stand behind me with your father's sword. And we're going to let Varric Sorn make his move in front of the whole court."* Her dark eyes went round the table. *"And then we're going to break it."*



"There's something else," said Oriel Sant.

Everyone turned. The old woman had been so quiet all evening that half of them had forgotten she was there. She sat at the far end of the table in her red shawl, with her black thorn stick across her knees and her white eyes turned toward nothing.

"Two fires," she said.

Lex went still.

"I see two fires tomorrow night," said Oriel. "One here. In a fine house, full of masks. And one far away. In the mountains. Where the lanterns are." Her thin dry voice didn't change. "The one here is loud. The one there is quiet. The one here is the one he wants you to look at."

Silence around the table.

"The masquerade's a diversion," said Wren slowly. "While everyone's looking at Sorn's house—"

"Elric goes for the blade," said Lex.

He was already standing up. He didn't remember standing up.

"The Hollowmaw," he said. "Antho. Seraphine. The students. Father, he's going for the—"

"I know." Arion was on his feet too. His face had gone grey. "Roole sent three hundred Keepers to the Keep a month ago. They're on the slopes now. And Antho's back. With the storm-mother."

"Three hundred Keepers against two pieces of the Key," said Lex. "Against Elric at Tier IV. Against Umbral Wardens." He was breathing too fast. "I have to go. Tonight. Now."

"It's three hundred miles," said Elowen. "Ten days' ride. Four on a dragon. You don't have a dragon."

"I don't care, I'll—"

"Lex."

His father's voice. Very quiet.

Lex stopped.

"There's a way," said Arion. "Through the Stones. The Lattice is a net. A net has threads. And a Root-holder, at Tier IV, can walk them." He looked at his son. "From the Great Stone in the Spire to the Stone at Kessick Falls, in the Greyspine. A day's ride from the Hollowmaw. I can do it. Once. For two people. It'll take everything I have."

"Then do it now."

"No," said Oriel Sant.

Everyone looked at her again.

"Not now," said the old woman. "If you go now, the fire here will burn. And it will burn your Queen, and your father, and everyone in this room."

Her white eyes moved toward Lex. *"And the fire there will burn anyway. You won't be in time. He isn't there yet. He's waiting. For the masks."*

"How do you know?"

"I don't know," said Oriel simply. *"I see. That's all I've ever done."* She tilted her head. *"Break the fire here first, smith. Fast. Then go. That's the only way both fires go out."*

Lex stood at the Queen's table with his hands clenched, and looked at his father, and at Wren, and at the Queen.

[She's been right about everything so far,] said Ember quietly.

I know.

[I hate it when old women are right.]

I know.

He sat down.

At the end of the table, Kestrel Varn hadn't moved. She was looking at her hands in her lap. And her face, in the candlelight, was the color of ash.



HE FOUND HER ON the castle wall, after.

She was standing at the battlements in the dark, looking north. The wind off the mountains lifted her red hair, and there was a faint red glow in it, very low. Tamsin stood beside her. Faint as smoke. Watching her face.

Lex came and leaned on the battlements beside her. He didn't say anything for a while.

"You know," said Kestrel at last. Not looking at him. *"Don't you."*

"I know he offered you Tamsin."

"Not just offered." Her voice was very low. *"He sent me something. In the glass. Before he left. While you were down in your Well."* She reached into her coat. And took out a scrap of paper, folded small, creased with handling.

She didn't give it to him. She held it in her fist.

"A place," she said. *"A time. Tomorrow night. Where to find him."* Her jaw tightened. *"And a promise. That if I bring him what he needs, he'll write Tam back. Whole. First thing. Before anything else."*

"What does he need?"

Kestrel didn't answer.

"Kestrel. What does he need?"

She turned her head and looked at him. And her amber eyes were full of tears and fury and something that looked like hatred, though Lex couldn't tell who it was for.

"You," she said. *"Your blood. The blade's under a Vey door. Aurelian's own. Under your brother's floor. And the old man can't open it."* Her voice broke. *"He needs Vey blood. Just a little. Just enough to wet the ward."*

Lex didn't move.

"Your hand," said Kestrel. *"In the glass. When you cut it for the tower door. You wrapped it in a rag after. And threw the rag away, at the edge of the crater, when you'd healed."* She swallowed. *"I picked it up."*

He looked at her coat. At the place where her hand had been.

"I've been carrying it for three weeks," said Kestrel Varn. *"In my coat. Next to my heart. Every night, I take it out, and I look at it. And I think about Tam. Solid. Whole. Laughing."* Her voice was barely a whisper. *"And I think about your brother. And his lanterns. And his door."*

"Have you decided?"

"No." She laughed. A terrible little sound. *"No. I haven't. That's the worst of it, smith. I haven't. I keep thinking I'll throw it in the fire. And I don't."*

Beside her, faint and pale, Tamsin Varn had put his face in his hands.

"Kes," he whispered. *"Kes, don't. Don't. Not for me."*

She couldn't hear him.

Lex could. He didn't tell her. He didn't need to.

He looked at her for a long time.

"I'm not going to take it from you," he said at last.

She stared at him.

"I could," said Lex. "I'm bigger than you. And I've got the Root. I could take it." He looked out at the dark mountains. "But it's yours. Whatever you decide. It has to be yours."

"Why?"

"Because if I take it, you'll never know what you would have done," said Lex. "And you'll wonder. Every day. For the rest of your life." He pushed himself off the battlements. "I'd rather you chose. Even if you choose wrong."

He walked away down the wall. He didn't look back.

[Lex,] said Ember. Very quietly. *[That might have been the bravest thing I've ever seen you do. Or the stupidest.]*

I know.

[Which one?]

I don't know yet.



SORN'S HOUSE STOOD AT the top of the Crown Terrace, the highest street in Highcrest below the castle itself. A great white palace of a house, with columns along its front and a garden that ran down the mountainside in tiers, and every window blazing with light.

It was full of masks.

Lex had never seen anything like it. Hundreds of people, the whole court of Caldor and half the wealthy merchants of the Lower Town, in silk and velvet and cloth-of-gold, and every face hidden. Masks of white porcelain and black lacquer. Masks of feathers, of gold leaf, of silver filigree. Masks shaped like birds and beasts and moons and suns. A man in a stag's head with real antlers. A woman whose whole face was a mirror, so that when you looked at her you saw yourself.

Lex wore a mask of plain dark leather, a smith's mask, that covered his face from brow to lip. It had been Ilse's idea. *If you're going to hide, hide as what you are. Nobody looks twice at a man pretending to be himself.* He wore a dark coat that Arion had found somewhere, too tight across the shoulders, and Aurelian's hammer in his belt under it.

And beside him, holding his arm, in a gown of deep green silk that made her look like a queen out of an old story, with a fox-mask of copper and red enamel over her eyes, Wren.

"I hate this," she said. Through a smile. Not moving her lips.

"You look beautiful."

"I look like a cake. I can't breathe. There's a knife strapped to my thigh and it's cutting off the blood to my foot." Her smile didn't waver. *"And these shoes. Who invented these shoes. I'm going to find them and shoot them."*

"You'd miss."

"*I would not miss.*" She tightened her grip on his arm. "*You're enjoying this.*"

"A little."

"*I'm going to put an arrow in you later. Very gently. Somewhere fleshy.*"

He laughed. And she looked up at him from behind the fox-mask, and something in her face softened. Just for a moment.

"*Dance with me,*" she said.

"I can't dance."

"*Neither can I. Dance with me anyway.*"

So they danced. Badly. In the middle of the great ballroom of Varric Sorn's house, under a ceiling painted with gods and chandeliers blazing with a thousand candles, surrounded by masks. He trod on her feet twice. She trod on his four times, at least one of them on purpose. Neither of them knew the steps. They just held onto each other and moved, more or less, in time with the music, and for a few minutes, Lex forgot everything. Forgot keys and doors and kind voices. Forgot the Hollowmaw, three hundred miles away in the dark.

Just Wren. In his arms. In a gown she hated. Laughing at him through a fox-mask.

"*I missed you,*" she said. Very quietly. Under the music.

"I missed you too."

"*Don't leave me behind again.*" Her green eyes, behind the copper mask, were fierce. "*Promise.*"

"I promise."

"*Properly.*"

"I promise properly," said Lex. "Never again."

She leaned her head against his chest. And they danced.



ACROSS THE BALLROOM, THE Queen stood in a mask of silver feathers, with Elowen Dunmore behind her in plain black armor and an owl's mask, Oathkeeper on her back. Arion stood at the Queen's right hand in a mask of grey silk, very plain. Fenn's twenty Keepers were scattered through the crowd in borrowed finery, masked, swords under their coats.

And the Unlit were everywhere.

Lex couldn't see them. That was the point. Ilse and Ivo had spent the afternoon weaving illusions, and now Dorran Vask, all seven feet of him, was a footman with a tray of wine glasses, slightly stooped, entirely forgettable. Oriel sat on a bench by the wall disguised as a dowager in a black lace mask, which was barely a disguise at all. The twins themselves were nowhere. Or everywhere. Lex had seen the same pair of servants in three different doorways in the last hour.

Kestrel had not come.

He'd looked for her at the castle gate, when they left. She hadn't been there. Tamsin hadn't been there either.

[She's gone,] Ember had said quietly.

I know.

[Where?]

Where the paper said.



AT THE STROKE OF midnight, Varric Sorn stood up on the gallery above the ballroom and raised his glass.

He wore no mask. He was the host; it was his privilege. He stood at the gallery rail in black velvet with his silver hair swept back and his silver beard neatly pointed and a single grey band on his sleeve, and the music stopped, and five hundred masked faces turned up toward him.

"*My friends,*" he said. His beautiful voice filled the ballroom effortlessly. "*My lords and ladies. Majesty.*" A graceful bow toward the Queen. "*Thank you for coming tonight.*"

Polite applause.

"*We live in frightening times,*" said Sorn. "*I don't need to tell you. Fifty-five of our people, gone. Their families don't even remember their names. And every week, more.*" His voice was grave and sorrowful. "*And our Council deadlocked. Our Queen, young and brave, but alone. Our protector, the Order, broken. The Ceiling that kept us safe for nine hundred years, gone.*"

Murmurs. A few nods, behind the masks.

"I have been asked," said Sorn, *"by many of you, privately, to do something. To act. To protect the realm while there is still a realm to protect."* He set down his glass on the gallery rail. *"And tonight, I am answering."*

The doors of the ballroom closed.

All of them. At once. Every great double door, on every side, swinging shut with a single heavy *boom* that shook the chandeliers.

And behind the doors, Lex heard boots. A great many boots. Marching.

"By the authority of the Eclipse Concord," said Lord Chancellor Varric Sorn, *"and for the safety of the realm, I hereby declare a regency over the Crown of Caldor. Her Majesty will be placed under my protection, for her own safety, until the present danger has passed."* He smiled down at the Queen. Kindly. *"No one will be harmed. Everyone will be home by morning."* A pause. *"Except, I'm afraid, Lord Arion Vey."*

The great doors at the far end of the ballroom opened.

And Isaura Kell walked in, in the white of a High Warden, with a hundred men in ash-grey behind her.



THINGS HAPPENED VERY FAST after that.

Lex saw Kell raise her hand. Felt the great cold silver pressure come down over the ballroom like a lid. *Inspection.* The Order's oldest power. *Show yourself. Show your thread. Show what you are.*

He felt the Unlit's illusions tear. All of them. All at once. The footman with the wine tray was suddenly seven feet tall and holding a hammer. The dowager in black lace was a tiny blind old woman in a red shawl. Two servants in two different doorways flickered and became two mouse-haired thieves in patched coats, one of them faded and pale.

And Lex's own Lampshade, which he'd been holding all night, ripped away like a curtain in a gale, and his thread blazed out naked into the net, gold and silver, bright as a beacon.

"There he is," said Kell. Quietly. Looking straight at him across the ballroom. *"Take the father. I'll hold the son."*

The men in ash-grey came in.

And someone came out of the crowd behind Arion with a coil of silver-black chain and threw it over his shoulders.



LEX SAW IT HAPPEN.

Saw his father turn, too late. Saw the chain fall across his shoulders and wrap itself around him, link after link, like a snake. Saw the gold go out of his eyes. All at once. Like a candle snuffed. Saw him stagger, and go down on one knee on the polished ballroom floor, with the silver-black chain wound around his chest and arms.

Severance.

Everything the Lattice gave him. Every skill. Every stat. The Root. The Authority. Two hundred and thirty-one years of power. Gone. Cut off. Leaving a lean tired man in a grey silk mask kneeling on a dance floor.

"FATHER—"

Kell's hand turned toward Lex.

And the silver pressure came down on him. Not Inspection now. Something heavier. Something he'd felt once before, in the Spire, years ago, when the Order had tried to lock his class. *Hold. Be still. Obey.* The voice of the High Warden, Tier IV, the highest Sanction the Lattice had ever granted, pressing down on him with nine hundred years of authority behind it.

He felt his knees start to bend.

[Lex,] said Ember. [Lex, she's using a Sanction. Her own. The one the Lattice gave her when she was raised to High Warden.] A pause. Very fast. [And Sanctions are granted. By the Root. Lex. You're the Root.]

He understood.

He stopped fighting the pressure. He let it push him down, onto one knee, like his father. And he reached, not out at Kell, but *down*. Into the gold. Into the Root. Into the deep place where every Sanction in the Lattice was written, every Tier permission, every flag and lock and grant, the whole great ledger of who was allowed what.

And found hers.

ISAURA KELL — HIGH WARDEN — TIER IV SANCTION — granted by the Order under Root delegation.

Granted.

Under Root delegation.

And he was the Root.

He felt the door at the bottom of the gold stir as he reached. Felt something open its eye a crack wider, warm and interested, watching what he did.

Let it watch, he thought.

PREROGATIVE: SANCTION (REVOKE)

Target: ISAURA KELL

Tier IV Sanction – REVOKED

Authority: 100 → 75



KELL SCREAMED.

Not loudly. A sharp short cry, like someone who's put her hand on a hot stove. The silver pressure over the ballroom *vanished*. Just—gone. Like a lid lifted off a pot.

She staggered. Her hand fell. She stared at it. Then at Lex. Her pale grey eyes, for the first time since he'd known her, wide with shock.

"You can't," she whispered. *"You can't do that. That Sanction was granted by the Order. By the High Council. By—"*

"By the Root," said Lex, standing up. "Through the Order. On loan." He looked at her. "I'm calling in the loan."

And then he reached again. Not at Kell. At the giant standing frozen in the middle of the ballroom, with a hammer in his hands and a faded silver brand on his forearm, still glowing faintly with the last of her command.

DORRAN VASK — WARDEN OF THE KINDLING — Sanction to Ceiling, granted under Root delegation.

PREROGATIVE: SANCTION (REVOKE)

Target: DORRAN VASK

Kindling Sanction – REVOKED

Brand: VOID

Authority: 75 → 65

Across the ballroom, the brand on Dorran's forearm flared silver one last time. And went dark. And then it was just a scar. An old burn on a big man's arm. Nothing else.

Dorran looked down at it.

Then he looked up. At Kell. And something came into his great slab of a face that Lex had never seen there before.

Not anger. Not quite. Something older and heavier and much more patient. Like a mountain deciding to move.

"*Commander,*" said Dorran Vask. "*I've been waiting twenty years to say this.*"

And he dropped his hammer, and walked across the ballroom toward her.



AFTER THAT, IT WAS a fight.

The men in ash-grey were hired swords. Good ones. A hundred of them, armored, trained, filling the ballroom from three doors. But they'd been told they'd be facing a frightened court and an old man in chains. They hadn't been told about the Unlit.

Ilse and Ivo went up the walls. Literally. They'd brought ropes, under their coats, and grapnels, and they swarmed up the tapestries like squirrels up a tree and perched on the gallery rail and began to *weave*. Illusions. Dozens of them. Fifty Queens of Caldor appeared in the ballroom at once, all in silver feather masks, all running in different directions. The men in ash-grey stopped, bewildered, swinging their swords at Queens who dissolved like smoke.

Wren went up too. Not on a rope. On the wind. She kicked off her shoes, hiked her green silk gown up to her knees, pulled a bow out from behind the tapestry where she'd hidden it that afternoon, and *stepped* up into the air. She stood on nothing, twenty feet above the ballroom floor, under the painted gods, with her fox-mask pushed up on her head and her red hair coming down, and began to shoot. Not to kill. To stop. Arrows through sword-hands. Through boots. Through the straps of shields. Every one exactly where she wanted it.

Elowen Dunmore drew Oathkeeper.

Lex had never seen her fight. He'd heard about it. He hadn't believed it. She stood in front of the Queen, the real one, in her plain black armor with her owl-mask torn off, and swung her father's sword, and men in ash-grey simply went backwards. Like waves breaking on a rock. She didn't speak. She didn't shout. She just stood there, square and steady and immovable, exactly the way Garrick had stood at the gate of Fort Caldris, and nobody got past her.

And behind her, the Queen of Caldor tore off her silver feather mask and pulled a slim straight sword out of the folds of her gown, and stood at Elowen's shoulder with it raised. Her dark eyes were blazing.

"SORN," she shouted. Up at the gallery. "*You called this a regency? I am the Queen of Caldor, and I was Kindled a Sovereign, and I will not be protected.**"

Lex had forgotten. *Sovereign. Epic.* He felt it come off her, a great bright gold-silver wave, rolling out across the ballroom. Not an attack. A *command*. The way the old kings of Caldor had commanded, before the Order ever set a Ceiling on them. *Stand with me.*

And all around the ballroom, behind the masks, people stood.

Not all of them. But many. Lords and ladies in silk and velvet, merchants in cloth-of-gold, pulling off their masks, picking up chairs and candlesticks and the swords of fallen men in ash-grey. Standing with their Queen.



LEX WENT FOR HIS father.

He went through the fight like a man wading through a river in flood. He didn't use his gold. He didn't use Flame. He didn't need to. He was the biggest man in the room except Dorran, and he'd swung a hammer every day for ten years, and when a man in ash-grey came at him with a sword, he simply caught the man's wrist and squeezed until the sword fell out of it.

He reached Arion. His father was still on his knees. The silver-black chain wound around him. His face grey. His eyes ordinary and dark and very, very tired.

"Go," said Arion. Hoarse. "*Lex, go. The Hollowmaw. Don't waste time on—*"

"Be quiet," said Lex.

He knelt. He took out Aurelian's hammer.

He looked at the chain. Not with True Sight. With a smith's eye. Fine silver-black links, each one perfect, each one forged by someone who knew what they were doing. Severance chains. Made by the Order three hundred years ago in a secret forge under the Spire, to cut sorcerers off from the Lattice. Very well made.

But *made*.

And everything that was made had a flaw.

Find the maker's flaw, he thought. *Strike there*.

He listened. With the hammer in his hand. The way he'd listened to the Umbral Wardens on the moor. The way he'd listened to iron in the coals since he was twelve years old.

There. In the forty-third link. A place where the smith who'd made it, three hundred years ago, had been tired, or distracted, or thinking about his supper. A seam. A tiny place where the metal hadn't quite fused.

Tink.

The chain fell apart.

All of it. Every link. Unfolding, uncoiling, sliding off Arion's shoulders onto the polished floor in a jangling silver-black heap, like a dead snake.

SEVERANCE CHAIN — UNMADE

Unmaking → Novice 7

And the gold came back into his father's eyes.

Arion took a breath. A long shuddering breath, like a man coming up from deep water. He looked down at the chain on the floor. Then at his son.

"How did you—"

"Everything that's made has a flaw," said Lex. "Even you." He held out his hand. "Get up, Father. We've got to go."



DORRAN HAD KELL.

Lex saw it as he pulled his father to his feet. The giant had walked straight through the fight to her, ignoring the men in ash-grey, ignoring the

swords that glanced off his old leather coat. Kell had tried to stop him. With her hand. With her voice. With the Sanction that wasn't there anymore. Nothing happened.

And Dorran Vask had picked her up.

Not violently. Not cruelly. He'd simply put his huge hands under her arms and lifted her off her feet, the High Warden of the Order, the most powerful woman in Caldor for twenty years, and held her there. At eye level. Like a child.

"Four thousand one hundred and nine," said Dorran. His voice was very quiet. *"Children. I put my hand on their shoulders and closed their lids. Because you told me it kept them safe."*

Kell didn't answer. She hung in his grip, her ragged silver hair falling in her face, her pale eyes staring at him.

"It didn't keep them safe," said Dorran. *"It kept them small. It kept them yours."* He looked at her for a long moment. *"I'm not going to hurt you, Commander. I've hurt enough people for you."*

And he set her down. Gently. On her feet. And stepped back.

Kell stood there. Swaying. Looking at him.

And then the air behind her opened.

A keyhole. Black. Cutting through the world. And a gloved hand came out of it, and closed on her arm, and *pulled*. And she went backwards into it, into the dark, without a sound. And the keyhole closed.

Up on the gallery, Lex saw another one open. Behind Sorn. The Lord Chancellor was already backing toward it, his elegant face white, his beautiful voice silent. He looked down at the ballroom one last time. At the Queen with her sword raised. At the court of Caldor standing with her. At his ruined coup.

He went into the keyhole. It closed.



IT WAS OVER IN less than an hour.

The men in ash-grey threw down their swords when Kell vanished. Most of them, anyway. A few ran, and Fenn's Keepers caught them on the Crown Terrace. The rest knelt on the polished ballroom floor with their hands on their heads while the court of Caldor stood around them in torn

silk and broken masks, breathing hard, staring at each other as if they'd never seen each other before.

Wren came down out of the air and landed beside Lex. Barefoot. Her green gown torn to the knee. Her hair coming down in a wild red tangle. Her fox-mask hanging from one ear.

"*Well*," she said. "*That was a party.*"

He laughed. He couldn't help it. And she grinned at him, wild and fierce, and kissed him, quick and hard, in the middle of the wrecked ballroom.

"*Now go*," she said. "*Your brother.*"

He was already turning. To his father. Arion was standing by the heap of broken chain, gold back in his eyes, but pale. Very pale. The Severance had taken something out of him that hadn't come back yet.

"Can you still do it?" said Lex. "The Stones. Walk the threads."

"Yes." His father's jaw was set. "It'll cost more now. I'm weaker. But yes. For two."

"Me and Wren."

"*Me and Wren*," Wren agreed.

"*And me*," said Dorran Vask, coming up behind them with his hammer. "*I'm not as fast. But I'll follow.*"

Lex looked around for the others. The twins on the gallery rail. Oriel on her bench by the wall, entirely unruffled, in her red shawl.

"*Kestrel*," he said. "*Has anyone seen—*"

And then it hit him.

Not a sound. Not a sight. A *feeling*. Through the Bloodbond. Through the deep gold thread that ran from him across three hundred miles of mountains and valleys to the other end, where his brother was.

Pain.

Not Lex's. Antho's. Sudden and enormous, like a blow to the chest. And under it, rising up through the Bloodbond like water through a cracked floor, something cold. Something dark. The Hollow. Pressing.

And a voice. Antho's. Not words. Just—his brother, in the Bloodbond, calling. The way he'd called once before, years ago, in the dark of the Hollowmaw, when the breach had nearly taken him.

Lex.

Lex staggered. Wren caught his arm.

"What—"

"He's there," said Lex. His voice came out strange. *"Elric. He's at the Hollowmaw. He's—"*

He felt it then. Through the Bloodbond. Faint and far but unmistakable. A cut. A slice through a Vey ward, deep under a mountain, under a door of black glass. Something that had been sealed for nine hundred years by Aurelian's own blood, opening.

Because someone had wet it with *more* of Aurelian's blood.

Lex's blood.

On a rag. From the edge of a crater in the Glass Desert.

"Kestrel," he whispered.

Across the ruined ballroom, on her bench by the wall, Oriel Sant turned her white eyes toward him. Her face was very sad.

"Two fires," she said softly. *"I told you, smith. I'm sorry."*

CHAPTER 14

THE GATHERING STORM



Tonight.

The voice through the door said it at dusk. Not singing. Not *not yet*. Just the one word, low and rough, through the black glass, while Antho stood with his palm pressed flat against it and the clay lamp leaning in its niche.

Tonight, love. He's coming tonight.

Antho took his hand away from the glass.

He didn't ask how she knew. He'd stopped asking. For three weeks since he came back from the Drowned Country with a storm-mother and a hole in his memory, the voice had spoken to him every night at the end of the count. And every night it had been right. *Rain tomorrow. There's a crack in the north passage; mend it. The little one who doesn't talk is having nightmares; sit with him.* Small things. True things. As if whoever was on the other side of the door could see the Hollowmaw better than he could.

As if she'd been watching it for a long time.

"How many?" he said to the glass.

Silence.

Then, very faintly: *All of them.*



HE WENT UP THE long passage counting.

One thousand one hundred and eleven. One thousand one hundred and ten. Backwards. Up through the deep part of the mountain, past the bell-shaped cavern and the library and the cold-room and the great carved

hall, toward the mouth of the cave. Every lantern lit. Every lantern steady. Gold light on black rock.

Four hundred. Three hundred.

The students were in the hall. Nine of them, and Seraphine, and Brannoc and Hedda, who'd arrived two weeks ago on a cart full of iron and opinions and had been arguing with each other about the Keep's drainage ever since. They all looked up when Antho came in.

He didn't have to say anything. They saw his face.

"*Tonight*," said Seraphine. Not a question.

"Yes."

Brannoc got up from the bench. He was sixty-one now, bald as an egg, his great beard gone grey, and his knees cracked when he stood. But his shoulders were still the shoulders of a man who'd swung a hammer every day for fifty years, and the hammer in his hand was the biggest in the Ashbourne forge.

"*Right*," he said. "*Where d'you want me, lad?*"



HE PUT THEM WHERE he'd planned. He'd planned for three weeks. Every night after the count, at the table in the library with Seraphine's maps spread out and Roole's Keeper-Captain, a scarred quiet woman named Harrow Ves, sitting across from him.

The Keepers on the slopes. Three hundred of them, in their grey coats, in three lines across the long green shoulder of the mountain below the cave mouth. Pikes and crossbows and Ward-scribers. Good soldiers. Roole had sent his best.

The students in the deep hall, with the door shut and barred. Odile in charge. *If anything comes through that door that isn't me or Seraphine, you go down the north passage to the cold-room and out through the old water-shaft. All of you. Don't come back.*

We're not children, Master Antho, Odile had said.

No. You're my students. That's worse.

Brannoc and Hedda at the cave mouth, with the forge-iron they'd brought. Bars and spikes and a great barricade of it, built across the mouth of the Hollowmaw in two weeks of hammering. Hedda had painted runes

on every bar. *Steadfast* and *Bulwark* and one Antho didn't recognize, which she said was her own, and which she refused to explain.

Seraphine with him. Down at the door. With the steel crossbow Lex had made her four years ago, the one that wouldn't load upside down.

And in the sky, the dragons.

Vharuun had recovered, a little. Three weeks of mountain air and sun and Ashka bringing her goats (not Correspondence; Antho had been very firm about Correspondence). Her scales were storm-blue again in great patches, and her one good eye was bright gold. She still couldn't fly well. But she could rise. And she could breathe thunder.

And Ashka had grown again. Antho didn't know how. Something her mother had given her in the drowned square, in that long slow breath of storm. She was bigger. Brighter. Lightning didn't just crawl along her sides now. It *lived* there. When she flew, the air behind her crackled and smelled of rain.

They perched on the crags above the Hollowmaw, mother and daughter, black against the dusk. Watching the sky.



HE SAT WITH PIM before it started.

The boy was in the hall with the others, on his bench at the end of the front row, knees pulled up. Antho sat down beside him. Didn't say anything. Pim didn't either.

They sat for a while.

"*Is it the old man?*" said Pim.

It was the third thing he'd ever said. Antho kept count.

"Yes."

"*The one who makes people disappear.*"

"Yes."

Pim was quiet. Then: "*Will he make you disappear?*"

Antho looked at him. Thin and grave and twelve years old. With eyes that had seen a man in Kessick take off his belt.

"I don't know," said Antho honestly. "He'll try."

Pim nodded. Slowly. As if this were what he'd expected.

Then he reached out, without looking, and put his small cold hand on Antho's wrist. And left it there. The way Antho had put his hand on Corin Bell's shoulder on Ashka's back, months ago. The way Lex used to put his hand on Antho's sleeve, on the woodpile.

He didn't say anything else. He didn't need to.



IT STARTED AT MIDNIGHT.

Antho was at the door. Seraphine beside him with her crossbow. The cavern quiet. The clay lamp burning straight up in its niche.

And then every lantern in the Hollowmaw flickered.

All of them. At once. All one thousand one hundred and eleven. A single great shudder of gold light running up the walls and across the ceiling of the bell-shaped cavern and away up the passage, like a breath of wind across a field of candles.

They didn't go out. But Antho felt it. Felt something pass *through* the mountain. Something cold.

He's here, said the voice through the door.

And from far above, faint through a mile of rock, he heard the Keepers' horns.



ELRIC DIDN'T COME UP the mountain.

He came *through* it.

Antho learned that later, from Harrow Ves, who saw it from the slopes. Keyholes. Dozens of them. Opening in the air all over the long green shoulder of the mountain below the cave mouth, black and jagged, like rips in a painted cloth. And through them, shadows. Umbral Wardens. Not forty. Not a hundred.

Hundreds.

"He's been making them," Harrow Ves said, afterward, with blood drying on her face. *"Folding them. Out of something. I don't know what. They just kept coming out of the holes."*

And behind the shadows, men. In ash-grey. Two hundred of them, Kell's last loyal swords, coming through the keyholes in disciplined ranks with shields locked and crossbows raised.

The Keepers held. For a long time, they held. Three hundred against two hundred men and an endless river of shadows. The Ward-scribers drew glyphs in the air that burned silver and held the shadows back. The crossbowmen fired volley after volley. The pikemen stood their ground.

And above them, the storm broke.

Vharuun rose off the crags with a sound like the mountain splitting. Not fast. Not graceful. But *enormous*, a ragged storm-blue shadow against the stars, wings like the sails of a warship. And she breathed.

Thunder. A great rolling wall of it, pouring down out of her jaws onto the slope. Not lightning. *Sound*. A pressure-wave of storm that hit the advancing shadows like a hammer hitting glass. The Umbral Wardens didn't burn. Thunder couldn't burn them. But it *scattered* them. Tore them apart, the way wind tears smoke. They came back together, slowly, rippling. But it bought time.

And Ashka came down behind her mother like a spear of lightning.

She didn't breathe. She *dove*. Straight down into the mass of men in ash-grey, crackling white from nose to tail, and lightning leapt off her in every direction, forking, branching, finding steel. Shields. Swords. Helmets. Men went flying.

From the cave mouth, Brannoc Holt watched a storm-drake the size of a barn come down on two hundred armored men like the wrath of the sky, and said, very quietly, to no one: "*Well. I'll be damned.*"

Hedda Vorne, beside him, hefted her cudgel. "*Language,*" she said.



DOWN AT THE DOOR, Antho felt all of it.

Not with his ears. With Shade. The great cold quiet hearing that went out through the mountain like water through sand. He felt the Keepers on the slope, their fear, their resolve, the shape of the silence around each of them. He felt the shadows, hundreds of them, cold and empty. He felt the dragons, burning.

And he felt the moment Elric came into the mountain.

Not through the cave mouth. Not through Brannoc's barricade. Through the *rock*. A keyhole opened in the passage halfway down, between the library and the cold-room, cutting through solid stone like a knife

through cheese. And Elric Thorne stepped out of it into the gold-lit passage of the Hollowmaw, with two pieces of the Key of Shadows hanging black at his throat.

And beside him, red-haired, burning, a woman Antho had never seen.

"*Seraphine,*" said Antho. Very quietly. "*Go to the hall. Now. Get the students out.*"

"*Antho—*"

"*Now.*"

She looked at him. Then she went. Running, up the long passage, with her crossbow in her hands. He heard her footsteps fading.

He turned back to the door. And the lamp.

Here he comes, said the voice through the glass. *Oh, my love. Here he comes.*



ELRIC DIDN'T HURRY.

Antho heard him coming down the passage. Unhurried footsteps. And the lanterns going out.

One by one. As Elric passed them. Not blown out. *Cut.* Antho felt each one go. A small gold thread, snapped. *Four hundred and twelve. Four hundred and eleven. Four hundred and ten.*

He was counting them backwards. He couldn't stop.

Three hundred. Two hundred and ninety-nine.

The passage behind Elric went dark. A long tongue of black, coming down into the mountain, swallowing the gold.

Two hundred.

And then Elric came around the last bend into the bell-shaped cavern, and stopped.

He looked at the cavern. The high round walls, hung with lanterns. The black floor. The door of black glass at the bottom. The little clay lamp in its niche. And Antho, standing in front of it, with his staff in one hand and the Keeper's Lantern in the other.

"*Antho,*" said Elric. Almost gently. "*You look well. Better than the last time.*"

The last time had been Duskhold. A black corridor. Antho on his knees, with his Clarity shattered, and Elric standing over him.

"*You don't,*" said Antho.

It was true. Elric looked *younger*. Forty, perhaps. His hair was dark at the roots now, the grey growing out. His face was firm. But something about it was wrong. Too smooth. Too still. Like a mask of his own face, slightly too tight.

And his eyes. They'd always been brown. Warm, clever, tired brown.

They were darker now. Much darker. Almost black.

"*The Key has been kind to me,*" said Elric. "*Fifty-five threads. Every one of them gave me a little of what they had.*" He touched the black thing at his throat. "*I feel thirty again. Do you know what that's like? To be old, and tired, and slow, and then not?*"

"No."

"*Your father does.*" Elric's mouth twisted. "*Your father has never once in his life been old.*"

Behind him, the red-haired woman had stopped at the edge of the cavern. She was staring at Antho. At the door. At the lamp. Her face was white. And beside her—

Antho went very still.

Beside her stood a young man. Faint. Pale. Barely there. Thin and dark-haired, in a farmer's smock. Antho could see the black rock of the cavern wall through his chest.

And with Grave-Speech, with the old cold hearing that let him speak to things at the edge of being, Antho could *hear* him.

"*Please,*" the faint young man was saying. Over and over. To the red-haired woman. To Antho. To anyone. "*Please. Stop her. Don't let her do this. Not for me. Please.*"

The red-haired woman couldn't hear him. Antho could see that. She stood with her fists clenched at her sides and fire burning low in her hair and stared at the door.



"*I'm going to open the floor now,*" said Elric. "*Under the lamp. That's where he put it. Aurelian. He buried the blade right under the door, so he could*

guard it from both sides." He looked at the clay lamp in its niche. *"Your mother's lamp is sitting on top of it. Did you know? Nine hundred years of buried shadow, and a little clay lamp from the Ashbourne market sitting on top of it like a paperweight."*

"Don't touch it."

"I won't have to." Elric held out his hand toward the red-haired woman, without looking at her. *"Kestrel."*

She didn't move.

"Kestrel," said Elric again. Patient. *"We had an arrangement."*

Slowly, she reached into her coat. And took out something small and brown and stiff. A rag. Twisted and filthy, stained dark.

Antho knew what it was before he could see it properly. He felt it. Through the Bloodbond. A tiny piece of his brother. His blood. Dried brown on a scrap of cloth.

"Where did you get that," he said. Very quietly.

Kestrel looked at him. Her amber eyes were wet.

"The Glass Desert," she said. *"He cut his hand on a door, and wrapped it in this, and threw it away. And I picked it up."* Her voice cracked. *"I'm sorry. I'm so sorry. He took my brother."*

"He took fifty-five brothers," said Antho. *"And sisters. And mothers. And—"*

"I know." It came out of her like a sob. *"I KNOW. Don't you think I know?"*

Beside her, Tamsin Varn was weeping. *Kes, Kes, please, Kes.*

She held out the rag to Elric.



ANTHO MOVED.

He didn't think. He didn't plan. He'd planned for three weeks, and none of it mattered now. He came across the cavern floor in three long strides with the Lantern swinging in his hand and his staff coming up, and he threw everything he had at Elric Thorne.

Void Bolt. Not one. Six. A hail of them, black and silent, the cold empty nothing-stuff of Shade, hurled from his staff like stones from a sling. Shadowbind, wrapping around Elric's legs, his arms, his chest. Gale, a great

howling gust of wind, slamming across the cavern to tear the rag out of Kestrel's hand.

Elric turned the Key.

And it all stopped.

Not blocked. Not deflected. *Stopped.* The Void Bolts hung in the air, frozen, halfway across the cavern. The Shadowbind went slack and fell away like cut rope. The wind died in mid-howl.

"*Oh, Antho,*" said Elric. Very gently. "*Don't you understand yet? It's a key. Everything the Lattice gives you, it can lock. Or unlock.*" He looked at the frozen Void Bolts. "*Your skills are just doors. And I have the key to every door in the world.*"

He turned it again. The other way.

And the Void Bolts turned around in the air and came back at Antho.



HE GOT THE LANTERN up in time. Just. The Hush-runes on its glass flared white and the Void Bolts hit the circle of gold light around him and shattered, one after another, like black glass on stone. Each one hit like a hammer. He went backwards. One step. Two. His boots skidding on the black floor.

[He's going to kill you,] said the Murmur. Calmly. *[He's going to kill you, and then he's going to open the floor, and then he's going to have the whole key. And you'll have done nothing. Again.]*

"Be quiet."

[I'm only saying—]

He held the Lantern up. *Voices can't act through you while it's lit.* The Murmur went silent.

And Elric turned the Key toward *him*.

He felt it. The hook. Going into his chest. Into his thread. Not the gold-and-silver cord Lex had. Something stranger. Antho's thread was twisted. Gold, yes, the Root, the blood of the Veys. But wound through it, the old dark of the Hollow. The link he'd carried for eleven years. Dormant now. Quiet. But *there*.

The Key found it. And *pulled*.

He went to his knees.

It didn't hurt. Lex had told him that, in a letter: *it doesn't hurt, that's the worst of it, it's like falling asleep*. He'd thought he understood. He hadn't. It was like the grey river. Like walking into the forgetting mist with no Lantern and no fee paid. His name going soft. His edges blurring.

Anthoren. Anthoren V—

He tried to hold. The way he'd held the breach. The way he'd held the Hollow-chains in the drowned square while Ashka bit through them. Hold *still*. Hold *on*.

But he was holding against two pieces of the Key of Shadows. And Elric had fifty-five people's worth of strength behind him.

He felt himself start to fade.



A HAND CLOSED ON his wrist.

Small. Cold. A boy's hand.

He hadn't heard Pim come. He never heard Pim come. The boy was just *there*, kneeling beside him on the black floor of the cavern, in front of the door. He must have slipped away from the others in the hall. Come down the dark passage alone, past the cut lanterns, through the black.

He had his hand on Antho's wrist. And his eyes were closed. And he was *listening*.

And around Antho, the silence changed shape.

Antho felt it. The way he felt Shade. The great cold quiet that lived in the space between heartbeats. But this wasn't his. This was Pim's. A boy who'd spent his whole life listening to the dark because it was the only thing that had ever been kind to him. And now he was pulling that dark around Antho like a blanket. Like a cloak. Like a lampshade over a light.

Hiding him.

The hook in Antho's thread slipped.

Not out. But *sideways*. As if it had been pulling on a rope, and the rope had suddenly gone slack and dark and hard to find. Elric's face changed. He frowned. Turned the Key. Searched.

"*What—*" he said.

And from behind Antho, from the other side of the door, through the black glass, a voice spoke.

Not to Antho. Not to Pim. To Elric.
Low and rough and very, very cold.
Let go of my son.



ELRIC FROZE.

Antho saw it. Saw him go white. Saw the dark eyes go wide. Saw his hand on the Key go still.

"Seren," Elric whispered.

Let go of him, Elric Thorne. You were my husband's friend for forty years. You held my boys when they were babies. You sang to Antho when he had the croup. The voice through the glass was shaking. *Let go.*

"You're dead," said Elric. His voice was strange. "You're—you went into the dark. Eleven years ago. You're—"

I'm on the other side of a door, said the voice. *Holding it shut. With everything I have. Against the thing that's been whispering in your ear.* A pause. *Do you know what it is, Elric? Have you ever asked yourself? What's been telling you where to dig?*

Elric didn't answer. He stood in the middle of the cavern with the Key at his throat and his face white.

It's not Aurelian, said the voice through the door. *Not anymore. Not for eight hundred years. It's wearing his face. It's using his voice. And it's using you. The way it's tried to use every one of us.*

For one long moment, Elric Thorne stood absolutely still.

And Antho, on his knees on the black floor with Pim's hand on his wrist, saw something in the man's face crack. Just a little. Like the first fine line in a sheet of ice.

And then the other voice came.

Not through the door. From *inside* Elric. From the Key at his throat. Warm and kind and gentle as a hand on his hair.

She's lying, Elric. She's been in the dark too long. It's changed her. She wants the door shut because she wants you to stay small. Like Arion did. Like they all did. A pause. *They've always wanted you to stay second.*

Elric's face closed.

Like a door slamming.

"*Kestrel*," he said. Very quietly. Not looking away from the black glass.
"*The rag*."



SHE GAVE IT TO him.

Antho saw her do it. Saw her hand shaking. Saw her face, white and wet and twisted with something that looked like hatred, though Antho couldn't tell who it was for. Saw Tamsin beside her, screaming silently, *Kes, Kes, no*.

She put the rag in Elric's gloved hand.

And Elric knelt. In front of the niche. In front of the little clay lamp burning there. And pressed the rag, stained brown with Lex's blood, flat against the black stone floor beneath it.

The floor *opened*.

Not cracked. Not broke. Opened, like a mouth. A circle of black stone, a pace across, directly beneath the niche, folding back on itself in a spiral, like the petals of a flower opening in reverse. And under it, darkness. Deep. Cold. Breathing.

And from the darkness, rising slowly on a column of something that wasn't stone and wasn't shadow, the Blade.

Long. Thin. Black. A shaft as long as Antho's forearm, perfectly straight, perfectly smooth, so dark it seemed to drink the light from the lanterns around it. The part of a key that connects the bow to the bit. The part that goes into the lock.

Elric reached out and took it.



THE LAMP WENT OUT.

Antho felt it before he saw it. A small gold thread, snapping. The little clay lamp in the niche, the one he and Lex had carried down the long passage three years ago, the one that had lit every lantern in the mountain. Its flame shrank. Flickered. Went blue.

And went out.

And on the other side of the door, Antho heard his mother scream.

Not in pain. In *effort*. A long, terrible, straining cry, like someone holding up something far too heavy for far too long, and feeling it start to slip.

The black glass of the door *bulged*.

Toward him. Outward. Like a soap bubble pushed from the inside. And through it, faint and terrible, he felt the Hollow. Pressing. Hungry. *Awake*. The thing at the bottom of the world, that had been sealed under the Lattice for nine hundred years, leaning on the door with all its weight.

Because the Blade had been holding it shut. Nine hundred years under the floor. A piece of Aurelian's shadow, pinning the lid down from this side, while Seren held it from the other.

And now it was gone.

Antho. His mother's voice. Strained. Breaking. *Antho, the lamp. Light the lamp. I can't—I can't hold it alone—*



ELRIC STOOD UP WITH the Blade in his hand.

He didn't look at the door. He didn't look at Antho. He held the Blade up to his throat, where the Bow and the Bit hung joined on their black chain. And brought them together.

Click.

Three pieces. One key. Long and black and perfect, as long as a man's arm, with a looped bow and a straight shaft and a bit of jagged teeth like a mountain range. Exactly as Lex had described it, from Ysmir's window of ice. Exactly as Aurelian had forged it nine hundred years ago, on a gold anvil, under stars too close and too bright.

The Key of Shadows. Whole.

And every lantern in the Hollowmaw went out.



ALL OF THEM. ONE thousand one hundred and eleven. At once. Not cut. *Swallowed*. Like candles in a gale. The gold light of the cavern vanishing all at once and the dark coming down like a lid.

Antho couldn't see. He couldn't see anything. Just black. Absolute. The black of the inside of the world.

And in the black, Elric's voice. Very quiet. Very calm.

 WORLD NOTICE

THE KEY OF SHADOWS IS WHOLE.

"Thank you, Antho," said Elric. "And thank you, Kestrel. I said I would keep my word. I always keep my word."

Antho heard the Key turn.

Not toward him. Toward the place where the red-haired woman was standing.

And in the black, a light. Faint. Silver. A thread, being written. Being woven, strand by strand, out of nothing, the way a spider spins silk. Coming together. Getting brighter.

And a young man's voice. Not faint. Not a whisper. *Real*. Rough and shaking and *loud*.

"KES—"



SOMEWHERE FAR AWAY, ANTHO heard the Keepers' horns change.

Not the alarm. The *other* call. The one Harrow Ves had taught them for if things went very badly or very well. Three long notes, rising.

Reinforcements.

And through the Bloodbond, so close now he almost cried out, he felt his brother.

Lex.



THEY CAME OUT OF the Stone at Hollow's Foot at a dead run.

Lex had never walked the threads before. His father had done it for them. Standing at the Great Stone in the Spire with his hands on its silver face and the gold coming up in him so bright that Wren had had to look away. *Hold on to me. Don't let go. Whatever you see, don't let go.* And then the Spire had gone away. And Lex had been *in* the net. Rushing. Silver threads blurring past on every side like rain seen from a galloping horse. Wren's hand in his, crushing his fingers. And somewhere behind them, getting fainter, his father's voice: *Go. Go. I'll hold the thread as long as I can.*

And then the Stone at Hollow's Foot. The little Stone in the valley below the Hollowmaw, that Lex had Unbound himself two summers ago. Coming up around them like water. And spitting them out onto the wet grass of a valley full of fire and thunder.

He saw the mountain.

Saw the long green slope below the cave mouth, black now with fighting. Grey coats and ash-grey coats. Shadows, hundreds of them, swarming. Two dragons in the sky, one vast and ragged and one bright as a lightning bolt, pouring storm down onto the slope. And at the top of it, the great cleft of the Hollowmaw.

Dark.

Not a single lantern. Not one.

"*Antho*," he said.

Wren was already stepping up onto the wind.



HE DIDN'T REMEMBER THE climb.

He remembered fire. His own. Flame, pouring out of him the way it had poured out of the Sunwell, gold-white and roaring. Not borrowed this time. *His*. Every channel that the Sunwell's fire had blistered and burned in the Glass Desert had healed thicker, stronger, the way a smith's hands callus. He went up the slope through the shadows like a forge-fire through kindling.

He remembered Wren. Above him. Stepping on the wind, her bow singing, arrows burning gold. She was still wearing the torn green gown from the masquerade. He'd remember that later and laugh. He didn't laugh now.

He remembered Brannoc at the cave mouth. Grey and bloody, standing on Hedda's barricade with his great hammer in both hands, and his face when he saw Lex coming up the slope. Something breaking open in it. *Lad. Lad.*

He didn't stop.

He went into the dark of the Hollowmaw with fire in his hands, down the long passage where every lantern was out. Down past the hall, where nine children were huddled behind a barred door with Seraphine and a

steel crossbow. Down past the library and the cold-room. Down and down.

Into the bell.



IT WAS DARK.

His fire lit it. The great round cavern, black-walled. Hung with a thousand dead lanterns. And at the bottom, the door.

Bulging.

Lex had never seen anything so wrong. The smooth black glass of the sealed breach, bowed outward like the belly of a sail, straining, creaking, a web of fine cracks spreading across its surface. And from behind it, a sound. Low. Enormous. Like the breathing of something the size of the world.

In front of it, on his knees, Antho. With a small dark-haired boy kneeling beside him, gripping his wrist. Both of them with their hands pressed flat against the bulging glass. Holding it. Antho's face grey and running with sweat. The boy's eyes screwed shut.

To one side, a red-haired woman on her knees on the black floor. Clutching someone. A young man. Thin and dark-haired, in a farmer's smock. *Solid. Whole.* Real enough to touch. She had her arms around him and her face buried in his shoulder, and she was sobbing, great broken sobs that shook her whole body. And Tamsin Varn, *real*, with color in his face and blood in his cheeks, was holding his sister and staring over her head at the bulging door with his face full of horror.

And in the center of the cavern, Elric Thorne.

With a key in his hand. Long and black. Whole.

He turned when Lex came in. He looked at him. At the fire pouring off his hands.

"Lex," he said. "*You're late.*"

"*Put it down.*"

"No." Elric looked at the Key in his hand. At its long black shaft. Its teeth. "*No, I don't think I will.*" He looked up. "*You should help your brother. The door won't hold much longer. Not without the blade. Not*

without the lamp." A pause. *"Your mother's been holding it alone from the other side for eleven years. She's very tired."*

Lex went cold.

"She's—"

"Alive." Elric's mouth twisted. *"In a manner of speaking. Ask your father. He's known for three years."* He turned the Key, very slightly, and a keyhole opened in the air behind him. *"I'll see you at the end, Lex. At the lid. When I turn this, and everything changes."*

"Elric—"

"And Lex." Elric looked back. And for a moment, just a moment, his strange dark eyes were brown again. Tired. Clever. Old. *"It said I'd always be second. Your mother said it was lying."* He was quiet. *"I'd like to know which of them was right. Before the end."*

He stepped backwards into the keyhole.

It closed.



LEX DIDN'T GO AFTER him.

He couldn't. The door groaned. A sound like a ship's timbers breaking. A crack ran across the black glass from side to side, and through it, for one terrible instant, Lex felt the Hollow. The real Hollow. Not the shallows Antho had walked in. The deep. The *hungry*. A cold so enormous it wasn't cold anymore, just *absence*, pressing against the thin black skin of the door like a flood against a dam.

He dropped to his knees beside his brother. Put his own hands flat on the glass.

And *pushed*.

With Stone. With the mountain. With the deep old patient bones of the Greyspine, which had held this breach before, and didn't want to see it open again. With Flame, pouring gold-white heat into the black glass until it glowed red and steamed. With the Root, Authority, everything he had left after Kell and the Spire and the long walk through the threads.

It wasn't enough.

He felt it. The door was bending. Slowly. Inch by inch. Three of them holding it, two Veys and a boy who heard the dark, and it wasn't enough.

The lamp, said a voice through the glass. Strained. Breaking. A voice Lex hadn't heard in eleven years, and had never stopped hearing. *Lex. Lex, love. Light the lamp.*

He looked at the niche. At the little clay lamp. Dark. Cold. A chip in its spout and a thumbprint in its base.

His mother's lamp. That he and Antho had carried down this passage three years ago, and sung to, and watched light every lantern in the mountain.

He reached out, with one hand still on the bulging door. And touched it.

And *Spoke* to Flame.

Not Commanded. Not asked. *Spoke*. The way he'd spoken to the Sunwell. The way he talked to the forge-fire every morning when he lit it. *Hello. It's me. I need you.*

Please.

And the lamp lit.

Not with his fire. With its own. A small, steady, golden flame, rising up out of the cold clay as if it had only been sleeping. The same flame. The same warm summer-evening smell.

And one by one, all around the cavern, then up the passage, then all through the mountain, the lanterns of the Hollowmaw came back.



THE DOOR STOPPED BULGING.

Slowly. Like a breath let out. The black glass sinking back. Flattening. The crack across its face still there, a long jagged line from side to side. But holding. *Holding*.

From the other side, faint, so faint Lex almost didn't hear it:

Thank you, love.

And then nothing.

Lex knelt in front of the door with his hands on the glass and his brother beside him and a small boy holding his brother's wrist, and the lanterns burning gold all around them, and couldn't move.

Mam.

She's alive. She's on the other side of the door. She's been holding it for eleven years.

And Father knew.

He turned his head and looked at Antho.

His brother was grey. Exhausted. His face slick with sweat, his hands trembling on the glass. But his eyes were open. Grey and dark and steady. Looking at Lex.

"*You came,*" said Antho.

"*I came.*"

"*Late.*"

"I know. I'm sorry." Lex's voice cracked. "There was a party."

Something moved at the corner of Antho's mouth. Almost a smile.

They knelt together in front of the cracked door for a long time. Not speaking. Breathing. The lanterns burning gold around them. Pim had let go of Antho's wrist and slumped against his side, asleep, or something like it.

And then Lex said, because it was the thing he always said, the thing they always came back to, the thing that had been in his head the whole long run through the threads and up the burning slope:

"When this is done. When it's over. We'll go to your lake. On the other side of the Teeth. And skip stones." He tried to smile. "I'll beat you this time. I'll get six."

Antho looked at him.

Puzzled. Gently puzzled. The way you look at someone who's mentioned a friend you've never met.

"*Six?*" he said. "*Six what?*"

Lex stopped.

"Skips," he said. "The stone. At the millpond. When I was ten. You told me it was four, and it was five, and you told me the truth on the Founders' Road, under the stars, and I laughed until I couldn't—" He stopped again. "Antho. You remember. The five-skip stone. You—you *counted*. You always count."

Antho's face didn't change. Grey and dark and steady. And very, very sad.

"I paid the Ferryman," he said quietly. "To cross. To find Ashka's mother." He looked at his brother. "He takes the memory you'd least want to lose."

He put his scarred hand over Lex's on the black glass of the door.

"I don't remember, Lex," said Antho. "I'm sorry. Tell me. Tell me about the stone."

CHAPTER 15

OLD ALLIES, NEW



HE TOLD ANTHO ABOUT the stone at dawn, sitting on the rock at the mouth of the Hollowmaw with the valley below them full of smoke.

He told it badly. He'd never been good at telling things. He started in the wrong place and had to go back. He forgot the heron and had to put it in later. He got the willows wrong, then right. And when he got to the part where Antho had picked him up and swung him round, his voice went, and he had to stop and look at the smoke for a while.

Antho listened.

He sat with his arms around his knees and his grey eyes on Lex's face and didn't interrupt once. He listened the way he listened to Shade: completely, with his whole body, as if every word were a sound in the dark that might matter.

When Lex had finished, Antho was quiet for a long time.

"Five," he said at last.

"Five."

"And I said four."

"You said four. For nine years."

"Why?"

Lex looked at him. "Because you'd never done more than four yourself. And you didn't want your little brother beating you on the first day he got it right." He swallowed. "You said you were a petty, jealous fifteen-year-old. You said you were sorry."

Antho thought about that.

"*That sounds like me,*" he said. "*At fifteen.*" Something moved at the corner of his mouth. "*It sounds like a good story.*"

"It's not a story. It happened."

"*I know.*" Antho looked down at his scarred hands. "*I believe you. I can feel where it was. There's a—a shape. In the dark. Where I used to keep it.*" He was quiet. "*But when you tell it, Lex, it's like hearing about two boys I never met. Nice boys. I'd like them.*" He looked up. "*I just don't remember being one of them.*"

Lex couldn't say anything.

Antho reached out and put his hand on the back of Lex's neck. The way he used to, when they were small. Lex hadn't known he remembered that.

"*Tell it again,*" said Antho. "*Tomorrow. And the day after. Until I know it the way you know it.*" His voice was very steady. "*It won't be the same. I know that. But it'll be something. It'll be yours, given to me. That's not nothing.*"

That's not nothing. Lex had heard someone say that before. He couldn't think who.

"Every day," he said. "I'll tell it every day."

"*Good.*" Antho took his hand away. He looked out at the smoking valley. "*And when this is over, we'll go to the lake. And you can show me. And I'll count.*"

"You always count."

"*Apparently,*" said Antho, "*I do.*"



FORTY-ONE KEEPERS HAD DIED on the slopes.

Harrow Ves read the names at noon, standing on Hedda's barricade at the mouth of the cave, with her face bandaged and her arm in a sling. Forty-one. Lex didn't know any of them. He made himself listen to every one.

Alder Penrose. Mattie Crewe. Holm Dacey. Sefton Ward.

He thought of the Ledger. Of the narrow elegant hand, writing a line under each name. *He brought the cows in every evening. She was learning to read.*

Nobody would write lines under these. They hadn't been unwritten. They'd only died. Their families would remember them, and grieve, and the names would be carved on a stone somewhere and weather away.

That's better, he thought. Isn't it? To be remembered and grieved. That's better than being forgotten.

He didn't know. He stood at the back of the crowd of grey-coated Keepers with his hands at his sides and listened to the names, and didn't know anything.

Brannoc had broken his arm. Hedda had set it, swearing at him the whole time. *Sixty-one years old, standing on a barricade like a boy, you great bald fool, what were you thinking.* He'd sat on a bench in the hall while she bound it, grinning at Lex through his grey beard like a man who'd just won a bet.

"Saw you come up that slope, lad," he said. "With the fire on you." He shook his head slowly. *"Never thought I'd see the like. Never in my life."*

"You taught me," said Lex.

"I taught you to make horseshoes." Brannoc looked at him. *"You did the rest yourself."*



HIS FATHER CAME AT sunset.

Out of the Stone at Hollow's Foot, the way Lex and Wren had come. Alone. Lex felt him arrive through the Root: a great bright gold thread, coming up out of the net in the valley below, and then *dimming*. Guttering. Like a candle in a draft.

He was halfway down the slope before he knew he'd moved.

Arion was on his knees in the wet grass beside the little Stone. His face was grey. His hands were shaking. He'd walked the threads twice in two days, the second time alone, the first time carrying two people, with Severance still raw on him from the masquerade. He looked up when Lex came running down the slope.

And for the first time in his life, Lex saw his father look *old*.

Not in his face. His face was the same. Lean and dark and forty-five forever. But in his eyes. Something tired. Something that had been carrying

a weight for a very long time, and had finally put it down, and couldn't pick it up again.

"Is he—" said Arion. Hoarse. "*Antho. The door. Is it—*"

"It's holding," said Lex. "Cracked. But holding."

His father closed his eyes.

"*And Seren?*"

Lex looked at him.

"*Elric told us,*" he said. Very quietly. "*Before he left. He said she's alive. On the other side of the door. Holding it. For eleven years.*" His voice didn't shake. He was proud of that, later. "*And he said you've known for three.*"

Arion didn't open his eyes.

"Yes," he said.



ANTHO WAS WAITING AT the door.

He hadn't come up to the cave mouth when Arion arrived. He hadn't come down the slope. He was sitting on the black floor of the bell-shaped cavern, in front of the cracked door, beside the little clay lamp in its niche. Pim was asleep against his side. The boy had barely left him since the night before.

He looked up when Lex and Arion came down the last long passage into the cavern. He didn't get up.

"*Father,*" he said.

Arion stopped at the bottom of the passage. Lex stopped beside him.

"*Antho.*"

"*Sit down,*" said Antho. "*You look terrible.*"

Arion sat. On the black floor. Across from his eldest son, with the cracked door between them and the lamp burning gold in its niche. Lex sat too. The three of them, in a ring, in front of the door.

Nobody said anything for a while.

"*Three years,*" said Antho at last.

"Yes."

"*You knew for three years.*"

"Yes."

"*How?*"

Arion looked at the lamp.

"The night you lit it," he said. "The two of you. Three years ago. After Duskhold." His voice was very low. "When every lantern in the mountain caught fire, I felt it. Through the Root. All the way from Highcrest." He swallowed. "And I felt something else. A thread. Very faint. Very far down. On the other side of the door, where no thread should be."

"Hers."

"Hers." Arion's hands were clenched in his lap. "I'd have known it anywhere. I've known it since I was a young man." He looked at Antho. "I thought I was mad. I thought it was grief. I went to the Great Stone at the Spire that night and put my hands on it and reached down, as far as I could reach, and—"

He stopped.

"And she spoke to you," said Lex.

"Yes."

"What did she say?"

His father was quiet for a long time.

"She said: Don't tell the boys."



ANTHO WENT VERY STILL.

"She said," said Arion, "that if you knew, you'd try to come for her. Both of you. You'd find a way. You always find a way." His voice cracked. "And to reach her, you'd have to open the door. And if the door opened, even a little, even for a moment, everything she'd been holding back for eight years would come out. Everything. The whole Hollow. Into the world." He looked at his sons. "She said she hadn't held it for eight years so that her boys could undo it out of love."

"And you agreed."

"I agreed." Arion looked at the door. "I sat in my rooms in the Spire every night for three years and talked to her through the Root, and held the door from my side as much as I could from three hundred miles away, and didn't tell you." His voice was very flat. "Wren heard me. Through the door of my rooms. She never asked. I think she guessed."

Hold on, love. Not much longer. Lex remembered Wren's face on the steps of the Spire. Careful. Knowing more than it was saying.

"You let me sit here," said Antho. *"Every night. For three years. Counting lanterns. Saying good evening to her lamp. Thinking it was just a lamp."* His voice was very quiet. *"And she could hear me. Every word. And you knew."*

"Yes."

"Why?"

"Because she asked me to," said Arion simply. *"And she's the only person in two hundred years I've never once said no to."*

Antho stared at him.

Lex heard it. *Two hundred years.* He filed it beside Wren's face on the steps of the Spire.

But Antho didn't seem to hear it at all. He was looking at the door.



HE GOT UP.

Carefully, so as not to wake Pim. He laid the boy down on the black floor with his coat under his head. Then he went and stood in front of the cracked black glass. And put his hand on it.

"Mam," he said.

Nothing. The lamp burned straight up in its niche.

"Mam. I know you're there. I know you can hear me."

Silence.

And then the flame leaned.

I'm here, love.

Faint. So faint. Fainter than it had been before the Blade was taken. Like a voice from the bottom of a very deep well. Tired, and strained, and rough as stone.

"Did you tell him not to tell us?"

A long pause.

Yes.

"Why?"

Because you'd have come for me. Both of you. And I couldn't let you. The voice was barely a breath. *Don't blame your father, love. Blame me. I made him promise. I knew what it would cost him. I asked anyway.*

Antho stood with his hand on the glass. His shoulders were shaking.

"I sat here," he said. "I sat here every night."

I know. I heard every word. A pause. One thousand one hundred and eleven. Every night. Never missed one. The faintest ghost of something that might have been a laugh. You always did count, Antho. Even when you were tiny. You'd count the stairs up to the loft. Every night. Out loud.

Antho made a sound Lex had never heard him make. He bent forward until his forehead touched the glass.

Lex, said the voice. Are you there too?

Lex was on his feet. He didn't remember standing. He came and stood beside his brother and put his hand on the glass beside Antho's.

"I'm here, Mam."

You've got so big. A pause. Both of you. I can feel it. Through the door. You've got so big. The voice wavered. I'm so proud of you. I'm so proud.

"Mam—" Lex's voice broke. "How do we get you out? How do we—"

You don't. Not yet. Very firm, suddenly. The voice of a woman who had made a decision a long time ago and would not be moved. The door has to stay shut. He has the Key now. Whole. He'll take it to the lock and turn it. And when he does, everything I've been holding will push from below, and the lid will lift, and the Key will hold it open. A pause. You have to stop him turning it. That's all that matters. Not me. Him.

"And you?"

I'll hold. As long as I can. The voice was fading. Light the lamp every night. Keep the door shut. And go.

"Mam—"

Go, my loves.

And the flame in the niche straightened, and burned straight up, and she was gone.



THEY STOOD THERE FOR a long time. Two brothers, with their hands on a cracked black door.

Behind them, their father hadn't moved. He sat on the black floor where he'd sat down, with his hands open in his lap. Lex looked back at him once. Arion's face was wet.

At last Antho took his hand off the glass. He turned. He looked down at their father.

"*She's holding it alone,*" he said. "*From the other side. She's been holding it alone for eleven years.*"

"Yes."

"*Someone has to hold this side. While we're gone.*"

"Yes," said Arion. And got up. Slowly. Like an old man. And came and stood in front of the door, between his sons, and put both his hands on the black glass.

"*I'll stay,*" he said.

Lex looked at him.

"*It's my turn,*" said Arion Vey quietly. "*I've stood at the front for two hundred years. I've given orders and made speeches and kept secrets and sent other people into the dark.*" He looked at the lamp. "*Eleven years she's held it alone. Eleven years while I slept in a crystal and then sat in a tower and talked to her through the Root from three hundred miles away.*" He shook his head slowly. "*No more. I'll keep the door. You two go and stop Elric.*"

"*Father—*" said Antho.

"*I'm not asking.*" Arion didn't look away from the glass. "*For once in my life, Antho, I'm not asking anyone's permission. I'm staying.*" His voice dropped. "*Close to her. As close as I can get.*"

Antho looked at him for a long, long moment.

Then he did something Lex had never seen him do. Not once. Not in Duskhold, when they'd freed their father from the crystal. Not on the plinth, in front of eleven thousand people, when Antho had said *I forgive you*.

He put his arms around their father. And held on.

Arion stood very still. Then his hands came off the glass, slowly, and closed on his son's back.

Lex stood beside them and looked at the lamp, and let them have it.

[*Lex,*] said Ember. Very quietly. [*He said two hundred years.*]

I heard.

[*Twice.*]

I know.

[*Are you going to ask him?*]

Lex looked at his father. At the lean unchanged face pressed against Antho's shoulder. At the hands on his brother's back, trembling.

Not tonight, he thought.



THE REST OF THE Unlit came in two days later, on horses lent by Fenn, riding hard up the long valley from the south road. Dorran on foot beside them, of course. Ilse in the saddle in front of her brother, pale and faded, her head lolling against his chest. Oriel on her mule, entirely unruffled.

They found the Hollowmaw lit, and the slopes scarred and black, and forty-one fresh graves in a row below the cave mouth. And Kestrel Varn, sitting alone on a rock at the edge of the camp, with her brother beside her.

Ivo saw her first.

He was off the horse before it stopped. He handed his sister down to Dorran, very carefully, and then he walked across the camp toward the rock where Kestrel was sitting. Not running. Walking. His face perfectly white.

Kestrel stood up when she saw him coming. She didn't run either. She didn't burn. She just stood there with her hands at her sides, and waited.

He hit her.

Not with a knife. Not with a sling. With his fist, in the face, as hard as he could. He wasn't a big man. He wasn't a fighter. But he put everything he had into it, and Kestrel's head snapped sideways, and she went down on one knee in the grass.

She didn't get up. She didn't hit back. She knelt there with blood running from her lip and looked up at him.

"She's thirty percent gone," said Ivo. His voice was shaking. *"My sister. Thirty percent. I wake up in the night and I can't remember what she sounds like when she laughs. I have to go and wake her up and make her laugh so I don't forget."* His fists were clenched. *"He did that. Your old man. Your friend. And you gave him the key."*

"I know," said Kestrel.

"You gave him the key, Kes."

"I know."

"For your brother." Ivo's voice cracked. *"Your brother's whole. Look at him. Standing there. Solid. Whole."* He jerked his head at Tamsin, who stood beside the rock with his hands at his sides and his face grey. *"And my sister's thirty percent gone. And fifty-five people are still in that book. And the world's about to end."* He was crying now. *"Was it worth it? Was it worth it, Kes?"*

Kestrel looked at him for a long time.

"Yes," she said.

Ivo stared at her.

"And no," said Kestrel Varn. Her voice was very low. *"Both. All the time. Every minute."* She looked at her brother. Then back at Ivo. *"I'd do it again, Ivo. That's the worst of it. I'd do it again. And I'll spend the rest of my life paying for it."* She swallowed. *"You can hit me again if you want. I won't stop you."*

Ivo stood over her with his fists clenched and his face wet.

He didn't hit her again.

He turned around and walked back across the camp to his sister. And knelt down beside her where Dorran had laid her on a blanket in the grass. And put his face against her shoulder. And Ilse, faint and pale, put her hand on the back of his head.



THEY MET THAT NIGHT in the library. All of them.

Lex. Antho. Arion, grey and quiet in the corner. Wren, back in her own patched coat at last, with her boots up on the table. Seraphine with her spectacles and her maps. Brannoc with his arm in a sling and Hedda beside him with her cudgel. Harrow Ves for the Keepers. The Unlit: Dorran, Ilse and Ivo, Oriel.

And Kestrel and Tamsin, standing by the door. Not sitting. Not invited to.

"She stays," said Harrow Ves flatly, *"in a cell. Until the Queen's justice decides what to do with her. Forty-one of my people are in the ground because of what she did."*

"Forty-one of your people are in the ground because of what Elric did," said Dorran.

"She gave him the blood."

"She gave him a rag." Dorran's great slab of a face didn't change. "He'd have found another way. He always finds another way. He found Lex in the glass, and he found the Hollowmaw, and he found my old commander in a hole in the north." He looked at Kestrel. "She made it easier. That's all. She didn't make it happen."

"That's not all," said Ivo. Very quietly. He was sitting beside Ilse, holding her hand. He didn't look up.

"No," Dorran agreed. "It isn't." He was silent for a long moment. "I put the lid on four thousand one hundred and nine children. Because someone told me it was right. Because I wanted to believe them." He looked at Ivo. "Your sister forgave me. Do you remember? You wanted to kill me. In the Bitter Hills. And she wouldn't let you."

Ivo didn't answer.

"She said I'd only been doing what I thought was right," said Dorran. *"And then she said the Unlit needed someone big to lift things."* He looked at Kestrel. *"I've been lifting things ever since. Trying to make up for it. I'll never make up for it. But I try."*

The library was very quiet.

"Ilse," said Lex. *"What do you think?"*

Everyone looked at her.

She was very faint tonight. Faded, like a drawing left out in the rain. Her mouse-brown hair had gone almost grey. But her grey eyes, when she lifted them, were clear.

"I think," she said slowly, *"that if Ivo were thirty percent gone, and someone offered me the key to bring him back, I'd have given them anything. Anything."* She looked at Kestrel. *"I'd have given them the whole world."*

Ivo's hand tightened on hers.

"I don't forgive her," said Ilse. *"Not yet. Maybe not ever."* Her voice was faint but steady. *"But I understand her. And I'd hate her less if I didn't."*



"It's not my decision," said Lex.

They all looked at him.

"It's Antho's," said Lex. "It was his house. His door. His people on the slope." He looked at his brother. "And he nearly died."

Antho was sitting at the far end of the table. He hadn't said anything all evening. He sat with his hands folded on the table and his grey eyes on Kestrel Varn.

He looked at her for a long time.

"Come here," he said.

Kestrel came. Slowly. Across the library, past the table, past Harrow Ves's cold stare and Ivo's bent head. She stopped in front of Antho.

He stood up. He was taller than her by a head. He looked down at her face. At the bruise on her cheek where Ivo had hit her. At the split lip. At her amber eyes.

"Was it worth it?" he said.

Kestrel opened her mouth.

"No," said Antho. *"Don't answer. I heard what you said to Ivo."* He looked past her, at Tamsin, standing by the door. Solid. Whole. Real. *"I asked my father that once. On a plinth at Duskhold, about a man in a crystal."* He looked back at her. *"There's never an answer. Not a real one. You just carry the question for the rest of your life."*

Kestrel's face crumpled.

"I had a voice in my head for eleven years," said Antho quietly. *"Telling me things. Telling me what I wanted to hear. Showing me my mother's face in the trees."* He looked at her. *"Elric's had one too. Telling him he'd always be second. And it found you, didn't it. In the glass. It found the softest place in you and put its hand there."*

Kestrel didn't answer. She didn't need to.

"I know what that's like," said Antho. *"Better than anyone here."* He was silent for a moment. *"You can come."*

Harrow Ves made a sound.

"She can come," said Antho, without looking at the Keeper-Captain. *"With us. To stop him."* He looked down at Kestrel. *"But you walk with me. Not with Lex. Not with your brother. With me. Every step. Where I can see you."* His grey eyes were very steady. *"And if you ever hear that voice again, in your head, telling you what you want to hear, you tell me. At once. Before you do anything."*

Kestrel stared up at him.

"*Why?*" she whispered. "*Why would you—*"

"*Because somebody did it for me,*" said Antho. "*On a woodpile. When I was fifteen.*" He glanced down the table at Lex. "*He was ten. He didn't know what he was doing. He just came and sat beside me in the dark every night, and didn't let go of my sleeve.*"

He looked back at Kestrel.

"*I'm not going to let go of your sleeve,*" he said.



CORRESPONDENCE ARRIVED AT MIDNIGHT.

Nobody saw it come up the mountain. It simply walked into the library through the open door, a scruffy grey goat with a yellow eye and a letter tied round its neck with a piece of red string, and stood in the middle of the floor chewing on something it had found in the passage.

Everyone stared at it.

"*Is that—*" said Wren.

"Malachi's goat," said Antho.

"*Malachi has a goat? That delivers letters?*"

"Malachi has several goats," said Antho. "Only one of them delivers letters. The others are just goats." He crouched down and untied the string. The goat let him. Then it walked over to Brannoc and began, placidly, to eat the hem of his sling.

Antho unfolded the letter. It was written in a spidery, cheerful, slanting hand that Lex knew at once.

He read it aloud.

Deep one—and smith, I expect you're there too, and whoever else you've collected; you always collect people, it's a family habit—

I felt the Key come whole. Everyone did. My fire went out for the first time in four hundred years. I relit it. It was very upsetting for the goats.

Now listen, because I'm old and I don't like writing long letters.

The Key can only turn in one lock. The Lock of the World. The place where your ancestor tied the first knot in the net, nine hundred years ago, when he wove the Lattice over the dark. It's beyond the Veil's edge, in the Sundered Lands, in a great crack in the earth that the old texts call the

Umbral Rift. He'll have to walk there. The Key can cut through anything in the net, but the Rift is outside the net. It's where the net is tied off. He can't cut a keyhole into it.

It's a long walk. Forty days, perhaps. Maybe less. He's very motivated.

You can't stop him reaching it. Don't try. He's Tier IV now, and he's got Aurelian's shadow in his hand, and something whispering in his ear that knows the way.

But you can stop the Key turning.

Remember the verse. Ysmir's verse. The smith told me about it; Correspondence brought me his letter from the Bitter Hills, which I'll admit I read even though it wasn't addressed to me. "Only the blood that forged it can bar the way."

A bar, smith. You need to forge a bar. A lockward. Something to go into the Lock beside the Key and hold it fast, so it can't turn. Your ancestor would have known how. He was the best smith who ever lived.

But the Lock touches all four Wells. It's where the net was tied to the deep, and the deep is made of all of them. So the bar must be forged of all four, too. Fire from the heart of Flame. Iron from the heart of Stone. Water from the heart of Tide, to quench it. And breath from the heart of Gale, for the bellows.

Not from the Wells you know. From the Wellworlds. The places underneath the Wells, where each element is only itself. I've been to two of them. I didn't enjoy either.

You'll need someone who Speaks to each Well to open each door. You Speak to Flame, smith. The lightfoot girl Speaks to Gale, if I remember. That leaves Stone and Tide. You'll work it out. You always do.

Forty days. Go quickly.

—M.

P.S. "The blood that bars it, the blood will pay." I know. I read that bit too. I haven't stopped thinking about it. I don't know what it means. I don't think Ysmir did either. Prophecies are like that. They know the shape of things and not the size.

P.P.S. The goat's name is Correspondence. Please don't let the dragon eat it. It's very hard to train a new one.



NOBODY SAID ANYTHING FOR a while after Antho finished reading.

Correspondence ate Brannoc's sling. Brannoc let it.

"*Forty days*," said Oriel Sant at last, from her corner. Her white eyes were turned toward nothing. "*I see forty days. Thirty-nine, now.*" She tilted her head. "*Four doors. Four fires. And a dark place at the end, where something old is waiting.*"

"*That's not very helpful, Oriel*," said Ivo.

"*I'm not here to be helpful, boy. I'm here to see.*"

"Four Wellworlds," said Lex slowly. "Flame. Stone. Tide. Gale."

"*I Speak to Gale*," said Wren. She'd taken her boots off the table. She was leaning forward. "*Malachi's right. I got there before Duskhold. Speaking. I can open that one.*"

"And I Speak to Flame."

"Stone," said Antho. He was frowning. "*You're at Answering. Not Speaking. And I've never heard Stone at all.*"

"I'll get there," said Lex. "I'll have to."

"*And Tide.*" Seraphine was looking at her notes. "*Who Speaks to Tide? Antho, you're only at Listening.*" She looked up. "*Does anyone here Speak to Tide?*"

Silence.

And then, from the doorway, a small, damp, embarrassed voice:

"Um."

Everyone turned.

Teo Brask was standing in the doorway of the library in his nightshirt. Dripping. A small puddle forming around his bare feet on the stone floor. He'd obviously been listening at the door for some time. He'd gone bright red.

"Teo," said Antho. "*You're supposed to be in bed.*"

"*I know, Master Antho. Sorry, Master Antho.*" Teo swallowed. "*It's only—I don't know if it's Speaking. I don't know what Speaking is.*" He looked down at the puddle around his feet. "*But the water talks to me. All*

the time. It never stops. And sometimes I talk back." He went even redder. "*And sometimes it answers.*"

Antho stared at him.

"*What does it say?*" said Lex.

Teo thought about it. Seriously. A round-faced fifteen-year-old in a wet nightshirt, frowning at the floor.

"*Mostly,*" he said, "*it says it misses the sea.*"



THEY LEFT TWO DAYS later. On the fortieth morning before the end. On dragons.

Vharuun carried most of them. She'd recovered enough to fly now, though not fast, and her vast ragged back could take a dozen people if they didn't mind holding on to scales the size of shields. Dorran and Oriel and the twins and Seraphine (who had refused, flatly, to be left behind: *I'm the only one who's read about the Wellworlds, Antho, the only one, I've read everything there is, which is three paragraphs and a very bad poem*). Teo, wrapped in a borrowed coat, white with terror and excitement, clutching a scale. Brannoc and Hedda stayed behind. Brannoc had wanted to come. Hedda had sat on him.

Ashka carried Antho and Lex. And Kestrel, behind Antho, with her hands on his waist. Where he could see her.

Tamsin rode Vharuun, beside Dorran. He'd been very quiet since the night of the Blade. He looked at his sister, sometimes, across the camp. With an expression Lex couldn't read.

And Wren didn't ride at all. She stepped up into the morning air above the Hollowmaw and stood there on nothing, with her red braid blowing and her bow on her back, grinning down at them.

"*Keep up,*" she said.

Arion stood at the mouth of the cave to watch them go. With Pim beside him, and Odile, and the other students. Lex looked down at him from Ashka's back as the dragons lifted off the slope.

His father raised one hand.

Lex raised his.

Two hundred years, he thought. You'll tell me. When we get back. Both of us. You'll tell us everything.

[Will he?] said Ember quietly.

He'll have to, thought Lex. There's nothing left to hide behind.

The Hollowmaw fell away below them. The great cleft in the mountain, glowing gold. One thousand one hundred and eleven lanterns. And at the bottom of it, a little clay lamp. And a cracked black door. And on the other side of it, their mother. Holding.

And on this side, at last, their father.

They flew south and west. Toward Ashbourne. Toward the first door. Toward fire.

CHAPTER 16

THE WELLWORLD OF FLAME



THE ASHBOURNE FORGE HAD twenty anvils, and every one of them stopped ringing when the dragons came down on the green.

Lex saw the students pour out of the long hall. Leather aprons and scarred forearms and soot-black faces, forty of them, staring up at a storm-dragon the size of a cathedral settling onto the village green like a mountain lying down. Behind them, Mother Orla in the door of the Crooked Kettle with a ladle in her hand and her mouth open. Behind *her*, on the forge chimney, a raven, who looked at Vharuun, looked at Ashka, looked at Lex sliding down off Ashka's neck, and said in a voice like a rusty hinge:

"Late."

"Hello, Quill," said Lex.

"Very late. Bacon gone. Girl burned the tongs."

"*I did NOT,*" shouted a voice from the crowd of students, and Tilda Crane pushed her way to the front, red-faced and freckled, in her too-big apron. "*It was ONE pair. And they were already cracked. And he wasn't even there, he was on the chimney eating Mother Orla's—*" She stopped. She'd seen Lex's face. "*Master Lex,*" she said, in a different voice. "*What's happened?*"

He didn't know how to answer. There was too much. The Glass Desert and the Sunwell and the masquerade and the Hollowmaw and his mother behind a cracked black door. He stood on the green of the village where

he'd grown up, with his forty students staring at him, and didn't know where to start.

"I need the forge," he said at last. "The big hearth. Tonight."

Tilda looked at him. Then at the dragons. Then at the strange band of people climbing down off Vharuun's back: the giant, the twin thieves, the blind old woman, the red-haired witch, the Royal Archivist with her spectacles askew, the wet boy in the borrowed coat.

"*Right*," said Tilda Crane. "*I'll bank the others down.*"



THE GREAT HEARTH STOOD at the far end of the long hall. Brannoc had built it with Lex, three years ago, when they rebuilt the forge after the fire. A huge round fire-pit of black stone, waist-high and wide as a cartwheel, with a hood of hammered copper above it and a chimney going up through the roof. It was the heart of the Ashbourne Forge. The other nineteen anvils were lit from it every morning, with coals carried in iron pans down the long hall. It had never once gone out.

Lex stood in front of it at midnight.

The hall was empty except for the people who'd come with him. The students had been sent to bed, protesting. Tilda had stayed until the last moment, banking the side-fires, and then gone, looking back over her shoulder all the way to the door.

Antho stood at Lex's left hand. Wren at his right. Kestrel a pace behind Antho, where Antho could see her. The others were further back, by the anvils. Seraphine with a notebook open, pen poised. Teo, pale, dripping onto the stone floor. Dorran. The twins. Oriel on a stool with her stick across her knees.

"*How many can go through?*" said Wren.

"I don't know," said Lex. "Malachi said a Speaker opens the door. He didn't say how wide."

"*Three*," said Oriel Sant, from her stool. "*Besides the smith. I can see it. The door's the size of a hearth. Four can pass.*" She tilted her head. "*Choose well.*"

Lex looked at them.

"Me," said Antho. *"Obviously. And Kestrel, because I'm not letting go of her sleeve."* He glanced at Kestrel. She didn't say anything. Her face was very still. *"And she hears Flame. Better than anyone here except you."*

"And me," said Wren. Very firmly.

"Wren—"

"Hammer. You promised. Properly. In a wrecked ballroom with my shoes off." Her green eyes were very bright. *"Never again, you said."*

He looked at her. He remembered the masquerade. His own voice. *I promise properly. Never again.*

"Never again," he said.



HE PUT HIS HANDS into the fire.

He'd done it before. At Malachi's hearth, on the shore of the Stillwater, the first time he ever heard Flame. In the coals of a hundred forges since. It didn't burn him anymore. It hadn't burned him in years. The fire leaned into his hands like a cat into a stroke, warm and glad and *alive*.

He closed his eyes.

And *Spoke*.

Not to this fire. Through it. Down. Down through the coals and the black stone of the hearth and the earth of the Vale beneath, down to the place below the Lattice where the river ran, where Flame came up from the deep like water from a spring.

I need to come in, he told it. *Please. I need to come all the way in.*

For a long moment, nothing.

Then the fire under his hands went *white*.

Not gold. Not orange. White, the white of iron at welding heat, the white of the center of the sun. It rose up out of the hearth in a column, silent, roaring without sound, so bright that he saw it through his closed eyelids. And it *opened*.

He felt it open. The way you feel a door open behind you in a cold room. A rush of heat. A smell like hot metal and summer and the inside of a bread oven. And a sound, very far off, like a thousand bells ringing at once.

He opened his eyes.

The column of white fire stood in the hearth, taller than a man, and in the middle of it, there was a door. Not a door. A *hole*. A round space in the white fire where the fire went *deeper*, gold and red and endless, like looking down a tunnel into the heart of a forge.

[*Oh*,] breathed Ember. [*Oh, Lex. Look at it.*]

"*Well*," said Wren, beside him. Her voice was not quite steady. "*Hammer. After you.*"

He stepped into the fire.



IT WAS LIKE BEING born.

He thought that afterward, trying to explain it to Seraphine, who wrote down every word. Like being pushed through something too small and too hot and too bright, with everything pressing on you, and then coming out the other side into air and light and noise, gasping.

He came out on his hands and knees on a floor of gold.

Not gold metal. Gold *light*. Solid. Warm. Like standing on the surface of a lamp-flame. It held him up. It was hot, but not burning. It hummed under his palms.

He lifted his head.



THE WELLWORLD OF FLAME was the most beautiful thing he had ever seen.

There was no sky. Or rather, the sky was fire. A great dome of it, overhead, gold and red and orange, moving slowly, the way the surface of a forge-fire moves when you look down into it. Not burning. *Breathing*. Rising and falling, slow and steady, like the chest of something enormous and asleep.

And under the sky, a land.

Hills of embers. Red and black and glowing, rolling away to every horizon like a landscape made of coals. Rivers of liquid light, gold and white, running down the hills in long bright ribbons, pooling in valleys into lakes of fire so bright he couldn't look at them. Trees. *Trees*, made of flame. Tall and slender, with trunks of red fire and branches of gold and

leaves of flickering white, swaying in a hot wind that smelled of cinnamon and iron.

And everywhere, *life*.

Things moving. In the rivers of light, long sinuous shapes swimming, like eels made of sparks. In the trees, small bright birds, flitting from branch to branch, trailing fire. On the hills, creatures like lizards, long and low and glowing red-gold, basking on the embers with their eyes half closed. Salamanders, Lex thought. The old stories called them salamanders. He'd never believed in them.

And far away, on the very edge of sight, so far that it was only a glow, a light. Brighter than everything else. White and steady and enormous. Like a star sitting on the horizon.

[*The heart,*] said Ember. [*That's the heart of it. Lex. That's where the fire comes from.*]



WREN CAME THROUGH BEHIND him. Then Antho. Then Kestrel.

Wren landed on her feet, of course, light as a cat, and stood with her bow in her hand and her mouth open, staring up at the burning sky. Her red braid was lifting in the hot wind. Little sparks were catching in it.

"*Oh,*" she said. "*Oh, Hammer. Oh.*"

Antho came through on his knees, the way Lex had. He knelt on the gold floor and lifted his head and looked around at the burning world. His face was white. His grey eyes were very wide.

"*It's loud,*" he whispered.

Lex looked at him. "*Loud?*"

"*Not the sound. The—*" Antho pressed his hand flat against the gold floor. "*There's no dark here. None. No Shade. No silence.*" He swallowed. "*Everything's full. Every inch of it. Everything's burning.*" He looked up at Lex. "*I've never been anywhere without any dark at all.*"

And Kestrel came through last.

She didn't fall. She didn't kneel. She stepped out of the fire onto the gold floor as if she'd been walking through doors of flame all her life. And stopped.

And her hair *blazed*.

Not the low red glow it had been since the Hollowmaw. Not the furious roar of the temple at Ysmir. Something else. Bright, and gold, and steady, like a crown. Her whole body lit up from within. Fire in her hands, her hair, her eyes. Gold fire, pouring off her, and *leaning*, the way Lex's fire leaned, toward the burning sky and the burning hills and the burning trees.

She stared down at her own hands.

"It knows me," she whispered. "It knows me. My grandmother's fire. The Ashari fire. It knows me."

And all across the hills of embers, the salamanders lifted their heads. And turned. And looked at her.



THEY WALKED TOWARD THE light.

There was no other direction. Every river of liquid fire ran toward it. Every tree leaned toward it, like flowers toward the sun. Every salamander on every hill had its head turned toward it. The heart. The white star on the horizon.

It was hot. Not burning. But hot the way a summer afternoon is hot, a heavy steady heat that pressed on you and made you slow. Wren's face was flushed and running with sweat. Antho had taken off his coat and slung it over his shoulder and was walking with his head down, as if against a wind.

Lex didn't feel it. Not the way they did. He walked through the Wellworld of Flame and felt it all around him like warm water, like a bath, like coming home.

[Careful,] said Ember. Quietly. *[Lex. Careful.]*

Of what?

[Of how good it feels.]

He didn't answer. But he noticed, after a while, that he'd stopped sweating. That the heat had stopped feeling like heat. That when he looked down at his hands, the gold glow that always came off them had got brighter. Much brighter. And spread. Up his wrists. Up his arms.

He made himself look away.



THE SALAMANDERS FOLLOWED KESTREL.

They came down off the hills in ones and twos. Then dozens. Long low glowing shapes, gliding over the embers on short legs, their eyes like drops of molten gold. They didn't come near Lex, or Antho, or Wren. They went to Kestrel. They walked beside her, and behind her, and in front of her, a great slow shining procession, like a cat's tail of fire trailing behind her across the hills.

She didn't seem to notice. She walked with her face turned toward the white light on the horizon and her hair blazing gold, and her lips moving.

"She's talking to them," said Wren quietly.

"She's talking to it," said Antho. He was walking close beside Kestrel, the way he'd promised. Not touching. But close. *"All of it. The whole world."*

Lex dropped back to walk beside them. And he heard what Kestrel was saying. Very low. Over and over.

"I'm sorry. I'm sorry. I'm sorry. I'm sorry."



THEY WALKED FOR A long time. Lex didn't know how long. There was no sun to measure by. Only the slow rise and fall of the burning sky, breathing overhead.

And the light grew.

It stopped being a star on the horizon. It became a glow. Then a blaze. Then a great white column, rising out of the land ahead of them, so tall it touched the burning sky and so bright it cast no shadows at all. Like the column of white fire that had opened in the Ashbourne hearth, but a thousand times bigger. A pillar of the purest fire. Silent. Roaring without sound.

And at its foot, a lake.

Not of liquid light. Of *fire*. White fire. Perfectly still. Perfectly flat. Like a mirror made of flame, spreading out from the foot of the pillar in a great circle, miles across.

They came down the last hill to its shore and stopped.

The salamanders didn't go any further. They stopped on the hills behind, in a great glowing crowd, hundreds of them, and lay down on the embers with their heads toward the lake. Waiting.

"*This is it,*" said Kestrel. Her voice was strange. Far away. "*The first fire. The one all the others come from.*"

Lex looked at the white lake. At the pillar rising out of it.

"How do we get the coal?" said Wren. "Malachi said fire from the heart. A coal. How do we—"

You ask.

The voice came from everywhere.

From the lake. From the pillar. From the burning sky. From the embers under their feet and the fire in their own bodies. Not loud. Not soft. A voice like the crackle of a log on a winter hearth, and the roar of a forest fire, and the hiss of a struck match, all at once.

You ask. And I ask you a question back. And if your answer is true, you may take what you need.

The lake moved.

A shape rose out of the white fire. Slowly. Not a woman. Not a man. A *shape*, tall and slender and made of flame, white at its heart and gold at its edges, with no face but two burning points where eyes would be. It stood on the surface of the lake as if the lake were stone.

I am the Hearth, said the shape. *I am the first fire. I was burning when your world was dark, and I will be burning when it is dark again.* The burning eyes moved over them. Over Wren. Over Antho, who flinched. Over Kestrel. And stopped on Lex.

Smith, said the Hearth. *I have heard you. Every morning, for ten years. You say good morning to my children in your forge before you light them.*

Lex didn't know what to say.

Nobody does that, said the Hearth. *Not in nine hundred years. Not since the one who wove the net.* A pause. *He said good morning too. Before.*



Ask, said the Hearth.

Lex stepped forward. To the edge of the white lake.

"I need a coal," he said. "From your heart. To forge a bar. To stop a key from turning. If it turns, the lid comes off the world, and something comes out from under it that eats light." He swallowed. "It'll eat you too. Eventually. All the fire. All of it."

The Hearth was silent for a moment.

I know what lies under the lid, it said. I burned it once. Long ago. In a land of grass and rivers. My child burned it, and burned everything with it, and has grieved ever since.

The Sunwell, thought Lex.

You woke my child, said the Hearth. In the glass. You went down and listened, and told it that it had done well. The burning eyes were very bright. It sent word to me. Through the deep. It said: a smith came. He listened.

"It deserved to be listened to."

Yes. A long pause. Ask your question, smith. Then I will ask mine.

"I've asked it. Can I have the coal?"

That is a request. Not a question. The Hearth tilted its faceless head. But very well. Here is mine.

And the white fire of the lake rose up around Lex's feet.

What do you burn for?



HE DIDN'T ANSWER AT once.

He'd been asked a version of it before. By Malachi, on the shore of the Stillwater. *What's your fire for, smith?* And he'd said *to make things*, and Malachi had laughed and said *that's not an answer, that's a job*.

He thought about it now. Standing at the edge of the first fire in the world, with the white flame lapping at his boots.

To make things. That was true. He loved making things. He loved the moment when the iron gave, and bent, and became what it wanted to be. He loved the ring of the hammer and the hiss of the quench and the weight of a finished blade in his hand.

But that wasn't it. Not all of it.

To protect people. That was true too. Antho. Wren. His father. His students. The Unlit. Forty-eight names in a dead woman's book. He'd burned for them. He'd burned the Umbral Wardens in the glass and the shadows on the Hollowmaw slope.

But that wasn't it either.

He looked down at the white fire around his feet. And thought about the Sunwell. About the plain of red earth and green grass and singing people, and the sun rising from below to save them, and burning them.

It saved them. And it killed everyone it was saving.

Fire doesn't choose who it burns. The only thing you can choose is what you burn it for.

"I don't know," he said.

The Hearth went very still.

"I don't know," said Lex again. His voice was rough. "I used to think I did. To make things. To protect people. To fix what's broken." He looked up at the burning eyes. "But the Sunwell burned to protect people. And it killed them all. And the man I'm trying to stop thinks he's burning for something too. He thinks he's earned it. He thinks the world owes him." He swallowed. "And somewhere at the bottom of me there's a door, with something behind it that sounds kind and loves me and wants me to burn for it."

The white fire was very hot around his ankles now. He didn't move.

"I don't know what I burn for," said Lex. "I only know I have to keep asking. Every day. Every time I light the forge. What's this fire for? Is it the right fire? Am I burning the right thing?" He met the Hearth's eyes. "Because the day I stop asking, I'll be like the Sunwell. Or like Elric. Or like the thing behind the door. Burning, and sure, and wrong."



THE HEARTH DIDN'T SAY anything for a long time.

The white lake was very still. The pillar of fire rose silent behind it. The salamanders on the hills lay with their golden eyes fixed on the shore.

That, said the Hearth at last, is the first true answer I have heard in nine hundred years.

The white fire around Lex's feet sank back into the lake.

Every one who comes here tells me what they burn for, said the Hearth. To protect. To build. To destroy. To win. Kings and sorcerers and Founders. They are all very sure. The burning eyes moved, slowly, over the lake. The one who wove the net was very sure. He stood where you stand and told me he

burned to keep the world safe. And I believed him, and gave him what he asked.

A long pause.

He was wrong, said the Hearth. He was so sure, and so wrong. And the net he wove became a cage. And the thing he caged got into him through the bars.

Lex didn't move.

You are not sure, said the Hearth. Good. Stay that way. Keep asking. It lifted one long burning arm. Take your coal.



THE LAKE PARTED.

Not like water. Like a curtain. The white fire drew back on either side, opening a path from the shore to the foot of the great pillar. A path of gold light, solid and warm, leading straight into the heart of the first fire in the world.

Lex looked at it.

[Lex,] said Ember. Very carefully. [Lex, look at your hands.]

He looked.

The gold glow had spread. All the way up his arms now. To his shoulders. He could feel it creeping up his neck. And his hands—

His hands were fire.

Not burning. *Being*. His fingers flickering at the edges, gold and white, like candle flames. He could see the gold floor through his palms.

[It's Becoming,] said Ember. [The fifth stage. Malachi warned you. Commanding is when you tell the Well what to do. Becoming is when the Well tells you. When you go in so deep you turn into it.] Its voice was urgent. *[Lex, it's been happening since we came through. Slowly. The longer you stay, the more you burn. If you walk into that pillar—]*

I'll come out with the coal.

[You won't come out at all. You'll be the coal.]

Lex looked at the path. At the pillar. At the white fire at its heart, roaring without sound.

It was so beautiful. It felt like coming home. Like every forge he'd ever stood at, every fire he'd ever lit, every morning he'd said *good morning* to the coals. All of them coming from here. All of them going back here.

It would be so easy, he thought. Just walk in. Just keep walking.

No more keys. No more doors. No more kind voices at the bottom of me. Just fire.

He took a step onto the path.



A HAND CLOSED ON his sleeve.

Cold. The coldest thing in the Wellworld of Flame. Long-fingered and scarred and very, very cold, like a hand that had spent eight years holding a breach shut in the dark.

He looked down.

Antho. Holding his sleeve. Not his arm. His *sleeve*. Between finger and thumb. The way a ten-year-old boy had held a fifteen-year-old's sleeve, on a woodpile, in the dark, every night for a year.

His brother's face was grey and running with sweat. His grey eyes were very dark. In the Wellworld of Flame, with no Shade anywhere, he looked like a man standing in a gale. But his hand was steady on Lex's sleeve.

"No," said Antho.

Lex stared at him.

"I don't remember the stone," said Antho. "I paid it away. I don't remember the millpond, or the heron, or you being ten." His voice was very quiet. *"But I remember the woodpile. Every night. For a year. You came out and sat beside me in the dark, and you didn't say anything, and you held my sleeve."* His fingers tightened. *"You held on. Every time the voices called me into the trees, you held on."*

"Antho—"

"It's my turn," said Antho. "I'm holding on."

And Lex felt it. Through the Bloodbond. Not fire. Not gold. Something cold and quiet and deep. His brother's Shade, the absence, the silence between heartbeats, pouring down through the thread that bound them together and into Lex like cold water into a quenching trough.

And the fire in his hands *bissed*.

Steamed. Like hot iron in the slack tub. The gold glow on his arms flickered. Dimmed. Drew back. Down from his shoulders. Down his arms. To his wrists. His hands. His fingers solid again. Flesh. Scarred and callused and his own.

He stood on the path of gold light, one step from the shore, with his brother holding his sleeve, and breathed.

ATTUNEMENT – FLAME

Speaking → COMMANDING

"The fourth stage is not when the fire obeys. It is when you can tell it no."

WARNING: BECOMING (Flame) – resisted

Anchor: BLOODBOND (Anthoren Vey)

Shade-quench applied

[Oh, thank the light,] said Ember. [Oh, thank every light there is.]



"I'll go," said Kestrel.

They both turned.

She was standing at the edge of the white lake. Blazing. Gold from head to foot, her hair a crown of fire, the salamanders crowded on the hills behind her with their eyes on her. Her face was wet. Her amber eyes were very bright.

"I'll go in," she said. "I'll get the coal."

"You can't," said Antho. "You'll Become. You'll—"

"No." Kestrel shook her head. "I won't. I'm not like him." She looked at Lex. "He's the Root. He's got the gold in him. The net. It pulls him in because it wants to use him." She looked at the pillar. "I've never been in the net. I've never had a thread. The fire doesn't want to use me. It just—" She stopped. "It just knows me."

She looked at Antho.

"You said you wouldn't let go of my sleeve," she said.

He didn't answer.

"Let go," said Kestrel. "Just for a minute. Let me do one thing right."

Antho looked at her for a long, long moment.

Then he looked at the Hearth. Standing on the white lake. Watching.

She will not Become, said the Hearth quietly. *She has never been caged. There is nothing in her for the fire to pull loose. A pause. But she will be tested. Every one who walks into my heart is tested. She will see what she burns for.*

"*I know what I burn for*," said Kestrel.

Do you?

Kestrel didn't answer that. She looked at Antho. Waiting.

And Antho Vey, who had promised not to let go of her sleeve, nodded once. Very slowly.

She turned and walked onto the path of gold light. Into the heart of the first fire in the world.



SHE WAS GONE A long time.

They stood on the shore and waited. Lex. Antho. Wren, who had come up beside Lex without a word and put her hand in his and held on very tight. The salamanders on the hills behind them. The Hearth, standing on the white lake, still as a flame in a windless room.

The pillar roared without sound. They couldn't see into it. It was too bright. They could only see the path of gold light running into it, and nothing coming out.

[What do you think it's showing her?] said Ember quietly.

Tamsin, thought Lex. *The Hollowmaw. The rag. Forty-one graves. Ilse.*

[All of it,] said Ember.

All of it.

Wren's hand tightened on his.

"*If she doesn't come out*," she said quietly. "*If she Becomes. If she just—stays.*"

"She'll come out," said Antho.

"*How do you know?*"

He didn't answer for a long time. He stood on the shore of the white lake with his coat over his shoulder and his face grey and running with sweat, and looked at the pillar.

"Because she's got something to carry," he said at last. "Something heavy. She's going to carry it for the rest of her life." He was quiet. "People with something to carry always come back out. They can't put it down long enough to stay."



SHE CAME OUT.

Walking. Slowly. Down the path of gold light from the foot of the pillar. Not blazing anymore. Her hair was red again. Just red. Her face was white and wet and very calm.

And in her cupped hands, something burned.

Small. The size of a hen's egg. A coal. But not like any coal Lex had ever seen. It was white at the heart, and gold at the edges, and it didn't flicker. It burned *steady*, absolutely still, like the flame of the lamp in the niche at the Hollowmaw. And it *sang*. Very faintly. A sound like a far-off bell.

She came off the path onto the shore. She held it out to Lex.

He took it. It sat in his palms like a living thing. Warm. Humming. The heart of the first fire in the world.

ITEM ACQUIRED

THE HEART-COAL (Wellworld of Flame)

"Fire from the first fire. It will
burn for as long as there is a
world to burn in."

Component 1 of 4: LOCKWARD

He looked up at Kestrel.

"What did it show you?" said Antho.

Kestrel looked at him. For a long time.

"Everything," she said. *"Every bit of it. The rag. Your door. The graves. Ilse. Ivo's face."* Her voice was very steady. *"And then it asked me. What do you burn for?"*

"And?"

"I said: for Tam," said Kestrel. *"Because it's true. I'd do it all again. For Tam."* She swallowed. *"And it said: yes. That's true. And then it asked me again."*

She was quiet.

"And I said: for the people I hurt," said Kestrel Varn. "To make up for it. Even though I can't. Even though it'll take the rest of my life and won't be enough." Her amber eyes were very bright. "And it said: yes. That's true too."

She looked at the white lake.

"And then it let me go."

KESTREL VARN (unlatticed)

ATTUNEMENT — FLAME

Answering → SPEAKING

"The fire asked twice. She answered twice. Both answers were true."

Lex couldn't see it. Not with True Sight. Kestrel wasn't in the Lattice. But the panel came up anyway, in silver, hanging in the burning air of the Wellworld over her head. As if the fire itself had written it.



Go now, said the Hearth. The door is closing. The world you came from is moving faster than this one. You have been here a day. There, it has been an hour.

A day for an hour. Lex did the sum. *Forty days. Thirty-eight, now. Thirty-seven.*

Take my coal to the other three, said the Hearth. To Stone. To Tide. To Gale. They will not be as kind as I am. A pause. They do not remember the one who wove the net as fondly as I do. They remember what he became.

"Thank you," said Lex.

The burning shape inclined its faceless head.

Keep asking, smith, it said. Every day. Every time you light the forge.

And the white fire of the lake rose up around them like a wave, and lifted them, and they were falling, upward, through gold and red and white, through heat and light and the sound of a thousand bells—



—AND OUT ONTO THE black stone floor of the Ashbourne Forge, at a quarter past one in the morning, in front of a hearth burning perfectly ordinary orange.

Seraphine was there, with her notebook. She'd fallen asleep on it. She jerked awake when they came through, and her spectacles fell off, and she scrabbled for them on the floor.

"An hour," she said, peering at them. *"You've been gone an hour. What happened? Did you get it? What was it like? Did you—"*

Lex opened his hands.

The Heart-Coal sat in his palms, white and gold and humming, filling the long dark hall of the Ashbourne Forge with a light like a summer noon. Every one of the nineteen banked side-fires down the length of the hall flared up at once, gold, as if saying hello.

Seraphine stopped talking.

Behind her, Teo, who had been asleep on a bench, sat up and stared. Dorran stood up from the anvil he'd been leaning on. The twins woke, and Ilse made a small sound. Oriel Sant turned her white face toward the light.

"Oh," said Oriel softly. *"Oh, that's lovely. I can almost see that."*

And on the forge chimney, outside in the dark, a raven ruffled his feathers, and looked down through the smoke-hole at the light pouring up out of the hall, and said, to no one in particular, in a voice like a rusty hinge:

"About time."

CHAPTER 17

THE WELLWORLD OF TIDE



TEO BRASK HAD NOT stopped talking since they left Ashbourne.

Antho had known him for a year. In that year, Teo had said perhaps a thousand words, most of them *sorry* or *yes*, *Master Antho* or *I think there's a leak in the cold-room*. He was a quiet boy. A homesick boy. A boy who sat at the back of the hall and dripped.

On Vharuun's back, flying east toward the coast with the wind in his face and the sea somewhere ahead of him, Teo Brask turned into someone else.

"—and the marshes go on for miles," he was saying, "*miles and miles, all reeds and water and little channels, and the tide comes in twice a day and fills them all up, and then goes out again, and you can hear it, Master Antho, you can hear it, it sounds like breathing, like the whole marsh is breathing in and out—*"

"Teo," said Seraphine faintly. She was sitting behind him on the storm-mother's back, clutching a scale the size of a shield with both hands and her eyes screwed shut. "*Please. I'm begging you. Stop talking about water.*"

"*Sorry, Mistress Seraphine.*" A pause of perhaps three heartbeats. "*It's only that there's a place near my village where the channels all meet, and when the tide turns, they make a whirlpool, a little one, and if you drop a leaf in it goes round and round and round—*"

Seraphine made a small despairing noise.

Antho, sitting behind her, put his hand on her shoulder. She leaned back against him without opening her eyes.

"*I hate the sea,*" she said, very quietly, so only he could hear. "*I've always hated the sea. My father drowned in it. When I was six. In a storm off the Tidewater, on a merchant ship. They never found him.*" She swallowed. "*I've never told anyone that. Not even you.*"

He didn't say anything. He tightened his hand on her shoulder.

"*And now I'm going into it,*" said Seraphine. "*Into the heart of it. The heart of all the water in the world.*" She laughed, a little wildly. "*Because I'm the only one who's read about the Wellworlds. Three paragraphs and a very bad poem.*"

"You don't have to come."

"*Yes, I do.*" She opened her eyes and looked up at him. Behind her spectacles, they were wet. "*Because you're going. And I'm not letting you go into the sea without me. Not after my father.*"



THEY CAME DOWN ON the Tidewater coast at dusk.

Antho had never seen the sea. Not properly. He'd seen it from a distance once, from the top of a hill in the east, a grey line on the horizon. That had been in the bad years, when he'd been running from the Wardens with the Murmur screaming in his head. He hadn't looked at it long.

He looked now.

It was enormous. That was the first thing. Bigger than the sky. Grey and green and silver, stretching away to the edge of the world, heaving slowly under a darkening sky, with long white lines of foam rolling in toward the shore like the creases in a blanket. And it was *loud*. A deep, slow, endless roar, rising and falling, rising and falling.

Breathing, he thought. *Teo was right. It sounds like breathing.*

And under the roar, with Shade, he could hear something else. The silence in the deep. The great cold dark places under the water, where no light had ever reached. Miles of it. Endless. More dark than he had ever felt in one place, more even than the Hollow.

But not hungry. That was the strange thing. The Hollow's dark was hungry. This dark was just—deep. Patient. Old. Like the dark under a sleeping person's eyelids.

He stood on the shingle at the edge of the sea with the wind in his face, and for the first time since the Wellworld of Flame, he felt the knot in his chest let go.



TEO WALKED STRAIGHT INTO the water.

He didn't take off his boots. He didn't roll up his trousers. He walked down the shingle and into the surf, up to his knees, his waist, his chest, and stood there with the waves breaking around him and his arms spread wide and his face turned up to the darkening sky. And he laughed. A great, wild, delighted laugh that Antho had never heard from him in a year.

And the sea *answered*.

Antho felt it. The whole vast grey-green body of it, shifting. Turning. The way a sleeping dog lifts its head when it hears its master's step. The waves around Teo changed. They stopped breaking. They came in and *curled* around him, gently, like arms. Like an embrace.

"It missed me," Teo shouted back to them, over the roar. His round face was shining. *"Master Antho, it missed me. It says I've been gone too long. It says I've been in the mountains in a cold-room talking to fish in a bucket and it's very offended."*

Behind Antho, on the shingle, Lex started to laugh.

"It says that?" said Wren.

"Not in words." Teo was wiping his eyes. Or the sea was; it was hard to tell. *"But that's what it means."*



THEY CHOSE WHO WOULD go through.

Teo, because the door was his. Lex, because he carried the Heart-Coal, and because the Lockward was his to forge. Antho, because Tide was his third Well, and because he'd been to the edge of the deep before, in the Drowned Country, and come back.

And Seraphine.

"No," said Antho.

"Yes."

"Seraphine. Your father—"

"I know about my father, Antho. I was there when they came to tell my mother." Her face was very white. Her hands were shaking. But her voice was steady. "I've read everything there is to read about the Wellworlds. Every scrap. Every mention. Every footnote in every Founder's codex in the Spire's sealed vaults." She pushed her spectacles up her nose. "Three paragraphs. And a very bad poem. About Tide."

"What does it say?"

"The poem?" Seraphine closed her eyes. And recited, flatly, in the voice of someone who has read something many times and disliked it more each time:

"The sea remembers every stone that ever sank beneath her foam. She keeps them all, and keeps them well, and if you ask, she'll let you tell the story of the one you lost, but you must pay her what it cost."

She opened her eyes.

"It rhymes 'foam' with 'stone,'" she said. "It's terrible."

"What does it mean?" said Lex.

"I don't know." Seraphine looked at Antho. "But I've read it a hundred times. And I think it's the most important thing anyone's ever written about Tide. And I'm the only one who knows it." She swallowed. "So I'm coming."

Antho looked at her. Shaking. White. Terrified. Standing on the shingle with the sea that had taken her father roaring in front of her.

She's braver than me, he thought. *She always has been.*

"Hold my hand," he said. "The whole time. Don't let go."

"I won't."



TEO OPENED THE DOOR at midnight, under a moon like a silver coin.

He stood chest-deep in the sea, with the waves curling around him, and put his hands flat on the water. Not in it. *On* it. As if it were a table. And the water held them up.

He closed his eyes.

And Antho heard him *Speak*.

Not words. Not with his mouth. With his whole body. A sound like the tide coming in over the marshes, slow and steady and endless. A sound like a whirlpool where the channels meet, going round and round. A sound like a homesick boy in a cold-room in the mountains, talking to fish in a bucket because there was nothing else that understood him.

Let us in, said Teo Brask to the sea. *Please. I've brought friends. They need to see your heart.*

And the sea *opened*.

Not parting. Not like a curtain. *Down*. A great slow whirlpool, forming in the water in front of Teo, turning, turning, wider and wider. Silver in the moonlight. A funnel, going down into the dark. Into the deep. Into somewhere that wasn't the sea anymore.

"There," said Teo. He was crying again. *"There it is. Come on."*

He stepped into the whirlpool.

And went down.



ANTHO WENT AFTER HIM, with Seraphine's hand crushing his fingers and the Keeper's Lantern held high in the other.

The water closed over his head.

He didn't drown. He'd known he wouldn't. He'd walked under the not-water of the Drowned Country with the Lantern's gold light around him like a bubble of air. This was different. This was *water*. Real, cold, salt, heavy. It pressed on his ears and his eyes and his chest. It filled his mouth.

And he could breathe it.

Not like air. Like something thicker. Something richer. Every breath of it went into him cold and came out warm, and as it went in, he *felt* things. Not saw. Felt. Faint and far and fleeting, like the edge of a dream.

A fisherman, hauling in a net, singing.

A child, dropping a ring off a pier, crying.

A ship, going down in a storm. Men shouting. A merchant, clinging to a spar, thinking of a little girl with spectacles at home in—

Seraphine screamed.

He felt it through her hand. Through the water. A sound that went through the deep like a crack through ice. He pulled her close. Wrapped his arm around her. Held her against his chest in the cold rushing dark.

"*I felt him,*" she was saying. Sobbing. Into his coat. "*I felt him, Antho, I felt him, he was thinking about me, at the end, he was thinking about—*"

The sea remembers, thought Antho. *Every stone that ever sank beneath her foam.*

He held her. And they went down.



THE WELLWORLD OF TIDE was dark.

Not the dark of the Hollow. Not hungry dark. The dark of the deep sea, miles down, where the light of the sun had never reached. Cold and still and heavy, pressing on every side. Endless. In every direction. No floor. No surface. No up or down. Just water, and dark, and silence.

And in the dark, lights.

Thousands of them. Millions. Small and faint and drifting. Blue and green and silver and pale gold, like stars in a night sky. But moving. Slowly. Turning and drifting and rising and falling on currents Antho couldn't feel. Some were tiny, pinpricks. Some were the size of a fist. A few, far off, were enormous, great slow-turning globes of pale light the size of houses.

"*Memories,*" said Teo.

He was floating beside them in the dark, his round face lit blue by the drifting lights. He looked entirely at home. More at home than Antho had ever seen him, anywhere.

"*They're memories,*" he said. "*Everything that's ever been dropped in water. Every stone. Every ring. Every tear. Every—*" He stopped. Looked at Seraphine. His face changed. "*Every person.*"

Seraphine was very still in Antho's arms.

"*The sea keeps them,*" said Teo quietly. "*That's what it does. That's what Tide is. It's change, and it's memory. It washes everything away. And it keeps everything it washes.*" He looked out at the drifting lights. "*All of them. Forever.*"



LEX CAME THROUGH BEHIND them. Antho felt him: a sudden blaze of gold in the dark, as if someone had opened a forge door at the bottom of the sea. The Heart-Coal, burning white in Lex's hands. Its light pushed out into the deep in a great warm circle, and the drifting memories near it *flinched*. Scattered. Like fish from a shadow.

Put it away, said a voice.

It came from everywhere. From the water. From the dark. From the drifting lights. Cold and slow and heavy, like the weight of a mile of sea pressing down. Not angry. Worse than angry. *Tired*.

Put away your fire, Root-beir. This is not a place for burning.

Lex closed his hands over the Heart-Coal. Its light went dim. Not out. Just covered, glowing faintly gold between his fingers.

And the dark *moved*.

Something came up out of it. Below them, or ahead of them, or all around them; there was no direction here. Something vast. A shape in the deep, darker than the dark, rising slowly toward the little cluster of four people floating in the cold. Antho felt it with Shade. He felt the silence around it, the enormous shape of the absence where it was.

It was the size of a mountain.



IT DIDN'T HAVE A face. It didn't have a shape. It was a *current*. A great slow-turning body of colder, darker, heavier water, moving through the deep like a whale moves through the sea. And all through it, like stars in a cloud, memories. Millions of them. Drifting through its body. Glowing faint blue and green and gold.

I am the Undertow, said the voice. *I am the pull beneath the waves. I am what takes the drowned down, and what keeps them.*

It turned around them. Slowly. They were tiny, beside it. Like four grains of sand beside a tide.

I know you, Root-beir, said the Undertow. *I knew the one who made you. The one who wove the net.*

Lex didn't speak.

He came here, said the Undertow. *Long ago. He asked for my water, to quench the steel of his great net. And I gave it to him. And he took it, and*

quenched his net, and laid it over the world. The cold voice didn't change. And the net held everything still.

"Still?" said Antho.

Still. The Undertow turned toward him. He felt its attention like a weight of water pressing on his chest. I am Tide. I am change. I am the coming in and the going out. Nothing stays. Everything moves. Everything that is washed away is kept, and everything that is kept is washed into something new. A long pause. That is how the world was meant to be. Moving. Changing. Growing.

And then the one who wove the net put a lid on it. A Ceiling. On every thread. On every soul. Thus far, and no further. Grow this much, and stop. Be this, forever. The cold voice was very heavy. He dammed the deep rivers of the world. He made every soul in it a pond, when it was meant to be a sea.

And I have hated him for nine hundred years.



SERAPHINE'S HAND WAS CRUSHING Antho's fingers.

Lex floated in the dark with the Heart-Coal glowing between his closed hands. His face was very still.

"I broke the Ceiling," he said. "Some of it. Forty thousand people in Caldor. Four hundred thousand in the Sunreach."

You did, said the Undertow. I felt it. Every one. Like ice cracking in spring. A pause. Four hundred and forty thousand. Out of how many? There are millions under the net, Root-beir. Millions. Still capped. Still ponds. Still still.

"I know."

And now you come here, as he came, to ask for my water. To quench another piece of steel. Another lock. Another bar. The great slow body of the Undertow turned around them. Colder. Heavier. To hold something shut. To keep something still.

"To stop a key from turning," said Lex. "If it turns, the lid comes off. Everything under it comes out. The thing that ate the drowned city at the edge of the Hollow. The thing that's wearing my ancestor's face."

I know what lies under the lid. I have drowned its children. The Undertow's voice didn't change. And I know what the lid is made of. Locks

and bars and Ceilings. Stillness. The same stillness that holds back the hungry thing holds down every soul in your world. A pause. You cannot have one without the other, Root-beir. That is the bargain the one who wove the net made. A world held still, to keep it safe.

Why should I help you make it stiller?



NOBODY ANSWERED.

Antho felt the question settle on all of them. Like a weight of water. Cold and true.

Why should I help you make it stiller?

He looked at his brother. Lex had his eyes closed. His jaw was tight. Antho could feel him through the Bloodbond, turning it over and over. Looking for the answer, the way he looked for the flaw in a piece of iron. And not finding it.

Because there wasn't one. The Undertow was right. The Lockward was a bar. A lock. A thing to hold the lid shut. To keep the world still.

Then we fail, thought Antho. Here, in the dark, at the bottom of the sea. Because it's right.

And then Seraphine spoke.



"The sea remembers every stone," she said.

Her voice was shaking. She was white as paper, floating in the dark in Antho's arms, with the drowned memories drifting around her and her father somewhere among them. But she lifted her chin. And said it again. Louder.

"The sea remembers every stone that ever sank beneath her foam."

The Undertow went still.

"She keeps them all, and keeps them well," said Seraphine. "And if you ask, she'll let you tell the story of the one you lost. But you must pay her what it cost." She stopped. Swallowed. "It's a terrible poem. It rhymes 'foam' with 'stone.' I've hated it for eight years."

The Undertow didn't speak.

"It's in a codex in the Spire," said Seraphine. "A Founder's codex. Unsigned. In a margin, in a hand nobody's ever been able to identify. Next

to a page about the forging of the Lattice." Her voice was steadier now. *"I always wondered who wrote it. I thought it was a scribe. Bored. Doodling."* She looked out into the dark, at the vast slow shape turning around them. *"But it wasn't, was it. It was him. Aurelian. After he came here."*

Silence. Cold and enormous.

"He wrote it after you gave him your water," said Seraphine. *"I think he was trying to say thank you. Badly."* She took a breath. *"I think he was trying to say: I know what I took from you. I know what it cost. And I'm sorry."*

The Undertow turned around them. Once. Slowly.

He never said sorry, it said.

"No," said Seraphine. *"He wrote a bad poem in a margin instead. And then he hid it in a codex where nobody would read it for nine hundred years."* Her mouth twisted. *"Men are like that. Even Founders. Especially Founders."*



THE UNDERTOW WAS SILENT for a very long time.

Around them, the drowned memories drifted. Blue and green and gold. A fisherman singing. A child crying over a lost ring. A merchant clinging to a spar, thinking of his daughter.

The one you lost, said the Undertow at last. Quietly. To Seraphine. *Your father.*

Seraphine went rigid in Antho's arms.

He is here, said the Undertow. *I keep him. I keep them all.* A pause. *Would you like to see him?*

Seraphine didn't answer. She couldn't. She was shaking so hard Antho could feel it through his whole body.

You must pay what it cost, said the Undertow. *That is the rule. That is the poem. The sea remembers. And if you ask, I will let you tell the story of the one you lost.* The cold voice was very heavy. *But you must pay me what it cost you to lose him.*

"What did it cost?" whispered Seraphine.

Your fear, said the Undertow. Of me. Of the sea. You have carried it since you were six years old. It has kept you on the shore your whole life. A long pause. Give it to me. And I will show you your father.



SERAPHINE DIDN'T MOVE FOR a long moment.

Then she let go of Antho's hand.

He almost grabbed it back. He almost said *no*. But he looked at her face. White and wet and terrified. And underneath the terror, something else. Something he'd seen in her face once before, in the Spire, years ago, when she'd walked out of a week in Kell's cells with her mind entirely her own.

Choosing.

He let her go.

She floated out into the dark. Away from him. Away from the gold glow of the Lantern, into the deep, where the memories drifted. Alone. Very small. A girl with spectacles and ink-stained fingers, at the bottom of the sea that had taken her father.

"Take it," she said.

And Antho felt the Undertow take it. Felt a great cold current pass through her, gently, the way the tide goes through a rock pool. Felt something leave her. Something old and heavy and tight, like a knot that had been tied in a little girl's chest twenty years ago and never untied.

She took a breath. A deep one. The cold water of the deep going into her, and coming out warm.

And her face changed. Opened. Like a window being thrown wide.

And out of the dark, slowly, drifting toward her on a current only the Undertow could feel, came a light.



ANTHO DIDN'T WATCH.

He turned away. He pulled Teo round with him, and Lex. And floated in the dark with his back to her, and let her have it. Whatever it was. Whatever the sea showed her.

He heard her, though. He couldn't help it. Shade heard everything.

He heard her say *Papa*. Very small. Like a six-year-old.

He heard her laugh. Once. Startled.

He heard her cry.

And he heard her say, after a long time, in her own voice, her grown-up voice, the Royal Archivist of Caldor: *Thank you. Thank you. I'll remember. I promise.*

When he turned back, she was floating in the dark with her spectacles in her hand and her face wet and the light gone. And she was smiling.

"He was singing," she said. "At the end. On the spar. In the storm. He was singing a song he used to sing me at bedtime." She laughed, wet and shaky. "He couldn't sing either. He was terrible. He was so terrible, Antho."

She came back to him through the dark. Not clutching. Not shaking. Swimming. Easily. As if she'd been swimming in the deep all her life.

She took his hand.

"I'm not afraid anymore," she said wonderingly. "Of the sea. I'm not afraid of it at all."



Now, said the Undertow. *You, Root-heir.*

Lex lifted his head.

She paid what the poem asks, said the Undertow. And I have shown her what she lost. That is between her and me. The vast slow shape turned toward him. But you still ask for my water. To quench a bar. To keep the world still.

"Yes."

Then you must pay too. A long pause. Not a fear. Not a memory. A promise.

Lex waited.

When this is done, said the Undertow, when your bar is set and the key is stopped and the hungry thing is held, you will not stop. Its voice was very heavy. You will break the net. Not mend it. Not patch it. Break it. And weave a new one. One that holds back the hunger beneath without holding down the souls above.

Lex stared into the dark.

"I don't know how," he said.

Neither did the one who wove the first, said the Undertow. He found out. A pause. Promise me, Root-heir. That you will not leave the deep rivers

dammed. That you will let the world move again. Every soul in it. Every one. Not forty thousand. Not four hundred thousand. The cold voice rose, very slightly. *All of them.*

The dark was very quiet.

Antho felt it through the Bloodbond. Felt his brother turn it over. Felt how big it was. The whole net. The whole world. Millions of Ceilings. The thing Aurelian had made, nine hundred years ago, with all the Founders and all their power, to be unmade and remade by a smith from Ashbourne.

And he felt his brother decide.

"I promise," said Lex.



Then take it, said the Undertow.

And from somewhere in its vast slow body, a light came drifting toward them. Not a memory. Something else. A drop. A single drop of water, the size of a plum, clear as glass, glowing faintly silver. It floated through the dark toward Lex and stopped in front of him, turning slowly.

"I don't have anything to carry it in," said Lex.

Seraphine let go of Antho's hand. She reached into her coat. And took out a small glass bottle with a cork stopper, half full of black ink.

She looked at it. Then she pulled out the cork, and poured the ink out into the deep sea, where it bloomed in a dark cloud and drifted away.

"I'll buy more," she said. And held out the empty bottle.

The drop of silver water floated into it. Lex pushed the cork in.

ITEM ACQUIRED
THE QUENCH (Wellworld of Tide)
"Water from the deep. It remembers the shape of everything it has ever touched, and will teach that shape to steel."
Component 2 of 4: LOCKWARD

OATH RECORDED (Root)
To the Undertow: "The deep rivers will not stay dammed. All of them."
Status: BINDING

Binding, Antho read. Over his brother's head, in gold. He felt the weight of it settle on Lex like a yoke.



Go now, said the Undertow. *The boy will take you up. He knows the way. He has always known the way.*

Its great slow body began to sink. Away from them. Down. Into the deep.

"*Wait*," said Antho.

He didn't know he was going to say it until he did. The Undertow stopped. Its attention came back to him. A weight of water on his chest.

"*The poem*," said Antho. "*The sea remembers every stone.*" He swallowed. "*Is there—a stone. In a millpond. Below the Ashbourne mill. Skipped by a boy of ten. Five times.*" His voice cracked. "*Is it here?*"

Silence.

Beside him, he felt Lex go very still.

There are a great many stones, said the Undertow. *In a great many millponds.*

"*I know.*"

You paid away your own memory of it. To the Ferryman. At the grey river. It wasn't a question. *I felt it. Your memory fell into his water, and his water runs into mine, eventually. All water does.*

"*Is it here?*"

The Undertow was quiet for a long time.

Not your memory, it said at last. *That is his now. He keeps it. But the millpond remembers. The water remembers. The stone touched it five times, and it kept each touch.* A pause. *I cannot give you back what you paid. But I can show you what the water saw.*

Antho couldn't speak.

It will not be yours, said the Undertow. *It will be the millpond's. Seen from below. From the water's side.* The cold voice was almost gentle. *Do you still want it?*

"*Yes*," said Antho.



THE LIGHT CAME OUT of the dark.

Small. Pale gold. The size of a pebble. Drifting toward him on a slow current. He held out his hand, and it came and sat in his palm, and he looked into it.

And saw.

From below. From under the water. A summer sky, gold and blue, wavering through the surface. Willows, trailing green fingers. And a shape on the bank. Two shapes. A tall thin boy, kneeling. A small one, standing, with a fist drawn back.

Plunk. A stone coming down into the water. Sinking past. Settling into the mud.

Plunk. Another.

And then. A shadow, skimming across the surface. Touching. A ring, spreading out. Lifting. Gone. Touching again. A ring. Lifting.

One. Two. Three. Four.

Five.

And sinking. Slowly. Down through the gold-green water. Turning over and over. A flat grey stone, settling into the mud of the millpond bottom beside a hundred others. And above, wavering through the surface, the two shapes on the bank. The tall one picking up the small one. Swinging him round.

The water couldn't hear. The water didn't know what they were saying. But it saw the small boy's face, wavering through the surface, lit up like the sun.

The light in Antho's palm went out.

He floated in the dark at the bottom of the sea with his hand open and empty, and his eyes stinging with salt that wasn't the sea's.

It wasn't his. The Undertow was right. It was the millpond's. Seen from below. He didn't remember being the tall boy on the bank. He didn't remember the weight of the small one in his arms.

But he'd seen it. The stone, skipping. Five times. The rings spreading. The small face, lit up.

It happened, he thought. It really happened. It's not just a story Lex tells me.

A hand closed on his shoulder. Warm. Big. Scarred with forge-burns.

"Five," said Lex. Hoarse. "You see? Five."

"Five," said Antho.

And then he laughed. At the bottom of the sea, in the dark, with the drowned memories of the world drifting all around him. He laughed until he couldn't breathe, and his brother laughed with him, and Seraphine held his hand and laughed too without knowing why, and Teo floated beside them looking bewildered and delighted.

The sea remembers, said the Undertow, very softly, from far below. Sinking. Going. *Every stone.*



TEO TOOK THEM UP.

It was faster than coming down. A great rushing upward current, cold and dark and then less dark, the drifting memories streaming past them like sparks from a fire, and then blue, and then green, and then silver—

—and they came out of the sea on the Tidewater coast at dawn, gasping, in a whirlpool that spun them out onto the shingle and then smoothed itself flat, as if it had never been.

The others were waiting on the beach. Wren with her bow. Dorran with a fire going. Kestrel sitting on a rock beside Tamsin, watching the sea. Oriel on her mule. The twins, asleep against each other under a blanket.

Wren reached Lex first. She didn't say anything. She just put her arms around him, soaking wet as he was, and held on.

Over her shoulder, Lex held up the little glass bottle. The drop of silver water inside it caught the dawn light and glowed.

"Two," said Wren into his chest.

"Two."

"Two more."

"Two more." He looked down at her. "Stone. And Gale."

"Gale's mine," said Wren. She leaned back and looked up at him, and grinned, wild and fierce. "*And I'm not afraid of anything.*"

Behind them, on the shingle, Teo Brask had sat down at the edge of the surf with his knees drawn up and the waves curling around his bare feet. He was talking to the sea. Very quietly. Antho couldn't hear the words. But he could hear the shape of the silence around them, and it was a happy shape.

Seraphine came and stood beside Antho at the water's edge. She'd taken her boots off. She was standing in the surf. Up to her ankles. Letting the cold grey water wash over her feet.

"It's lovely," she said, sounding surprised. *"It's actually lovely. Why did nobody tell me?"*

"Everyone told you," said Antho.

"Well, I didn't believe them." She took his hand. *"I believe them now."*

They stood together in the surf as the sun came up over the sea, and Antho thought, very clearly, the way he hadn't let himself think in years:

I want to marry her.

He didn't say it. Not yet. But he held her hand, and watched the sun come up, and thought it. And the thought sat in the warm empty hollow in the dark, where something else had been, and fit there. Not the same shape. But warm.

That's not nothing, he thought.

CHAPTER 18

THE WELLWORLD OF STONE



"You're hitting it too hard," said Dorran Vask.

Lex opened his eyes.

He was sitting cross-legged on a ledge of grey rock, high on the south face of the Old Man of the Ironbacks, with his palms flat on the cliff in front of him and the wind tearing at his coat. He'd been sitting there since dawn. It was past noon now. His legs had gone numb an hour ago. His back ached. His hands were raw from the cold stone.

And the mountain had said nothing. Nothing at all.

"I'm not hitting it," he said. "I'm not doing anything. I'm sitting here. *Listening.*"

"You're listening too hard." Dorran was sitting on a boulder a few paces along the ledge, with his great hammer across his knees and his old leather coat buttoned to the throat against the wind. He'd been there as long as Lex had. He hadn't moved. *"Same thing. You're trying to make it talk. Like a plowshare. Pushing."*

"I'm not pushing."

"You are." Dorran's great slab of a face didn't change. *"I can see it in your shoulders. You've been pushing since sunrise. Pushing and pushing."* He shifted his hammer. *"You're in a hurry."*

"Of course I'm in a hurry." It came out sharper than he meant. Lex took a breath. "Thirty-three days, Dorran. Oriel says thirty-three. Elric's walking to the Lock, and I've got two pieces out of four, and I can't open the next door until this mountain decides to talk to me, and it *won't.*"

"No," Dorran agreed. *"It won't. Not while you're in a hurry."*

Lex stared at him.

"Stone doesn't hurry," said Dorran. "You know that. You said it yourself. In Ysmir's temple. You told me after. The mountain doesn't hurry, but it does, sometimes, agree." He looked up at the great grey peak rising above them, its summit lost in cloud. *"It's been here a million years, lad. It'll be here a million more. Your thirty-three days are nothing to it. Less than nothing."* He looked back at Lex. *"You want it to talk to you? Stop counting."*



HE DIDN'T STOP COUNTING. He couldn't. It was like telling himself not to breathe.

But he tried.

He sat on the ledge as the afternoon went on and the shadows of the Ironbacks crept across the valleys below. He put his palms on the cold rock. He closed his eyes. And he tried, very hard, not to try.

[That's a contradiction,] said Ember.

I know.

[I'm only mentioning it.]

Thank you.

He listened.

He'd been at Answering in Stone for three years. Since the moor, since the Umbral Wardens, since the night in Ysmir's temple when he'd asked the bedrock under the glacier to hold and it had, grudgingly, like an old man getting up from a chair. Answering meant the Well heard him and answered back. A little. When it chose to.

Speaking was more. Speaking was a conversation. Speaking was what he had with Flame: the fire leaning toward him, talking back, telling him things, listening to his answers. The Sunwell had spoken to him. The Hearth had spoken to him.

Stone had never once said a word.

He listened. The wind. The cold. The great grey weight of the mountain under his palms. Deep. Old. Silent.

Please, he thought at it. *Please. I need to come in.*

Nothing.

Please. There's a key. There's a lock. There's something under the world that wants to come out. Please.

Nothing.

He opened his eyes. The sun was going down. The valleys below were full of blue shadow.

"Too hard," said Dorran, from his boulder.

Lex put his face in his hands.



ILSE FOUND HIM THERE after dark.

He hadn't gone down to the camp. The others were in a hollow below the ledge, around a fire: Kestrel and Tamsin, Antho with Seraphine, Wren, Teo. Oriel on her mule. Ivo, sitting apart, with a blanket around his shoulders. The two dragons were on the next ridge, curled together like a pair of storm-clouds.

Ilse came up the path alone, slowly, leaning on a stick. She was very faint tonight. Fainter than she'd been in the Wellworld days. Lex could see the rock through her shoulders when she passed in front of the stars.

She sat down beside him on the ledge.

"Ivo's asleep," she said. *"Finally. He sits up with me every night. Watching me. In case I fade while he's not looking."* She pulled her coat tighter. *"He thinks I don't notice."*

"I'm sorry," said Lex.

"Stop saying that." She didn't look at him. *"You gave him the bit for me. In the glass. Everyone keeps forgetting that part. You traded the second piece of the key for me."* She was quiet. *"Nobody's ever traded anything for me before. Except Ivo."*

Lex didn't say anything.

"I'm thirty-six percent now," said Ilse. *"Did you know? It's been going up. Slowly. Since the Hollowmaw."* She held up her hand against the stars. He could see them through her fingers. *"Ivo's holding me. Every day. Remembering. But he's tired. And the key's whole now, and it's pulling. On all of us. All the fifty-five."* She lowered her hand. *"I can feel it. Like a book in my chest. Like someone very far away, slowly reeling in a line."*

"Elric," said Lex.

"*Elric.*" She was quiet. "*He's getting closer to the lock. Every day. And the closer he gets, the harder it pulls.*"

Lex looked at her. At her faint face in the starlight.

"How long?" he said.

"*I don't know.*" Ilse shrugged. "*Long enough. Maybe.*" She looked at the cliff. "*So you'd better get this mountain talking, smith. Because I'd quite like to be all here for the end of the world.*"



HE SAT ON THE ledge all night.

He didn't sleep. He didn't move. He put his palms on the rock, and closed his eyes, and listened.

Not trying. He'd stopped trying around midnight. He was too tired to try. He just sat. And breathed. And let the cold of the stone come up into his hands, and his arms, and his chest.

He thought about Brannoc.

He didn't know why. It just came. Brannoc in the Ashbourne forge, ten years ago, when Lex was twelve and so desperate to be good at everything that he'd broken three hammers in a month.

You're fighting it, lad. Brannoc's big hand on his shoulder. Gentle. *Iron's not your enemy. It doesn't want to be a hoe or a horseshoe or a sword. It just wants to be iron. You're not making it do anything. You're asking it nicely to be something else for a while.*

How do I ask it nicely?

You wait. You let it get hot enough. You let it tell you when it's ready. Brannoc had shrugged his enormous shoulders. *You can't hurry iron. It knows when you're hurrying. It goes stiff on you. Like a horse.*

Lex sat on the ledge with his hands on the mountain and thought about iron. About waiting for the color. About the moment, every time, when the bar in the coals went from red to orange to the yellow of a summer sunset, and you just *knew*. Not because you'd counted. Not because you'd hurried it. Because it told you.

I'm not making you do anything, he thought at the mountain. *I'm just here. Sitting. Like Brannoc taught me. I'll wait until you're ready.*

However long it takes.

And he let go of the thirty-three days.

It was the hardest thing he'd ever done. Harder than the Lampshade. Harder than not reaching for the gold in the Glass Desert. He felt the count go out of him like a held breath. Thirty-three days. Elric walking. Ilse fading. His mother behind the door. He let go of all of it. Just for a moment. Just for now.

And sat. On a ledge. On a mountain. In the dark. With his hands on the stone.

Waiting.



THE MOUNTAIN SPOKE AT dawn.

Not in words. Not in fire, the way Flame spoke. Not in a current, like Tide.

In *weight*.

He felt it come up through his palms. Slowly. So slowly. A pressure, from somewhere very far down, below the roots of the Old Man, below the bedrock, below everything. Rising. Not like a wave. Like a tide of stone. Like the slow, slow heave of a continent shifting in its sleep.

It took a long time to reach him. A very long time. The sun came up while he waited. The valleys below filled with gold. He didn't move.

And then it was there. In his hands. In the rock under his palms.

...You... waited.

Slow. So slow. Each word took a breath. A voice like the grinding of boulders in a riverbed. Like a landslide heard from very far away. Like the creak of the earth.

...Nobody... waits.

Lex didn't move. He didn't speak. He barely breathed.

...The one who... wove the net... did not... wait. A pause as long as a sunrise. *...He came... with his hammer... and his hurry... and he cut my bones... into Stones... and he tied his net... to me... and pinned me... still.*

...He never... asked.

I'm asking, thought Lex. As slowly as he could. *I'm sorry. I'm asking.*

The mountain was silent for a long time.

...Yes, it said at last. ...You are.

And the cliff in front of him *opened*.



ATTUNEMENT – STONE

Answering → SPEAKING

"The mountain does not hurry. Neither,
now, do you."

HE HEARD DORRAN STAND up behind him. Heard the big man's breath go out of him in a long slow *hub*.

"*Told you,*" said Dorran Vask. "*Too hard.*"

Lex laughed. He couldn't help it. He sat on the ledge with his legs completely numb and his hands frozen to the rock, and laughed until his eyes ran.

Then he looked at the opening in the cliff.

It wasn't a door. It was a *seam*. A long vertical crack in the grey rock, a pace wide and twenty feet tall, running straight up the face of the mountain. And beyond it, darkness. Not black. Deep grey-brown, like the inside of a stone. And from it, a smell. Cold, mineral, ancient. Like the air in a cave that has been sealed for a thousand years.

"*Four can go,*" said Oriel Sant, from somewhere behind him. She'd come up the path on her mule while he wasn't looking. "*Same as the others. Choose.*"

Lex looked around at them. They'd all come up from the camp. The whole band of them, on the ledge in the dawn light, looking at the crack in the mountain.

"Dorran," he said.

The giant nodded slowly. As if he'd known.

"*Me,*" said Ivo Marrow.

Everyone turned. He was standing at the back, with the blanket still around his shoulders. His face was grey with tiredness. He had his arm around his sister's waist.

"*And Ilse,*" he said. "*Both of us. Or neither.*"

"*Ivo—*" said Ilse.

"*No.*" He didn't look at her. He looked at Lex. "*She's thirty-six percent gone. The key's pulling her. I can feel it. Every night.*" His voice cracked.

"Stone holds things. Doesn't it? That's what it does. It holds things still. Holds things in place." He swallowed. "Maybe it can hold her."

Lex looked at him. Then at Ilse. Faint and pale in the dawn, leaning on her brother.

"Yes," he said. "Both of you."



THE WELLWORLD OF STONE was heavy.

That was the first thing. The moment Lex stepped through the seam, he felt it come down on him like a yoke. Not pressure. *Weight*. Everything weighed more here. His arms. His legs. His head. The Heart-Coal in its iron box on his belt. The little glass bottle of the Quench in his coat. He staggered. Caught himself on the wall.

Behind him, Dorran grunted. Ivo swore. Ilse made no sound at all.

"It's like," said Ivo, through his teeth, "*carrying a cart. On my back. Uphill.*"

"Walk slow," said Dorran. He was moving carefully, deliberately, like a man walking through deep water. "*Don't fight it. Let it hold you.*"

Lex looked around.

They were in a cavern. Or the Wellworld was a cavern. There was no sky. Above them, far above, so far it was only a dim brown-grey haze, there was a ceiling of rock. Below them, a floor of rock. And between them, in every direction, rock. Walls. Columns. Pillars as thick as towers, rising from the floor to the haze above. Some of them were carved. Or worn. Or *grown*; Lex couldn't tell. They had faces in them. Huge, ancient, weathered faces, eyes closed, like the faces of sleeping giants.

And everywhere, running through the rock, light. Veins of it. Crystal. Glowing faint blue and violet and gold, threading through the stone like the veins on the back of a hand. They pulsed. Slowly. So slowly. Once every hundred heartbeats.

Like a heartbeat, thought Lex. *A very, very slow one.*

[*It's alive,*] said Ember. Very quietly. [*All of it. The whole world. It's one thing. One enormous, slow, sleeping thing.*]



THEY WALKED.

It took a long time. Everything took a long time here. Every step was a decision. Lift. Move. Set down. Like walking through mud, except the mud was the air, and the air was made of stone.

And as they walked, Lex noticed something. The light in the crystal veins. It wasn't just pulsing. It was *moving*. Very slowly. Along the veins. Flowing. All in one direction. Down. Toward something.

They followed it.

The pillars grew bigger. The faces in them grew older. More worn. Some of them had opened their eyes. Very slightly. Slits of crystal light, watching the four tiny figures walk past at their feet.

"*Giants*," whispered Ivo.

"*Sleepers*," said Dorran. He didn't sound surprised. "*The old mountain-kings. Before the net. Before anything.*" He was looking up at a face in a pillar the size of a castle. "*My grandmother used to tell stories. About the stone-folk who slept under the hills.*" He was quiet. "*I didn't believe her.*"



THEY FOUND THE HEART after what felt like a day.

It was a pit. Like the Sunwell. A great round shaft going down into the floor of the cavern, so wide that Lex couldn't see the other side. All the crystal veins in the Wellworld ran down into it, pulsing, flowing. The light poured over the edge of the pit like a slow waterfall of glow.

And at the bottom, very far down, something *shone*.

Not bright. Not like the Heart-Coal. A deep, dull, steady glow. Grey and red and iron-dark. Like the color of metal in a forge, just before it starts to glow. Like the core of a cannonball fresh from the mould.

...*Heartiron*, said the voice.

It came from everywhere. From the floor. From the pillars. From the sleeping faces. From the weight on Lex's shoulders. Slow. Grinding. A landslide heard from very far away.

...*The bones... of the world... The first... iron... From before... the net... From before... the light...*

...*He took... some... once. The one who wove the net. To make... his Stones... his anchors... his pins.* A long, long pause. ...*He did not... ask.*

"I'm asking," said Lex. Slowly. "For a little. A piece. To forge a bar. To stop a key from turning."

...I know... what you want it for. The voice was very slow and very heavy. *...I felt you... ask me... on the mountain... all night.* A pause. *...You waited.*

"Yes."

...Then you may... have it. Another pause, longer. *...If you... can carry it.*



LEX LOOKED DOWN INTO the pit.

It was a long way down. Hundreds of feet. Thousands. The walls were sheer, ridged with veins of crystal light flowing downward. And at the bottom, the Heartiron. Glowing dull red-grey.

"How do we get down?" said Ivo.

...You do not, said the voice. *...It comes... up.*

And from the bottom of the pit, slowly, something began to rise.

A lump. Rough and dark. The size of a man's fist. Not glowing now, as it came up out of the deep. Just dark. Grey-black and pitted, like a meteorite. Rising slowly through the air of the pit, borne up on nothing, turning a little as it came.

It reached the lip of the pit. It hung there, in the air, in front of Lex.

He reached out to take it.

And it *weighed*.

Not like iron. Not like anything. He got his hand under it and it came down into his palm like a mountain. His arm buckled. His knees hit the floor. His whole body bent toward the stone under him, as if the Heartiron were pulling him down into the earth.

He couldn't lift it. He couldn't even hold it. It was crushing his hand.

...Heartiron, said the voice, *weighs... what you carry.*

Lex gasped. "*What—*"

...Not what it is. What you are. What you carry... in you. The voice was very slow. *...Your guilt. Your grief. Your promises. Your hurry. Every... weight... you have ever picked up... and not put down.*

...You carry... a great deal... Root-beir.



HE TRIED.

He got his other hand under it. He pushed with everything he had. Stone. Flame. Muscle. He was the strongest man he knew, after Dorran, and he'd swung a hammer every day of his life since he was twelve.

He couldn't lift it.

The weight of it was everything. Forty-eight names in a book against his chest. Fifty-five. Ilse, thirty-six percent gone. Forty-one graves on the Hollowmaw slope. The Bit, thrown across a crater. Kestrel's rag. His mother, behind a door, for eleven years, while he made horseshoes in Ashbourne and didn't know. A promise to the Undertow, binding. Millions of Ceilings. A whole world to remake.

He couldn't lift it. Nobody could have lifted it.

"Give it here," said Dorran.



LEX LOOKED UP.

The giant was kneeling beside him on the stone floor. His great slab of a face very calm. His huge scarred hands held out.

"Dorran, no. You don't understand. It weighs what you—"

"I heard." Dorran's voice was a slow deep rumble. Like rocks shifting in a stream. Like the voice of the mountain, almost. *"What you carry. Guilt. Grief. Promises."* He looked at Lex. *"I've been carrying four thousand one hundred and nine children for twenty years, lad. Every one of them. In a book in my coat."* He held out his hands. *"I know how to carry things."*

"It'll crush you—"

"Maybe." Dorran didn't move. *"But I've been practising."*

And he reached out and took the Heartiron out of Lex's hands.



LEX FELT THE WEIGHT leave him. All at once. Like setting down a cart he'd been pulling uphill for years. He fell backward onto the stone floor and lay there, gasping.

And Dorran Vask knelt on the floor of the Wellworld of Stone, with the Heartiron in his hands.

Lex saw it hit him.

Saw the giant's shoulders bow. Saw his arms tremble. Saw his great head bend forward, slowly, slowly, toward the floor. Saw the veins stand out on his shaved scalp like ropes. Saw his face go dark red, then grey.

He didn't drop it.

His knees cracked against the stone. His back bent. He was bowing over it, like a man bowing over a grave. Like a man praying. And the Heartiron sat in his cupped hands, small and dark and pitted, and weighed four thousand one hundred and nine children. And twenty-two years of Kindling-days. And a little girl at a Stone in Kessick, looking up at him and saying, *Why did you put the light out?*

"Dorran," said Ilse.

She'd come forward. Slowly. Through the heavy air. Leaning on her stick. Faint as smoke. She knelt down beside the giant on the floor. And put her faint hand on his bowed back.

"Dorran," she said again. *"I forgave you. In the Bitter Hills. Do you remember?"*

He couldn't answer. His jaw was locked. His whole body was shaking.

"*I meant it,*" said Ilse Marrow. *"I meant it then and I mean it now. You only did what you thought was right. And then you found out it wasn't, and you stopped. And you spent twenty years trying to make up for it."* Her faint hand pressed on his back. *"You've made up for it, Dorran. You made up for it a long time ago. You can put some of it down."*

Dorran made a sound. Low. Terrible. Like a mountain cracking.

"*Not all of it,*" said Ilse. *"I know you won't. You're too stubborn. But some. Put down some of it."* Her voice was very gentle. *"Put me down. I forgave you. I'm not yours to carry anymore."*

And Lex saw the giant's back straighten.

A little. Just a little. An inch. As if something had been lifted off it.

"*Me too,*" said Ivo.

He was kneeling on Dorran's other side. Lex hadn't seen him move. His grey eyes were wet.

"*I wanted to kill you,*" said Ivo. *"In the Bitter Hills. When we found you. I had my knife out. Ilse stopped me."* He swallowed. *"I've hated you for a long time, Dorran. Even after. Even when you were carrying things for us*

and building forges and making us soup." He put his hand on Dorran's shoulder. *"I'm done. I'm putting it down too. Both of us."*

Another inch.

Dorran Vask lifted his head.

His face was wet. His great slab of a face, broken nose, grey beard, all of it running with tears. He looked at Ilse. At Ivo. At the twins he had capped at fourteen, kneeling on either side of him, with their hands on his back.

And he stood up.

Slowly. Slowly. Like a mountain getting up from a chair. With the Heartiron held in both his cupped hands against his chest. Shaking. Grey-faced. Sweat running down his scalp.

But standing.



...Ah, said the voice.

The whole Wellworld seemed to breathe. The crystal veins pulsed, all at once, bright. The sleeping faces in the pillars opened their eyes. All of them. Hundreds of them. Slits of crystal light, turned toward the giant standing at the edge of the pit with the bones of the world in his hands.

...He carries... what you could not... Root-beir, said the voice of Stone. Slow. Grinding. *...Because he has learned... to put things down.*

...That is... what weight is for. Not to carry forever. To carry... until you can set it down... somewhere it belongs.

ITEM ACQUIRED

HEARTIRON (Wellworld of Stone)

"The bones of the world. It weighs
what its bearer carries."

Bearer: DORRAN VASK

Component 3 of 4: LOCKWARD

DORRAN VASK

ATTUNEMENT — STONE (awakened)

Listening → ANSWERING

"He was always the mountain's kind.
Nobody ever asked him to listen."

Lex lay on the floor and looked up at the panel over Dorran's head, in silver, hanging in the heavy brown air of the Wellworld of Stone. And laughed. And cried. He wasn't sure which.



...And the faded one, said the voice.

Ilse turned her head.

...She is... coming apart. The voice was very slow. ...A thread... being pulled... from very far away. By the key. A pause. ...I cannot... restore... what was cut. That is not... mine.

Ivo's face crumpled.

...But I can... hold... what is.

And from the floor of the cavern, at Ilse's feet, something rose. A pebble. Small and round and grey, with a single vein of crystal light running through it, pulsing slowly. It rose up through the heavy air and hung in front of her face.

...Take it, said the voice of Stone. ...Keep it... close. Against your heart. Where the thread... runs out.

Ilse reached out a faint hand. And closed it around the pebble.

And Lex, lying on the floor, saw the panel over her head flicker.

ILSE MARROW

THREAD: UNWRITTEN (partial – 36%)

Anchored by: KIN-MEMORY (twin)

+ STONE (Wellworld)

Status: HELD – further loss halted

Held.

Ivo read it. Over his sister's head, in gold. Lex saw him read it. Saw his lips move. *Held. Further loss halted.*

And Ivo Marrow, the thief, the illusionist, who had sat up every night for six weeks watching his sister fade, put his arms around her and his face in her shoulder, on the floor of the Wellworld of Stone, and wept like a child.



THE WAY OUT WAS slow.

Everything here was slow. They walked back through the heavy air, between the pillars with their sleeping faces, following the crystal veins upward instead of down. Dorran walked in the middle, with the Heartiron held against his chest in both hands. He didn't speak. He didn't need to. He walked steadily, one great slow step after another, and the weight of the world in his hands didn't bow him again.

The faces in the pillars watched him go. All of them. Eyes open. Crystal light.

...Go well, said the voice of Stone, behind them, very faint now. Sinking back down into the deep. *...Mountain's child.*

They came out through the seam onto the ledge on the south face of the Old Man of the Ironbacks.

And it was night.

Lex stopped. He looked up at the stars. Then at the moon, which was a thin silver crescent low over the western peaks. It had been full. When they went in. At dawn.

"How long?" he said.

Wren was there. She'd been waiting on the ledge, sitting cross-legged on Dorran's boulder with her bow across her knees. She stood up when they came out. Her face was very still.

"Six days," she said.

Lex went cold.

"You were gone six days," said Wren. *"It felt like six hours to you, didn't it?"* She looked at his face. *"It was six days here. Oriel says the Stone runs slow. Slower than anything."* She swallowed. *"Twenty-six days left, Hammer. Twenty-six."*

Lex stood on the ledge and looked at the thin crescent moon.

Six days.

[It's all right,] said Ember. Very firmly. *[It's all right, Lex. You have three of the four. Three. In eleven days. Fire and water and iron.]* A pause. *[One more. And then the forging.]*

Twenty-six days.

[Twenty-six days is a lot of days.]

He looked at Dorran. The giant was standing at the edge of the ledge, with the Heartiron held against his chest, looking out at the dark valleys of the Ironbacks below. His face was calm. Calmer than Lex had ever seen it.

He looked at Ilse and Ivo. Sitting together on the ledge. Ilse with the little stone pebble held against her heart. Ivo with his arm around her. Both of them asleep, almost at once, leaning against each other, like children after a long day at the fair.

He looked at Wren.

"*Gale,*" she said. "*Mine. Tomorrow.*" She lifted her chin. "*And I'm not going to take six days. I'm going to take six minutes.*"

Lex almost laughed.

"Where's the door?" he said.

Wren looked west. Toward the far end of the Greyspine. Toward the Teeth, black against the stars, where the world grew thin. And above them, very faint, a flicker. Lightning. Silent. Walking along the high ridges on long white legs.

"*Up there,*" she said. "*Where the storms are born.*"

Behind her, on the next ridge, a vast ragged storm-dragon lifted her head and looked west too. And made a sound. Low and deep and rumbling, like thunder over mountains a hundred miles off.

Like someone who knew the way home.

CHAPTER 19

THE WELLWORLD OF GALE



WREN ASHDOWN HAD NEVER been afraid of heights.

She'd been told so, often. By her mother, who used to find her at the top of the tallest pine in the forest at five years old, singing. By Garrick, who'd watched her walk along the parapet of Fort Caldris with her arms out like a tightrope dancer and said, *Ashdown, if you fall off that wall I will personally kill you*. By Lex, who'd held onto her on the back of a dragon over the Greyspine at night, and felt her laughing, and said, *How are you not terrified?*

She didn't know. She'd just never been. The ground was a place you started from. The sky was where you were going.

So when they came up through the high passes of the Teeth on the twenty-sixth morning before the end, on dragons, into the place where the storms were born, she wasn't afraid.

She was *home*.



THE STORMS WERE BORN at the top of the world.

That's what it looked like. The highest peak of the Teeth, a black spike of rock so tall it punched through the clouds, and around it, the sky was alive. Lightning walked along the ridges on long white legs. Clouds boiled up out of nothing, grey and black and purple, churning, and tore themselves apart, and boiled up again. The wind howled. Not one wind. A hundred winds. Coming from every direction at once, crashing together over the peak, spiralling up into the sky in great invisible towers.

And at the very center of it, directly above the black spike, a hole.

A hole in the storm. A perfect circle of calm, clear, deep blue sky, ringed by churning cloud. Like the eye of a hurricane. Like the pupil of an enormous eye, looking down.

"*There*," said Wren.

She was standing in the air beside Ashka, with the wind tearing at her coat and her braid whipping round her face. She hadn't needed to step for an hour. The wind here *held* her. Like hands under her feet. Like the whole sky was a floor.

"*That's the door*," she said. "*Can you feel it, Hammer? Can you hear it?*"

Lex was clinging to Ashka's neck with both hands. His face was green. He looked at the eye in the storm. Then at her.

"I can hear the wind," he said. "That's all. Very loud wind."

"*It's singing*," said Wren.



IT WAS. SHE'D NEVER heard anything like it.

At Duskhold, when she'd reached Speaking, Gale had spoken to her for the first time. A voice in the wind. Light and quick and laughing, like a girl running through long grass. She'd heard it every day since. Every time she stepped into the air. A little whisper at her ear: *up, up, up, lightfoot. Higher. Faster. Come on.*

This was that voice. But a thousand times bigger. A thousand voices. Singing. All around the peak. In the churning clouds and the walking lightning and the crashing winds. A great wild wordless chorus, rising and falling, like every wind that had ever blown in the world singing at once.

And under it, very faint, from the eye of the storm, one voice. Older than the others. Deeper. Calling.

Come up.

Wren stood in the air and listened, and felt tears freeze on her cheeks in the high cold wind.

"*Wren*," said Antho.

He was behind Lex on Ashka's back. Holding on with one hand. His other hand was stretched out toward the vast ragged shape of Vharuun, flying beside them. Pushing wind under her torn wings. Holding her up,

the way he'd held her up all the way from the Drowned Country. His face was grey with the effort.

But the storm-mother wasn't struggling now. That was the strange thing. As they'd come up into the storms, Vharuun had flown easier. Stronger. Her ragged wings had caught the winds and *beld* them. And now she was gliding beside them in great slow arcs, her head lifted toward the eye in the sky, her one good gold eye wide.

"*Wren,*" said Antho again. "*Look at her.*"

Wren looked.

And saw that Vharuun was crying.

Great slow tears. Rolling out of her gold eye. Freezing in the wind. Falling away down into the clouds like hailstones.

HOME, said the storm-mother. Wren didn't hear it. She felt it. Through the wind. A great slow rumble of thunder that came through the sky and into her chest. *THIS IS WHERE I WAS BORN. A THOUSAND YEARS AGO. IN THE EYE OF THE STORM.*

I THOUGHT I WOULD NEVER SEE IT AGAIN.



THEY WENT UP.

Not on the dragons. The dragons couldn't take them through the eye; Wren knew that somehow, the way she knew which way the wind was going to turn. The eye was a door, and doors were for people. Dragons could follow. But people had to go first.

"*Four,*" she said. "*Oriel said four.*"

"*Me,*" said Antho. "*I hear Gale. Answering.*" He looked at Vharuun. "*And somebody has to keep her up.*"

"*And Lex.*" Wren looked at him. Still clinging to Ashka's neck. Still green. "*He's carrying the coal and the water. And the iron's with Dorran on the ridge below.*" She hesitated. "*And because it's his bar. He has to see where the breath comes from.*"

"Who's the fourth?" said Lex.

Wren looked down. At the ridge far below them, where the others were waiting. Dorran with the Heartiron. Seraphine with her notebook. Teo.

Oriel. The twins. And Kestrel, sitting on a rock a little apart, with her brother beside her.

"Nobody," said Wren. "*Three's enough.*"

Lex looked at her.

"*Gale doesn't like crowds,*" said Wren. "*I can bear it. It's a door for one, really. Two at a push. Three if they hold hands.*" She held out her hand. "*Come on, Hammer.*"

He looked down at the drop. Four thousand feet of empty air, straight down into the boiling clouds.

"*You're going to tell me to jump,*" he said.

"*I'm going to tell you to step,*" said Wren. "*Off the dragon. Into the air. Holding my hand.*" She grinned at him. "*And I'm not going to drop you. I promise. Properly.*"

He looked at her for a long moment.

Then he let go of Ashka's neck.

And took her hand.

And stepped.



SHE DIDN'T DROP HIM.

She'd never carried anyone before. Not really. Windstep was for one. It held her up, light as a leaf, but she'd always known it wouldn't hold anyone else. She'd tried, once, with Seraphine, at Fort Caldris, and they'd both nearly broken their necks.

But this wasn't Windstep. This was the sky at the top of the world. And the sky *wanted* them.

She felt it. The moment Lex stepped off the dragon's back, the moment his weight came onto her hand. The winds came. All of them. From every direction. Crashing together under him, under her, under Antho stepping off behind, and *lifting*. Like a hand. Like the whole storm reaching down and cupping them in its palm.

Lex made a sound. Not a scream. Something between a gasp and a laugh.

"*Wren,*" he said. "*Wren, I'm flying. I'm—*"

"*I know*," said Wren. She was laughing too. "*I know, Hammer. Isn't it wonderful?*"

And they went up into the eye of the storm.



THE WELLWORLD OF GALE had no ground.

That was the first thing. Wren had half expected it, the way she'd half expected everything about this place. But it still took her breath away.

There was sky. Only sky. Endless. In every direction. Above, below, around. Blue and gold and white and silver, going on forever. And in it, *clouds*. Huge ones. Islands of cloud, floating in the endless sky, white and grey and pink and gold, with mountains on them and valleys and rivers of mist pouring off their edges into nothing. Some of them were small, the size of a house. Some were bigger than Caldor. They drifted slowly through the sky, turning, colliding, merging, tearing apart.

And between them, the winds.

She could *see* them. Here, the winds were visible. Long rippling streams of silver light, flowing between the clouds like rivers in the air. Some were gentle, slow, broad as lakes. Some were fierce, narrow, shrieking, twisting around each other like ropes. They crossed and wove and tangled, a great endless shining web of moving air, filling the sky.

And in the winds, *things*. Living. Shapes of air and light. Birds, but not birds. Long and slender, trailing streamers of silver, diving and rising through the winds faster than anything Wren had ever seen. Fish, but not fish. Swimming through the sky in great shimmering shoals. And far off, very far, something enormous. A shape like a whale, made of storm-cloud and lightning, drifting slowly through the endless blue.

"*Oh*," said Antho, behind her. His voice was very small. "*Oh. It's free.*"

Wren looked back at him.

He was standing on the wind. On his own. Not holding her hand anymore. His grey eyes were wide and wet. His black hair was blowing wild. And on his face was an expression she'd never seen there in four years.

Joy. Plain, uncomplicated, open joy. Like a child's.

"*There's no net here*," said Antho. "*Can you feel it? No net. No Lattice. No Ceiling. No door. Nothing holding anything down.*" He laughed. A short

wild startled sound. *"It's the only place I've ever been where nothing's holding anything down."*



THEY FLEW.

There was nothing else to do. There was no ground to walk on. You either stood on the wind or you fell. And the wind didn't want them to fall. It wanted them to *fly*. Wren felt it pulling at her, tugging, laughing. *Come on, lightfoot, come on, come on.*

So she went. With Lex's hand in hers. With Antho flying beside them on his own, clumsy, laughing, his long coat flapping like a crow's wings. Down a long silver river of wind between two cloud-islands, so fast the air screamed past her ears. Up through a waterfall of mist pouring off the edge of a cloud. Around and around a column of rising air, spiralling up, up, up, until the clouds below were tiny and the blue above went on forever.

Lex stopped being green. Somewhere in the first hour. He stopped clutching her hand like a drowning man and started just holding it. And then, near the top of the spiral, he started laughing too.

"This is mad," he shouted over the wind. *"This is completely mad. I'm a smith. I'm a smith from Ashbourne. I'm supposed to be on the ground. Next to an anvil."*

"Do you want to go back?"

"No!"

Wren laughed so hard she nearly lost the wind.



THEY FOUND THE HEART in the afternoon. If there was afternoon here.

It wasn't a place. It was a *wind*. The oldest one. Wren felt it before she saw it: the deep slow voice she'd heard from the eye of the storm, calling. *Come up*. Getting louder. Closer. Until they came around the edge of a cloud-island the size of a mountain range, and there it was.

A wind. A single wind. Wider than a river. Wider than a lake. Flowing through the endless sky in a great slow circle, around and around, so wide that Wren couldn't see the other side. Silver and gold and white, shining,

like a ring of light. And in the middle of the ring, empty sky. Perfectly still. Perfectly calm. Perfectly blue.

The First Breath.

She knew its name the way she knew the wind's direction. Not because anyone told her. Because it was *true*.

Lightfoot, said the First Breath.

Its voice was everywhere. In every wind. In every cloud. In her own lungs, going in and out. Light and deep and very, very old. Like the first breath of a newborn, and the last breath of a dying man, and every breath in between.

You came. You heard me calling. Through the eye.

"Yes," said Wren. Her voice came out small. *"I heard you."*

Not many hear me. Not anymore. The net is very loud. It drowns me out. A pause. Like a sigh. The one who wove it heard me once. Long ago. He came here, and stood on my wind, and asked me for breath. For his bellows. To forge his great net.

I gave it to him.

And he wove the net. And laid it over the world. And the world below stopped breathing.



LEX HAD GONE STILL beside her. She felt his hand tighten.

"*Stopped breathing?*" said Wren.

Not the people, said the First Breath. *Their souls. Their threads. Every soul is meant to breathe. In and out. To grow and change and become. That is what I am. Breath. Life. Freedom. The air that moves.*

And the net held every soul still. Capped. Ceilinged. Thus far and no further. A long sigh. A soul with a Ceiling is a soul holding its breath. Forever. Never letting go. Never taking in.

I have felt them below me for nine hundred years. Millions of them. All holding their breath.

Wren looked at Lex.

He was staring into the empty blue at the center of the great ring of wind. His jaw was tight. She felt it through his hand: the same thing she'd

felt from the Undertow. The weight of it. The whole world, holding its breath, because his ancestor had asked.

"I promised the Undertow," he said. Quietly. "At the bottom of the sea. That I'd break the net. All of it. Every Ceiling. And weave a new one."

I know. I heard. The sea and I talk. All the Wells talk, in the deep. A pause. That is why I let you up through my eye.

"Then you'll give us the breath?"

I will give the lightfoot the breath, said the First Breath. Not you, Root-heir. Her.

Wren went still.

You cannot carry it, said the First Breath. It is not a coal, or a drop, or a stone. It is breath. It must be carried in a chest. In lungs. Held, and carried, and breathed out into the fire when the bar is forged. A pause. Only one who Speaks to me can hold my breath without being torn apart by it.

And there is a price.



WREN HAD KNOWN THERE would be. There always was. She'd watched Seraphine pay her fear to the sea. She'd watched Antho pay a stone that skipped five times. She'd watched Dorran carry the weight of four thousand children and set some of it down.

"Name it," she said.

The First Breath was quiet for a long time.

You hold on, it said at last. Too tight.

Wren didn't move.

You hold on to him, said the First Breath. To the smith. You are afraid. Not of heights. Not of falling. You have never been afraid of falling. A pause. You are afraid of being left.

Something cold went through Wren's chest.

Your mother, said the First Breath. Very gently. Like a breeze through long grass. When you were eight. She went into the dark. For a year. Into her own head, behind her own eyes, and did not come out. You sat beside her bed every day. And held her hand. And she did not know you.

Wren couldn't speak.

And then the smith, said the First Breath. Who left you a note on a pillow. Who walks into the dark again and again without you. You hold on to him so tight. You follow him into burning forges and Founders' temples and the Pale Warden's fortress. Because if you let go, even for a moment, he might go into the dark and not come out.

Like her.



SHE WAS CRYING. SHE didn't know when she'd started. The tears were blowing away off her face in the wind, little silver drops, scattering into the endless blue.

Lex's hand was very still in hers.

"*What do you want,*" she said. Her voice was shaking. "*What's the price.*"

Let go of his hand, said the First Breath.

Wren stared into the empty blue.

Just for a moment, said the First Breath. *Here. In my sky. Where nothing holds anything down.* A pause. *Let go of his hand, and trust that he will not fall. Trust that the sky will hold him. Trust that if he goes into the dark, he will come back out. Not because you held on. Because he will.*

That is the price. One moment. Of letting go.



LEX TURNED HIS HEAD and looked at her.

She could see it in his face. He'd heard it all. Every word. He was looking at her with his brown-gold eyes wide and wet and *stricken*, as if someone had shown him something he'd never seen before. As if he'd never once, in four years, understood why she followed him everywhere.

"*Wren,*" he said. "*I didn't know. I didn't—*"

"*I know you didn't.*" Her voice cracked. "*That's the point, Hammer. You weren't supposed to.*"

"*Your mother—*"

"*Is getting better. She knows me now. Most days.*" She swallowed. "*It doesn't matter. It's not about her. It's—*" She stopped. Looked down at their hands. His big scarred forge-callused hand, wrapped around hers.

She'd held it on the back of a dragon over the Greyspine. She'd held it in the black hall at Duskhold, when Garrick died. She'd held it in a wrecked ballroom with her shoes off. She'd held it in the dust of the south road below Highcrest.

She'd never once let go first.

If I let go, she thought, and he falls—

If I let go, and he goes into the dark—

If I let go, and he doesn't come back—

"Wren," said Lex. Very quietly. *"It's all right. Let go."*

She looked at him.

"I'll come back," he said. "I always come back. I came back from Duskhold. I came back from the glass. I came back from the masquerade, and the Hollowmaw, and the bottom of the sea." His voice was rough. "I'll come back from this. And from the Lock. And from whatever's at the end."

"You don't know that."

"No," said Lex. *"I don't."* He looked at her. *"But I'll try. Every time. I'll always try. Because you're there."* He swallowed. *"Not because you're holding my hand. Because you're there. Waiting. With your bow. On the roof of the Spire."*

Wren made a sound she'd never made before. Not a sob. Not a laugh. Something in between.

And opened her hand.



HE FELL.

Not far. A foot. Two feet. She saw his face change, saw him drop away from her through the shining air, saw his arms go out and his eyes go wide.

And then the sky caught him.

The winds came. All of them. Gentle, now. Like hands. Lifting him. Holding him. Setting him down on a long slow river of silver air a few feet below her, where he stood, swaying, with his arms out like a tightrope walker, staring up at her.

"I'm all right," he said. Wonderingly. "Wren. I'm all right. It's holding me."

She looked down at him. Standing on the wind. On his own. Without her.

And something in her chest, something that had been clenched tight since she was eight years old and sitting beside a bed, holding a hand that didn't know her, *let go*.

She breathed out.

All the way out. Every bit of air in her lungs. A long, shaking, endless breath, going out of her into the endless sky.

Thank you, said the First Breath.

And then she breathed in.



IT CAME INTO HER like a storm.

She felt it. The First Breath. The oldest wind in the world. Pouring into her lungs from the great ring of silver air around the still blue center. Not cold. Not warm. *Alive*. Like breathing lightning. Like breathing the whole sky.

She thought she'd burst. She thought her chest would split open. It filled her lungs and kept coming, filled her throat, her head, her fingertips, her toes. She felt herself lifting. Off the wind. Up into the blue. Light as a leaf. Lighter. Light as air.

Hold it, said the First Breath. *Hold it in. Don't let it out. Not until the fire.*

She held it.

She clamped her mouth shut and held it, the whole sky in her chest, and floated in the blue with her eyes streaming and her hair standing out around her head in a crackling halo, and *held*.

WREN ASHDOWN – MISTWALKER

ATTUNEMENT – GALE

Speaking → COMMANDING

"The fourth stage is not holding the wind. It is letting go of everything else."

ITEM ACQUIRED (carried)

THE FIRST BREATH (Wellworld of Gale)

Bearer: WREN ASHDOWN

"The oldest wind. It will fill a
bellows once, and the fire will
remember it forever."

Component 4 of 4: LOCKWARD

She couldn't read it. Her eyes were full of tears and sky. But she felt Lex read it, below her, on the wind. Felt his face change.

Commanding.

She'd skipped past him again.

She wanted to laugh. She couldn't. She'd have let the breath out.

So she grinned instead. A huge, wild, tear-streaked grin, at the smith from Ashbourne standing on the wind below her.

And he grinned back.

**THEY DIDN'T GO BACK** alone.

When they came back down through the eye of the storm into the churning sky above the Teeth, Vharuun was waiting.

But not the Vharuun they'd left. Wren saw that at once. The storm-mother was hanging in the air above the black peak with her vast wings spread, and they weren't ragged anymore. They were *whole*. Storm-blue and silver, every tear mended, stretched out across a hundred feet of sky like the sails of the greatest ship ever built. Her scales were blue all over. No grey. No patches. And her eyes—

Both of them. Gold. Bright. Clear.

THE STORM HEALED ME, said Vharuun. Her voice rolled through the sky like a thunderclap. *WHILE YOU WERE ABOVE. I FLEW INTO THE CLOUDS WHERE I WAS BORN, AND THE STORM REMEMBERED ME.*

Ashka was beside her. Small, beside her mother. Bright as a spark. She was flying in circles around Vharuun, tight and fast and joyful, the way a puppy runs around its mother's legs.

I AM WHAT I WAS, said the storm-mother. *A THOUSAND YEARS OLD. LIGHTNING AND THUNDER. AND I HAVE A DEBT TO PAY.*

Her gold eyes found Antho.

TO YOU, KEEPER OF MY CHILD. WHO SANG TO HER IN THE DARK. WHO CROSSED THE GREY RIVER AND PAID A PRICE FOR ME HE CANNOT REMEMBER.

Antho, standing on the wind beside Wren, didn't say anything. His face was wet.

WHEN YOU GO TO THE LOCK, said Vharuun, *I WILL CARRY YOU. AND WHEN YOU FIGHT, I WILL FIGHT. AND WHATEVER WAITS AT THE END, IT WILL HAVE TO GO THROUGH ME.*



WREN HELD THE BREATH for three days.

It was the hardest thing she'd ever done. Harder than letting go of Lex's hand. She couldn't speak. She couldn't eat. She couldn't drink, except in tiny sips, through her nose, with her mouth clamped shut. She couldn't sleep properly, because every time she started to drift off, she felt the breath start to slip, and jerked awake with her heart pounding.

She didn't need to breathe. That was the strange thing. The First Breath was in her lungs, and it was enough. It kept her alive. But it wanted *out*. It pushed against her ribs and her throat and her teeth, all the time, like a bird beating against the bars of a cage.

Not yet, she told it. *Not yet. Not until the fire.*

They flew east. Back along the Greyspine. On Vharuun's great whole back, all of them together, with Ashka darting around her mother like a swallow. Back to the Hollowmaw.

Lex held her hand the whole way.

She let him.



HE FORGED IT ON the twenty-second night before the end.

In the Hollowmaw. In the bell-shaped cavern at the bottom of the mountain. In front of the cracked black door, and the little clay lamp in its niche.

Brannoc had built the forge. In the three weeks they'd been gone, the old smith had hauled an anvil down the long passage on a sled, with his arm still in a sling and Hedda swearing at him the whole way, and built a hearth of black stone against the cavern wall, and a chimney cut up through the rock. *Knew you'd need it*, he said, when Lex stared at it. *Knew you'd come back with something to make. You always do.*

Arion was there. He'd been at the door for three weeks. Sitting in front of it, day and night, with his hands on the black glass. He looked thinner. Older around the eyes. But when his sons came down the long passage into the cavern, he stood up, and the lean unchanged face did something it almost never did. It smiled.

Everyone was there. Wren looked around the cavern and saw them all, ringed around the forge in the gold light of a thousand lanterns. Antho and Seraphine. Brannoc and Hedda. Dorran, with the Heartiron in his hands. Kestrel and Tamsin. Ilse and Ivo. Oriel on her stool. Teo. Pim and Odile and the other students, crowded in the mouth of the passage.

And Lex. Standing at the anvil. In his leather apron. With Aurelian's little hammer in his hand.

He looked at her.

She nodded. She couldn't speak.



HE LAID THE HEART-COAL in the hearth.

It didn't need coal around it. It didn't need wood. It sat in the black stone fire-pit on its own, white and gold and singing, and the heat came off it like the heat off the sun. The whole cavern lit up. Every lantern flared. The black glass of the door glowed red.

"Iron," said Lex.

Dorran came forward. Slowly. With the Heartiron held against his chest. He knelt beside the hearth and laid it on the white coal.

It glowed. Not red. Not orange. *Grey*. A deep, strange, iron-grey light, like the light at the bottom of the Wellworld of Stone. It didn't melt. It didn't soften. It just sat there on the Heart-Coal, glowing grey, getting heavier.

"It's not taking the heat," said Brannoc. Frowning. "It's too cold. Too dense. It needs more."

Lex looked at Wren.

And she understood.

Not until the fire.

She came forward. To the bellows. A great old leather bellows, Brannoc's, patched and cracked, as long as her body. She took hold of its handles. She looked at the Heart-Coal, white and singing, and the Heartiron on it, grey and stubborn.

She opened her mouth.

And breathed out.



THE FIRST BREATH WENT into the bellows like a storm into a sail.

She felt it go. All of it. Three days of it. The whole sky, pouring out of her lungs. She pushed the bellows down and the breath went *through* it, into the hearth, onto the Heart-Coal, and the coal *roared*.

Not a fire. A *sun*. White and gold and blinding, rising up out of the hearth in a column that hit the roof of the cavern and spread out across it like the burning sky of the Wellworld of Flame. The whole cavern went white. Wren couldn't see. She felt the heat like a hand pressed against her face. She heard the lanterns ringing, all thousand of them, like bells.

And the Heartiron *gave*.

She heard it. A sound like ice cracking on a river in spring. Like a mountain sighing. The grey glow went red, then orange, then gold, then the white of the sun.

"NOW," said Lex.



SHE'D SEEN HIM FORGE before. A hundred times. In the Ashbourne forge. In the Frostvault. In a dozen camps on a dozen roads. She'd sat cross-legged by the fire and watched him strike, and thought: *this is when he's most himself*.

She'd never seen this.

He took the Heartiron out of the fire with the tongs, white-hot, and laid it on the anvil. And Dorran Vask stood across the anvil from him with

his great hammer, the striker's place, the place Brannoc had stood for Lex when he was twelve. And they began.

Strike. Dorran's hammer, heavy, slow, steady. A mountain's blow.

Tink. Lex's little hammer. Aurelian's. Light and fast and precise.

Strike. Tink. Strike. Tink.

The rhythm filled the cavern. Like a heartbeat. Like a song. Brannoc, standing at the side with his arm in a sling, was humming it under his breath. A hymn. Badly. Hedda was beside him with a brush and a pot of something that glowed, and every time Lex turned the bar, she leaned in and painted a rune on it. Fast. Sure. *Steadfast. Bulwark.* And her own one, the one she wouldn't explain.

And Arion. Standing behind his son. With his hands on Lex's shoulders. Gold pouring off him. Root-runes. Wellscript. Writing them into the iron through his son's hands, the way he'd once written Ember into a seal.

Wren watched the bar take shape.

It wasn't a sword. It wasn't a key. It was short, as long as her forearm, and thick, and flat, and its edge was *notched*. Jagged. A row of teeth. A mountain range.

She knew that shape. Lex had drawn it for her a dozen times on the road north, in the dust beside the campfire, as if he were trying to get it out of his head. The Bit. The second piece of the Key. Black and jagged, in a cup of glass, at the top of a column in a burning Well.

The negative of it, she realized. The opposite. Where the Bit has a tooth, the bar has a gap. Where the Bit has a gap, the bar has a tooth.

It's a ward. Like in a lock. It goes into the lock beside the key and fills every space the key needs to turn.

He's forging it from memory. From the one time he held the Bit in his hand.



THEY FORGED UNTIL DAWN. Wren worked the bellows the whole time. Not with the First Breath; that was gone, all of it, poured into the first great roar. But the fire remembered it. Every time she pumped the old

leather bellows, the Heart-Coal roared up white and gold, and she heard, very faint, a sound like wind in long grass. Like a girl running.

At dawn, Lex held up his hand.

Dorran stopped.

The bar lay on the anvil. Glowing. White-gold.

Lex looked at it for a long time.

Then he took his knife from his belt. And cut his palm. And held it out over the little glass bottle Seraphine had given him at the bottom of the sea. And let his blood drip into the Quench. Three drops. The silver water went red, then gold, then silver again.

Only the blood that forged it can bar the way.

He poured the Quench over the bar.



IT DIDN'T HISS. WREN had expected it to hiss. Quenched iron always hissed. Steam and spit and fury.

This *sang*.

A single note. Pure and high and clear. Like a bell struck once in a silent church. It rang out through the cavern, through the mountain, up the long passage and out of the cave mouth and across the valleys of the Greyspine. Every lantern in the Hollowmaw rang with it. The black glass of the cracked door rang with it. Wren felt it in her bones, in her teeth, in the place in her chest where the First Breath had been.

And the bar on the anvil cooled. From white to gold. From gold to silver. From silver to—

Grey. Dark grey, almost black. Smooth. Heavy. Notched along one edge like a mountain range. With runes running down its face in a thin line of gold. Steadfast. Bulwark. Hedda's nameless one. And Wellscrip, Arion's, too small to read.

And one more. At the very end, near the hilt. In a hand Wren knew. Lex's hand. A rune she'd seen him cut once before, into Anvilson's blade, at Avaloria. *The bearer cannot be severed from those he holds dear.*

STAY.

ITEM FORGED
THE LOCKWARD
Grade: MYTHIC
"A ward for the Lock of the World. Fire of the first fire. Bones of the world. Water of the deep. Breath of the sky. Blood of the line that forged the Key."
Effect: when set beside the Key of Shadows in the Lock, the Key cannot turn.
Setting: requires blood of the forger's line.
Cost of setting:

Cost of setting.

Wren read it over Lex's head. In gold. And the last line was black. Blotted out. Like the Lattice itself didn't want to say.

And the blood that bars it, the blood will pay.

She looked at Lex. He was looking at the panel too. His face was very still.

Then he looked at her. And smiled. Tired. Soot-black. Sweat running down his face.

"Twenty-two days," he said.

She came around the anvil. She took the Lockward out of his hands and laid it down on the anvil. Very gently. Then she took his hands. Both of them. His big scarred bleeding forge-callused hands.

And held them.

Not tight. Not like she was afraid he'd fall. Just held them. The way you hold something you've chosen to hold.

"Twenty-two days," she said.

Behind them, at the cracked black door, the little clay lamp leaned in its niche. And from the other side of the glass, so faint that only Antho and Arion heard it, a voice said:

Oh, love. Oh, it's beautiful.

CHAPTER 20

THE UMBRAL RIFT



THE WORLD ENDED AT the Veil.

Not like the White Shore, where the land simply ran out into a frozen sea. Not like the Teeth, where it grew thin and grey. Here, the world *broke*.

Lex saw it from Vharuun's back on the sixth morning out of the Hollowmaw, with the sun coming up behind them and the storm-mother's vast wings beating slow and steady over the last of the eastern hills. The land below was ordinary. Green and brown. Farms, at first, then forest, then moor. Then rock. Then a line.

A long ragged line across the earth, running north and south as far as he could see. Like a crack in a dropped plate. And on the far side of it, the land wasn't land anymore.

It was *pieces*.

Huge slabs of earth and rock, broken off and tilted, hanging at angles in the air. Some of them were the size of villages. Some were the size of mountains. They floated, slowly turning, above a darkness so deep it had no bottom. Between them, the sky was wrong. Cracked. Like a window someone had thrown a stone through. Lines of black ran across the blue, branching, spreading. And through the cracks, very faint, stars. In the middle of the morning.

"*The Sundered Lands*," said Seraphine. She was sitting behind Lex on the storm-mother's back, with her notebook clutched to her chest and her spectacles fogging in the cold. She'd refused to stay behind. She'd refused so firmly that Antho had stopped arguing after the first hour. "*Where the*

net was tied off. The edge of the Lattice." She swallowed. *"The old texts say that when Aurelian wove the net, he pulled it so tight that the world at the edges tore. Like cloth stretched over a frame. And the torn bits just—hung there."*

"For nine hundred years," said Ivo.

"For nine hundred years."

[It's like the grey beyond the Teeth,] said Ember quietly. *[But broken instead of thin. Lex. Look at your panel.]*

He looked.

LEX VEY

FORGEHEART SORCERER — Tier III

Level 70

Flame COMMANDING

Stone SPEAKING

Tide (listening — faint)

Gale (listening — faint)

AUTHORITY: 100

LATTICE INTEGRITY (local): 11%

■ WARNING: approaching net-edge ■

Eleven percent. Less than the grey river. Less than anywhere he'd ever been.

He looked down at his hands. They were steady. The gold glow on them was steady. He felt the Root in him, deep and strong and humming, and Ember in the Root, and under Ember, very far down, the door. A crack of warmth. A faint sound of breathing.

It's closer here, he thought. *Isn't it.*

[Yes,] said Ember. *[Much closer. The door's at the bottom of the gold, and the gold's at the bottom of the net, and the net ends here.]* A pause. *[We're flying toward the place where it starts, Lex. The very first knot. The root of the Root.]*



THEY SAW THE RIFT at noon.

It was in the middle of the Sundered Lands, where the floating slabs were thickest. A great crack in the world. Not a crack in the earth; the earth here was all cracks. A crack in the *darkness* below. A line of deeper black,

running through the bottomless dark under the floating slabs, a mile long and very straight. Like a seam. Like a scar.

And around its edge, on the largest of the floating slabs, a camp.

Grey tents. Hundreds of them. Banners of ash-grey, with a silver key stitched on them. Cookfires. Men. And shadows. Lex could see them from here, even without True Sight: tall dark featureless shapes, standing in ranks around the edge of the slab like the teeth of a comb. Hundreds. Maybe a thousand.

The Eclipse Concord, he thought. *What's left of it. Kell's men. Sorn's swords. And Elric's shadows.*

And at the edge of the slab, where it hung over the black seam of the Rift, a stair. Carved into the rock. Going down.

"*He's already gone in*," said Oriel Sant.

Everyone turned. The old woman was sitting on Vharuun's back near the storm-mother's shoulders, wrapped in her red shawl, with her white eyes turned toward the Rift.

"*Yesterday*," she said. "*Down the stair. With the Key. Into the dark.*" Her thin dry voice didn't change. "*He's going down to the Lock. It's a long way. Very long. He won't reach it until the longest night.*"

"*Midwinter*," said Seraphine slowly. "*Midwinter's in—*"

"*Sixteen days*," said Oriel. "*He'll reach the Lock on the longest night. And turn the Key at midnight.*"

"*Then we go down after him*," said Lex. "*Now. Today.*"

"*Through that?*" Wren was standing in the air beside the storm-mother's head, her bow in her hand, looking at the camp. At the ranks of shadows. "*Hammer, there's a thousand of them.*"

"*Then we go through a thousand of them.*"

Behind him, Dorran Vask laughed. A low slow rumble.

"*He's in a hurry again*," said the giant.



THEY DIDN'T GO THROUGH a thousand of them.

They went *over*.

It was Antho's idea. And the twins'. And Vharuun's, in the end, though she didn't say so in words. They came down out of the cracked sky in the

late afternoon, out of the west, with the sun behind them, and the storm-mother *breathed*.

Thunder. A great rolling wall of it, pouring down out of her jaws onto the camp of the Eclipse Concord. Not lightning. *Sound*. The pressure-wave hit the ranks of shadows like a hammer hitting glass and scattered them, tore them apart, flung them out across the slab like smoke in a gale. Tents went flying. Men went flying. The grey banners with their silver keys tore loose and spun away into the bottomless dark.

And Ashka came down behind her mother like a spear of lightning, white from nose to tail, and lit the camp up like the noon sun.

And in the confusion, in the thunder and lightning and screaming, nobody noticed a dozen people climbing down off a storm-dragon's back at the top of the stair.

Because there was nobody there. Just rock. Just shadow. Just an empty patch of ground at the edge of the slab, where the stair went down.

Ilse and Ivo stood together at the head of the stair with their hands joined and their eyes closed and sweat running down their faces. Weaving. The Lampshade, the old trick from the Wickhollow, stretched as wide as it would go. Not over one thread. Over twelve. Over everyone.

"Go," said Ilse, through her teeth. She was faint. Very faint. The little stone pebble the Wellworld had given her was clutched against her heart. "*Go, go, go, we can't hold it long—*"

They went.

Down the stair. Into the dark. Lex at the front with fire in his hands. Wren behind him with her bow. Antho with the Lantern. Kestrel beside Antho, where he could see her. Tamsin behind his sister. Seraphine with her crossbow. Oriel, riding on Dorran's shoulders like a child on its father's, her thorn stick tapping the rock wall as they went. Dorran with the Lockward in a leather case on his back. He'd carried it from the Hollowmaw. He'd insisted. *I'm good at carrying things*.

And last, the twins. Backing down the stair, still holding hands, still weaving, until the stair turned and the camp was out of sight.

Above them, the thunder rolled on. The storm-mother and her daughter, holding the rim.

Holding the door.



THE RIFT WENT DOWN a long way.

Lex had thought the Sunwell was deep. He'd thought the Wellworld of Stone was deep. They were nothing. The stair went down and down and down, carved into the black rock of the Rift's wall, spiralling. Narrow. No rail. On one side, the wall. On the other, nothing. Darkness. Going down forever.

They walked for a day. Then another. They slept on the stair, in turns, roped together, with Antho's Lantern hanging from a spike in the wall. They ate what they'd carried. They didn't talk much.

And as they went down, the Lattice thinned.

Lex felt it. Every hour. The silver threads of the net, which had always been there, humming at the edge of his mind, getting fewer. Fainter. Farther apart. His panels flickered. Ember's voice came and went, like a voice heard through a storm.

[Seven percent], it said, on the second day. *[Lex. Seven.]*

And on the third:

[Four].

And something else was getting *stronger*.

Not the net. Not the Root. Something underneath both of them. A warmth. Gold. Coming up from below, the way heat comes up through the floor of a forge. And with it, very faint, a sound. Like breathing.

The door, he thought. *The door at the bottom of the gold. We're walking down toward it.*

[No,] said Ember. Very quietly. Barely there. *[We're walking down toward the thing on the other side of it.]*



ON THE FOURTH DAY, they found the first of the dead.

Men in ash-grey. Five of them. Lying on the stair in a heap, as if they'd fallen together. Their armor was crushed. Their swords were broken.

And they were *grey*. All the way through. Like the thinned in the valley beyond the Teeth. Like the man with the rubbed-out face. Their faces were blurred. Their bodies were faint. Lex could see the stair through their chests.

"Unwritten," said Seraphine. Very quietly. *"He's unwriting his own men."*

"*He's feeding,*" said Antho. He was kneeling beside the bodies with the Lantern held low, his face grey. *"On the way down. The deeper he goes, the more the Key needs. He's taking whatever's nearest."*

"*His own people,*" said Kestrel. Her voice was strange.

"*His own people.*"

Lex took out the Ledger. He opened it to the last page.

Five new names. In the narrow elegant hand. Very faint.

Garret Shale. Soldier. He sent half his pay home to his mother in Thornby.

Wil Brack. Soldier. He was afraid of the dark.

He read them all. Then he closed the book and put it back against his chest.

"*Sixty,*" he said.



ON THE SIXTH DAY, they found Kell.

She was sitting on the stair. At a place where it widened into a ledge, a flat shelf of black rock jutting out over the dark. She was sitting with her back against the wall and her knees drawn up and her ragged silver hair hanging in her face. Alone.

She looked up when the light of Antho's Lantern came round the bend.

Lex barely recognized her. She'd been gaunt at the masquerade. She was skeletal now. Her white robes were torn and filthy. Her face was hollow, her eyes sunk deep in dark circles. Her hands, resting on her knees, were shaking.

And she was *faint*.

Not as faint as the dead men. Not yet. But the edges of her were blurring. The white of her robes was going grey. When Lex looked at her with True Sight, the panel over her head flickered and stuttered like a candle in a draft.

ISAURA KELL

Class: [REDACTED] (Sanction REVOKED)

THREAD: UNWRITTEN (partial - 41%)

Anchor: [REDACTED] (none found)

None found.

Nobody remembered her. Nobody loved her enough to hold her.

"Lex Vey," said Isaura Kell. Her voice was a dry whisper. "Of course. Of course it would be you."**NOBODY MOVED.**

Dorran had stopped at the back of the group, with Oriel still on his shoulders. His great slab of a face was very still.

*"He's taking you," said Lex.**"He's taking everyone." Kell laughed. A terrible little sound. "Did you see them? On the stair? My men. My last loyal men. Two hundred who followed me out of the Spire. Who followed me into the north, and the masquerade, and this." She gestured at the dark. "Forty of us came down with him. Forty. There are three left. And he's taken a piece of me every day." She looked at her faint grey hands. "He says it's nothing personal. He says the Key is hungry, and he's only feeding it what's nearest."**"Where is he?"**"Below." Kell didn't look up. "Three days below. Maybe four. He left me here this morning. He said I was too slow." Her mouth twisted. "He said he'd come back for the rest of me when he needed it."*

Lex looked at her.

The High Warden of the Order. The woman who had kept the Ceiling on Caldor for twenty years. Who had set the flag on the Queen's class at sixteen. Who had sent Seraphine to the cells for a week. Who had told Dorran Vask, for twenty-two years, that he was keeping children safe.

Sitting on a stair in the dark at the bottom of the world, coming apart, with nobody to remember her.

"Why?" said Lex. "Why did you go with him?"

Kell was quiet for a long time.

"Because he was right," she said at last. *"About the Ceiling. About the lid. About what's under it."* She lifted her sunken eyes to his. *"I've read the Order's oldest records, Lex Vey. The ones even your father never saw. I know what Aurelian sealed under the net. I know what it is. What it wants."* Her voice was very flat. *"The Ceiling wasn't cruelty. It was a weight. Holding it down. Every capped thread was a stone on the lid."* She shook her head slowly. *"And you took the stones off. Forty thousand of them. Four hundred thousand. And I felt it start to lift."*

Lex didn't say anything.

"Elric said he could put the stones back," said Kell. *"With the Key. Re-cap the world. Ceiling every thread again, harder, permanently. And hold the lid shut forever."* Her laugh was barely a breath. *"He lied. Of course he lied. He doesn't want to hold the lid shut. He wants to open it. He wants to reach under it and take whatever's there and make himself a god."* She closed her eyes. *"And I followed him all the way down here before I understood."*

"The voice," said Antho quietly.

Kell opened her eyes. Looked at him.

"He hears a voice," said Antho. *"Doesn't he. In the Key. Telling him what to do. Where to go. What he deserves."*

"Yes." Kell's whisper was barely audible. *"I've heard it too. At night. Down here. Since we came below the net."* Her faint hands were shaking. *"It's so kind. It's the kindest voice I've ever heard."*



"Leave her," said Ivo.

Everyone looked at him. He was standing at the back, with his arm around his sister. His face was hard.

"Leave her," he said again. *"She put the Ceiling on us. On everyone. She sent people to the cells. She came to the masquerade with a hundred swords and a Severance chain."* His voice shook. *"Leave her here. Let him come back for the rest of her."*

Nobody answered.

Kell didn't look at him. She sat on the ledge with her head bowed. As if she agreed.

And Dorran Vask set Oriel down on the stair. Very gently. And walked to the front of the group. And knelt down on the black rock of the ledge in front of the woman who had been his commander for twenty-two years.

"Commander," he said.

Kell lifted her head. She looked at him. At his great slab of a face. At the old scar on his forearm where the brand had been.

"Vask," she whispered.

"I said I wasn't going to hurt you," said Dorran. "At the masquerade. I meant it." He looked at her for a long moment. "I'm not going to leave you either."

Behind him, Ivo made a sound.

"I know," said Dorran, without turning around. "I know, Ivo. I know what she did. I did it too. I did it for her. Four thousand one hundred and nine times." He was quiet. "And your sister forgave me. On the floor of the Wellworld of Stone. And I put down some of the weight." He looked at Kell. "I'm not going to forgive her. That's not mine to do. But I'm not going to leave her on a stair in the dark for him to eat."

He held out his huge scarred hand.

"Come on, Commander," said Dorran Vask. "I'll carry you. I'm good at carrying things."



KELL STARED AT HIS hand.

Then she started to cry. Silently. Faint grey tears running down her hollow face. The High Warden of the Order, weeping on a stair at the bottom of the world.

She took his hand.

And Lex saw the panel over her head flicker.

ISAURA KELL

THREAD: UNWRITTEN (partial – 41%)

Anchor: DORRAN VASK

(not kin. Not love.

Something else.)

Anchor strength: WEAK – HOLDING

Something else.

[Duty,] said Ember. Very quietly. Barely there, at four percent. [Or mercy. Or both. I don't know what to call it.]

Dorran does, thought Lex.

The giant picked Kell up. Easily. As if she weighed nothing. Which, Lex thought, she very nearly did. He settled her against his chest, the way he'd carried Oriel, and the Lockward on his back, and the book of names in his coat.

"Right," he said. *"Down."*

Ivo stood at the back of the group with his arm around his sister and his face white. He didn't say anything. But after a long moment, Ilse turned her head and pressed her faint forehead against his shoulder, and Lex saw him close his eyes.

And they went on down.



THE RIFT BEGAN TO fall on the eighth day.

Lex felt it first through Stone. A shudder. Far above them. A great slow tremor running through the black rock of the Rift's walls, like the shiver that runs through a horse's flank before it bolts. He stopped on the stair. Put his hand on the wall.

...Ah, said Stone. Faint. So faint, this far below the net. *...He is... unlocking it.*

"What?"

...The Rift. Is held shut. By the knot. The first knot. The Key... is loosening it. A long, slow pause. ...As he goes down... the walls... are coming apart... behind him.

Lex looked up.

Far above, very far, at the very edge of the Lantern's light, the black rock of the Rift's wall was moving. Slowly. Cracking. A long jagged line of black running across it, branching, spreading.

And then, with a sound like the end of the world, a slab of rock the size of a cathedral broke away from the wall and fell.

It went past them. Close. So close the wind of it nearly tore Wren off the stair. A great black mass of stone, tumbling, spinning, falling away into

the dark below. They heard it hit something, a long time later. Very far down.

And above them, more cracks. Spreading. The whole wall of the Rift, from the stair to the darkness above, beginning to come apart.

"*RUN*," shouted Lex.



THEY RAN.

Down the stair. Round and round. In the dark, with the Lantern swinging, with rock falling around them. Wren went up into the air, stepping, shooting at the falling stones with arrows that burned gold, breaking them into smaller stones that clattered past harmlessly. Kestrel burned. Antho shadowbound the larger slabs, slowing them, holding them for a heartbeat while everyone got past. Lex went at the front with Stone pouring out of him into the wall of the stair, holding it together, step by step, asking, asking, *please, hold, just a little longer, please*.

It wasn't enough.

The cracks were coming faster than they could run. Above them, the whole wall was shifting. Leaning out over the Rift. Lex felt it through Stone: a great slow heave, like a cliff deciding to fall. Thousands of tons of rock, loosening, tilting, starting to slide.

Straight down onto the stair.

He stopped. He turned. He put both hands on the wall and *pushed*, with everything he had. Stone. Flame. Root. Authority. Everything.

It held. For a heartbeat. Two.

And then he felt it slip. Felt the weight come down on him like the Heartiron in his palm. Too much. Far too much. A whole cliff, a whole wall of the Rift, leaning out over the stair. And he was one man.

His knees buckled.

"*Lex—*"

And a hand came down on the wall beside his.

Huge. Scarred. With an old burn on the forearm where a brand had been.



DORRAN VASK HAD SET Kell down on the stair behind him. He'd set the Lockward down beside her, in its leather case. He'd set Oriel down. He stood on the narrow stair beside Lex with both his enormous hands flat against the black rock of the Rift's wall, and his feet planted, and his great shaved head bowed.

And Lex felt him *Answer*.

Stone. The Well he'd woken in the Wellworld, kneeling on the floor with the Heartiron in his hands and two thieves telling him he could put it down. Not Speaking. Not Commanding. Answering. Barely. A man who had spent fifty years not knowing he was the mountain's kind.

But he was carrying.

Lex felt the weight shift. Felt some of it come off him. Not much. But some. Felt it go into Dorran. Into the giant's hands and arms and shoulders and back. Felt Dorran take it, the way he'd taken the Heartiron. And not bow.

"Go," said Dorran.

"No—"

"Go, lad." Dorran's voice was a low slow rumble through his teeth. "Take them down. Take the bar. You've got a key to stop."

"I'm not leaving you—"

"You're not leaving me." Dorran turned his head. Just a little. And looked at Lex. His great slab of a face was dark red and running with sweat, and the veins stood out on his scalp like ropes. But his eyes were calm. Calmer than Lex had ever seen them. "I'm staying. It's different."

The wall shuddered. More rock came loose above them. Lex felt the weight come down again, crushing, and felt Dorran take more of it. Felt the big man's knees start to bend.

"I'll hold it," said Dorran Vask. "Long enough. I'm good at carrying things."



"Dorran." Ilse. Behind them on the stair. Her faint voice cracking. "Dorran, no, you can't—"

"I can." The giant didn't look round. "Ilse. Listen to me. In my coat. The book."

Lex understood before she did. He reached into Dorran's old leather coat with one hand, the other still flat on the wall, and found it. Small. Thick. Brown leather gone black with handling. Four thousand one hundred and nine names.

"*Twelve villages,*" said Dorran. His voice was getting rougher. Slower. "*Out past the Blightmarch. You promised. You said I'd come with you. Stand beside the Stone. Put my hand on their shoulders.*" His breath came out of him in a long shaking groan. "*I can't now. You'll have to do it for me.*"

"Dorran—"

"*You and the twins.*" The giant's eyes found Ilse and Ivo, standing together on the stair. "*You stand beside the Stone. Both of you. You were the first ones I ever felt go dim. You should be the first ones there when they light up.*"

Ilse was sobbing. Ivo had his arms around her. His face was grey.

"*Promise me,*" said Dorran.

"*We promise,*" said Ivo. His voice cracked. "*Dorran. We promise.*"

"*Good.*"

The wall groaned. Dorran's knees bent further. His arms were shaking. Lex could feel it through Stone, the weight crushing down on him, a whole cliff, and the giant holding it. Holding it. Holding it.

"*Lex,*" said Dorran. "*Take them down.*"



LEX TOOK HIS HANDS off the wall.

It was the hardest thing he had ever done. Harder than the Lampshade. Harder than letting go of the count on the Old Man. Harder than throwing the Bit across the crater. He felt the weight leave him and go into Dorran, all of it, everything, and he heard the giant grunt, a sound like a mountain cracking, and he didn't put his hands back.

"*Go,*" he said. To the others. His voice was a stranger's. "*Down. Go.*"

They went. Wren pulling Seraphine. Antho with Kestrel and Tamsin. Kestrel looking back, her amber eyes wide, her fire guttering. Oriel on Tamsin's back now, her white eyes turned toward the giant on the stair.

Ivo, carrying his sister.

Lex picked up the Lockward. In its leather case. He slung it over his shoulder. He looked at Kell, sitting on the stair where Dorran had set her down. Faint and grey and staring at the giant's back.

"Get up," he said.

She looked at him.

"He didn't carry you all this way for you to sit there," said Lex. *"Get up."*

And Isaura Kell got up. Slowly. Shakily. And went down the stair after the others.

Lex was last.

He stopped at the bend. He looked back.

Dorran Vask stood on the narrow stair in the dark at the bottom of the world, with both his hands flat against the leaning wall of the Rift, and his shaved head bowed, and his whole enormous body shaking. Above him, the cracks were spreading. Rock was falling. The wall was coming down.

He was holding it. Alone.

"Dorran," said Lex.

The giant didn't turn his head. He couldn't.

"You're hitting it too hard," said Lex. His voice broke. *"You always hit it too hard."*

And from the stair, very faint, through his teeth, Dorran Vask laughed. A low slow rumble. Like rocks shifting in a stream.

"Hub," he said.

And then:

"Go, lad. I've got it."



LEX WENT.

He ran. Down the stair. Round the bend. Down and down and down, into the dark, after the others, with the Lockward on his back and the book of names in his coat beside the Ledger.

Behind him, he heard it.

Not all at once. Slowly. A long, slow, grinding roar, like a mountain sighing. Like a giant setting something heavy down, at last, somewhere it belonged.

The wall of the Umbral Rift came down.

He felt it through Stone. Felt it fall, thousands of tons of black rock, sliding down over the stair where a man had been standing with his hands flat against it.

And felt, for one moment, just before it reached the bottom, something else. Faint. Through Stone. Through the deep slow bones of the world.

...Ah, said the voice of the mountain. Very soft. ...Mountain's child. Come home.



■ **PARTY MEMBER LOST** ■

DORRAN VASK

Warden of the Kindling (former)

Stone-Answerer

"He was always the mountain's kind."

LEX STOPPED ON THE stair.

He read it. Gold, hanging in the dark. He read it twice.

Then he sat down on the stair. In the dark. With the Lockward on his back and the book of names against his chest.

And put his face in his hands.



WREN FOUND HIM THERE.

She came back up the stair. Alone. With her bow on her back and the Lantern in her hand; she'd taken it from Antho. She didn't say anything. She sat down beside him on the narrow stair, in the dark, and put the Lantern down between them, and put her arm around his shoulders.

He leaned into her.

They sat like that for a long time.

"He told me," said Lex at last. Into her shoulder. "In the Bitter Hills. When I first met him. He said I'd get them all killed. By being born."

"You didn't kill him."

"He'd have been in the Wickhollow. Making plowshares. Badly."

"He'd have been in the Wickhollow," said Wren, "carrying four thousand children in a book in his coat for the rest of his life. Alone." She tightened her arm. "He put some of it down, Hammer. On the floor of the Wellworld. You

saw. Ilse and Ivo saw." She was quiet. *"He carried the rest of it as far as it needed to go. And then he set it down. Somewhere it belonged."*

Lex didn't say anything.

He took out the book. Dorran's book. Small and thick and black with handling. He opened it.

Aldo Cray. Fen Hollow. Spring Kindling. Ceiling 18.

Bess Rook. Fen Hollow. Spring Kindling. Ceiling 12.

Four thousand one hundred and nine names. In a big clumsy careful hand.

And on the inside of the back cover, in the same hand, smaller, a line Lex hadn't seen before. Written, maybe, on the night in the Wickhollow when he'd promised.

When they light up, tell them I'm sorry. Tell them the big man who put the lid on said he was sorry, and that he spent the rest of his life lifting things.

Lex closed the book.

"*Twelve villages,*" he said.

"*Twelve villages,*" said Wren. "*When this is done. All of us. Me and you and the twins.*" She pressed her face against his hair. "*We'll stand beside the Stone. And put our hands on their shoulders. For him.*"



THEY WENT DOWN.

There was nothing else to do. The stair above them was gone, buried under a mountain of fallen rock. There was only down.

The others were waiting on a ledge a little way below. Antho, with his face grey. Seraphine, crying quietly. Kestrel and Tamsin. Oriol, sitting on the stair with her stick across her knees and her white face turned up toward the place where the rock had fallen.

"*I saw it,*" she said, when Lex came down. "*Before we left the Wickhollow. I saw a big man holding up a mountain.*" Her thin dry voice cracked, just once. "*I didn't tell him. He'd have come anyway.*"

The twins were sitting together at the edge of the ledge, with their legs dangling over the dark. Holding hands. Not weaving. Not talking. Ilse had the little stone pebble from the Wellworld clutched in her other hand, against her heart.

And Kell.

She was sitting apart from everyone. At the far end of the ledge. With her knees drawn up and her ragged silver hair in her face. Faint. Grey.

But not fading.

Lex looked at her with True Sight. Four percent of the net, barely there, the panel flickering.

ISAURA KELL

THREAD: UNWRITTEN (partial – 41%)

Anchor: DORRAN VASK (deceased)

Anchor persists.

"Some anchors outlast the hand
that set them."

Some anchors outlast the hand that set them.

He looked at her for a long time.

She looked back at him. Her sunken eyes were red.

"He carried me," she said. Barely a whisper. "Twenty-two years, I told him what to do. And he did it. Every time. Without complaining." Her faint hands were shaking. "And then he carried me. Down here. And told me he wasn't going to forgive me. And held up a mountain."

She bowed her head.

"I don't know what to do with that," said Isaura Kell. "I don't know what to do."

"Neither do I," said Lex.

He turned away. He looked down. Into the dark. Into the bottom of the Umbral Rift, where something gold was glowing, very faint, very far below. Where something was breathing.

Eight days, he thought. *Eight days to the longest night.*

[Lex,] said Ember. So faint now he could barely hear it. Two percent. One. [I'm losing you. The net's too thin. I'm—]

I know. It's all right.

[I'll be here. At the bottom of the gold. I'll be right here.] A pause. Fainter. [Lex. He was a good man. The big one.]

I know.

[He hit things too hard.]

I know.

[So do you.]

And then Ember was gone. Not swallowed, this time. Not taken. Just out of reach. Like a voice on the far side of a river.

Lex was alone in his own head for the first time in four years.

He slung the Lockward higher on his back. He took the Lantern from Wren. He looked at all of them, on the ledge. His brother. Wren. Seraphine. Kestrel and Tamsin. The twins. Oriel. Kell.

"Down," he said.

And they went down into the dark, toward the Lock of the World.

CHAPTER 21

THE KEY OF SHADOWS



THE BOTTOM OF THE world was gold.

Lex hadn't expected that. Eight days down the stair in the dark, with the Lattice thinning to nothing and Ember gone silent and the cold getting into his bones. He'd expected the bottom of the Umbral Rift to be the darkest place there was.

It was the brightest.

They came round the last turn of the stair on the evening of the longest night, and the dark simply *ended*. Like stepping out of a cave into noon. Gold light, warm and steady, pouring up from below. Lex threw up his arm against it. Behind him, he heard Wren gasp, and Seraphine say something that wasn't a word.

He lowered his arm.



IT WAS A CAVERN. So big that *cavern* was the wrong word. A hollow in the bottom of the world, round and vast, a mile across, a mile high. Its walls were black rock, smooth as glass, curving up into darkness overhead.

And from every part of those walls, threads.

Silver. Thousands of them. Millions. Coming out of the black rock on every side, from the floor to the unseen roof, thin as spider-silk and bright as moonlight. All of them running inward. Toward the center of the cavern. Converging. Thickening. Twisting around each other, braiding, plaiting, the way the strands of a rope twist together. Getting brighter as they came. Silver, then silver-gold, then gold.

And at the center, hanging in the air a hundred feet above the cavern floor, they met.

A knot.

Lex had never seen anything like it. Nobody had. It was the size of a house. A great tangled ball of light, silver and gold, every thread in the world tied together in one vast, intricate, impossible knot. It pulsed. Slowly. Like a heart. And with every pulse, light ran out along the threads, out to the walls, out through the rock, out into the net that covered the whole world.

The first knot, he thought. Where Aurelian tied off the Lattice. Nine hundred years ago. With his own hands.

He felt it in the Root. All at once. Like a door bursting open. The net, which had been fading for eight days, down to four percent, two, one, nothing, came roaring back. Not thin. *Full*. Every thread in the world, running through the knot over his head. He felt them all. Millions. The whole Lattice. Humming.

And in the gold, at the bottom of him, a familiar warmth.

[—ex? Lex! Lex, I'm back, I'm here, oh, that was horrible, I was shouting the whole way down and you couldn't—] Ember stopped. *[Oh.]* A long silence. *[Oh, Lex. Look up.]*

He was looking up.

[That's it,] breathed Ember. *[That's the beginning. That's where it all starts. Every thread. Every soul. Every class and level and Ceiling in the world. All tied off right there.]* Its voice was shaking. *[Your ancestor did that. With his hands. Lex, I don't think anyone's ever seen it.]*

Someone has, thought Lex.

And looked down.



BELOW THE KNOT, THE cavern floor was black glass.

A disc of it. Perfectly round. Perfectly smooth. A mile across, filling the whole floor of the cavern from wall to wall. Like the door at the Hollowmaw. Like the sealed breach. But a thousand times bigger.

The lid.

He knew it the way he'd known the knot. It was the other half. The knot was where the net was tied off. And the lid was what the net was *holding down*. A great black disc, pinned in place by every thread in the world, sealing the bottom of the Rift.

And under it, light.

Gold light. Coming up through the black glass from below. Faint, at the edges. Brighter toward the center. So bright, at the very center of the disc, that the glass there glowed like a window with a fire behind it.

And at the center of the glow, a keyhole.

Cut into the black glass. Small. The size of a man's hand. And in it, black, long, jagged, with its looped bow sticking up out of the lid like the handle of a door—

The Key of Shadows.

And kneeling beside it, alone in the middle of a mile of black glass, with his hands resting on its bow, Elric Thorne.



HE DIDN'T LOOK UP when they came down the last of the stair.

He knelt in the gold light with his head bowed and his hands on the Key, and didn't move. Lex walked toward him across the black glass. It was warm under his boots. Very warm. Like the hearthstone of a forge. He could feel the light underneath, pressing up.

He stopped twenty paces away.

"Elric."

Elric lifted his head.

He looked younger. Again. Thirty, now. Maybe less. Dark-haired, without a thread of grey. His face smooth and unlined. He might have been Arion's younger brother. He might have been the young man who'd walked into the Spire forty years ago and met a lean grey-eyed Warden who never seemed to get older.

But his eyes were black.

Not dark brown. Not nearly black. *Black*. All the way through. Like the Key in his hands. Like holes cut in a painted face.

"Lex," he said. "*You came.*"

His voice was the same. That was the worst of it. Dry, warm, faintly amused. The voice that had explained the Lattice to a terrified smith's apprentice by a campfire in the Greyspine.

"*I knew you would,*" said Elric. "*It told me. It said, he'll come. He always comes. And he'll bring a bar.*" His black eyes moved to the leather case on Lex's back. "*Is that it? The ward? The thing you made to stop me?*"

"Yes."

"*May I see it?*"

Lex didn't move.

Elric smiled. "*No. Of course not.*" He looked back down at the Key. "*It doesn't matter. You can't use it. Not now. The Key's in the Lock. It'll only take a ward when it's turned closed. And it's not going to be turned closed.*" He lifted his head again. "*It's going to be turned open. At midnight. In about an hour.*"



THEY SPREAD OUT BEHIND Lex. He felt them come. Wren on his right, with her bow in her hand and an arrow on the string. Antho on his left, with the Lantern and his staff. Kestrel beside Antho, burning low. Tamsin behind her. Seraphine with her crossbow. The twins. Oriel on her stick.

And Kell. At the back. Faint and grey.

Elric looked at all of them. One by one. His black eyes passing over each face.

They stopped on Kell.

"*Isaura,*" he said. Mildly surprised. "*I left you on the stair.*"

Kell didn't answer.

"*Someone carried you,*" said Elric. He tilted his head. "*Who carried you, Isaura? Nobody remembers you. I took the people who might have. I made sure.*"

"*Dorran Vask,*" said Kell. Her voice was barely a breath. "*He carried me. And then he held up the Rift so they could get down. And it fell on him.*"

Elric looked at her for a long moment.

"*Vask,*" he said. "*Your Kindling-Warden. The big one.*" He was quiet. "*I'm sorry. I didn't mean the Rift to fall on anyone. It's only that when I*

unlock things, they come apart." He shrugged, very slightly. *"It's the nature of keys."*

"It's the nature of you," said Antho.



ELRIC'S BLACK EYES MOVED to Antho.

"Antho," he said softly. *"Still angry. I always liked that about you. Your father never let himself be angry. Not once in forty years. You've got enough for both of you."*

"What are you doing?"

"You know what I'm doing."

"Say it."

Elric was quiet for a moment. Then he looked down at the Key. At the gold light pouring up around it.

"Under this lid," he said, *"is everything. All the power the Lattice was built to hold down. Nine hundred years of it. The wild magic of the old world, before the net. The sorcerer-kings. The Founders' power. All of it."* His hands tightened on the Key. *"Aurelian didn't destroy it when he wove the net. He couldn't. He just put a lid on it. And then he put a Ceiling on everyone, so that no one would ever be strong enough to lift the lid."*

"And you're going to lift it."

"A crack." Elric's voice was very calm. *"Only a crack. Enough to reach in. Enough to take what's there."* He looked up. *"And then I'll remake the net. Not with Ceilings. Not with Veys at the top and everyone else beneath. With everyone the same. Everyone free. No Root. No Authority. No blood-right. No family that gets to decide who's allowed to grow and who isn't."*

"Except you," said Wren.

Elric looked at her.

"Except you," said Wren again. *"Someone has to hold the new net. Someone has to be at the center of it. Like Aurelian was. Like Arion is."* Her green eyes were very hard. *"Someone has to be the Root. And that's going to be you."*

Elric didn't answer for a long moment.

"Someone has to," he said at last. Quietly. *"Why not me? I've earned it. I've given forty years. I've walked every road and mended every Stone. I've*

been second for my whole life." His black eyes went to Lex. *"Why shouldn't I go first? Just once?"*



"Because it's lying to you," said Lex.

Elric went still.

"The voice," said Lex. "In the Key. The one that told you where to dig. The one that told you you'd always be second." He took a step forward. "It's lying to you, Elric. It's been lying to you since the Sundered Lands."

"You don't know what it is."

"I do. It's in me too." Lex touched his own chest. "At the bottom of the Root. There's a door. And it's on the other side. And it calls me *good boy*, and *child*, and it hums my mother's lullaby in a voice that isn't hers." He looked at Elric's black eyes. "My mother told you. Through the door at the Hollowmaw. She said, it's not Aurelian. Not anymore. Not for eight hundred years. It's wearing his face."

"Your mother," said Elric, *"has been in the dark for eleven years."*

"And you've been listening to the dark for three."

Something moved in Elric's face. Just for a moment. Like the first fine crack in a sheet of ice.

And then the voice came.

Not from the Key. Not from Elric. From *below*. From under the lid. From the gold light pouring up through the black glass, all around them. Warm and kind and gentle as a hand on your hair.

Oh, children.



LEX FELT IT GO through all of them.

Felt Wren flinch beside him. Felt Antho go rigid. Felt Kestrel's fire gutter and Seraphine's breath catch and Oriel lift her white face. Felt Kell, at the back, make a sound like a whimper.

He'd heard it before. In the Glass Desert. At the bottom of himself. But never like this. Never *out loud*. Never coming up out of the floor under his feet, filling a cavern a mile wide, warm and gold and loving.

Oh, children. You came all this way.

So many of you. So brave. So tired. I can feel how tired you are.

The big one on the stair. I felt him fall. I'm so sorry. He was a good man. He carried so much.

The voice was full of grief. Real grief. Lex could hear it. It *mourned* Dorran.

Elric, said the voice. Don't listen to them. They're frightened. They've been frightened all their lives. They don't understand.

They've never had to stand behind anyone.

Elric's hands were shaking on the Key.

Midnight, Elric, said the voice. Gently. It's nearly midnight. Turn it. Just a little. Just a crack. And then you'll see. And then they'll all see.

You'll never be second again.



LEX RAN.

He didn't think. He went across the black glass toward the Key with the Lockward's leather case in his hands, tearing it open as he ran. Not to set it. He couldn't set it. Not with the Key turned open. But to *jam* it. To get it in the Lock somehow, beside the Key, in the way, before—

Elric turned the Key.



IT WAS VERY QUIET.

That was what Lex remembered afterward. Not a roar. Not a crash. A *click*. Small. Final. Like a lock turning in a door the size of the world.

And the knot over their heads *loosened*.

He felt it. Through the Root. Through every thread. The great tangled ball of silver and gold, a hundred feet above the cavern floor, every thread in the world tied together. And one strand of it, deep in the center, the first one, the one all the others had been tied to, *slipping*. Just a little. Just an inch.

And the whole net *shuddered*.

He felt it go out. Through the walls of the Rift. Through the Sundered Lands. Through Caldor and the Sunreach and the Greyspine and the White Shore, through every Stone and every thread and every soul under the Lattice. A single great shudder. Like the shiver that runs through a horse's flank. Like the moment before a cliff falls.

And the lid *lifted*.



NOT MUCH. NOT ALL of it. The black glass disc under their feet, a mile across, *tilted*. Just at the center. Just around the Key. Lifting, like the lid of a pot when the water underneath begins to boil. A crack opening. A thin line of gold light around the Lock. Then wider. A hand's width. An arm's length.

And the light came up.

Gold. Blinding. Pouring up through the crack in the lid like the sun rising from below. Like the Sunwell. Like the eye of a forge. It hit the knot overhead and the knot *blazed*, every thread in it lighting up gold, and the gold ran out along the threads, out through the walls, out into the world.

And everywhere it went, the light went *out*.



IN HIGHCREST, ON THE longest night of the year, the Queen of Caldor was standing at the window of her tower, looking at the lanterns. Every window in the city had one. She'd ordered it. *Light a lamp for the ones who've gone to the Rift.*

She saw every lantern in the city go out. At once. All of them. And the stars go out above them. And the moon.

And then there was no light at all. Anywhere. Just black.

She stood in the dark with her hand on the cold glass of the window and felt, for the first time since she was crowned, entirely alone.

And then, somewhere below in the black city, a single small flame. In a window in the Lower Town. A candle. Lit by hand. With flint and steel.

And another. And another.

The Queen of Caldor stood at her window and watched her city light candles in the dark, one by one, by hand, and wept.



IN SAFFARAN, ON THE mesa, Queen Ishara of the Sunreach was asleep. She woke when Zahir screamed. She sat up in the dark. Absolute dark. No moon. No stars.

She held out her hand.

Fire came. Small and gold. The Ashari fire, in her palm, the way it had come every day since the smith from Caldor knelt at the foot of her Stone.

And all over the city, on every terrace and rooftop, her people woke in the dark, and held out their hands, and the fire came.

Saffaran burned in the eternal night like a beacon on top of the world.



IN THE WICKHOLLOW, UNDER the Bitter Hills, a little girl with no thread was asleep in a gallery full of candles. She woke when her mother shook her. She sat up. All around her, the Unlit were standing, looking up, at the rock ceiling, as if they could see through it.

"What is it?" she said.

"The sky," said her mother. *"It's gone out."*

The little girl looked around the gallery. At the candles. Hundreds of them. Thousands. Beeswax and tallow, in jars and tin cups and on bare rock. All still burning. Warm and yellow and ordinary.

She picked up her candle-holder. Iron, with a twist in the stem like a vine, and a little drip-dish shaped like a leaf. She lit a candle in it, from the one beside her bed.

"Then we'll take ours up," she said. *"So the sky can see."*



IN ASHBOURNE, TILDA CRANE was in the forge when the light went out.

She'd been banking the fires for the night. She'd been the last one there. She was always the last one there; she liked the forge at night, when the hall was empty and the side-fires were glowing red and she could hear the coals tick.

Every fire in the hall went out. All twenty. At once. Even the great hearth.

She stood in the absolute dark with the tongs in her hand and her heart hammering.

Master Lex says good morning to them, she thought. Every morning. Before he lights them.

She didn't know why she thought it. She just did.

She felt her way down the long hall to the great hearth. She found it with her hands. Cold. Dead. She knelt in front of it. She put her hands on the black stone.

"Good morning," she said. Her voice was shaking. "I know it's night. I know it's dark. I'm sorry. Please. Please come back."

And under her hands, something *stirred*.

A spark. Deep in the dead coals. Gold.

Tilda Crane had heard Flame since she was fourteen. She'd never once heard it answer.

It answered now.



AT THE HOLLOWMAW, ARION Vey was sitting in front of the door when the lid lifted.

He felt it. Through the Root. Every thread in the world shuddering. The knot slipping. And then the light going out, and the dark coming down, and every lantern in the Hollowmaw, one thousand one hundred and eleven, going black.

Except one.

The little clay lamp in the niche. With a chip in its spout and a thumbprint in its base. Burning. Steady. Gold.

And the door *bulged*.

Toward him. Outward. The black glass straining, cracking, the long jagged line across its face spreading, branching. And behind it, the Hollow, pressing. Not the shallows. The *deep*. Everything that had been held under the lid for nine hundred years, pushing up through every crack in the world. And this was the biggest crack. The oldest. The one his wife had been holding shut for eleven years.

Arion. Her voice. Through the glass. Strained. Breaking. *Arion, I can't—*

He put his hands on the door.

"I'm here," he said. *"Seren. I'm here."*

It's so heavy—

"*I know.*" He pressed his palms flat against the bulging glass. He felt the weight on the other side. The whole Hollow. Leaning. "*I know. I've got it. I've got this side.*"

Arion—

"*Eleven years,*" said Arion Vey. "*Eleven years you've held it alone. Not tonight.*" He put his forehead against the glass. "*Not tonight, love. Tonight I'm here.*"

And behind him, in the dark of the bell-shaped cavern, a small cold hand closed on his sleeve.

Pim.

And another. Odile. And Teo, dripping. And all the students of the Lantern Keep. Coming down the long dark passage with candles in their hands. Kneeling down beside the old man in front of the door. Putting their hands on the glass.

Holding.



AT THE BOTTOM OF the world, Lex was on his knees on the tilting lid.

The light from the crack was blinding. Gold. Pouring up all around him. He couldn't see. He couldn't see anything but gold. He felt the black glass under his hands, warm, tilting, lifting. He felt the Lockward in his fist. He felt the Root in him, every thread in the world, shuddering.

And he felt the door at the bottom of the gold.

Open.

Not a crack now. *Open.* Wide. Like a door flung back on its hinges. And through it, the warmth. The breathing. The voice. Coming up through the Root, through Ember, through the gold at the very bottom of him.

There you are, said the voice. *There you are. My boy. My good boy. Come home.*



SOMETHING CAME UP OUT of the crack in the lid.

Lex saw it through the gold. A shape. Rising. Slowly. Out of the light. Tall. Taller than a man. Slender. Wrapped in light the way a man is wrapped in a cloak.

A man.

Fair-haired. Beautiful, in a tired way, like a fine blade that has been used too long. In a robe of white and gold, with a smith's leather apron over it and his sleeves rolled up and his forearms corded and scarred. With a face Lex had seen once before, through a window of ice nine hundred years deep, bending over a gold anvil with a silver knife in his hand.

With eyes of gold. Root gold. Lex's gold. Antho's. Arion's.

He rose up out of the crack in the lid until he was standing on the light, a few feet above the black glass, with the Key of Shadows at his feet and Elric Thorne kneeling beside it. And he smiled.

It was the kindest smile Lex had ever seen.

"Hello, children," said Aurelian Vey.



NOBODY MOVED.

Nobody *could*. Lex felt it. A pressure. Not like Kell's Inspection. Not like the Key. Warmer. Softer. Like a great gentle hand pressing down on all of them. Not hurting. Just *holding*. The way you'd hold a bird you didn't want to fly away.

Wren was frozen beside him, an arrow on her string, her green eyes wide. Antho was on one knee, the Lantern in his hand, its gold light pushed down to a tiny circle around him, guttering. Kestrel's fire was out. Seraphine had dropped her crossbow. The twins had their arms around each other.

And Elric.

Elric was looking up at the shape standing on the light. His black eyes wide. His young face *open*. Like a child's. Like a man seeing the sun for the first time.

"It's you," he whispered. *"It's really you."*

"It's really me," said Aurelian Vey gently. He looked down at Elric. *"You did so well, Elric. So very well. Three years. Three pieces. All the way down to*

the bottom of the world." He reached down and touched Elric's dark hair. Very lightly. *"Thank you."*

Elric made a sound. Like something breaking.

"I promised you," said Aurelian, *"that you'd never be second again."*

"Yes." Elric's voice was barely a whisper. *"Yes. You promised."*

"And you won't be." Aurelian smiled. And lifted his hand from Elric's hair.

And turned. Away from Elric. Toward the others. Toward Lex, on his knees on the lid with the Lockward in his fist.

"You'll be nothing at all," said Aurelian Vey, kindly, over his shoulder.



LEX SAW ELRIC'S FACE.

He would see it for the rest of his life. In dreams. In the quiet moments at the forge, between strikes. The face of a man who had given everything, forty years and three years and fifty-five souls and his own name, for a voice that had promised him he'd go first.

And had just been told, gently, kindly, over its shoulder, what he really was.

A hand. A key-turner. Second.

"Lex," said Aurelian Vey.

He was standing in front of him now. On the light. Close enough to touch. Tall and fair and beautiful. Smelling of hot iron and summer and the inside of a bread oven, like the Wellworld of Flame. His gold eyes looking down at Lex with so much love that Lex felt it like a blow.

"My boy," said Aurelian. *"My blood. My smith."* He knelt. On the light, in front of Lex. So their eyes were level. *"Do you know how long I've been waiting for you?"*

Lex couldn't speak.

"Nine hundred years," said Aurelian softly. *"Nine hundred years, at the bottom of the world. Under the lid I made. Waiting for one of my blood to be strong enough."* His gold eyes moved over Lex's face. *"Your father almost was. Two hundred years ago. I asked him. Through the Root. Every night. Come down, Arion. Come home. Let me in."* A small sad smile. *"He said no. He's very stubborn, your father."*

Two hundred years. Lex heard it. Filed it. Somewhere very far away.

"*But you,*" said Aurelian. "*You opened the door yourself. In the glass. When you touched my shadow.*" He reached out and touched Lex's chest. Over his heart. Over the Root. "*You've been carrying me inside you ever since. All the way here.*"

His fingers were warm. So warm.

"*Let me in,*" said Aurelian Vey. "*All the way. And I'll take this weight off you. All of it. The keys and the doors and the promises. The names in your book. The Ceilings. The world.*" His voice was so gentle. "*I'll carry it for you. The way I carried it for nine hundred years. You can rest, Lex. You can finally rest.*"



THE DOOR AT THE bottom of the Root swung wide.

Lex felt it. Felt the warmth come up through him. Through the gold. Through Ember, who was screaming somewhere very far away, [*LEX, NO, LEX*]
—

Felt it reach his chest. His heart. His eyes.

Felt himself start to *go*. Not unwritten. Not fading. *Replaced*. Like iron in the coals, going soft, going gold, losing its shape, becoming something else.

Rest, said the voice. *Rest, my boy. Let me carry it.*

He was so tired.

He'd been tired for months. Since the festival. Since the baker. Since he'd walked north alone and found a faded man on a moor and a dead woman in a glacier and a grieving Well in the glass. Since Dorran.

Let me carry it.

It would be so easy. Like walking into the pillar in the Wellworld of Flame. Like Becoming. Just let go. Just let the gold have him.

He felt his hands go slack on the Lockward.



AND A HAND CLOSED on his sleeve.

Cold. Long-fingered. Scarred. The coldest thing at the bottom of the world.

And another hand. On his other arm. Small and slim and calloused from a bowstring. Holding. Not tight. Not afraid. Just *there*.

And through the Bloodbond, cold and quiet and deep, his brother's voice.

"*Not him,*" said Antho Vey.

Aurelian turned his head.

Antho was beside Lex. On his knees on the tilting lid. Gripping Lex's sleeve with one hand and the Keeper's Lantern with the other. The Lantern's light was almost gone. A tiny gold circle, barely the size of a coin, guttering. But it was lit. And in its light, Antho's face was grey and running with sweat and absolutely, coldly furious.

"*You don't get him,*" said Antho. "*I had a voice in my head for eleven years. Telling me to come into the trees. Wearing my mother's face.*" His grey eyes were locked on Aurelian's gold ones. "*It was you. Wasn't it. All along. On the woodpile. In the breach. It was always you.*"

Aurelian looked at him.

And for one moment, just one, the kind face *slipped*.

Lex saw it. Through the gold. Through the warmth pouring into him. Saw the beautiful tired face of the smith who had sung at his anvil flicker, like a reflection in disturbed water. And underneath it—

Nothing.

Not darkness. Not a monster. *Nothing*. An absence. A hole. A hunger with no shape, that ate light. The thing that had come up out of the ground under a plain of red earth and green grass and singing people. The thing the Sunwell had burned back down into the dark. Wearing a dead man's face like a coat.

Then the face was back. Kind. Sad. Beautiful.

"*Antho,*" said Aurelian gently. "*My poor broken boy.*"

"*I'm not broken,*" said Antho Vey. "*And I'm not yours.*"

And he pulled.



NOT WITH HIS HANDS. Through the Bloodbond.

Lex felt it. Cold. Quiet. Deep. Shade. The absence. The silence between heartbeats. His brother's whole Well, everything Antho had, everything

he'd learned holding a breach in the world for eight years and a door for three, pouring down through the thread that bound them together.

Into the gold.

Into the place where the door was open.

The way he'd quenched Lex's fire in the Wellworld of Flame. The way you put hot iron in the slack tub. Cold water, pouring into gold.

The warmth in Lex's chest *hissed*.

Steamed. Recoiled. The gold drawing back, down, away from his heart, away from his eyes. Back down through the Root. Back toward the door.

And Wren's hand on his other arm. Not pulling. Not holding him back. Just *there*. The way she'd been there in the Wellworld of Gale, when she'd let go of his hand and the sky had caught him.

I'll come back, he'd said. *I always come back. Because you're there.*

She was there.

He came back.



LEX TOOK A BREATH. A great shuddering gasp, like a drowning man coming up. The gold was gone from his eyes. Down. Back behind the door. Not shut. He could feel it. Still open. Still warm. But *below*. Where it belonged.

He looked up at Aurelian Vey.

The thing in his ancestor's face was looking down at him. Still kind. Still sad.

But its gold eyes had gone very, very still.

"Not tonight, then," it said softly. *"That's all right. I've waited nine hundred years. I can wait a little longer."* It smiled. *"But the lid is open, my boy. The Key is turned. And I don't need you to come home anymore."*

It stood up. On the light. And spread its arms.

"I can come to you," said Aurelian Vey.

And the crack in the lid *widened*.

And from below, from the gold, from the hungry nothing under the bottom of the world, something began to rise.

CHAPTER 22

A LEGACY FORGED ANEW



IT CAME UP OUT of the crack like smoke out of a chimney.

Not a shape. Not a body. *Absence*. A darkness so complete that the gold light pouring up around it seemed to bend away from it, the way water bends around a stone. It rose in long slow tendrils, curling, reaching. Dozens of them. Hundreds. Coming up out of the widening crack in the lid like the fingers of a hand reaching up through a grate.

And everywhere they touched, things went *out*.

Lex saw one brush the edge of the black glass lid. The glass didn't crack. It didn't break. It simply *wasn't there* anymore, where the tendril had touched it. A hole. A clean round absence in the world, with nothing on the other side.

[That's it,] said Ember. Its voice was shaking. [That's what's under the lid. Lex. That's the hunger. That's the thing the Sunwell burned. That's—] The Unmaker.

[Yes.] Barely a breath. [And it's wearing your ancestor like a glove.]

Above the rising dark, standing on the light with his arms spread wide, Aurelian Vey smiled down at them all. Fair and gold and kind. And the darkness rose up around him like a cloak.

"Don't be afraid," he said gently. "It doesn't hurt. Ask the big man on the stair. Ask the shepherd on the White Shore. It never hurts."



THE PRESSURE WAS GONE.

Lex felt it lift off them. The great gentle hand that had held them all still. Aurelian didn't need it anymore. He didn't need them still. He had the dark coming up, and the dark would do what it did.

They moved.

Wren first. She always moved first. She went up into the air, stepping, with her bow already drawn, and loosed. An arrow burning gold. It went straight at the nearest tendril of dark.

And went *through* it.

Not passing through. Going *in*. The gold fire of the arrow vanishing into the black like a coal dropped into deep water. Gone. Not even smoke.

"*It eats it*," Wren shouted. "*Hammer, it eats the fire—*"

Kestrel burned. A great roaring gout of Ashari fire, red and gold, pouring off both her hands at the tendrils rising nearest to Tamsin. The fire hit the dark and *vanished*. Every bit of it. Swallowed.

Seraphine fired her crossbow. The bolt went into the dark and didn't come out.

Antho threw Void Bolt. Shade against hunger. Absence against absence. It was the only thing that *slowed* them. The black bolts hit the tendrils and the tendrils *recoiled*, just slightly, as if they'd touched something that tasted wrong.

But only slowed. Not stopped.

And the dark kept rising.



IT WENT FOR ILSE.

Lex saw it a heartbeat before it happened. Saw a long tendril of absence curling out across the black glass, low, fast, toward the twins. Toward Ilse. Faint and grey, thirty-six percent gone, clutching the little stone from the Wellworld against her heart. The weakest thread in the cavern. The easiest to take.

"*ILSE—*"

Ivo threw himself in front of her. Of course he did. Arms spread. Weaving, desperately, an illusion of a wall, of a door, of anything. The tendril went straight through the illusion as if it wasn't there. Because it wasn't.

And someone else moved.

Grey. Faint. Ragged silver hair. Torn white robes.

Isaura Kell came across the black glass faster than Lex had ever seen anyone move. Faster than Wren. She didn't run. She just *went*. As if she'd been waiting for it. As if she'd known, the whole way down, that this was where she was going.

She shoved Ivo aside. Shoved Ilse aside. Stood where they'd been, with her arms at her sides and her chin up and her sunken eyes open.

And the dark took her.



IT WRAPPED AROUND HER the way a wave wraps around a rock. Slowly. Almost gently. Black tendrils curling up around her legs, her waist, her chest. She didn't fight. She didn't scream.

She looked at Lex.

"*Vask*," she said. Her voice was very steady. "*Tell his twelve villages. When you stand beside the Stone.*" The dark was at her throat. "*Tell them the High Warden who gave the order was sorry too.*"

"*Kell—*"

"*He carried me*," said Isaura Kell. "*Nobody ever carried me.*"

And the dark closed over her face.

And she was gone. Not into nothing. *Down*. Lex saw it. The tendril drawing back into the crack in the lid, slowly, with something faint and grey wrapped inside it. Going down. Into the gold light. Into whatever was under the bottom of the world.

She's mine, said the voice from below. Warm. Pleased. *Nobody remembers her. She's mine.*

And above the crack, Aurelian Vey smiled.



LEX LOOKED AT THE Ledger.

He didn't know why. His hand went to it, against his chest. He pulled it out and opened it to the last page, there on the tilting lid in the gold light, with the dark rising around him.

At the bottom of the page. Under the five soldiers. In the narrow elegant hand.

Isaura Kell, of Highcrest. Fifty-eight. High Warden. She was carried once.

He closed the book.

Not in the Lattice anymore, he thought. Not cut. Not unwritten. Taken. Below. Where the Key can't reach.

[She saved Ilse,] said Ember. Very quietly. [Lex. She chose.]

Dorran's anchor.

[Some anchors outlast the hand that set them.]



ELRIC HADN'T MOVED.

He was still kneeling beside the Key. In the middle of the rising dark, with the crack in the lid widening around him and the tendrils curling past him. They didn't touch him. They went around him the way water goes around a post. As if he weren't there. As if he weren't worth eating.

He was looking at the place where Kell had been.

"*Isaura*," he said. Barely a whisper.

Then he looked up. At Aurelian. Standing on the light above the crack, with the dark rising around him like a cloak, smiling down at everything.

"*You said*," said Elric Thorne, "*you said she'd be safe. At the end. You said everyone who followed me would be safe.*"

Aurelian glanced down at him. Mildly. The way you'd glance at a dog that had barked.

"*Did I?*" he said. "*I don't remember. I say so many things.*"

And looked away again.

Lex saw Elric's face.

It wasn't the face of a man who had been told he was second. That had been before. When Aurelian had turned his back and said *you'll be nothing at all*. That face had been broken.

This face was something else.

This face was *awake*.



"*Lex*," said Elric.

Lex was on his knees on the tilting lid, ten paces away. The Lockward was on the glass beside him where he'd dropped it. He'd been reaching for

it. Antho was beside him, throwing Void Bolt after Void Bolt at the rising dark, his face grey, his Lantern almost out. Wren was above them, shooting arrows that vanished. Kestrel had Tamsin behind her and was burning, burning, pouring fire into the dark and watching it disappear.

"Lex," said Elric again. Louder. *"The bar. Give me the bar."*

Lex stared at him.

"It won't go in," said Elric. *"Not while the Key's turned open. You know that. You made it."* His black eyes were very clear. *"The Key has to be turned back. Closed. And then the ward goes in beside it. And then it can never turn again."*

"I know—"

"And you can't turn it back." Elric's voice was flat. Steady. A teacher's voice. The voice that had explained mana-shaping on the Old Founders' Road. *"Not from there. It's my Key. I turned it. My hand's on it. If you try, you'll have to take it from me first, and I won't let go, and by the time you've pried my fingers off it, it'll be too late."* He looked at the dark rising around him. *"It's already nearly too late."*

"Then let go."

"No." Elric looked at him. *"I'm going to turn it back. Myself. And you're going to give me the bar."*



He's lying.

Lex felt it. Felt every instinct in him say it. *He's lying. He's always lied. He opened the wards at Fort Caldris. He took Father's crystal. He took fifty-five people. He took Ilse. He gave Kestrel a choice and made her choose wrong.*

He's lying.

And under it, faint, from somewhere very far back, a dry warm voice by a campfire in the Greyspine. A clever tired old man in a tattered cloak, explaining the Lattice to a terrified boy who'd just found out he could set things on fire.

I always tell you exactly what I want. It's the Veys who lie.

"Why?" said Lex.

Elric was quiet for a moment. The dark rose around him. The crack in the lid widened. Gold light poured up past his face.

"Because it said I'd always be second," he said. "And your mother said it was lying." He looked up at Aurelian, standing on the light, not looking at him. "And I'd like to find out which of them was right. Before the end."

His black eyes came back to Lex.

"Give me the bar, Lex. Let me go first."



[Lex,] said Ember. [The cost. The panel. Cost of setting. The blood pays.]

I know.

[If he sets it—]

I know.

[He's not blood. It might not work. It might not take him. It might take you anyway, because you forged it. Or it might—]

I know, Ember.

He looked at the Lockward. On the black glass. Dark grey, almost black. Notched like a mountain range. With a thin line of gold runes down its face. Steadfast. Bulwark. Hedda's nameless one. Arion's Wellscrip. And at the very end, near the hilt, in Lex's own hand: *STAY*.

The bearer cannot be severed from those he holds dear.

He'd made it to stop Elric. Every strike. Every breath of the bellows. Every drop of the Quench. He'd made it so that Elric Thorne could never turn the Key.

And now Elric was asking for it.

Lex picked it up.

He looked at Elric. Kneeling beside the Key, with his young face and his black eyes and his hands on the bow. Waiting. Not reaching. Just waiting.

"If you're lying," said Lex, "I'll stop you. I don't know how. But I will."

"I know," said Elric. And something moved at the corner of his mouth. Almost a smile. "You always do. You and your brother both. It's the most infuriating thing about you."

Lex threw him the Lockward.



ELRIC CAUGHT IT.

And Aurelian turned his head.

Lex saw it happen. Saw the kind fair face turn, slowly, from the rising dark, to look down at the man kneeling beside the Key. Saw the gold eyes see what was in Elric's hand.

And saw the face *slip*.

Not a flicker this time. A *slide*. The beautiful tired features of the smith who sang at his anvil, sliding off the thing underneath like a mask sliding off a wet face. And for three heartbeats, standing on the light above the crack in the world, there was nothing there at all. A hole. A hunger. A shape cut out of reality, Aurelian-sized, with nothing inside it.

"*ELRIC.*"

The voice wasn't kind anymore. It was *enormous*. It came up out of the crack and out of the dark and out of the gold and out of every thread in the knot overhead, all at once, so loud that the black glass under Lex's knees cracked. So loud that Wren fell out of the air. So loud that the Lantern in Antho's hand went out.

"*ELRIC THORNE. PUT. THAT. DOWN.*"

Elric looked up at it.

At the hole in the world, standing on the light. At the thing that had whispered in his ear for three years. That had told him where to dig. That had told him he deserved it. That had promised.

"*No,*" said Elric Thorne.

And turned the Key.



IT DIDN'T WANT TO turn.

Lex felt it. Felt the whole Hollow, everything under the lid, *push*. Against the Key. Against Elric's hands. The dark rising out of the crack surged up, toward him, around him, reaching. The tendrils that had gone around him like water around a post turned and came *at* him.

He didn't let go.

He knelt on the black glass with both hands on the bow of the Key, and his young face set, and his black eyes wide, and turned it. Back. Closed. Against the push of a thing that had been waiting under the world for nine hundred years.

It was too strong. Lex could see that. One man against the Hollow. A Tier IV man with stolen Authority and a stolen key, but one man. The Key moved a quarter-inch. Stopped. Started to slide back the other way.

And Elric did something Lex didn't expect.

He *let go* of what he'd taken.



LEX FELT IT THROUGH the Root. Like a dam bursting. Like a man opening his fists after three years of holding on.

Fifty-five threads. Sixty. Every soul Elric had cut out of the Lattice and swallowed. Every one that had made him younger, stronger, faster. The Authority they'd given him. The mana. The power. Everything he'd taken from them, he *gave back*. All at once. Through the Key. Not into himself. Into the *turn*.

Every one of them pushed the Key a little further.

Mella Bell. A quarter-inch.

Hollis Penn. Another.

Tamsin, no, Tamsin was already back, Elric had written him back at the Hollowmaw, but Lex felt the place where he'd been, felt it close like a healed wound.

Odo Ferris. *Bram Sowerby*. *Amira bint Hassa*. *Tarek al-Nur*.

The Key turned. Inch by inch. Back. Closed. And with every name, Lex felt something else. Felt it far away, through the knot overhead, through every thread in the net. Felt *threads*. Being written. Being woven back into the Lattice, strand by strand, out of nothing, the way Tamsin had been woven back at the Hollowmaw.

He looked down at the Ledger. Still in his hand. Still open.

The names were going.

One by one. From the bottom of the page. Fading. Not like ink washed away. Like a word being *crossed out*, gently, because it isn't needed anymore. *Garret Shale*. Gone. *Wil Brack*. Gone. *Bram Sowerby, of the White Shore*. He *named every one of his lambs after a star*. Gone.

Back.



AND ELRIC WAS GETTING older.

Lex saw it. With every name. With every thread he gave back. The young face aging. Thirty. Forty. Fifty. Lines coming back. Grey coming back into his hair, at the temples, at the roots, spreading. His shoulders stooping. His hands, on the bow of the Key, going thin and spotted and old.

Sixty. Seventy.

The Key turned.

And his eyes—

Brown. Coming back. Out of the black. Like the sun coming out from behind a cloud. Brown. Warm. Clever. Tired. The eyes of an old man by a campfire in the Greyspine, explaining the world to a boy.

Eighty.

ELRIC, screamed the thing above the crack. *ELRIC, STOP, YOU WILL HAVE NOTHING, YOU WILL BE NOTHING—*

"*I know*," said Elric Thorne. His voice was old now. Cracked. Dry. "*I know. I've always known.*"

And the Key clicked closed.



THE CRACK IN THE lid slammed shut.

Not slowly. Not gently. *Slammed*. Like a door in a gale. The black glass disc tilting back down, flat, the gold light pouring up through the crack cut off like a candle snuffed. The tendrils of dark that had risen out of it severed, all at once, at the base. They hung in the air for a moment, writhing. Then they fell. And dissolved. And were gone.

And Aurelian Vey—

The thing standing on the light above the crack—

The light under its feet went out.

It hung there for a moment. In the air above the closed lid. Fair and gold and beautiful again, the mask back on. And it looked down at Elric, old and grey and kneeling beside the Key, with an expression Lex would never forget.

Not fury. Not hate.

Surprise.

As if, in nine hundred years, it had never once been told no by someone it thought it owned.

And then it *fell*.

Down. Into the lid. Through the black glass, as if the glass were water. The beautiful form going down into the dark, slowly, its gold eyes fixed on Elric the whole way. Going. Going.

This isn't the end, it said. Very softly. From below. Fading. *Elric. Lex. Antho. All of you.*

I've waited nine hundred years.

I can wait a little longer.

And it was gone.



"The bar," said Elric. "*Lex. Quickly. Before it pushes again.*"

He was holding up the Lockward. His hands shaking. Old hands. So old. Lex came across the black glass and knelt beside him.

The Key stood in the Lock. Turned closed. Its looped bow sticking up out of the lid. And beside it, in the black glass, a second slot. Narrow. Jagged. Notched like a mountain range.

The shape of the Lockward.

It was always there, Lex realized. *Aurelian made the Lock with a place for a ward. In case. In case someone needed to bar it.*

Before whatever happened to him happened.

Elric held the Lockward over the slot. He looked at Lex.

"*Blood of the forger's line*," he said. "*That's what it says, isn't it. On the panel.*"

"Yes."

"*I'm not blood.*" Elric smiled. A thin, tired, old man's smile. "*Never was. Never will be. Forty years, standing next to your father, and not a drop.*"

He held up his left hand. Still in its glove. The fine grey glove he'd worn at Ysmir and the Glass Desert and the Hollowmaw. And Lex saw the palm of it. Stained. Brown. Dried.

"*I kept the rag*," said Elric. "*Kestrel's rag. With your blood on it. I wiped it on my glove at the Hollowmaw. Before I gave it back.*" He shrugged. A tiny movement. "*I don't know why. I suppose I thought it might come in useful.*"

His brown eyes were very bright. *"And I have nine points of your father's Authority. That I stole from him in the crystal, four years ago. The Root still thinks they're his."*

"Elric—"

"Blood of the forger's line," said Elric Thorne. *"On my hand. And the Root of the forger's father, in my thread."* He looked at Lex. *"Close enough, I think. Close enough to fool a lock."*

"It'll take you." Lex's voice cracked. *"The cost. The blood pays. You know what that means."*

"I know."

"It's supposed to be me."

"I know." Elric looked at him. *"That's why."*



LEX COULDN'T SPEAK.

Elric looked down at the Lockward in his hands. Dark grey, notched, with its thin line of gold runes. His thumb found the last one. Near the hilt. In Lex's hand.

STAY.

"The bearer cannot be severed from those he holds dear," said Elric quietly. *"I read it. On the panel at Avaloria, when you put it on your blade. I was standing behind you. You didn't know."* He traced the rune with his thumb. *"I thought it was the most sentimental thing I'd ever seen. I thought, that boy's going to get himself killed being sentimental."*

He looked up.

"I was right," he said. *"You will. Someday."* His brown eyes were wet. *"Just not today."*

And he pressed the Lockward into the slot beside the Key.



IT WENT IN LIKE a key into a lock.

Smoothly. Perfectly. Every notch finding every gap, every tooth finding every space. Sliding down into the black glass of the lid until only the hilt showed, a short dark-grey bar standing up beside the looped bow of the Key of Shadows. Side by side.

And it *sang*.

The same note it had sung in the Hollowmaw, when Lex quenched it. Pure and high and clear. Like a bell struck once in a silent church. It rang out through the cavern, through the black rock walls, up through the Rift, out across the Sundered Lands.

And the knot overhead *tightened*.

Lex felt it. The great tangled ball of silver and gold, every thread in the world, pulling *in*. Snug. Secure. The first strand, the one that had slipped, settling back into place. And the whole net, everywhere, shivering once, like a horse settling after a fright.

And then still.

WORLD NOTICE

THE LID IS SEALED.

THE KEY OF SHADOWS IS BARRED.



ELRIC WAS FADING.

Lex saw it. Not like the Unnamed. Not grey. Not blurred. *Gold*. A soft gold light coming up out of him, out of his old thin hands where they rested on the Lockward's hilt, out of his chest, his face. Rising. Like sparks from a forge going up a chimney.

Going up toward the knot.

"*Elric*." Lex had his hands on the old man's shoulders. He didn't remember putting them there. "*Elric, no. No, there has to be—*"

"*There isn't.*" Elric's voice was very faint now. Very old. "*The blood pays. That's the cost. Ysmir wrote it, and she didn't make things up.*" He smiled. "*It's all right, Lex. It doesn't hurt. Ask anyone.*"

"*You don't have to—*"

"*I do.*" Elric looked up. At the knot. Gold and silver, pulsing, a hundred feet overhead. "*Someone has to hold it. The bar. Someone has to stay down here and keep it in.*" The gold light was coming up out of him faster now. His hands were going faint on the hilt. "*It'll be me. I'll be in the knot. Holding the ward. Forever.*"

He laughed. A dry, cracked, old man's laugh.

"*First,*" he said. "*At last. At the very bottom of the world, where nobody will ever see it.*" He shook his head. "*That's about right, isn't it.*"



ANTHO HAD COME. LEX didn't know when. He was kneeling on Elric's other side. His face was grey. The Lantern in his hand was dark.

"Elric," he said.

The old man turned his head. Slowly. And looked at him.

"Antho," he said. *"You had the croup. When you were two. Your father was in the Spire and your mother was beside herself. I sat up with you all night. Singing."* His fading face crinkled. *"I couldn't sing. Neither can you. It must be catching."*

Antho didn't say anything.

"I'm sorry," said Elric. *"For the breach. For Duskhold. For your Clarity."* His brown eyes held Antho's. *"I knew what it would do to you. When I broke it. I knew. I did it anyway."*

"I know," said Antho.

"I don't ask you to forgive me."

"I know." Antho was quiet. *"I'm not going to."*

"Good." Elric almost smiled. *"You shouldn't. Your father would. That was always his trouble."*

He turned back to Lex.

The gold was pouring out of him now. Up toward the knot. His hands were almost gone. His face was going faint at the edges.

"Tell Arion," he said.

Lex leaned closer.

"Tell him I went first." Barely a whisper. *"Tell him he was right. All those years. I wasn't ready. For Tier IV. For the Root. For any of it."* A long, slow breath. *"I am now. Tell him that. Tell him, old friend, I'm ready now."*

"I'll tell him."

"And give him these."

Lex felt it. Through the Root. Nine small bright points of gold, coming out of the fading old man in front of him. Warm. Familiar. *Arion's*. Rising out of Elric's chest and drifting, slowly, into Lex's hands. Like coals passed from one hearth to another.

AUTHORITY RETURNED

9 points – ARION VEY (original holder)

Held in trust: LEX VEY

"He'll want them back," said Elric. *"He's very particular about his things."*

And then he looked past Lex. Up. At the knot. At the gold light rising out of him toward it.

"Oh," said Elric Thorne softly. Wonderingly. *"Oh, look. It's beautiful from down here."*

And the last of him went up.



LEX KNELT ON THE black glass beside the Key and the Lockward, with his hands on nothing.

The old man was gone. Not a body. Not ash. Nothing. Just a kneeling-place on the black glass, and a pair of fine grey gloves lying empty on it, one of them stained brown on the palm.

And overhead, in the great tangled knot of silver and gold, a new thread. Lex could see it. Just one. Thin and gold and steady, running from the very center of the knot straight down to the hilt of the Lockward. Holding it. Holding it in.

He took out the Ledger.

He didn't know why. His hands just did it. He opened it, there on the black glass, in the fading gold light. To the last page.

It was empty.

All of them. Gone. Every name. Mella Bell and Tamsin Varn and Odo Ferris and Hollis Penn and Bram Sowerby and Amira bint Hassa and Tarek al-Nur and Garret Shale and Wil Brack. All sixty. Crossed out, gently, one by one, because they weren't needed anymore. Because they were *back*.

Except two.

At the bottom of the page. In the narrow elegant hand.

Isaura Kell, of Highcrest. Fifty-eight. High Warden. She was carried once.

And below it, very faint, in a hand Lex had never seen in the Ledger before. Not Ysmir's. Shakier. Older. A hand he knew from a letter half-burned in a grate at Fort Caldris, four years ago.

Elric Thorne, of nowhere in particular. Sixty-eight. Second.

He went first, once.



WREN FOUND HIM THERE.

She came across the black glass with her bow on her back and a cut on her forehead where she'd fallen out of the air. She knelt down beside him. She didn't say anything. She looked at the empty gloves. At the Lockward. At the book in his hands.

She read the last line over his shoulder.

And put her arms around him.

Behind them, Lex heard the others. Coming across the lid. Slowly. Antho. Seraphine, with her crossbow dragging. Kestrel and Tamsin, holding hands. Oriel, on her stick.

And Ivo Marrow, carrying his sister.

He stopped beside Lex. He knelt down on the black glass. He set Ilse down beside him, very carefully.

She opened her eyes.

They were grey. Clear. And *bright*. Her mouse-brown hair was mouse-brown. Her patched green coat was green. Her face was pink with color, and her hands, when she held them up in front of her face, were solid all the way through.

"*Ivo*," she said. Wonderingly. "*Ivo, I can't see through my fingers.*"

Ivo made a sound.

"*I can't see through my fingers*," said Ilse Marrow again. And started to laugh. And cry. And her brother put his arms around her and his face in her hair and held on, and they knelt on the black glass at the bottom of the world, laughing and crying together, the way they'd done on the floor of the Wellworld of Stone.

ILSE MARROW

THREAD: WRITTEN (whole)

"Brought back by the hand that cut her.
Some debts are paid in the strangest
coin."

**THE RIFT WAS FALLING.**

Lex felt it through Stone. A shudder, far above. The great black walls, already cracked, already crumbling, beginning to come down. The knot had tightened. The lid was sealed. The Rift had been held open by the Key's unlocking, and now the Key was barred, and the Rift was closing. Like a wound healing. Like a mouth shutting.

"*We have to go,*" said Antho.

"*Go where?*" Seraphine was staring up into the dark. "*The stair's gone. It's eight days up. And it's falling.*"

Nobody answered.

And then, from very far above, faint, through a mile of falling rock, they heard it.

Thunder.

Not the thunder of the Rift coming down. Something else. Deep and slow and rolling, like a storm over mountains a hundred miles off. Getting closer.

And with it, crackling, bright, a sound like lightning walking.

"*Oh,*" said Wren. Her face lit up. "*Oh, Hammer. Look.*"

Lex looked up.

And saw them coming down. Out of the dark. Through the falling rock. Two shapes. One vast and storm-blue and whole, with wings like the sails of a warship, breathing thunder at the boulders that fell toward her and scattering them like leaves. One small and bright as a spark, darting ahead of her, lightning pouring off her in every direction, lighting the whole Rift up white.

Vharuun. And Ashka.

Diving. Straight down. Into the bottom of the world.

I SAID, said the storm-mother, and her voice rolled down the Rift like the end of a storm, *THAT WHATEVER WAITED AT THE END, IT WOULD HAVE TO GO THROUGH ME.*

I DID NOT SAY I WOULD WAIT AT THE TOP.



THEY CAME OUT OF the Umbral Rift at dawn.

On dragons. All of them. Clinging to the storm-mother's vast back and her daughter's narrow one, with the Rift collapsing beneath them and the Sundered Lands falling away on every side. Up through the last of the dark. Up past the floating slabs of broken earth. Up past the camp of the Eclipse Concord, which was empty now, its grey tents torn and its men fled.

Up into the sky.

And the sun was rising.

Lex saw it from Vharuun's back. Coming up over the eastern edge of the world, beyond the Sundered Lands, beyond the Veil. Gold. Ordinary. The plain gold light of an ordinary morning, after the longest night of the year.

The cracks in the sky over the Sundered Lands were still there. Black lines across the blue. But fainter. Narrower. Healing.

[It's over,] said Ember. Very quietly. *[Lex. It's over. The lid's sealed. The Key's barred. The sun came up.]*

It's not over.

[No,] Ember agreed, after a moment. *[It said it could wait.]*

It's waited nine hundred years. It's patient. Lex watched the sun come up. *And it's still at the bottom of the Root. The door's still open. A crack.* He closed his eyes. *And it's got Kell.*

[I know.]

And Mam's still behind the door at the Hollowmaw.

[I know.]

And Father's two hundred years old.

[Two hundred and thirty-one,] said Ember. *[I did the sums. From what it said. From what he said. From the portraits Wren won't tell you about.]* A pause. *[He'll tell you. When we get back. He promised.]*

Lex opened his eyes.

Wren was sitting in front of him on the storm-mother's back. Leaning against his chest. Asleep. Her red braid coming undone in the wind, a cut on her forehead, her bow across her knees. Behind him, Antho and Seraphine, holding each other. Kestrel and Tamsin. The twins, Ilse solid and laughing in her sleep. Oriel with her white face turned toward the sun, smiling faintly, as if she could feel it.

And beside them, Ashka, bright as a spark, flying close to her mother's wing.

Not everyone came back, thought Lex. Dorran. Kell. Elric.

But most of us did.

He put his arms around Wren. She murmured something in her sleep and pressed closer.

He held the Ledger against his chest with his other hand. Two names in it. Only two. And Dorran's book beside it. Four thousand one hundred and nine.

Twelve villages, he thought. When we get home.

And then the rest of the world.

The sun came up. And the storm-mother carried them west, toward home.

LEX VEY

FORGEHEART SORCERER – Tier III

Level 70 → 76

TITLE: KEYBREAKER

"He did not break the Key. He let
someone else bar it. Sometimes that
is the harder thing."

AUTHORITY: 100 (+9 held in trust)

Behind them, at the bottom of a sealed Rift in the Sundered Lands, under a mile of fallen rock, a single thin gold thread ran from the center of the first knot of the world down to the hilt of a short dark bar. And held it.

And held it.

And held it.

INTERLUDE

A NEVER-ENDING JOURNEY



ON THE OTHER SIDE of the door, it was always night.

Not dark. Seren Vey had learned that in her first year. The Hollow wasn't dark the way a cellar is dark, or a moonless field. It was dark the way the inside of your own eyelids is dark when you're very tired. Soft. Deep. Faintly blue, faintly violet, endless in every direction. You could see, if you wanted to. You just didn't, usually. There was nothing to see.

Except the lamp.

It sat on a ledge of black stone at the foot of the door. A small clay lamp, brown and round and plain, with a chip in its spout and a thumbprint in its base. Burning. Gold.

It was the same lamp. She'd worked that out in the second year. Not a twin. Not a copy. The *same*. The flame went through the door. One lamp, one flame, burning on both sides of the world at once, the way a candle in a window burns for the room and for the night outside.

She'd lit it eleven years ago, in the kitchen at Harrow, with her hands shaking and the hole in the world opening behind the hearth and her eldest son screaming on the stairs. She'd carried it into the dark with her.

And it had never once gone out.

Except the night of the Blade. When it had gone blue and died, and she'd screamed, and held, and held, and then felt her youngest son on the other side put his scarred hand on the lamp and *Speak* to it. And it had lit.

Lex. She'd felt him. Through the door. Through the flame. Big now. So big. Gold and hot and steady as a forge.

She'd sat down on the black stone afterward and wept for an hour.



SHE WAS VERY TIRED.

She knew that. She'd known it for a long time. Eleven years. Eleven years on the far side of a door, with her back against it and her hands flat on the black glass, holding.

Not holding it shut. People always got that wrong, in the stories. *She closed the door on herself.* As if a door, once closed, stayed closed. As if you could shut it and walk away.

You couldn't. Not this door. The Hollowmaw breach was the oldest crack in the world, older than the net, older than the lid. The Blade had been under it for nine hundred years, pinning it shut from the world's side. But from the Hollow's side, nothing held it. Nothing but whoever was willing to sit with their back against it and *push*.

For eight years, that had been Antho. She hadn't known. Not at first. She'd been lost in the shallows, wandering, half-mad, with her lamp. And then, standing on the far shore of a grey river with her way home in front of her, she'd felt it. A boy. On the other side. Holding the breach shut with his own mind, with green fire and Shade and his sanity. Her boy. Her eldest. Who'd been sixteen on the stairs at Harrow, screaming.

She'd come to the door. She'd put her back against it. And held from her side.

They'd held it together for eight years. Neither of them knowing.

And then the lamp. Three years ago. Her two boys, singing. And every lantern in the mountain catching fire. And the door sealing. And she'd felt Antho, through the glass, put his hand on it and say *Evening, Mam* to a lamp he thought was only a lamp.

She'd answered. He hadn't heard.

She'd kept answering. Every night. For three years.



THERE WAS SOMETHING ELSE she didn't tell anyone.

Not the boys. Not the voice in the Root that came to her every night, warm and low and tired, and said *Seren* as if her name were a prayer.

She didn't remember him.

She knew him. She knew his name. Arion Vey. She knew he was her husband, and the boys' father, and that he'd been asleep in a crystal for fifteen years and then awake in a tower for three. She knew his voice. She'd come to know it very well, these three years, through the Root, every night, in the dark. She knew he was clever, and stubborn, and kind, and afraid, and that he kept secrets the way other men kept dogs: carefully, and for company, and too many of them.

But she didn't *remember* him.

She didn't remember meeting him. She didn't remember marrying him. She didn't remember his face. She knew facts, the way you know facts about a stranger in a story. *They met in Highcrest. They married in spring. He went away often.* But the memories themselves, the warm bright living ones, were gone.

She'd paid them to the Ferryman.



ELEVEN YEARS AGO. THE first winter.

She'd been in the dark a season by then. Three months, that had felt like three years. Wandering. Lost. She'd found the Drowned Country, the shallows at the edge of the Hollow, where the drowned cities were and the grey dead drifted through the streets. She'd sat by the edge of the deep with her lamp and sung to the dark, because it was the only thing she could think of to do, and the dark had listened, a little.

And then she'd found the river.

Grey. Wide. Slow. Flowing between the Hollow and the world. And on its shore, a tall thin figure in a grey hat, leaning on a long grey pole, with an unlit lantern swinging at the top of it.

Seren Vey, the Ferryman had said. *You want to go home.*

She'd wept. She hadn't been able to stop. Three months in the dark. Three months without her boys. And here was a boat, and a river, and the world on the other side.

There is a price, said the Ferryman. *The memory you would least wish to lose.*

She'd known what it would be. She'd known before he said it. Not the boys. The boys were her heart; she'd sooner have paid her heart. But the

boys were also *hers*. She carried them. She'd carried them since before they were born.

The brightest thing. The warm stone she took out in the dark and turned over in her hands. The thing that was only *hers*, that nobody else had, that she'd chosen.

A young man in a grey coat, said the Ferryman softly. *On the steps of the Spire. In the rain. Who looked at you as if you were the first light he'd seen in two hundred years.*

She'd paid it.

And crossed.



SHE'D STOOD ON THE world's shore of the grey river, in the thin grey valley beyond the Teeth, with the Lattice humming faint and silver around her for the first time in three years. With her lamp in her hand. With the way home stretching east in front of her, through the grey, over the mountains, to wherever her boys were.

And she'd heard it.

Through the thin world. Through the Hollow behind her. From the east. Faint and terrible.

A boy screaming.

Not on the stairs at Harrow, this time. Somewhere else. Somewhere in the mountains. A cave. A crack in the world, newly torn, breathing cold. And a boy in front of it, sixteen, gaunt and wild-eyed, with green fire in his hands and the Hollow pouring into him through the crack, filling him, *drinking* him. Holding it shut with nothing but his own mind.

Alone.

Losing.

She'd stood on the shore of the grey river with her way home stretching out in front of her, and the price already paid, and every memory of the man she'd married already gone.

And she'd turned around.



THE FERRYMAN HAD WATCHED her walk back down the shingle.

You have paid for one crossing, he'd said. One. If you go back now, I cannot take you over again. Not for that price. Not for any.

I know, she'd said.

You will be in the dark. Perhaps forever.

I know.

Why?

She'd stopped at the water's edge. She'd looked back at him. At his long eyeless face under the wide grey hat.

Because my boy is holding a door, she'd said. Alone. And I promised him, on the stairs at Harrow, that I'd keep it.

And she'd walked into the grey river. Without paying. And the river had taken what it was owed, the way it takes from everyone who crosses without a fee. It had taken her way home. Every road back. She'd felt them go, one by one, like doors closing in a long corridor.

And she'd walked on, through the grey, through the shallows, through the Drowned Country, east. Toward the screaming. Following it through the dark for a month. Until she found the far side of the Hollowmaw breach.

And put her back against it.

And held.



EIGHT YEARS. THEN THREE.

And then the Key.

She'd felt the Blade go. On the night of the Blade. Felt it torn out from under the floor on the world's side, the old pin that had held the breach shut for nine hundred years. Felt the door bulge. Felt the whole weight of the Hollow come down on her back.

And she'd held. Somehow. With Antho's hand on the glass on the other side. And a boy she didn't know, holding Antho's wrist. And then Lex, lighting the lamp.

And then, three weeks later, a new hand on the glass. On the other side. Long-fingered. Lean. Warm.

I'm here, the voice had said. The voice from the Root. The voice she'd come to know so well in the dark, three years of nights. Not through the Root now. Through the door. Close. So close. *Seren. I'm here. I'm staying.*

She didn't remember his face.

She'd fallen in love with his voice anyway. All over again. In the dark. Without remembering why she had the first time.

She thought that was probably the strangest love story anyone had ever had.



THE LONGEST NIGHT HAD been the worst.

She'd felt the lid lift. Not here. Far away, at the bottom of the world, at the first knot. But the Hollow was all one thing, under everything, and when the lid lifted, *everything* pushed. Up. Through every crack. And the Hollowmaw was the biggest crack there was.

The door had bulged. Cracked. Screamed.

And on the other side, Arion. *Tonight I'm here.* With his hands on the glass and his forehead against it. And a crowd of small cold hands beside his: children, students, she could feel them, holding candles, holding on.

She'd held. They'd all held.

And then, at the bottom of the world, someone had turned the Key back.

She'd felt it. Felt the push stop. Felt the lid slam down, far away, and the whole Hollow *recoil*, like a hand snatched back from a fire. Felt the door stop bulging. Felt it settle.

And felt, faint and far, through the deep, a thread go up into the knot. Gold. Old. *Tired.*

Elric, she'd thought. And hadn't known how she knew.

She'd sat down on the black stone at the foot of the door, beside her lamp, and wept for him. For the man who'd sat up all night with Antho when he had the croup. She remembered that. She'd paid away her husband, but not the man who'd sung, badly, to her baby.



IT CAME TO HER three nights after.

She knew it was coming. She'd known for eleven years that someday it would. She'd felt it in the deep, all that time, at the bottom of the Hollow. Patient. Waiting. Turning toward her sometimes, the way a sleeper turns toward a sound.

She was sitting by her lamp. Singing. The lantern song. *If the dark comes calling, love, don't you mind.*

And the dark in front of her *thickened*.

And there he was.

Tall. Fair. Beautiful, in a tired way, like a fine blade used too long. In a robe of white and gold with a smith's apron over it. With gold eyes. With her sons' eyes.

"Seren," said Aurelian Vey.

She didn't stop singing.

He waited. Politely. Standing in the dark a few paces away, with his scarred hands folded in front of him, while she sang the whole song through. All the verses. The one about the lantern. The one about the window. The one about the long road home.

When she'd finished, he smiled.

"*You always did have a lovely voice,*" he said.

"*You've never heard my voice,*" said Seren. "*You've heard my sons say good evening to my lamp.*"

"*I've heard you sing to the door for eleven years.*" His gold eyes were very kind. "*Every night. I've been listening.*" He tilted his head. "*It's very soothing. I've grown quite fond of it.*"



HE WASN'T WHOLE.

She saw that. She'd seen him before, through the deep, from far off. Always beautiful. Always perfect. Not tonight. Tonight, at the edges, his shape *flickered*. Like a reflection in disturbed water. His left hand, folded over his right, kept going faint, and then coming back, and then going faint again. And under the faintness, for a heartbeat at a time, there was nothing at all. A hole. A shape cut out of the dark.

The Key, she thought. *The bar. When the lid slammed shut, it caught him. Half in and half out.*

It hurt him.

"*It did,*" said Aurelian Vey. As if she'd spoken aloud. "*It did hurt. I won't pretend. I've been hurt before, Seren, but never by someone I'd thought was mine.*" He looked down at his flickering hand. "*Elric. Of all people. Second Elric.*" He shook his head slowly. "*I underestimated him. I underestimated your son. I underestimated you.*" He smiled. "*That's three mistakes. I don't make many.*"

"*Go away.*"

"*In a moment.*" He came a step closer. "*I wanted to show you something first. I've been very lonely, these nine hundred years. And now I'm not.*" He turned his head. "*I've made some friends.*"



THEY CAME OUT OF the dark behind him.

Four of them.

The first was a man. Tall and thin and stooped, in the long dark robe of a church choir-master, with a wide mouth and long pale hands. He was singing. Not aloud. Seren couldn't hear it. But she could see his throat moving, and his lips, and the air around him *shivered*, the way the air shivers over a fire. Wherever he looked, the dark bent toward him. Listening.

The Cantor, said a voice in her head. Not Aurelian's. Her own. Remembering something. A story. A village in the north, three hundred years ago, where the choir-master had sung so beautifully that the whole village had followed him into the hills one night and never come back.

The second was a woman. Short and round and motherly, in a grey apron, with her sleeves rolled up and her grey hair in a bun. A midwife's apron. A midwife's hands, strong and capable. She was smiling. A warm, kind, grandmotherly smile. And wherever she walked, the black stone under her feet went *soft*. Rotten. Like old fruit.

Mother Sallow. A plague village in the Vale, two hundred years ago. The midwife who'd stayed when everyone else fled. Who'd tended the sick until she was the only one left. And then had tended the dead.

The third was a knight. In armor. Black and silver, old-fashioned, with a great helm. But wrong. *Doubled*. Two shapes in one suit of armor,

overlapping, as if two men had been poured into one mould. Four arms. Two swords. Two voices, Seren could hear them, faint, inside the helm, arguing. *Left. No, right. No, LEFT.*

The Twinned Knight. Two brothers. The Knights of the Ford, in the old ballads, who'd held a river crossing against an army, back to back, until the water rose and drowned them both. Holding each other. They'd never let go.

And the fourth.

A woman. Tall. Gaunt. In torn white robes gone grey. With ragged silver hair hanging in her face. And no face. Not a hole. Not a blank. Just—*unremembered*. Seren looked at it and couldn't hold it. Her eyes slid off. As if the face had been written in pencil and then rubbed out.

She stood behind the others. Very still. With her hands at her sides.

"*My Choir,*" said Aurelian Vey fondly. "*Isn't it lovely? The Cantor. Mother Sallow. The Knights. And my Warden.*" He looked at the faceless woman. "*She hasn't got a name anymore. Nobody remembers it. So I've given her a new one. She guards my door now. Don't you, Warden?*"

The faceless woman didn't answer.

But Seren saw her hands. At her sides. Clenching. Very slightly. As if, somewhere, a long way down, something in her didn't agree.



"*They're going up,*" said Aurelian. Conversationally. "*All four of them. Up into the world.*"

"*You can't.*" Seren's voice was steady. She was proud of that. "*The lid's sealed. The Key's barred. My son made a bar, and your Elric set it, and you'll never—*"

"*Not through the lid.*" Aurelian smiled. "*Oh, Seren. Did you think the lid was the only way?*" He knelt down. On the black stone. Across the little clay lamp from her. So his gold eyes were level with hers, with the flame between them. "*Do you know what the Tithe is?*"

She didn't answer.

"*Every Stone in the world,*" said Aurelian Vey, "*every one my brother and sister helped me cut from the bones of the mountain, every one with a thread running into it, takes a little. A tenth. Of every soul's mana. Every day. Since*

the net was woven." His voice was very gentle. *"It runs down. Through the Stones. Through the threads. Down, down, to the bottom of the world. A tithe. For the binding. To keep the lid strong."*

He smiled.

"That's what I told them. My brother and sister. The other Founders. A tithe, for the binding." He tilted his head. *"It wasn't for the binding, Seren. It was for me. Nine hundred years. A tenth of everything. Every soul under the net. Feeding me."*

Seren went cold.

"Four thousand Stones in Caldor," said Aurelian. *"Thousands more in the Sunreach and the north and the east. Every one with a thread running down. Down to me."* His gold eyes were very bright. *"They're pipes, Seren. Every Stone is a pipe. Running from the world straight down to the bottom of the Hollow."*

"And pipes," said Aurelian Vey softly, *"run both ways."*



SHE UNDERSTOOD.

She sat on the black stone with her back against the door and the lamp in front of her and felt the understanding go through her like cold water.

The Stones. Every village. Every town. Every city square. Harrowgate. Coldbrook. Kessick. Highcrest. Saffaran. The Stone at Hollow's Foot, below the Hollowmaw, where Arion had walked his sons out of the threads.

Pipes. Running down.

And something coming up.

"Your sons have been very busy," said Aurelian. *"Breaking Ceilings. Freeing threads. Four hundred and forty thousand of them. And every one they free shines brighter. Carries more mana. Pays a bigger tithe."* He smiled. *"They've been feeding me, Seren. Every Stone they Unbind, they make the pipe wider."*

"No."

"Yes." He stood up. *"And now the lid's shut. And I can't come up through the middle. So I'll come up through the edges. Through every Stone in the*

world. One at a time. Very slowly." He looked at his Choir. *"They'll go first. To get the pipes ready."*

He turned to go. Then turned back.

"Oh. And I've written a little poem," he said. *"For your boys. A prophecy. They like prophecies, the Vey's. They always have."* He smiled. *"I'll make sure they find it."*

"What does it say?"

"It says come home," said Aurelian Vey. *"It says the Root of the world is buried in my tomb, and only the heir can free it, and if he doesn't, the net will fail and everyone will die."* He shrugged, very slightly. *"Some of that's even true."*

"They won't come."

"They always come." He looked down at her with infinite kindness. *"That's the thing about your family, Seren. You always come. You came into the dark for a boy on the stairs. You came back across the river for a boy at the breach. Your husband sat in front of a door for three weeks because you were behind it."* His gold eyes were very soft. *"They'll come for the same reason. Because someone they love is in the dark."*

And he looked, very briefly, at the faceless woman standing at the back of his Choir. With her clenched hands.

And then he was gone. And the Choir with him. Into the deep. Going. Up.



SEREN SAT BY HER lamp for a long time.

Then she turned around. And put her hands on the door. On the black glass. The way she'd done every night for eleven years.

"Arion," she said.

Nothing.

She pressed harder. Pushed her voice into the glass. Into the flame. Into the Root, deep down, where the thread ran that had once been tied to his.

"Arion. The Stones. Tell them. The Stones, Arion. It's coming up through the Stones—"

Nothing.

The glass was different. She felt it. Harder. Thicker. Sealed. When the lid slammed shut at the bottom of the world, when the Lockward went in, every crack in the Hollow had tightened. Including this one. The door that had been cracked enough for a voice to pass was cracked enough now for a flame. Only a flame.

She could hear him. Faintly. On the other side. His voice. Talking to her, the way he did. *Seren. Are you there? I can't hear you. Seren.*

He couldn't hear her.



SHE SAT DOWN ON the black stone.

She looked at the lamp. At the little gold flame, burning on both sides of the door at once.

They always come, the thing had said. *Because someone they love is in the dark.*

You came back across the river for a boy at the breach.

She thought about that. For a long time. Sitting in the soft endless dark at the bottom of the world, with her back against a door she'd held for eleven years and a voice on the other side she couldn't remember falling in love with.

He's right, she thought. *They will come. They'll find his poem, and they'll come to his tomb, and they'll walk into whatever he's built for them. Because I'm in the dark.*

Unless I'm not.

She looked out into the deep. Into the soft blue-violet nothing, going on forever. Toward the place where the Choir had gone. Toward the bottom of the Hollow. Toward wherever the thing in her sons' ancestor's face lived.

And at the back of the Choir, a faceless woman with clenched hands.

Nobody remembers her, Seren thought. *Nobody but him. And he's given her a new name.*

And I know what it's like. To be in the dark with no one to call you by your name.

She stood up.

It was very hard. Her legs had forgotten how. Eleven years, sitting against a door. She stood with one hand on the black glass, swaying, and looked at the lamp.

I can't take it with me, she thought. It has to stay here. It's the door. It's the flame on both sides. If I take it, the door goes dark.

But they'll keep it lit. On their side. Arion. Antho. The boy who doesn't talk.

They'll leave a light on.

She knelt down. She cupped her hands around the little clay lamp, the way you'd cup your hands around a bird. She didn't pick it up. She just held her hands around it. And sang. Very softly. The last verse. The one about the long road home.

If the dark's too long, love, and the way's too far, look for the light, love, wherever you are. I'll be walking toward it, however I can. Leave a light in the window. I'm coming home.

She stood up again. She took her hands away.

The flame burned on. Steady. Gold.

And Seren Vey, who had held the far side of a door for eleven years, and paid away her husband, and turned back across a river for her son, turned her back on the door for the first time.

And walked into the deep.

After the Choir. After the faceless woman with the clenched hands. After the thing in Aurelian's face.

The long way round.



ON THE OTHER SIDE of the door, in the bell-shaped cavern at the bottom of the Hollowmaw, Arion Vey sat with his hands on the black glass.

He'd been sitting there for three days. Since the longest night. Since the lid lifted and slammed shut. He'd felt the door settle. Felt it seal tighter. And since then, nothing. No voice. No *Arion*. Just the lamp in its niche, burning straight up.

The boy who didn't talk sat beside him. Pim. He'd barely left since the longest night. He sat with his knees drawn up and his small cold hand on Arion's sleeve.

And the flame leaned.

Arion felt his heart stop.

It leaned. Toward the door. The way it had leaned every night for three years, when she came. A finger's width. Toward the glass.

And then, slowly, it straightened again. And burned straight up.

He waited. An hour. Two. All night.

It didn't lean again.

"*She's gone*," said Pim.

Arion turned his head. The boy was looking at the lamp. His thin grave face very still. His dark careful listening eyes.

"*She was there*," said Pim. "*On the other side. I could hear her. Every night. Like a sound you stop noticing.*" He was quiet. "*And now she isn't.*"

It was the longest speech he had ever made.

Arion looked at the door. At the lamp. At the flame, burning gold and steady on both sides of a door that nobody was holding anymore.

Seren, he thought. *Seren. Where have you gone?*

He didn't get up.

He sat in front of the door with the boy beside him, and kept his hands on the glass. And when the lamp needed oil, though it never did, he filled it anyway. And every night, at the end of the count, he said good evening.

Leaving a light on.

Just in case.

PART TWO



ECHOES OF THE PAST

CHAPTER 23

ECHOES OF THE PAST



FEN HOLLOW WAS THE first.

It was a small place. Smaller than Ashbourne. Thirty houses of grey stone and green turf, crouched in a fold of the land past the Blightmarch, where the moors gave way to marsh and the sky went on forever. There was a mill on a slow brown stream. A church with no spire. A green with a well. And on the green, a Lattice Stone.

Old. Older than the village. Grey, and pitted, and leaning a little to one side, the way old Stones did in the west, where the Order had never cared enough to straighten them. Its silver was faint. Lex could feel its threads from the edge of the village. Four hundred souls. Every one of them capped.

It was spring. Three months after the longest night. The marsh was full of frogs and the hedges were full of blackthorn and the air smelled of mud and new grass. And on the green at Fen Hollow, in the thin bright morning, the whole village had come out to see why a smith from Ashbourne had walked a hundred miles to stand beside their Stone.

He didn't stand there alone.

Ilse stood on his left. Ivo on his right. In their patched coats, green and brown, with their mouse-brown hair brushed for once and their faces very pale.

And Wren stood a little behind, with her bow on her back. Not holding his hand. Just there.



"*I don't know what to say,*" Ilse had said, the night before. In the inn at the edge of the marsh, sitting on the end of the bed with Dorran's book in her lap. "*I don't know what to say to them.*"

"Say what he wrote," said Lex.

She'd looked down at the book. At the inside of the back cover. At the big clumsy careful hand.

"*He never said it out loud,*" she said. "*Not once. In all the years. He just lifted things.*"

"Then you say it for him."



SHE SAID IT.

Standing on the green at Fen Hollow, beside the old grey Stone, with four hundred people looking at her. A thief from Kessick. Twenty-four. Who had been capped at fourteen by a big man with a brand on his arm, and asked him *why did you put the light out*.

She held up the book.

"*There was a man,*" said Ilse Marrow, "*who used to come here. A long time ago. Every spring, and every autumn. A Warden of the Kindling.*"

Some of the older people in the crowd went still.

"*A big man,*" said Ilse. "*Bigger than anyone. With a shaved head and a broken nose. He stood beside this Stone, every Kindling-day, for twenty-two years. And when your children came up and put their hands on it, he put his hand on their shoulders. And pushed down.*"

The crowd was silent.

"*He wrote down every name,*" said Ilse. Her voice cracked. She steadied it. "*Every child. Every Ceiling. Four thousand one hundred and nine of them. Twelve villages. This was the first.*" She opened the book. "*Aldo Cray. Bess Rook. Wat Lister.*"

A sound from the crowd. An old woman, near the front, with her hand over her mouth. A man beside her, grey-haired, staring.

"*He died,*" said Ilse. "*In the winter. At the bottom of the world. Holding up a mountain, so we could get past.*" She swallowed. "*And before he died, he asked us to come here. Me and my brother. Because he capped us too. In Kessick. We were the first ones he ever felt go dim.*"

She turned to the back cover. And read it. In a clear, shaking voice, to the whole of Fen Hollow.

"When they light up, tell them I'm sorry. Tell them the big man who put the lid on said he was sorry, and that he spent the rest of his life lifting things."

She closed the book.

Nobody said anything for a long time.

Then the old woman at the front came forward. Slowly. Leaning on a stick. She stopped in front of Ilse and looked at her for a long moment, with her faded eyes very bright.

"Bess Rook," she said. *"That's me. Spring Kindling. Ceiling twelve."* She was quiet. *"I remember him. He had very gentle hands. For such a big man."* She looked at the Stone. *"I always wondered why he looked so sad."*



LEX PUT HIS HANDS on the Stone.

He'd done it two hundred and sixty times in Caldor. Once in Saffaran, the hardest of all. He knew the shape of it now the way he knew the shape of a hammer-swing. Reach in. Find the Ceilings. Lift.

He didn't need to ask this one. It was old and tired and it had been holding these lids down for nine hundred years, and when he reached into it, it practically *sighed*.

But he asked anyway. Because he always asked now. Since the Glass Desert. Since the Old Man of the Ironbacks. *Please*.

And lifted.

The light came up off the Stone like the sun coming up over the marsh. Silver and gold, pouring out through every thread in Fen Hollow. Four hundred threads, coming loose all at once. Lex felt them go. Felt the whole village take a breath.

And Ilse and Ivo stepped forward. The way Dorran had told them. *Stand beside the Stone. You were the first ones I ever felt go dim. You should be the first ones there when they light up.*

They put their hands on people's shoulders.

Bess Rook first. The old woman with the stick. Ilse put her hand on her shoulder, and Bess's eyes went wide, and her whole face lit up silver from

inside, and she laughed. A cracked old woman's laugh, startled and delighted. Then a man. Then a girl of fifteen. Then a boy. One by one. As they came up to the Stone. Ilse on one side, Ivo on the other, with their hands on shoulders, the way a big man had once stood there with his.

Opening the lids.

FEN HOLLOW – 411 CEILINGS LIFTED

"The big man said he was sorry."

Lex stood back and watched them. Wren came and stood beside him. She didn't take his hand. She just leaned against his arm.

"He'd have hated this," she said quietly. "All these people. Crying. Thanking them."

"He'd have hated it," Lex agreed. "He'd have gone and hidden in the forge and hit something too hard."

Wren laughed. And wiped her eyes.

"Eleven more," she said.

"Eleven more."



BUT SOMETHING WAS WRONG with the Stone.

He noticed it at the end. When the light had faded and the village had gone to the church to ring the bell, and the twins were sitting on the edge of the well with Bess Rook between them, holding a hand each. Lex had stayed at the Stone. He had his palm on it still. Feeling the threads settle. The way you leave your hand on a horse's neck after a hard ride.

And he felt it.

A thread. Running *down*.

Not out. Every other thread in the Stone ran out, to a person, to a soul, to the four hundred and eleven people of Fen Hollow. This one ran down. Into the ground. Into the bedrock under the Stone. Thin and grey and very faint, so faint he'd never noticed it before. Not here. Not in two hundred and sixty-one other Stones.

Ember, he thought. What's that?

A long silence.

[I don't know,] said Ember slowly. [I've never seen it. Lex, I've never seen it. And I've been in the Root with you for four years.]

It's always been there. In every Stone. I can feel it now I'm looking. It's like—he searched for it—like your own heartbeat. You never notice it until you stop and listen.

He followed it. Gently. With the Root. A little way down.

It went a long way. Through the bedrock. Through the deep. Down and down. Thin and grey and steady. Carrying something. A trickle. A thin steady trickle of silver. Mana. From the Stone. From every thread in the Stone. A little from each. Running down.

[A tenth,] said Ember suddenly. [Lex. It's taking a tenth. From every soul. Look. Every thread that runs out, there's a little bit of it running back, and down.]

Lex pulled back. Fast.

He stood on the green at Fen Hollow with his hand on the old grey Stone and his heart hammering.

Because at the very bottom of the thin grey thread, a long, long way down, as far as he'd let himself follow it, he'd felt something.

Warmth.

Gold.

The faint, faint sound of breathing.



THEY DID THE TWELVE villages in a month.

Fen Hollow. Brackwater. Thornby, where Garret Shale's mother lived, and opened the door to find her son, unwritten and rewritten, sitting at her kitchen table eating porridge. Lex hadn't known. Ilse cried for an hour. Morrow's End. Saltmere. Little Ashby. All of them. Small grey places in the far west, where the Order had never cared and nobody had ever come.

Every time, Ilse read the back cover of the book.

Every time, someone in the crowd remembered him. *He had very gentle hands. He always looked so sad. He gave me a sweet, after, when I cried. He carried my little brother home on his shoulders because his legs had gone weak.*

Every time, Lex felt the grey thread running down.

He didn't say anything. Not to the twins. Not to Wren. He just felt it, every time, under every Stone. And every time, it was there. A tenth. Running down. Into the dark.

[You have to tell someone,] said Ember, on the last night. In the inn at Little Ashby. *[Lex.]*

I know.

[Your father.]

I know.

[He has a lot to tell you too.]

Lex lay on his back on the narrow inn bed with Wren asleep against his side and looked at the ceiling.

I know, he thought. That's why I haven't gone yet.



HE WENT TO THE Hollowmaw at the end of the month. With Wren, on Ashka, who'd come to find them at Little Ashby with her silver eyes bright and lightning crawling along her flanks and a goat in her mouth (not Correspondence; a stranger's goat, which she'd stolen, and which Lex had to pay for).

Antho was waiting at the mouth of the cave.

He'd been there all winter. With Seraphine. With the students. With their father. He looked better than Lex had seen him in years. Not thinner. Not grey. His face had color in it. He'd cut his hair. He was wearing a new coat, dark blue, that Seraphine had obviously chosen.

"You look," said Lex, sliding off Ashka, *"almost respectable."*

"Seraphine made me." Antho looked down at the coat. *"She said if I was going to teach nine children I should at least look like someone who owned a mirror."*

"Does she know you don't own a mirror?"

"She bought me one." Antho's mouth twitched. *"I put it in the cold-room. Teo uses it to look at the fish."*

And then, without warning, his brother pulled him into a hug. Hard. Brief. And let go.

"Tell me about the stone," said Antho.

Lex told him. Standing on the slope below the Hollowmaw in the spring sunshine, with the valley green below them and Ashka chasing a goat and Wren sitting on a rock grinning at them both. He told it well this time. He'd had a month of practise, in inns at the edge of marshes, telling it to the ceiling.

Antho listened. The way he always did.

"Five," he said, at the end.

"Five."

"I saw it," said Antho. *"From the water. At the bottom of the sea."* He looked out at the valley. *"I didn't remember it. But I saw it."* He was quiet. *"Every time you tell it, it gets a bit more like mine."*



THEIR FATHER WAS AT the door.

He'd been there all winter too. Lex knew that. Antho had written. *He doesn't leave. He sleeps in front of it. On a blanket. The students bring him food. Pim sits with him every night.* And then, in a later letter: *The lamp doesn't lean anymore. Not since the longest night. She's gone, Lex. From the other side. Father doesn't know where.*

Arion was sitting on the black floor of the bell-shaped cavern with his back against the wall beside the door, and a blanket over his knees, and a book open on the blanket that he wasn't reading. The little clay lamp burned in its niche. Straight up. Steady.

He looked up when his sons came down the last of the passage. And his lean unchanged face did the thing it almost never did.

"Lex," he said. And then, quieter: *"Thank you. For bringing them back. The nine points. Antho gave them to me."* He touched his chest. *"I'd forgotten what it felt like. To have them."*

"Elric gave them back," said Lex. "Not me."

"I know." His father looked at the lamp. *"Antho told me. All of it. What he said at the end."* He was quiet for a long moment. *"Tell him I went first. Tell him he was right. I wasn't ready."* His voice dropped. *"I am now."*

"Old friend," said Lex. "He said, tell him, old friend, I'm ready now."

Arion closed his eyes.

They stood there for a while. The three of them. In the gold light.

Then Arion opened his eyes, and folded the blanket, and closed the book. And looked at both his sons.

"*Sit down,*" he said. "*I promised you something. Before you went to the Rift.*" He took a breath. "*I'm going to keep it.*"



HE TOLD THEM EVERYTHING.

The Root. The way it had stopped him, at thirty-one, like a clock. The portraits in the secret room in the Spire: Wren had told Lex about them on the road north, after the Rift, quietly, as if she'd been holding it like a breath. *Arion Vey the scholar. Arion Vey the Warden. Arion Vey's son. Arion Vey's grandson.* The two hundred years of moving, and changing his name, and watching everyone he knew grow old and die.

"*Two hundred and thirty-one,*" said Arion. "*Two hundred and thirty-two now. It was midwinter. The longest night.*" A faint, tired smile. "*I spent my birthday holding a door with nine children and a lamp. It was the best birthday I've had in a century.*"

Antho didn't say anything. He was sitting very still, with his hands folded in his lap and his grey eyes on their father's face.

Lex said: "*Aurelian told me.* At the Rift. He said he asked you. Two hundred years ago. Through the Root. Every night. To come down. To let him in."

His father went very still.

"Yes," he said at last.

"*What happened?*"

Arion was quiet for a long time. When he spoke, his voice was very low.

"*I was young,*" he said. "*Thirty-five. Thirty-six. I'd had the Root for five years. I was the strongest sorcerer in Caldor, and I was frightened all the time, and I didn't know why.*" He looked at his hands. "*And I started hearing a voice. At night. When I was tired. In the deep gold, at the bottom of the Root.*"

"*Kind,*" said Antho quietly.

"*Kind.*" Arion nodded. "*So kind. It knew everything about me. Every fear. Every doubt. It said: you're carrying too much, Arion. Let me help. Let me carry it. Come down to me, and I'll take the weight, and you'll never be*

afraid again." He was silent. *"It said it was Aurelian. Our ancestor. The Root of the world. It said it was buried, and trapped, and lonely, and that if I came down and let it in, together we'd make the world safe forever."*

"And you said no."

"I said no." Arion's mouth twisted. *"Not because I was wise. Not because I saw through it. Because I was stubborn. I've always been stubborn. My father said I'd say no to the sun if it asked me to get up in the morning."* He shook his head slowly. *"It asked me every night for a year. And every night I said no. Not because I thought it was lying. Because I didn't want to be told what to do."*

Lex almost laughed. He didn't.

"And then it stopped asking," said Arion. *"And I thought I'd won."* He looked at the lamp. *"I hadn't. It had only decided to wait. For someone younger. Someone less stubborn. Someone who'd open the door himself."* His eyes came to Lex. *"I sealed you. Both of you. When you were small. The class-masks. The Smith. The Hollow-touched. I told myself it was to hide you from the Order. And it was. But it was also to hide you from that. From the thing at the bottom of the gold. I thought, if they don't know they're Veys, it can't find them."*

"It found us anyway," said Antho.

"It found you anyway." Arion's voice cracked. *"Through the breach. Through the Hollow. Through Elric. Through the Key."* He bowed his head. *"Everything I did to hide you, it just went round."*



NOBODY SAID ANYTHING FOR a long time.

The lamp burned in its niche. The lanterns burned on the walls. Somewhere far up the passage, Lex could hear the students in the hall, Odile's sharp voice and Teo's laugh.

"Mam's gone," said Antho at last. Very quietly. *"From the door."*

"Yes."

"Where?"

"I don't know." Arion's hands were clenched in his lap. *"The night after the longest night, the flame leaned. Once. And then never again."* His voice was barely a whisper. *"I felt her go. Through the Root. Away from the door."*

Down. Into the deep." He looked up. *"I don't know why. I don't know where. She didn't tell me. She couldn't. The door sealed tighter when the Lockward went in. Too tight for a voice."*

Lex looked at the lamp.

She's been holding that door for eleven years, he thought. And the night it finally holds itself, she walks away from it. Into the dark.

Why?

[Because something needed her more,] said Ember quietly. [That's the only reason anyone in your family ever walks into the dark.]



HE TOLD THEM ABOUT the grey thread.

He hadn't meant to. Not yet. Not today, with his father still raw from confession and Antho sitting so still. But it came out anyway. The way things came out of him. He'd never been able to hold anything in.

The Stone at Fen Hollow. The thread running down. A tenth. From every soul. Into the dark. And at the bottom, very far down, warmth. Gold. Breathing.

He watched his father's face while he told it.

And saw it go white.

"The Tithe," said Arion. Barely audible.

Lex stared at him. *"You know about it?"*

"I've heard the word." His father's voice was strange. *"Once. A long time ago. In a Founder's codex in the Spire's sealed vaults. A single line. In a margin."* He swallowed. *"The tithe for the binding. A tenth of every thread, to keep the lid strong."* He looked at Lex. *"I thought it meant something else. I thought it was a metaphor. I thought—"*

He stopped.

"I thought it was for the binding," said Arion Vey. *"That's what it said. To keep the lid strong."*

"And if it isn't?" said Antho.

Their father didn't answer.

He didn't need to. Lex saw it on his face. The same thing he'd seen on Elric's face at the bottom of the Rift, when the kind voice turned its back and said *you'll be nothing at all.*

The face of a man realizing that something he'd believed his whole life had been a lie.



HE DREAMED THAT NIGHT.

He was sleeping in the hall of the Lantern Keep, on a pallet by the fire, with Wren curled against his back. He'd been tired. He'd been so tired, for months.

And he dreamed of a forge.

Not Ashbourne. Not the Hollowmaw. A great round forge on top of a white mountain, open to the sky. Stars overhead, so close and bright he could almost hear them. An anvil of gold. And a man at the anvil.

Tall. Fair-haired. In a smith's leather apron over a robe of white and gold, with his sleeves rolled up and his forearms scarred. Working a bar of iron. Light and fast and precise. *Tink. Tink. Tink.*

And singing.

Not well. His voice was rough, and he kept losing the tune. An old song. A working song, the kind smiths sang at the anvil to keep the rhythm. Lex knew it. Brannoc sang it. Badly.

The man looked up.

His eyes were gold. Root gold. Lex's gold.

But not like at the Rift. Not bright and warm and loving. These eyes were *tired*. Red-rimmed, as if he hadn't slept in a very long time. Sad. And when they found Lex, standing at the edge of the forge in his dream, they didn't light up.

They *flinched*.

"*Oh,*" said the man at the anvil. "*Oh, no. Not you. Not one of mine.*"



LEX DIDN'T MOVE.

"*You're the one it's been talking to,*" said the man. He'd set the hammer down. His scarred hands were shaking. "*The smith. My blood. I've felt it. Down here. Through the gold. Talking to you in my voice.*" His face twisted. "*Wearing my face.*"

"*Who are you?*" said Lex.

The man laughed. A short, broken sound.

"I'm what's left," he said. "Of Aurelian Vey. Of the man who made the net. Who sang at this anvil, a long time ago, before." He looked down at his hands. "It got into me. Eight hundred years ago. I went down to speak to it. To understand it. I thought—" He stopped. "It doesn't matter what I thought. I was wrong. I was so sure, and so wrong."

So sure, and so wrong. The Hearth had said that. In the Wellworld of Flame.

"It wears me now," said the man. "Like a coat. And I'm—underneath. Buried. In my own tomb. At the Heart. Where the first thread goes down." His gold eyes found Lex's. "It's eating me. A little at a time. For eight hundred years. There's not much left."

"Why are you telling me this?"

The man looked at him for a long time.

"Because you're going to come," he said. "It's going to make you come. It always does. It'll write you a reason. A prophecy, or a promise, or someone you love, in the dark." His voice dropped. "And when you come, it will be waiting."

"Then I won't come."

"You will." Very gently. "You're a Vey. You always come." He picked up the hammer again. Looked at it. "So listen. When you come. When you're standing at the Heart. When it's wearing my face and telling you to let it in."

He looked up.

"Look for the flaw," said the man who had been Aurelian Vey. "Everything that's made has one. Even it. Even me." His tired eyes held Lex's. "It didn't make itself. It made itself out of me. And I was never very careful with my folding."



LEX WOKE.

It was dark. The fire had burned low. Wren was asleep against his back, breathing slow and steady.

And Antho was sitting beside his pallet. On the floor. With his arms around his knees and his grey eyes on Lex's face.

"You were talking," said Antho. "In your sleep."

Lex sat up. Slowly. His heart was hammering.

"*I dreamed,*" he said. "*Of Aurelian. At a forge. On a white mountain.*" He swallowed. "*He said he was what was left. Buried under the thing that wears him. He said it was eating him.*"

Antho didn't say anything.

"*He said I'd come,*" said Lex. "*To his tomb. At the Heart. He said it would make me come. And when I did, I should look for the flaw.*"

[Lex,] said Ember. [*Lex, it's a trick. It has to be. It's the same thing. It's the same face, the same voice, it's the thing at the door—*]

I don't know.

[*It's luring you. That's what it does. It told your father it was lonely and trapped. It told Elric he deserved more. It's telling you it's being eaten so you'll come and—*]

I know, Ember. I know.

He looked at his brother.

"*Was it the same?*" said Antho quietly. "*The voice. Was it the same as at the Rift?*"

Lex thought about it. Honestly. The way Malachi had taught him.

The voice at the Rift had been warm. Gold. Loving. *My boy. My good boy. Come home.* It had wrapped around him like a blanket.

The voice in the dream had been rough. Tired. Breaking. *Oh, no. Not you. Not one of mine.*

"No," he said. "*It wasn't the same.*"

"*What was different?*"

Lex was quiet for a long time.

"*At the Rift,*" he said, "*it never once said it was sorry.*"

Antho looked at him.

"*This one did,*" said Lex. "*He said he was wrong. He said he was so sure and so wrong.*" He swallowed. "*And he couldn't sing. He kept losing the tune.*"

His brother was quiet for a long time. Sitting on the floor by the dying fire, with his arms around his knees.

"*The thing in my head,*" said Antho at last. "*For eleven years. The Murmur. The voice in the trees. It sang to me in Mam's voice.*" He looked at the fire. "*And it never once got the tune wrong.*"

They looked at each other.

[Lex,] said Ember. Very quietly. [That doesn't prove anything.]

No, thought Lex. It doesn't.

But he lay back down on the pallet, beside Wren, and looked at the ceiling. And thought about a tired man at a gold anvil, singing a working song badly, with his hands shaking.

Look for the flaw.

Everything that's made has one.

And far down, at the bottom of the gold, at the bottom of the Root, at the door, something warm turned over in its sleep. And breathed.

And waited.

CHAPTER 24

THE FORGOTTEN CHRONICLES



MALACHI CAME UP THE mountain on foot, with five goats.

Odile saw him first. She'd been on watch at the mouth of the Hollowmaw, sitting on Hedda's old barricade with her knees drawn up and her eyes half closed, listening to the valley. And she'd come down the long passage at a run, which Odile never did, and burst into the library where Lex and Antho and Seraphine were arguing over a map, and said:

"There's an old man coming up the path. With goats. And he's singing. And Master Antho, he hasn't got a thread. He hasn't got anything. When I listen to him, there's just—" She stopped. Frowned. *"There's just this enormous quiet. Like the bottom of a well."*

Antho was already on his feet.



HE WAS HALFWAY UP the switchbacks when they came out of the cave mouth. A tiny brown figure, small and bent and wrinkled as a walnut, barefoot on the cold stone of the path, with a staff of twisted driftwood in one hand and a battered straw hat on his head. Five goats trailed behind him in a ragged line. One of them was Correspondence. The others were strangers, and one of them was eating the hem of his robe as he walked.

He was singing. Loudly. Badly. Something about a miller's daughter and a very large cheese.

He looked up when they came out onto the slope. And his face, brown and creased and ancient, split into a gap-toothed grin.

"*Deep one!*" shouted Malachi, the Last Listener. "*Smith! And the little archivist with the spectacles! And—*" He peered past them. "*Is that a storm-mother on your mountain? Bless me. I thought they were all dead. Oh, she's lovely. Look at her. Look at her wings.*"

Vharuun, sprawled across the slope below the cave in the spring sunshine, lifted her vast head and looked down at the tiny old man on the path. And made a sound. Low and rumbling and deep. Like recognition.

LISTENER, she said. Lex felt it through the rock. *I REMEMBER YOU. YOU WERE SMALL. YOU HAD A BELL.*

Malachi stopped on the path.

The grin went out of his face. Just for a moment. Like a lamp blown out.

Then it came back. Smaller.

"*I did,*" he said. "*I did have a bell.*" He looked up at the storm-mother. "*You've got a long memory, old girl.*"

I AM A THOUSAND YEARS OLD, said Vharuun. *I HAVE A LONG EVERYTHING.*

Malachi laughed. And then he came up the rest of the path, with his goats, and walked straight past Lex, and straight past Seraphine, and stopped in front of Antho.

And put his gnarled brown hand flat on Antho's chest. Over his heart.

He stood there for a long moment. His shifting eyes, which were every color and no color, going still. Going black. The soft black of the sky between the stars.

"*Ninety-nine,*" he said.

Antho stared at him.

"*Clarity,*" said Malachi. "*Ninety-nine. I can hear it. There's barely a whisper left in there.*" His eyes went to Antho's face. "*The thief in the empty house. It's nearly moved out.*"

"*It went quiet,*" said Antho. His voice was rough. "*At the Rift. When I pulled Lex back. It went quiet and it hasn't really come back.*"

"*Because you told it no.*" Malachi's hand stayed on his chest. "*At the bottom of the world. To its face. With your brother's sleeve in your fist.*" He smiled. The gap-toothed grin, but softer. "*That's all it ever needed, deep one. Somebody to say no to its face.*"

And then the old man did something Lex had never seen him do.
He put his arms around Antho. And held on.



"*Why?*" said Lex, later. In the library. With Malachi sitting cross-legged on the table, peeling an apple with a little bone knife, and the goats being chased round the slope outside by Ashka. "*You haven't left the Stillwater in four hundred years. You said so.*"

"*Four hundred and twelve,*" said Malachi. "*Not that anyone counts.*" He held up a long curl of apple peel and examined it. "*Because the fire went out, smith.*"

Lex waited.

"*My fire,*" said Malachi. "*The eternal one. In my hearth. It's been burning nine hundred years. It went out on the longest night. When the lid lifted.*" He bit into the apple. "*I relit it. I told you that, in my letter. It was very upsetting for the goats.*"

"*And?*"

"*And three nights later, it went out again.*" Malachi chewed. Swallowed. "*And I relit it. And the next night. And the next.*" His shifting eyes were very still. "*Every night since the longest night. It goes out at midnight. Every night. Like something's blowing on it.*"

Nobody said anything.

"*It's a watch-fire,*" said Malachi. "*Did you know that? That's what it's for. That's why it's eternal. My sister lit it. Ysmir. The year after the Weaving. She put me in the Stillwater with a fire and said, Malachi, watch the road.*" He set down the apple. "*The road to the Heart. Through the Wastes. Through the white. To the place where the first thread goes down.*"

"*The Heart,*" said Lex. Very quietly.

Malachi looked at him.

"*You've heard that word,*" he said. "*Haven't you. Recently.*"

"*In a dream.*" Lex swallowed. "*From someone who said he was what's left of Aurelian.*"

The old man went very still.



"*Tell me,*" said Malachi. "*Exactly. Every word.*"

Lex told him. The forge on the white mountain. The stars. The man at the gold anvil, singing badly. *Oh, no. Not you. Not one of mine.* The tomb. The Heart. *It's eating me, a little at a time. Look for the flaw. Everything that's made has one. Even it. Even me. I was never very careful with my folding.*

Malachi listened. He didn't interrupt. He sat on the library table with his gnarled hands folded on his knees and his shifting eyes fixed on Lex's face, and didn't move at all.

When Lex finished, the old man was quiet for a long time.

"*He said that,*" said Malachi at last. "*I was never very careful with my folding.*"

"Yes."

Malachi closed his eyes.

"*He used to say that,*" he said. Barely audible. "*When I was small. When something he'd made went wrong. A blade that cracked. A pot that leaked. He'd hold it up and look at it and laugh and say, well, Mal, I was never very careful with my folding.*" His voice cracked. "*Nobody else ever heard him say it. Nobody. It was a thing he said to me.*"

The library was very quiet.

"*Could the other one—*" said Antho. "*The thing that wears him. Could it know that? Could it have taken it from him?*"

"Yes," said Malachi. Without opening his eyes. "*Of course. It's had eight hundred years. It's had every memory he ever had.*" He was silent. "*It could have taken it. It could be using it. To make you trust it.*"

"Then—"

"*But it wouldn't,*" said Malachi. He opened his eyes. They were wet. "*Because it doesn't understand why it matters. It's a hunger. It doesn't care about bells and folding and little brothers. It's never once in eight hundred years used anything like that.*" He looked at Lex. "*It uses the big things. Mothers. Fear. Pride. Being second. It doesn't know the small things are the ones that count.*"



"*I have to tell you something,*" said Malachi. "*All of you. I should have told you in the Stillwater. I didn't. I was a coward.*"

He'd climbed down off the table. He was standing at the window of the library, looking out at the slope where Ashka was still chasing goats, with his back to them. Small and bent and brown in the spring light.

Lex looked at Antho. Antho looked at Seraphine. Seraphine had her notebook open on her knee and her pen poised and had stopped writing.

"*The Tithe*," said Malachi.

Nobody moved.

"*You found it*," he said, without turning. "*At the Stone in that little village. Fen Hollow. I felt you find it. Through the river.*" A pause. "*A grey thread. Running down. A tenth of every soul.*"

"Yes," said Lex.

"*I knew*," said Malachi. "*I've always known.*"



HE TOLD IT STANDING at the window. Not looking at them.

"*There were seven of us*," he said. "*You know that. Aurelian, the eldest. Ysmir. Tarn. Oriane. Haldis. Brannagh. And me, the baby. Mal.*" He was quiet. "*We wove the net together. The Weaving. Nine hundred years ago. To cage the hunger. To stop the sorcerer-kings. To make the world safe.*"

"*I know*," said Lex. "*You told us. In the Stillwater.*"

"*I told you what I wanted you to know.*" Malachi's voice was flat. "*I told you I begged him not to put himself into the net. That I stood beside him on the night of the Weaving and said you can't cage a storm by becoming the bars. That was true.*" He was silent. "*I didn't tell you the rest.*"

"*The Tithe was his idea. The Ceiling was his idea. He brought them to us after the Weaving. A year after. When he'd been down at the root of the net, holding the hunger, for a whole year.*" Malachi's gnarled hands were clenched on the windowsill. "*He came up, and he was different. Tired. Thin. His eyes were wrong. Too bright. And he said: the net isn't strong enough. The hunger's too big. We need two more things. A Ceiling, on every thread, so nobody ever grows strong enough to lift the lid. And a tithe. A tenth of every soul's mana, running down through every Stone, to feed the binding. To keep it strong.*"

"*And you agreed*," said Antho quietly.

"We agreed." Malachi's voice cracked. *"He was Aurelian. He was the eldest, the cleverest, the one who was always right. And we were frightened. The Sundering had nearly ended the world. We'd buried half our friends. We'd do anything."* He was quiet for a long moment. *"So we agreed. All six of us. We put the Ceiling on the world. And we cut the Stones from the bones of the mountains, and ran the Tithe-threads down through every one of them. To the bottom. To him."*



"Ysmir found out," said Malachi. *"A hundred years later. She was the Keeper of What Was. She remembered everything. And she noticed that the binding wasn't getting stronger. Not with all that mana running down into it. Not with a tenth of every soul in the world."* His voice was very low. *"She went down and looked. As far as she could go. And she came back up and found me, and her face was white, and she said: Mal. It's not the binding. It's not going into the binding."*

"It's going into him."

The library was absolutely silent.

"The hunger had him by then," said Malachi. *"All the way. A hundred years at the root of the net, holding it, and it had got into him through the bars the way I'd always said it would. And it was using him. His voice. His face. His place at the root of the net."* He bowed his head. *"The Tithe was never for the binding. It was for the hunger. It had told him to ask for it. And he'd asked. And we'd said yes."*

"Then why didn't you stop it?" said Seraphine. Her voice was shaking. *"If you knew. A hundred years after. Why didn't you cut the threads? Why didn't you—"*

Malachi turned around.

His face was wet. Ancient and brown and creased, and running with tears.

"Because he was still in there," said Malachi. *"My brother. Somewhere. Under it. Holding on."* His voice broke. *"Ysmir felt him. When she went down. Very faint. Very deep. Still Aurelian. Still holding the hunger, even with it inside him. Still trying."* He drew a long shaking breath. *"And the Tithe was the only thing keeping him alive. If we cut it, the hunger would*

have nothing to eat. Nothing but him. It would have eaten him all the way down, in a year, in a month. And then it would have been loose. With nothing holding it. Not even him."

"So you let it feed," said Antho.

"So we let it feed." Malachi looked at him. "A tenth of every soul in the world. For eight hundred years. To keep my brother alive at the bottom of the dark, a little bit, enough to hold on." He was silent. "Ysmir went to her temple and froze herself in the ice to remember everything, because she couldn't bear to live with it. Tarn went beyond the Veil and never came back. Oriane and Haldis and Brannagh grew old and died and took it with them. And I went to the Stillwater, and lit a fire, and watched the road. For eight hundred years."

He looked at all of them. One by one.

"That's my confession," said Malachi, the Last Listener. "I let the world pay for my brother. Every soul. Every day. For eight hundred years. And I'd have kept letting it, forever, if you hadn't found the thread."



NOBODY SAID ANYTHING FOR a very long time.

Lex sat in the library of the Lantern Keep and looked at the old man by the window. Small. Bent. Brown. Crying.

A tenth of every soul. For eight hundred years.

To keep his brother alive.

He thought about Kestrel, giving a bloody rag to a man with a key, for Tamsin. He thought about Ivo, sitting up every night to watch his sister fade. He thought about his mother, turning back across a grey river for a boy at a breach.

He thought about himself. In the Glass Desert. Throwing the Bit across a crater, for Ilse.

You don't trade people for metal, Ember had said. *That's the first thing a smith ever learns.*

But what about people for people?

[I don't know,] said Ember, very quietly. *[I don't think anyone knows. I think that's the question nobody can answer.]*

"Mal," said Antho.

The old man looked at him.

"I'm not going to forgive you," said Antho. Very gently. *"That's not mine to do. It's theirs. Everyone who paid."* He stood up. Crossed the library. Stood in front of the old man by the window. *"But I understand you. I'd hate you less if I didn't."*

Malachi stared up at him.

"That's what Ilse said," said Antho. *"About Kestrel. On the night of the Blade."* He put his scarred hand on the old man's shoulder. *"It's the best any of us can do."*



"There's more," said Malachi.

He'd sat down again, on the library table, cross-legged. Seraphine had made tea. He held the cup in both hands and looked into it.

"The fire going out," he said. *"Every night at midnight."* He looked up. *"It's not something blowing on it. It's something drawing on it. Drawing the heat out. Down. Through the Wastes. Down the road to the Heart."*

"The Tithe," said Lex.

"The Tithe runs both ways now." Malachi's shifting eyes were very dark. *"Since the longest night. Since the lid was barred. He can't come up through the middle anymore. So he's pulling. Harder. Through every thread. Every Stone. Drawing everything he can down to him."* He set the cup down. *"And when he's pulled enough. When the pipes are wide enough."*

"He'll come up through them."

"Yes." Malachi looked at Lex. *"Not him. Not yet. He's too big. Too hurt, from the lid. But things. Pieces. The things he's been keeping at the bottom of the world for eight hundred years."* He was quiet. *"The ones nobody remembers."*

Kell, thought Lex.

He didn't know why. It just came. A faceless woman in torn white robes, wrapped in a tendril of dark, going down through a crack in the lid.

She's mine, the voice had said. *Nobody remembers her.*



THE RAVEN CAME AT dusk.

Not Quill. Not a Keeper's raven. A small black ragged thing, wet and exhausted, that came down out of the darkening sky and crashed into the window of the library and fell, stunned, onto the sill outside.

Seraphine got to it first. She opened the window and lifted it in, very gently, and it lay in her hands panting, with its eyes half closed.

There was a message tied to its leg. A scrap of paper, folded small. Written in pencil, in a child's careful hand, pressed so hard the lead had torn the paper in places.

Seraphine read it. Her face went white.

She handed it to Lex.

Master Lex—

It's Corin Bell. From Harrowgate. You remember. The boy with the sister.

Mella's back. You brought her back. At the end of the winter. She just came home one night and sat down at the table like she'd never been gone and nobody remembered she'd been gone except me. Everyone just said oh, Mella, there you are. Like she'd been at the market.

But something's wrong with her.

She gets up at night. Every night. And walks out to the Stone. In her nightdress. With her eyes open. And stands there. With her hand on it.

And last night the Stone went black.

Not dark. Black. Like a hole. And something came up out of it. Out of the Stone. Grey. Like mist. Like a person made of mist. With no face.

It stood next to Mella. And she wasn't afraid. She took its hand.

And it said her name. In a voice like singing.

I'm frightened, Master Lex. Please come.

—Corin Bell (12)



LEX READ IT TWICE.

Then he handed it to Antho. And Antho read it. And handed it to Malachi.

The old man read it slowly. His lips moving. When he got to the end, he folded it very carefully, along its creases, and set it down on the table.

"*The ones nobody remembers*," he said. Very quietly. "*Except the ones who were unwritten. And came back.*" He looked up. "*They were down there.*"

Smith. All sixty of them. For weeks. For months. Cut out of the net. At the edge of the dark. Where he was."

"Elric wrote them back," said Lex. "At the Rift. All of them."

"He wrote their threads back." Malachi's eyes were very dark. "He couldn't write back where they'd been. What they'd heard. Who'd been singing to them, at the edge of the dark, all that time."

Lex thought about Ilse. Thirty-six percent gone. Pulled. *Like someone very far away, slowly reeling in a line.*

He thought about Hollis Penn. Sitting at his kitchen table in the Lower Town. Eating porridge.

He thought about Mella Bell. Sixteen. Weatherwise. Who sang to the goats. Walking out to the Stone at Harrowgate every night in her nightdress with her eyes open.

A voice like singing.

"The Cantor," said Malachi.

Everyone looked at him.

"I don't know," said the old man. "It's a word. It came to me. Out of the river." He looked at the folded paper. "Something that sings, and that people follow. Something very old. That he's had at the bottom of the world for a very long time."



ANTHO WAS ALREADY STANDING up.

"Harrowgate," he said. "Tonight. Ashka can be there by morning."

"Both of us," said Lex.

"All of us," said Wren, from the doorway. Nobody had heard her come. She had her bow on her back and her boots on, and her face was very set. "I'm not getting left in a library while you two fly off to fight a singing ghost in the middle of the night."

"Not all of us," said Malachi.

They looked at him. The old man was still sitting on the table. Cross-legged. With his cup of tea going cold in his hands.

"Go to the girl," he said. "To Harrowgate. All of you. Go and see what's come up out of the Stone." He looked at the window. At the darkening sky

over the Greyspine. *"But that's one Stone. One girl. One raven, that found its way here."*

"What do you mean?"

Malachi looked at Lex.

"Four thousand Stones in Caldor," he said. "Thousands more in the Sunreach. In the north. In the east." His voice was very quiet. "And sixty people who came back from the edge of the dark." He set down his cup. "How many ravens do you think didn't find their way?"

Lex didn't answer.

[Lex,] said Ember. [Lex. Sixty. Hollis Penn. Bram Sowerby. Amira bint Hassa. Tarek al-Nur. Odo Ferris. Garret Shale.] A pause. [Ilse.]

He turned.

Ivo was standing in the passage behind Wren. Lex hadn't seen him either. His face was perfectly white.

"Ilse," said Ivo Marrow. "She's been getting up at night. For a week. I thought she was just going to the privy."

He swallowed.

"She was gone for an hour last night," he said. "I followed her. She was at the Stone at Hollow's Foot. Down in the valley. In the dark. With her hand on it." His voice cracked. "Humming."

CHAPTER 25

THE PROPHECY OF RETURN



HARROWGATE LOOKED EXACTLY THE way Lex had pictured it, every night since the festival.

A village of grey stone under the Ironbacks. Forty houses. A church. A mill-race running loud with snowmelt. And on the green, a Lattice Stone, leaning a little, with frost on its north face even in spring.

He'd never been here. He'd only seen it in Roole's report and Corin's eyes and the Ledger's narrow elegant hand. *Mella Bell, of Harrowgate. Sixteen. Weatherwise. She sang to the goats.* But he knew it the moment Ashka came down over the ridge in the grey dawn. He knew the green. He knew the Stone. He knew the cottage with the blue shutters at the end of the lane, where a boy of twelve was standing in the doorway in his nightshirt, looking up at the dragon coming down out of the sky.

Corin Bell didn't wave. He didn't run. He stood very still in the doorway with his hands at his sides and his face white.

And when Lex slid down off Ashka's neck on the green and walked up the lane toward him, the boy said, in a voice that cracked:

"*You came.*"

"I came."

"*She's asleep,*" said Corin. "*She's always asleep in the day now. She sleeps all day and walks all night.*" He swallowed. "*Mam doesn't notice. Nobody notices. They just say, Mella's tired, let her rest.*" His eyes were very bright. "*I'm the only one who notices.*"

Lex knelt down in the lane. So their eyes were level.

"You noticed last time too," he said. "When she was taken. You were the only one who remembered her."

"*I know.*" Corin's chin trembled. "*It's horrible. Being the only one.*"

"I know," said Lex. "But it's why she came back."



MELLA BELL WAS ASLEEP in the little room under the eaves. Lex stood in the doorway and looked at her.

Sixteen. Thin. Brown-haired, like her brother. Asleep on her side with her knees drawn up and one hand under her cheek. An ordinary girl. In an ordinary room, with a window looking out at the mountains and a shelf of wooden goats that someone had carved for her, badly.

He looked at her with True Sight.

MELLA BELL

Class: WEATHERWISE (Rare — Unbound)

Level 19

THREAD: WRITTEN (restored)

■ ANOMALY ■

Tithe-link: AMPLIFIED (x7)

Resonance: ■■■■■■■■■■

Amplified. Times seven.

[Lex,] said Ember quietly. [*Her tithe-thread. It's seven times thicker than it should be. It's not taking a tenth. It's taking—*] A pause. [*It's not taking. It's listening. It's a line. Running straight down. Like a string on a tin can.*]

To what?

[*To whatever's singing at the bottom of it.*]

Antho came up behind him on the narrow stair. He looked past Lex at the girl on the bed. He didn't use True Sight. He didn't need to. He stood in the doorway with his grey eyes very dark and *listened*.

"*She's humming,*" he said quietly. "*In her sleep. You can't hear it with your ears.*" He tilted his head. "*It's the same tune. As Ilse. At the Stone at Hollow's Foot.*"



THEY WAITED FOR NIGHT.

There was nothing else to do. Malachi said so, sitting on the bench outside the Bells' cottage with his straw hat over his eyes and a goat chewing his sleeve. *Whatever it is, it comes up at midnight. When the fire goes out. When the pull's strongest. So we wait for midnight.*

Corin's mother made them supper. She was a thin tired kind woman who looked at the dragons sprawled across the village green and the giant storm-mother on the ridge above the church, and the small brown barefoot ancient man with the goats, and the red-haired archer and the two gold-eyed brothers, and said, very calmly, "*Well, I suppose you'll want stew,*" and went inside and made some.

She didn't notice anything wrong with Mella. Lex watched her. When Mella came downstairs at dusk, yawning, in her nightdress, her mother kissed her on the forehead and said, "*There you are, love. You were tired.*" And that was all.

Mella sat at the table. She ate her stew. She smiled at Corin and ruffled his hair. She looked at Lex across the table, at his gold eyes, and went pink, the way girls in villages did when they met the Smith of Ashbourne from the terrible song.

"*You're him,*" she said shyly. "*Aren't you. The one who Unbound me. At the Stone. In the spring.*"

"Yes."

"*I felt it,*" said Mella. "*When you did it. Like a window opening.*" She looked down at her bowl. "*And then I don't remember anything for a while. Months. Corin says I was gone.*" She frowned. "*I don't remember being gone. I just remember—*"

She stopped.

"*What?*" said Lex gently.

"*Singing,*" said Mella Bell. Her eyes had gone vague. Unfocused. "*Someone singing. Very far away. Very beautiful. To all of us.*" She smiled. A slow, dreamy, faraway smile. "*He said he'd come for us. He said he'd sing us home.*"

Across the table, Corin's spoon clattered into his bowl.



AT MIDNIGHT, MELLA GOT up and walked to the Stone.

They were waiting for her. In the dark at the edge of the green. Lex and Antho and Wren and Malachi, and Seraphine with her crossbow, and Kestrel, who'd come on Vharuun's back with Tamsin and hadn't said a word all day. Corin, who'd refused to stay inside, holding Wren's hand so hard his knuckles were white.

The cottage door opened. Mella came out.

In her nightdress. Barefoot. With her eyes open and her face calm and her brown hair loose down her back. She walked down the lane in the moonlight, not hurrying, not stumbling, the way you walk somewhere you've been a hundred times.

She was humming.

Lex heard it. Not with his ears. With the Root. A thread of sound, running out of her, down through the thin grey tithe-line into the ground. And coming *back* up. Answering. From very far down. A voice. A man's voice. Singing.

He couldn't make out the words. He didn't need to. It was the most beautiful sound he had ever heard.

[Lex,] said Ember sharply. [Lex, don't listen to it. Don't listen.]

I'm not—

[You are. You stopped walking. You've got your eyes closed.]

He opened them. He hadn't known they were shut.

Beside him, Wren was swaying. Very slightly. Her bow hanging from her hand. Seraphine's crossbow was pointed at the ground. Corin had let go of Wren's hand and taken a step toward the Stone.

And Malachi was standing very still with his straw hat in his hands, and his shifting eyes gone wide and wet.

"*Oh,*" the old man said softly. "*Oh, that's a voice. I've never heard a voice like that. Not in nine hundred years.*"



ANTHO LIT THE LANTERN.

Lex heard him do it. A small sharp click of the shutter. And then the gold light, spilling out across the dark green. Not wide. A small circle. Around Antho. Around the people closest to him.

Hush. Twelve runes on the glass. Lex had cut them himself, four years ago, in a forge in the mountains. *A rune of silence. For bells that ring too loud, or dogs that bark too much, or voices that won't stop.*

The singing *stopped*.

Not everywhere. Not out in the dark, where Mella was walking. But inside the circle. Inside the gold light. Like a door slamming. Lex felt it cut off, and felt his head clear, and felt Wren jerk upright beside him with a gasp.

"*What—*" she said. "*What was—*"

"*Stay in the light,*" said Antho. His voice was very calm. Very cold. "*All of you. Stay in the light. Corin—*"

The boy was still walking. Out of the circle. Toward the Stone. Toward his sister.

Antho caught him by the sleeve.

Not by the arm. By the sleeve. Between finger and thumb.

Corin stopped. He looked back. His eyes were vague. Unfocused.

"*Not you,*" said Antho Vey. Very gently. "*You're the one who remembers. You stay here with me.*"

And something in the boy's face cleared. Like fog lifting. He looked down at Antho's hand on his sleeve. Then up at Antho's face. And came back into the light.



MELLA REACHED THE STONE.

She laid her hand on it. Flat. On the frosted north face. And the humming coming out of her rose. Higher. Clearer. Joining the voice from below. Harmonizing. A duet. A girl in a nightdress and something very far down, singing together in the dark.

And the Stone went black.

Lex saw it happen. Saw the faint silver glow of the old Lattice Stone go out. Not dim. *Out.* And then saw it go darker than dark. Black. A hole. A shape cut out of the moonlight, Stone-shaped, with nothing inside.

And from the hole, something came up.



GREY. LIKE MIST. LIKE a person made of mist.

It rose out of the black Stone slowly, the way smoke rises out of a chimney on a still night. Unfolding. Taking shape. Tall. Thin. A man's shape, in a long robe that hung to the ground. But no face. Just a smooth grey oval where a face should be.

And a mouth.

Only a mouth. Wide. Open. In the middle of the smooth grey nothing. Singing.

It stood beside Mella Bell at the Stone. And Mella, with her hand still on the black stone, turned her head and looked up at it. And smiled. The dreamy, faraway smile.

And took its hand.

"*Mella,*" sang the grey thing. In a voice like a choir. Like a hundred voices at once, all perfectly in tune. "*Mella Bell. Weatherwise. Who sings to the goats.*"

"*Yes,*" whispered Mella.

"*We've been waiting for you,*" sang the grey thing. "*All of us. All the ones who went down to the edge of the dark and heard the singing. We remember you. Even if no one up here does.*"

"*My brother remembers,*" said Mella. Very faintly.

The grey thing's mouth paused.

"*Your brother,*" it sang, "*is very small. And very far away. And the singing is so much louder.*"



LEX MOVED.

He walked out of the Lantern's light. Into the dark. Toward the Stone.

The singing hit him like a wave. He staggered. Felt it go through him. Into his chest. Into the Root. Down through the gold, toward the door. And at the door, something *answered*. Warm. Gold. Humming along.

Oh, said the warmth at the bottom of him. Fondly. *Oh, my Cantor. Isn't he lovely?*

He set his teeth.

Not tonight, he thought at it. *Not tonight. Not ever.*

He kept walking.

The grey thing turned its faceless head toward him. Its wide singing mouth turned toward him. And the song changed.

"Heir," it sang. *"Heir of the Root. Blood of the one who wove the net. You've come."*

"Let her go."

"She came to me." The mouth smiled. Wide. Too wide. *"She's always come to me. Every night. Since the spring. She hears me in her sleep. They all do. All sixty."* The song swelled. *"They were at the edge of the dark, heir. For weeks. For months. And I sang to them. And they listened. They'll always listen now. It's in their threads. A string, running down to me."*

"Let her go."

"I can't," sang the grey thing. Almost sadly. *"I'm only the voice. The herald. The first note."* It lifted Mella's hand in its own grey one. *"I've come to sing you a song, heir. From my master. A song for you. A prophecy."*

And it sang.



IT WASN'T LOUD. THAT was the strange thing. Lex had expected it to be loud. It was soft. Gentle. A lullaby. And it went out from the black Stone in every direction, through the dark, through the ground, through the tithe-threads, the way the Lattice went out from a Stone. Through every thread.

He felt it go. Felt it go *everywhere*.

When the Key is barred and the night is done, the Root lies bound where the threads begun. The heir must come to the Heart alone and break the chain on the buried bone, or every Stone in the world shall sing, and every thread to the Hollow bring, and the bright ones first, and the young ones last, till the song is sung and the world is passed.



SILENCE.

The grey thing stood beside the black Stone with Mella's hand in its own. Its singing mouth closed. Waiting.

And far away, through the Root, through the net, through every thread in Caldor, Lex felt it.

Humming.

Not just Mella. Not just Ilse at the Stone at Hollow's Foot. Everywhere. Sixty threads. All over the world. All the Unnamed who had come back. Humming the same song at the same moment, in their sleep, in their beds, walking out of their houses in the dark toward their village Stones.

Hollis Penn in the Lower Town of Highcrest. Bram Sowerby on the White Shore. Amira bint Hassa in Qarn, at the edge of the glass. Tarek al-Nur. Odo Ferris. Garret Shale, in Thornby, getting up from his mother's kitchen table and walking out the door.

All of them.

And around them, through the Stones, through the tithe-threads, very faint, very far, something else. Other threads. Ordinary threads. People who had never been unwritten. People who had never been anywhere near the edge of the dark. Hearing it. Just a little. Just a whisper. Stirring in their sleep.

Every Stone in the world shall sing.

[Lex,] said Ember. Its voice was shaking. *[Lex, it's spreading. Through the tithe-threads. Every Stone's got one. Every soul's connected. It's using the Tithe like a—like a—]*

Like a choir.

[Like a choir.]



"Come to the Heart, heir," sang the grey thing softly. "Alone. And break the chain. And my master will be free, and the Root will be whole, and the singing will stop." Its mouth smiled. "Or don't. And I'll keep singing. Every night. Louder. Through every Stone in the world." It looked down at Mella, smiling dreamily at its side. "And they'll come to me. The bright ones first. The ones you Unbound. They shine so loudly."

"And the young ones last," said Lex.

"And the young ones last." The mouth widened. "Children are so hard to sing to. They don't listen properly. They're always thinking about something else."

Behind Lex, in the circle of gold light, Corin Bell made a small sound.

"Choose, heir," sang the herald of the Cantor. "The Heart. Or the world."



AND LEX DID THE only thing he could think of.

He put his hand on the Stone. On the black hole where the Stone had been. Beside Mella's.

And reached for the Tithe-thread with the Root.

It was there. Running down. Thick. Grey. Humming. Seven times thicker than the others, where Mella's thread joined it. A string on a tin can, running down to something singing at the bottom of the world.

He took hold of it.

And *pulled*.



THE WHOLE WORLD SCREAMED.

He felt it. Through the Root. Through every thread in the net. A great tearing shudder, like a sheet being ripped in half. Not from Harrowgate. From *everywhere*. Every Stone in Caldor. Every thread. Every soul. Jerking. Like a fish on a line. Like a puppet with its string pulled.

And Mella Bell screamed. Her hand tore free of the grey thing's. She fell to her knees on the frosty grass, clutching her chest.

And in the cottages around the green, in the dark, Lex heard others. Corin's mother. The miller. The priest. Every soul in Harrowgate. Crying out in their sleep. Waking. Clutching their chests.

[STOP.] shouted Ember. *[LEX. STOP. You're pulling on everyone. The Tithe's in every thread. Every single one. You can't pull one without pulling all of them.]*

He let go.

The scream stopped. The shudder stopped. Mella lay on the frosty grass, gasping. The grey thing stood over her. Watching.

And laughing. Softly. A choir of a hundred voices, laughing.

"*You can't cut it, heir,*" sang the herald. "*Not one. Not here. Not without cutting everything.*" Its mouth was very wide. "*The Tithe is in every thread in the world. It's woven in. It's part of the net. You'd have to unmake the whole net to cut it.*"

It leaned down. Close. Its smooth grey faceless head inches from Lex's.

"*And only one person ever knew how to make the net,*" it sang softly. "*And he's buried at the Heart.*"



ANTHO CAME OUT OF the dark.

He walked straight across the green, out of his own circle of gold light, with the Lantern held high in front of him. Its shutter wide open. Twelve Hush-runes blazing white on its glass.

He walked straight up to the grey thing.

And held the Lantern up in front of its singing mouth.

"Be quiet," said Antho Vey.

And the herald of the Cantor *stopped*.

Not silenced. *Stopped*. As if someone had put a hand over its mouth. Its wide grey lips froze, half-open. Its grey body went rigid. The singing that had been going out from the black Stone through every thread in the world simply—ceased. Like a bell with a cloth over it.

"I had a voice in my head for eleven years," said Antho quietly. *"Telling me things. Singing to me in my mother's voice."* He held the Lantern steady. *"My brother made this. For me. So that voices couldn't act through me while it was lit."* He tilted his head. *"It works on other people's voices too. It turns out."*

The grey thing's frozen mouth trembled.

"Go back down," said Antho. *"Tell your master we heard his song."* He leaned closer. *"Tell him he got the tune wrong."*

And he closed the Lantern's shutter. Sharp. *Click*.

The herald of the Cantor went down. Into the black Stone. Fast. Like smoke sucked down a chimney. Gone.

And the Stone at Harrowgate went from black to grey, and from grey to silver. And was a Stone again.



MELLA WAS CRYING.

Lex knelt beside her on the frosty grass. She was curled up with her arms around her knees, shaking, sobbing. Awake. Properly awake. For the first time since the spring.

"I was there," she was saying. *"I was there. At the edge. In the dark. There were so many of us. And he was singing."* She clutched at Lex's sleeve. *"He sang every night. He said we were his. He said we'd always be his."*

"*You're not his,*" said a voice.

Corin Bell. Standing over his sister in his nightshirt. Shaking. Fierce.

"*You're not his,*" said Corin again. "*You're mine. You're my sister. You sing to the goats, and you're terrible at it, and they don't even like it.*" His voice cracked. "*And you burned the porridge last week and blamed me. You're mine.**"

Mella looked up at him.

And then she reached up and pulled her little brother down into her arms, and held on, and wept into his hair.

Lex looked at her with True Sight.

MELLA BELL

THREAD: WRITTEN

Tithe-link: AMPLIFIED (x7)

Resonance: SUPPRESSED (Hush)

Anchor: KIN (Corin Bell)

███ Link persists. ███

Link persists.

[It's still there,] said Ember quietly. *[The string. Running down. Antho shut the song up. He didn't cut the string.]*

Nobody can cut the string, thought Lex. *Not without cutting everything.*



THEY SAT IN THE Bells' kitchen until dawn.

Nobody slept. Corin's mother, who had woken at midnight clutching her chest with every other soul in Harrowgate, sat at the head of the table with a cup of tea going cold in her hands and her face very still, and listened to Seraphine explain, gently, what had happened to her daughter in the spring. She didn't say anything. But when Mella came down the stairs at dawn, wrapped in a blanket, with Corin holding her hand, her mother got up and put her arms around her and held on for a very long time.

"*I didn't notice,*" she whispered. Into Mella's hair. "*I didn't notice you were gone. Corin kept telling me. And I didn't notice.*"

"*It wasn't your fault, Mam.*"

"*I'm your mother.*" She was crying. "*I'm supposed to notice.*"

Lex looked away.

He thought about a woman in the dark, on the far side of a door, singing to a boy who said good evening to a lamp. Who noticed. Every night. For eleven years.

Where are you, Mam?



"*The Heart*," said Malachi. "*He wants you at the Heart.*"

They were in the yard, at dawn. The old man was sitting on the chopping-block with his straw hat in his lap and his goats grazing on the Bells' cabbages. He looked very old. Older than Lex had ever seen him.

"*It's a lure*," said Antho. "*Obviously.*"

"*Of course it's a lure.*" Malachi turned his hat round and round in his gnarled hands. "*He wants the heir at the Heart. At his tomb. Where the first thread goes down. Where the Root starts.*" He looked up at Lex. "*Where the door at the bottom of your gold opens onto. Right onto him.*"

"*Then I don't go.*"

"*Then every Stone in the world sings.*" Malachi's voice was very quiet. "*Every night. Louder. Through the Tithe. And the bright ones go first. The Unbound. The ones you freed.*" He looked at the cottage. "*Starting with the sixty. Then the four hundred thousand. Then everyone.*"

Lex didn't answer.

"*And the young ones last,*" said Wren. Her voice was flat. She was standing by the gate with her arms folded, looking at the Stone on the green. "*That's what it said. Children are hard to sing to. They don't listen properly.*" She was quiet. "*It'll take the whole world, Hammer. And leave the children till last. Alone. In the dark.*"

Nobody said anything.

"*The Lantern stopped it,*" said Seraphine. "*Antho's Lantern. One Stone. One herald.*" She looked at Antho. "*Could you do it again? Everywhere?*"

"*With one Lantern?*" Antho shook his head. "*Four thousand Stones in Caldor. I can hold one.*"

"*Then we make more,*" said Lex.

Everyone looked at him.

"*Hush-runes,*" he said. "*Lanterns. Bells. Anything. I can make them. Hedda can paint the runes. Brannoc. Tilda. All forty students at the forge.*"

His voice was getting faster. *"One for every village. Every Stone. Hang them on the Stones. Like the lanterns at the Hollowmaw. Keep the song quiet."*

"Four thousand," said Seraphine slowly.

"Four thousand," said Lex. *"In Caldor. More in the Sunreach."* He looked at Malachi. *"How long? Before the singing gets too loud?"*

The old man looked at him for a long moment.

"I don't know," he said. *"Weeks. A month. It's only the herald so far. The first note."* His shifting eyes were very dark. *"When the Choir comes up properly. All of them. The Cantor himself. And the others he's been keeping."* He shook his head. *"No Lantern will stop that."*

"The others?" said Antho.

"Four," said Malachi. *"I can feel them. Through the river. Through the tithe. Four of them. Coming up."* He closed his eyes. *"A voice. A rot. Two-in-one. And a—"* He stopped. Frowned. *"And something with no name."*



LEX STOOD IN THE yard of the Bells' cottage at dawn and looked at the Stone on the green.

Silver again. Faint. Ordinary. With frost on its north face. And running down from it, into the ground, a thin grey thread that he could feel now every time he looked. Thicker than it should be. Humming. Very faintly.

Come to the Heart, heir. Alone.

[You can't,] said Ember. *[Lex. You can't. It's a trap. It's at the bottom of the Root, where the door is. It wants you to walk right through it.]*

I know.

[Then don't.]

And let every Stone in the world sing?

Ember didn't answer.

Make the lanterns, he thought. *Buy time. As much as we can. And find another way. A way to cut the Tithe without cutting everyone.*

A way to unmake the net.

[Only one person ever knew how to make the net,] said Ember quietly. *[That's what it said.]*

And he's buried at the Heart.

He looked at Malachi. Sitting on the chopping-block with his hat in his hands. The youngest of seven. Who had stood beside his brother on the night of the Weaving and said *you can't cage a storm by becoming the bars.*

Not the only one, thought Lex.

"*Mal,*" he said.

The old man looked up.

"*You were there,*" said Lex. "*At the Weaving. You watched him make it.*"

He swallowed. "*Do you know how he did it?*"

Malachi stared at him for a very long time.

"*Smith,*" he said at last. Very softly. "*I've been waiting nine hundred years for someone to ask me that.*"

CHAPTER 26

THE AWAKENING DARKNESS



THE ASHBOURNE FORGE HAD twenty anvils, and for nineteen days not one of them stopped ringing.

Lex had never seen anything like it. Not at Duskhold. Not at the Hollowmaw, the night they forged the Lockward. Forty students at twenty anvils, in shifts, day and night. Brannoc at the great hearth with his arm out of its sling at last, bellowing orders like a sea captain in a gale. Hedda at a long trestle table down the middle of the hall with a dozen pots of glowing paint and a dozen brushes and three apprentices she'd stolen from the Millbridge chandlers, painting runes. *Hush. Hush. Hush.* Twelve to a lantern. Over and over.

And the lanterns. Everywhere. Hanging from every rafter. Stacked on every bench. Packed in straw in crates by the door, waiting for carts. Tin lanterns and iron lanterns and brass ones, little clay lamps like Seren's, bells of copper and bronze with the runes cut into their rims.

Four thousand Stones in Caldor.

They'd made eleven hundred.



"It's not enough," said Tilda Crane.

She said it at the anvil next to Lex's, on the nineteenth night, with sweat running down her freckled face and her apron scorched black and her arms trembling. She'd been working for nineteen hours. Everyone had. She didn't stop hammering when she said it. *Tink. Tink. Tink.*

"We're not going to make it," she said. *"Are we."*

"No," said Lex.

She looked up at him. Then back down at the lantern-frame on her anvil.

"Then why are we doing it?"

He didn't answer for a while. He kept hammering. The frame on his own anvil was a lantern for Harrowgate. The third. The first two had cracked in the night when the song got loud. He'd made this one heavier. Twenty runes instead of twelve.

"Because every one we make," he said at last, "is one village that sleeps through the night."

Tilda thought about that. *Tink. Tink. Tink.*

"Eleven hundred villages," she said.

"Eleven hundred villages."

"That's a lot of people sleeping."

"Yes."

She nodded. Slowly. And kept hammering.



THE SONG WAS GETTING louder.

Lex felt it every night. Through the Root. Through every thread. At midnight, when Malachi's fire went out, three hundred miles away in the Stillwater. A whisper. Coming up through the tithe-threads in every Stone in the world. Soft. Beautiful. A man's voice, singing.

The Hush-lanterns helped. Where they hung on the Stones, the song went quiet. Lex could feel it: villages going still in the net, one by one, as the carts rolled out of Ashbourne and the lanterns went up. Queen Lysandra had commandeered every cart in Caldor. Roole's Keepers were riding them, day and night, from village to village. Fenn had ridden four hundred miles in a week.

But where there were no lanterns, the song got through.

And people got up in the night. And walked out to their Stones. And stood there, with their hands on the cold silver, humming.

Not just the sixty. Not anymore. The sixty walked every night now, every one of them, wherever they were. But others had started. People

who'd never been unwritten. Never been anywhere near the dark. Unbound people, mostly. Bright ones. The song found them first.

The bright ones first.



MALACHI TALKED TO HIM while he worked.

The old man sat on an upturned bucket beside Lex's anvil, out of the way of the sparks, with his straw hat pushed back on his head and an apple in his hand. He'd sat there every day for nineteen days. He talked while Lex hammered. And Lex listened. With half his mind on the iron and the other half on the old man's voice.

He was talking about the Weaving.

"It wasn't weaving," said Malachi. "That's the first thing. Everyone calls it the Weaving. The Lattice. The net. As if he sat at a loom." He bit into his apple. "He didn't. He forged it."

Tink. Lex paused. "Forged?"

"Like mail." Malachi held up his gnarled hand, fingers spread. "Ring by ring. Link by link. Every thread in the world is a ring, smith. A little ring of the river, bent round and closed. And every ring is linked through four others. And the whole thing hangs from the first knot, down at the bottom of the Rift, where you set your bar."

Lex had stopped hammering altogether.

"On an anvil the size of a mountain," said Malachi. "The Old Man of the Ironbacks. That's what it was, before. His anvil. With the river running hot through the Wells for his forge-fire. And his own Root for the hammer." He was quiet. "It took him a year. A year without sleeping. I brought him soup."

"And the Ceiling?"

"Came after." Malachi's face darkened. "A year after. When the hunger had him. He went back to the anvil and struck every ring again. A second time. Tighter. With a little crimp in it." He made a pinching motion with his fingers. "A Ceiling. And through every crimp, a little hole. For the Tithe to run through."

Lex looked at his own hands. At the lantern-frame on the anvil.

"So to unmake it," he said slowly. "To take out the Ceiling. And the Tithe."

"You'd have to strike every ring again." Malachi looked at him. "Every one. Every thread in the world. Uncrimp it. Close the hole. And link it back through, clean."

"Millions of them."

"Millions of them." The old man nodded. "And you'd have to do it from where he did it. With the Root as your hammer. At the place where all the threads come together."

"The first knot."

"No." Malachi's voice was very quiet. "The first knot's where the net hangs from. Where it's tied off. You've been there. You've seen it." He set down his apple. "The place where the threads start. Where the hammer struck. Where the river comes up into the Wells. The Heart."

Lex stood very still at his anvil.

"Every road goes to the Heart, smith," said Malachi, the Last Listener. "That's why he chose it. That's why he's buried there. That's why the song says come." His shifting eyes were very sad. "He knows. He's always known. If you ever want to break his net, you'll have to stand exactly where he stood when he made it. With your hammer in your hand."

"Right on top of him."

"Right on top of him."



[It's a trap,] said Ember. That night. In the loft above the forge, where Lex had been sleeping for nineteen nights, in the gaps between shifts. [It's a trap all the way down. He wants you at the Heart. And the only way to break the net is to go to the Heart. And he knows that.]

I know.

[He wrote the song so that whichever you choose, you end up there. Save the world from the singing, go to the Heart. Break the net and end the Tithe, go to the Heart.] A pause. [There's no choice. There was never a choice. He's built a road with no turnings.]

Lex lay on his back on the straw pallet and looked at the rafters. Below him, through the gaps in the floorboards, he could see the glow of the great

hearth. Hear the hammers. *Tink. Tink. Tink.* The night shift. Tilda and the Millbridge boys.

Everything that's made has a flaw, he thought. Even a road.

[What?]

The man in the dream. At the gold anvil. He said, look for the flaw. Even it. Even me. He closed his eyes. He made the net. And the thing wearing him made the Ceiling and the Tithe. But it made them out of him. Out of his rings. His folding.

[And he was never very careful with his folding,] said Ember slowly.

Then there's a flaw. Somewhere. In the Ceiling. In the Tithe. In the road.

[And if there isn't?]

Lex didn't answer.



IT CAME ON THE twentieth night.

He was at the anvil. The Harrowgate lantern, the third, with twenty runes. He'd just quenched it. It sang in the slack tub, a high clear note, and he lifted it out and held it up to the forge-light, and it was good. The best he'd made.

And every Hush-lantern in the Ashbourne Forge cracked.

All of them. At once. Eleven hundred lanterns waiting in their crates. The ones hanging from the rafters. The ones on the benches. A sound like a thousand panes of glass shattering at the same moment. The runes on every one of them flaring white, and then going dark, and the glass splitting from top to bottom.

The hall went silent.

Tilda had dropped her hammer. Brannoc had turned from the great hearth with his mouth open. Hedda was standing at her trestle table with a brush in her hand and paint dripping onto the floor, staring at the lanterns.

And through the Root, through every thread in the net, Lex felt it.

Not a whisper. Not a song through the tithe-threads.

A voice. Coming up.



[Lex,] said Ember. [Lex, the Stones. Every Stone. It's—]

He felt it. Felt the tithe-threads, all over Caldor, all over the world, go *taut*. Like the strings of a harp when someone puts their hand on them. And then *pulled*. From below. Hard. All at once.

And something came up them.

Not the herald. Not the grey thing with the singing mouth. Something *bigger*. Coming up through every tithe-thread in the world at once, like water coming up a thousand pipes. Filling them. Stretching them. And at the top of four of them, in four places, *breaking through*.

He felt where.

Highcrest. The Great Stone. In the square at the foot of the Spire.

The Vale. Millbridge. The Stone on the green, twenty miles from Ashbourne.

The valley below the Hollowmaw. The Stone at Hollow's Foot.

And the fourth—

The fourth was strange. Not a Stone. He felt it come up the tithe-threads and then *veer*. Sideways. Away from the Stones. Toward something else. Something old. Something that wasn't a Stone but had been a breach, once, the oldest crack in the world, held shut for eleven years by a woman with her back against it.

The door.



"*Malachi*," said Lex. His voice came out strange.

The old man was already standing. He'd dropped his apple. His shifting eyes had gone black, all the way, and he was staring at nothing.

"*Four*," he said. "*All four. They've come up.*" He turned to Lex. "*The Cantor. In the city.*"

"*Highcrest.*"

"*The rot. In the Vale. Close. Very close.*" Malachi's face was grey. "*The two-in-one. At your brother's mountain.*"

"*And the fourth?*"

Malachi was silent.

"*The one with no name*," he said at last. "*She's at the door. Your mother's door. On the other side.*" He swallowed. "*With her hand on the glass.*"



LEX WAS ON ASHKA in four minutes.

He didn't remember getting there. He remembered running out of the forge into the night. He remembered Ashka, who'd been sleeping on the village green beside Vharuun, already awake, already rising, lightning crawling along her flanks. He remembered Wren, coming down out of the dark sky above the forge where she'd been on watch, stepping onto Ashka's back behind him without a word.

He remembered looking back.

At the forge. At Tilda Crane, standing in the doorway with her hammer in her hand and the light of the great hearth behind her. At Brannoc and Hedda. At Malachi, small and brown and barefoot, on the green.

"The rot," Malachi had said. *"In the Vale. Close."*

"Go," shouted Brannoc. *"Lad, go. Your brother. We'll hold here."*

"Brannoc, it's the Vale, it's twenty miles—"

"I know where the Vale is, lad. I've lived in it sixty-one years." The old smith hefted his hammer. *"Go."*

He went.



THEY FLEW NORTH THROUGH the dark.

Faster than Ashka had ever flown. Lightning pouring off her. The air screaming past. Wren's arms around his waist. Below them, the dark land of Caldor, rushing past. And every few miles, a village. A Stone.

Lex could feel them. Every one.

Some were quiet. Hush-lanterns, hanging on them, the ones that had already gone out on the carts, cracked now, shattered like the ones in the forge. But the Stones were quiet anyway. Holding. For now.

Some were not.

He felt them. Villages where the song was coming up loud through the tithe-thread. Where people were walking out of their houses in the dark. Dozens. Hundreds. Gathering around their Stones. Hands on the silver. Humming.

And at the bottom of every tithe-thread, very far down, the voice. Singing. Beautiful. Getting louder.

The bright ones first.



ANTHO WAS AT THE Stone at Hollow's Foot when they came down out of the sky.

Lex saw him from the air. A small dark figure in the valley below the Hollowmaw, standing in front of the Stone with the Keeper's Lantern held high. Its shutter wide open. Its gold light pouring out across the dark valley. Twelve Hush-runes blazing white.

And in front of him, facing him across the Stone, the Twinned Knight.



IT WAS ENORMOUS.

Taller than Dorrان had been. Taller than anyone. A suit of armor, black and silver, old-fashioned, the kind knights had worn in the ballads Brannoc used to sing. A great helm with a narrow slit. A long cloak, torn and rotted. And *wrong*.

Doubled.

Lex saw it as Ashka came down. Two shapes. In one suit of armor. Overlapping. Like a drawing someone had traced twice, slightly off. Four arms. Two of them holding swords, long and black. Two of them holding shields. Two heads, inside the one helm; he could see them moving, through the slit, turning slightly different ways. And two voices. Coming out of the helm. Arguing.

"Left," said one.

"No. Right," said the other.

"Left, brother. The small one's on the left."

"The small one's behind the light."

Behind the light. Behind Antho. On the ground, beside the Stone.

Ilse and Ivo.



ILSE WAS ON HER knees. Her eyes were closed. Her hand was flat on the Stone. She was humming. The song. The beautiful song.

And Ivo was holding her. His arms around her from behind. His face pressed into her hair. Holding on. And *weaving*. Lex could see it. An

illusion, flickering around the two of them. A wall. A door. A cage. Anything. To keep her from going down the tithe-thread after the song.

"She came down here an hour ago," said Antho. He didn't turn his head. His voice was very calm. *"Sleepwalking. Ivo followed her. He couldn't wake her. He sent Pim up to get me."* The Lantern trembled in his hand. *"And then that came up out of the Stone."*

The Twinned Knight's helm turned toward Lex. Both heads. Two pairs of eyes, glinting through the narrow slit.

"Another one," said one voice.

"The heir," said the other.

"Not ours. The heir's not ours."

"No. Ours are the two by the Stone." The helm turned back. Toward Ilse and Ivo. *"Two who won't let go."*

"Like us," said the first voice.

"Like us," the second agreed.



"What do you want with them?" said Lex.

He'd slid down off Ashka. He was walking across the dark grass toward the Stone. Fire in his hands. Wren was up on the wind above him, her bow drawn, an arrow burning gold on the string.

The Twinned Knight looked at him.

"We were brothers," said one voice. Slowly. Almost dreamily. *"Long ago. Knights of the Ford. We held a river crossing. Against an army. Back to back."*

"For a day and a night," said the other.

"And the river rose."

"And we wouldn't let go." A pause. *"Of each other. Of the ford. We held on."*

"And we drowned," said the first voice. *"Together. Holding on."* The helm tilted. *"And we went down. Into the dark. Still holding on. And the dark said, you'll never have to let go now. And it poured us into one."*

"One armor," said the second voice.

"One sword-arm."

"One." Both voices together. *"Forever."*

The helm turned toward the twins on the ground. Ivo, holding Ilse. Holding on.

"They're like us," said the Twinned Knight. Both voices. Almost tenderly. *"Two who won't let go. Our master says we can have them. To keep us company."*

And it moved.



IT WAS FAST. FAR faster than anything that big should be. Four arms. Two swords. Two shields. It came at Antho like a landslide, and Antho didn't move. He stood in front of the Stone with the Lantern held high, and the gold light hit the Twinned Knight's black armor, and the armor *smoked*.

But it didn't stop.

Voices can't act through him while it's lit. That was what the Lantern did. It stopped the song. It stopped the Murmur. It stopped the herald.

But the Twinned Knight wasn't a voice. It was a sword.

Lex was there. He didn't know how. He was between Antho and the swords with his own hands up, fire roaring off them, Flame at Commanding, everything he had. The black swords hit the fire and the fire *held*. Just. Gold and white and furious, a wall of it, and the swords grinding against it like iron on a whetstone.

Wren's arrow hit the helm. Burning gold. Right in the slit. The Knight jerked back. One head screamed. The other laughed.

"The archer," said the laughing voice. *"Brother, she's good."*

"She's in the way," said the screaming one.

And one of the four arms swept up and *threw* a shield. At Wren. In the air. Spinning, black and enormous, like a millstone.

She stepped. Sideways. On the wind. The shield went past her by a hand's width and vanished into the dark.

"She's very good," said the laughing voice.



IT WAS A FEINT.

Lex understood that too late. The shield, the swords, all of it. Something to look at. While the Knight's other two arms, the ones nobody

was watching, reached past Antho. Past the Lantern. Past Lex's fire. Down. To the twins on the ground.

To Ivo.

They closed on him. Black gauntlets. On his shoulders. And *lifted*.

Ivo screamed. Not in pain. In *terror*. Because his arms were coming away from Ilse. Because the Knight was pulling him off her. And she was still humming, still on her knees with her hand on the Stone and her eyes closed, still going down the tithe-thread after the song.

And he couldn't hold on.

"*ILSE—*"

She opened her eyes.



LEX SAW IT. SAW her eyes snap open. Grey. Clear. *Awake*. Saw her look up and see her brother. Lifted off the ground. In the Twinned Knight's black hands. Being carried backward, toward the Stone, toward the black hole that was opening in it.

"*Ivo—*"

She lunged. She got his hand. His wrist. Both her hands, wrapped around his wrist. Holding on.

And for one moment, the Twinned Knight was pulling one twin, and the other twin was pulling back, and neither of them would let go.

"*Oh,*" said the laughing voice. Softly. "*Oh, brother, look. Look at them.*"

"*They won't let go,*" said the other. Wonderingly.

"*They're just like us.*"

And the Knight *pulled*.



ILSE HELD ON.

She held on with everything she had. Lex saw her face. White. Furious. Teeth bared. Her heels dug into the frozen grass. Her hands locked around her brother's wrist.

It wasn't enough.

The Knight was too strong. Two dead knights in one armor. It pulled, and Ilse came forward across the grass on her heels, and the black hole in the Stone opened wider.

"*Let go,*" said Ivo.

She stared at him.

"*Ilse. Let go.*" He was crying. "*You'll go too. It'll take both of us. Let go.*"

"*No.*"

"*Ilse—*"

"*NO. I'm not letting go. You never let go. You sat up with me every night for six weeks. You held on when I was thirty-six percent gone. You—*"

"*Please,*" said Ivo Marrow. "*Please. One of us has to stay.*"

And he did something Lex would never forget.

He *wove*.

An illusion. Small. Simple. The simplest one he knew. Over his own wrist. Where her hands were holding.

He made it look like nothing. Like empty air. The Lampshade. The old trick. *You make it look like the room's dark.*

And for one heartbeat, Ilse's hands believed it. Believed there was nothing there to hold.

And opened.



THE TWINNED KNIGHT WENT down into the Stone with Ivo in its arms.

Fast. Like smoke sucked down a chimney. The black hole in the silver closing behind it. And Ivo's face, the last thing Lex saw, white and wet and looking back at his sister. Not afraid. *Sorry.*

And then the Stone was silver again. And the valley was dark. And Ilse Marrow was on her knees on the frozen grass, with her hands open in front of her. Empty.

She didn't scream.

She looked at her hands. At the place where her brother's wrist had been.

And then she put her face down on the cold grass at the foot of the Stone, and her whole body shook, and she didn't make any sound at all.



FROM THE HOLLOWMAW, HIGH on the mountain above them, Lex heard a sound.

Faint. A long way up. Through the rock. Through a mile of passage and a thousand lanterns.

A sound he'd heard once before. On the night of the Blade.

A door. Bulging.

"*Father*," said Antho.

He was already turning. Already running. Up the slope. Toward the cave. With the Lantern swinging in his hand.

Lex went after him.



THE BELL-SHAPED CAVERN AT the bottom of the Hollowmaw was full of gold light.

All the lanterns, burning. One thousand one hundred and eleven. The black glass door at the bottom of the bell. Cracked across its face, the way it had been since the night of the Blade. Holding.

Arion was in front of it. On his knees. With both hands flat on the glass.

And on the other side—

Lex saw it. Through the glass. Faint. A shape. Pressed against the black from the other side. A hand. Long-fingered. Pale. Flat against the glass, palm to palm with Arion's.

And the lamp was leaning.

Toward the door. A finger's width. The way it had leaned every night for three years, when Seren came.

"*Seren*," Arion was saying. Over and over. His face pressed against the glass. Wet. "*Seren. Seren. You came back. You came back.*"

Antho stopped dead at the bottom of the passage.

"*Father*," he said. Very quietly. "*Father, that's not her.*"

Arion didn't hear him.

"*Father.*" Antho's voice was steady. Cold. "*Look at the hand.*"

Lex looked.

A woman's hand. Pressed flat against the glass. Long-fingered. Pale.

And grey.

Faint. Blurred at the edges. Like a drawing someone had started to rub out. Like the thinned in the grey valley. Like the man with the rubbed-out face.

Like Isaura Kell, sitting on the stair at the bottom of the Rift, forty-one percent gone.

And behind it, through the glass, a face.

Not a face. A place where a face should be. Pale. Smooth. *Unremembered*. Lex's eyes slid off it. He looked, and couldn't hold it, the way you can't hold a word that's on the tip of your tongue.

And a voice.

Not Seren's. Not low and rough. Dry. Thin. Precise. A voice that had given orders for twenty years.

"Lex Vey," said the faceless woman on the other side of the door. *"I've been sent to keep the door. From this side."* A pause. *"He says it's mine now."*

The lamp leaned further. Toward her.

"He says your mother isn't coming back," said the Unnamed Warden.

And her grey hand on the glass *pushed*.

CHAPTER 27

ALLIES AND ADVERSARIES



THE FACELESS WOMAN PUSHED, and the door groaned.

Lex felt it. Through the Root. Through the black glass. A pressure. Not like the night of the Blade, when the whole Hollow had leaned on it. Smaller. Narrower. One hand. One will. But *cold*. Precise. A pressure that knew exactly where the door was weakest, the way a High Warden had once known exactly where every Ceiling in Caldor was set.

The crack across the glass widened. A hair. A hair more.

And Arion didn't move.

He was still on his knees in front of the door with his hands flat on the glass and his face pressed against it. Palm to palm with the grey hand on the other side. His lips moving.

"*Seren*," he was whispering. "*Seren*."

"*Father*." Antho was beside him. The Lantern in his hand. "*Father, get up. It's not her. It's not her. Look at me.*"

Arion didn't look.

And the faceless woman on the other side of the glass tilted her head. Very slightly. As if listening to something far away. And her thin dry voice came through the crack.

"*He's been saying that name for three days*," she said. "*Every night. To the glass. I could hear him. Through the dark.*" A pause. "*I don't know who it belongs to. But he says it so beautifully.*"

The grey hand pressed harder.

"*I'd like to have a name someone said like that,*" said the Unnamed Warden.



ANTHO PUT THE LANTERN against the glass.

Not held up. *Against.* Pressed flat to the black surface, right beside their father's hands, with its shutter wide and its twelve Hush-runes blazing white. The gold light poured into the crack.

And on the other side, the faceless woman *flinched.*

Not much. A little. Her grey hand jerked back from the glass an inch. Then pressed again.

"*That won't stop me,*" she said. "*I'm not a voice, Anthoren Vey. I'm a hand.*"

"*I know,*" said Antho. "*But it'll stop him.*"

He meant their father. Lex understood a heartbeat later. The gold light had poured over Arion too, kneeling against the glass. Over his face. Over his eyes. *Voices can't act through you while it's lit.* Whatever had been pouring through that crack into their father for three days, whatever had made him hear his wife in a stranger's hand, cut off.

Arion blinked.

He looked at the hand on the other side of the glass. Grey. Blurred at the edges. Long-fingered.

Not Seren's.

He made a sound Lex would never forget. Like something tearing. And took his hands off the door.



LEX TOOK HIS PLACE.

He didn't think about it. He went down on his knees in front of the black glass where his father had been, and put his hands flat on it, and *held.* With Stone. The way he'd held the Rift wall with Dorran. The way he'd held the floor of Ysmir's temple while the ice came down. *Please. Hold. Just a little longer.*

The mountain answered. Slow. Grudging. Old. But it answered. The crack stopped widening.

On the other side, the faceless woman pressed. He felt her. Cold. Narrow. Precise. Searching for the weak place.

"*Kell*," he said.

The pressure flickered.

Just for a moment. Like a candle in a draft. The grey hand on the other side of the glass went still.

"*What*," said the Unnamed Warden. Very quietly. "*What did you call me?*"

Lex opened his mouth.

And the pressure came back. Harder. Colder. The grey hand slamming against the glass.

"*Don't*," she said. "*Don't do that. Don't say things to me. He told me you would. He told me you'd say things.*" Her voice was very thin. "*He said it would hurt.*"

"*Does it?*"

The faceless woman didn't answer.

But after a long moment, the grey hand came off the glass. Slowly. And the shape behind the door drew back. Into the dark. Fading.

"*I'll be here*," said the Unnamed Warden. From very far away. "*He says the door is mine now. I'll be here every night.*"

And she was gone.



THEY SAT ON THE black floor of the cavern for a long time after. Arion with his back against the wall, his face grey, his hands shaking in his lap. Antho beside him with the Lantern. Lex in front of the door. Pim, who'd come down the passage at some point without anyone noticing, sitting beside Arion with his small cold hand on the old man's sleeve.

"*I thought it was her*," said Arion at last. Barely a whisper. "*For three days. I thought she'd come back.*"

"*I know*," said Antho.

"*I sat here and talked to it.*" His voice cracked. "*I told it things. Things I've never told anyone. About the Spire. About the night we met. About—*" He stopped. "*And it listened. And it said nothing. And I thought she was just tired.*"

Nobody said anything.

"It said," said Arion, "it said it would like to have a name someone said like that." He put his face in his hands. "I was saying her name to someone who doesn't have one."

Lex looked at the door. At the crack across its face. At the little clay lamp in its niche, burning straight up again. Not leaning.

Kell, he thought. Isaura Kell. Fifty-eight. High Warden. She was carried once.

She flinched.



ILSE CAME UP FROM the valley at dawn.

Wren brought her. Half carrying her. Up the long switchbacks from the Stone at Hollow's Foot, with Ilse's arm over her shoulders and Ilse's feet stumbling on the stones. Ilse wasn't crying. She hadn't cried since the Stone. She walked with her eyes open and her face white and blank, like a sleepwalker, like Mella Bell on her way to the green.

She stopped at the mouth of the cave. She looked at Lex.

"He made it look like nothing," she said.

Lex didn't understand.

"His wrist," said Ilse Marrow. "Where I was holding on. He made it look like nothing. The Lampshade. Our trick. The first one we ever learned." Her voice was very flat. "And my hands believed him. And let go."

"Ilse—"

"He said one of us has to stay." She looked down at her hands. Open. Empty. "He always says things like that. He's always the one who says the sensible thing." Her voice cracked, just once. "And I always ignore him. And this time I didn't get to."

She looked up.

"Where did it take him?" she said. "The Knight. Down the Stone. Where does it go?"

Lex looked at Malachi. The old man had come up the mountain in the night on Vharuun's back, with Seraphine and Kestrel and Tamsin. He was standing in the mouth of the cave with his straw hat in his hands.

"Down," said Malachi quietly. *"Down the tithe. To the bottom."* He looked at Ilse. *"To the Heart."*

"Then I'm going to the Heart," said Ilse Marrow.



THE QUEEN OF CALDOR came at noon.

On the storm-mother's back. Vharuun had gone in the night: Antho had asked her, and she'd gone without a word, a vast storm-blue shadow lifting off the slope and turning west toward Highcrest. And she came back at noon with three people clinging to her scales. Elowen Dunmore, in black armor, with Oathkeeper on her back. Daxian Roole, grey-faced, with his hatchet face set like stone.

And Lysandra.

In a plain grey riding cloak, with her dark hair coming down and her face white with exhaustion. She slid down off the storm-mother's shoulder onto the slope below the Hollowmaw and nearly fell, and Elowen caught her.

"They're singing," said the Queen of Caldor. Before anyone could speak. *"In Highcrest. Half the city. They're in the square around the Great Stone. Thousands of them. With their hands on it. Singing."*

She looked up at Lex. Her dark eyes were very bright.

"And there's a man," she said. *"Standing on top of the Stone. A tall thin man in a long dark robe. With a wide mouth. Conducting them."* She swallowed. *"I watched him from the castle wall. All night. He doesn't stop. He doesn't sleep. He just stands there with his hands up and sings, and they sing back."*

"The Cantor," said Malachi.

"Is that what he is?" The Queen's mouth twisted. *"I thought he was the end of the world."*



THEY MET IN THE library.

All of them. It was the only room in the Lantern Keep big enough, and even then they were packed in shoulder to shoulder, standing between the shelves, sitting on the table, on the floor, on the windowsill. Lex looked round at them and thought: *this is everyone. Everyone left.*

The Queen, in the best chair, with Elowen standing behind her. Roole by the door with his arms folded. Arion in the corner, grey and silent, with Pim beside him. Antho and Seraphine at the table, with maps. Wren on the windowsill with her bow across her knees. Kestrel and Tamsin, standing together. Oriel on a stool, with her white eyes turned toward nothing. Malachi on the table, cross-legged, with an apple he wasn't eating.

And Ilse. Sitting on the floor in the corner with her knees drawn up and her arms around them. Alone. For the first time since Lex had known her.

"Four," said Seraphine.

She had her notebook open. She'd been writing since dawn. Her spectacles were askew and there was ink on her nose.

"Four of them," she said. *"Malachi felt them. Lex felt where they came up."* She turned a page. *"I've been through every record I brought from the Spire. Every chronicle. Every ballad."* She looked up. *"I think I know who they were."*

Silence.

"The Cantor," said Seraphine. *"Brother Aldous of Hollin's Rest. A choir-master. In a village in the north, three hundred years ago. The records say he had the most beautiful voice in Caldor. People came from a hundred miles to hear him sing."* She swallowed. *"And one midwinter night, he walked out of his church singing, and the whole village followed him. Every man, woman, and child. Into the hills. In the snow."*

"And?" said Roole.

"And they never came back." Seraphine turned the page. *"Hollin's Rest was struck from the Order's maps in the next year. As if it had never been. The records say the Stone there went black."*

"He's been doing it for three hundred years," said Malachi quietly. *"At the bottom of the world. Singing. That's all he knows how to do."*



"Mother Sallow," said Seraphine.

She turned another page.

"Agathe Sallow. A midwife. Of Millbridge, in the Vale." She looked at Lex. *"Two hundred years ago, there was a plague in the Vale. The grey cough. It killed half of Millbridge in a month. Everyone who could fled. The priest.*

The Warden. The lord." She was quiet. *"She stayed. The midwife. She nursed the sick until there were no sick left. Only dead."* Seraphine took off her spectacles and rubbed her eyes. *"And then she nursed the dead. The records say when they came back to Millbridge in the spring, they found her in the church. With all of them. Laid out in rows. Washed and dressed and tucked in."* A pause. *"And she was singing to them. Lullabies."*

"Gods," said Wren softly.

"And she rots things," said Lex. *"Malachi said a rot."*

"She tends things," said Malachi. *"That's what she knows. She tends them until there's nothing left to tend. And then she keeps tending."* He looked at the apple in his hands. *"Everything she touches, she tries to keep. Forever. And nothing living can be kept forever."*



"The Twinned Knight," said Seraphine.

Across the room, Ilse lifted her head.

"Ser Corran and Ser Cael," said Seraphine. *"The Knights of the Ford. Brothers. Twins."* She looked at Ilse. *"There's a ballad. Everyone knows it. Brannoc used to sing it in the forge, badly. They held the ford at the Silverrun against an army out of the east. Back to back. For a day and a night. And the river rose, and they wouldn't give ground, and they drowned."* Her voice was gentle. *"Holding each other. When they found them, after, they couldn't separate them. They had to bury them together."*

"Two who won't let go," said Ilse. Very quietly. From the corner.

"Two who won't let go."

Ilse put her face down on her knees.



"And the fourth," said Seraphine.

She closed her notebook. She didn't open it again.

"We know who she is," she said. *"Lex saw her taken. At the Rift."* She looked at the door of the library. As if she could see down the passage, down to the bell-shaped cavern, down to the black glass door and whatever waited behind it. *"Isaura Kell. High Warden of the Order."*

"Who put my Ceiling on me," said the Queen of Caldor. Very quietly. *"At sixteen. At the Great Stone in the Spire. With the flag that weighted it."*

She looked at her hands. *"Who sent Seraphine to the cells for a week. Who tried to take my crown at the masquerade."*

Nobody said anything.

"And who threw herself in front of Ilse," said Lex. *"At the Rift. When the dark came for her."*

Everyone looked at him.

"She did," said Lex. *"I saw it. Ilse was thirty-six percent gone. The easiest thread in the cavern. The dark went for her. And Kell shoved her out of the way and took it instead."* He looked at Ilse. *"You don't remember. You were half asleep. Ivo was carrying you."*

Ilse had lifted her head again. She was staring at him.

"Why?" she whispered.

"Because Dorrان carried her," said Lex. *"Down the stair. And told her he wasn't going to forgive her. And held up the Rift."* He swallowed. *"And when the dark came for you, she said: tell his twelve villages the High Warden who gave the order was sorry too."*

The library was very quiet.

"And now she's at the door," said Antho. *"Without a face. Without a name. Holding it for him."* He was looking at the Lantern on the table in front of him. *"And when Lex said her name, she flinched."*



"They're pipes," said Malachi.

Everyone turned to look at him. The old man was sitting cross-legged on the table, turning his apple over and over in his gnarled hands.

"Each of them," he said. *"They came up the tithe-threads. Four of them, at four Stones. And they're holding the threads open. Wide. Like a man standing in a doorway so it can't close."* He set the apple down. *"Every night they hold them open, the pipes get wider. And the song gets louder. And more people walk out to their Stones."*

"And when the pipes are wide enough—" said Lex.

"He comes up." Malachi's shifting eyes were very dark. *"Himself. Not a herald. Not a Choir. Him. Through the four widest pipes. Into Highcrest. Into the Vale. Into the valley below this mountain. And through your mother's door."*

"How long?"

The old man was quiet.

"Oriel?" he said.

The blind woman on her stool turned her white face toward him.

"Twenty days," said Oriel Sant. *"Maybe less. I see four fires. Burning down. And at the end of them, something gold coming up out of the ground."* Her thin dry voice didn't change. *"I see the Heart. I see a smith with a hammer. A brother with a lamp. A girl with empty hands."* She tilted her head. *"And an old man with a bell."*

Malachi went very still.

"A bell," he said.

"A little one," said Oriel. *"Silver. No bigger than a thumb."* She smiled faintly. *"Ringing."*



THEY MADE THE PLAN in an hour.

Lex had thought it would take longer. Councils always took longer, in the stories. But there wasn't time to argue. And everyone in the room already knew, he thought, what they were going to say. They'd known since the night of the Blade. Since the Rift. Since the song.

"We split," said the Queen. *"There's no other way. Four of them, four places, twenty days."*

"Highcrest," said Antho. *"The Cantor."* He put his hand on the Lantern. *"He's a voice. Nothing stops voices like this."*

"One lantern against a whole city?" said Roole.

"Not one." Antho looked across the room. At Pim. Sitting beside Arion, with his knees drawn up. *"The Lantern stops voices. But there's something better than a lantern."* He held out his hand. *"Pim. Will you come?"*

The boy looked at him. A long, grave, careful look.

Then he got up, and crossed the room, and took Antho's hand.

"I'll come too," said Seraphine. *"I've read every record of Hollin's Rest. Every one. If there's anything in there about how to stop him—"*

"And the Guard," said Elowen Dunmore. *"It's my city. My Queen."* She looked at Lysandra. *"Majesty, you'll stay here."*

"*I will not.*" The Queen was already standing. "*He's singing to my people. On my Stone. In my square.*" Her dark eyes were very hard. "*I'm a Sovereign, Elowen. I was Kindled to command. If anyone in Caldor can out-shout a choir-master, it's me.*"



"*The Vale,*" said Lex. "*Mother Sallow. Millbridge.*"

He looked at Kestrel.

She looked back at him. Her amber eyes were very steady. She hadn't said a word all morning. She'd stood by the shelves with her brother beside her and listened.

"*Rot,*" said Kestrel. "*She rots things.*"

"*Yes.*"

"*Fire burns rot.*" Kestrel's mouth twisted. "*My grandmother used to say. When the sheep got foot-rot, she'd burn it out. With the Ashari fire.*" She looked at her hands. "*I'll come.*"

"*And me,*" said Tamsin.

Everyone looked at him. He hadn't spoken in council before. He stood beside his sister, thin and dark-haired, in a borrowed coat, and his face was very pale.

"*I was at the edge of the dark,*" said Tamsin Varn. "*For months. Like Mella. Like Ilse. I heard him singing.*" He swallowed. "*I can still hear him. At night. Very faint. If I listen.*" He looked at Lex. "*If anything comes up out of the Stone at Millbridge, I'll hear it first.*"

Kestrel looked at her brother for a long moment.

Then she reached out and took his hand.

"*The Vale is mine,*" said Lex. "*It's home. Brannoc's there. Hedda. Tilda. The forge.*"

"*And Teodra,*" said Roole.

Lex looked at him.

"*Teodra Hale,*" said Roole. "*The free company. She's been in the Vale since the winter, guarding the carts from Ashbourne. Two hundred swords.*" His hatchet face was very grim. "*I sent her word last night. She'll be at Millbridge by now.*"



"*And the Knight*," said Ilse.

She'd got up. She was standing in the middle of the library floor, in her patched green coat, with her hands clenched at her sides.

"*He took Ivo down the Stone*," she said. "*To the Heart. To the bottom.*" She looked at Malachi. "*How do I get there?*"

The old man looked at her for a long time.

"*The long way*," he said at last. "*There's no other. Down the Stone, you can't follow. Not without the song in you.*" He looked at the window. West. Toward the Teeth. "*Across the grey river. Through the Drowned Country. Into the deep. The Forbidden Lands.*" He was quiet. "*It's the way to the Heart, girl. It's the only way. It's the way all of us will have to go, in the end.*"

"*Then I'm going now.*"

"*Not alone*," said Antho.

Ilse turned on him.

"*Not alone*," said Antho again. Very gently. "*I've been across the grey river. I know the Ferryman. I know the Drowned Country.*" He looked at the Lantern on the table. "*And I promised someone there I'd come back. With a light.*"

"*You're going to Highcrest. The Cantor.*"

"*I'm going to Highcrest first.*" Antho looked at her. "*Twenty days, Oriel says. The Cantor first. Then the river.*" His grey eyes were very steady. "*Wait for me. Ten days. Ten days, and I'll take you across myself. And we'll go down together and find your brother.*"

Ilse stared at him.

"*He sat up with you every night for six weeks*," said Antho. "*He beld on when you were thirty-six percent gone.*" His voice was very quiet. "*You can wait ten days for him. He'd want you to come with a lamp.*"

Ilse Marrow stood in the middle of the library floor and shook.

Then she nodded. Once.

And sat down on the floor where she was, and put her face in her hands, and cried for the first time since the Stone.

Wren slid down off the windowsill and went and sat beside her. And put an arm around her. And didn't say anything.



"*And the door,*" said Arion.

He was still in the corner. Grey. Quiet. But he'd lifted his head.

"*Someone has to keep the door,*" he said. "*She'll be back. Every night. Pushing.*" His voice was very steady now. "*I'll keep it.*"

"*Father—*" said Antho.

"*I know what you're going to say.*" Arion looked at him. "*That I thought she was Seren. That I sat there for three days and talked to her. That I'll do it again.*" His lean face didn't change. "*I won't. I know now.*" He looked at the Lantern on the table. "*And I'll have the students. Odile. Teo. And a lantern of my own.*"

"*I'll make you one,*" said Lex. "*Tonight. Before I go.*"

His father looked at him.

"*Twenty runes,*" said Lex. "*Not twelve. The heaviest I've ever made.*"

Something moved at the corner of his father's mouth.

"*Thank you,*" said Arion Vey.



THEY WERE STANDING UP. Moving. Talking in low voices. Splitting into groups. The Queen with Elowen and Roole, bent over Seraphine's map of Highcrest. Kestrel and Tamsin by the door, waiting for Lex. Malachi still on the table.

And Lex turned to go, and found Malachi watching him.

"*A bell,*" said the old man quietly. "*She said a bell.*"

Lex came and stood beside the table.

"*You threw it in the sea,*" he said. "*You told us. In the Stillwater. The night after the Weaving.*"

"*It rang and rang.*" Malachi's voice was barely audible. "*All the way down.*" He looked at his gnarled hands. "*It was the only thing he ever made just for me. Not for the world. Not for the net. For me. So he'd know when I was sad.*"

The sea remembers every stone, thought Lex. *That ever sank beneath her foam.*

He turned his head.

Teo Brask was standing in the doorway of the library. Dripping. As usual. He'd been listening, as usual. He went red when he saw Lex looking at him.

"Um," said Teo.

"Teo," said Lex. *"How do you feel about going home for a bit?"*

The boy blinked.

"*To the coast,*" said Lex. "*To the sea.*" He looked at Malachi. "*There's something at the bottom of it. Something very small. Silver. That rang all the way down.*" He looked back at Teo. "*Do you think the Undertow would give it back? If you asked nicely?*"

Teo's round face went very still.

Then it lit up. Like a window being thrown open.

"*I can ask,*" he said. "*I can always ask. It likes it when I ask.*"



LEX MADE HIS FATHER a lantern that night.

In the forge Brannoc had built at the bottom of the bell-shaped cavern, in front of the cracked door. With the Heart-Coal's ordinary cousin in the hearth, plain charcoal, and Aurelian's little hammer in his hand. Iron. Heavy. Squat and round, like a clay lamp, with a ring to carry it by. And on its glass, twenty runes. *Hush*. Twenty times.

And on the inside of the ring, where only the person carrying it would see, one more.

STAY.

He gave it to his father at dawn. Arion took it in both hands and looked at it for a long time. Turned it over. Found the rune on the inside of the ring.

He didn't say anything. He didn't need to.

He hung it in the niche beside Seren's clay lamp. Two lights, side by side, in front of the cracked door. And sat down on the black floor beside them, with the blanket over his knees and Odile cross-legged at his side.

"Go," he said. *"All of you. I've got the door."*



THEY LEFT AT SUNRISE.

Antho and Pim and Seraphine and the Queen and Elowen and Roole on Vharuun, west, toward Highcrest and the singing city.

Teo on Ashka, east, toward the Tidewater coast and the sea. Alone. Clutching the dragon's crest with white knuckles and a grin so wide it nearly split his face.

And Lex and Wren and Kestrel and Tamsin and Malachi on horses Roole had brought up the valley, south, toward the Vale. Toward Millbridge. Toward home.

Ilse stood at the mouth of the Hollowmaw and watched them all go. Alone. With her hands open at her sides.

Ten days, she thought.

And sat down on the rock where Pim always sat, and pulled her knees up, and waited.

CHAPTER 28

THE CANTOR

HIGHCREST WAS SINGING.

Antho heard it from forty miles out. From the storm-mother's back, over the river valley, with the sun going down behind them and the golden city climbing its mountain ahead. Not with his ears. Not yet. With Shade. With the deep cold hearing that listened to silences.

There was no silence in Highcrest.

That was what he heard. A city of a hundred thousand souls, and not one quiet place in it. Every street. Every terrace. Every room. Full of sound. The same sound. One sound. Rising up off the mountain like heat off a forge.

"*Can you hear it?*" said Seraphine, behind him. Her voice was strained.

"Yes."

"*I can't.*" She swallowed. "*Not with my ears. But I can feel it. In my teeth.*"

In front of him, Pim sat very still on the storm-mother's neck. His thin shoulders hunched. His hands over his ears. He'd put them there an hour ago, when they first crossed the river, and he hadn't taken them down.

Antho put his hand on the boy's back.

"*Too loud?*" he said.

Pim nodded. Once.

"*I know,*" said Antho. "*It's too loud for me too.*"



THEY CAME DOWN ON the castle wall at dusk.

The castle was empty. The Queen's guard was gone. Elowen's knights were gone. The servants, the cooks, the grooms. Gone. Down into the city. Down to the square.

The Queen walked along the battlements of her own castle in the twilight with her face like stone. She didn't say anything. She stopped at the place where the wall looked down over the city, and stood there with her hands on the cold parapet, and looked.

Antho came and stood beside her.



THE SQUARE AT THE foot of the Spire was the biggest open space in Highcrest. He'd seen it at the festival, three years ago and then again in the summer: lanterns everywhere, stalls, dancing, the Queen's speech.

It was full of people.

All of them. More than at any festival. Packed shoulder to shoulder from wall to wall, filling the square, spilling up the streets that led into it, up the stairs, onto the rooftops. Thousands. Tens of thousands. In nightclothes, mostly. Barefoot. With their faces turned up.

And all of them singing.

He could hear it now, with his ears. Even from the castle wall. A great soft swelling sound, rising up out of the square like a tide. Not words. Not a tune he knew. Just *singing*. Tens of thousands of voices, perfectly together, perfectly in tune, the way no crowd has ever sung, in all of history.

It was the most beautiful thing he had ever heard.

And in the middle of the square, on top of the Great Stone of Highcrest, a man.



HE WAS TALL. VERY tall. Thin, like a heron. In a long dark robe that hung to the Stone and spilled over its edges like water. His arms were raised. His hands were long and pale and moving, slowly, gracefully, the way a choir-master's hands move. Conducting. Shaping the sound. Lifting it, softening it, sending it swelling out across the square and back.

His head was thrown back. His eyes were closed.

And his mouth was open. Wide. Too wide. Singing.

Antho couldn't hear his voice. Not separately. It was *in* the sound. Under it. The thread that all the other voices hung from. The note they were all tuned to.

"*Brother Aldous,*" said Seraphine quietly. Beside him. With her notebook clutched to her chest. "*Of Hollin's Rest.*"

The Queen made a sound. Low. Furious.

"*That's my bakers,*" she said. "*Down there. My grooms. My guards. My council.*" Her hands were white on the parapet. "*That's the Duke of Harlowe. In his nightshirt. On the steps of the Spire. Singing.*"

"*He can't hear you,*" said Antho. "*None of them can.*"

"*Then I'll make them hear me.*"



SHE TRIED.

From the castle wall. Standing at the parapet with her arms spread. And Antho felt it come off her: the Sovereign's command. Gold-silver. A great bright wave, rolling out over the city the way it had rolled out over the ballroom at the masquerade. *Stand with me. Hear me. I am your Queen.*

It hit the singing like a wave hitting a sea-wall.

And broke.

Antho felt it break. Felt the Queen's command go out over the square and *vanish* into the song. Swallowed. The way the Hollow had swallowed Kestrel's fire at the Rift. Not resisted. Absorbed. Made part of it.

And the song swelled. A little. As if someone had added a new voice to the choir.

The Queen staggered back from the parapet. Elowen caught her.

"*It took it,*" said Lysandra. Her face was white. "*It took my command. It sang it.*"



ANTHO LIT THE LANTERN.

He did it on the castle wall, in the falling dark, with the song pouring up from the square below. The shutter clicked. The gold light spilled out. Twelve Hush-runes, blazing white.

The song went quiet. Inside the circle. Around him. Around Pim, and Seraphine, and the Queen, and Elowen, and Roole. A small circle of silence on a castle wall, in a city full of singing.

Pim took his hands off his ears.

He looked up at Antho. His thin grave face very pale.

"*It's beautiful*," said Pim.

Antho looked at him.

"*The singing*," said Pim. "*It's beautiful. That's why they go.*" He was quiet. "*Nobody ever sang to them like that before.*"

It was the longest thing the boy had ever said.



"*Hollin's Rest*," said Seraphine.

She'd sat down on the battlements, inside the circle of gold light, with her notebook open on her knees. She was turning pages fast. Her spectacles were sliding down her nose.

"*The records*," she said. "*Everything I could find. There's not much. A tax roll. A letter from the Warden of the north to the Spire. A ballad, a bad one.*" She stopped on a page. "*And this.*"

She held it up. A copy, in her own neat cramped hand, of something older.

"*The letter from the Warden*," she said. "*Written the spring after. When they went back to Hollin's Rest and found it empty.*" She read it aloud. "*The village is deserted. The Stone is black. Every house is empty. The church door stands open. We have found no one.*" She looked up. "*And then, at the bottom. Almost as an afterthought.*"

She read:

"*Save one child. A girl of seven, found in the loft of the miller's house, alone, half-starved. She did not go with the others into the snow. When asked why, she could not answer, for she has been deaf from birth.*"



THE CIRCLE OF GOLD light was very quiet.

"*Deaf*," said Antho.

"*She couldn't hear him.*" Seraphine's voice was shaking. "*Every soul in Hollin's Rest followed him into the hills, singing. Every one. Except the one who couldn't hear the song.*"

"*Children are hard to sing to,*" said Antho slowly. "*That's what the herald said. At Harrowgate. They don't listen properly. They're always thinking about something else.*"

"*He can't sing to someone who isn't listening,*" said Seraphine.

They both looked at Pim.

The boy was standing at the parapet. Inside the circle of light. With his small hands on the cold stone and his dark careful eyes looking down at the square. At the tens of thousands of people, singing. At the tall thin man on top of the Stone, conducting.

He wasn't covering his ears anymore.

He was *listening*.

Not to the song. Antho could see it. Feel it. With Shade. The boy was listening *past* the song. Under it. Through it. To the silence. To the shape of the quiet underneath all that sound. The way he'd listened to the dark his whole life, in a cottage in Kessick with a man who took off his belt, because the dark was the only thing that had ever been kind to him.

There was silence under the song. Antho felt it. Very small. Very deep. Like the space between heartbeats.

And Pim had found it.



"*No,*" said the Queen.

She'd understood. Antho saw it on her face. She was looking at the boy at the parapet. Twelve years old. Thin. Silent.

"*No,*" said Lysandra again. "*You're not sending a child down there. Into that.*"

"*I'm not sending him,*" said Antho. "*I'm taking him.*"

"*He's twelve.*"

"*I know how old he is.*" Antho didn't look away from Pim. "*I know exactly how old he is. I was fifteen when the voices started. On a woodpile. And the only thing that kept me from walking into the trees was a ten-year-old boy holding my sleeve.*"

The Queen stared at him.

"Pim," said Antho.

The boy turned his head.

"*The man on the Stone,*" said Antho. "*He sings, and people follow. Because they listen. Because it's beautiful and nobody ever sang to them like that before.*" He crouched down. So they were eye to eye. "*But you don't listen to the singing. Do you. You listen to the quiet underneath.*"

Pim looked at him for a long moment.

Then nodded.

"*Can you make the quiet bigger?*" said Antho. "*Like you did at the door. On the night of the Blade. When you held my wrist and hid me from the Key.*"

Pim thought about it. Seriously. The way he thought about everything.

"*I don't know,*" he said. "*It's very loud.*"

"*I know.*"

"*I'd have to be close,*" said Pim. "*To the Stone. To him.*" He looked down at the square. At the tens of thousands of people. "*They're in the way.*"

"*Then we'll get you through them,*" said Antho. "*All of us. We'll get you to the Stone.*" He held out his hand. "*And then you just listen. That's all. Listen to the quiet. As hard as you can.*"

Pim looked at the hand. Then at Antho's face.

Then he put his small cold hand in Antho's.

"*Don't let go,*" he said.

"*I won't.*"



THEY WENT DOWN INTO the square at midnight.

Six of them. Antho, with Pim's hand in his and the Lantern held high in the other, its shutter wide, its twelve runes blazing. Seraphine at his shoulder, with her crossbow, which she knew she couldn't use. Roole, with his sword sheathed. Elowen, with Oathkeeper on her back. And the Queen of Caldor, in her plain grey cloak, with her face set.

The circle of silence went with them. Gold. Small. Around them like a bubble. And outside it, the song.

It hit them like a wall the moment they stepped off the last stair into the square. Even inside the Lantern's light. Antho felt it pressing against the edges of the gold, the way the grey had pressed in the valley beyond the Teeth. Thirsty. Patient. Beautiful.

And the people.

Packed shoulder to shoulder. Tens of thousands. Facing the Stone. Faces turned up. Eyes closed. Singing. They didn't move aside. They didn't see the little band of six with the gold light. They just stood there, swaying, singing, a wall of bodies between them and the Stone.

"We can't push through," said Roole. Low. *"Not without hurting them. There's too many. They'll crush each other."*

"Then don't push," said the Queen.



SHE STEPPED TO THE front.

Outside the circle. Out of the gold light. Into the song.

Antho saw it hit her. Saw her face go slack. Saw her eyes start to close. Saw her lips part, the way every lip in the square was parted.

And then saw her set her jaw.

"I was Kindled a Sovereign," said Lysandra of Caldor. Through her teeth. To no one. To herself. *"At sixteen. At the Great Stone. With a flag on it that weighted me down so I'd never be strong enough to rule on my own."* Her voice was shaking. *"And a smith from Ashbourne took the flag off. And I have been my own Queen for three years."*

She lifted her head.

"I will not sing your song," said the Queen.

And she didn't command. She'd learned that, on the castle wall. The song swallowed commands. Took them. Sang them.

She did something else.

She *spoke*. Quietly. Not to the crowd. To the man in front of her. A baker, in his nightshirt, with flour still on his arms. Singing with his eyes closed.

"Hollis," said the Queen. *"Hollis Penn. You make the burnt loaves for the children by the fountain. You sing in the Lower Town choir. Badly. Your*

wife's name is Ada." Her voice was very gentle. *"Hollis. It's Lysandra. Step aside, please. Just a little. Just for me."*

The baker's singing faltered.

His eyes flickered. Didn't open. But flickered.

And he stepped aside. A half-step. Swaying. Still humming. But aside.

The Queen walked into the gap.



SHE DID IT ALL the way across the square.

Antho would never forget it. A young woman in a grey cloak, walking through a crowd of tens of thousands of her own people, outside the circle of gold light, in the full force of the song. Not commanding. Not shouting. *Naming them.* One by one. Every face she passed.

"Mistress Orrin. You keep the bookshop on the Crown Terrace. You lent me the Founders' Chronicles when I was twelve and never asked for them back. Step aside, please."

"Ser Hadley. You taught me to ride. You put me on a pony called Biscuit and told me if I fell off you'd tell my grandfather I'd jumped. Step aside."

"Little Wenna. You're six. You gave me a daisy at the festival. Step aside, love."

And they did.

Half a step. A step. Swaying. Still singing. Eyes still closed. But aside. Opening a path. A narrow winding path through the singing crowd, from the foot of the stair to the Great Stone, a person wide. And the Queen of Caldor walking down it, with tears running down her face, naming every single soul she passed.

"How does she know them?" whispered Seraphine. *"All of them. How does she know—"*

"She's their Queen," said Elowen Dunmore. Very quietly. Her square face was wet. *"She's spent three years learning their names."*



THEY REACHED THE STONE.

The Great Stone of Highcrest. Taller than a man. Silver once. Black now. A hole cut out of the night. And on top of it, the Cantor.

Close up, he was bigger. Taller. Thinner. His dark robe pooled over the edges of the black Stone like ink. His long pale hands moved above the crowd, slowly, endlessly. His head thrown back. His eyes closed. His wide mouth open.

And the song was *enormous*. Even inside the gold light. Antho felt it batter at the circle. Felt the Lantern shake in his hand. Felt the twelve Hush-runes straining.

And then the Cantor opened his eyes.

They were silver. Pale silver. Like the Lattice. Like the threads of the net.

And they looked down at the little circle of gold light at the foot of his Stone. At Antho. At the Lantern. At the boy holding his hand.

The song changed.



IT CAME STRAIGHT AT Antho. Through the gold. Through the Hush-runes. As if they weren't there.

And it wasn't the song anymore.

It was a woman's voice. Low and a little rough. Flat on the high note.

If the dark comes calling, love, don't you mind.

His mother's voice.

A lantern's lit for the ones behind.

He stood at the foot of the black Stone with the Lantern in his hand and felt his knees start to go. The way they'd gone on the woodpile at fifteen. The way they'd gone every night for eleven years when the Murmur sang to him in the trees.

Come home, love, sang his mother's voice. *Come home. I'm right here. I've been waiting so long.*

The Lantern was shaking.

And from somewhere very deep inside him, from the last whisper of the four percent, the one percent, the place where the Murmur used to live, a voice said:

[...oh, that's a beautiful voice.]

He closed his eyes.

It is, he thought. *It's the most beautiful voice I've ever heard.*

[...you could go. You know. It wouldn't hurt.]

I know.

[...then why don't you?]

He opened his eyes. And looked up at the Cantor, on top of the black Stone, singing to him in his mother's voice.

"Because you got the tune wrong," said Antho Vey.



THE SONG STUTTERED.

Just for a moment. A missed note. A crack in the sound. The Cantor's silver eyes widened.

"She's flat," said Antho. *"On the high note. Always. Every time. It used to drive Father mad."* His voice was very steady. *"You sing it perfectly. You sing everything perfectly."* He held the Lantern higher. *"You've never once heard her sing. You've only heard the song."*

The Cantor's mouth closed.

For the first time in three hundred years, Brother Aldous of Hollin's Rest stopped singing.

And in the silence, in the tiny crack of quiet between one note and the next, Pim let go of Antho's hand.



HE WALKED TO THE Stone.

Antho didn't stop him. He'd promised not to let go. But Pim had let go first. And Antho understood, watching the boy walk out of the circle of gold light into the full roaring force of the song, that it wasn't his to hold anymore.

Pim put his small hand on the black Stone.

And listened.



THE SILENCE CAME OUT of him like a breath.

Antho felt it. With Shade. With every part of him. A silence. Not the absence of sound. Something *deeper*. The silence under everything. The quiet at the bottom of the world, before the world, before the net, before

the hunger. The space between heartbeats. The pause at the top of a breath. The stillness in a room where someone has just stopped crying.

It went out from the boy's hand through the black Stone.

And down.

Down the tithe-thread. The great wide pipe the Cantor had been holding open for twenty days. Down and down, through the dark, to the bottom of the world, where something gold and kind and hungry had been singing through a choir-master for three hundred years.

And *out*. Through the Stone. Into the square. Into every thread.

And the square went quiet.



TENS OF THOUSANDS OF voices. Stopping. Not all at once. In a wave. Like wind dying across a field of wheat. From the Stone outward. Rippling. Every mouth closing. Every voice going still. The great soft swelling sound that had risen off Highcrest for twenty days, dying away, dying away, until the only sound in the whole of the square was the wind off the mountain and somebody, somewhere, very quietly, beginning to cry.

And on top of the black Stone, the Cantor stood with his long pale arms still raised, and his mouth closed, and his silver eyes wide.

Listening.

For the first time in three hundred years.



ANTHO SAW IT HAPPEN. Saw it go through the tall thin man on the Stone. The silence. Going into him the way the song had gone into everyone else.

And in the silence, Brother Aldous heard something.

Antho didn't know what. He would never know exactly. But he saw the choir-master's face change. Saw the wide mouth tremble. Saw the silver eyes fill.

Snow, Antho thought. He's hearing the snow.

A village in the hills on a midwinter night. Everyone following him. Singing. Out of the church, out of the village, up into the hills. In the snow. In the dark. Singing.

And then the singing stopping. One voice at a time. As the cold took them. And him, still singing. Alone. On a hillside. In the snow. Because he didn't know how to stop.

"*I only wanted them to hear it,*" said the Cantor.

His voice was small. Cracked. An old man's voice. Not a choir. One voice. Speaking, not singing, for the first time in three hundred years.

"*I only wanted them to hear the music,*" he said. "*It was so beautiful. I wanted everyone to hear how beautiful it was.*" His long pale hands came down. Slowly. "*And they followed me. And I couldn't stop. If I stopped, it would end. And I couldn't bear for it to end.*"

He looked down at the boy with his hand on the Stone.

"*Is it quiet?*" said Brother Aldous. "*Is it really quiet?*"

Pim looked up at him.

"*Yes,*" said Pim. "*You can stop now.*"



THE CANTOR KNELT DOWN on top of the Stone.

Slowly. The way an old man kneels in a church. His dark robe pooling around him. His long pale hands folding in his lap. His silver eyes still wet.

"*It's been so long,*" he said. "*Since I heard nothing.*"

"*I know,*" said Pim.

"*It's lovely.*" The Cantor closed his eyes. "*I'd forgotten it was lovely.*"

And then, very softly, so softly that only the people closest to the Stone heard it, he hummed. Just a little. Not the song. Something else. A simple tune. Three notes. Rising.

The kind of tune a choir-master hums to give the note before a hymn begins.

And then he stopped. And smiled. And was quiet.

And the black Stone under him went grey.

And then silver.

And Brother Aldous of Hollin's Rest went with it. Not down. Not into the dark. *Out.* Like a candle going out in a quiet room. The tall thin shape on top of the Stone, fading. Grey, then pale, then nothing. Gone. Leaving only the Great Stone of Highcrest, silver and plain and ordinary, with a twelve-year-old boy's small hand flat against its side.

THE CANTOR – SILENCED

"He only wanted them to hear it.
Someone finally let him hear nothing."



PIM TOOK HIS HAND off the Stone.

He turned around. He looked at Antho. Standing in the circle of gold light with the Lantern in his hand.

And then the boy's knees gave out, and he sat down very suddenly on the cobbles of the square, and started to shake.

Antho was there before he hit the ground. He knelt. He put his arms around the boy. Small and thin and cold, shaking like a leaf.

"It was so loud," said Pim. Into his coat. *"It was so loud and I had to find the quiet and it was so small."*

"I know."

"And then he heard it." Pim was crying. Antho had never seen him cry. Not once. Not in all his months at the Keep. *"He heard it and he was so sad."*

"I know."

"Is he gone?"

"Yes."

"Is he all right?"

Antho held the boy and looked at the silver Stone.

"I think so," he said. *"I think he's somewhere quiet."*



ALL AROUND THEM, THE square was waking.

Tens of thousands of people, blinking. Looking around. In their nightclothes. Barefoot. On the cobbles of the square at the foot of the Spire, in the middle of the night. Staring at each other. At their own hands. At the silver Stone.

Someone started to laugh. Shakily. Someone else started to cry. A child was calling for her mother. A dog was barking, somewhere in the Lower Town, as if it had been holding its breath for twenty days.

And a man in a nightshirt with flour on his arms was standing a few paces from the Stone, holding a loaf of bread he didn't remember picking up, and looking around in total bewilderment.

"*Your Majesty?*" said Hollis Penn. Staring at the Queen. "*What are you doing in the square in the middle of the night? In your cloak?**"

Lysandra of Caldor looked at him.

And laughed. A great helpless startled laugh, with tears running down her face. And put her arms around the baker, flour and bread and all, and held on.

"*Oh,*" said Hollis Penn, very faintly, into the Queen's shoulder. "*Oh. All right then.*"



ANTHO SAT ON THE cobbles at the foot of the Great Stone with Pim in his arms and the Lantern beside him, and didn't move for a long time.

Seraphine came and sat beside him. She didn't say anything. She leaned against his shoulder.

And somewhere very deep inside him, in the last place where the Murmur had lived, something stirred. Very faint. Like a dry leaf moving in the wind.

[...it was a beautiful voice,] it said. *[...wasn't it.]*

It was, thought Antho.

[...you didn't go.]

No.

A long silence. And then, so faint he almost didn't hear it:

[...good.]

And it was gone.

Not quiet. Not asleep. *Gone*. Like a breath let out. Like a door closed for the last time on an empty room. He felt the place where it had been, for eleven years, in the space between his heartbeats. Empty. Clean. *His*.

ANTHOREN VEY

CLARITY: 99 → 100 / 100

Hollow-link: SEVERED

Murmur:  (no signal)

"The thief has left the empty house.

The house is not empty. It is his."

He read it. He read it twice.

Then he put his face in Seraphine's hair, with the boy still in his arms, on the cobbles of the square in the city that had stopped singing, and wept.



A RAVEN CAME AT dawn.

Not Quill. A Keeper's raven. Grey and sleek. It found them on the castle wall, where they'd gone to watch the sun come up over a silent city, and dropped a scrap of paper at Roole's feet.

Roole read it. His hatchet face went grey.

He handed it to Antho.

Commander—

Millbridge is gone.

Not burned. Not fallen. Gone soft. The Stone went black at midnight three nights ago and a woman came up out of it in a midwife's apron and everything she touched began to rot. Houses. Fields. Wells. People.

It's spreading. Through the Vale. Toward Ashbourne.

Teodra Hale's company is holding the road at the Millbridge ford. The Forgeheart arrived last night with the fire-witch and the old man. They're going in at dawn.

Teodra says to tell you: if you've got a dragon to spare, send it. Now.

—Fenn

Antho looked south. Toward the Vale. Toward a forge with twenty anvils, and a village where his brother had grown up, and an old bald smith with a broken arm who'd said *lad, go*.

"*Vharuun*," he said.

On the castle wall behind him, the storm-mother lifted her vast head.

I HEARD, she said.

CHAPTER 29

MOTHER SALLOW



THE VALE SMELLED OF autumn in the middle of spring.

Lex noticed it first on the road south from the Hollowmaw, two days out, when they crested the last ridge of the Greyspine foothills and the green bowl of the Ashbourne Vale opened below them. It was his home. He'd been born at the far end of it, in a cottage at Harrow. He'd grown up at the near end, in a forge in Ashbourne. He knew every smell it had. Woodsmoke and hay and the river and Mother Orla's bacon.

This was wrong.

Sweet. Heavy. Like apples left too long in a barrel. Like leaves going soft on a forest floor. Like a cellar where something has been forgotten.

"*Rot*," said Kestrel. Beside him on her borrowed horse. Her nose wrinkling. "*That's rot*."

Lex looked down the Vale. At the river, winding silver through the green. At the villages strung along it like beads. At Ashbourne, tiny, at the near end, with the smoke of the forge going up straight in the still air.

And at the far end, twenty miles off, where Millbridge should be—
Grey-green.

A stain. Spreading out from the river like a bruise. Soft and dull and colorless, eating into the green of the fields around it. He could see the edge of it from here, creeping. Slowly. Very slowly. Like ink soaking into wet paper.

Toward Ashbourne.



TEODRA HALE WAS HOLDING the ford.

They found her at dusk, at the Millbridge crossing, where the road from the north came down to the river and crossed on a long stone causeway half a mile above the village. Her company was strung out across the causeway in a line. Two hundred of them. Men and women in battered leather and mismatched mail, with spears and shields and a great banner of grey and black. The Ashen Banners. Standing in a wall across the causeway, facing south.

Facing the grey.

It was close. Two hundred paces off. The edge of the stain. Lex could see it properly now: the fields on the far side of the river, slumped and soft and grey-green, the hedges sagging, the trees drooping as if their trunks had turned to wet bread. A farmhouse at the edge of it, leaning. Its roof caving in, slowly, like a pie crust left in the rain.

And between the grey and the causeway, on the near bank, things moving.

People. Or what had been people. Walking slowly toward the ford. Grey-green. Soft. Their faces slack and peaceful. Their clothes old-fashioned, two hundred years out of date. Shuffling. Not hurrying. Coming toward the wall of shields.

"The plague-dead," said Malachi quietly. *"From Millbridge. Two hundred years ago. She tended them."* His shifting eyes were very dark. *"She's still tending them."*



"Forgeheart."

Teodra Hale came down the causeway toward them. She was exactly as Lex remembered her from Fort Caldris, four years ago: a broad weathered woman in battered leather armor, with a greatsword on her back and two fingers missing from her left hand. Greyer. More lined. But the same frank, unimpressed eyes.

She looked at Lex. At Wren. At Kestrel and Tamsin. At the small brown barefoot old man on the mule.

"That's it?" she said. *"That's what the Queen sends me? A smith, an archer, a fire-witch, a farmer, and somebody's grandad?"*

"Somebody's great-great-great-grandad," said Malachi mildly. "Give or take thirty generations."

Teodra looked at him for a long moment. Then she spat on the causeway.

"Fine," she said. "I've had worse." She jerked her head at the grey. "They come every night. More every time. They don't fight. They don't hit back. They just walk into the shield-wall and try to hold you." Her jaw tightened. "And if they get hold of you, you go soft. Like them. I lost eleven last night. Eleven good swords. Went soft and walked off into the grey, smiling."

"Where's she?" said Lex. "The midwife."

"In the village." Teodra pointed. South. Across the river. Into the heart of the stain. "At the Stone. On the green. Fenn's scouts saw her. Sitting on a stool beside it. Knitting."

"Knitting?" said Wren.

"Knitting." Teodra's face was grim. "Fenn said she looked up and smiled at him. Like a nice old granny. And then his horse went soft under him."



THEY CAMPED ON THE causeway that night. Behind the shield-wall. With fires burning all along the line, because Teodra said the plague-dead didn't like fire.

"They don't run from it," she said. "They're past running. But they go slower. And they don't reach for you quite so hard."

Lex sat by one of the fires with Teodra Hale. She'd brought a flask. She offered it. He shook his head. She drank.

"I heard about Thorne," she said.

Lex looked at her.

"Roole sent word," said Teodra. "In the winter. After the longest night." She looked into the fire. "Said he went down to the bottom of the world with a key and turned it. And then turned it back. And died doing it."

"Yes."

"Was it true?"

"Yes."

Teodra was quiet for a long time. She turned the flask over in her hands. The two missing fingers on her left. She'd lost them in the border wars, Lex remembered. Twenty years ago. Fighting beside Elric.

"He saved my life," she said. "Twice. In the east. Once from a Gloam-thing in a ditch, and once from my own stupidity, which was worse." She drank. "He wrote me, four years ago. Said there was work. Dead man in a crystal. Stupidest letter I ever got." She almost smiled. "And then I heard what he did at Caldris. To your father. To you lot. And I said, that's it, Thorne, you've used up both lives you saved, we're square."

She was quiet.

"Tell me," she said. "How he went. Exactly."

So Lex told her. The bottom of the Rift. The kind voice turning its back. *You'll be nothing at all.* The old man's face. The Key, turning back. The fifty-five threads, given up one by one. Getting older with every one. The Lockward. The blood on his glove. *First. At last. At the very bottom of the world, where nobody will ever see it.*

Teodra listened. She didn't interrupt.

When he finished, she sat for a long time looking into the fire.

"Stupid old goat," she said at last. Very softly.

She took a long drink. And then poured a little out of the flask, onto the stones of the causeway, into the firelight.

"For Thorne," said Teodra Hale. "Who never once turned down a stupid fight."



THEY WENT IN AT dawn.

Not the Ashen Banners. Teodra wanted to. She stood at the head of her shield-wall with her greatsword drawn and said, *we'll cut you a road*, and Lex said no.

"They're people," he said. "The plague-dead. They were people. Two hundred years ago. She's been tending them ever since." He looked at the grey shapes on the far bank, shuffling toward the ford. "If you cut them, she'll just tend them again. And again. And they'll never rest."

"Then what?"

"Hold the ford," said Lex. "Don't let them past. Don't let them get to Ashbourne." He looked at Teodra. "We'll go to the Stone."

"Five of you." Teodra's face was very flat. "Into that."

"Five of us."

She looked at him for a long time.

"Thorne said that about you," she said. "In his letter. Four years ago. He said, the boy's stubborn as an anvil and twice as dense, and he'll walk into anything if someone he loves is on the other side." She hefted her greatsword. "Go on, then. Anvil. We'll hold your ford."



THE GREY WAS SOFT under their feet.

That was the first thing. The moment they stepped off the causeway onto the far bank, past the shield-wall, into the edge of the stain, the ground gave. Not like mud. Like moss. Like a deep soft carpet, springy and damp, that sank a little under every step and slowly rose again behind.

It smelled of apples and leaf-mould and sleep.

Lex felt it go into him. Through his boots. Up his legs. A heaviness. A warmth. A *tiredness*. The kind you feel at the end of a long day at the forge, when you sit down by the fire and your eyes start to close and you think, *just for a moment, just a little rest*.

[Lex,] said Ember sharply. [Lex, that's her. That's the rot. It's in the ground. It wants you to lie down.]

I know.

He lit his hands.

Flame. Commanding. Gold-white fire pouring off his fingers. And where it touched the grey ground, the moss *bissed*. Shrivelled. Went black. And under the black, for a moment, he saw green. Real green. Grass.

The tiredness lifted. A little.

Beside him, Kestrel's hair caught. All at once. Red and gold, the Ashari fire, roaring up off her head and down her arms. She walked through the grey with fire pouring off her like a torch in a cellar, and the moss shrivelled black around her boots.

"*My grandmother,*" she said, through her teeth, "*burned foot-rot out of sheep. Every spring. Stank for a week.*" She looked at the grey stretching away ahead of them. "*This is going to stink for a year.*"



THE PLAGUE-DEAD DIDN'T STOP them.

They came. Shuffling across the soft grey fields. Out of the slumped houses. Out of the drooping orchards. Men and women and children in clothes two hundred years old, with slack peaceful faces and grey-green skin and arms held out.

Not attacking. *Reaching*. The way you reach for someone to hug them. And where Lex's fire touched them, they stopped.

Not burned. Not destroyed. They stopped and stood still, swaying. And their faces changed. The slack peace going out of them. Something else coming in. *Confusion*. As if they'd woken up in the middle of a long dream and didn't know where they were.

A girl of perhaps ten, in a long brown dress, stopped in front of Lex with her grey arms held out and the gold light of his fire on her face. And looked up at him. And said, in a small cracked voice, two hundred years old:

"*Where's Mam?*"

Lex couldn't answer.

The girl looked around. At the grey fields. At the slumped houses. At the other plague-dead, standing still in the fire-light, swaying.

"*It's cold,*" she said. "*I want to go to sleep. Mother Sallow won't let me go to sleep.*"

And she turned. And shuffled away. Back into the grey. Toward the village. Toward the Stone.

[*She's keeping them,*] whispered Ember. [*She won't let them go. Two hundred years. She won't let them sleep.*]



MILLBRIDGE WAS VERY QUIET.

They came into it at noon. Down the soft grey lane from the north, between houses slumped like melting candles. Roofs caved in. Doors

hanging. Windows filmed with grey-green, like the skin on old milk. And every house was full.

Lex looked through a window as he passed. A family. Mother, father, three children. In their beds. Under their blankets. Asleep. Grey-green and soft and peaceful. Not dead. He could see their chests rising and falling. Very slowly.

Tended.

Every house. Every bed. The whole of Millbridge, asleep. Tucked in. Kept.

"*Gods*," said Wren softly. "*Hammer. These aren't the plague-dead. These are now. These are the people who lived here three days ago.*"

"*She's tending them*," said Malachi. "*Like she tended the others.*" His voice was very old. "*She can't help it. It's all she knows.*"

Tamsin had stopped walking.

He was standing in the middle of the lane, with his head tilted. Listening. His face was very pale.

"*She's humming*," he said. "*Can you hear it? It's not his song. It's different. It's—*" He frowned. "*It's a lullaby.*"

Lex listened.

And heard it. Faint. Coming from ahead. From the green. From the Stone. A woman's voice. Old and warm and a little cracked. Humming. A lullaby. The kind every mother in the Vale sang. The kind Seren had sung.

Hush now, hush now, the day is done.



SHE WAS SITTING ON a stool beside the Stone.

Exactly as Teodra had said. A short round motherly woman, in a grey midwife's apron, with her sleeves rolled up and her grey hair in a neat bun. Knitting. Her needles clicking, steady and quick. A long grey-green scarf trailing from them across the soft ground, yards and yards of it, winding around the Stone.

The Stone was black. A hole. A shape cut out of the noon light.

And all around it, on the soft grey green of the village, in rows, the plague-dead. Lying down. Laid out. Washed and dressed and tucked in

under blankets of grey moss. Hundreds of them. Two hundred years of them.

And among them, newer. The sleepers of three days ago. Carried here. Laid out in their nightclothes. In rows. Tucked in.

Mother Sallow looked up from her knitting.

She smiled.

"*Oh*," she said. "*Oh, more of you. Come in, come in. You look so tired.*"



HER VOICE WENT INTO him like warm milk.

Lex felt it. Not like the Cantor's song. Not like the kind voice at the bottom of the Root. *Softer*. A grandmother's voice. A nurse's voice. The voice that comes into the room at night when you're sick and puts a cool hand on your forehead and says *there, there, sleep now*.

He felt his knees start to go.

"*There, there*," said Mother Sallow. Kindly. Her needles clicking. "*You've been carrying so much. I can see it. All of you.*" Her warm brown eyes moved from face to face. "*The big one. Look at him. He's been carrying the whole world on his back. And the little archer, she's been carrying him. And the red-haired one—*" Her eyes found Kestrel. And softened. "*Oh, love. Oh, you've been carrying something terrible.*"

Kestrel's fire flickered.

"*Lie down*," said Mother Sallow. "*All of you. Just for a little. I'll take care of everything. I'll tuck you in and keep you safe and you won't have to carry anything ever again.*" She smiled. "*That's what I'm for, you know. That's what I've always been for. Taking care.*"



LEX WAS ON HIS knees.

He didn't remember kneeling. The ground was so soft. So warm. The moss sinking under his hands like a feather bed. His eyes were closing.

[LEX,] Ember was shouting. Far away. [LEX, GET UP, GET UP, SHE'S—]

Just a moment, he thought. *Just a little rest. I'm so tired, Ember. I've been tired for so long.*

Beside him, Wren had sat down. Her bow across her knees. Her head nodding.

Tamsin was lying on his side. On the moss. His eyes closed. A small peaceful smile.

Malachi was sitting on his mule with his straw hat tipped over his eyes, swaying.

And Kestrel—

Kestrel was standing.



SHE WAS THE ONLY one. Standing in the middle of the soft grey green, with her fire guttering, low, almost out. Swaying. Her amber eyes heavy. But on her feet.

Staring at Mother Sallow.

"You kept them," said Kestrel. Her voice was thick. Slurred. Like someone fighting sleep. *"All of them. Two hundred years."*

"Of course I did," said Mother Sallow kindly. *"Somebody had to. Everybody else ran away."*

"You wouldn't let them go."

"Let them go?" The midwife looked shocked. Her needles stopped. *"Where would they go? Into the cold? Into the dark? Into the ground?"* She shook her head. *"No. No, I kept them. I keep them warm. I keep them clean. I keep them safe. I'll keep them forever."*

"They want to sleep," said Kestrel. *"Properly. I heard one. A girl. In the field. She said, Mother Sallow won't let me go to sleep."*

The midwife's face went very still.

"She's cold," said Kestrel. *"She wants her mam. She wants to sleep. And you won't let her."*

"If I let her sleep," said Mother Sallow, and her voice cracked, just a little, *"she'll be gone. They'll all be gone. And I'll be alone. In the church. With nobody to tend."*



KESTREL'S FIRE WENT OUT.

All of it. Her hair went red. Just red. Her hands went cold. She stood in the middle of the green, swaying, with nothing burning.

And she knelt down. In front of the midwife. On the soft grey moss. So their eyes were level.

"I know," said Kestrel Varn.

Mother Sallow stared at her.

"I know," said Kestrel again. Very quietly. *"I had a brother. Tam. He was taken. Cut out of the world. Nobody remembered him. Nobody but me."* Her voice was shaking. *"And someone offered me a way to keep him. To bring him back. Whole. If I just gave them one thing."*

"Did you?" whispered the midwife.

"I did." Kestrel didn't look away. *"I gave a madman the key to the end of the world. So I could keep my brother."* Her amber eyes were wet. *"Forty-one people died. A door nearly broke. A man I'd never met gave up the best memory he had to save a dragon because of what I did."*

Mother Sallow's needles had fallen into her lap.

"And I got him back," said Kestrel. *"Tam. He's here. He's right there, asleep on your moss."* She didn't look at her brother. *"And I'd do it again. I would. That's the worst of it."*

"Then you understand," said Mother Sallow. Almost pleading. *"You understand. You kept him. Like I keep mine."*

"No," said Kestrel.



SHE STOOD UP.

Slowly. Swaying. Fighting the soft warm weight of the moss with everything she had.

"I kept him," she said. *"But he's not mine. He's his. He gets to walk around and make stupid jokes and tell people I pick the worst horses at the fair. He gets to live."* She swallowed. *"*You don't keep people by holding on to them forever. You keep them by letting them go and live and be stupid and leave you."*

She turned. Looked down at her brother, lying on the moss with his eyes closed and a peaceful smile.

"Tam," she said. *"Get up."*

Tamsin didn't move.

"*Tam the Ram*," said Kestrel Varn. Louder. "*Get up. You named a prize ram after yourself and you're lying in a field like a sheep. Mam would be ashamed.*" Her voice cracked. "*Get up, you idiot. I gave away the world for you. Get up.*"

And Tamsin Varn opened his eyes.



LEX FELT IT. THROUGH the moss. Through the soft warm weight pressing him down. A *crack*. Like ice breaking on a pond.

Tamsin was sitting up. Blinking. Staring at his sister.

"*Kes?*" he said. Muzzily. "*What—*"

"*You were asleep,*" said Kestrel. "*On a rot-witch's moss. Get up.*"

He got up. Swaying. And as he got up, Lex felt the crack spread. Felt the soft warm weight on his own chest *lift*, just a little. Just enough.

[*NOW*,] shouted Ember. [*Lex, NOW, while it's cracked—*]

He got one knee under him. Then a foot. Then he was standing. His head clearing. Like coming up out of deep water.

And Mother Sallow was staring at Kestrel with tears running down her round kind face.

"*You let him go,*" she whispered. "*And he got up.*"

"*He always gets up,*" said Kestrel. "*He's terrible like that.*"



"*Burn it,*" said Malachi.

He'd got off his mule. He was standing on the moss, small and brown and barefoot, with his straw hat in his hand and his shifting eyes gone gold. Steady gold. Like fire.

"*Smith,*" he said. "*Burn it. All of it. Not to destroy. To release.*" *He looked at the rows of the tended dead, laid out on the green. "They've been waiting two hundred years for someone to light the pyre."*

Lex looked at the rows. At the plague-dead. Two hundred years in their grey moss blankets. The girl in the brown dress, lying near the end of a row, her eyes open, staring at the sky.

Where's Mam? I want to go to sleep.

He looked at the newer sleepers. The people of Millbridge, three days asleep.

"Not them," he said. *"The living. Not them."*

"Then ask it," said Malachi. *"Ask the fire. You know how. You're Commanding now."* His gold eyes were very bright. *"The fourth stage is when you can tell it no. Tell it no for the living. And yes for the rest."*



LEX KNELT ON THE soft grey green of Millbridge.

He put his hands on the moss.

And *Commanded*.

Not shouting. Not forcing. The way the Hearth had taught him, in the Wellworld of Flame. *Keep asking. Every time you light the forge. What's this fire for?*

This fire is for them, he told it. *For the ones who've been waiting. Two hundred years. Let them sleep. Not the living. Never the living. Only the ones who are already gone.*

Burn for them. Gently. The way you'd burn a candle in a window. To show them the way home.

And far away, at the other end of the Vale, in a long hall with twenty anvils, a girl with freckles and a too-big apron felt the great hearth under her hands *leap*.



TILDA CRANE TOLD HIM about it later. Weeks later. Sitting on an anvil in the Ashbourne Forge, with her feet swinging.

She'd been at the great hearth. Brannoc had kept it roaring for three days, day and night, every side-fire lit, every lantern blazing, because the fire kept the rot back from the edge of the village. She'd been feeding it. She'd been so tired.

And it had *leapt*. Under her hands. Up. Out of the hearth. A column of gold. Through the roof. Into the sky.

And it asked me, said Tilda. *Not out loud. It just—asked. Can I go? Can I go to him?*

And I said yes.



LEX FELT IT COME.

Down the Vale. Twenty miles. Not along the ground. Along the *river*. The silver river running through the green, from Ashbourne to Millbridge. Fire. Gold. Running down the water like a lit fuse. Like a wick. Every forge it passed, every kitchen hearth, every candle in every window in every village in the Vale, *leaping*, joining it. Feeding it.

A river of fire, running down a river of water, toward Millbridge.
And Kestrel lifted her hands.

Her fire came back. Not red now. *Gold*. Clean and bright and fierce. The Ashari fire, the oldest fire in the world, that the Hearth had looked at and said *it knows me*. Pouring up off her. Joining his.

And the fire came into Millbridge.



IT DIDN'T BURN THE houses. It didn't burn the sleepers. It went *around* them. Lex felt it go. Felt it find every living thread in every slumped house and curl around it, warm and gentle, the way Kestrel's fire had curled around his fingers in Ysmir's vault. Not burning. *Warming*.

And the moss on them shrivelled. And the grey on their skin went pink. And in every bed in Millbridge, people began to stir.

And the fire came to the green.

To the rows.

To the plague-dead, two hundred years in their grey moss blankets.

And it burned.

Gently. Gold. Like candles. Like a hundred candles in a hundred windows. Rising up off every one of them. And where it rose, the grey-green faces didn't twist, or scream, or burn.

They *relaxed*.

Every one. The slack peace going out of them. Something else coming in. Something Lex had seen once before, on a dead man's face in a crystal at Duskhold, when Antho said *I forgive you*.

Rest.

The girl in the brown dress was near the end of the row. He watched the gold fire rise off her. Watched her open eyes close. Watched her small grey face soften.

"*Mam*," she said. Very faintly. "*Ob. There you are.*"

And she was ash. Gold ash. Rising up off the green on the warm air, like sparks from a forge. Going up. Into the noon sky.

All of them. Row after row. Two hundred years of them. Going up in gold.



MOTHER SALLOW SAT ON her stool beside the black Stone and watched them go.

She didn't stop it. She didn't move. She sat with her knitting in her lap and her round kind face lifted to the sky, watching the gold sparks rise. Every one of them someone she'd tended. Washed. Dressed. Tucked in. Kept.

Going.

"Oh," she said. Very softly. *"Oh. They can sleep now."*

Kestrel knelt down beside her stool.

"Yes," she said.

"I kept them so long." The midwife's voice was barely a whisper. *"I was so afraid. That if I let them sleep, I'd be alone. In the church. With no one."*

"I know."

"And now I'm alone." She looked at the empty rows. At the gold ash, drifting up. *"And it's not so bad. It's quiet."* She smiled. A small, tired, grandmotherly smile. *"It's like the end of a long night. When the last one's finally sleeping. And you can sit down."*

She looked at Kestrel.

"Will you sit with me?" said Mother Sallow. *"Just for a little. Until I sleep too."*

Kestrel looked at her for a long moment.

Then she reached out. And took the midwife's grey hand in her own burning one.

"Yes," said Kestrel Varn. *"I'll sit with you."*

And Agathe Sallow, midwife of Millbridge, who had stayed when everyone else ran, closed her eyes.

And went up in gold.



THE STONE WENT SILVER.

The moss went black, then brown, then green. Real grass. Underneath, all this time. The houses straightened. Slowly. Like old men getting up from chairs. The windows cleared. And all over Millbridge, in their beds, people woke up and sat up and looked around and said *what happened? how long was I asleep?*

MOTHER SALLOW – RELEASED

"She only wanted to keep them.
Someone finally let her rest."

KESTREL VARN (unlatticed)

ATTUNEMENT – FLAME

Speaking → COMMANDING

"She burned for the one she kept.
Then she burned for the ones she let go."

Kestrel sat on the green beside the empty stool with her hands in her lap. She wasn't crying. She was looking at the sky, where the last of the gold ash was drifting up.

Tamsin came and sat beside her. He put his arm around her. She leaned into him.

"*Tam the Ram*," she said. Very quietly.

"*I hate that.*"

"*I know.*" She closed her eyes. "*You can leave, you know. Whenever you want. Go and be a farmer. Go and be stupid. You don't have to stay with me.*"

Tamsin was quiet for a long time.

"*I know*," he said. "*That's why I'm staying.*"



THE FORD WAS VERY quiet when they came back to it.

The plague-dead had come in the night. Teodra had said they would. More than ever. Every one of them, pouring out of the grey toward the causeway, toward the shield-wall, toward Ashbourne. And then, at noon, they'd stopped. All at once. And stood still on the riverbank, swaying. And then gone up in gold.

The Ashen Banners were standing on the causeway in the afternoon light. Staring at the sky. At the last gold sparks drifting away.

And Teodra Hale was sitting on the stones at the head of the line.

With her back against the parapet. With her greatsword across her knees. With her two-fingered left hand resting on the hilt.

Grey-green.

From the waist down. Soft. Mossy. Like the plague-dead. Like the sleepers in the houses. And spreading. Slowly. Up her chest. Toward her heart.

"*Anvil*," she said, when Lex came running up the causeway. Her voice was very calm. "*You did it, then.*"

"*Teodra—*"

"*One of them got me.*" She looked down at herself. "*At dawn. A big one. Went for Benno, my standard-bearer. Seventeen. First contract.*" She shrugged, very slightly. "*So I got in the way.*"

Lex knelt beside her. He put his hands on her. Fire. Gold. The way he'd burned the rot off the sleepers in Millbridge.

The grey didn't shrivel.

"*Too late*," said Teodra. "*It's been in me since dawn. Your fire'd have to burn me to burn it.*" She looked at him. "*Don't. I'd rather go soft than go up. It doesn't hurt. Ask anyone.*"

"*No—*"

"*Anvil.*" Very firmly. "*Listen to me. I've had a good run. Fifty-three years. Never turned down a stupid fight.*" She almost smiled. "*Thorne'd be furious. I was supposed to outlive him by twenty years and spit on his grave.*"

The grey was at her collarbone.

"*Tell Roole*," said Teodra Hale, "*he owes me two hundred crowns. For the ford. He'll say it was a volunteer action. It wasn't.*" Her eyes were getting heavy. "*And tell the Queen I held her road.*"

"*I'll tell them.*"

"*And Anvil.*"

He leaned close.

"*When you see him*," said Teodra. "*Thorne. In your knot, or wherever he went. If you ever see him.*" She was smiling. A real smile. Frank and unimpressed. "*Tell him I said it was a stupid fight. And I'm glad I came.*"

And her eyes closed.

And she was asleep. Soft and grey and peaceful, sitting on the stones at the head of the causeway she'd held, with her greatsword across her knees and her standard-bearer, seventeen, standing over her with the black and grey banner in his hands and tears running down his face.



LEX SAT BESIDE HER until the grey reached her heart.

It didn't hurt. She'd been right. It never did. She just went still. And softer. And then, very slowly, like the plague-dead on the green at Millbridge, she went *gold*. The rot burning off her in a quiet golden glow, from the edges in, the way the last of a fire glows in the grate.

And then she was ash. Gold ash. Rising up off the causeway into the evening air.

And her greatsword lay on the stones where she'd been. With its hilt worn smooth by a two-fingered hand.

■ ■ ■ **ALLY LOST** ■ ■ ■

TEODRA HALE

Captain, the Ashen Banners

"She never once turned down a stupid fight."



THE STORM-MOTHER CAME DOWN out of the sky at dusk.

Lex heard her before he saw her. Thunder, rolling up the Vale from the west. And then the vast storm-blue shape, coming in low over the river, with her wings spread wide and a small figure on her neck holding a lantern.

Antho slid off her shoulder onto the causeway before she'd finished landing. He looked at the Ashen Banners. At the empty place at the head of the line. At the greatsword lying on the stones. At his brother, sitting beside it, with his face in his hands.

He didn't say anything.

He came and sat down beside Lex on the causeway. And put his scarred hand on the back of Lex's neck. And left it there.

They sat like that for a long time. While the sun went down over the Vale, and the last of the gold ash drifted away on the wind, and far off at

the other end of the valley, in a long hall with twenty anvils, a girl with freckles banked the great hearth for the night and said, very quietly, *thank you*.

"Two," said Antho at last.

"Two."

"*The Cantor's gone. Pim did it.*" His brother's voice was very steady. "*And my Clarity's at a hundred. The Murmur's gone. All the way.*"

Lex lifted his head.

Antho was looking out at the dark river. His grey eyes were very clear. Clearer than Lex had ever seen them.

"Two more," said Antho. "*The Knight. And Kell.*" He looked at Lex. "*And then the Heart.*"

"*And Ilse's been waiting ten days.*"

"Eleven," said Antho. "*I counted.*" He stood up. Held out his hand. "*Come on. The river's a long way. And I promised a little girl in a drowned city I'd come back with a light.*"

Lex looked at the hand.

Then he took it, and stood up. And picked up Teodra Hale's greatsword from the stones of the causeway. And gave it, very carefully, to a seventeen-year-old standard-bearer named Benno, who held it in both hands and couldn't speak.

And went to find Ilse.

CHAPTER 30

THE FORBIDDEN LANDS



TEO BRASK MET THEM at the Teeth.

He came out of the east on Ashka's back on the morning of the fourth day, just as Vharuun was laboring up into the high cold passes with a dozen people clinging to her scales. A small round figure on a storm-drake's neck, waving both arms wildly, which nearly knocked him off.

"*Master Antho,*" he shouted across the wind. "*Master Lex! I've got it! I've got it!*"

Ashka came in close, under the storm-mother's vast wing, matching her pace. Lightning crawled along her flanks. She looked very pleased with herself.

And Teo held up his hand.

Something small glinted in it. Silver. No bigger than a thumb.

And it was *ringing*.

Lex heard it over the wind. Over the thunder of the storm-mother's wingbeats. Over everything. A tiny, clear, sweet sound. Like a drop of water falling into a still pool. Over and over. Never stopping.

On Vharuun's back, behind Lex, someone made a sound like a breaking heart.



MALACHI HELD THE BELL in both hands for a long time.

They'd come down on a ledge in the high Teeth, in the thin cold air, so Teo could climb across from Ashka. The boy had handed it over without a word. Just held it out, in his wet palm, ringing, and Malachi had taken it.

And it had kept ringing.

The old man sat on the cold rock with the little silver bell cupped in his gnarled brown hands, and looked at it. Tears were running down his face, into the creases, into his beard. He didn't wipe them away.

"It rings when I'm sad," he said. Barely audible. *"So he'd know to come and find me."*

Nobody said anything.

"It's been ringing for nine hundred years," said Malachi. *"At the bottom of the sea. Every time I was sad. He couldn't hear it. He was in the net. And then he was in the dark."* He turned it over. The tiny silver clapper swung. *Ting. Ting. "It never stopped. Not once. I was sad for nine hundred years."*

"The Undertow kept it," said Teo. Very quietly. He was standing on the ledge, dripping, with his round face solemn. *"It said it was the loudest thing in the whole deep. It said everything else down there is silent, all the lost things, and this little bell never stopped ringing."* He swallowed. *"It said it was glad to give it back. It said it had been listening to someone being sad for nine hundred years, and it was very tired of it."*

Malachi laughed. Through his tears. A cracked, broken, astonished sound.

"It said that?"

"More or less." Teo went red. *"It doesn't use words. But that's what it meant."*



"Oriel said a bell," said Lex, later. Sitting beside the old man on the ledge, with the wind howling past and the bell still ringing, very softly, in Malachi's lap. *"At the Heart. An old man with a bell."*

"Yes."

"What does it mean?"

Malachi was quiet for a long time.

"I don't know," he said. *"I don't know, smith. I'm the youngest of seven. I was never the one who knew things."* He looked down at the bell. *"But I know this. He made it so he'd hear it. Wherever he was. Whatever he was doing. If I was sad, it would ring, and he'd hear, and he'd come."* His voice cracked. *"He always came. Every time. Until the Weaving."*

He closed his gnarled hand around it. The ringing muffled. Didn't stop.

"He's at the Heart," said Malachi. *"Under the thing that wears him. The real him. What's left. You said so. Your dream. The man at the anvil who couldn't sing."* He looked at Lex. His shifting eyes were wet and very steady. *"If there's any of him left at all. Any of my brother. And I bring this to him."*

"He'll hear it."

"He'll hear it." Malachi opened his hand. The bell rang. *Ting. Ting. And maybe, for one moment, he'll come."*



THEY CAME DOWN TO the grey river on the sixth day.

Lex had heard about it. From Antho, a dozen times, in a dozen tellings. From Seraphine's notes. He'd thought he knew what to expect.

He hadn't.

It wasn't a river. It was the edge of everything. A mile-wide band of slow grey mist, flowing between the world and the dark, so flat and grey and silent that his eyes kept sliding off it. And on the far side, the Hollow. Deep and soft and blue-violet, like the inside of his own eyelids.

He felt the net thin as they came down the grey valley. Felt the Lattice go faint. Fainter. Like the Sundered Lands. Like the bottom of the Rift.

[Nine percent,] said Ember. *[Lex. I'm going to lose you again. Soon. On the other side.]*

I know.

[I'll be at the door. Like last time. I'll be right there.] A pause. *[Lex, the door's going to be right there too. On the other side. In the Hollow. The thing at the bottom of your gold. You're going to be walking toward it.]*

I know, thought Lex. *I've known since Malachi said every road goes to the Heart.*



THE FERRYMAN WAS STANDING by his boat.

Exactly as Antho had described. Tall. Thin as a heron. In a long grey robe and a wide grey hat. Eyeless. Leaning on a long grey pole with an unlit lantern swinging from its tip.

He turned his long face toward them as they came down the shingle. All of them. Lex and Antho. Wren. Ilse, walking alone, her hands clenched. Kestrel and Tamsin. Seraphine with her notebook. Malachi with his ringing bell. Teo. Oriel on her mule. And behind them, filling the grey valley, two storm-dragons.

"*Anthoren Vey*," said the Ferryman.

His voice was like rain on a slate roof.

"*You came back*," he said. "*I said you would. They always come back.*"

"*I promised someone*," said Antho. "*In the Drowned Country. A little girl. I said I'd bring a light.*"

The eyeless face turned toward the Lantern in his hand.

"*So you did*," said the Ferryman. And then, after a long pause: "*She has been waiting. At the edge of your gold light, where you left her. She has not moved.*"

Antho's hand tightened on the Lantern.



"*There is a price*," said the Ferryman. "*For each who crosses. The memory you would least wish to lose.*"

Nobody moved.

Lex had known it was coming. Antho had told him. He'd lain awake at night on the road west, thinking about it. *What's my brightest thing?* He didn't know. Wren on the roof of the Spire. His mother's floury hands. Brannoc swinging him up onto the anvil at eleven and saying *this is yours now, lad*. The stone at the millpond.

He didn't want to give up any of them.

"*No*," said Malachi.

Everyone turned.

The old man had come down to the water's edge. He was standing on the grey shingle in front of the Ferryman, small and brown and barefoot, with the silver bell ringing in his hand.

"*Ferryman*," he said. "*You know me.*"

The eyeless face turned toward him. For a long time, the Ferryman didn't speak.

"*Malachi,*" he said at last. "*Youngest of seven. Who stood beside his brother at the Weaving and said no.*" A pause. "*I know you. You have never crossed my river.*"

"No." Malachi held up the bell. "*But you know where we're going.*"

"*The Heart.*"

"*The Heart.*" Malachi's shifting eyes were very steady. "*To end the Tithe. To unmake the net. To stop the thing at the bottom of the world from drinking a tenth of every soul.*" He was quiet. "*Every thread it takes falls into your river first. Doesn't it? Every tithe. Every soul's tenth. On its way down.*"

The Ferryman was very still.

"*Eight hundred years,*" said Malachi. "*You've had a tenth of the world pouring through your water. Down into the dark. Eight hundred years of other people's mana. Other people's light.*" His voice dropped. "*Your river was clean, before. I remember. I was there when it was clean.*"

The unlit lantern on top of the Ferryman's pole swung gently in the wind off the water.

"*It was,*" said the Ferryman. Very quietly. "*It was clean. Before.*"



HE DIDN'T TAKE A price.

Lex didn't understand at first. The Ferryman simply turned, and stepped into his long grey boat, and held out his pole.

"*Get in,*" he said. "*All of you. All who are going to the Heart.*"

"*The fee—*" said Seraphine.

"*Is waived.*" The eyeless face turned toward her. "*For this crossing. For this purpose.*" A long pause. "*I have been the Ferryman of this river since before the world was made. I have carried kings and beggars and lovers and the dead. I have taken a great many memories.*" The rain-voice was very soft. "*And for eight hundred years, my river has run grey with the Tithe. I would like it to run clean again before the world ends.*"

He looked at Malachi.

"*And I will take you further than the far shore,*" said the Ferryman. "*Further than I have ever taken anyone. Down. Through the Drowned Country. Over the falls at the edge of the deep. To the Heart.*" The lantern

swung. *"The river goes there. All rivers do, in the end. I have simply never been asked."*



ANTHO WAS THE LAST to get in.

He stood on the shingle with the Lantern in his hand, looking at the Ferryman. And the Ferryman looked back.

"You said," said Antho. *"When I paid you. You said if I ever wished to see it again, I could come back to your shore. You couldn't give it back. But you could let me look."*

"I did."

"Can I?" Antho's voice was very quiet. *"Now. Before we go."*

The Ferryman was silent for a long moment. Then he reached out one long grey hand, thin as a heron's leg, and laid it on Antho's forehead.

"Close your eyes," he said.

Antho closed them.

And Lex, standing in the grey boat, watched his brother's face change.

He didn't know what Antho saw. He'd never know exactly. But he saw Antho's face go soft. Young. Younger than Lex had seen it in eleven years. He saw his brother's mouth open, very slightly, as if in surprise. He saw his eyes, behind the closed lids, moving. Following something. Something skipping across water.

He saw Antho's lips move. Counting.

One. Two. Three. Four.

And then Antho's whole face lit up. From inside. Like a window when a lamp is lit. Like a small freckled boy on a riverbank turning round with the sun coming out on his face.

Five.

The Ferryman took his hand away.

Antho opened his eyes. He stood very still on the grey shingle. His face wet.

"Oh," he said. Very softly. *"Oh. He was so small."*

He looked at Lex. Standing in the boat.

"You were so small," said Antho. *"And so furious. And then you turned round and your face—"* He stopped. Couldn't go on.

"Is it back?" said Lex. His voice cracked.

"No." Antho shook his head slowly. *"It's gone again. Already. Like a dream when you wake up."* He put his hand on his chest. Over the warm empty hollow. *"But I saw it. From the inside. My own eyes."* His mouth twisted. *"I counted, Lex. Out loud. You couldn't hear me over the heron."*

He stepped into the boat.

And sat down beside his brother. And put his scarred hand on the back of Lex's neck.

And the Ferryman pushed off from the shore.



THE DROWNED COUNTRY WAS exactly as Antho had described it.

The not-water. The drowned city. Towers of pale grey-green stone. Wide streets of cracked slabs. Doorways with no doors. And the grey dead, drifting through it all, going about errands that had ended a thousand years ago.

The Ferryman poled them down a channel between the towers. The boat slid through the not-water without a sound. Above them, the soft blue-violet dark. Below, the drowned streets.

And in the great square at the center of the city, where Vharuun had lain chained for eleven years, a light.

Gold. Faint. Flickering. Like the last of a candle.

And around it, the dead.



ANTHO WAS OUT OF the boat before it stopped.

He went down into the not-water of the square with the Lantern held high, the way he had the first time. Walking on the drowned flagstones. And the grey dead parted for him. Slowly. Like mist.

Lex followed him.

In the middle of the square, on the cracked flagstones, there was a little girl.

Faint and grey. Sitting cross-legged. With her hands held out toward something on the ground in front of her. A light. Very small. Very faint. Gold. The last ember of the Hearthglow Antho had left her, months ago,

by the edge of the drowned square. She'd carried it here. Into the middle. And sat with it.

Around her, in a ring, other grey dead. Dozens of them. Sitting. Hands held out. Toward the dying light.

The little girl looked up.

She saw the Lantern. Saw it coming toward her through the drowned dark, gold and bright and steady. Saw the man holding it.

And she *smiled*.

Lex saw it. Clear as day. A faint grey face, a child's face, lighting up the way Antho's had on the shore.

"I said I'd come back," said Antho. Kneeling. In front of her. Setting the Lantern down on the drowned flagstones beside the dying ember. *"I'm sorry it took so long."*

The little girl didn't answer. She didn't understand. She just held out her faint grey hands to the new light, and the gold of it poured over her, over all of them, the whole ring of the drowned dead, and they *leaned* into it. Like flowers toward a window.

"I can't leave it," said Antho quietly. To Lex. Not looking up. *"The Lantern. I need it. For the Heart."*

"I know."

"But I promised."

Lex knelt down beside his brother. He unslung the pack on his back. The one he'd carried from the Hollowmaw, heavy with iron. And took out what was inside.

Lanterns. Six of them. Small, squat, iron. Like his father's. The last six from the Ashbourne Forge, that hadn't cracked on the night the Choir came up, because he'd made them heavier. Not Hush-runes. Something else.

ARDENT. The first rune he'd ever learned. The rune that had lit every lantern in the Hollowmaw.

He'd made them on the road west. At night. At a little anvil in the back of a wagon. For this.

He lit them. One by one. With his own fire. And set them down in a ring on the drowned flagstones, around the little girl and the gathered dead.

Gold light. Six little suns. Warm and steady.

[Hearthglow,] said Ember. Faint. Barely there. Six percent. *[He's not doing it. You are. With Ardent.]* A pause. *[Lex, that's—that's lovely.]*

The little girl looked at the six new lights. Then up at Lex. Then at Antho.

And very slowly, she reached out one faint grey hand. And touched Antho's sleeve.

Between finger and thumb.

Antho went absolutely still.

"Oh," he said. Barely a breath.

The little girl held his sleeve for a moment. Just a moment. And then let go. And turned back to the light, and held out her hands, and was quiet.

Antho knelt there for a long time.

When he stood up, he picked up the Keeper's Lantern. And looked at the six iron lanterns burning in a ring on the drowned flagstones. And the faint grey dead, sitting around them.

"I'll come back," he said. *"When this is done. And bring more. And see if anything can be done."*

He didn't say it to anyone in particular. But the little girl looked up, once, as he walked away.



THE DROWNED COUNTRY ENDED in a waterfall.

Lex didn't know how else to describe it. The Ferryman poled them out of the drowned city and across a long flat expanse of not-water, grey and still, and at the far end of it the not-water simply *stopped*. Went over an edge. Fell. Down. Into a darkness so deep it had no bottom.

It made no sound. The not-water poured over the edge in a vast slow silent curtain, grey and shimmering, a mile wide. Falling. Forever.

"The edge of the deep," said the Ferryman. *"Beyond this, the shallows end. Beyond this is the Hollow itself."* He turned his eyeless face toward them. *"Hold on."*

And he pushed the boat over the edge.



THEY FELL FOR A long time.

Lex didn't scream. He wanted to. He held onto the gunwale of the long grey boat with both hands and Wren's arm around his waist and his eyes screwed shut, and fell, and the not-water fell with them, a slow grey silent curtain on every side.

And the Lattice went out.

He felt it. All at once. The last faint silver threads of the net, which had been thinning since the Teeth, simply—stopping. Like a candle snuffed. One moment there, faint and far. The next, nothing.

[*Lex—*] said Ember. [*Lex, I'm—*]

And Ember was gone too.

He was alone in his own head. In the dark. Falling.

And at the bottom of him, at the bottom of the gold, at the door—

Warmth.

Getting closer.



THEY LANDED SOFTLY.

The boat simply stopped falling. Lex opened his eyes. They were floating on something. Not water. Not not-water. Something darker. Thicker. Like ink. Spreading out flat and black in every direction under a sky that wasn't a sky.

He looked up.

And saw the Forbidden Lands.



It was *empty*.

That was the first thing. Not dark. Not black. *Empty*. A vast nothing, going on forever. No ground. No sky. No horizon. Just the black ink under the boat, and above it, around it, in every direction, an absence. A place where things weren't.

And in the absence, *pieces*.

Floating. Like the slabs of earth in the Sundered Lands. But not earth. *Things*. Fragments. A piece of a forest, a dozen trees, their roots dangling into nothing. Half a house, its rooms open to the void, a table still set for dinner. A street. A hillside with sheep on it, grey and still. A church. A field of wheat. A ship.

Floating. Drifting. Slowly turning in the empty dark.

"*What are they?*" whispered Wren.

"*Eaten,*" said Malachi.

He was sitting in the bow of the boat with the bell in his lap. Still ringing. Very softly. His shifting eyes had gone black, all the way. The soft black of the sky between the stars.

"*Everything the hunger ever ate,*" he said. "*Before the Weaving. Before the net. Every village. Every forest. Every life.*" He looked out at the drifting pieces. "*It doesn't destroy. It takes. And it keeps what it takes. Down here. In the dark. Forever.*"

A little way off, a fragment drifted past. A kitchen. A small one. With a hearth, cold. A table. A chair. And on the chair, a shape. Grey. Faint. A woman. Sitting. Very still. With her hands in her lap.

Waiting for someone to come home.



And everywhere, falling, *threads*.

Lex saw them. Even without the Lattice. Even without the Root. Grey. Thin. Thousands of them. Millions. Coming down out of the emptiness above like rain. Like the grey threads he'd felt running down from every Stone in the world. Falling through the void, past the drifting pieces, all at a slant, all in the same direction.

Converging.

He followed them with his eyes. Far off. Very far. Where all the grey threads came together.

And there, in the middle of the empty dark, a light.

Gold. Steady. Bright. A pillar of it. Rising up out of nothing into nothing. Like the pillar in the Wellworld of Flame. Like the column of white fire in the Ashbourne hearth. Like the light that had poured up through the crack in the lid at the bottom of the Rift.

And at its foot, small at this distance, something that looked like a mountain.

White.

With a round open forge on top of it. Under stars too close and too bright.

"*The Heart*," said Malachi.

The bell in his lap rang louder.



THEY WENT TOWARD IT.

The Ferryman poled. The black ink under the boat didn't ripple. The drifting pieces of eaten worlds slid past on either side. A forest. A schoolroom. A bridge, with no river under it. A garden full of grey roses.

Nobody talked.

And as they went, things *noticed* them.

Lex felt it first. The way he'd felt the thinned in the grey valley, in Antho's telling. Attention. From the drifting pieces. From the grey shapes sitting in eaten kitchens and standing in eaten fields. Turning. Slowly. Toward the boat. Toward the light.

Toward the Lantern in Antho's hand. The only gold thing in all that grey.

"*They want it*," said Antho quietly. "*Like the thinned. Like the drowned. They want the light.*"

"*Can you give it to them?*"

Antho looked at the Lantern. Then at the drifting pieces. Thousands of them. Going on forever.

"*Not all of them*," he said. "*Not now.*" His voice was very low. "*Later. If there is a later.*"



THE KNIGHT WAS WAITING at the foot of the white mountain.

Lex saw it from a long way off. A shape. Standing on the black ink at the place where the white mountain rose out of it. Tall. Black and silver. Four arms.

Waiting.

And as the boat came closer, he saw what it was holding.

Not swords. Not shields. Its four arms were wrapped around something. Holding it against its chest. Close. The way you hold a child.

Ivo.

Lex heard Ilse make a sound. A tiny sound. Like something tearing.

Ivo Marrow was alive. Lex could see him breathing. Held in the Twinned Knight's four black arms against its armored chest. His eyes were closed. His face was white. His mouse-brown hair was hanging over his forehead.

And he was *going in*.

Lex saw it. As the boat came closer. Saw where the Knight's black armor touched Ivo's body. His shoulder. His side. His arm. Where they touched, Ivo was *faint*. Blurred. Overlapping. Like a drawing someone had traced twice, slightly off. Like the two dead brothers inside the armor.

The Knight was pouring him in.

Slowly. A little at a time. Into the armor. Into the place where two brothers had been poured together for three hundred years.

To make three.



THE FERRYMAN STOPPED THE boat.

Fifty paces from the white mountain. On the black ink. Facing the Knight.

"*I can take you no further,*" he said. "*The Heart is not my river. It is his.*" The eyeless face turned toward the white mountain. Toward the forge on its summit. Toward the pillar of gold. "*From here, you walk.*"

Nobody moved.

And then Ilse Marrow stood up in the boat.

She was very calm. Lex saw it. All the shaking had gone out of her. All the crying. She stood in the long grey boat on the black ink of the Forbidden Lands, in her patched green coat, with her hands open at her sides. Looking at the Twinned Knight. At her brother, in its arms.

"*He made it look like nothing,*" she said. Very quietly. "*His wrist. Where I was holding on.*" She looked at her hands. "*And my hands believed him.*"

She stepped out of the boat.

Onto the black ink. It held her. Lex didn't know how. She walked on it the way Wren walked on the wind. Toward the Knight.

"*I'm a thief,*" said Ilse Marrow. Walking. "*An illusionist. I make things look like what they're not.*" She didn't hurry. "*It's the only thing I'm any good at. That and stealing pies.*"

The Twinned Knight's helm turned toward her. Both heads. Two pairs of eyes glinting through the narrow slit.

"*The other one*," said one voice. Wonderingly.

"*The sister*," said the other. "*She came*."

"*Of course she came*," said Ilse. She stopped. Ten paces from the Knight. Looking up at it. At her brother, faint and overlapping in its four black arms. "*You'd have come. Wouldn't you. If it was your brother*."

The Knight was very still.

"*We'd have come*," said one voice. Slowly.

"*We did come*," said the other. "*Into the river. When it rose. We came for each other*."

"*And drowned*."

"*And drowned*."

"*I know*," said Ilse. Very gently. "*I know the ballad. Everyone knows the ballad*." She looked at Ivo. Then back up at the helm. "*Brannoc sang it in the forge. Badly. The Knights of the Ford. Who held the crossing back to back and wouldn't let go*."

She took a breath.

"*He sang the last verse wrong*," said Ilse Marrow. "*Every time. Lex told me. He always forgot the last verse*." She tilted her head. "*Do you remember it? The last verse? How it really goes?*"

The Twinned Knight didn't answer.

But its four black arms, holding her brother, went very, very still.

And behind Lex, in the long grey boat on the black ink at the bottom of the world, Malachi's little silver bell rang, once, very clearly.

Like a note given before a hymn begins.

CHAPTER 31

THE TWINNED KNIGHT



SERAPHINE KNEW THE LAST verse.

Of course she did. Lex should have guessed. She stood up in the long grey boat on the black ink of the Forbidden Lands, with her notebook clutched against her chest and her spectacles fogged and her voice shaking, and said:

"I found it."

Everyone turned.

"In the Spire," said Seraphine. *"In the sealed vaults. When I was cataloguing."* She swallowed. *"There's a copy of the ballad. The Knights of the Ford. The oldest one. Written down two years after the battle by a priest who was there. Who saw them pulled out of the river."* She looked at Ilse, standing alone on the black ink ten paces from the Knight. *"Everyone sings it wrong. Everyone. Brannoc. Every tavern in Caldor. They all end it at the wrong verse."*

"How does it end?" said Ilse. Without turning.

Seraphine took a breath.

And sang. Badly. Her voice cracking on every note. A thin, wavering, terrible voice, in the dark at the bottom of the world.

Ob the river rose and the river ran, and the brothers stood as one, and Cael said, Corran, let me go, and live to see the sun.

And Corran said, I'll never go, I'll hold you to the last, and the water rose above their heads, and held the brothers fast.

She stopped. Swallowed. Kept going.

But under the water, the old priest said, where no one else could see, Cael let go of his brother's hand and pushed him to the lee.

And Corran felt the current take him, felt the bank beneath his heel, and turned around, and dove back down, for the brother he could not feel.

And so they drowned, the ballad says, holding each other tight. But they did not drown because they held. They drowned because each tried to let the other go, and the other one came back.

The last line didn't scan. It didn't rhyme. It was barely a verse at all. Seraphine spoke it more than sang it, in a whisper, with tears running down behind her spectacles.

The black ink was very still.



THE TWINNED KNIGHT HAD not moved.

It stood at the foot of the white mountain with its four black arms wrapped around Ivo, and its helm tilted down toward Ilse, and it didn't move at all.

But inside the helm, through the narrow slit, Lex could see the two heads. Overlapping. Slightly off. And they were *turning*. Slowly. Toward each other. As if looking at each other for the first time.

"*Cael*," said one voice. Very quietly.

"*Corran*," said the other.

"*You let go.*" The first voice was shaking. "*Under the water. You let go of my hand.*"

"*You came back.*" The second voice was shaking too. "*I pushed you to the bank. I felt you get there. I felt your heel touch. And you came back.*"

"*Of course I came back.*"

"*You could have lived.*"

"*Without you?*"

The helm trembled.

"*I let go so you could live,*" said Cael. Inside the armor. Three hundred years too late. "*And you came back for me. And we both drowned.*"

"*And the dark said,*" said Corran, "*you'll never have to let go now.*"

"*And poured us into one.*"

"*So we'd never have to choose again.*"

The four black arms were shaking now. All of them. Around Ivo Marrow. Holding him. Pouring him in.



"*He did the same thing,*" said Ilse.

She took a step forward. Nine paces.

"*My brother,*" she said. "*At the Stone. When you took him. I was holding his wrist. I wouldn't let go.*" Her voice was very steady. "*And he made his wrist look like nothing. So my hands would open. So you'd only take one of us.*"

Eight paces.

"*He let go,*" said Ilse Marrow. "*So I could live.*" She looked up at the helm. At the two heads inside it, overlapping, turning toward each other. "*And I came back.*"

Seven.

"*I came all the way down here,*" said Ilse. "*Across the grey river. Through the Drowned Country. Over the edge of the world. For him.*" She stopped. Six paces. Close enough to see her brother's face, white and faint and half-poured into the black armor. "*And now I don't know what to do. Because if I take him back, I'm doing what Corran did. Coming back. And if I don't, I'm leaving him.*"

She looked up at the Twinned Knight.

"*So you tell me,*" she said. "*You've had three hundred years to think about it.*" Her voice cracked, just once. "*Which one was right? The one who let go, or the one who came back?*"



NOBODY MOVED.

On the black ink, at the foot of the white mountain, under a pillar of gold light, a girl in a patched green coat stood six paces from a knight made of two dead brothers. And waited.

And the Twinned Knight answered.

Not with words. With its arms.

The four black arms loosened. Slowly. One by one. The way a man's hands loosen when he's been gripping something so long he's forgotten

how to open them. The black gauntlets came away from Ivo's shoulders. His side. His arm.

And where they came away, he came *back*. Solid. Whole. The faint overlapping blur of him sharpening, like a drawing being inked in. His face. His hands. His mouse-brown hair.

The Knight lowered him. Very gently. Onto the black ink. At its feet. And stepped back.

"*Both*," said Corran's voice. Very softly. Inside the helm.

"*Both were right*," said Cael's.

"*The one who lets go is right*." The first voice.

"*And the one who comes back is right*." The second.

"*It's only*," said both voices together, "*that you have to let the other one choose*."



ILSE WAS ON HER knees beside her brother.

She had his face in her hands. She was saying his name. Over and over. *Ivo, Ivo, Ivo*. And his eyes opened. Grey. Clear. Confused.

"*Ilse?*" he said. Hoarse. "*You're—where are we? What—*"

"*You made your wrist look like nothing*," said Ilse Marrow. "*You stupid—you absolute—you made your wrist look like nothing.**"

"*Oh*." Ivo blinked up at her. "*Yes. I did, didn't I.*" A pause. "*Did it work?*"

"*It worked*." She was crying. Laughing. Both. "*It worked perfectly. My hands just let go. They believed you*." She pressed her forehead against his. "*It's the best illusion you've ever done. I hate you*."

"*I know*," said Ivo. And put his arms around her. "*I hate you too. You came all the way down here*."

"*Of course I came all the way down here*."

"*You could have stayed. You could have lived—*"

"*Without you?*" said Ilse Marrow.

And Ivo stopped. And looked at her. And Lex saw him understand.

He didn't say anything else. He just held on.



THE TWINNED KNIGHT WAS coming apart.

Lex saw it. Standing in the boat with Wren's hand crushing his. The black and silver armor, so solid, so enormous, beginning to *separate*. Not breaking. Not cracking. *Untangling*. Like two threads that had been twisted together for three hundred years, slowly unwinding.

Two shapes. Stepping apart. Out of the one armor.

Two knights. Young. Younger than Lex had imagined. Twenty, perhaps. Fair-haired, both of them, with the same face, the same jaw, the same eyes. In old-fashioned mail, rusted and torn, the way it must have looked when they pulled them out of the river. Faint. Grey. Translucent. Ghosts.

But *two*.

They stood side by side on the black ink, where the Twinned Knight had stood. And looked at each other.

"*Corran*," said one.

"*Cael*," said the other.

And then they laughed. Both of them. At the same moment. The same laugh. Startled and helpless, like two boys who've just got away with something.

"*Three hundred years*," said Corran. "*In one suit of armor. With you.*"

"*You snore*," said Cael.

"*We don't sleep.*"

"*You'd snore if we did.*"

They looked at each other. And then, very simply, the way you'd reach for your brother's hand on any ordinary day, they reached out. And took each other's hands.

Not gripping. Not holding on for dear life. Just holding. Loosely. Easily. The way you hold something you've chosen to hold, and could let go of, and don't.

"*Shall we?*" said Cael.

"*Let's*," said Corran.

And the Knights of the Ford walked away together across the black ink of the Forbidden Lands. Hand in hand. Not toward the Heart. Away from it. Out into the empty dark, between the drifting pieces of eaten worlds. Getting fainter. Getting smaller.

Until they were gone.

THE TWINNED KNIGHT – UNBOUND

"They did not drown because they held.

They drowned because each tried to

let the other go."



THEY SAT ON THE black ink at the foot of the white mountain for a long time after.

Nobody wanted to move. Ilse and Ivo sat together, a little apart, holding each other. Not talking. Seraphine had sat down in the bottom of the boat with her notebook in her lap and her face in her hands. Antho was beside her, with his arm around her shoulders.

"*You sang,*" he said quietly. "*In front of everyone.*"

"*Don't,*" said Seraphine, through her fingers. "*I know. I was terrible. I've never been so terrible at anything in my life.*"

"*You were,*" Antho agreed. "*You were absolutely terrible.*" He pressed his face into her hair. "*It was the best thing I've ever heard.*"

Wren had come to sit beside Lex on the black ink. She leaned against his arm. He leaned back.

"*Hammer,*" she said. Very quietly. "*Can you feel it?*"

He could.

He'd been feeling it since the boat stopped. Since they came in sight of the white mountain. Growing. Getting closer. Not from the mountain. From *inside*.

The door.

At the bottom of the gold. At the bottom of the Root. The door he'd found in the Glass Desert, when he touched the Bit. The door that had swung wide at the Rift, when the kind voice said *come home*. The door that had been open a crack ever since.

It was *right there*. Under him. Under the black ink. Under the white mountain. As if the bottom of his own Root and the foot of this mountain were the same place.

Every road goes to the Heart, Malachi had said. *Including the one at the bottom of your gold.*

He couldn't feel Ember. Not since the waterfall. Not since the net went out. He was alone in his own head.

Except for the warmth. At the door.
Breathing.



"Up," said Malachi.

The old man had climbed out of the boat. He was standing on the black ink at the foot of the white mountain, small and brown and barefoot, with his straw hat in one hand and the little silver bell in the other.

It was ringing. Louder now. Steadily. *Ting. Ting. Ting.*

"Up," he said again. *"He's up there. At the forge. At the anvil."* He looked up at the white slope, rising out of the black ink into the empty dark, toward the round open forge at its summit and the pillar of gold light. *"Both of him."*

"Both?" said Kestrel.

"The hunger." Malachi didn't look away from the summit. *"And my brother."* He was quiet. *"I can feel them. Through the bell. The bell's ringing for him. And something's answering."* His shifting eyes were wet. *"Faintly. Very faintly. But something's answering."*

The Ferryman stood in his long grey boat on the black ink. He hadn't moved since they stopped. His eyeless face was turned up toward the summit.

"I will wait," he said. *"Here. At the foot. For whoever comes back down."* A long pause. *"If anyone comes back down, I will take them home. Without a fee."*

"And if no one does?" said Wren.

The Ferryman was silent.

"Then I will take the river home alone," he said at last. *"And it will run grey forever."*



THEY CLIMBED.

The white mountain was smooth. Like bone. Like the white stone of Avaloria, which glowed from within. It rose steeply out of the black ink, and there was no path, but it wasn't hard to climb. It was as if it *wanted*

them to climb. As if every step had been worn smooth for them, a long time ago, by someone who'd known they'd come.

Lex went first. Then Antho, with the Lantern. Then Wren. Then the others, in a long straggling line. Kestrel and Tamsin. Seraphine. Ilse and Ivo, holding hands. Teo. Oriel, on Tamsin's back now; her mule had stayed in the boat with the Ferryman. And Malachi last, slow and barefoot, with the bell ringing in his hand.

The pillar of gold light rose ahead of them. From the summit. Into the dark. Lex could feel it now. Warm. Gold. Like the knot at the bottom of the Rift. Every grey tithe-thread in the Forbidden Lands converging on it. Falling into it. Feeding it.

And under it, the warmth at the bottom of his own Root. Getting stronger. With every step.

Come up, child, it said. Very softly. For the first time since the Rift. *Come up. I've been waiting.*

He didn't answer.

He kept climbing.



HALFWAY UP, ANTHO CAUGHT his sleeve.

Lex stopped. Turned.

His brother was standing on the white slope just below him, with the Lantern in his hand and his grey eyes very dark. Not the soft black of Shade. Something else. Something Lex had never seen in them before.

Clear.

All the way through. Clear as glass. As a still pool. As the sky over the Wellworld of Gale.

"It's talking to you," said Antho. *"Isn't it. Again. At the door."*

"Yes."

"What's it saying?"

"Come up." Lex swallowed. *"It's been waiting."*

Antho looked at him for a long moment.

"At the Rift," he said. *"I held your sleeve. And pulled you back through the Bloodbond. With Shade. Quenched it."* He was quiet. *"It worked because*

I had the Murmur in me. Eleven years of the Hollow. I knew what it felt like. I knew how to hold a door against it."

"And now?"

"And now the Murmur's gone." Antho's clear grey eyes held his. "All the way. Clarity a hundred. Hollow-link severed." His mouth twisted. "I don't have a door in me anymore, Lex. I've got a house. An empty clean house with nothing in it but me."

Lex didn't say anything.

"So I don't know," said Antho. "If I can do it again. Pull you back. I don't know if I've still got the trick of it." He looked down at the Lantern in his hand. "I've spent eleven years learning how to keep a door shut. And now I haven't got one."

"You've got mine," said Lex.

His brother looked up.

"The door at the bottom of my Root," said Lex. "It's right there. Under us. I can feel it. Like a draft." He swallowed. "You know doors, Antho. Better than anyone alive. You held one for eight years from this side, and Mam held it from the other, and neither of you knew." His voice cracked. "If it opens. When it opens. Up there. You're the only one I'd trust to hold it."

Antho stood on the white slope and looked at him for a very long time.

Then he reached out. And took hold of Lex's sleeve. Between finger and thumb.

"I'm not letting go," he said.

"I know."

"Not this time. Not ever."

"I know."

They stood like that for a moment. On the white mountain. Under the pillar of gold. Two brothers. One holding the other's sleeve.

And then Antho let go. And they climbed on.



THE SUMMIT WAS A forge.

Lex had known it would be. He'd seen it in his dream, at the Hollowmaw, months ago. He'd seen it through a window of ice nine hundred years deep, in Ysmir's vault.

A great round forge, open to the dark. A floor of white stone. A ring of white pillars, broken, some of them, fallen. No roof. Above, where the sky should be, the empty dark, and in it, impossibly, stars. Too close. Too bright. Lex could almost hear them.

And in the center of the forge, an anvil.

Gold. Huge. The size of a cart. Battered and scarred by a thousand thousand blows. And from the anvil, rising straight up into the dark, the pillar of gold light. Every grey thread in the Forbidden Lands falling into it.

The Heart.

He felt it. The moment he stepped onto the white floor of the forge. The Root. All of it. Every thread in the world, the whole Lattice, the net Aurelian had forged ring by ring nine hundred years ago, *starting here*. Not tied off, like the knot at the bottom of the Rift. *Starting*. As if every thread in the world had been struck, the first time, on this anvil. And still remembered it.

And at the anvil, a man.



TALL. FAIR-HAIRED. IN A smith's leather apron over a robe of white and gold, with his sleeves rolled up and his forearms scarred. Working a bar of iron. Light and fast and precise. *Tink. Tink. Tink.*

Not singing.

He looked up.

His eyes were gold. Root gold. Bright and warm and loving. And when they found Lex, standing at the edge of the forge with his brother and his friends behind him, they *lit up*. Like a father seeing his son come home.

"*Lex,*" said Aurelian Vey. And set down his hammer. "*Oh, my boy. You came.*"

Behind Lex, the little silver bell in Malachi's hand rang.

Ting.

And Aurelian Vey's head turned.

Very slightly. Toward the sound. A small movement. A flicker. The way a sleeping man turns his head toward a voice he half recognizes.

And for one heartbeat, just one, the bright warm loving gold of his eyes went *dull*. Tired. Red-rimmed. Sad.

And his lips moved. Without sound. One word.

Mal?

And then the gold came back. Bright. Warm. Loving. And the kind face smiled.

"*Malachi,*" said the thing wearing Aurelian Vey. "*Little brother. You brought your bell.*" Its gold eyes found the old man at the back of the group. "*How lovely. I always did like that bell.*"

Malachi stood very still on the white floor of the forge. The bell ringing in his hand.

"*That's not you,*" he said quietly. "*You never once called it lovely. You said it was the worst thing you ever made. You said the clapper was crooked and it rang flat.*"

The kind face didn't change.

But behind it, very far down, Lex felt something *stir*. At the door at the bottom of his Root. Something that wasn't warm. Something that was tired and sad and couldn't sing.

Mal, it said. Very faint. From very far away. *Mal. You kept it.*

And the bell rang louder.

CHAPTER 32

UNVEILING THE TRUTH



"Sit down," said the thing at the anvil. *"All of you. You've come such a long way."*

Nobody sat.

It didn't seem to mind. It stood at the great gold anvil in the center of the round white forge, under stars too close and too bright, with its sleeves rolled up and its scarred forearms bare and a smith's hammer resting on the anvil beside it. And smiled at them. One by one. As if it were glad to see every single one.

"Wren Ashdown," it said. *"The lightfoot. Who let go of his hand in the sky. That was very brave."* Its gold eyes moved. *"Kestrel Varn. Who kept her brother. And Tamsin, who was kept. I sang to you, Tamsin, at the edge of the dark. Do you remember? You had such a lovely way of listening."*

Tamsin's face went white.

"Seraphine." The kind face lingered on her, gently, the way a host lingers on a favourite guest. *"The archivist. Who sang the last verse. Terribly."* It smiled. *"I've never heard anything so terrible. I loved it."*

"Stop it," said Antho.

The gold eyes moved to him. And softened.

"Antho," said the thing wearing Aurelian Vey. *"My poor broken boy. Not broken anymore."* It tilted its head. *"I felt you go. At the Cantor's Stone. The last of the Murmur. Like a lamp going out in a window I'd been watching for eleven years."* A small, sad smile. *"I'll miss you. You were such good company."*

"I was never your company."

"Weren't you?" It looked at him with infinite fondness. *"Eleven years, in your head. Every night. I knew you better than anyone alive. Better than your mother. Better than your brother."* Its voice dropped. *"I knew every lantern you counted."*

Antho's hand tightened on the Lantern. But he didn't say anything else.



"And Lex," it said.

It came around the anvil.

Slowly. Its boots making no sound on the white floor. Tall and fair and beautiful and tired, in its leather apron. It stopped in front of him. Close. Close enough that he could smell it: hot iron, and summer, and the inside of a bread oven. The smell of the Wellworld of Flame. The smell of every forge he'd ever loved.

"My smith," it said. *"My blood. My boy."*

"I'm not yours."

"You will be." Gently. Without any doubt at all. *"Everything is, in the end. Everything comes down here. To the Heart. Every thread. Every soul. Every road."* It spread its scarred hands. *"Do you know why?"*

Lex didn't answer.

"Because I made it so," said the thing at the Heart. *"Let me show you."*

And it lifted one hand. And touched the air between them.

And the air turned to *gold*.



HE WAS STANDING ON the white mountain.

Not the white mountain at the bottom of the Forbidden Lands. *The* white mountain. In the world. Nine hundred years ago. Under a real sky, blue and enormous, with a real sun. A round forge on its summit, new, unbroken, the white pillars standing straight. A gold anvil at its center.

And a man at the anvil. Fair-haired. Young. Younger than the thing that wore him. Thirty, perhaps. With a smith's hands and a smith's shoulders and gold eyes, bright and *alive*. Working. Striking. Over and over. Something on the anvil that glowed silver and gold and *every* color, so bright it hurt to look at.

A ring. A tiny ring. Of light. Of the river itself, bent round and closed.

He struck it. Once. And it linked through four others, already lying on the anvil. And a fifth. And a sixth.

Ring by ring, Lex thought. Link by link. Like mail.

Around the forge, at the edges, people. Six of them. Watching. A tall dark-haired woman with Antho's face: Ysmir. A broad grim man with a traveller's staff: Tarn. Two women and a man Lex didn't know. And a boy. Small. Brown. Barefoot. Twelve, perhaps. Sitting on an upturned bucket by the bellows with a bowl of soup in his lap he wasn't eating. Watching his brother work.

Mal.



"*A year,*" said the voice of the thing at the anvil. Beside him. In the vision. Fond. "*A year without sleeping. Ring after ring. Every thread in the world. Every soul.*" It sighed. "*He was magnificent. Wasn't he. The best smith who ever lived.*"

The young Aurelian struck. And struck. And the rings spread out from the anvil across the white floor of the forge, across the mountain, down the slopes, out across the world. A net. Silver. Shining. Settling over everything like frost.

"*And then he had to hold it,*" said the voice. "*From the root. From the inside. The net was forged over the hunger, and someone had to be at the center of it, holding the center down.*" A pause. "*He chose himself. Of course he did. He always chose himself. For everything.*"

The vision shifted.

The young Aurelian, standing at the anvil, with the finished net spread out over the world. And his brothers and sisters around him. And the boy on the bucket, standing up. Crying. Saying something Lex couldn't hear.

You can't cage a storm by becoming the bars.

And Aurelian, looking down at his little brother. Smiling. Tired. And saying something back.

And then putting his hand on the anvil. And going *down*. Into it. Into the gold. Into the root of the net. Like a man stepping into deep water.

And the boy on the bucket screaming his name.



"He came down to me," said the thing at the Heart. *"Willingly. To hold me. To be the bars of my cage."* Its voice was very soft. *"Do you know what it's like? To be a hunger with no shape, in the dark, for longer than the world has existed? And then to have someone come down to you. Willingly. And hold you."* A pause. *"Close. So close."*

The vision showed it. Lex couldn't look away. The young Aurelian, in the dark, at the root of the net. Holding something. Something with no shape, that ate light. His arms around it. His face set. His gold eyes fierce. Holding it down. Holding it in.

Year after year.

And the thing in his arms, slowly, patiently, *leaning in.*

"He held me for a hundred years," said the voice. *"A hundred years, in the dark, with his arms around me. Brave. Stubborn. Magnificent."* A long sigh. *"And every year, I got a little further in. Through the bars. Through his arms. Through his skin. Through his fear."* Its voice was almost tender. *"He was so afraid, Lex. Of me. Of what people did with power. Of himself. I just had to find the fear. And go in through it."*

The vision showed it. The young Aurelian's gold eyes, year after year, getting dimmer. Duller. Tired. And something else coming into them. Brighter. Warmer. *Kinder.*

"And then," said the thing at the Heart, *"there was no difference anymore. Between the bars and the thing behind them."*



THE VISION LET HIM go.

He was back in the round white forge at the bottom of the Forbidden Lands. Under the too-close stars. With the thing in Aurelian's face standing in front of him, smiling.

Behind him, he heard Malachi. Making a sound. Very small. Like the boy on the bucket.

"The Ceiling," said the thing. Conversationally. As if they'd been chatting by a fire. *"That was mine. After I had him. I sent him back up, wearing his face, and told the others: the net's not strong enough. We need a*

lid on every thread, so no one ever grows strong enough to lift the lid off me." It smiled. *"They agreed. They were so frightened. They'd do anything."*

"And the Tithe," said Lex.

"And the Tithe." The thing nodded. *"A tenth. For the binding. To keep the lid strong."* It spread its hands. *"It was for me, of course. All of it. A tenth of every soul in the world. Running down every thread. Into me."* Its gold eyes were very warm. *"Eight hundred years. Do you know how much that is? A tenth of everyone. Every day. For eight hundred years."*

"Enough to grow," said Malachi. Hoarse. From the back.

"Enough to grow." The thing looked past Lex at the old man. *"Enough to fill the Forbidden Lands with everything I've eaten. Enough to sing through a choir-master and rot through a midwife and pour two drowned brothers into one suit of armor."* It smiled at Malachi. *"Enough to wait. Patiently. For one of my blood to come down to the Heart."*



"Why?" said Seraphine.

Everyone turned. She was standing at the edge of the forge with her notebook clutched against her chest. White. Shaking. But her voice was steady.

"Why the blood?" she said. *"If you have Aurelian. If you're wearing him. Why do you need Lex?"*

The thing looked at her for a long moment. And something in its face *flickered*. Just for an instant. A ripple. Like a reflection in disturbed water.

"Clever girl," it said softly.

It turned back to Lex.

"Because he's dead," it said. *"Aurelian. Mostly. I've eaten nearly all of him. Eight hundred years. There's barely anything left."* It looked down at its own scarred hands. *"And when he's gone. When I've finished him. I'll have nothing to wear. Nothing to hold. Nothing at the root of the net. And the net will go slack. And the lid will lift."*

"And you'll be free," said Lex.

"And I'll be nothing." For the first time, the kind voice had an edge. Sharp. Hungry. *"Free in the dark. With nothing to hold. Nothing to wear."*

Nothing to eat but the dark itself. Do you know what that's like? Do you know what I was before he came down to me?"

It leaned close.

"Empty," whispered the thing at the Heart. *"Empty forever. A hunger with no mouth. In the dark. Alone."*

Lex didn't move.

"So I need another," it said. Softer again. Kind again. *"Another of the blood. To come down to the Heart. To the root. To hold me, the way he did."* It smiled. *"And then I'll have a new face. A new pair of hands. A new smith."*

"Me."

"You." Fondly. *"You've already opened the door. In the glass. When you touched my shadow. It's been open ever since. Right there. At the bottom of your gold."* It reached out and touched his chest. Over his heart. Over the Root. *"And the bottom of your gold is here. The Heart. Every Root starts here. Every Vey thread runs down to this anvil."*

Its fingers were warm. So warm.

"You're standing on your own door, Lex," said the thing in his ancestor's face. *"You've been walking toward it since the festival. Since the baker. Since the Ledger and the glass and the Rift."* Its gold eyes were very bright. *"All you have to do is open it."*



"And the prophecy," said Wren.

She was standing at Lex's shoulder. Bow in her hand. Arrow on the string. Pointed at the thing's face. Her green eyes very hard.

"The song," she said. *"At Harrowgate. The Root lies bound, the heir must come. You wrote that."*

"I did." It didn't look at her. It was still looking at Lex. *"I've written a great many things. Through a great many hands. Through Aurelian's, at first. Then through the Cantor's mouth. Through Elric's ear."* A small smile. *"The Veyes love a prophecy. They can never resist one."*

"And Ysmir'?" said Lex. *"The verse in the vault. Bow and bit and blade. The blood that bars it, the blood will pay."*

For the first time, the thing at the Heart hesitated.

Just for a moment.

"*That one,*" it said slowly, "*was not mine.*"

"No," said Malachi, from the back. Very quietly. "*It wasn't. My sister wrote it. And you hated it.*" The old man's voice was shaking. "*Because she was the Keeper of What Was. And she wrote what was true.*"



"*Why did you choose Arion?*" said Antho.

The thing looked at him.

"*Two hundred years ago,*" said Antho. "*You asked our father. Every night. For a year. Come down. Let me in.*" His clear grey eyes were very steady. "*Why him?*"

The thing in Aurelian's face smiled. Very slowly.

"*Because he was the strongest,*" it said. "*The strongest Vey in eight hundred years. And the most afraid.*" It tilted its head. "*Do you know what your father was afraid of, Antho? At thirty-one? When the Root stopped him like a clock?*"

Antho didn't answer.

"*Of being alone,*" said the thing. "*Of standing at the front of the world forever while everyone he loved grew old behind him. Of being Aurelian.*" It smiled. "*I told him I'd keep him company. Forever. I told him he'd never be alone again.*"

"*And he said no.*"

"*And he said no.*" The smile faded. Just a little. "*Every night. For a year. Not because he saw through me. Because he didn't want to be told what to do.*" It shook its head. "*The most stubborn man I've ever met. Worse than Aurelian.*"

"*So you waited.*"

"*So I waited.*" It looked at Lex. "*For someone less stubborn. And less afraid of being alone.*" Its gold eyes were very soft. "*Someone who's never been alone in his life. Who's always had a brother, and a father, and a little voice in his head, and a girl with a bow.*" It smiled. "*Someone who'd do anything to keep them.*"



ORIEL SANT LAUGHED.

Everyone turned. Even the thing at the anvil.

The old blind woman was sitting on the white floor at the edge of the forge, where Tamsin had set her down, with her black thorn stick across her knees and her red shawl around her shoulders. Her white eyes were turned toward the anvil. And she was laughing. A thin dry crackle, like dead leaves.

"*What's funny, old woman?*" said the thing at the Heart. Kindly.

"*I can't see you,*" said Oriel Sant.

The thing went still.

"*I've never seen anything in my life,*" said Oriel. "*Not with eyes. But I've always seen what's there. I saw the smith's little fire. I saw the door at the bottom of his gold. I saw a big man holding up a mountain.*" She tilted her white face toward the anvil. "*And I look at you, and there's nothing there. Nothing at all.*" She smiled. "*Just a smith's apron and a pair of scarred hands and a kind voice. Hanging on nothing. Like a coat on a hook.*"

The kind face didn't change.

But behind it, very far down, Lex felt the thing at the door at the bottom of his Root *flinch*.

"*And behind the nothing,*" said Oriel softly, "*very small. Very far down. Something that is there.*" Her white eyes were very bright. "*Tired. Sad. Holding a hammer. Trying to sing.*"

Ting, said the bell in Malachi's hand.



THE THING AT THE Heart turned away from them.

It walked back to the anvil. Slowly. And picked up the hammer. Aurelian's hammer. The great one. Not the little hand-hammer Lex carried in his belt. The one from the vision. The one that had struck every ring in the world.

"*You don't have to believe me,*" it said. Its back to them. "*It doesn't matter. Nothing you believe matters, here.*" It turned the hammer over in its scarred hands. "*Because I'm going to show you something else.*"

It struck the anvil.

Once.



The whole world *rang*.

Lex felt it. Through the Root. Through every thread. A single great note, going out from the anvil at the Heart, up the pillar of gold, up every grey tithe-thread falling into it, up and out into the world. Into every Stone. Every thread. Every soul.

And then he *saw* it.

The Heart was the start of every thread. Every Root. Every soul. And standing on it, with his own Root humming in him, he could see them all. The whole net. The whole world. As if he were standing at the top of the white mountain looking down at a map spread out below, every thread shining.

Highcrest. The Great Stone in the square. Silver. Quiet.

Saffaran. On its mesa. Burning gold with the Ashari fire.

The Wickhollow. Under the Bitter Hills. A thousand candles.

Ashbourne. The forge. Twenty anvils. A girl with freckles asleep on a bench by the great hearth.

The Hollowmaw. A cracked black door. Two lamps in a niche. A man with his hands on the glass.

And every Stone. Four thousand in Caldor. Thousands more. Every one with a thin grey thread running down from it. Down. Into the dark. Into the Forbidden Lands. Into the pillar of gold rising from the anvil.

A tenth.

And the thing at the anvil lifted its hammer again.

"*Watch,*" it said.

And struck.



The tithe-threads went *taut*.

Every one. All at once. Like the strings of a harp pulled tight. And then *pulled*. Down. Hard.

Not a tenth.

More.

Lex felt it. Felt the threads all over the world, every soul under the net, suddenly losing more than a tenth. A fifth. A quarter. Being drawn down. Through the Stones. Into the dark. Into the pillar.

And all over the world, people *faltered*.

He saw it. In Highcrest, in the dark before dawn, a city stirring in its sleep. People sitting up in their beds, gasping. Clutching their chests. Feeling something go out of them, the way you feel the warmth go out of a room when someone opens a door in winter.

In Saffaran, the Ashari fire guttering on every terrace.

In the Wickhollow, every candle flickering.

In Ashbourne, Tilda Crane jerking awake on her bench with a cry, staring at her own hands.

"STOP," shouted Lex.

The thing at the anvil lowered its hammer.

The threads went slack. The pull stopped. Not all the way. A tenth was still running down. The way it always had. But not more.

All over the world, people lay back down in their beds. Breathing hard. Bewildered.



"*That was a quarter,*" said the thing at the Heart. Mildly. "*For a moment. Just to show you.*" It set the hammer down on the anvil. Gently. "*I can take half. If I strike harder. I can take all of it.*"

It turned around.

"*I am the Tithe, Lex,*" it said. "*I am in every thread in the world. Every soul your ancestor ever caught in his net, I have my hand in. A tenth of everyone.*" Its gold eyes were very calm. "*If I pull, they come. All of them. Down to me. Every soul in the world. Emptied. Like Millbridge. Like Hollin's Rest.*"

Nobody moved.

"Or," said the thing at the Heart, "*you open the door.*"

It came around the anvil again. Slowly. And stopped in front of Lex. And held out its hand. The way Elric had held out his hand at Ysmir's vault. Patient. Reasonable. A teacher's hand.

"*Open the door,*" it said. "*Let me in. And I'll stop pulling. I'll take only the tenth. As I always have. The world will go on. Your friends will go home. Your brother will count his lanterns. Your girl will shoot her arrows.*" Its voice was very gentle. "*And you'll be the Root of the world. Forever. Like Aurelian. Like your father. Never alone again.*"

"And you'll be wearing me."

"And I'll be keeping you company." It smiled. "That's all. Just company. In the dark. At the bottom of your gold."



HE FELT THE DOOR.

At the bottom of his Root. Right there. Under his feet. Under the anvil. Under everything. Open. A crack. Warm. Breathing.

He felt the thing on the other side of it, leaning on it. Gently. Patiently. The way the Hollow had leaned on his mother's door for eleven years. The way the hunger had leaned on Aurelian for a hundred. Not pushing. Just *leaning*. Waiting for the hinges to give.

And he felt something else.

Further down. Below the warmth. Below the leaning. Very far down, in the deepest gold, where the first thread went down into the dark. Something small. Tired. Sad.

Holding on.

Lex, it said. Faintly. Through the door. Through everything. A rough voice. A voice that lost the tune. *Lex, don't. Don't. I held it for a hundred years and it still got in. Don't let it in. Look for the—*

The warmth surged. The small voice cut off.

"Ignore that," said the thing in front of him, kindly. *"That's only what's left. He's very confused, at the end."*



"Lex."

Antho. Behind him. Very quiet.

Lex didn't turn. He couldn't. He was looking at the hand held out in front of him. Scarred. A smith's hand. Like his own.

"Lex," said Antho again. *"It's lying."*

"About what?"

"About company." His brother's voice was very steady. Very clear. *"I had it in me for eleven years. It never once kept me company. It sat in my head and whispered and showed me things and wore Mam's face."* A pause. *"And I was the loneliest person in the world."*

The thing's hand didn't move. But its gold eyes flickered. Toward Antho. Just for a moment.

"It doesn't keep anyone company," said Antho. "It doesn't know how. It's a hunger. It eats." His voice dropped. "It ate Aurelian for a hundred years with its arms around him and he was alone the whole time."

Far down, at the bottom of Lex's Root, the small tired voice made a sound. Like someone weeping.

"Don't," said Antho. "Lex. Don't let it in. Whatever it does. Whatever it pulls." Lex felt his brother's hand close on his sleeve. Between finger and thumb. "We'll find another way. We always find another way."



"There isn't another way," said the thing at the Heart.

It said it very kindly. Very sadly. As if it truly regretted it.

"There's the door," it said. "Or the Tithe. That's all. I've built it that way. Every road comes here." It looked at Lex. "Choose, my boy. The door. Or the world."

And it turned its head.

Toward the edge of the forge. Toward the dark beyond the broken white pillars, where the Forbidden Lands stretched away forever, and the drifting pieces of eaten worlds turned slowly in the emptiness.

"And while you're choosing," it said, "I've sent for my Warden."



SHE CAME OUT OF the dark.

Lex saw her. Walking. Across the empty void, toward the white mountain, the way the Ferryman's boat had come across the black ink. Not on anything. Just walking. A tall gaunt figure in torn white robes gone grey. Ragged silver hair hanging in her face.

No face.

Where a face should be, *unremembered*. His eyes slid off it.

She came up the white slope. Slowly. Not looking at anyone. And stepped into the round forge, between two broken pillars. And stood there. With her hands at her sides.

"My Warden," said the thing at the Heart. Fondly. "She keeps the door. Your mother's door. At the Hollowmaw. Every night. From the inside." It

smiled at Lex. *"If you don't open your door, she'll open that one. And everything I've eaten in nine hundred years will come up through it. Into your father's face."*

The faceless woman didn't move.

But her hands, at her sides, *clenched*.

Lex saw it. The way he'd seen it through the black glass at the Hollowmaw. A tiny movement. A tightening.

As if, very far down, something in her didn't agree.



AND THEN HE HEARD it.

Behind the Warden. In the dark. Far off. Across the empty void, from the direction she'd come.

Faint. So faint. A woman's voice. Low and a little rough. As if from long disuse.

Singing.

If the dark comes calling, love, don't you mind.

He went absolutely still.

Beside him, Antho's hand on his sleeve went rigid.

A lantern's lit for the ones behind.

It was faint. It was far. It was barely there at all, coming out of the dark behind the faceless woman, following her, the way a lamp follows someone through a dark house.

And on the high note—

It went *flat*.

Just a little. Just a hair. The way it always had. Every time. In a cottage at Harrow, in the dark, when Lex was small and frightened of the noises in the walls.

The way it used to drive their father mad.

"Lex," whispered Antho. His voice was shaking. *"Lex. She's flat on the high note."*

And the thing at the Heart, standing at the anvil with its hand still held out, turned its head toward the sound.

And for the first time since Lex had known it, in the Glass Desert and the Rift and the Forbidden Lands, the kind face in Aurelian's shape looked *surprised*.

CHAPTER 33

THE UNNAMED WARDEN



SHE CAME OUT OF the dark singing.

Lex saw her. Across the empty void beyond the broken pillars of the forge, following the path the faceless woman had walked. Walking on nothing, the way everything walked here. Slowly. Like someone who has been walking for a very long time.

A woman. Small. Dark-haired. In a faded blue dress gone grey at the hem.

Faint. Not like the thinned. Not like the Unnamed. Faint the way a candle is faint at the end of a long night, when it's burned down almost to the dish and the flame is small and steady and very tired.

She was singing. Low and a little rough. Flat on the high note.

If the dark comes calling, love, don't you fear. There's a light in the window, and I'm right here.

Lex couldn't breathe.

He'd forgotten. He'd forgotten so much. He'd been eleven. Eleven years. He'd forgotten the exact color of her eyes, and the shape of her hands, and the way her hair fell when she bent over the hearth. He'd seen her in the Glass Desert, in the reflections, and it had been her, and it hadn't, because he'd forgotten too much to know.

He knew now.

Small. Dark-haired. A narrow face, with high cheekbones and a mouth that didn't smile easily. Antho's face. Ysmir's face. And eyes—

She lifted her head. She looked up the white slope. At the forge. At the broken pillars. At the people standing in it.

At him.

Grey. Her eyes were grey. Like Antho's. Like the sky between the stars. And she stopped singing.



"Seren," said the thing at the Heart.

It said it pleasantly. Lightly. The way you greet a neighbour who has turned up unexpectedly at your door.

"Seren Vey. You left your door."

Seren came up the white slope. Slowly. She didn't look at the thing at the anvil. She came to the edge of the forge, between two broken pillars, a little way behind the faceless woman in torn white robes. And stopped. And stood there.

"You left yours," she said. Her voice was low and rough and very tired. *"Eight hundred years ago. When you let the hunger in."*

The kind face didn't change.

"I've been following your Warden," said Seren. *"Since the longest night. Since you came to my door and showed me your Choir."* She looked at the faceless woman standing in the forge. *"Every night she goes to my old door, and pushes. And every night she comes back down through the dark. Alone. With no one to call her anything."* Her grey eyes were very steady. *"So I followed her. And sang to her. So she'd have something."*

"How kind," said the thing at the Heart.

"Not kind." Seren's mouth twisted. *"Stubborn. I've always been stubborn."* She looked at the anvil. At the thing standing at it, in its leather apron. *"Your Arion's worse. You told me so yourself."*



"Mam," said Antho.

It came out of him like a breath.

Seren turned her head.

She looked at him. Across the round white forge. Standing beside his brother with the Lantern in his hand and his clear grey eyes wet.

And her whole face changed.

"Oh," she said. Very softly. *"Oh, Antho."*

She didn't move. She stood at the edge of the forge with her hands at her sides. Faint. Tired. Looking at her eldest son.

"You've got so big," she whispered. *"I could feel it. Through the door. Every night. But I couldn't see."* Her voice cracked. *"You've got your father's height. And my face. Poor love."*

Antho made a sound. Something between a laugh and a sob.

"And Lex," said Seren.

Her eyes moved to him. And he felt them. Like warmth. Like a hand on his face.

"My little one," she said. *"My Lex. Who used to hide under the table when it thundered."* She looked at him for a long moment. At his shoulders. His scarred hands. His gold eyes. *"Look at you. Oh, look at you. You're the size of a door."*

"Mam," said Lex. He didn't know his voice could sound like that.

"I know, love." She smiled. Small. Tired. *Hers. "I know."*



"How touching," said the thing at the Heart.

It said it gently. Fondly. But it had turned. Away from Lex. Toward Seren. And its hand, the one it had held out to Lex, was lowered.

"Eleven years," it said. *"In the dark. Holding a door. Following my Warden. Singing."* It tilted its head. *"And now you're here. At the Heart. Where your sons are."* Its gold eyes were very warm. *"Did you think you could stop me, Seren? You? A hedge-witch from the Greyspine with a clay lamp?"*

"No," said Seren.

She walked into the forge.

Past the faceless woman. Past the broken pillars. Across the white floor. Not toward the anvil. Not toward her sons. Toward the *Warden*. She came round in front of her. And stood there. Looking up into the place where a face should be.

"I didn't come to stop you," said Seren Vey. Without looking at the thing at the anvil. *"I came to give her back her name."*



THE FACELESS WOMAN DIDN'T move.

Seren reached up. Slowly. And put her faint hand on the Warden's cheek. On the unremembered place. The place Lex's eyes kept sliding off.

"I don't know it," said Seren. *"I've been singing to her for months. In the dark. Every lullaby I know. Every song."* Her voice was very gentle. *"And I don't know her name. Nobody does."* She looked over her shoulder. At her sons. At the band of people standing in the forge. *"He took everyone who might have remembered."*

"Except one," said Lex.

He was already reaching into his coat.

The Ledger. Cold and heavy against his chest. Where it had been since Ysmir's vault. Since the White Shore. Since the Rift. He took it out. He opened it. To the last page.

Two names.

He read the first one out loud.

"Isaura Kell," said Lex. *"Of Highcrest. Fifty-eight. High Warden."* His voice was steady. *"She was carried once."*



The faceless woman *flinched*.

Hard. Like a blow. Her whole body jerking. Her hands, at her sides, clenching so tight that Lex could see the knuckles stand out, grey and faint.

"Don't," she said. Thin. Dry. Desperate. *"Don't. He said you'd say things. He said it would hurt."*

"Does it?" said Seren. Very softly. Her hand still on the woman's cheek.

The Warden didn't answer.

"Isaura," said Seren. Trying it. The way you try a key in a lock. *"Isaura. Is that you? Is that your name?"*

The faceless woman was shaking.

"I don't—" she said. *"I don't know. I don't know. It sounds—"* She stopped. *"It sounds like something I used to wear. A long time ago. Like a coat. That doesn't fit anymore."*

"It fits," said a voice.

Ilse Marrow.

She'd come forward. Out of the group. Across the white floor. In her patched green coat, with her mouse-brown hair and her grey eyes. Solid. Whole. Her brother a step behind her.

She stopped in front of the Warden. Beside Seren.

"Isaura Kell," said Ilse. "You were the High Warden. You put the Ceiling on everyone in Caldor. You put it on me." Her voice was very steady. "And at the bottom of the Rift, when the dark came for me, you shoved me out of the way. And it took you instead."

The Warden's head jerked. Toward Ilse. The unremembered place where a face should be.

"I don't—"

"You did," said Ilse. "I didn't see it. I was asleep. But Lex saw. And Ivo." She looked at her brother. "And I've been thinking about it every day since. Every day. Why would she do that? Why would the woman who capped me throw herself in front of me?"

Silence.

"And Lex told me," said Ilse Marrow. "He said: because someone carried her."



LEX SAID IT.

He'd known he would. Since the Rift. Since the Ledger. Since he'd read *she was carried once* in a dead woman's narrow elegant hand.

"Dorran Vask," he said.

The faceless woman went absolutely still.

"He was your Warden of the Kindling," said Lex. "Twenty-two years. He never complained." He swallowed. "And at the bottom of the Rift, when Elric had taken forty-one percent of you and left you on the stair to die, Dorran knelt down in front of you. And said: I'm not going to forgive you, Commander. But I'm not going to leave you either."

The Warden's hands had come up. To her face. To the unremembered place.

"And he picked you up," said Lex. "And carried you. Down the stair. And when the Rift fell, he set you down and held up the mountain so you could get away."

"Vask," whispered the faceless woman.

"Dorran Vask."

"He had very gentle hands." It came out of her like something breaking.
"For such a big man."

And her face came back.



NOT ALL AT ONCE. Slowly. The way a face comes clear through a frosted window when someone breathes on the glass. The unremembered place, *remembering*. Lex saw it. Saw a jaw come back. A thin mouth. High cheekbones. Hollow cheeks. Sunken eyes, pale grey, wide and wet and staring.

Isaura Kell.

Gaunt. Grey. Faint. Standing in the round white forge at the Heart of the world, in her torn white robes, with Seren Vey's hand on one cheek and Ilse Marrow standing in front of her.

She looked at Ilse.

"You," she said. Barely a whisper. "*The thief. From the Rift. The faded one.*"

"*Not faded anymore,*" said Ilse. "*Elric wrote me back. At the end.*" She held up her hand. Solid. "*Because you pushed me out of the way first.*"

Kell stared at her hand.

And then she put her own hands over her face. Her own face. And bent forward. And her shoulders shook.

Seren put her arms around her.

Just like that. A hedge-witch from the Greyspine, holding the former High Warden of the Order in the middle of the Heart of the world. Holding her the way she'd held her boys when they were small and frightened of the noises in the walls.

"*There,*" said Seren Vey. Very softly. "*There. There you are. Isaura.*"



ISAURA KELLTHREAD:  (beyond the net)

NAME: RESTORED

Speakers: Lex Vey, Ilse Marrow,
Seren Vey

Anchor: DORRAN VASK (deceased)

"Some anchors outlast the hand that
set them. Some names outlast the
dark that ate them."

THE PANEL CAME UP in gold, over Kell's bowed head, hanging in the air of the forge. Lex didn't know how. There was no net here. No Lattice. But it came anyway. As if the Heart itself had written it.

[Lex—]

He nearly fell over.

Ember.

[I'm here,] said Ember. Faint. So faint. Like a voice from the bottom of a well. *[I'm at the door. I've been at the door the whole time. Since the waterfall. Since the net went out.]* A pause. *[You're standing on it, Lex. The Heart. It's the bottom of the Root. I could feel you get closer and closer and I couldn't reach you and then you said her name, and the Heart wrote it down, and I—]*

You can hear me?

[I can hear you. A little. Through the Heart. Through the door.] Ember's voice was shaking. *[Lex. The thing. On the other side of the door. It's angry. I've never felt it angry before.]*



THE THING AT THE Heart had not moved.

It stood at the gold anvil with its hammer in its hand and its kind face turned toward the edge of the forge, where Seren Vey was holding Isaura Kell. And it didn't say anything.

But the kind face was *slipping*.

Lex saw it. Not a flicker now. A slide. Slow. Like wax melting. The fair hair, the gold eyes, the tired beautiful features of the smith who had sung at his anvil, sliding down off something that wasn't there. And under it, for

longer and longer each time, the hole. The hunger. A shape cut out of the dark, Aurelian-sized, with nothing inside.

"Warden," it said.

The voice wasn't kind. It wasn't warm. It was *enormous*. It came from the anvil and the pillar of gold and every grey tithe-thread falling into the Heart, all at once.

"WARDEN. YOU ARE MINE. I GAVE YOU A NAME. I GAVE YOU A DOOR."

Isaura Kell lifted her head from Seren's shoulder.

She looked at the thing at the anvil. Her pale grey eyes very red. Her gaunt face very still.

"You did," she said. Her voice was thin and dry and precise. A voice that had given orders for twenty years. "You gave me a door. The one at the Hollowmaw. You said it was mine now."

"IT IS MINE. YOU ARE MINE."

"No," said Isaura Kell. "You said the door was mine."

She stepped back from Seren. Gently. She turned to face the anvil. She stood very straight in her torn white robes, in the middle of the forge at the Heart of the world, the way she must have stood at the head of the High Council for twenty years.

"I was High Warden of the Order," she said. "I know about doors. I know about Wardens. I know what it means to be given one to keep." She lifted her chin. "A Warden decides who comes through. That's what the word means."

And she reached.



LEX FELT IT. THROUGH the Heart. Through the Root. Through every thread that ran down from the world into the Forbidden Lands.

A pipe. One pipe. The last one. The widest. Running down from a cracked black door at the bottom of a mountain hung with a thousand lanterns. Held open, every night, for months, by a faceless woman pushing from the inside.

Kell reached down it. With the authority she'd been given. The Warden of the door.

And closed it.

Not slammed. Not sealed. *Closed*. The way a careful person closes a door behind them when they leave a room. Firmly. Finally. And turned the key.

Far away, through the Root, Lex felt the black glass door at the bottom of the Hollowmaw *settle*. Felt the crack across its face, that had been there since the night of the Blade, draw together. Felt it seal. Not by anyone pushing. By someone on the inside, deciding.

And felt, faint and far, a man with his hands on the glass sit back. And look at the two lamps in the niche. And put his face in his hands.

"*It's closed*," said Isaura Kell. Very quietly. "*I'm the Warden. I've decided. Nothing comes through.*"

THE HOLLOWMAW THRESHOLD – SEALED

Warden: ISAURA KELL (by gift)

"A Warden decides who comes through."



THE THING AT THE anvil *screamed*.

Not a voice now. The kind face was gone. All of it. Slid off. And what stood at the anvil was a *hole*. A hunger. A shape cut out of the white forge, tall and narrow, with nothing inside it but dark. The smith's apron hung on it like a coat on a hook. The scarred hands holding the hammer were the only solid things.

And the scream went out through the Heart. Up the pillar of gold. Up every tithe-thread.

Into the world.

Lex felt it hit. Every Stone. Every thread. Every soul.

Pulling.

Not a quarter. Not a third. *Half*. More. The tithe-threads going taut as bowstrings, all over the world, and *yanking*. Down. Hard. Every soul under the net losing more than half of what they were in a single terrible heartbeat.

And all over the world, people *fell*.

He saw it. Through the Heart. Highcrest. People collapsing in the streets, in their beds, at their tables. Clutching their chests. Going grey. Going faint. Saffaran. The Ashari fire guttering out on every terrace. The

Wickhollow. Every candle going out at once. Ashbourne. Tilda Crane on her knees by the great hearth, gasping, her freckled face going pale.

Brannoc. Hedda. Mother Orla. Quill on the chimney, toppling.

His father, at the Hollowmaw. Sliding sideways onto the black floor beside the sealed door.

Everyone.



"STOP—"

He didn't know he'd shouted it. He was on his knees on the white floor. He felt it in himself too. The pull. Going down through his own thread. Taking. A tenth. A quarter. Half. His strength going out of him like water out of a cracked jug.

Beside him, Wren had fallen. Her bow clattering on the white stone. Antho was on one knee, gripping the Lantern, his face grey.

Behind him, the others. Going down. Kestrel. Tamsin. Seraphine. Teo. The twins. One by one. Like wheat in a gale.

Only three stood.

Oriel Sant. Sitting on the white floor at the edge of the forge, with her black stick across her knees. Untouched. She'd never had a thread. Never been in the net. Nothing to pull.

Malachi. Small and brown and barefoot. The Last Listener. Unlatticed. Standing at the edge of the forge with the silver bell ringing in his hand. Ringing so loud now that it was almost a scream.

And Seren. Faint and grey and very tired, holding Isaura Kell. Neither of them had threads anymore. They were beyond the net. In the dark. Where the Tithe couldn't reach.



THE HOLE AT THE anvil turned toward Lex.

It didn't have a face. It didn't have eyes. But he felt it look at him. The way he'd felt it look at him through his own eyes in the Glass Desert. Through the door at the bottom of his Root.

"OPEN," it said. "*THE. DOOR.*"

The pull went up. Further. Sixty percent. Seventy.

All over the world, people stopped moving.

"OPEN IT, OR I TAKE THEM ALL. EVERY SOUL. EVERY THREAD. DOWN. INTO ME. NOW."

Lex knelt on the white floor of the forge with his hands flat on the stone and felt the world going out of everyone he'd ever loved.

[Lex,] said Ember. Faint. Desperate. [*Lex, don't. Don't. It's what it wants. It's what it's always wanted—*]

I know.

[*Then—*]

Ember, thought Lex. *Listen to me. Are you at the door?*

A pause.

[*Yes.*]

Right at it?

[*Right at it. I'm sitting on the doorstep. I haven't moved since the waterfall.*]

Is anyone else there?

Another pause. Longer.

[*Yes,*] said Ember. Slowly. [*Yes. Further down. Below the door. Very far down. Something small. Tired.*] A pause. [*It's been trying to talk to you. The whole time we've been here. It keeps saying the same thing.*]

What?

[*Look for the flaw,*] said Ember. [*Over and over. Look for the flaw.*]



LEX TURNED HIS HEAD.

His brother was beside him. On one knee. Grey-faced. The Lantern in his hand, guttering. His clear grey eyes on Lex's face.

"*Antho,*" said Lex.

"*Don't.*" It came out of his brother like a groan. "*Don't you dare. Don't you—*"

"*Hold my sleeve.*"

Antho stared at him.

"*Hold my sleeve,*" said Lex again. "*Like you promised. Between finger and thumb.*" His voice was very steady. He didn't know how. "*And when it goes through, don't let go.*"

"*When what goes—*"

"When I open the door," said Lex.

He turned back to the anvil.

To the hole. The hunger. The thing standing in a smith's apron with a hammer in its hands, pulling the world down into the dark.

"All right," said Lex Vey. *"I'll open it."*



THE PULL STOPPED.

All at once. Like a held breath let out. The tithe-threads going slack. All over the world. People gasping. Lying where they'd fallen. Breathing.

The hole at the anvil was very still.

And slowly, slowly, the kind face came back. Slid back up over the dark, like a mask being put on. Fair hair. Gold eyes. The tired beautiful features of the smith who had sung at his anvil. Smiling.

"My boy," it said. Warm again. Kind again. Loving. *"Oh, my boy. I knew you would."*

"Lex," said Wren. From the floor. Her voice cracked. *"Lex, no—"*

"I know," he said. Without looking at her. *"I know, Wren. Trust me."*

He felt her go still.

Trust that if he goes into the dark, he will come back out, the First Breath had said. In the sky. *Not because you held on. Because he will.*

"I'll come back," said Lex. *"I always come back. Because you're there."*

He heard her breathe. Once. Shaking.

"You'd better," said Wren Ashdown. Very quietly. *"Hammer."*



HE FELT ANTHO'S FINGERS close on his sleeve.

He stood up.

He walked across the white floor of the forge. Toward the gold anvil. Toward the pillar of light. Toward the thing in his ancestor's face, standing with its scarred hand held out, waiting.

He stopped in front of it.

"Not like that," he said.

The kind face tilted.

"Not with your hand," said Lex. *"Not out here. If you want in, come through the door. The way you came into him."* He nodded at the face it was

wearing. *"The way you came into my father's dreams, and Antho's head, and Elric's ear. Come through the bottom of the gold. Where you've been waiting."* He swallowed. *"I'll open it from my side."*

The thing looked at him for a long, long moment.

Its gold eyes were very bright.

"You're afraid," it said softly. *"I can feel it. All the way through you. You're so afraid, Lex."*

"Yes."

"Good." It smiled. *"That's how I get in."*

And it put its hand on the anvil.

And went *down*.



LEX FELT IT GO.

Down. Into the anvil. Into the gold. Into the Heart. Into the root of every Root. The way Aurelian had gone down, nine hundred years ago, with his little brother screaming on a bucket. The smith's apron and the scarred hands and the kind face, sinking into the gold anvil like a man stepping into deep water.

Gone.

And at the bottom of his own Root, at the door—

Pressure.

Warm. Gold. Enormous. Leaning. On the other side of the door that had been open a crack since the Glass Desert. Leaning *hard*. The whole weight of it. Everything it had eaten in nine hundred years. Pressing.

Open it, child, said the voice. From right there. Right on the other side. *Open it. You promised.*

He closed his eyes.

He went down. Into himself. Into the gold. Down and down, past his own thread, past his brother's twined around it, past his father's and his mother's pale silver line. Down to the bottom. To the door.

Ember was sitting on the doorstep.

He couldn't see it. There was nothing to see. But he felt it. A small warm gold presence, humming, sitting right in front of the door with its

back against it. The way his mother had sat against the door at the Hollowmaw. The way Antho had sat against the breach.

[Lex,] it said. Very quietly. [Are you sure?]

No.

[All right.] A pause. [I'll be right here.]

And far, far down, below the door, below everything, in the very deepest gold where the first thread went down into the dark, something small and tired and sad that couldn't sing said:

Oh, child. Oh, no. Not you. Not one of mine.

It's all right, thought Lex. I'm looking for the flaw.

And he put his hand on the door.

And opened it.

CHAPTER 34

REBORN IN LIGHT I



INSIDE, IT WAS THE forge.

Lex had never known that. He'd been in the Root a thousand times. Reached into it, drawn on it, gone down into it once at the bottom of the Rift and looked at the threads. But he'd never been *inside* it. Never stood in it. Never seen what it looked like from the inside of himself.

It looked like the Ashbourne forge at night.

The long low hall. The smell of coal-smoke and hot iron and leather. The great hearth at the far end, banked down to a red glow. The anvil in front of it, black and battered, with a horn worn smooth by fifty years of Brannoc's hammer. The racks of tools on the walls. Tongs and hammers and punches and swages, every one of them in its place.

And hanging from the rafters, *chains*.

Hundreds of them. Thousands. Hanging down from the dark beams overhead like the lanterns in the Hollowmaw. Each one a different metal. Iron and copper and bronze and silver and gold. Each one glowing, faintly, from within.

He reached up and touched one. Iron. Warm.

Brannoc swinging him up onto the anvil at eleven. This is yours now, lad.

Another. Copper.

Wren on the roof of the Spire. The wind in her hair. Laughing.

Another. Silver. Very old. Very thin.

A woman bending over a hearth. Flour on her hands. Singing. Flat on the high note.

[They're you,] said Ember. [All of them. Everything you are. Every memory. Every thread. Hanging up in the forge like tools waiting to be used.]

He turned.

Ember was sitting in the hearth.



IT WAS A COAL. A single coal, in the middle of the great hearth's red glow. Bigger than the others. Brighter. Gold. Humming. He'd never seen it before. Not once in four years. Only heard it.

[Hello, Lex,] said Ember. [Welcome home.]

He couldn't speak.

[I know,] said the coal in the hearth. [I know. I'm smaller than you thought. Your father made me out of a piece of himself the size of an ember. I suppose I should have expected it.] A pause. *[I've always lived here. In your hearth. Keeping the fire in.]*

"The door," said Lex. His voice echoed in the long dark hall. "Where's the door?"

The coal pulsed. Toward the end of the hall. Not the end with the hearth. The other end.

The great double doors of the forge. The ones that opened onto the yard. The ones Lex had walked out of every morning of his life since he was eleven, to fetch water from the well.

They were open.

Not wide. A crack. And through the crack, light. Gold. Warm. *Pouring.*



IT CAME IN LIKE a flood.

Lex watched it. Standing in the middle of his own forge, with the chains of his whole life hanging overhead. Watched the gold come through the crack in the great double doors. Not like light. Like *honey*. Thick. Warm. Slow. Pouring across the stone floor of the forge in a spreading tide. Lapping at the legs of the benches. At the base of the anvil.

And where it touched, things went *soft*.

He saw it reach the first rack of tools by the door. Tongs. Old ones. His first pair. The gold flowed up over them, gently, the way water flows over a

stone. And the tongs *melted*. Not into the gold. Into *nothing*. Gone. And with them—

He reached for it. In himself. The memory of his first tongs. Brannoc handing them to him at eleven. *Mind your fingers, lad.*

Gone.

He couldn't remember. He knew there'd been something. He could feel the shape of it. A warm smooth hollow, the size of a pair of tongs. But nothing in it.

[It's eating,] said Ember. Very quietly. *[It's eating you, Lex. Starting at the door.]*

"I know."

[Then shut it.]

"Not yet."



THE GOLD CAME IN. And in. Spreading across the floor of the forge. Climbing the walls. Reaching for the chains hanging from the rafters.

And in the middle of it, rising up out of the flood the way the Hearth had risen out of the lake of white fire, a shape.

Tall. Fair-haired. In a smith's leather apron over a robe of white and gold. With scarred forearms and gold eyes and a kind, tired, beautiful face.

It stood in the middle of the forge, ankle-deep in its own gold, and looked around. At the hearth. At the anvil. At the chains of Lex's life, glowing in the rafters.

And smiled.

"Oh," said the thing in Aurelian's face. *"Oh, Lex. It's lovely. It's just like his."*

It walked to the anvil. Brannoc's anvil. Black and battered. And put its scarred hand on it.

"He had a forge like this," it said softly. *"Inside. When I first came in. Smaller. Older. A forge on a white mountain under stars."* It ran its hand along the horn of the anvil. *"I lived in it for eight hundred years. I ate it one tool at a time."* It looked up at the chains. *"Yours is bigger. Fuller. So many people. So many memories."* Its gold eyes were very bright. *"It'll last me a long time."*



"*Now*," said Lex.

He didn't say it to the thing at the anvil. He said it to the door. To the great double doors of the forge, standing open, with the gold pouring through.

To his brother.

He'd felt Antho all along. Through the Bloodbond. Through the thread that ran from him to his brother, twined around his own like a vine, dark and cold and steady. Felt his brother's fingers on his sleeve, out there, in the round white forge at the Heart. Holding. Between finger and thumb.

When it goes through, don't let go.

He felt Antho come *in*.



NOT INTO THE FORGE. Into the *doorway*.

Lex saw it. Saw a shape appear in the crack between the great double doors, where the gold was pouring through. Tall. Lean. Dark-haired. In a dark blue coat. With a lantern in his hand.

Antho.

Standing in the doorway of Lex's Root. Not inside. Not outside. *In* the door. On the threshold. With the gold pouring past him on either side, and his clear grey eyes very calm.

He'd had a door in him for eleven years. The Hollow, pressing through, every hour of every day. He'd held a breach for eight years. He'd counted lanterns in front of a black glass door for three. He'd stood beside his mother's door, and his father's, and watched Isaura Kell close the last one from the inside.

He knew doors.

Better than anyone alive.

"*Hello, Lex,*" said Antho. In the doorway. "*Nice forge.*"

The thing at the anvil turned its head.

And for the first time, Lex saw it understand.



"No," it said.

It said it softly. Almost wonderingly. It stood at Brannoc's anvil, ankle-deep in its own gold, and looked at the man standing in the doorway.

"No," it said again. *"You can't. You've got no door. I left. I felt you empty. Clarity a hundred. Hollow-link severed."*

"I've got no door in me," Antho agreed. *"That's right. You left. It's an empty clean house with nothing in it but me."* He lifted the Lantern. *"Which means I can stand in a doorway without anything pulling me through."*

The gold was still pouring past him. Through the crack. Into the forge. But slower now. Thinning.

"You came off the anvil," said Antho. *"The Heart. Where every thread starts. Where the Tithe runs in."* His voice was very calm. *"You came off it and went down into my brother's door. All of you. Everything you are. Because he said he'd open it."* He looked at the thing at the anvil. *"And you're in now. All the way. Off the Heart. Off the Tithe. In here."*

The gold stopped pouring.

The last of it trickled through the crack, past Antho's boots, onto the floor of the forge.

"And I'm closing the door," said Antho Vey.



HE PUT HIS HAND on the great double doors.

Not pushing. Not slamming. The way Isaura Kell had closed the Hollowmaw door. The way a careful person closes a door behind them when they leave a room.

He drew them shut.

And turned the key.



LEX FELT IT THROUGH everything.

Through the Root. Through the Bloodbond. Through the Heart, outside, where his body stood at the gold anvil with his brother's fingers on his sleeve. A *click*. Small. Final. Like a lock turning in a door the size of a man.

And then *silence*.

Not inside. Inside, the thing at the anvil was screaming. Lex could hear it. Feel it. But *outside*. In the world. Through the Heart. Through every Stone and every thread.

The tithe-threads went slack.

All of them. All over the world. Every grey thread running down from every Stone into the Forbidden Lands, into the pillar of gold at the Heart. *Slack*. Like the strings of a harp when the harper takes his hands away.

Nothing was pulling.

Because the thing that had pulled was in Lex's Root. Behind a closed door. With his brother standing on the threshold.

██	ROOT — INTERNAL	██
█	THRESHOLD: SEALED	█
█	Warden: ANTHOREN VEY	█
█	Contained: ██████████	█
█	TITHE-LINK (Heart): SEVERED	█
█	(host absent)	█



AND OUTSIDE—

Lex didn't see it. Not then. He heard about it after. From Wren, and Seraphine, and Oriel, and Seren, all of them telling it a little differently, the way people tell things that are too big for one telling.

He heard that his body stood at the gold anvil in the round white forge with its eyes closed and its hands flat on the anvil, very still.

He heard that his brother knelt beside him, with his fingers on his sleeve and his own eyes closed, and his face gone absolutely calm. Like a man asleep. Like a man standing in a doorway.

He heard that a panel came up over Antho's head. In silver and gold and violet, all at once. In the middle of the Forbidden Lands, where there was no net.

ANTHOREN VEY

Class: TWILIGHT WARLOCK (Unique)

→ THRESHOLD WARDEN (Unique)

TIER IV

"One who stands in the doorway between
dark and dark, and decides."

Level 64 → 79

ATTUNEMENT

Shade COMMANDING

Gale SPEAKING

Tide ANSWERING

He heard that Seraphine read it, sitting on the white floor where she'd fallen, with Kestrel's arm around her. And started to cry. And couldn't stop.

And he heard that all over the world, at that moment, people who had fallen sat up. And breathed. And felt something come *back*. Not all of it. Not the half the hunger had pulled. But the pulling had stopped. And the tenth that had always run down, every day, for eight hundred years, had stopped running.

For the first time since the Weaving, nobody in the world was paying the Tithe.



INSIDE, THE THING AT the anvil turned around.

Slowly. In Lex's forge. Ankle-deep in its own gold. And looked at him. The kind face was gone.

Not slid off. *Dropped*. Like a mask thrown on the floor. And what stood at Brannoc's anvil in the long dark hall was the hole. The hunger. A shape cut out of the inside of Lex's own Root. Tall and narrow. With nothing inside it. With a smith's leather apron hanging on it and two scarred hands at the ends of its arms.

"*You tricked me,*" it said.

Not a voice. A *pressure*. Coming from everywhere in the forge at once. From the gold on the floor. From the dark between the rafters. From inside Lex's own chest.

"*You opened the door to shut it behind me.*"

"*Yes,*" said Lex.

"*You've locked me in with you.*"

"*Yes.*"

"*Do you understand what that means?*" The pressure was enormous. Lex felt it in his bones. In his teeth. "*I'm off the Heart. I'm off the Tithe. I've got nothing to eat but what's in here.*" The hole turned. Toward the chains. Hanging from the rafters. Glowing. "*And there's so much in here, Lex.*"

And the gold on the floor *rose*.



IT CAME UP THE walls like a tide. Fast now. Not slow and warm and patient. *Hungry*. Climbing the racks of tools. Pouring over the benches. Rising toward the rafters. Toward the chains.

Lex saw it reach the first one.

Iron. Low-hanging. Near the door.

Brannoc swinging him up onto the anvil at eleven.

The gold flowed over it. And it went soft. And then it was gone.

He reached for it. In himself. And there was nothing. A warm smooth hollow. The shape of a big bald bearded man, and an anvil, and the word *lad*.

Brannoc, he thought. *Brannoc. I know that name. Who—*

He knew. He knew Brannoc. Brannoc Holt, the smith of Ashbourne. Sixty-one. Bald. Who'd raised him. He knew all of that. Facts.

But the moment on the anvil was gone. The warmth of it. The weight of Brannoc's hands under his arms. *This is yours now, lad.*

Gone.

The gold rose. Another chain. Copper.

The first time he heard Flame. In Malachi's hearth. Fire leaning toward his hands.

Gone.



HE FOUGHT.

He didn't know how. Not in here. Not inside himself. But he tried. He lit his hands. Flame. Commanding. Gold-white fire roaring up off his fingers in the long dark hall of his own Root. And threw it at the rising gold.

And the gold *ate* it.

Of course it did. It was the hunger. It had eaten the Sunwell's people and the Drowned Country and every eaten world drifting in the Forbidden Lands. It ate fire. It ate light. It ate everything.

He tried Stone. He put his hands on the floor of the forge and asked the bedrock under it to rise. And it rose, a little, slow and grudging. And the gold flowed over it and it went soft.

[Lex,] said Ember. From the hearth. Its voice was shaking. [Lex, it's no good. You can't fight it in here. It's in you. Everything you throw at it is you. It just eats it.]

Then what?

[I don't know. I don't know.] The coal in the hearth was flickering. *[Lex, it's getting closer to the hearth. It's going to eat me too. And then the fire goes out. And then—]*

And then it has me.

[And then it has you.]



THE GOLD ROSE. CHAIN after chain.

Wren in the dust of the south road below Highcrest. You can hit me now.

Gone.

The Hearth, in the Wellworld of Flame. Keep asking, smith.

Gone.

Dorran at the plowshare. Huh.

Gone.

He stood in the middle of his own forge with the gold rising around him and his memories going out one by one like lanterns in a passage, and felt himself getting *smaller*. Fainter. Less. Like the thinned in the grey valley. Like the man with the rubbed-out face.

Lex Vey, he thought. Lex Vey. Twenty-two. Forgeheart Sorcerer. I—

He couldn't remember what came next.

I make things, he thought. I'm a smith. I—

The gold was at his knees.

And the hole stood at the anvil, in its apron, watching him. Patient again. Calm again. It had all the time in the world. It had waited nine hundred years.

"It doesn't hurt," it said. Softly. "Ask anyone."



Look for the flaw.

It came from very far down.

Not from the hearth. Not from Ember. From *below*. Below the floor of the forge. Below the gold. Below everything. From the very deepest part of Lex's Root, where his own thread ran down into the gold and joined his father's, and his father's joined his grandfather's, and on and on, down and down, to the first thread of all.

The thread that ran down from this forge, through every Vey who had ever lived, to a gold anvil on a white mountain. To the Heart.

And down that thread, from the Heart, from the very bottom, something had come in with the hunger. Through the door. Riding it. The way a splinter rides into a hand on the end of a stick.

Look for the flaw, child.

Lex looked down.

At the gold. Rising round his knees. Thick. Warm. Endless.

And in the gold, deep, very small, *something*.



HE WENT DOWN.

He didn't know how. He just did. The way he'd gone down into the Root at the Rift, looking for Ember. He let himself sink. Into the gold. Into the hunger. Into the thing that was eating him.

It was warm. So warm. It closed over his head like the not-water of the Drowned Country. Like the grey river. Like honey. He felt it going into him. Taking. Chain after chain.

He kept going down.

Through the gold. Through the hunger. Deeper. To the bottom of it. To the place where it had come from. The place it had been folded.

And there, at the very bottom, curled up in the dark like a child asleep—

A man.



SMALL. SMALLER THAN LEX had ever imagined. Curled on his side in the deepest dark at the bottom of the gold, with his knees drawn up and his scarred arms wrapped around them. Fair-haired. Grey now, mostly. Thin. So thin.

In the remains of a smith's leather apron. Torn. Scorched.

Holding a hammer.

Not the great one. A little one. A hand-hammer. Worn smooth. With faint gold runes on its cheeks.

Lex knew that hammer. It was hanging on his own belt. Out there. In the world. On his body, at the anvil, at the Heart.

The man lifted his head.

His eyes were gold. Root gold. But dim. So dim. Red-rimmed. Tired beyond anything Lex had ever seen. The eyes of a man who has been holding something for nine hundred years.

"*You came,*" said Aurelian Vey.

His voice was rough. Cracked. It lost the tune even when it wasn't singing.

"*Oh, child. Oh, I'm sorry. I'm so sorry. I told you not to.*"



"*You're the flaw,*" said Lex.

He didn't know how he knew. He just did. The way he knew when iron was ready. The way he'd known in the Glass Desert that the Sunwell was grieving.

Aurelian looked at him for a long time.

"*Yes,*" he said at last. "*I'm the flaw.*"

He uncurled. Slowly. Painfully. Like an old man getting up from a chair. He sat up in the dark at the bottom of the hunger, with the little hammer in his lap.

"*It made itself out of me,*" he said. "*Over a hundred years. Ring by ring. It took my rings, the ones I'd forged for the net, and folded them into itself. Into a shape. A face. A voice.*" He looked down at his scarred hands. "*It*

needed a shape. It never had one before. It was just hunger. Just mouth." His mouth twisted. *"So it took mine."*

"And you were never very careful with your folding."

Aurelian laughed. Cracked. Broken. Startled.

"Who told you that?"

"You did." Lex knelt in the dark across from him. *"In a dream. At the Hollowmaw. And Malachi. He said you used to say it to him. When something you'd made went wrong."*

"Mal." The old man's face changed. Lit up. Faintly. Like a candle in a far window. *"Mal said that? He remembers?"*

"He's here," said Lex. *"At the Heart. Outside. He brought his bell."*

Aurelian Vey went absolutely still.

"His bell," he whispered. *"The little one. Silver. With the crooked clapper."* His voice broke. *"I made that. When he was six. So I'd know when he was sad."*

"It's been ringing for nine hundred years," said Lex. *"At the bottom of the sea. Teo got it back. It's ringing now. Out there. As loud as it can."*

The old man put his face in his hands.



"I can hear it," said Aurelian. Through his fingers. *"I've been hearing it. Since you came to the Heart. Very faint. Through all of this."* He gestured, weakly, at the gold above them. The hunger. Pressing down. *"I thought I was imagining it. I've imagined so many things."*

"You're not."

"No." He lifted his face. Wet. Tired. *"No. I know that ring. It's flat. The clapper's crooked. I never fixed it."* A sound that might have been a laugh. *"I was never very careful with my folding."*

Above them, the gold pressed down. Lex felt it. Felt it eating. Another chain. Another. *Seraphine at the bottom of the sea. I'm not afraid anymore. Gone. The Undertow. I promise. Gone.*

"It's eating you," said Aurelian. Quietly. *"Isn't it. Up there. In your forge."*

"Yes."

"It ate me too. A tool at a time. For eight hundred years." He looked up. *"There's only me left now. This. Curled at the bottom. Holding on."* He held

up the little hammer. *"And this. The first thing I ever made for myself. Before the net. Before anything."*

"I've got it," said Lex. *"Out there. On my belt. Malachi gave it to me."*

"I know." Aurelian's dim gold eyes were very soft. *"It's happy with you. I can feel it. Through the hunger. Through everything. It sings when you use it."*



"How do I unmake it?" said Lex.

The old man looked at him for a long time.

"You strike the flaw," he said. *"That's how you unmake anything. You know that. You've done it a dozen times. The Umbral Wardens. The Severance chain."* He held up his own hand. Thin. Shaking. *"Find the seam where the maker was careless. Strike there. What was folded, unfolds."*

"And the seam is you."

"The seam is me." Aurelian nodded slowly. *"It's made of my rings. Folded round me. I'm the place where it's joined. If you strike me—"*

"It comes apart."

"It comes apart." He was very calm. *"It unfolds. All of it. Everything it's eaten. Everything it's built. The Ceiling. The Tithe. The face. The voice. It all comes undone. Like a knot pulled loose."* He looked at Lex. *"And there's nothing left of it. Just hunger. No shape. No face. No hands. Just mouth. In the dark. Where it was before I came down."*

"And you?"

The old man smiled. Tired. Gentle. *Real.*

"Child," said Aurelian Vey. *"I've been dead for eight hundred years. I've just been too stubborn to lie down."*



LEX COULDN'T DO IT.

He knelt in the dark at the bottom of the hunger, with the gold eating his memories above him, chain by chain, and looked at the tired old man curled on the floor. And couldn't do it.

He's the flaw. Strike the flaw.

He's a man. He's my blood. He sang at his anvil. He made his little brother a bell.

"I can't," he said.

"I know." Aurelian didn't seem surprised. *"I couldn't either. When I was your age. I couldn't strike anything that was mine."* He looked down at the hammer in his lap. *"That's why I built a cage instead. Because I couldn't bear to break the thing I'd caught."*

Above them, another chain went. Lex felt it. *His mother's floury hands.* He reached for it. Nothing. A warm hollow. The shape of a woman bending over a hearth.

Mam, he thought. Mam. I can't remember your—

"It's getting to the deep ones now," said Aurelian. Very quietly. *"The oldest. The brightest. It always saves those for last."* He looked up. *"You haven't got long, child. A little while. And then it'll have all of you, and it'll walk out of here in your face. Through your brother's door. Into the world."*

"Antho won't let it through."

"Your brother will hold that door until he dies." Aurelian's voice was very gentle. *"And then it'll walk through anyway."*

Lex knelt in the dark and shook.

Strike the flaw.

I can't.

Strike the flaw.

I can't. I can't. He's—

And from very far away, from outside, from beyond the hunger and the gold and the forge and the closed door with his brother standing on its threshold, he heard it.

Ting.

Ting.

Ting.

A little silver bell. With a crooked clapper. Ringing flat.

Ringing louder than it had ever rung in nine hundred years.

And Aurelian Vey lifted his head.

And his dim gold eyes, for the first time in eight hundred years, went *bright.*

CHAPTER 35

REBORN IN LIGHT II



WREN ASHDOWN WATCHED LEX go grey.

She was on her knees on the white floor of the forge at the Heart, where she'd fallen when the hunger pulled. She'd got up as far as her knees. She couldn't get any further. She didn't want to. She knelt three paces from him and watched.

He was standing at the gold anvil. Very still. With his eyes closed and his scarred hands flat on the anvil's battered face. The way she'd seen him stand a hundred times, at a hundred forges, waiting for the iron to tell him it was ready.

And he was *fading*.

Not like the Unnamed. Not like Ilse at the bottom of the Rift, going faint at the edges. From the *inside*. She could see it. A greyness, spreading out from somewhere deep in his chest. Into his face. His hands. The gold glow that had always come off his skin, ever since the night in the Ashbourne forge four years ago when the seal cracked, going dim. Like a forge-fire left too long without bellows.

Antho knelt beside him. With his fingers on Lex's sleeve, between finger and thumb. His eyes closed. His face absolutely calm. Like a man asleep. Like a man standing in a doorway.

He wasn't grey. He was holding.

And on Lex's other side, a small faint woman in a faded blue dress was standing with both her hands pressed flat against his back. Over his heart. Over the Root. Singing. Very softly. Flat on the high note.

If the dark comes calling, love, don't you mind.

It wasn't helping. Wren could see that. Seren could see it too. Her face was wet and set and desperate, and she kept singing anyway.



"*It's eating him,*" said Oriel Sant.

The old blind woman was sitting on the white floor at the edge of the forge, where she'd been all along. Her black stick across her knees. Her white eyes turned toward Lex.

"*I can see it,*" she said. Very quietly. "*Inside him. Everything he is. Hanging up like tools in a forge. And the gold coming up the walls, taking them. One at a time.*" Her thin dry voice cracked. "*It's taken a lot already.*"

Wren made a sound she didn't recognize.

"*Can you see what?*" said Seraphine. She was sitting with Kestrel, both of them grey-faced, holding each other up. "*Which ones?*"

Oriel tilted her head. Listening.

"*An old bald man swinging a boy onto an anvil,*" she said. "*A fire in a hut leaning toward his hands. A girl in the dust of a road, saying you can hit me now.*"

Wren put her hands over her face.

"*It's going for the deep ones now,*" said Oriel. "*The old ones. The brightest.*" She was quiet. "*His mother's hands. With flour on them.*"

Seren's singing broke. Just for a moment. Then went on.



MALACHI WAS RINGING THE bell.

He'd been ringing it since Lex opened the door. Since the thing in Aurelian's face put its hand on the anvil and went down. He stood at the edge of the forge, small and brown and barefoot, with his straw hat fallen off and the little silver bell held up in front of him in his gnarled hand.

He wasn't shaking it. He didn't have to. It rang on its own. *Ting. Ting. Ting.* Louder than Wren had ever heard it. So loud it filled the whole round white forge, bounced off the broken pillars, rang out into the empty dark of the Forbidden Lands.

Flat. The clapper was crooked. Every ring was a little off.

"*He can bear it,*" said Malachi.

He said it to no one. To himself. To the bell. His shifting eyes were fixed on Lex, standing grey at the anvil.

"*He can hear it,*" he said again. "*I can feel him. Through the bell. Through the Heart. Down there. At the bottom of it. With the boy.*" His voice was shaking. "*He's awake. For the first time in eight hundred years, he's awake.**"

"*Who?*" said Wren.

The old man turned his head and looked at her.

"*My brother,*" said Malachi.



HE WALKED TO THE anvil.

Wren watched him go. Across the white floor. Past the broken pillars. Past Oriel and Seraphine and Kestrel and Tamsin and the twins and Teo, all on the floor, all grey and tired and watching. Past Isaura Kell, standing very straight at the edge of the forge with her hands clenched.

He stopped beside Lex. On the far side from Antho. Beside Seren.

He looked up at Lex's face. Grey. Fading. Eyes closed.

Then he looked down at the anvil.

Gold. Battered. Scarred by a thousand thousand blows. The anvil where his brother had forged the net. Nine hundred years ago. While a little boy sat on a bucket by the bellows with a bowl of soup he wasn't eating.

"*He went down,*" said Malachi. Quietly. "*Right here. He put his hand on this anvil and went down into the gold, to hold the hunger.*" His gnarled fingers touched the edge of it. "*And I sat on a bucket. And screamed his name. And didn't follow.*"

"*You were twelve,*" said Seren. Very gently. Still singing, under her breath. Between the words.

"*I was twelve.*" Malachi looked at her. "*And then I was twenty. And fifty. And a hundred. And nine hundred and forty-one.*" His shifting eyes were wet. "*And I never followed. Not once. I sat by a fire in the Wastes and watched the road. For eight hundred years. And never once went down it.*"

He looked at Antho. Kneeling. Eyes closed. Fingers on Lex's sleeve.

"*Deep one,*" said Malachi.

Antho's eyes didn't open. But his face changed. Just slightly. As if he'd heard.

"*You're on the door,*" said Malachi. "*I can feel you. Standing on the threshold. Holding it shut.*" He swallowed. "*Will you let me through?*"



WREN DIDN'T UNDERSTAND.

Nobody did. Not at first. Seren stopped singing. Kell turned her head. Seraphine sat up.

"*Mal,*" said Seren. "*What are you—*"

"*He's my blood,*" said Malachi. Simply. "*Lex. Aurelian's blood. Which is mine. The seventh child of seven.*" He looked down at his own gnarled brown hands. "*I never had the Root. I was born before the net. I never Kindled. I never had a thread.*" He laid his palm flat on the gold anvil. "*But the Heart doesn't care about threads. It cares about blood. Every Vey root starts here. Every one. Including the ones that never grew.*"

He looked at Antho.

"*Let me through, deep one,*" said Malachi, the Last Listener. "*Let me go down. The way he did. I've been sitting on the bucket for nine hundred years.*"



ANTHO'S EYES OPENED.

Wren saw it. Saw the clear grey of them, very far away, as if he were looking at Malachi from the other side of a door. Which he was.

He looked at the old man for a long time.

"*If I open it,*" said Antho. His voice was strange. Distant. Like a voice from the bottom of a well. "*Even a crack. It'll try to come out.*"

"*I know.*"

"*I'll have to hold it.*"

"*I know.*" Malachi smiled. Gap-toothed. Tired. "*You're very good at holding things, deep one. You've had more practice than anyone alive.*"

Antho was silent.

"*He's my brother,*" said Malachi. Very quietly. "*Please.*"

And Antho Vey, Threshold Warden, who decided who came through, closed his eyes again.

And nodded.



MALACHI WENT DOWN.

Wren watched him do it. The way Lex had told her Aurelian did it, in the vision, nine hundred years ago. The old man stood at the gold anvil with his palm flat on its face and the silver bell ringing in his other hand. And he closed his eyes. And *sank*.

Not his body. His body stayed. Small and brown and barefoot, standing at the anvil. But something went out of it. Down. Into the gold. The way a man steps into deep water. Wren felt it go. Saw the anvil's battered face *ripple*, like a pond when a stone drops in.

And then the old man's body folded up. Slowly. Like a puppet with its strings cut. And sat down on the white floor at the foot of the anvil. With its back against it. With its head tipped forward and its eyes closed.

With the silver bell in its hand. Ringing.



LEX WAS ON HIS knees in the dark at the bottom of the hunger when his ancestor's little brother arrived.

He didn't know it was Malachi at first. He'd lost so much. The gold was eating the deep ones now. He'd lost the Stillwater. He'd lost the eternal fire, and the apples, and *Listening is hearing the Well; Answering is the Well hearing you*. He knew there'd been an old man. Small. Brown. Laughing. He could feel the shape of him in the warm hollows where the memories had been.

And then the old man was *there*.

Standing in the dark beside him. At the bottom of the gold. Small and brown and barefoot. With a silver bell in his hand, ringing.

Looking at the tired thin grey-haired man curled on the floor in the remains of a smith's apron.

"*Aurelian*," said Malachi.



AURELIAN VEY LOOKED UP.

His dim gold eyes found the old man standing over him. And went wide. And went bright.

"*Mal,*" he whispered.

"*Hello, Aurelian.*"

"*Mal. You—*" The tired man's voice broke. "*You're old.*"

"*I'm nine hundred and forty-one,*" said Malachi. "*You'd be old too.*" He looked down at his brother. Thin and grey and curled in the dark. "*You are old. You look terrible.*"

Aurelian laughed. Cracked. Broken. And then, without any warning at all, he was crying. Great dry gasping sobs, like a man who has forgotten how and is remembering all at once.

Malachi knelt down. On the dark floor at the bottom of the hunger. In front of his brother.

He held out the bell.

"*You never fixed the clapper,*" he said.

Aurelian looked at it. Small. Silver. Ringing. Flat.

"*I was never very careful with my folding,*" he whispered.

"*No,*" Malachi agreed. "*You weren't.*" His shifting eyes were running with tears. "*It's been ringing for nine hundred years, Aurelian. At the bottom of the sea. Every day. I was sad every day.*"

"*I know.*" Aurelian reached out a shaking hand. And touched the bell. Very lightly. With one finger. "*I heard it. I think. Sometimes. Very far away. I didn't know what it was. I thought I was imagining it.*" He looked up at his little brother. "*I'm sorry, Mal. I'm so sorry. I should have come.*"

"*You couldn't.*"

"*I should have.*"



LEX KNELT BESIDE THEM in the dark and couldn't speak.

Above them, the gold was still eating. He felt it. Another chain. Another. *A woman in a faded blue dress, singing, flat on the high note.* He reached for it. Felt it going. Felt it start to—

"*Smith,*" said Malachi.

He looked up.

The old man was looking at him. Kneeling beside his brother. With the bell in his hand.

"He told you," said Malachi. *"Didn't he. That he's the flaw."*

"Yes."

"And you couldn't strike him."

"No."

"Good." The old man smiled. *"You shouldn't. That's not what a smith does. A smith doesn't break the thing he loves to get at the flaw."* He looked at his brother. *"He finds another way."*

"There isn't another way," said Aurelian. Very quietly. *"It's folded round me, Mal. I'm the seam. If he strikes it, I come apart too."*

"Only because you're holding on to it."

Aurelian stared at him.

"You've been holding on to it for nine hundred years," said Malachi. *"With your arms round it. In the dark. Because you went down to hold it, and you're the most stubborn man who ever lived, and you never once let go."* His voice was very gentle. *"Even when it got into you. Even when it ate you. You held on."* He reached out and took his brother's thin grey hands in his own gnarled brown ones. *"And it's folded itself round your arms. Round your holding. That's the seam, Aurelian. Not you. Your holding.*"*



AURELIAN VEY LOOKED AT his brother's hands on his.

"If I let go," he said slowly, *"it'll have nothing to hold it. It'll be free. In the dark. Loose."*

"No," said Malachi. *"It'll have me."*

The tired man went absolutely still.

"I'm the Last Listener," said Malachi. *"I've got all six Wells in me. I've had them for nine hundred years. Flame and Stone and Tide and Gale and Radiance and Shade."* He smiled. *"I'm not a cage, Aurelian. I never was. I told you that on the night of the Weaving. You can't cage a storm by becoming the bars."*

"Then what?"

"You sit with it," said Malachi. *"In the dark. Like a fire. Like a friend. You don't hold it down."* His shifting eyes were very soft. *"You just stay with*

it, so it isn't alone. It's been alone longer than anything, Aurelian. Longer than the world. That's why it's so hungry."

Aurelian stared at him.

"That's what I came down to do," said Malachi. "I've been sitting on a bucket for nine hundred years. I've finally worked out what I'm for." He tightened his hands on his brother's. "Let go. I'll hold you. You let go of it. And the smith can strike the seam."

"And you?"

The old man smiled. Gap-toothed. Ancient. Delighted.

"I'll be with you," said Malachi. "Wherever you go. That's all I ever wanted, you stupid clever man. That's why you made me a bell."



AURELIAN VEY LET GO.

Lex felt it.

Not in the dark at the bottom of the hunger. *Everywhere*. Through every part of himself. Through the forge, up above, with the gold rising up its walls. Through the closed door, where his brother stood on the threshold. Through the Heart, and the anvil, and every thread that had ever run down into it.

Nine hundred years of holding. Letting go.

Like a breath let out. Like a fist uncurling. Like a man who has carried something so long he's forgotten it's not part of him, setting it down.

And in the dark, all around them, the hunger *shuddered*.

Lex saw it. Saw the seam. For the first time. Saw where the gold had been folded round Aurelian's arms, round his holding, ring after ring, for nine hundred years. And where the arms had let go, a gap. A line. A flaw. Running down through the whole of the hunger like the crack in a dropped plate.

The place where it wasn't folded properly.

The place where a man had been holding on, and wasn't anymore.

"Now," said Aurelian Vey.

He was holding out the little hammer. Worn smooth. With faint gold runes on its cheeks. The first thing he'd ever made for himself.

"Strike there," he said. "What was folded, unfolds."



LEX TOOK THE HAMMER.

It was warm. It was always warm. It had been warm in his hand at the Umbral Wardens on the moor, and at the Severance chain in Sorn's ballroom, and at the anvil at the Hollowmaw the night he forged the Lockward.

It was *singing*.

Very faintly. In his palm. A working song. The kind smiths sing at the anvil. Losing the tune.

He looked at the seam. Running through the dark.

He looked at the two old men kneeling beside it. Holding each other's hands. One small and brown and barefoot. One thin and grey and tired.

"Go on, child," said Aurelian. Gently. "*I'll be all right. I've got Mal.*"

"He's got me," said Malachi. Grinning through his tears. "*God help him.*"

Lex lifted the hammer.

And struck.

Tink.



IT CAME APART.

He'd unmade things before. He'd watched Umbral Wardens unfold like flowers. He'd watched a Severance chain slide off his father's shoulders like a dead snake.

This was different.

The seam *opened*. All the way. Top to bottom. And the hunger, that had been folded round Aurelian Vey for nine hundred years, folded into a face and a voice and a pair of scarred hands and a kind loving smile, *unfolded*.

Lex felt it go. Ring by ring. Every fold. Every crimp. Every piece of Aurelian it had taken and shaped into itself. Coming loose. Uncurling. Like a knot pulled out of a rope. Like a fist opening.

The face went first. The fair hair and the gold eyes and the tired beautiful features of the smith who had sung at his anvil. Unfolding. Gone.

The voice. *My boy. My good boy. Come home.* Unfolding. Gone.

The hands. The apron. The kindness. The patience. The waiting.

Gone.

And what was left—



WHAT WAS LEFT WAS very small.

Lex hadn't expected that. He'd thought it would be enormous. The hunger that had eaten the Sunwell's people and the Drowned Country and every drifting piece of every world in the Forbidden Lands.

It wasn't.

It was a *dark*. A small dark. The size of a man's two hands held together. Shapeless. Faceless. Mouthless. Floating in the dark at the bottom of everything.

Hungry. He could feel that. Still. A hunger with no shape. No face. Nothing to hold. Nothing to wear.

Alone.

He could feel that too. More than the hunger. Underneath it. A loneliness so old and so deep that it had been there before the world. Before the river. Before the Wells. A dark that had always been there, at the bottom of everything, with nothing in it but itself.

It's been alone longer than anything, Malachi had said. *That's why it's so hungry.*

The small dark drifted. Shapeless. Searching. Reaching out, blindly, for something to hold. Something to wear. Something to fill it.

And Malachi held out his hands.



"*Here,*" said the Last Listener.

He was kneeling in the dark. His gnarled brown hands cupped in front of him. The way you'd hold a bird. The way Seren had cupped her hands round her lamp at the door.

"*Here,*" he said again. Very gently. "*Come here. It's all right. You're not alone. Not anymore.*"

The small dark hesitated.

It had no eyes. No face. But Lex felt it *turn*. Toward the old man. Toward the cupped hands. Toward the voice.

"I'm not going to cage you," said Malachi. "I'm not going to hold you down. I'm just going to sit with you. In the dark. For as long as it takes." His shifting eyes went black. The soft black of the sky between the stars. "I've got Shade in me, little one. The real dark. Not the thing you pretended to be. The quiet. The rest. The space between heartbeats." He smiled. "You're not the dark. You just got lost in it. A long, long time ago."

The small dark drifted closer.

"Come on," said Malachi. "I've got a fire. And my brother. And a bell."

And the hunger at the bottom of the world, that had eaten worlds and worn a dead man's face and sung through a choir-master and rotted through a midwife, drifted into the cupped hands of a nine-hundred-and-forty-one-year-old man who had been sad for nine hundred years.

And Malachi closed his hands around it.

Gently.



AURELIAN PUT HIS ARMS around his brother.

From behind. Around his shoulders. The way you hold someone you love who's holding something precious. And laid his grey head against Malachi's.

"Mal," he said.

"Mm."

"Where are we going?"

"Down," said Malachi. "Into the deep. The real deep. Under the Hollow. Where the Wells come from." He looked down at the small dark in his cupped hands. Quiet now. Still. "It's very peaceful down there. I've heard it. Through the Wells. All my life." He closed his eyes. "We'll find somewhere to sit. And I'll build a fire. And we'll keep it company."

"Forever?"

"For a while," said Malachi. "Nothing's forever. You taught me that." He opened one eye. "And then maybe it won't be hungry anymore. And we can stop."

Aurelian Vey laughed. Softly. Into his little brother's hair.

And then he looked up. At Lex. Kneeling in the dark with the little hammer in his hand.

"*Child,*" he said.

His gold eyes were bright. Clear. Not dim. Not tired. *Alive.* For the first time in eight hundred years. The eyes Lex had seen through a window of ice nine hundred years deep, on a young man at a gold anvil under stars too close and too bright.

"*The net,*" said Aurelian. "*It's still there. Up above. Every ring. With the crimp in it. The Ceiling. The holes where the Tithe ran through.*" He smiled. "*Nobody's pulling on them anymore. But they're still crimped.*"

"*I know.*"

"*Fix it,*" said Aurelian Vey. "*Please. I made it so badly. I was so afraid.*" His voice was very gentle. "*You're not afraid. Not the way I was. You're afraid for them. That's the right kind.*" He looked at the hammer in Lex's hand. "*Take that up to the anvil. My anvil. And strike every ring. Uncrimp them. Close the holes. Make it what I should have made.*"

"*I don't know how.*"

"*Yes, you do,*" said Aurelian. "*You've known since you were eleven. Since an old bald man put you on an anvil and said, this is yours now.*" He smiled. "*You just have to ask it nicely.*"



THEY WENT.

Lex watched them. Kneeling at the bottom of the dark with the hammer in his hand. Two old men. One small and brown and barefoot, with his hands cupped around something quiet. One tall and thin and grey, with his arms around his brother's shoulders.

Sinking. Slowly. Down. Into the deep. Into the dark below the dark. Getting smaller. Fainter. Like the Knights of the Ford walking away across the black ink.

And as they went, Lex heard Malachi start to sing.

Badly. Loudly. Something about a miller's daughter and a very large cheese.

And after a moment, Aurelian joined in.

Worse.

Losing the tune.

And the little silver bell, wherever it was, in Malachi's hand, or on the floor of the forge at the Heart, or somewhere in between, rang once more.

Ting.

And stopped.



LEX CAME UP.

Through the dark. Through the place where the hunger had been. Up into his own forge.

And the gold was *going back*.

He saw it. Standing in the middle of the long dark hall. The gold that had flooded his forge, risen up its walls, eaten his memories chain by chain. Draining away. Back down. Through the floor. Like water through sand. And as it went—

The chains came back.

Not all at once. One at a time. Up in the rafters, where they'd been. Iron and copper and bronze and silver and gold. Reforming. Link by link. Glowing.

Brannoc swinging him onto the anvil at eleven. This is yours now, lad.

Back.

Fire in a hut on the shore of the Stillwater, leaning toward his hands.

Back.

A girl in the dust of a road. You can hit me now.

Back.

A woman bending over a hearth. Flour on her hands. Singing. Flat on the high note.

Back. All of them. Every one. Everything the hunger had taken, it had folded into itself. And when it unfolded, it let them go.

He stood in his own forge with the chains of his whole life glowing overhead, and wept.

[*Lex.*]

The coal in the hearth. Gold. Bright. Humming. Not flickering anymore.

[Lex. You're back. You're all back. I can feel them. Every one.] Ember's voice was shaking. *[I thought I was going to go out. I thought—]*

I know.

[What happened? Down there? I couldn't see. It was all dark and then it was all light and then—]

Malachi, thought Lex. *Malachi happened.*

He looked at the great double doors of the forge. Closed. Locked. With his brother standing on the other side of them. Holding.

Antho, he thought. Through the Bloodbond. *Antho. It's gone. You can open it.*

A long pause.

And then, very slowly, the great double doors of the Ashbourne forge swung open. And outside them, instead of the yard and the well and the village green, there was light. Gold and white and silver. And his brother standing in it, with a lantern in his hand and his clear grey eyes wet.

"Come on," said Antho. *"There's a world to fix."*



WREN SAW HIM OPEN his eyes.

She was still on her knees on the white floor. Three paces away. She'd been there the whole time. Watching him go grey. And then watching the grey stop. And go back. Slowly. From his hands. From his face. The gold coming back into his skin. Like a forge-fire when someone pumps the bellows.

He opened his eyes.

Brown-gold. Clear. *His.*

He looked down. At the white floor at the foot of the gold anvil.

Malachi was sitting there. With his back against the anvil. His head tipped forward. His eyes closed. Small and brown and barefoot, in his old robe, with his straw hat lying on the floor beside him.

With the little silver bell in his hand.

Silent.

Wren had never heard it silent. Not once since Teo brought it up from the sea.

Seren was kneeling beside the old man. With her hand on his shoulder. Her faded face wet.

"*He's gone,*" she said quietly. "*Just now. When the bell stopped.*" She looked up at Lex. "*He was smiling.*"

He was. Wren could see it. The gap-toothed grin. Faint. Peaceful. The way you smile in your sleep when you're dreaming about something good.

Lex knelt down on the white floor.

He reached out. And very gently took the silver bell out of the old man's hand.

It didn't ring.

He held it for a long time. Small and silver. With its crooked clapper.

"*It's not ringing,*" said Wren. Barely a whisper. "*Why isn't it ringing?*"

Lex looked at it.

"*Because he's not sad anymore,*" said Lex Vey.

■ ■ ■ ALLY LOST ■ ■ ■

MALACHI

The Last Listener

Seventh of Seven

"He sat on the bucket for nine
hundred years. Then he followed."

CHAPTER 36

REBORN IN LIGHT III



HE STOOD UP AT the anvil with the bell in one hand and the hammer in the other, and looked at the net.

He could see all of it. From here. From the Heart. From the gold anvil where every thread in the world had been struck the first time, nine hundred years ago, by a frightened young man with his little brother watching from a bucket. He'd felt it before, when he first stepped onto the white floor of the forge: every thread *starting* here. He saw it now. Not with True Sight. Not with the Root. With his eyes. As if the empty dark above the round white forge had turned to glass, and through it, spread out below him like a map, the whole of the world.

And over the world, the net.

Silver. Every thread. Every soul. Millions. Ring linked through ring linked through ring, the way Malachi had said. Like mail. Like a great shirt of silver mail thrown over the whole of the world, every link shining.

And in every link, a crimp.

He saw them. Tiny. Every one. A little pinch in each ring, where the thing that had worn Aurelian's face had gone back to the anvil a year after the Weaving and struck every ring a second time. Tighter. The Ceiling. *Thus far, and no further.* And through every crimp, a hole. A tiny dark hole, where the Tithe had run down.

Nothing was running down them now. The holes were empty. The tithe-threads hung slack, all over the world, grey and limp, like the strings of a harp with no harper.

But the crimps were still there. Every one. Millions of them. Holding every soul in the world to a Ceiling. Holding every soul's breath.

A soul with a Ceiling is a soul holding its breath, the First Breath had said. *Forever.*



[Lex,] said Ember. Very quietly. In the hearth. [*There are millions of them.*]

I know.

[*You can't strike them one at a time. You'd be here until the end of the world.*]

I know.

[*Then how—*]

He didn't answer.

He looked down at the little hammer in his hand. Worn smooth. With faint gold runes on its cheeks. The first thing Aurelian ever made for himself. Singing, very faintly, in his palm.

You just have to ask it nicely.

He thought about Brannoc. In the Ashbourne forge. Twelve years old, so desperate to be good at everything that he'd broken three hammers in a month. *You can't hurry iron, lad. It knows when you're hurrying. It goes stiff on you.*

He thought about the old Stone at Fen Hollow, sighing when he asked it. About the Stone of Saffaran, which had hated holding its people down for two hundred years and had let go the moment he said *please*.

About the Sunwell. The Hearth. The Undertow. The First Breath. The mountain.

Not do this. Help me.

[Lex,] said Ember slowly. [*You're not going to strike them. Are you.*]

No, thought Lex. *I'm going to ask.*



HE TURNED AROUND.

They were all there. On the white floor of the round forge at the Heart. Where they'd fallen when the hunger pulled. Getting up now. Slowly. Grey-faced and shaking and alive.

Wren. Three paces away. On her knees. With her green eyes on his face, wide and wet.

Antho. Standing. With the Lantern in his hand. Clear-eyed. Very tired.

His mother. Kneeling beside Malachi's body at the foot of the anvil. Faint. With her hand still on the old man's shoulder.

Kestrel and Tamsin. Seraphine. Ilse and Ivo. Teo. Oriel. And Isaura Kell, standing at the edge of the forge with her hands at her sides and her gaunt face very still.

"I need help," said Lex.



"It's a forging," he said. *"The biggest one there's ever been. Bigger than the Weaving. Bigger than anything."* He held up the hammer. *"And you can't forge alone. Not something this big. You need a striker. And a bellows. And a fire. And a quench."* He looked at them. *"And you need all six Wells. Because the net was forged from the river, and the river runs through all six."*

Nobody spoke.

"Flame," said Lex. *"That's me. And Kestrel. Commanding. Both of us."*

Kestrel looked at him. Then at her hands. And very slowly, she stood up. Her hair catching. Gold. The Ashari fire.

"Gale," said Lex. *"Wren. Commanding. You've got the breath."*

Wren was already on her feet.

"Tide," said Lex. He looked at the round dripping boy at the back of the group. *"Teo. You Speak to the sea. I need a quench. The biggest quench there's ever been."*

Teo Brask went white. Then red. Then stood up very straight, dripping, and said, *"Yes, Master Lex."*

"Stone," said Lex. *"That's me. Speaking."* He looked down at the white floor of the forge. At the white mountain under it. At the bones of the world. *"And it's here. Under us. The anvil."*

"Shade," said Antho. Quietly. *"Me. Commanding."* He looked at the Lantern in his hand. *"Every forging needs a dark. For the iron to cool in. For the quiet after."*

"And Radiance," said Lex.

He turned.

Toward the small faint woman kneeling beside Malachi's body at the foot of the anvil.



SEREN VEY LOOKED UP at him.

"You're a Listener," said Lex. "A hedge-witch. Unlatticed. Father told me, at Avaloria, when I was nineteen. He said you heard things nobody else could hear."

His mother looked at him for a long moment.

"I hear light," she said. Very softly. "I always have. Since I was a girl. I hear it the way you hear fire. Lamps. Candles. Stars." She looked down at her faint hands. "That's why I could carry the lamp into the dark. That's why it never went out."

"Radiance," said Lex.

"I never knew what to call it."

"Will you?" His voice cracked. "Mam. Will you help?"

Seren Vey stood up. Slowly. Faint. Tired. Eleven years of holding a door, and months of walking in the dark after a woman with no face.

She came around the anvil. She stood beside him.

And she reached up and put her hand on his face. The way she used to, in the cottage at Harrow, when he was small and frightened of the thunder.

"Oh, my love," she said. "Of course I will."



THEY GATHERED ROUND THE anvil.

Lex at the anvil itself, with the little hammer in his hand. His mother at his right shoulder. Antho at his left, with the Lantern. Wren behind him, at the place where the bellows would be, if there were bellows. Kestrel and Teo on the far side of the anvil, facing him. Fire and water.

And the others in a ring around them. Seraphine with her notebook, not writing. The twins, holding hands. Tamsin. Oriel, on her stool. And Isaura Kell, standing a little apart, with her hands clenched.

"What do we do?" said Wren.

"I don't know," said Lex honestly. "I've never done this." He looked down at the anvil. Gold. Battered. Scarred. "Nobody has. Except him." He

swallowed. "*I think you just—give it. What you have. Your Well. Into the fire. And I'll ask.*"

"*Into what fire?*" said Kestrel. "*There's no fire.*"

Lex looked up.

At the pillar. Gold. Rising from the anvil into the empty dark. The pillar every tithe-thread in the world had fallen into, for eight hundred years. Still standing. Still burning. Empty now. Nothing falling into it.

"*That one,*" he said.



KESTREL GAVE FIRST.

She put her hands into the pillar of gold. Both of them. To the wrist. And her fire went *in*. Red and gold. The Ashari fire. The oldest fire in the world, that the Hearth had looked at and said *it knows me*. Pouring off her hands into the pillar. And the pillar *roared*.

Not gold anymore. Gold and *red*. Flame. Real flame. Leaping.

Lex put his hands in beside hers.

His own fire. Commanding. Gold-white. The fire he'd said good morning to every day for ten years. *What's this fire for?* He gave it. All of it. Into the pillar.

And it became a *forge*.

He felt it. The pillar of gold that had been the Tithe's drain for eight hundred years, roaring up into the empty dark above the white mountain. Not falling. *Rising*. A column of fire, red and gold and white, so hot that the white stone of the forge glowed, so bright that the too-close stars overhead went pale.

[*Lex,*] said Ember. In the hearth. [*Lex, the Hearth. I can feel it. In the Wellworld. It's leaning. Toward us. All of it.*]

Hello, thought Lex. At the first fire in the world. *Hello. It's me. I'm asking.*

And far away, in a world made of fire, a burning shape standing on a lake of white flame turned its faceless head toward the Heart. And *leaned*.



WREN BREATHED.

She stood behind him, where the bellows should be, and opened her mouth, and breathed *out*. Into the fire. Not the First Breath. That was gone, into the Lockward. But the sky remembered it. And she was Commanding now. And she breathed out the way she'd breathed out in the Wellworld of Gale, when she let go of his hand and the sky caught him.

The wind came.

From everywhere. From nowhere. Pouring past her into the pillar of fire, the way air pours through a bellows. And the fire went *white*. Welding heat. The color of iron at the moment it's ready.

Up, up, up, lightfoot, said a voice in the wind. Lex heard it. Light and quick and laughing, like a girl running through long grass. *Higher. Come on.*



ANTHO LIFTED THE LANTERN.

Not into the fire. *Beside* it. At Lex's left shoulder. With its shutter wide and its twelve Hush-runes blazing. And its gold light, small and steady, falling on the anvil.

And around the anvil, where the gold light fell, a *quiet*.

Lex felt it. Shade. Not the hunger pretending to be the dark. The real dark. The quiet. The rest. The space between heartbeats. Antho was making a place for the iron to cool. A place for the quiet after.

The dark isn't your enemy, Malachi had said, four years ago, by the eternal fire. *It never was.*

His brother's face, in the Lantern's light, was very calm.



AND HIS MOTHER SANG.

Not the lantern song. Something else. Something Lex had never heard. Low and rough and very soft. No words. Just a sound. Like light. Like the sound a candle makes, if a candle could make a sound. Like stars.

Radiance.

He'd never heard it before. Nobody had. Not in nine hundred years. Not since the Listeners. The sixth Well. The one that was only light.

It went into the fire. And the fire went *gold* again. Not white. Not red. *Gold*. The gold of the lanterns at the Hollowmaw. The gold of the little clay lamp with the chip in its spout. Warm and steady and kind.

And somewhere very far away, in a cavern at the bottom of a mountain, two lamps in a niche in front of a sealed black door *flared*. All at once. Bright as noon.

And a man sitting on the black floor in front of them looked up.



"*Teo*," said Lex.

The boy was on the far side of the anvil. Shaking. White. Dripping. Looking at the pillar of fire roaring up into the dark.

"*When I strike*," said Lex, "*I need you to quench. All of it. Everything. The whole net.*"

"*The whole—*" Teo's voice cracked. "*Master Lex, I can't. I'm fifteen. I talk to fish in a bucket.*"

"*You talk to the sea*," said Lex. "*And the sea talks back.*" He looked at the boy. "*It said it missed you, Teo. On the beach. It said you'd been gone too long.*"

Teo stared at him.

"*Ask it*," said Lex. "*Ask the Undertow. Tell it I'm keeping my promise.*" He swallowed. "*Tell it the deep rivers won't stay dammed. Tell it I said all of them.*"

Teo Brask closed his eyes.

And Lex heard him. Not with his ears. The way he'd heard him on the Tidewater coast. A sound like the tide coming in over the marshes. Slow. Steady. Endless. Like a homesick boy talking to the sea.

Please, said Teo. To the deep. To the dark under all the water in the world. *Please. He's keeping his promise. He needs you. All of you.*

And far away, under all the oceans of the world, something vast and slow and cold turned in the deep.

And *came*.



LEX LIFTED THE HAMMER.

It was singing. Loud now. In his palm. A working song. The kind smiths sing at the anvil to keep the rhythm. Losing the tune. He knew that tune. Brannoc sang it. Badly. He'd heard it every day of his life since he was eleven.

He looked down at the anvil.

At the net. Spread out below him, through the glass of the empty dark. Every ring. Every soul. Every crimp.

I'm not going to strike you, he thought. At all of them. At every ring. Every thread. Every soul in the world. I'm going to strike the anvil. The one you were all made on. And it's going to ring. And when you hear it—

He took a breath.

When you hear it, you can let go. If you want to. You don't have to hold your breath anymore.

Please.

And he struck.



Tink.



IT WASN'T LOUD.

He'd thought it would be. The biggest forging there had ever been. He'd thought it would shake the world.

It was a *tink*. Small. Bright. Clear. Aurelian's little hammer on Aurelian's gold anvil. The sound a smith makes a thousand times a day. The sound Lex had made every morning of his life since he was eleven.

And it rang.

Out from the anvil. Up the pillar of fire. Through the six Wells pouring into it. Flame and Gale and Shade and Radiance and Stone. Out into the empty dark. Down the slack grey tithe-threads. Into every Stone. Every thread. Every ring.

Everywhere.



IN HIGHCREST, THE QUEEN of Caldor was standing on the steps of the Spire, at dawn, looking at the silver Great Stone in the square. She'd been there all night. She hadn't slept since the hunger pulled.

She heard it. A tiny bright sound. Like a hammer on an anvil, very far away.

And felt something in her chest *let go*.

She didn't know what it was. Not at first. A loosening. A breath. As if she'd been holding it her whole life without knowing, and someone had just said *you can stop now*.

She looked down at her hands.

They were glowing. Faintly. Silver and gold.

All around her, in the square, in the streets, in the windows of the golden city, people were stopping. Standing still. Looking at their hands.

Glowing.



IN SAFFARAN, QUEEN ISHARA of the Sunreach was on the highest tower, with Zahir on her shoulder, watching the sun come up over the glass.

She heard it.

And the Ashari fire in her palms, which had come back when the smith from Caldor knelt at the foot of her Stone, went *gold*. Brighter than it had ever been. Brighter than her grandmother's stories.

And all over the city, on every terrace, every rooftop, her people's fire went gold with it.



IN THE WICKHOLLOW, UNDER the Bitter Hills, a little girl with no thread was asleep with an iron candle-holder in her arms.

She woke. She sat up. She looked around the gallery. At the candles. At the Unlit, sleeping on their benches. At her mother.

She didn't hear anything. She'd never been in the net. She never would be.

But every candle in the Wickhollow, every single one, beeswax and tallow, in jars and tin cups and on bare rock, *leaned*. All at once. In the same direction. Toward something very far away.

And then straightened.
And burned a little brighter than before.



IN ASHBOURNE, TILDA CRANE was at the great hearth.

She heard it. Clear as anything. A hammer on an anvil.

She knew that sound. She'd know it anywhere. *Tink*. Light and fast and precise. Master Lex's strike. The one he used for the fine work.

She looked down at the hearth. At the fire. And the fire looked back at her.

Good morning, it said.

Not in words. But she heard it. For the first time. Clear as a bell.

Tilda Crane sat down on the floor of the Ashbourne Forge with her too-big apron around her knees, and laughed, and cried, and said *good morning* back.



AT THE HOLLOWMAW, ARION Vey was sitting in front of the sealed door.

He heard it.

And felt something go out of him.

Not taken. Not pulled. *Released*. Like a hand opening. The gold in him, the Root, the thing that had stopped him at thirty-one like a clock and kept him for two hundred years. He felt it go. Out of him. Up. Into the net. Into everyone.

He looked down at his hands.

On the back of the left one, between the knuckles, very faint, there was a spot. Small. Brown. The kind old men get.

He'd never had one before.

He sat in front of the door with Pim beside him and stared at it for a very long time.

And then he started to laugh.



AT HARROWGATE, CORIN BELL woke up in the little room under the eaves and found his sister sitting on the end of his bed, glowing.

At Fen Hollow, an old woman named Bess Rook, Spring Kindling, Ceiling twelve, sat up in bed and said, very clearly, to nobody, "*Oh. Oh, there it is.*"

At Thornby, Garret Shale's mother dropped a pot.

At Coldbrook, in a farmhouse with a cow gate, a coat that nobody would admit to owning fell off its hook by the door.

All over the world. Every soul. Every thread. Every ring.

Letting go.



LEX FELT IT.

All of it. Through the anvil. Through the hammer. Through the six Wells pouring through him.

Every crimp, in every ring, in every thread, *relaxing*. Uncurling. Like a fist opening. Like a held breath let out. Millions of them. All at once. The Ceiling that had held every soul in the world for eight hundred years. Not broken. Not torn. *Released*. Because someone had asked. Because they'd heard a hammer ring on the anvil they were made on, and remembered they'd been made to breathe.

And the holes. Where the Tithe had run. Closing. Healing. Like wounds. Like the cracks in the sky over the Sundered Lands. One by one. Then all at once.

And the grey tithe-threads, hanging slack from every Stone in the world, *dissolving*. Like frost in sunlight. Like mist. Gone.

And Teo's quench came.



FROM THE DEEP. FROM under all the oceans in the world. Up through the dark. Up through the Forbidden Lands. Up through the white mountain. A wave. Not of water. Of *Tide*. Of change and memory and the coming in and the going out. Cold and enormous and patient.

It hit the pillar of fire.

And the pillar *sang*.

The same note the Lockward had sung. Pure and high and clear. Like a bell struck once in a silent church. It went out from the Heart. Up through

the net. Into every ring. Every newly uncrimped ring, still hot from the forging, still glowing.

Setting. Fixing them. The way a quench sets a blade. Teaching the steel its new shape.

Open. Free. Breathing.

The sea remembers every stone, Lex thought. Dimly. *And now it remembers this.*



AND THEN THERE WAS one thing left.

He felt it. Standing at the anvil with the hammer in his hand and the fire roaring and the quench singing. One thing. In the center of the net. At the very bottom. Where every Root began.

The Root.

His own. His father's. His brother's. The gold thread that ran from the Veys down to this anvil. That made them Root-heirs. That let them see every thread and set every Sanction and grant every Tier and hold every soul in the world in the palm of their hand.

The center of the net.

He had to be at the center, Malachi had said. *Holding the center down. He chose himself. Of course he did.*

[Lex,] said Ember. Very quietly. [It's still there. The Root. At the center. If you leave it, the net still has a center. Someone holding it.]

I know.

[You could keep it. You'd be the Root of the world. Like him. Like your father. Forever.]

I know.

[Lex—]

No one at the center, thought Lex Vey. *No one holding it down. Everyone holding everyone.*

And he let go.



IT WENT OUT OF him like the Tithe had gone out of the world.

The gold. The Root. Authority. True Sight. Command. Sanction. Unbind. Every Prerogative he'd ever used. The thing that had come up in

him the night the seal cracked in the Ashbourne forge four years ago, when Elric Thorne stood over him and said *so it's true*.

He felt it go. Up. Out. Into the net. Not to anyone. To *everyone*. Spreading out through every newly freed ring. A little to each. Not enough for anyone to hold the world. Just enough for everyone to hold themselves.

And beside him, he felt Antho let go too. The same. Gold, going out. Up. Into everyone.

And very far away, at the bottom of a mountain, in front of a sealed door, he felt his father's last threads of it go. Arion. Two hundred and thirty-two years. Letting go.

███ WORLD NOTICE ███
THE CEILING IS LIFTED.
THE TITHE IS ENDED.
THE ROOT IS RELINQUISHED.
THE NET IS REFORGED.

███ WORLD NOTICE ███
EVERY THREAD IS FREE.



THE FIRE WENT DOWN.

Slowly. The pillar of gold and red and white sinking. Back down into the anvil. The six Wells drawing back. Kestrel's hands coming out of the flame. Wren's breath running out. The Undertow's quench sinking back into the deep, cold and slow and satisfied. His mother's song going quiet.

And the anvil was just an anvil. Gold. Battered. Scarred. In a round white forge on top of a white mountain at the bottom of the world.

With a little hammer lying on it.

Lex stood there. Swaying. Empty. Lighter than he had ever been in his life.

He looked down at his hands.

The gold was gone. The faint glow that had come off his skin since he was nineteen. Gone. His hands were just hands. Big. Scarred. Callused. A smith's hands.

And then, very faintly, in the hearth at the center of him—

[Lex?]

He nearly fell over.

Ember?

[I'm still here,] said Ember. Wonderingly. *[I'm still here. I thought I'd go. With the Root. I thought I lived in the Root.]* A pause. *[I don't. I live in your hearth. I always did.]*

Lex sat down. On the white floor of the forge. Very suddenly. With his back against the gold anvil, beside Malachi's small brown body.

[You gave it away,] said Ember. *[All of it. The whole Root.]*

Yes.

[You could have been the Root of the world.]

I know.

[Why didn't you?]

Lex thought about it. Honestly. The way Malachi had taught him.

Because I'm a smith, he thought. *Not a king. Smiths make things. And then they give them away.*

The coal in the hearth was quiet for a long time.

[That's the best answer I've ever heard,] said Ember. *[I'm putting it in the book.]*



THE PANEL CAME UP anyway.

He didn't ask for it. He didn't have True Sight anymore. But the net was new, and the net was everyone's, and it seemed to want to tell him.

LEX VEY

Class: FORGEHEART SORCERER

→ WORLDFORGER (Unique)

TIER IV

"He did not rule the net. He reforged
it, and gave it away."

Level 76 → 90

ROOT: RELINQUISHED

ATTUNEMENT

Flame COMMANDING

Stone COMMANDING

Tide ANSWERING

Gale ANSWERING

Shade LISTENING

Radiance LISTENING

He read it. He read it twice.

Then he closed his eyes and leaned his head back against the anvil and
breathed.



WREN SAT DOWN BESIDE him.

She didn't say anything. She leaned against his shoulder. He leaned
back.

Antho sat down on his other side. With the Lantern in his lap. Its
shutter closed. Its light small and steady. He put his hand on the back of
Lex's neck.

And his mother came and knelt in front of them. Faint. Tired. Smiling.
And put one hand on each of their faces. Her two boys. Sitting against an
anvil at the bottom of the world.

"Oh, my loves," said Seren Vey. *"Oh, look at you. Look what you've done."*

Nobody said anything.

There wasn't anything to say.



THE FORBIDDEN LANDS WERE *rising*.

Seraphine saw it first. She'd gone to the edge of the forge, between the
broken pillars, and was looking out at the empty dark. And she made a
sound.

They all looked.

The pieces. The drifting fragments of eaten worlds. The forests and kitchens and schoolrooms and gardens and churches and ships, floating in the empty dark, slowly turning.

They were going *gold*.

One by one. Then dozens. Then all of them. Lighting up from inside, the way the plague-dead had lit up on the green at Millbridge. A soft warm gold glow. And rising. Up. Out of the dark. Like sparks from a forge going up a chimney. Like lanterns released over a river at a festival.

Lex watched a kitchen go past. Small. With a hearth. A table. A chair. And on the chair, a woman. Faint. Grey. Who had been waiting for someone to come home for a very, very long time.

She was gold now. And rising. And smiling.

"*It let them go,*" said Antho. Very quietly. "*When it unfolded. Everything it ate.*" His clear grey eyes were wet. "*It's letting them all go.*"



THEY WENT DOWN THE white mountain at what might have been dawn, if there had been a dawn in the Forbidden Lands.

Lex carried Malachi. He was very light. Like a bundle of dry sticks wrapped in an old robe. Lex carried him down the smooth white slope with the old man's head on his shoulder and his straw hat on top of Lex's own head, because there was nowhere else to put it, and the little silver bell in his coat, beside the Ledger and Dorran's book.

It didn't ring. Not once.

At the foot of the mountain, on the black ink, the Ferryman was waiting.

He was standing in his long grey boat. Leaning on his long grey pole. Exactly where they'd left him.

But the lantern at the top of his pole was *lit*.

Gold. Small. Steady. Burning for the first time in nine hundred years.

The Ferryman turned his eyeless face toward them as they came down onto the black ink.

"*My river,*" he said. His rain-voice was very strange. "*It's running clean.*"



THEY WENT HOME.

Back across the black ink. Back up the waterfall at the edge of the deep, which the Ferryman poled them up as if it were a gentle slope. Back through the Drowned Country.

The drowned city was empty.

All the grey dead were gone. Every one. The woman with the basket. The man leading a horse that wasn't there. The children running without sound. Gone. Gone up. Gold.

Except one.

In the great square at the center of the city, in a ring of six iron lanterns marked with Ardent, burning gold, a little girl was sitting cross-legged on the drowned flagstones.

Waiting.

Antho was out of the boat before it stopped.

He went down into the not-water of the square, the way he had twice before. With the Lantern held high. And the little girl looked up at him.

She was glowing. Faintly. Gold. Like all the others had been, as they rose.

But she hadn't gone.

Antho knelt down in front of her.

"You waited," he said.

The little girl looked at him. Then she reached out one small faint hand. And took hold of his sleeve. Between finger and thumb.

And held on.

"Oh," said Antho Vey. Very softly. *"Oh. You were waiting for me."*

She didn't answer. She held his sleeve. And smiled.

And then, slowly, gently, the way a candle goes out in a quiet room at the end of a long evening, she went up. Gold. Rising. Out of the drowned square. Up through the not-water. Up into the soft blue-violet dark above the Drowned Country.

Still holding on to his sleeve. Until she was too high to reach.

And then letting go.



AT THE GREY RIVER, the Ferryman set them down on the world's shore.

All of them. Except two.

Seren Vey stood in the long grey boat with Isaura Kell beside her. And didn't get out.

"Mam," said Lex.

"I know, love."

"Mam, come on." His voice cracked. *"It's done. It's over. The Tithe's gone. The hunger's gone. You can come home. Antho's a Threshold Warden, he can let you through any—"*

"I know," said Seren. Very gently. *"I know he can."*

She looked at her eldest son. Standing on the grey shingle with the Lantern in his hand.

"Not yet," said Seren Vey. *"Not yet, my loves."*



"Why?" said Antho. His voice was very quiet.

His mother looked out across the river. At the far shore. At the soft blue-violet dark of the Hollow. Not hungry anymore. Just dark. Just quiet. Just Shade.

"Because there are more," she said. *"Down there. Further than the Drowned Country. Further than the Forbidden Lands."* She looked back at them. *"Places it ate before the net. Before the Weaving. Long, long before."* Her faint face was very calm. *"They're rising. All of them. Going home. But some of them don't know the way."*

"Like the little girl," said Antho.

"Like the little girl." Seren smiled. *"Someone has to walk them home. Someone who knows the dark. Someone with a light."* She looked at Kell. *"Isaura's coming with me. She's a Warden. She's good at doors."*

Kell didn't say anything. But she stood very straight beside Seren in the boat. And her hands, at her sides, were not clenched.

"And then?" said Lex.

His mother looked at him. With her grey eyes. Antho's eyes. Ysmir's eyes.

"And then I'll come home," said Seren Vey. *"I promise."* She reached out of the boat and put her faint hand on his face. *"Leave a light on, love. Both of you. In the window."*

"*Always*," said Antho.

"*I know*." She smiled. "*You always count*."



THE FERRYMAN PUSHED OFF.

The long grey boat slid out into the river. Into the mist. Which wasn't grey anymore. Lex saw that, as it closed around the boat. Not grey. *Clear*. Silver. Shining. Like water in sunlight. Like the river in Malachi's stories, before the Tithe. Before the Weaving.

The lantern on the Ferryman's pole burned gold.

And in the boat, getting smaller, getting fainter, a woman in a faded blue dress stood beside a woman in torn white robes, and looked back at the shore.

And waved.

And Lex stood on the shingle with Malachi in his arms and his brother beside him and Wren's hand in his, and waved back. Until the mist closed. Until the gold light of the lantern was only a spark. Until it was gone.

[She'll come home,] said Ember. Very softly. In the hearth.

I know, thought Lex.

[How do you know?]

He looked down at the little silver bell. In his coat. Beside the Ledger. Silent.

Because she's a Vey, he thought. *And we always come*.

CHAPTER 37

A NEW ERA OF BALANCE



THEY BURIED MALACHI AT the Stillwater, by his fire.

It was burning when they got there. Lex hadn't expected that. Nobody had tended it in months. Malachi had left it to go out every night at midnight, drawn down the road to the Heart, and walked away up the Greyspine with his goats.

But when they came down into the hidden green valley in the white salt of the Wastes, the eternal fire was burning in its ring of stones in the hearth of the little hut by the still pool. Small. Gold. Steady. As if it had relit itself the moment the Tithe ended. As if it had been waiting for him.

They dug the grave beside the pool. Lex and Antho. With borrowed spades. While Wren and Seraphine and the others stood in a ring, and the goats wandered among them eating everyone's hems, and Correspondence stood at the head of the grave chewing very slowly and watching with its yellow eye.

They laid him in it in his old robe, with his straw hat on his chest and his driftwood staff beside him. Small and brown and barefoot.

Lex took out the bell.

He'd carried it all the way from the Heart. In his coat. Beside the Ledger and Dorran's book. It hadn't rung once.

He knelt at the edge of the grave and held it out over the old man's folded hands.

And didn't let go.

[Lex?] said Ember.

He'd want me to keep it, thought Lex. Wouldn't be.

[Why?]

So I'd know. He closed his hand around the little silver bell. If anyone was sad. So I'd know to come and find them.

The coal in his hearth was quiet for a long time.

[Yes,] said Ember. [Yes. He'd want that.]



ANTHO SAID THE WORDS. There weren't many. Antho had never been good at words.

"He was the youngest of seven," he said. Standing at the head of the grave, with the Lantern in his hand. "He was sad for nine hundred years. He taught me the dark wasn't my enemy. He taught my brother to say good morning to fire." He was quiet. "And when it mattered, he got up off the bucket."

He looked down at the old man's face.

"Thank you, Mal," said Antho Vey. "Go and sit with your brother."

And Correspondence, standing at the head of the grave, bleated. Once. Very loudly.

And then walked away and ate a bush.

Wren started laughing. She couldn't help it. And then Seraphine. And then Lex. Standing by an open grave in the Wastes, laughing until they cried, while a goat ate a gorse bush and the eternal fire burned gold in the hut behind them.

Malachi would have liked that, Lex thought. Malachi would have liked that very much.



THE WORLD WAS DIFFERENT.

Lex noticed it the moment they came out of the Wastes. Small things, at first. The way the light looked. The way people walked.

There were no Ceilings.

Not anywhere. Not on anyone. He couldn't see threads anymore. He'd given that away at the Heart, with the rest of the Root. But he didn't need to see them. He could see it in people's faces. In the way they stood. Like

people who'd been holding their breath their whole lives and had only just noticed they could stop.

The first village they came to was a farming place on the edge of the salt, called Brine. Forty houses. A Stone on the green.

There was a girl at the Stone. Fourteen. Kindling-day. With her hand on it.

And there was no Warden standing beside her with a hand on her shoulder. Just her mother. And her grandmother. And half the village, standing round, waiting.

The Stone lit up under her hand. Silver and gold. A panel rose over her head. Lex couldn't read it anymore. But he heard her read it. Out loud. Her voice shaking.

"*Healer*," said the girl. "*Rare. Level one.*" She stared at it. "*No Ceiling. Mam. Mam, it says no Ceiling. It says growth: unbounded.**"

Her mother put her hand over her mouth.

And her grandmother, who was seventy if she was a day, who had been capped at fourteen at this same Stone sixty years ago, sat down very suddenly on the grass and started to cry.



"*Unbounded*," said Wren. That night. In the inn at Brine. Sitting on the end of the bed with her boots off. "*That's the word. Unbounded.*"

"Yes."

"*Everyone.*" She looked at her hands. "*Everyone in the world. Unbounded. Forever.*" She shook her head slowly. "*Hammer, do you know what that means? Every child who Kindles from now on. They can be anything. As high as they want. As far as they can go.*"

"Yes."

"*You did that.*"

"*We did that*," said Lex. "*All of us. Kestrel and Teo and you and Antho and Mam. And Malachi. And Elric, at the Rift. And Dorrán. And Kell, at the end.*" He was quiet. "*And Aurelian. At the very end. When he let go.*"

Wren looked at him for a long time.

"*You gave it away*," she said. "*The Root. All of it. You could've been the most powerful man in the world.*"

"I know."

"Why didn't you?"

He thought about it. The way he always did now.

"Because I'd have been at the center," he said. "*Holding everything. Like him. Like Father.*" He looked at his hands. Big. Scarred. Ordinary. "*And I don't want to hold everything. I want to hold you.*"

Wren didn't say anything for a long moment.

Then she reached out and took his hand. And held it. Not tight. Not afraid. The way you hold something you've chosen to hold.

"Idiot," she said softly.



HIGHCREST WAS FULL OF lanterns again.

They came in on the first night of summer, on Vharuun's back, all of them, and the whole golden city was lit up like the festival. Every window. Every eave. Every balcony and lamppost and rooftop. Gold.

The Queen met them on the castle wall. In a plain blue dress, with no jewels, and a thin silver circlet on her brow. She didn't say anything. She came down the steps and put her arms around Lex. And then around Antho. And then, after a moment's hesitation, around Wren, who went very red.

"*They're for you,*" said Lysandra. Looking out at the lanterns. "*All of them. Nobody ordered it. They just started lighting them. The night the World Notice came.*" She was quiet. "*They've lit them every night since.*"

There was a lantern in the window of the Lower Town bakery. A big one. Shaped like a loaf of bread.



LORD CHANCELLOR VARRIC SORN had been found in the spring.

In a fishing village on the northern coast, in a borrowed coat, trying to buy passage across the White Shore. He'd shaved his silver beard. A ten-year-old girl had recognized him anyway, from the coins.

He'd been brought to Highcrest in chains. Ordinary chains. Not Severance. There was no Severance anymore. Nobody could cut anyone off from the net.

The Queen had stripped him of his titles. His lands. His seat on the Council.

And then, instead of the dungeon, she'd sentenced him to ten years as schoolmaster in the village of Fen Hollow. Past the Blightmarch. Teaching letters to the children of the people Dorran Vask had capped.

"*He'll hate it,*" said Elowen Dunmore, with deep satisfaction.

"*He'll hate it,*" the Queen agreed. "*And every one of those children is unbounded now. Every one. Bright as stars.*" Her mouth twitched. "*He'll spend ten years teaching the very people he wanted to put on a list.*"

"*That's cruel, Majesty,*" said Roole.

"*That's justice, Commander.*" Lysandra looked at him. "*There's a difference. Seraphine taught me. She found it in a book.*"



THE ORDER WAS GONE.

Not destroyed. *Changed.* Roole had done it. Over the summer. Standing in front of the High Council in the Spire with his hatchet face set like stone, and telling them that there was nothing left to ward. No Ceilings to set. No Sanctions to grant. No Inspections. No Severance.

"*So what are we for?*" an old Warden had asked. From the tiers.

"*The Stones,*" said Roole. "*Someone has to look after them. Keep them clean. Keep them straight. Stand beside them on Kindling-day, so children aren't frightened.*" He looked around the chamber. "*Not to put the lid on. To be there when it doesn't.*"

They called themselves the Keepers of the Stones now. Roole was their Commander. Fenn was his lieutenant.

The first thing they did was straighten every leaning Stone in the west.



ARION WAS GETTING OLD.

Lex saw it the first time he went back to the Hollowmaw. In late summer. On Ashka, alone, with Wren on the wind beside him.

His father was at the mouth of the cave. Sitting on the rock where Pim always sat. With Pim beside him. Talking.

Talking. Pim. The boy who'd said six words in his first year at the Keep. Sitting on a rock in the sunshine, with his knees pulled up, telling

Arion Vey something long and complicated about the bats in the cold-room. Waving his hands.

Arion was listening. Gravely. With his lean face turned toward the boy. And his hair was going grey.

Not much. At the temples. A few threads. Silver in the dark. Lex saw them as Ashka came down on the slope, and felt something in his chest go tight and warm at the same time.

His father looked up. Saw him. And stood up.

Slowly. The way an old man stands. One hand on the rock.

"Lex," said Arion Vey.

"Father." Lex slid down off Ashka's neck. He walked up the slope. He stopped in front of his father.

And looked at the grey at his temples.

"*I found another one this morning,*" said Arion. He touched it, with two fingers. Almost shyly. "*And a line here.*" He touched the corner of his eye. "*Odile says I look distinguished. Teo says I look like a badger.*"

"*You look old,*" said Lex.

His father's lean face did the thing it almost never did.

"Yes," said Arion Vey. And smiled. A real smile. Wide. Startled. Like a man who has been given something he stopped hoping for a long time ago. "*Yes. I do. Isn't it wonderful?*"



THE DOOR AT THE bottom of the Hollowmaw was sealed.

Lex went down to see it. With his father. Down the long passage, past one thousand one hundred and eleven lanterns, into the bell-shaped cavern.

The black glass was smooth. Unbroken. The crack that had been there since the night of the Blade was gone. Healed. As if it had never been. When Lex put his hand on it, he felt nothing on the other side. No hunger. No pushing. No whisper.

Just a deep, soft, peaceful quiet. Like the dark between the stars.

Shade, he thought. *Not the Hollow. Not anymore. Just the dark.*

And in the niche beside it, two lamps. A little clay one, brown and round and plain, with a chip in its spout and a thumbprint in its base. And an iron one, squat and heavy, with twenty runes on its glass.

Both burning.

"*Every night,*" said Arion. Beside him. Quietly. "*I fill them. They don't need it. I fill them anyway.*" He looked at the clay lamp. "*And I say good evening.*"

"*Does she answer?*"

His father was quiet for a long time.

"*No,*" he said at last. "*She's too far. She's walking.*" He looked at the black glass. "*But sometimes, very late, the clay one leans. Just a hair. Toward the door.*" He swallowed. "*I think that's her. Somewhere. Passing near. On her way to somewhere else.*"

Lex looked at his father. At the grey at his temples. At his hands, with the brown spot between the knuckles.

"*She doesn't remember you,*" he said. Very gently. "*Father. She told us. At the Heart. She paid you to the Ferryman. Eleven years ago. To cross back.*"

"*I know,*" said Arion.

Lex stared at him.

"*Antho told me,*" said his father. "*In the spring. When you came back.*" He looked at the clay lamp. "*He said she'd paid away every memory of me. Our meeting. Our wedding. Everything.*" His voice was very steady. "*And then she spent three years in the dark talking to me through the Root every night, not knowing who I was. And fell in love with me again anyway.*"

He was quiet.

"*Do you know how many people get to be fallen in love with twice?*" said Arion Vey. "*By the same person? Without her even remembering the first time?*"

Lex didn't say anything.

"*I'll wait,*" said his father. "*For her to come home. I'll get old waiting. Older.*" He touched the grey at his temples. "*And when she comes, I'll tell her. Everything. The Spire. The rain. The steps. Every word.*" He smiled. "*And she'll say, tell me about us. And I'll tell her.*"

"*Like Antho and the stone.*"

"Like Antho and the stone." His father looked at him. "It won't be the same. I know that. It'll be something else." He was quiet. "But it'll be something. That's not nothing."



ILSE AND IVO MARROW put on a play in the square at Highcrest on the last night of summer.

They called themselves the Marrow Players. Two people and a cart. And a great deal of illusion. They'd been touring all summer. The Bitter Hills. The Vale. The twelve villages past the Blightmarch, where they stood beside every Stone on Kindling-day, in Dorran Vask's place, with their hands on children's shoulders.

The play was *The Knights of the Ford*.

Lex watched it from the steps of the Spire, with Wren beside him. Two knights, holding a river crossing, back to back. The river rising. Made of light, of illusion, so real that the people in the front rows flinched from the water.

And at the end, the last verse. The real one. Sung by Ilse, alone, in the middle of the square, in a clear thin voice.

But they did not drown because they held. They drowned because each tried to let the other go, and the other one came back.

The square was very quiet.

And then Ivo, standing at the side of the stage, made his own wrist look like nothing. Held it up. A trick of the light. A hand, ending in empty air.

And Ilse reached out and took hold of it anyway.

The square erupted.



KESTREL VARN WENT TO the Sunreach.

She came to say goodbye in the autumn, at the Ashbourne Forge, with Tamsin beside her. She had a pack on her back and a new red coat, not scorched at all, and her hair was tied back with a strip of Sunreach cloth.

"Ishara wrote," she said. "She says there are fire-women in the south. Old ones. Ashari. Who remember things about the fire that nobody in Caldor ever knew." She looked at her hands. *"She says I should come and learn."*

"You should," said Lex.

"I know." Kestrel looked at her brother. *"Tam's not coming."*

"I'm going home," said Tamsin Varn. *"To Coldbrook. To the farm."* He shrugged. *"Someone has to bring the cows in."*

"He names them," said Kestrel. *"All of them. Talks to them by name. Every evening."* Her mouth twisted. *"It's mortifying."*

"It's in the Ledger," said Lex.

Kestrel looked at him.

"Ysmir wrote it," said Lex. *"In the Ledger. The first time. Tamsin Varn, of Coldbrook. Twenty-one. Farmer. He brought the cows in every evening and talked to each one by name."* He smiled. *"She thought it was worth remembering."*

Kestrel stared at him for a long moment.

Then she laughed. And hugged her brother. Hard. And hugged Lex, harder. And walked out of the Ashbourne Forge into the autumn sunshine, heading south.

She didn't look back.

But Lex saw her lift one hand, at the bend in the road, without turning around. And a little flame came up off her fingers, gold, and danced there for a moment.

And then she was gone.



TEO BRASK WENT HOME to the Tidewater.

He was sixteen. He said he'd been homesick for a year and a half and he'd had enough. And besides, the sea had told him it wanted him back.

"It says I should be the Tide Speaker," he said. Dripping, on the steps of the Lantern Keep. *"For the coast. For the fishing villages. It says there hasn't been one in nine hundred years and it's been very lonely."* He went red. *"It says I'm the only one who ever asks it nicely."*

Antho put both hands on the boy's shoulders.

"Write," he said. *"Every week. Or send a fish. Or whatever the sea does."*

"I will, Master Antho." Teo was crying. Or the sea was. It was hard to tell. *"Thank you. For the cold-room. For the fish in the bucket. For not laughing."*

"I laughed," said Antho. *"Every day. When you weren't looking."*

Teo laughed too. And hugged him. And climbed up onto Ashka's back, dripping, for the flight east. And waved all the way out of sight.



TILDA CRANE GOT BRANNOC'S hammer.

Lex didn't see it happen. He heard about it from Hedda, who told it with her cudgel across her knees and a face like thunder that didn't fool anyone.

Brannoc had called the girl over to the great hearth at the end of the day. In front of everyone. All forty students. And held out his hammer. The big one. The one he'd used for fifty years. The one he'd swung in the Ashbourne forge when Lex was eleven, and on Hedda's barricade at the Hollowmaw, and every day in between.

It's yours now, lass, he'd said.

Tilda had stared at it.

I'm too old for the big work, Brannoc had said. *Knees. Arm. Hedda says I'll fall over.* He'd shrugged his enormous shoulders. *And you hear the fire. Properly. I never did. Not once in sixty years. You talk to it, and it talks back.* He'd put the hammer in her hands. *You should have a hammer that's been talked to.*

"*She cried,*" said Hedda. "*All over it. Rusted the face. He had to grind it.*" She scowled. "*Sentimental old fool.*"

"*You cried too,*" said Lex.

"*I did not.*"

"*Hedda.*"

"*Something in my eye,*" said Hedda Vorne. "*Soot. It's a forge.*"



HE MADE THE RING in winter.

In the Ashbourne Forge. At night. When the hall was empty and the side-fires were banked and the great hearth glowed red.

He'd been thinking about it since the Wellworld of Gale. Since Wren had opened her hand in the sky and let him fall and trusted the wind to catch him. Since she'd said *never again* in a wrecked ballroom with her shoes off.

He'd known what he wanted to make it from for longer than that.

The nail was in a box in Brannoc's loft. He'd asked for it. Brannoc had gone very quiet, and then climbed up the ladder, slow, with his bad knees, and come back down with it in his palm.

Old. Black. Square-headed. Hand-forged. A hundred years old at least.

It had come out of the door of the old Ashbourne forge. The little one, with a single anvil, where Lex had learned his trade. Brannoc's forge, and his father's before him. When they knocked the wall through to build the long hall with twenty anvils, Brannoc had pulled the nail out of the old door frame with his own hands and put it in a box.

First nail I ever drew, Brannoc had said. *My da showed me. When I was eleven.* He'd put it in Lex's hand. *Same age as you. When I showed you.*

Lex held the nail over the fire for a long time.

Then he worked it. Slowly. Carefully. Asking. The way the Hearth had taught him. The way Brannoc had taught him, before that. *You're not making it do anything, lad. You're asking it nicely to be something else for a while.*

He drew it out. Thin. Round. Bent it into a circle. Closed it. Small. Plain. Black iron, with the faint grain of a hundred years of a forge door still in it.

And on the inside, where only the person wearing it would see, he cut one rune.

STAY.

[It's beautiful,] said Ember. In the hearth. Very softly.

It's an old nail.

[It's the most beautiful thing you've ever made,] said Ember. *[And you made a Lockward out of the bones of the world.]*



HE ASKED HER ON the roof of the Spire.

At dawn. On the first day of spring. A year after Fen Hollow. Two years after the festival. Five years after he first met a girl with a fox-red braid at Thistledown, on the road to the Greyspine, and she told him he walked like a bear in a china shop.

She'd waited for him on that roof. Every dawn, for a month. When he was in the north, and she was guarding his father, and she didn't know if he was alive.

He climbed up the long spiral stair in the dark. She was already there. Sitting on the parapet, with her back to the eight-hundred-foot drop and her boots dangling over the roof, watching the sky go grey over the golden city.

She looked round when he came up through the trapdoor.

"*Hammer,*" she said. "*What are you doing up here? You hate heights.*"

"*I know.*"

"*You're shaking.*"

"*I know.*"

She stared at him. Then her green eyes narrowed.

"*What,*" said Wren Ashdown, "*have you done.*"

He didn't answer. He came across the roof. He stopped in front of her, where she sat on the parapet. He knelt down. On the cold white stone of the roof of the Spire, eight hundred feet above Highcrest, at dawn.

And held out his hand.

The ring sat in his palm. Small. Plain. Black iron.

Wren looked at it for a very long time.

"*It's a nail,*" she said at last.

"*It's a nail,*" Lex agreed. "*From the door of Brannoc's first forge. His father showed him how to draw it, when he was eleven.*" His voice was shaking. "*And there's a rune on the inside. You can't see it unless you're wearing it.*"

"*What rune?*"

"*Put it on and see.*"



SHE PUT IT ON.

He watched her do it. Slowly. Her hands not quite steady. She slid it onto her finger and turned it, and he saw her feel the rune. Cut into the inside of the band. Against her skin.

He saw her face change.

"*Stay,*" she whispered.

"*The bearer cannot be severed,*" said Lex, "*from those they hold dear.*" He swallowed. "*By any working of the Lattice or the Hollow. Or anything else.*"

Wren Ashdown sat on the parapet of the Spire with the dawn coming up behind her and the ring on her finger and stared at him.

"*You absolute,*" she said. "*You stupid, idiot, stubborn, enormous—*"
"I know."

"*On the roof. At dawn. When you hate heights.*"

"*You waited for me up here,*" said Lex. "*Every morning. For a month. When you didn't know if I was coming back.*" His voice cracked. "*I wanted to ask you somewhere you'd waited for me. So you'd know I came.*"

She didn't say anything.

Then she slid down off the parapet. Onto her knees. On the roof. In front of him. And put her hands on either side of his face. And looked at him. Fierce and windburned and so beautiful he couldn't breathe.

"*You haven't actually asked,*" she said.

"*Will you marry me?*" said Lex Vey.

"*Yes,*" said Wren. "*Obviously. You idiot.*"

And she kissed him. On the roof of the Spire. At dawn. With the sun coming up gold over the city of lanterns, and somewhere below, very faintly, a church bell starting to ring for the morning.



ANTHO SKIPPED A STONE on the lake beyond the Teeth in the first week of summer.

Lex had promised. Years ago. On the plinth at Duskhold, and in the forge at the Hollowmaw, and in a hundred letters. *When this is done. When it's all quiet. We'll go to your lake. And skip stones.*

It was a lake in a high valley on the far side of the Teeth. Where the world had been thin and grey. It wasn't grey now. The Tithe was gone. The world had come back. Green and blue and full of birds. The lake was very still. Very flat. Perfect for skipping stones.

They stood on the shore. The two of them. With Wren and Seraphine sitting on a rock a little way back, pretending not to watch.

Lex had told him the story that morning. The way he did every morning. The millpond. The willows. The heron. Five.

"*Your turn,*" said Lex. And held out a stone.

Flat. Grey. Smooth. He'd found it on the shore. He'd looked for an hour.

Antho took it.

He weighed it in his hand. Looked at the lake. Looked at his brother.

"*Low,*" said Lex. "*Flatter. Like it's trying to fly under a door.*"

"*I know how to skip a stone.*"

"*You don't remember.*"

"*I've seen it,*" said Antho. "*From the water. And from the inside. At the Ferryman's shore.*" He turned the stone over. "*I know how it goes.*"

He threw.



LOW. FLAT. SPINNING. LEAVING his hand like a bird.

It touched the water.

Lifted.

One, said Antho. Out loud.

Touched. Lifted.

Two.

Lex had stopped breathing.

Three. Four.

And Antho's whole face was lighting up. From inside. Like a window when someone lights a lamp. Like a small freckled boy on a riverbank turning round with the sun coming out on his face.

Five.

The stone sank. A little ring spreading out on the still water where it went down.

And on the far shore, a heron lifted off the reeds. Great grey wings flapping. Startled.

The two brothers stood on the shore of the lake beyond the Teeth and watched it go.

"*Five,*" said Antho.

"*Five,*" said Lex.

"*I counted.*" His brother's voice was shaking. "*I always count.*"

And then he turned round. And picked Lex up. All of him. The size of a door. And swung him round. Staggering. Nearly falling into the lake. While Lex shouted and Wren shrieked with laughter on her rock and Seraphine put her face in her hands.

"*You're brilliant,*" said Antho Vey. Into his brother's shoulder. Laughing. Crying. "*You're brilliant. You're going to be better at this than me.*"



HE ASKED SERAPHINE THAT evening.

By the lake. At sunset. With a ring he'd had Lex make. Silver. Plain. With a rune on the inside: *ARDENT*. The first rune. The one that lit every lantern in the Hollowmaw.

Lex didn't hear what he said. He and Wren had gone up the hill, on purpose, and sat on the slope with their backs to the lake. Not looking.

But they heard Seraphine.

Everyone in the valley heard Seraphine.

"*YES,*" shouted the Royal Archivist of Caldor. "*YES, you ridiculous, wonderful, lantern-counting, absolutely impossible man, YES, of course yes, did you think I'd say anything else, did you think I'd read every letter you ever wrote me eleven times and kept them in a box under my bed and NOT say yes—*"

Wren was laughing so hard she fell over.

Lex lay on his back on the hillside beside her, with the stars coming out over the Teeth, and the lake going dark below, and the sound of his brother laughing drifting up the slope.

[*Lex,*] said Ember. In his hearth. Very softly.

Mm.

[*I'm writing it down. All of it. The stone. The heron. The ring.*] A pause. [*I've been writing everything down. Since the Heart. In the hearth. A book.*]

A book?

[*Somebody should,*] said Ember. [*So it's kept. The way Ysmir kept the names.*] Another pause. [*The Book of What Was. Volume Two.*]

Lex laughed. Out loud. On the hillside.

"*What?*" said Wren.

"Ember's writing a book."

Wren rolled over. Propped her chin on his chest. Looked at him in the starlight with her ring on her finger and her green eyes bright.

"About what?"

Lex thought about it.

"About us," he said. *"All of us. Everything that happened."* He looked up at the stars. *"So nobody forgets."*

Wren was quiet for a long moment.

"Tell it to put in the bit about the roof," she said. *"And the nail. And how you were shaking."*

[Already done,] said Ember. *[Page four hundred and twelve.]*

EPILOGUE

THE EVERLASTING LEGACY



ARION VEY WAS TWO hundred and thirty-three years old, and he had eleven grey hairs.

He'd counted them that morning. In the little mirror Seraphine had given Antho, which Antho had put in the cold-room, which Teo had used to look at fish, and which now hung on a nail in the passage outside the library, because Odile said someone in the Lantern Keep ought to be able to see what they looked like.

Eleven. At the temples, mostly. And one, very bold, right at the front, curling over his forehead like a question mark.

And lines. At the corners of his eyes. Around his mouth. Faint. But there.

He'd stood in front of the mirror for a long time. Looking. A lean man with dark hair going grey, and grey eyes, and a face that had stopped being forty-five forever and had started, at last, to be whatever it was going to be.

Then he'd gone down to breakfast and told Pim, who had said, very seriously, "*You look like a badger*," and then laughed so hard he fell off the bench.

Pim laughed a lot now. Arion had never heard a sound he liked better.



THE HOLLOWMAW WAS FULL.

He'd never seen it so full. Not in the three years he'd kept the door. Not even on the night of the Blade, when three hundred Keepers stood on the slopes and two dragons held the sky.

It was the eve of the wedding. *Weddings*. Two of them. Tomorrow, at noon, in the bell-shaped cavern at the bottom of the mountain, in front of the sealed black door, among one thousand one hundred and eleven lanterns.

Both his sons. On the same day.

Antho had said it was the only sensible thing. *One wedding's bad enough. Two would be unbearable. Get it all over with at once.* Seraphine had said he was the least romantic man in Caldor, and then kissed him, and then gone off to argue with the Queen's steward about seating.

Lex had just said, *yes*. And looked at Wren. And gone red to the ears.

So everyone had come.



THE QUEEN OF CALDOR was sleeping in the library, on a camp bed, because it was the only room left and she'd refused to let anyone give up theirs. Elowen Dunmore was sleeping across the doorway, with Oathkeeper across her knees. Roole and Fenn and half the Keepers of the Stones were in tents on the slope.

Queen Ishara of the Sunreach had arrived that afternoon on a golden horse with fifty riders and Zahir on her shoulder, and had taken one look at the Hollowmaw and said, *you live in a cave?* to Antho, who had said *yes, Majesty*, and Ishara had laughed until she cried.

Kestrel Varn had come with her. Brown from the southern sun. With a new scar on her chin and her hair burning gold, quietly, all the time now, like a lamp left on in a window. She'd brought Tamsin, who'd brought a cow. Nobody knew why. The cow was called Prudence. It was in the pen with Correspondence, and they'd taken against each other immediately.

Teo Brask had come from the Tidewater coast on Ashka's back, dripping, with a fish. A very large fish. Silver. Still alive, somehow, in a barrel of seawater. *The sea sent it*, he said. *As a wedding present. For Master Antho. It says he'll know why.* Antho had looked at the fish for a long time. And then laughed. And put it in the cold-room.

Brannoc and Hedda had come on a cart full of iron and opinions. Tilda Crane had come with them, with Brannoc's hammer on her back and forty

students behind her. Mother Orla had come, with bacon. Quill had come, for the bacon.

The Marrow Players had set up their cart on the slope below the cave mouth. Ilse and Ivo were rehearsing something. Every so often an illusion flickered up over the cart: a dragon, a knight, a lantern the size of a house. Ivo kept falling off the cart. Ilse kept laughing.

Corin Bell had come from Harrowgate with his sister. Mella sang to the goats. They didn't like it.

Hollis Penn had come from the Lower Town with a wagon of bread, because, he said, nobody was getting married at the Lantern Keep without a proper loaf, and he'd heard the cooking in caves was terrible.

A seventeen-year-old standard-bearer named Benno had come with the Ashen Banners, all two hundred of them, carrying a black and grey banner and a greatsword with a hilt worn smooth by a two-fingered hand.

And an old woman from Fen Hollow named Bess Rook, Spring Kindling, Ceiling twelve, had walked three hundred miles with a stick, because, she said, she'd never been to a wedding in a cave, and she wanted to see the big smith who'd made the lights come on.



ARION STOOD AT THE mouth of the Hollowmaw at dusk and looked at all of them.

On the slope below. Around the cookfires. In the tents. On the cart. Laughing and arguing and eating Hollis Penn's bread. Two dragons sprawled across the far ridge like a pair of sleeping storm-clouds. A storm-mother, vast and whole and blue, with her daughter curled against her side.

And in the middle of it, his sons.

Lex was by the biggest fire. With Wren beside him. Telling a story, badly, with his hands. Brannoc was laughing at him. Tilda Crane was laughing at Brannoc.

Antho was sitting a little apart. On a rock. With Seraphine leaning against his shoulder and Pim on his other side. Not talking. Just watching. The way he always did. Counting, probably. Arion would have bet money he was counting.

Two hundred and thirty-three years, he thought. And I've never once seen anything like this.

He thought about Seren.

He thought about her every evening, at this hour. When the light was going. When the lanterns in the Hollowmaw began to glow gold behind him. He thought about a woman he'd met on the steps of the Spire in the rain, two hundred years into his long life, who'd looked at him as if he were the first light she'd ever seen.

Who didn't remember that now.

Who'd fallen in love with him again anyway. In the dark. Through the Root. Not knowing who he was.

She'd have loved this, he thought. All of it. The bread and the dragons and the cow.

She'd have sung. Flat on the high note.



HE WENT DOWN TO the door at midnight.

He always did. Every night. Down the long passage, past one thousand one hundred and eleven lanterns, into the bell-shaped cavern at the bottom of the mountain. To the sealed black door. And the niche beside it. And the two lamps.

He'd been doing it for a year and a half. Since the spring after the Heart. Since his sons came home and told him she'd stayed. In the dark. To walk the lost ones home.

Leave a light on, love.

So he did.

He took the little copper oil-flask from his coat. He filled the clay lamp, which didn't need it. He filled the iron one, which didn't need it either. He stood back and looked at them. Two small gold flames, side by side, in front of a door of black glass.

"Good evening," said Arion Vey.

And the clay lamp leaned.



HE WENT VERY STILL.

It leaned. Toward the door. The way it had leaned every night for three years, when she came to the other side of the glass. The way it had leaned, very rarely, very faintly, this past year and a half, late at night, when she passed somewhere near on her long walk.

But not faintly.

Hard. Far over. Almost flat. The little gold flame bent so far toward the black glass that it nearly touched it.

And then the iron one leaned too.

Arion had never seen the iron one lean. Not once. It was Lex's. Twenty Hush-runes. *STAY* on the inside of the ring. It burned straight up, always, steady as a forge.

It was leaning.

Both of them. Side by side. Toward the door.

And on the black glass, in the gold light of the leaning lamps, words.



NOT CARVED. NOT WRITTEN. *Shining.* Like a panel. Like the old Lattice panels, silver and gold, that had hung over people's heads for nine hundred years before his son reformed the net and gave it away.

But not over anyone's head.

On the door.

MESSAGE

From: SEREN VEY

Location: THE HOLLOW

(beyond the Drowned Country –
depth:)

"My boys.

Leave a light on.

I'm coming home –

but not alone."



ARION READ IT.

He read it twice.

And then he sat down. On the black floor of the cavern. Very suddenly. With his back against the wall beside the niche, and the two lamps leaning over his head.

I'm coming home.

He couldn't breathe.

I'm coming home.

After eleven years on the far side of a door. After paying him away to the Ferryman. After a year and a half walking in the dark, walking the lost ones home. She was coming home.

He put his face in his hands. And laughed. And wept. Both. At once. The way his sons did. The way he'd never, in two hundred and thirty-three years, let himself do.

And then he took his hands away.

And read the last line again.

But not alone.



THE LAMPS WERE STILL leaning.

Arion looked at them. At the two small flames, bent toward the black glass. At the words shining on its surface.

And beneath the words, in the glass, faint, like a reflection in deep water, something moving.

He leaned closer.

Shapes. On the other side of the door. Very far down. Very faint. Walking. Coming up out of the deep dark, the way you'd see someone coming up a long road at night with a lantern.

One small. In a faded blue dress. Holding nothing in her hands. Singing, he thought. Though he couldn't hear it.

One tall and gaunt, in robes that had been white. Walking a little behind. Straight-backed. Like a Warden.

And behind them—

He couldn't see. It was too far. Too faint. A shape. Or shapes. Following. Many, maybe. Or one, very large. He couldn't tell. Something that was coming up out of the deep dark behind his wife, along the long road home, the way the drowned dead had come toward Antho's lantern.

He couldn't tell if it was following her.
Or if she was leading it.



THE WORDS ON THE glass faded.

The lamps straightened. Slowly. The clay one, then the iron one. Until they burned straight up again, side by side, small and gold and steady, in front of the sealed black door.

And the shapes in the glass were gone.

Arion sat on the floor of the cavern for a long time.

Then he got up.

Slowly. One hand on the wall. The way an old man gets up. He was an old man now. Or starting to be. He had eleven grey hairs and lines at the corners of his eyes, and he'd spent two hundred years keeping secrets because he was afraid of what would happen if he didn't.

He looked at the door. At the two lamps.

Antho, he thought. *Lex*.

They're asleep. It's midnight. They're getting married tomorrow. In front of this door. With the Queen and the cow and the fish.

I could wait. I could tell them after. Let them have tomorrow. Let them—
He stopped.

He stood in front of the door with his hand on the cold black glass and thought about the portraits in the secret room in the Spire. Two hundred years of his own face. Arion Vey the scholar. Arion Vey the Warden. Arion Vey's son. Arion Vey's grandson. Every one of them keeping something. Every one of them waiting for the right moment to tell.

No, he thought.

No more.



HE WENT UP THE long passage.

Past one thousand one hundred and eleven lanterns. Not counting them. He'd never been the one who counted.

He found Lex asleep by the dying fire on the slope, with Wren curled against his back and the little silver bell on a cord round his neck, silent. He

found Antho in the library doorway, asleep sitting up against the frame, with Seraphine's head in his lap and the Lantern beside him.

He woke them both.

He didn't wait. He didn't make it gentle. He knelt down in front of his sons, at midnight, on the eve of their wedding, and said:

"She sent a message. Through the door. Just now."

And told them. Every word.



THEY WENT DOWN TOGETHER.

All three of them. Father and sons. With the Lantern. And Wren and Seraphine behind them, who had woken too, and come, and weren't going to be left behind, obviously.

They stood in front of the door.

The lamps burned straight up. The glass was smooth and black and silent. No words. No shapes.

But Antho put his hand on it.

And stood there for a long time. With his clear grey eyes closed. Listening. The way he listened to the dark. The way he'd listened to a door for eight years from one side and three from the other.

"She's there," he said at last. Very quietly. *"Far down. Very far. Walking."* He opened his eyes. *"Coming up."*

"And the rest?" said Lex. *"Not alone. What did she mean?"*

Antho was quiet.

"I don't know," he said. *"It's too far. It's too deep."* He took his hand off the glass. *"But there's something with her. More than one. I can feel the shape of the quiet around them."* He looked at his father. *"And it's a big shape."*

Nobody said anything.



LEX TOOK SOMETHING OUT of his coat.

A lantern. Small. Iron. Squat and round, like a clay lamp, with a ring to carry it by. Not Hush-runes. Not twenty runes. One. On the glass.

ARDENT.

"I made it at the forge," he said. "Last week. For the wedding." He looked at it. "For the window. At the cottage. At Harrow." His voice was rough. "I thought, when we go home after, there should be a light in the window."

He set it down.

In the niche. Beside the clay lamp and the iron one. Three lamps now. Side by side. In front of the sealed black door.

He lit it. With his own fire. The fire he said good morning to every day. It burned. Small. Gold. Steady.

And Antho, standing beside him, with his father on his other side and the two women they loved behind them and a door in front of them with their mother somewhere on the other side of it, coming home, counted.

"One thousand one hundred and thirteen," said Antho Vey.

He looked at his brother.

"I always count," he said.



UPSTAIRS, ON THE SLOPE, under the stars, a vast storm-mother lifted her head off the ridge and looked toward the cave mouth. And made a sound. Low and deep and rumbling. Like thunder over mountains a hundred miles off.

Like recognition.

And in the cold-room of the Lantern Keep, in a barrel of seawater, a silver fish turned once in the dark, and was still.

And on a cord around Lex Vey's neck, against his chest, under his shirt, a little silver bell with a crooked clapper, which had not made a sound since the Heart, since an old man's hands went still around it, since a nine-hundred-year sadness ended—

Rang.

Once.

Very softly. Flat.

Ting.



Here ends The Sorcerer's Legacy, Book Two of the Lattice Chronicles.

The story continues.

THE STORY CONTINUES



Book Three of The Lattice Chronicles

coming soon